

The Age of STRANGERS

LINN AN ACAIR

The Legendarium of Dia-chìr

— The Age of Strangers

(An Aois Choigreach)

being the Books of the age, the Annals of its years,
a Gazetteer of its towns, and the Appendices
the Anchor Era, AE 1 – 151

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PART ONE

Of the Opening of the Sea

CHAPTER ONE

Of the Gauze on the Water

AE 1 – 2

A Mhanannain, cùm a' mhuir dùinte. Manannan, keep the sea shut.

I

Of the Four Witnesses

This telling is set down in Seilear Muileann chaol, in the winter the rolls came down to it, by the copyists of Na Trì Teaghlaichean, who have kept the custodians' copies there through the last years of this age and now have more paper than shelf. The chests came in by cart over the frozen ruts from the west, some with their lids nailed and some with a rope round them, and some still smelling of the lamp-soot of the rooms they had lain in. There are four witnesses in them, and the telling leans on each in turn.

The first witness is the rolls of the custodians: the rolls of each town, and above them the roll of Comhairle a' Chùrain¹ at Cathair dhearg, in the hands of a hundred and fifty years of clerks, a few fine and most of them hurried. The second is the letter-books of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach², which were found on the shelves of Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir³ when its last master went down to the water and left them behind. They are written in the humans' tongue and the humans' letters, and three of the copyists have learned to read them. The third is the day-books of the beacon-keepers, who wrote down every sail they saw and every night the flame was lit, and had nothing to gain by lying about a ship that was not there.

1. the Council of Custodians; lit. 'the council of the custody'

2. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

3. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

The fourth is the songs of the camps. They were forbidden, and for that reason somebody always wrote them down.

Where the four agree, the telling goes on without stopping. Where they quarrel, each is heard. When they fall silent, the telling says so once and goes on to the next thing it knows.

The age they speak of began in a winter like other winters. The crown had stood empty since the close of An Aois Scaraidh⁴, and the council sat in its place at Cathair dhearg, which had worked well enough for long enough that nobody asked any more whether it should. Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig⁵ was kept: the coal of the vein was burned in the measured handful at the shrines and nowhere else, and the island's hearths burned peat and driftwood and the wood of their own hedges. Clann Choinnich's petition to smelt silver with the coal lay unanswered in Taigh na Fèithe⁶. The north-west was nearly empty, its fields gone back to rush and its harbours to the gulls. At Seann Skell of the west eleven people had kept Deas-ghnàth a' Chalaigh Fhalaimh⁷ on Cidhe an Diosail⁸ the last time the harbour scribe troubled to count them, and the priests of Manannan went down to the river-mouth at every tide, morning and evening and in the dark between, to say their prayer:

A Mhanannain, cùm a' mhuir dùinte.

They said it because Ceò Mhanannain⁹ was thinning. For eighteen centuries it had stood on the eastern sea, where Cabhlach an Scaraidh¹⁰ had sailed into it and not come out, and on the north it had stood too, a grey wall a few oar-lengths off the capes, so that the sea ran into it and nothing came back. In the last winters of the old age the priests wrote that it lay thinner each year. On still mornings the fishers of the north-west could see through it to a dark line ruled across the edge of the world, which was the open sea going on. They saw it, and turned for home as the rule of sight-of-land told them, and said nothing about it in the alehouse, because there was nothing to say.

4. the Age of Sundering

5. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

6. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

7. the rite of the empty harbour

8. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

9. Manannan's mist over the eastern sea

10. the fleet of the Sundering

Of the Gauze off the Cape

Lachlann Odhar was steersman of the larger of the two boats of Achadh àrsaidh that went out after the winter cod in the month of am Faoilleach, in the first year of this age. He was a thick, sallow man of near forty with a broken nose and a habit of talking to the tiller. Achadh àrsaidh was a small place then, a few households on the rise behind the north-west cape who farmed a little and fished more, and it kept two boats because it could not man three.

They went out in the dark with the lines baited and the lanterns shuttered, and by first light they were off the cape in the long swell, where the water shelves down from the rocks and the cod lie in the cold. The other boat worked a cable's length to the west, Lachlann's brother-in-law at her steering-oar. The wind was light out of the north and the sky clear. Behind them the land stood up black. Ahead of them, where the grey had always stood, there was no wall.

Lachlann saw it before any of his crew did, because he was the only one of them not looking at his line. The grey was there, but it had gone to gauze: a thin, hanging, shifting stuff that the light came through, and through it he could see the sea going on, and on, farther than any man of Achadh àrsaidh had been told the sea went. He watched it a long while. Old men said that Uilebheist na Mara¹ rose in that water when it pleased, and Lachlann had half a mind that the paleness moving in the gauze was the beast's back.

Then the paleness took a shape, and the shape was sail.

It was one sail, high up, heaped on a mast taller than any tree Lachlann had ever cut or seen cut; then a second behind it and a third, and under them black hulls, wet and shining, riding higher out of the water than a hall stands on its hill. They came down out of the north slowly, with the grey tearing off their bows in rags and hanging a moment in their rigging before the wind took it. There were men along their sides. He could see the white of their faces.

Nobody in the boat spoke. One of the young men let his line run out through his fingers until it burned him, and swore, and let it go.

The first ship came near enough that Lachlann could hear her: the groan of her timbers, a block squealing somewhere up in the rigging, and then a man's voice from high on the stern, calling down.

1. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

"Ahoy the boat! What land is this? What land?"

It was no tongue that Lachlann had ever heard, or anyone at Achadh àrsaidh. He stood up at the tiller, set his feet wide against the roll, cupped his hands, and gave back the old hail of the north-west boats, which was the hail his father had given and his father before him, and which asks the stranger's harbour and his kin:

"Cò às a thàinig sibh?"

The voice on the ship called again, louder, as men do when they are not understood, and then another voice joined it, and a third, all saying something different. Lachlann hailed again. The ship's people pointed at the land, and at their mouths, and at the land again. One of them held up a wooden cask by its rope-handle and swung it so that it banged on the ship's side, and even at that distance Lachlann could hear that it was empty.

He sat down.

"Well," said his brother-in-law, who had brought the other boat in close. "What do we do?"

Nothing in all the customs of Dia-thìr told a fisherman what to do when the sea opened. There was the rule of sight-of-land, which said turn back, and there was the old law of the shore, which said that a man who asks for water is given water. The one told him to go home and the other told him to stay, and neither told him what to do with ships out of the north and a tongue that meant nothing.

"You go home," said Lachlann at last. "Tell them at Achadh àrsaidh what you saw. Tell them I've gone south to Cuan shean, and I've taken these with me, if they'll come."

"Why Cuan shean?"

"Because there are custodians there whose business it is to know. I don't know. You don't know."

His brother-in-law looked at the ships a while longer, spat over the side for luck, and put about for the cape. The boat went off into the light with her crew all turned round on the thwarts, looking back.

Lachlann put his tiller over and bore away south along the coast. When he looked back, the ships were following him.

That was the longest day of his life, by his own telling, and he told it often afterward. They ran south with the north wind on the quarter, past the headlands of the empty coast one after another, the black ships a mile astern and never nearer, shortening sail to keep behind a fishing boat as a man shortens his stride to

walk with a child. Past the cape of Baile chrom, where no fire had burned for a generation. Past the mouths of small rivers where nobody lived. His crew rowed when the wind dropped and sat with their hands between their knees when it rose again. They ate the bread they had brought for the fishing and drank the water, and toward evening one of them asked whether they should give some to the ships, and Lachlann said the ships would have to wait for the custodians like everyone else.

The fishers of Achadh àrsaidh gave the place of that meeting a name, Coinneachadh nan Long² (13 am Faoilleach, AE 1), and their boats slow there still when they pass it, as if something might come out of the north again.

It was full dark when Lachlann brought his boat round the last point and saw the lights of Cuan shean along the water, the long low rope-walks black against the town. He ran her up the shingle, and the first man who came down to see who was landing at that hour found him sitting on the gunwale with his head in his hands, and three lanterns hanging out on the sea behind him where no lanterns had ever been.

III

Of the Empty Cask

Oighrig nic Leòid had been custodian of Cuan shean for eleven years, and in that time the hardest thing she had been asked to decide was the line of a boundary between two rope-walks. She was near fifty, tall and big-handed, a widow whose sons had gone inland to the salt-pans and the capital, and she lived in the custodian's house above the harbour with a servant and a grey cat and a roll that had nothing much written in it.

They woke her that night. She went down to the shingle in her cloak and looked at the lanterns, and at Lachlann Odhar, and heard him out. Then she said that nobody was to put off to the ships in the dark, nor light any fire on the strand that could be taken for a sign, and that she would see them in the morning; and she went home and did not sleep.

In the morning there was no seeing them. The wind went round into the west in the night and blew hard, and when the light came Na Tri Longan¹ were stand-

2. the meeting of the ships

ing off and on beyond the bar, well out, with their topsails reefed, the sea breaking white along the reef between them and the harbour. They kept off like that for days, through a run of westerly weather such as the west coast gets in the back end of winter, and the whole town of Cuan shean stood on the dunes in the wind and watched them. Children made up names for them. The rope-makers laid bets on whether they would come in or go. Old women said they were the ships of Cabhlach an Scaraidh² come home at last, and other old women told them not to talk nonsense, and they went on saying it. At Seann Skell, half a day's walk up the coast, the priests of Manannan heard of the ships from a carter the second morning, and from that tide on they kept the prayer at every turn of the water without once missing, and a boy ran down the coast each evening to see whether the ships were still there, and ran back to tell them.

Lachlann Odhar stayed in Cuan shean. He said his boat was damaged, which was not true, and slept in a net-loft, and each morning he stood with the rest on the dunes.

The roll of Cuan shean sets the ships down first on 5 an Gearran, AE 1. On that morning the wind fell and the swell lay down, and the strangers' ships came in over the bar on the flood, one behind the other, feeling their way with a lead-line that a man swung and called from the bows, and let go their anchors off the town in water where no hull of their size had lain since Cabhlach an Scaraidh went out sunwise from Seann Skell and did not come back. The roar of the cables running out came over the water, and every gull on the strand went up at once.

Then a boat came off the nearest ship, with a man standing in the stern.

Oighrig went down to the shingle. She had her two fellow custodians with her, both older than she was and neither of them willing to be first, and behind them half the town, and behind the town the dunes with more people on them. She had put on her good cloak, and then thought better of it and put on her old one, and then gone back for the good one, and she was angry with herself about that all the way down the hill.

The boat grounded in the surf a stone's throw out, and the man in the stern jumped over the side into the water. It was up to his thighs and it was the cold sea of the back end of winter, and he gasped with it, and came on wading with a cask held up against his chest in both arms. Eleven men followed him out of the boat. She looked for weapons among them, and saw none, though one had a long knife

1. the three ships of the Crossing

2. the fleet of the Sundering

at his belt such as a fisherman carries. They were thin, all of them. Two of them had to hold each other up in the surf. The one in front was a man of about thirty-five with a short brown beard gone salt at the edges, a coat that had been good once, and eyes that went quickly over everything on the beach and came back to her, because she was the one standing a step in front.

The roll calls him Edmund Harrow. He came up out of the water onto the shingle, and stopped, and set the cask down at her feet, and knocked on it with his knuckles so that she could hear it was empty.

"Water," he said. "We need water, ma'am. We've been on short allowance a fortnight and the men are sick. Water. Do you understand me?"

She heard it as sounds. He heard her silence and tried again, slower, as men do, and then gave it up and did what any child of any shore would have done: he pointed at the cask and tipped his hand to his mouth, and made a little tilting motion with it, and swallowed.

There is a law of the shore on Dia-thir older than the custodians, older than Taigh na Fèithe³ and the crown, and every fisher's child knows it before she knows her letters. A man who comes up out of the sea and asks for water is given water. It asks nothing about who he is.

"Bring it," said Oighrig nic Leòid.

They brought it from the town well in two buckets, and she dipped the ladle herself and gave it into his hands, and he drank, and gave the ladle to the man behind him, and did not drink again until all eleven had drunk. She noticed that. The roll is silent on it; she said it afterward to the council in her letter, and the letter survives.

Then he pointed at the ships, and at the well, and made a gesture that took in the whole town and its wells and its fields behind, and looked at her with his eyebrows up.

She shook her head.

It was not hers to give. Water was given under the law of the shore. Anything more, a stay of a night on the strand, a sack of meal, a place for a sick man to lie, was a thing no custodian of Cuan shean had ever been asked in eighteen hundred years, and she knew it was not hers, and she knew that if she gave it the giving would be written in the roll and be a thing that had been done. She had them fill

3. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

the cask. She had them fill six more that the boat went back to fetch. Then she went up the hill to the custodian's house and wrote to Cathair dhearg.

The rider left within the hour. He was a rope-maker's son who kept a good horse, and she told him not to spare it. It is some twenty-six miles from Cuan shean up the valley road to the capital, and he was at the council's door by night-fall with the horse lathered and blown, and he gave the letter into the hand of the clerk of the council, who read it standing up, then sat down and read it again.

IV

Of the Forty Days below the Dunes

The council's first answer came back two days later. It said: feed them; keep them apart; decide nothing; the council will sit on it.

So Cuan shean fed them. The custodians would not let the strangers into the town, and would not let them stay aboard their ships and starve, and between the two they settled on the strand below the dunes, where the shingle gives way to hard sand and the marram grass holds the slope, a long stretch of beach with the town above it on one side and the sea on the other. The strangers came ashore there and put up shelters out of their spare sails and spars, and the town carried food down to them morning and evening. The roll gives it as forty days of feeding below the dunes. The roll counts the days and not the meal, which the custodians paid out of the town's own store and afterward put in the account to the council, where it was never repaid.

They were not easy days. The strangers were sick, most of them, with a sickness of the gums and the joints that comes to men who have lived too long on ship's food, and three of them died on the beach in the first weeks and were buried by their own people above the tide-line with a strange rite: a man read from a book, the rest stood bareheaded, and then all of them knelt on the sand. The children of Cuan shean watched that from the top of the dunes and could not be driven off. Afterward they played at it in the lanes, one reading out of a flat stone and the rest kneeling, until their mothers stopped them.

The fresh meat and the greens mended the rest. By the time the spring had come in, the strangers were walking about the strand like men and not like ghosts, and it was then that the town began to know them.

They could not be kept from working. That was the first thing Cuan shean learned about them. They had come down half starved and sick in a strange country, penned on a beach by people whose tongue they had not one word of, and as soon as they could stand they wanted something to do with their hands. They mended their own sails and caulked their boats. And then, because the fishers of Cuan shean spread their nets to dry along that same strand, the strangers began to mend the fishers' nets.

Nobody had asked them to. A fisher came down one morning and found a stranger sitting on the shingle with her torn net across his knees, knotting it up, and she stood over him with her mouth open until he looked up and grinned at her and held out his hand for more twine. He tied a knot the fishers had never seen, a flat hard knot that did not slip. By the end of the week half the strangers were at it. The fishers watched and learned the knot, and it is tied at Cuan shean to this day and called the strangers' knot.

Trade began the same way, out of nothing, with nobody deciding it. A stranger held out a button off his coat, a round thing of bright yellow metal with a device stamped on it, to a boy carrying a string of fish up the beach. The boy took the button and gave him a fish. By the next morning there were fishwives on the strand with baskets, and strangers with buttons, and the strangers' coats began to hang open. The custodians forbade it, and it went on, and they forbade it again, and it went on behind the dunes where they could not see. Oighrig let it be in the end. The roll notes that a good many buttons of yellow metal went into the town that spring and that the fishwives wore them on cords round their necks, and nothing more is said of it.

Word of the ships had reached Baile fhiadhaich, up the western coast, in two days, as word goes along a coast. Its custodian did not come at once, for the roads were bad and his knees were worse, but when the roads dried he rode south with two of his people to see for himself. He was an old man, a fisher's son who had held his town for thirty years and had opinions about everything, and he spent three days on the dunes and one on the strand among the strangers, feeling their ropes, looking at their blocks and their tackle, walking round their boats with his hands behind him. He asked Oighrig to take him out to the ships and she would not. Then he went home, and wrote to the council that the strangers' ropes were better than ours and their manners worse. The council kept the letter. The ropemakers of Cuan shean heard what he had said about the ropes before the ink was dry, and they took it hard, and three of them went down to the strand the next

day to look at the strangers' cordage for themselves. They came back and said nothing, which in a rope-maker is a great deal.

Harrow came to Oighrig's door many times in those weeks. He learned her name, or the sound of it, and he learned the word for water and the word for bread and the word for no, which he heard more than the other two. She learned his. He brought her things: a little glass that made small writing large, which she put away in a drawer and took out at night when nobody was looking; a length of fine cloth; a knife. She sent the knife back and kept the glass. He tried to tell her, with his hands and a stick in the sand and a great deal of talk she did not follow, where he had come from, and she understood from his drawing that it was north, and then east, round some great corner of sea, and she did not like the drawing and rubbed it out with her foot when he had gone.

She was never sure afterward whether she had liked him. She said in her letter that he was a man who asked for one thing at a time and was glad of it, and who always had the next thing ready.

Through all those days the priests of Manannan at Seann Skell kept the tide-prayer. When the boy told them the strangers were on the strand below Cuan shean, eating the town's bread, the eldest of the priests said that it made no difference, and they did not miss a tide in the forty days, nor in the days after. The harbour scribe wrote down their number each week, which was nine, and the state of Ceò Mhanannain¹, which was thin.

V

Of the Leave and the Margin

The council sat on it through the summer and into the autumn, and then, because nothing had been decided, sat on it through the winter. Custodians came in to Cathair dhearg from all over the island, from the hill towns and the eastern shore and the silver country and the far southern ports, some of them riding for a week, to sit in the council hall with the rain coming in off the lake and argue about ships that most of them had never seen. Ceann a' Chùrain¹ in those years was Tormod mac Ailein, a heavy, careful man of forty-five with a

1. Manannan's mist over the eastern sea

1. the high custodian of the Council of Custodians; lit. 'head of the custody'

lawyer's memory and a smith's hands, and he let them argue, and wrote down what they said, and said very little himself.

The strangers waited. They had long since come off the beach; the custodians had let them into the net-lofts along the harbour when the autumn gales began, since they could not in conscience leave men under sailcloth through a west-coast winter, and it was put in the roll that this was a shelter, and gave no leave. The ships lay in the harbour with skeleton crews aboard and their yards sent down. Harrow went twice to Cathair dhearg under the council's safe-conduct and stood in the hall and was looked at, and came back, and said nothing to anyone in Cuan shean about what he had seen there.

Oighrig nic Leòid fell ill at Samhain.

It began as a cough and went into her chest, and by the month of an Dùbhlachd she could not get out of her bed. The physician of Cuan shean sat with her, and her servant, and a sister of hers who came from inland; and Lachlann Odhar, who had never gone home, came up the hill one evening with a fish wrapped in a cloth, and stood in her doorway turning his cap in his hands, and she laughed at him and it made her cough for a quarter of an hour.

She knew the council was near to deciding. The custodians who passed through Cuan shean on their way up to Cathair dhearg came to her bedside, one after another, and told her so, each in the tone of a man who thinks he has brought news. She knew the way the hall was leaning. She knew that the iron the strangers carried in their ships was better than any iron on the island, that their carpenters had raised a boat-shed on the strand in four days that the carpenters of Cuan shean would have taken a month over, that their ships were the first ships in eighteen centuries, and that the ships that had brought them could come again. Every custodian who came to her bed told her one of those things. None of them told her anything else.

So she wrote to the council from her bed. The letter is in the roll of Cuan shean, copied fair by her clerk, with her own mark at the foot of it in a hand that shakes. It is short. She wrote that it was she who had given the strangers water, on the shore, under the old law of the shore, and that she had given them nothing more on her own word, because nothing more was hers to give. She wrote that she had fed them since because the council told her to, and that she had done it gladly. Last, she set down that the council should know, before it gave them anything else, that a leave given in the roll is given, and cannot be ungiven by the next

roll, and that the strangers would know that better than the council did, since it was they who would be holding it.

She asked that it be read out before the vote. The clerk's note on the copy says that it was received, and does not say that it was read.

On 11 am Faoilleach, AE 2, Comhairle a' Chùrain², sitting at Cathair dhearg in the crown's place, gave the strangers leave to stay, with Tormod mac Ailein in the chair. The clerk entered the vote in the roll as given with one voice. Tormod signed below it.

Later, in another ink and another hand, somebody wrote in the margin beside the entry that three custodians had been absent that day. It does not say who they were. Oighrig nic Leòid was one of them, lying in her bed at Cuan shean with the window shut against the wind. The other two are not named anywhere.

The copyists of Seilear Muileann chaol have kept that margin as they found it, with the note beside the vote. It is the first place in the record of An Aois Choigreach³ where what was written and what was so do not quite meet.

The news came back down the valley road to Cuan shean two days after. The rope-maker's son who had ridden up with the first letter rode down with the last, and went up the hill to Oighrig's house to tell her before he told the town, because he thought she ought to hear it first. She was asleep. Her sister told her when she woke, and she lay a while looking at the ceiling, and then asked for the cat.

She lived through the winter. She kept the custody of Cuan shean for many years yet, and never spoke of the vote to anyone, so far as the roll knows, except once, to Lachlann Odhar, and what she said to him he did not repeat.

VI

Of the Quarter of the Sea

The leave was read out on the strand at Cuan shean by one of Oighrig's fellow custodians, standing on an upturned boat, with a stranger beside him who had learned a little of the island's tongue in the net-lofts over the winter and put it into his own as well as he could. The strangers cheered, three

2. the Council of Custodians; lit. 'the council of the custody'

3. the Age of Strangers

times, in the way they had. The townspeople did not know what cheering was, and some of them thought it was a threat, and went indoors. Harrow shook the custodian's hand, and then the hands of everyone near him, and then went out to his ship in the boat, and that afternoon the strangers began to send the ships' yards back up.

It was in those weeks, at the back end of that second winter, that the saying began to go round the harbour.

It was the old sailors who said it first, the men who sat on the bench at the foot of the rope-walks in any weather and had done so since before most of the town was born. None of them had ever been out of sight of land, since the rule forbade it, but they had fished the western water all their lives, and their fathers before them, and they knew the set of every current and the lie of every sea-mark from the north-west capes to the mouth of the capital's river. They had watched the ships come in over the bar. They had watched the strangers' lead-line, and the way the ships stood off in the westerly blow and where they stood to. Over the winter they had talked with Lachlann Odhar about the gauze off the cape and the course the ships had come down on, and they had put it all together over a good many evenings on the bench.

What they said was this: that the strangers had come in from the same quarter of the sea into which Cabhlach an Scaraidh¹ had sailed.

That was all they said. They did not say what it meant. But it went up the valley road with the carters in a week, and it was said in the capital, and in the council hall, where at last a custodian of the hill country stood up and said it out loud before Tormod mac Ailein and the whole council. The council forbade the saying in its hall (9 an Gearran, AE 2). The clerk was told to strike it from the roll. He struck it, and then, being a careful man, wrote below the striking what it was he had been told to strike, so that the next clerk should know. It is there still, and it was never answered.

Lachlann Odhar went home to Achadh àrsaidh at last in the month of an Gearran, more than a year after he had left it for a morning's fishing. On the day he went he walked down to the harbour at Cuan shean early, with his bag over his shoulder, and stood on the harbour wall to look at the ships. They lay at anchor off the town with their yards crossed and their sails loosed to dry, and there were strangers going up and down their sides and in and out of the town now as if it

1. the fleet of the Sundering

were their own. Three of the old sailors were on the bench below the wall, and a fishwife with a yellow button on a cord, and a boy mending a net with the strangers' knot, and a stranger with him, showing him how to draw it tight.

Lachlann stood up on the wall. He was a man who had brought Na Trì Longan² down the coast behind him in a day, and he had heard that the saying was forbidden in the council hall, and he was not in the council hall.

"They came out of the quarter Cabhlach an Scaraidh went into," he said, loudly, so that the whole harbour could hear it. "I saw them come. The grey was gauze, and they came down out of it from the north, the way the old men say the old ships went. There's nobody here who doesn't know it."

The old sailors on the bench looked at him and then looked away at the water. The fishwife picked up her basket. The boy went on with the net. The stranger beside him looked up at Lachlann, hearing a man shouting from a wall, and smiled uncertainly, and went back to showing the boy the knot.

Nobody answered him. Lachlann stood a while longer on the wall with the wind pulling at his coat. Then he climbed down, and went along the strand to his boat, and put out for the north, and was a long way up the coast before the harbour lost sight of him.

CHAPTER TWO

OF FORTY WORDS FOR THE COLOURS OF COAL

AE 2 – 3

I

Of the Land Beyond

2. the three ships of the Crossing

By the back end of that second winter Comhairle a' Chùrain¹ had given leave to a people it had no name for, and the clerks of the roll were the first to feel the want of one.

In the forty days below the dunes the clerks had called the newcomers the men of the ships, and Harrow's men, and once, in a hand afterwards scored through, the wet men. That did well enough while they were a wonder on a beach. Leave to stay is another matter. It is given to people who come from somewhere, and the clerk who entered the leave on 11 am Faoilleach, AE 2, left a gap after the words *the people of*, meaning to fill it when he knew what to put there. He never filled it.

The strangers had told their country's name to the custodians of Cuan shean many times over, slowly and loudly, as men talk to the deaf, and nobody on the island ever learned to say it so that its owners knew it for theirs. No scribe tried to write it down. What the island called the place in the end came up the valley road from the harbour with the carters, and it was the fishers' way of naming a thing they could not reach: *an Tìr Thall*², the land beyond. On 26 an Gearran, AE 2, the clerk of the council wrote it into the roll for the first time, and after that he wrote nothing else, and neither did any clerk after him. The people of it the rolls called the humans, as if the island had never had any of its own, and so they are called in this telling.

Gormshuil nic Fhearchair read that entry in the fair copy the morning after it was made. She sat on the council for Clann Fhearchair, as her father had before her, and she was in her forty-second year that winter, a tall woman with a long plain face and grey coming in at her temples, who wrote a better hand than any clerk in the hall and was known for it. When the leave was put she had given her voice for it, thinking of the cask Harrow had held out on the shingle at Cuan shean, empty and turned upside down, and of what it must be to be so far from home that you have to ask a stranger for water with your hands. Beyond that she had not thought much. Few had.

The news that came up from Cuan shean in those weeks was mostly of small things: sails mended on the strand, fish bought with buttons, singing on the ships in the evenings that carried over the water and set the dogs howling. On the day they kept for their god, which came round every seventh morning whatever the moon was doing, the strangers did no work at all, and when the rain came on they asked the town, by signs, for a roof to pray under.

1. the Council of Custodians; lit. 'the council of the custody'

2. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

A sailmaker of Cuan shean lent them his loft. The custodians of the town set down what they saw there, and theirs is the first entry on the island to tell of the humans at prayer under a roof. The strangers knelt on the sailcloth among the bolts of canvas, the captain with the rest. One of their priests stood before them with a book. They lit no fire and burned nothing. They sang, and the priest read, and at the end they all said a word together that sounded like a door shutting. Two of Manannan's priests of the harbour went and stood on the loft stair to watch, the roll says, and came down again without a word, and went to the water's edge to say their own prayer at the turn of the tide.

The strangers had one god, and no other, and they called him by a name the island heard as *Criosd*³. Their faith they called by a word their priests used of the whole company of their believers, and the Dia-thìrich made of it *an Eaglais*. Those two words went into the roll that season, the first of the humans' tongue that the island took and kept.

It was in the month after, when the carts were back on the roads and the rain had turned soft, that Tormod mac Ailein sent for her.

Ceann a' Chùrain⁴ was a heavy, slow man with a beard that had gone white before his hair, and he kept a room at the top of the council hall with a window on the lake. On the table before him lay a letter in the humans' hand, which he could not read, and one from the custodians of Cuan shean, which he had read twice.

"They want words," he said. "Their priests do. They cannot teach their god to people who cannot understand them, nor trade with them either, and they would like to do both. They have asked Cuan shean for somebody to sit with them at a table and trade words as a man trades fish, one for one, until each side has enough to buy bread with."

"And Cuan shean sends to us."

"Cuan shean has sent to us for everything since the first ship," said Tormod. "Oighrig nic Leòid is still in her bed. The priests will come up to the capital, and the council wants a custodian to sit across the table from them and keep our side of the list."

"The council wants a clerk."

3. Christ

4. the high custodian of the Council of Custodians; lit. 'head of the custody'

"The council wants somebody who will not give away more than she is paid for." He moved one hand. "You have the best hand in the hall. You have more patience than I have. And you are not afraid of them."

"I have never been near them."

"That is what I mean," said Tormod mac Ailein.

So the council gave the keeping of the word-list to Gormshuil nic Fhearchair, and the roll enters it in a line, between a dispute over a mill-lade and the price of lamp-oil for the temple. She went home that evening and told her brother's daughter Muireall, who had been copying the roll for her since the autumn and had ink worked into the skin of her wrists that no washing would lift. Muireall was thirteen. She wanted to know at once whether she might come to the table, and whether the strangers really had hair on their faces as the carters said.

"You may come to the table," said Gormshuil. "You will sit at the end of it and make the fair copy, and you will not speak unless I tell you."

II

Of Cup and Bread

They came up from Cuan shean at the beginning of the seed-time moon, which the old folk call Siolach: two priests and a boy, on three ponies of the town, with a custodian's man walking at the head to show them the road. It is a long day's ride from the harbour to Cathair dhearg, and the priests were no horsemen. They came over the bridge at dusk soaked through, the older of the two sitting his pony like a sack of meal, and the younger coughing.

The younger was Samuel Wren. He was a thin man of about thirty, with long hands and a narrow face and a courteous way of bending his head when he was spoken to, as if to bring his ear nearer the words. The damp of the lake country did not agree with him. He coughed that first night in the house the council had lent them below the temple, and through most of the spring after, a dry catching cough that he would turn away from the table to finish, with a hand up, as if apologising to the room. The older priest was a broad red-faced man with the sea still in his walk, who slept a great deal.

The council gave them a long room on the east side of the hall, with a table under a window of thin-scraped horn, a shutter that could be taken down on fine days, and a peat fire at the far end. On the first morning Gormshuil was there be-

fore them. She had set her pens and her ink on her side of the table, and a stack of the grey rag paper they made at Muileann chaol, and Muireall sat at the end with the same.

Wren came in and bowed to her from the door. She inclined her head. He sat down opposite and took out of a leather case a quire of paper so white that Muireall gasped aloud and was frowned at; it was more paper than the council used in a moon. Then he looked across at Gormshuil, and she looked at him, and for a long while nobody said anything at all, because there was nothing either of them knew how to say.

In the end he picked up the cup at his elbow, which had water in it, and held it up between them, and said a word.

She dipped her pen and wrote the word in the stag-letters of the island, as near to the sound as the letters would go. Then she reached for the loaf that the hall's kitchen had sent up, and broke a piece off, and held it up in her turn.

"*Aran*," she said.

He wrote it in his own letters, slowly, with his lips moving, and said it back to her. He said it badly. She said it again. He said it better. And so it went, all through that morning and the mornings after: cup and bread, and water, and table, and hand, and knife, and window, and door; the one holding up a thing and giving its name, the other writing and saying it back; and the older priest asleep in his chair by the fire with his chin on his chest, and Muireall at the end of the table, copying every word fair, in both hands, as best she could manage the strangers' letters by the shape of them.

The things that could be held up were the easy part.

For three days Wren had her word for *finger* written down as the word for *that*, because she had pointed with her finger when she said it, and nobody could find the mistake until Muireall, copying, saw the same word against two things that were not the same. A whole morning went on *go* and *come*, with Wren walking to the door and back a dozen times while Gormshuil watched him. He pointed at the rain running off the sill and she said *uisce*, and he wrote it; then he pointed at the jug and she said *uisce* again, and he looked from one to the other, and laughed out loud, the first time she had heard him laugh, and wrote something long in the margin. Afterwards she learned that his people had one word for the water in the jug and another for the water that falls from the sky, and could not think how a people managed with only the one. She could not think how a people could need two.

He learned quickly. She learned more quickly than he did, though she was careful not to let him see it. By the end of Sìolach he could ask *Dè seo?*, what is this, with his head on one side, and she could ask him the same in his own tongue, and the table went faster.

There was one morning in that spring that the copyists set down because Wren's list still keeps what came of it. He had drawn a great wheel cut into twelve like a cake, with a word in each piece, and he tapped the pieces one after another and pointed out of the window at the sky. It took her most of the morning to understand that these were the months of his year, fixed to the sun, and that he wished to know what the island called them.

The island had no months of that kind. It had the moons. She drew them for him: twelve moons of thirty nights and twenty-nine in turn, each begun on the night of the full and turning at the dark, from Samhnas at the year's beginning, through Dubhlas and Faolach and Gearras, through the seed-time and the gap and the bright fire, round to the stags' moon at the year's end. He set his months against her moons one by one, as near as they would go, and wrote the moon's name beside each piece of his wheel. It went well enough until she drew the thirteenth.

She told him its name, *Eadrach*, the between-moon, and showed him with her hands how the keepers of the reckoning put it in at the year's end every thirtieth moon or so, so that Samhain should not come round before the summer was over. He understood at last what it was for, and could find nowhere on his wheel to put it. In the end he wrote it in the margin outside the wheel altogether, with a mark after it that Muireall copied without knowing what it meant, and which Gormshuil learned afterwards was the humans' sign for a question.

One morning in seven he did not come. The first time, Gormshuil thought him ill and sent Muireall down with a crock of broth, and the girl came back with the broth and said the priests were kneeling on the floor of the front room with the shutters closed, and the boy had shut the door on her. After that Gormshuil counted the mornings on her fingers. The island reckoned its time by nights, from dusk to dusk; the humans counted by days, and by these sevens of days, and nobody on the island had ever divided time by seven for any reason at all. She wrote the seven into the list with their names as he gave them, and beside each the thing she knew of it, which for six of them was nothing.

The peat fire at the end of the room smoked when the wind was in the east. On the worst of those mornings Wren's cough came on so hard that he had to get

up from the table and go to the window, and Gormshuil had Muireall bring a brazier of the fire's embers up to his end of the table. He held his long hands over it. Then he pointed at the embers and raised his eyebrows.

"*Mòine*," said Gormshuil.

His face lit up. He said his own word for it and made a digging motion with both hands; then he made the motion again, deeper, and said a different word, and pointed away east over the lake towards his own country. This we have too, he meant, tapping the brazier; and this other, which we burn at home, the stone that is dug from under the ground. It was black, he showed her, holding up the ink-pot, and it burned hot and long, and his people burned it in every house.

Gormshuil wrote the word down as he said it, and beside it, in the *Dia-thìris* column, she wrote what he had told her: *the black stone the humans dig in their own country and burn on their hearths*. It was one line among two hundred, and she thought nothing of it.

By the dark of the year there were some hundreds of words on each side of the table. On 13 an Dùbhlachd, AE 2, the council's clerk came in with his own ink to enter in the roll how far the work had come, and found both lists lying side by side, Wren's in his white quire and Gormshuil's on the grey paper of Muileann chaol, and counted the leaves of each, and wrote that they were near enough even. The roll puts it no more warmly than that. For a season's work between two people who had begun it with a cup and a loaf, it was a good deal.

III

Of the Basket of Coal

It was in the wolf-moon, when the island's hearths burn their hottest and the high passes are shut, that she did the thing the age remembers her for.

She had been thinking of it since before the dark of the year. Some hundreds of words lay between them now: cup and bread, rain and knife, a boat and its sail and every line that works a sail, and the moons and his months. They had peat, and the black stone of his own country. And in all those moons of pointing and naming, Wren had never once pointed at the coal of the vein, nor asked what it was called, nor seemed to know there was anything there to ask about.

He could not have lived three months in the capital and missed it. The shrine at the temple door kept the measured handful burning under its hood day and

night, as Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig¹ allowed, and the carriers came down from Taigh na Fèithe² with their sealed baskets on the white road, and every child in the town knew to stand aside for them. He had watched them go by, she knew, because she had watched him watching. He had never asked.

So on a still morning of thin winter sun she went up to the hall early, before the priests were out of bed, and had the shutter taken down from the window so that the light came in clear. She took from the council's store the basket that the carriers had brought down for the shrines of the capital, broken fresh from the vein that autumn, and she chose from it with her own hands a double handful, the best-broken pieces she could find. It broke no law. A custodian may carry the coal and hold it and show it; it is the burning that is measured. She set the basket on the table under the window and sat down behind it and waited.

Wren came in coughing, with the older priest behind him and the boy with the ink. He bowed. She inclined her head. Then she stood up, took the basket in both hands, and tipped it out on the table where the sun lay, and the coal ran out across the boards and came to rest in the light.

It was black as a wet crow, and bright all over with a sheen like oil on water. Where the pieces had split, the colours lay along the edges.

Gormshuil began to name them.

There was the green that lies under the black like deep water under weed, and she laid her finger on it and said *uaine*, and then the word for that green and no other, which is not the green of grass nor of the sea. There was the red at a fresh break that deepens if you breathe on it, and she breathed on it and showed him, and gave its word. She gave the grey-violet of the old cuttings, that no dyer has ever matched; and the brown that shows the piece came from near the surface; and the blue that runs along a split edge like the light on a mackerel's back. She gave a colour like the heather in Lùnastal, and one like the dark of a blackberry, and one like rust on a nail left out in the rain. There was the colour of an ember just before it goes grey, and there was the colour of the ember after. There was a hair-line of something like gold that ran through one piece and out the other side, and a sheen on another like a pigeon's neck, which changes as you turn it; and she turned it in the sun and gave him the two words for the two colours it showed, and then the third word, for the piece that shows both.

She laid her finger on each piece as she came to it and gave each colour its own word, plainly and without hurry, as any child of the hills could have done, and as

her mother had done for her with a double handful on the kitchen table when she was four years old. Muireall at the end of the table wrote them as fast as her pen would go. Wren wrote too, at first. He wrote the green, and the red at the break, and the grey-violet, and several more, and said them back to her with his head bent in the way he had.

She gave forty. There were more. She stopped because Wren had stopped writing.

He had put down his pen. He reached out and picked up one of the pieces, a large one with the green deep in it and the red at one end, and held it up to the window and turned it in the light, with his eyes narrowed, the way a man looks at a coin he suspects. Then he looked at her across the table. There was nothing unkind in the look at all. It was puzzled, and gentle, and a little sorry for her, as a grown man is sorry for a child who has told him a long story about the faces in the fire.

He laid the piece down with the rest and said one word. Then he took up his pen and wrote one word, and tapped the whole heap with the end of the pen, lightly, once, to show her that his word stood for all of it.

It took her a breath or two to know the word. When she did she sat without moving.

It was the word he had given her in the spring over the brazier, with the digging motion and the finger pointing east. It was the black stone of his own country, that his people dug out of the ground and burned in every house.

The sun had moved a little along the table. She could hear the older priest breathing by the fire, and a cart going down the hill outside, and Muireall's pen, which had stopped. She waited for him to ask for her word. There is an old courtesy on the island, when one has given the name of a thing and had the other's name back: *Agus thu fhèin?* And yours? It was in her mouth to say, if he would only ask the question to which it was the answer. She waited for him to ask what the island called the whole heap, the one word for all of it, since he had given her his.

He smiled at her. He moved the coal aside with the flat of his hand, gently, to make room on the table, and he reached behind him to the shelf and took down a candle, and held it up.

"*Coinneal*," said Gormshuil nic Fhearchair, after a moment.

1. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

He wrote it down. The morning went on.

When the priests had gone at noon she gathered the coal up a piece at a time and carried the basket down to the store herself, and saw it counted back in against the carriers' tally, not a crumb short; and it went up the hill to the shrine at the temple door with the rest of the capital's measure, and burned there under the hood in its turn, as it was meant to.

Muireall walked home with her that evening and did not say anything until they were over the bridge.

"He could not see them," she said then.

"No."

"Not any of them. Not the green. I watched his face. He looked and looked."

"He looked," said Gormshuil.

"Then how do they know what it is?" said Muireall. "When they burn it. How do they know what they are burning?"

Her aunt had no answer to give her, and gave none.

IV

Of the Note under the First Leaf

The list was bound in the gap-moon, when the stores run low and the first green has not yet come. Gormshuil had kept it through the year on loose sheets in a box, as the words came, and now that the season of words was plainly done she gave the sheets to Muireall to copy fair into a book for the keeping of Clann Fhearchair, and to be copied again after that for whoever else might want it.

She gave one order about the copying. The colours were to go first.

Muireall looked at her. The sheets began with cup and bread, as the work had. That was the order of the table, and it was the order the council's clerk had counted.

"The colours first," said her aunt. "Before the cup. Put them on the first leaf by themselves, and leave room at the foot."

So the first leaf of the fair copy holds forty words for the colours of broken coal, in Muireall's hand, which was young and careful and larger than it later grew, and nothing else on it but the room at the foot. The copyists of this cellar

know that leaf well. It has been handled more than any other leaf in the loft where it lies, and the corners have gone soft as cloth.

The list had two columns, the island's word on the left and Wren's on the right. For the forty colours Muireall came to the right-hand column and stopped with her pen in the air. There was one word she might have written in it forty times over. There was no other.

She went to her aunt with the leaf and asked her what she ought to put.

"Put what happened," said Gormshuil.

"All of it?"

"As much as goes at the foot of the leaf."

Muireall took it back to the table by the window and sat over it most of an afternoon. What she wrote at the foot of the leaf, on 23 an Giblean, AE 3, is short, and it is in the girl's hand and the girl's words, and it runs like this. The humans have one word for the coal of the vein. It is their word for the black fuel they burn on the hearths of their own country. No Dia-thiris word, in either list, answers to it. And they did not ask.

She brought it to her aunt, and stood while it was read.

"Should I have written that he was kind?" she said. "He was. He was kind about it."

"You have written what happened," said Gormshuil. "Leave it."

It was about that time, perhaps the same week, that Gormshuil went across the table to Wren with a request of her own.

She had been turning it over since the morning of the basket. He would not learn her colours, and she had given up waiting for the question; the word he had written for the heap was all his eyes could give him, and no patience across a table would put another in its place. Then she would learn his letters. There would be more of these people, and more paper, a great deal more paper, she thought; and a custodian who could not read what was written about the island in its own capital would be a poor sort of custodian.

She put her finger on a line of his writing, and then on her own breast, and then made the motion of a pen.

Wren understood her before she had finished, and was delighted. Since his god's book was written in those letters, he had been looking for a year for somebody on the island who would learn them, and here was the council's own custodian asking. From his white quire he took a clean sheet there and then, and wrote across the top of it the letters of his tongue, all of them, in their order, large

and plain; and under them he wrote them small; and then, underneath, as a gift, he wrote her name the way he heard it.

She looked at it a long time. It was a long name in his letters, with more of them in it than it had sounds, and it looked to her like somebody else's. She let it stand. She copied it out underneath, stroke by stroke, the first thing she ever wrote in the humans' letters, and he clapped his long hands together, and the older priest woke up and asked what had happened.

After that there were two lessons at the table. In the mornings they went on with words, more slowly now, for the easy ones were done; in the afternoons Wren taught her his letters, and she learned them as she did everything, without fuss and faster than he expected. By the end of that spring she could spell out a line of his list with her finger under it, and she did.

She found the page of the coal. It was in his white quire with the rest, and she read it through with Muireall at her shoulder. He had written the green at the top of the page, as near to her word as his letters would go, and the red at the break under it, and the grey-violet, and a few more down the page in his careful hand. Then there was a line drawn under them. Under the line was his one word, and a stroke of the pen that joined it to all the others above it, and then nothing more on that page at all.

V

Of the Chest for Muileann chaol

The fair trade began that summer, at the moon of the bright fire, and for the first time Gormshuil saw from her own window what the season of words had been for.

The strangers' goods came up from Cuan shean on the carts, iron knives and pots, window glass packed in straw, lamp-oil and white paper; wool and hides and salt fish and dyed cloth went down the other way; and in the market below the hill men of both peoples stood over the same bales and haggled with the words that had come out of the long room on the east side of the hall, and got them wrong, and laughed more often than they quarrelled. Gormshuil went down one morning on purpose, and stood among the stalls, and watched a hill shepherd give a fleece for a knife, and the stranger who took the fleece weigh it in his hands

and nod, and the shepherd test the knife's edge on his thumbnail and nod. She could find nothing unfair in it anywhere. She looked.

The council entered the first of those bargains in its roll, fleece for knife, cloth for glass, with both prices in the island's reckoning, so that anyone who came after could see that the strangers had given good measure. It was good measure. The copyists set that down plainly, since much of what they must set down later is otherwise. The island had been alone for eighteen centuries and lacked a great deal that the strangers had, and it was glad of what it got.

Wren bought wool too. Gormshuil's sister knitted him a pair of stockings from the fleece of the hill ewes, grey and thick, for the damp; and he gave Gormshuil in return a quire of his white paper and a steel pen, the first she had held, which never needed cutting. She wrote with it for twenty years.

It was the paper that decided her.

Through that spring she had watched him use it as if there were no end to it. A word he did not like cost a fresh sheet. A page spoiled with a blot was crumpled in his long hands and, when the brazier was lit, dropped on the embers to burn. Paper came in his ship's hold by the bale, and he meant nothing by it, any more than a baker means something when he throws a burnt loaf to the gulls. But she saw him do it, again and again, and she thought of the fair copy of her list, and of Clann Fhearchair's book-chest, which stood against the wall of a timber house in a town full of timber houses, and of how the strangers' ships had come down out of a sea that had been shut for eighteen centuries, and what else might come down out of it now that it was open.

There was one place on the island where nothing was burned.

Muileann chaol is a narrow mill town in the eastern hills, where they made the first paper on Dia-thìr from rags, and in it stands the loft of Beathag nic Thòmais. Beathag had been a mill-owner's widow in An Aois Scraidh¹ who bought up the old copies of Leabhar a' Chùrain² and the harbour rolls from houses that no longer read them, and stacked them in the loft over her mill; and when she died she left the loft and all that was in it to the town, on the one condition that nothing in it should ever be burned. The town had kept that condition since, and the custodian houses sent copies there when they had a thing they wished to be sure of.

So Gormshuil had Muireall make a second fair copy of the list, the whole of it, the colours first and the note at the foot of the first leaf, word for word as in the

first. It took the girl the rest of that moon. When it was done Gormshuil read it through against the first and found two mistakes and had them put right. Then she wrapped it in oilcloth, and laid it in a small chest of oak with straw about it, and sealed the chest with the seal of Clann Fhearchair, and wrote on the lid in the stag-letters where it was to go.

The carriers going east to the hills left the capital two days after, with the chest in the bottom of a cart under a load of the strangers' iron pots. It is some three days' road from Cathair dhearg to Muileann chaol, and longer with a laden cart.

Gormshuil and Muireall walked down with the cart as far as the bridge on a bright morning with a wind off the lake. At the far end of Drochaid Cathair dhearg³ the cart went on up the eastern road, and they watched it out of sight between the hedges, and Muireall asked her aunt whether anybody at Muileann chaol would ever read it.

"Somebody will," said Gormshuil. "It is a long time, in a loft."

Then they went back up the hill, because Wren would be waiting at the table, and it was the afternoon, and the afternoons were for his letters.

The copy came safe to the loft, and the loft keeps it still. Gormshuil's own list, the one she kept at the table, is lost; Wren's lies in the humans' letter-books in his own hand, in a good black ink that has not faded. The copyists of Seilear Muileann chaol have the two before them as they set down this age, side by side as they lay on the table in the long room. They have set the first leaf of the copy, and the note at its foot in the careful hand of a girl of fourteen, at the head of the whole age.

1. the Age of Sundering

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

3. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

CHAPTER THREE

Of the Post at Ros dhomhain

AE 3 – 5

I

Of the Counter

The humans' post at Ros dhomhain opened its door on 22 an t-Ògmhios, AE 3, in a net-loft on the lake shore that the fishers of the town let to Thomas Pike for a bolt of blue cloth a season. The loft had a floor of tarred planks and a smell of old rope that never left it. Pike had a counter built across it from wall to wall, waist-high, of ship's timber, and on the counter he laid a book bound in calf, a pen, a pot of ink, and a steelyard from the ship's stores with its hook and its sliding pea. Behind the counter, on shelves his own men put up, stood what Na Trí Longan¹ had carried over the sea for trading: iron tools in bundles tied with tarred twine, crates of window glass packed in straw, casks of lamp-oil, and reams of paper wrapped in oilcloth.

He was a man of some thirty years, short and square, with ink in the grain of his fingers and a habit of setting his hat down on the counter crown-first. The custodians of the capital shore who came to look him over on the first morning wrote that he stood up when they came in, which the strangers' sailors did not do, and that he looked at each thing that was set down before him as if it might be worth more than he had been told. Of all who wrote in those years he counted best, and his tally-book survives, in his own small upright hand.

The first thing across the counter was a bale of wool from a farm above the lake. The farmer had come in on a borrowed cart with two sons and a dog, and stood a long time in the doorway before he would come in. Pike weighed the bale

1. the three ships of the Crossing

on the steelyard and wrote the figure. Then he laid out, one at a time, the things he would give for it: a spade-blade, a hand-axe, a box of nails. The farmer looked at the nails for a long while. He took one out, turned it over, tried its point on his thumb, and at last put it in his mouth and bit it. Then he nodded, and Pike wrote a line in the book, and ruled it off.

That was how the post was kept for its first season: one thing set against another, each weighed or counted, each line ruled off. Wool came in, and salt fish in creels, and hides, and cloth dyed in the island's own madder and woad; iron went out, and glass, and oil, and paper. Pike had forty words of the island's tongue from Harrow's winter on the dunes, and he learned more at the counter, where a word is worth what it buys. He learned the words for hand and half-hand, for a creel and a fleece and a bundle, and the word for *enough*, which the farmers said sharply, as if it closed a door.

The custodians sent a clerk to sit on a stool by the door. He was a young man with ink to his wrists, and he kept a tally of his own on a long slate, marked in the old way with strokes and crosses, and at the end of each day he and Pike laid the two counts side by side. The clerk could not read the humans' figures and Pike could not read the strokes, and so each read his own aloud, item by item, in a speech that grew between them out of both tongues. On the evening they first found a difference, a single hide, they went through the day's goods again together by lamplight, and found the hide under a creel of fish where a boy had set it down. Pike wrote beside the line, in his own tongue, *found*, and the clerk made a mark on the slate that he said meant the same.

"Your book and his slate," Harrow said, when he came up from Cuan shean at the end of an t-Ògmhios and heard of it. "Two books for one trade."

"Two books that agree," said Pike. "I would sooner have that than one."

At the end of the first month the book balanced to the last line. Pike showed it to the custodians' clerk, turning the pages for him, and the clerk, who could read none of it, looked at the ruled lines for a long time, and then laid his slate beside it and showed him that the strokes balanced also.

II

Of the Hull in the Shallows

In the first weeks everything that came to the counter had come twenty miles and more by cart from Cuan shean, where Harrow's hulls lay in the roads below the dunes, and everything the post took in went back the same way. It was slow and dear. The carts went over the moor road in two days with the axles shrieking, and Pike's men walked beside them in the rain, and the carters of Cuan shean charged for every creel. So Harrow went down to the strait of Caol leathan to ask the pilots there whether a ship of his could be brought up the Abhainn gheal into Loch chrom.

The pilots of Caol leathan had taken toll of every boat bound for the capital's waters since An Aois Naomh¹, and they knew the river as a ploughman knows his furrow. They came up the coast in their own boats and went over the smallest of Harrow's hulls from her keel to her masthead, and argued among themselves a whole afternoon in their own speech, and at last named a price. It was twice the toll they took from any boat of Dia-thìr. Harrow was angry, and Pike, who had come down to see it done, wrote the price in his book and wrote beside it in his own tongue: *fair, for they know the shallows and we do not.*

On 21 an t-Iuchar, AE 3, they brought her up. Pike rode on her deck. The pilots took her in over the bar at the flood with six of their boats ahead of her on tow-lines, the oarsmen singing a slow count that kept the oars together, and the hull came on behind them, a great dark thing among the reeds with her sails furled and her yards cockbilled to clear the alders. Below Baile ghlas the river spreads out over gravel, and there she touched. Pike felt the deck lift under him and settle. The pilots did not shout. They let her lie on the gravel a while, and put two boats to her stern and two to each bow, and waited for a gust off the lake that came when they had said it would, and she slid off and swam again. The people of Baile ghlas had come down to the bank to watch, the rope-makers with their hands still hooked from the walk, and some of them cheered and some said nothing at all.

She anchored that evening off Ros dhomhain, in the lake, with the capital's roofs red in the low sun behind her. Thereafter the humans' goods came to the capital shore by water.

A month after, on 19 an Lùnastal, AE 3, a coasting boat came in from the northern coast with wool from Cathair naomh, the city above Seann Toll, the first goods that came to the post from so far. Her master had brought her round the

1. the Holy Age

western capes and up the river behind a pilot of his own. He carried a letter from the custodians of Cathair naomh, which the clerk by the door read aloud to Pike slowly, and which asked to be paid for the wool in paper and in ink, and in nothing else.

"Paper," said Pike. "All of it?"

"All of it," said the clerk, and read on. Their roll was old and full, the custodians wrote, and written on skins that were cracking; they would begin it again on the humans' paper, fair from the first page.

Pike gave them a ream for every bale and two bottles of ink besides, and put a quire of his own writing-paper in with the rest, uncounted. It is the only line in the whole book that he did not balance. He wrote beside it: *gift*.

Harrow sailed for home at the end of an Lùnastal. All three hulls went with him, north-about, with hides and dyed cloth in their holds, and he left Pike four men, the loft, the book, and the half of the goods not yet traded. Pike stood on the shingle at Cuan shean and watched the sails go north along the coast until the grey of the sea took them. Then he rode back to the counter, and was there the next morning when the door opened.

III

Of the Bar-Iron

Gilleasbuig Gobha was twenty-three years old in the year the post opened, and a smith of Cathair dhearg, as his father had been and his grandfather.

He had a forge in the smiths' lane below the bridge, where the lane runs down to the Abhainn dhomhain, and he worked bronze there as his fathers had: he cast hoes and sickles, pins and pot-legs and bells, and mended what broke. He was a tall young man, long in the arm, and when he stood at the anvil he stooped like a heron over a pool.

The humans' bar-iron came to the smiths' lane on 17 an t-Sultain, AE 3, on a cart from the lake shore, twenty bars of it tied with wet rope, and the smiths of the lane came out of their doors to look. They had seen the strangers' iron since the spring, as axes and spades and nails in the hands of farmers who had traded wool for them, and they had tried to mend it when it broke and could not. Here it was raw, grey and scaled, each bar as long as a man's forearm. Gilleasbuig

bought two bars with a bronze pot and a pair of shears, and carried them home on his shoulder.

He put the first in his fire as he would have put in bronze, and it did nothing. When he blew up the charcoal it glowed a dull red and would not move under the hammer. So he blew the fire white, and the bar came out spitting sparks like a green log, and when he struck it, it broke across in a spray of crumbs, and the broken ends were grey and grainy like stale bread. He had burnt it. That night he sat on the doorstep with the two halves in his lap and said to his wife Sine that the strangers had sold him a thing made of ash.

It was a smith off Harrow's ships who taught him. The ships' smith was a short man and thick through the body, who had stayed ashore at the post with Pike's four men, and who could say nothing at all in the island's tongue and talked with his hands and his hammer. He came up to the lane in an t-Sultain, sent by Pike, with a bag of his own tools, and he stood at Gilleasbuig's fire and watched the colour of the bar in it with his head on one side, and took the bellows-handle out of Sine's hand and slowed it. At an orange that had some yellow in it he drew the bar out and struck, and it moved under the hammer like cold butter. Then the man laughed, and gave Gilleasbuig the hammer.

All that autumn they worked together, the smith of the ships and the smith of the lane, with no word between them that both knew. Gilleasbuig learned to draw a bar and to fold it and to weld it in the fire with a pinch of sand. He learned to make a nail in eleven blows. The ships' smith had a word for each thing he did, and said it every time, and Gilleasbuig learned the words by the doing and forgot most of them, and kept the doing.

The tempering was last, and hardest. The ships' smith took a blade that Gilleasbuig had forged and ground, and heated it until it glowed, and plunged it hissing into a bucket of brine. When it came out it was hard as flint and would cut a hair, and it would also break like flint if it were dropped on the stones; he showed that with a spoiled one, and the pieces rang on the floor. Then he polished the hard blade bright and held it over a bed of coals, a hand's breadth above, and they watched it together.

The colours came up out of the bright steel like breath on glass. First a pale straw, then a darker straw, then a brown like a beech leaf in autumn, then a purple, then a blue like the sea in the lee of a headland. The ships' smith said a word at the straw and a word at the blue, and at the blue he took the blade away and let it cool. Now it would bend a little, and spring back, and hold its edge.

Gilleasbuig saw more in the steel than two words. Between the straw and the brown there was a colour like new rushes, and between the brown and the purple there was one like a hen's egg held to a lamp, and he had the island's words for both of them, and for the others as they came. He said them aloud as the steel went through them. The ships' smith listened, and looked, and nodded at each; and when Gilleasbuig named the last colour before the blue, the man held up a finger and said his own word for it, which was a different word, and they both looked at the steel and agreed that it was the same colour.

So it was that the two peoples first agreed on a colour, in a smithy below Drochaid Cathair dhearg¹, and the thing that they agreed on was the colour of hot iron.

Gilleasbuig tempered his first blade alone in the last days of an Dùbhlachd, when the rain came off the lake in sheets and the lane ran with water. It was a knife with a blade the length of a hand. He took it to the straw that is next to the brown and no further, as he judged a knife should be, and quenched it, and ground it, and cut a strip of hide with it that his old bronze knife would only have bruised. He gave the knife to Sìne, who kept it by her board and would let no one else touch it. The ships' smith was down at the post that day, and did not see it done.

IV

Of the Hoes and the Bells

By the spring of the next year there were iron hoes on the capital's fields.

Gilleasbuig made the first of them in am Faoilleach, when the ground was too wet to work, and by am Màrt all the smiths of the lane were making them, each a little differently and each saying his own was best. An iron hoe was lighter than a bronze one and cut deeper, and it did not bend when it met a stone. The farmers who came down from the fields above the lake to buy them brought their bronze hoes with them in sacks, since bronze was what they had to pay with, and they laid them on the smiths' floors and went home with iron.

So the smiths of the lane had more bronze than they had ever had, heaped in their corners, green and worn. Some of the hoes had belonged to grandmothers;

1. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

some had marks cut in the socket, a cross or a circle or a notch, that told whose field they were used in. Gilleasbuig kept these apart at first. Then there were too many to keep apart.

The custodians of Cathair dhearg asked the lane for bells. The town had had bells before, small ones, cast in An Aois Naomh¹ and cracked since, and a bell of the old kind had hung in the arch of the market gate as long as anyone remembered, rung for a death, a fire, or a ship. Now there was bronze enough in the lane to cast bells such as the capital had never had. Gilleasbuig and two other smiths of the lane dug the mould-pit in the yard behind his forge in an Cèitean, and made the moulds of clay and dung and chopped straw as their fathers had taught them, and on a dry morning in an t-Ògmhios they melted down the hoes.

It took a day to melt them. The bronze ran into the pit with a noise like a river at night, and smoked and spat, and the smell of it filled the lane. Gilleasbuig stood at the lip of the pit in a leather apron with his face wrapped, and when the bronze had gone in he said the words that his father said at a pour, which ask the metal to settle. Then they let it cool three days.

There were four bells. They were hung in the town that summer, one in the arch of the market gate, one at the bridge, and two at the temple, and they were rung together for the first time at Lùnastal. The farmers who had brought their hoes to the lane stood in the market and listened. An old woman who had carried her mother's hoe down from the fields in a sack told Gilleasbuig afterwards that she could hear it in the bell at the bridge, and he did not tell her that the bronze of all the hoes had run together in the pit and could not be told apart. It may be she was right. Bronze remembers its fire, the smiths of the lane say, and so do bells.

In the same year the weavers of Baile Mòr mhòr on the northern coast came to the post for the humans' dyes. The word of them had gone north with the Cathair naomh boat. On 4 an Dàmhair, AE 4, they traded their cloth at Pike's counter for jars of a red and a blue brighter than any the island had made, and Pike set down in his book what the jars had cost him over the sea and what the cloth would fetch there, and found the bargain fair on both sides. The weavers opened one jar at the counter and put a finger in it, and held up the finger to the light from the door, and one of them laughed aloud.

1. the Holy Age

V

Of the Letter from over the Sea

barrow came back on 16 an Dàmhair, AE 4, down from the north on a grey morning, with four ships in place of three. The fishers of Cuan shean who saw them first counted them twice. The fourth was a new hull, broader than the others and deep-laden, and she carried carpenters with their chests of tools, and a surgeon named Jonas Tull, and a stock of goods for the post twice the size of the first, and a letter.

The letter came up to Ros dhomhain by the river, in a sealed packet in the master's own coat, and Pike opened it at the counter on a wet afternoon toward the end of an Dàmhair. It was from the trading house over the sea whose goods he had been trading, and it had been written, by its date, in the spring. Pike read it through once to himself. Then, because the clerk by the door asked him what news had come from over the sea, and because there was no one in the loft but the clerk and Harrow's master and a smith from Cathair dhearg who had come down to buy bars, he read it again aloud, in his own tongue first and then, as well as he could, in the island's.

The smith was Gilleasbuig. He had come in out of the rain with his sack of bronze and his coat steaming, and he stood at the end of the counter with his arms folded while the letter was read.

It was a short letter and a civil one. The house thanked Pike for the hides and the cloth, which had sold well; it would send more iron and more glass; it named a price for salt. Then it came to what it had written for. The house asked what else the island had. It asked whether there was timber, and what kind; whether there was tin, or copper, or lead; whether the rocks of the island had been looked into, and by whom, and what had been found in them. It asked Pike to keep his eyes open, and to write.

When Pike came to the question he read it twice, once in each tongue, as he had read the rest, and did not stop over it. The clerk wrote it down on his slate. Gilleasbuig said nothing. He bought his bars and paid for them with his bronze, and put them on his shoulder, and went out into the rain.

He thought about the question all the way home along the lake road, and by the fire that night. It seemed to him a strange thing to ask. A smith knows what the hills have, since he works what comes out of them; and what they have is theirs, and a smith takes what the custodians allow him, and says the words. He

told Sìne the question, and she asked him who in the world would answer it, and he said the stranger with the book would. Then he said that the stranger was an honest man, which was true, and she said that had not been the question.

A month after, on 14 an t-Samhain, AE 4, the shipwrights of Inis mhòr came the length of the island to look at the new hulls. Two of Harrow's four lay in the lake off Ros dhomhain that winter, and the shipwrights came to them in a hired boat, seven old men and one young one, carrying coils of cord knotted at every hand's breadth. They asked leave of Harrow's master, who gave it, laughing. Then they went over the hulls from keel to rail, running their cords along every plank and rib and hanging them from the yards, and the young one wrote down each count on a board with a stick of charcoal. They were three days about it. Pike went out to watch on the second day and sat in the stern of the boat with his hands in his sleeves.

He asked the eldest of them, through the clerk, what they meant to do with the counts. The old man looked at him a while before he answered. Their guild had built nothing greater than a coaster since Cabhlach an Scaraidh¹ sailed, he said, and the craft of building for deep water had been half forgotten, since there had been no deep water that anyone of the island wished to sail. Now it seemed there was. So they would learn it again from these hulls, and the cords would keep what they learned.

Pike wrote to the house that night that the island's shipwrights measured by hand's breadths on a knotted cord, and that their joinery was very good.

VI

Of the First Debt

Pike went down to Cuan shean in an Dùbhlachd to make up the season's account with Harrow, and was lodged in the house of a fisherman below the dunes. It was a low house of turf and stone with its door to the lee, and the fisherman's brother lay in the box-bed by the fire with a leg that had been broken in the autumn under a boat hauled up the shingle.

The leg had been set by the town's bonesetter, and had knitted crooked. By the dark of the year the man could not stand on it. The bonesetter came and

1. the fleet of the Sundering

looked at it and said it would be so; there was a way to break and set a bone again, and he had seen it done once in his youth, and the man it was done to had died. The town had given the man up for lame. He was young, and he had a wife and a boat, and he lay in the box-bed with his face to the wall.

It was the fisherman's wife who asked Pike whether the strangers had a healer. Pike said they had a surgeon, lately come, and that he would ask.

Jonas Tull came down from the ships on 13 an Dùbhlachd, AE 4, in the afternoon, with his bag and two men from the ships to hold. He was a grey man near fifty with thick wrists and a patient, heavy way of talking, and he spoke no word of the island's tongue. He looked at the leg a long time, and felt along it with his thumbs, and asked through Pike how long since it was set. Then he said what he meant to do, and Pike said it in the island's tongue as well as he could, and the fisherman's brother turned from the wall to listen.

The custodian of Cuan shean was there. Oighrig nic Leòid was old, and not well, and had been fetched from her house in a chair. She had given the strangers' master water on the shingle the winter of their coming, and she sat now by the fire with a shawl over her head and her roll on her knees, and watched the surgeon unpack his bag. When the knives came out of it she asked Pike whether the man had done this before. Pike asked Tull. Tull said he had done it eleven times. Pike asked how many had walked. Tull said nine.

Oighrig said that nine of eleven was more than the island had.

They gave the man spirits from the ships and a strap of leather to bite. Tull broke the leg again at the old break with a stroke of a mallet that everyone in the house heard, and drew it straight with the two men pulling, and set it in splints of ash bound with linen. It was done before the fire had burned down. The man had fainted early and woke up after, grey and wet, with his leg straight under the blanket.

By the turn of the year he could sit up with the leg straight before him, and before the spring was out he was walking on the shingle with a stick.

That night, by the fire, Oighrig opened the roll of Cuan shean on her knees and asked Pike for the stranger's name, and wrote it, spelling it as it sounded. Then she wrote a line under it that Pike asked her to read to him. It said that a man of Cuan shean had been given back his leg by a stranger, and that the town owed the stranger a debt, and that it was the first such debt.

"He will not want paying," said Pike. "He has his wage from the ships."

Oighrig said that was the stranger's affair. The debt was the town's, and the roll would keep it until it was paid. She blotted the line with sand and closed the roll, and asked to be carried home.

VII

Of the Middling Coal

In the spring of the post's third year the salt-pans of Seann Warr began to sell to Pike's counter by the barrel, on 30 am Màrt, AE 5. Seann Warr lies on the western shore of the lake, three miles from Ros dhomhain, and its salt is boiled from brine springs that rise in the reed marsh behind the town. It is grey salt, coarse and damp, and the strangers' cooks would have none of it at first. Then the ships' masters found that fish packed in it kept the whole of a crossing, and the first barrels that went over the sea came back as a letter asking for more. They were the first goods of Dia-thìr that the humans came back asking for twice. The salt-boilers of Seann Warr heard of it, and put up their price, and Pike paid it.

In the first days of an Giblean Pike closed the book on the post's second year. He sat up two nights over it by the lamp, with the clerk by the door on his stool and the slate on his knees, and they went through every line of both years together. Wool, fish, hides, cloth, salt; iron, glass, oil, paper, dyes. The pilots' tolls, the carters' hire, the rent of the loft in blue cloth. The quire of paper marked *gift*. When they came to the end the two counts stood level, and Pike ruled a double line under the last figure, and the clerk made a mark on the slate. Then they sat a while in the loft with the lamp between them and did not say anything, and the lake knocked at the piles under the floor.

A fortnight later, on 14 an Giblean, AE 5, the walled harbour of Caol leathan sent its first wool-ship up the river to the post. Her master was a broad, grey-bearded man of the pilots' kin, and he came up to the counter with three of his merchants behind him. Tools he would not take, nor glass nor oil nor paper nor dyes. He wanted iron in bars, and he wanted it weighed on his own beam, which he had brought with him in a canvas bag, and on Pike's steelyard after, and he wanted the lesser of the two figures. They were at the counter from the morning until the lamps were lit. When they were done Pike wrote in his book that the merchants of Caol leathan were the hardest bargainers on the island, and he wrote it with some admiration.

That evening he sat down to answer the letter from over the sea.

He had kept his eyes open, as the house had asked. He wrote of the timber: oak in the south and pine on the moors, little of either near the coast. Then the salt and the wool and the hides went down on the page, and the smiths at Cathair dhearg who had learned in one winter what his own country's smiths took seven years to learn. He wrote that the island had copper and tin, since it had bronze, but that he did not know where; and that there was silver somewhere to the east, from the pins the women wore. Last he wrote that the island had coal.

That he had seen for himself. There was a basket of it by the custodians' hearth in Ros dhomhain, where the clerk lodged, and a single handful burned on that hearth at each feast of the year and at no other time. He had asked the clerk why so little. The clerk told him it was the law, and had been the law since An Aois Naomh¹, and that no household burned more than a measured handful in a season. Pike had asked him how much of it there was, and the clerk had laughed and said the hills were full of it. And Gilleasbuig, when Pike asked him in the lane why the smiths burned charcoal when there was coal in the hills, had said *Tha an cnoc làn d'beth*, which was the same answer, and had looked at him as if the question were a strange one.

Pike had taken a piece from the basket once, with the clerk's leave, and held it to the window. It was black, with a dull sheen at the break. It seemed to him much like the coal of home, a little harder. He had put it back.

So he wrote that the island had coal of a middling sort, and much of it. He read the line over, and let it stand, and signed the letter, and sealed it.

The letter went into a small iron-bound chest that stood under the counter, where Pike kept what was to go over the sea. The chest had a lid that sagged on its old hinge, and the next morning he took it up the lake road to the smiths' lane below the bridge.

Gilleasbuig looked at the lid and at the hinge, and put the chest on his bench. He could not read the humans' letters, and he did not ask what the chest held. He made a new hinge that morning from a strip of the strangers' bar-iron, drawn out and folded round a pin, and tempered it to the blue that is next to the grey, as the ships' smith had shown him, and set it with three nails on either leaf. The lid he worked until it swung true. Then he gave the chest back to Pike, and would take nothing for the work.

1. the Holy Age

Pike thanked him in the island's tongue, and carried the chest back down the lake road to the post, with his letter inside it and the new hinge bright at its back.

CHAPTER FOUR

OF the Council of Six

AE 5 – 6

I

Of the Straight Town

Of all the towns of the west in the first years of the strangers, the copyists of the cellar found only one that kept two books. They were a pair of plain calf-bound ledgers, one written in Dia-thìris and dated by the moon, the other in the humans' tongue and dated by the humans' day, and they stood side by side on a shelf in the net-loft of Baile dhìreach. The pages match one for one. Where a hand in one book has struck a line through a word, a hand in the other has struck the line through the word that answers it. The rolls of the custodians are full of things done to the island by strangers. These two books hold a thing the island and the strangers did together, in a town of some fifty souls at the end of a long straight street that ran down to a quay.

Baile dhìreach lay on the south-west coast, a day's walk from the capital and a morning's sail below Cuan shean. Traders of Òrd Mhanannain¹ had built it in the long quiet centuries, and it had kept its one street and its one quay ever since, with Òrd na Cloiche² at the temple city of Inis thais a few miles east along the shore and the weather coming in off the open sea from the west. The people were fishers and net-makers and salters of herring. They had a well at the head of the street, a salt-house at its foot, a loft over the salt-house where the nets were hung

1. the order of Manannan

2. the order of the Stone

to mend, and a strip of grey shingle north of the quay where no house stood, because the shingle above the wrack-line had been held in keeping for the whole town since before anyone's grandmother could remember, and nobody might build on it.

Eilidh nic Ruairidh was twenty-three that spring, and she mended nets on the shingle, as her mother had done before her and her mother's mother. The copyists knew her from both books. She was a broad, quick woman with scarred fingers who could work a needle blind. She was at her frames on a grey morning of Bearnach, the gap-moon between the last of the stores and the first of the green, when the humans' boat came round the point from the north.

II

Of the Rule of the Shingle

It was a broad heavy boat, rowed by six men and deep in the water, and it carried timber: sawn plank, which nobody at Baile dhìreach had seen in such a quantity, stacked to the gunwales and lashed down, with tools laid on top in sacking. The humans had come ashore at Cuan shean four winters before, and every soul on the coast had seen them by now, or said so. Harrow had lately come back from over the sea with four ships where he had taken three, and carpenters in them. The carpenters had been looking up and down the coast for a beach with good shelving and good shelter, where they might mend the small craft of the post and build new ones; for the anchorage at Cuan shean was crowded, and the townsfolk there had begun to count the humans' fires.

Eilidh stood up from the frame with the needle still in her hand. The boat came in on the tide and grounded on the shingle, on the town's shingle, above the wrack. A man jumped out into the shallows and walked up to her, dripping to the knee.

"Dia dhut," he said. He said it badly, with all the sounds in the wrong places, but she knew it.

He was a big man with a carpenter's shoulders and a sunburnt head going bald at the crown, and he held his hat in both hands. Behind him the others were already handing out plank. One of them, a younger man with long arms and black hair tied back with a thong, had found a split cask in the wrack and was

turning it over and looking at the staves, as a man looks at a horse he has been offered.

"Iain mac Chaluim," said Eilidh, and pointed up the street. That was all the answer she had, and it was the right one, for Iain mac Chaluim was the best fisherman on that stretch of the coast and the man the town sent to talk when talking had to be done. He was already coming down the street with half the town behind him.

So they met on the shingle, the town and the strangers, with the plank between them. The big man was William Rook, carpenter, lately of Harrow's ships. He had some forty words of Dia-thìris and the tall young man by the cask had perhaps twenty, and between them, with the help of a Cuan shean boy they had brought as far as the point and who then lost his courage and would not come further, they made the town understand what they wanted. They wanted the shingle north of the quay, for a slip and a yard, and would pay for it in iron and nails and tools, and build their own houses.

The shingle was the town's in keeping. It was nobody's to sell. Iain mac Chaluim said so, and Rook frowned, and said a word in his own tongue to the others, and they all frowned. Eilidh saw that they had no word for it. To them a piece of ground belonged to somebody or it belonged to nobody, and if it belonged to nobody a man might take it.

It was old Seonag nic Aoidh of the salt-house who settled it, on the second day of talking. The shingle could not be sold, she said. A man could be let work on it all the same, as the herring-curers of Inis thais had once been let work on it in a year when their own beach silted. The curers had kept the town's rule while they were there, and gone home when they were done, and nobody had thought the worse of them. If the strangers would keep the town's rule, then they might stay under it. And she said the rule over, the whole of it, standing on the shingle with her shawl pulled up against the wind: the well was drawn from in turn; no fire was lit on the shingle after dark in the herring season, when the boats were steering home by the lamps at the quay-head; no net was set and no hammer lifted on the night of the full moon or the night of the dark, which were the rest-nights; the dead of the sea were remembered in the black moon; the shingle above the wrack was held for the town and built on by no one.

Rook heard it through twice. He asked about the houses. They could not live in the boat.

There was a long argument then about whether a house of plank on a sill of stones was a house built on the shingle or only a tent that stood up by itself. The town decided in the end, on no grounds anyone afterwards could give, that it was a tent. Rook said that his men would keep the rule. He said it in his own tongue first, and then in his forty words, and then he put out his hand, and after a while Iain mac Chaluim took it.

The roll of Inis thais, to which Baile dhìreach sent its news, set down on 22 an Giblean, AE 5, that the strangers had been taken in at Baile dhìreach under the town's one rule. They were seven men. There were Rook and two other carpenters, a sawyer and his boy, a sailmaker who stayed only the summer, and the young man with long arms, who was a cooper, and whose name was Samuel Hale.

III

Of Rope and Knot

They built through Bealltach and Ògach, under a sky that stayed high and grey and let the work go on. The slip went down first, of split logs bedded in the shingle; then a long shed with one end open to the sea; then the house, which was not a house, of sawn plank set on a sill of beach stones, with a door in the middle and a window of real glass that the whole town came to look through. It stood a little crooked on the shingle, with its back to the west wind, and the gulls liked its roof. The town called it the tent, and went on calling it the tent after it had a hearth and a chimney. The copyists found it in the Dia-thìris book as *am pùball* and in the humans' as "the first house", and nobody in either book seems to have thought the other name wrong.

Samuel Hale was the first of them to be any use to the town. The herring barrels of Baile dhìreach were old, and half of them wept brine at every seam. Eilidh's father, Ruairidh, who salted herring for his living and had done since he was a boy, had a whole row of them standing idle behind the salt-house because the staves had shrunk and the hoops rusted through. One evening in Ògach he found the cooper among them with his sleeves rolled up. Samuel had taken one down to its staves and laid them out on the shingle in order, like the bones of a fish.

Ruairidh stood over him for a long time, saying nothing, and then went and got the next one.

By the turn of the summer every barrel in the town was tight. Samuel took no iron for it and no fish. He took, when he took anything, a bowl of whatever was in the pot, and he ate it sitting on the salt-house step with the barrels drying round him, and then he would take out a scrap of paper and a stub of lead and ask for words.

Most of all he asked Eilidh, because she was on the shingle most. He would come down in the evening when the light was going long and yellow over the water and sit on an upturned boat by her frames and point. *Ròp*, she told him, and he said it back and wrote it. Then he showed her his word for it. She said his word back and he laughed at the way she said it, and then he wrote hers again under his own, very carefully, with a line between.

They came to knots in the third week, and there they stayed a long time. She had a word for every knot she tied, and there were many: the knot that joins two ropes of different thickness, the knot that holds on a wet spar and will not slip, the knot that a child learns first and the knot that only the old net-makers could still throw one-handed. He had a word for every one of his, and he tied them for her in a length of line from the boat, and she found that most of his were hers under other names, and some were not. There was one of his she had never seen, a knot for hanging a weight that tightened as the weight pulled; and one of hers he had never seen, the net-maker's mesh knot of the south-west, which she could tie faster than he could follow with his eyes. He made her do it slowly, eleven times, and on the twelfth he tied it himself and held it up, and she said *snaidhm*, which is only the word for any knot at all, and he wrote that down too.

Word had come along the coast by then of what had happened at Cathair dhearg in the season of words, three years before: how the custodian Gormshuil nic Fhearchair had laid broken coal on a table and named forty colours in it, and the cleric of the humans had written one word for them all and put the coal aside to make room. The carters told it at the well. Eilidh had not thought much about it. It had seemed to her a thing that might happen between great people in a great hall.

She thought about it one evening at the end of Teasach, in her father's house, when Samuel had come up for his bowl and the rain had driven him in from the step. By the old law of the burning the house had its measured handful of coal for the hearth, and her father had laid a lump of it on the peat to catch, as he did on wet nights. It split in the heat and the colours came up at the break, the deep green under the black, and the red that grows if you breathe on it. Eilidh looked at

it, as anyone would. Samuel saw her look, and looked where she was looking, and asked her what it was.

She told him. She gave him the green and the red and the grey that the old lumps have at the edge. He leaned forward with his elbows on his knees and stared into the fire until his eyes watered.

"It's black," he said, in his own tongue, and then in hers, which he could manage by then: "Dubh."

"It is not black."

"I see black. I'm sorry." He took out his paper. "Say them again."

She said them again, and he wrote them, all three, in her spelling as near as he could come to it. He had no word of his own to put above them, and so he left the space above them empty, and drew his line under it just the same. Her father watched the whole business from the other side of the hearth with his pipe gone out.

That Lùghnas the humans' slip sent down its first boat. She was a small one, a coaster of the humans' pattern with a deeper keel than the boats of the southwest, and she was built for Iain mac Chaluim, who paid for her in fish and labour and in his own time on the saw-pit. The town gave her their rope. They launched her on the first evening of the Lùnastal gathering, with the fires going up on the headland behind the town, and the humans stood on the slip with their hats off while Iain's wife poured sea water over her bow and asked Manannan to keep her. Rook asked afterwards what the words meant. Iain told him, and Rook nodded and said that his own people would have said much the same to their own God, and there the matter rested.

IV

Of the Compact Written Twice

The trouble that made the council came from the dues.

By the time of Pailteach there were three boats of the post lying off the shingle for mending and a fourth hauled up on the slip, and the town's quay had never seen so much traffic. From of old the harbour dues of Baile dhìreach had gone to the custodians at Cathair dhearg, a few coppers' worth a year in fish and salt, carried up the road by whoever was going that way. Now the post's boats paid dues too, and the post at Ros dhomhain, which kept its books to

the last line, wrote to ask where its money was going, and why a harbour its own men had half rebuilt should pay the whole of it to a council that had never sent anyone to see it. At the same time the custodians of Inis thais, to whom Baile dhìreach had always sent its news, wrote to ask by what rule seven strangers were keeping a yard on a shingle held in keeping, and for how long.

Iain mac Chaluim sat on the salt-house step with both letters, one of which he could not read, and said that the town would have to write down its rule.

"Write it how?" said Seonag.

"Twice," said Rook, who had the other letter. "Once in each."

That was in the last days of Pailteach. The writing took until the middle of Damhrach, and the copyists, who knew something of the labour of putting one tongue beside another, reckoned it the hardest writing of its length in the whole age. The custodian of Inis thais sent over his clerk, a young man with ink to the wrist and a portable desk on a strap, to write the Dia-thìris book. Rook wrote the humans' book himself, in a round slow hand, with his tongue between his teeth. They sat at the long mending-table in the net-loft over the salt-house, among the hung nets and the smell of tar and old fish, with a lamp at each end of the table and the sea going on below the window. Six sat to make the compact, three of the town and three of the strangers: Iain mac Chaluim, Seonag nic Aoidh, and the pilot Murchadh mac Iain for the town, and for the strangers Rook, the carpenter Nathan Cobb, and the sawyer Peter Lusk. They did not intend to be the council. They became it by sitting.

Eilidh was fetched on the third evening, because the harbour clauses had come to moorings and nobody at the table could agree what the humans' words for them meant. The humans had one word for a rope that holds a boat to a quay and another for a rope that holds her to an anchor, and a third for the ring the rope goes through, and the town had words for all of these and for four more besides, and the clerk from Inis thais knew none of them, having been bred in a temple city where the boats belonged to other people. Samuel was fetched for the same reason from the other side. The two of them sat at the foot of the table with his papers between them, the papers that had her words written under his with a line between, and turned them over until they found what was wanted. Then Eilidh said it in Dia-thìris and the clerk wrote it, and Samuel said it in the humans' tongue and Rook wrote it, and the line down the middle, which nobody wrote, lay between them all the same.

Not everything could be found so. There was a night-long quarrel over the shingle. The humans' book wanted to say who owned it. The town's book could only say who kept it. In the end the humans' book said that the shingle was the town's and the town's book said it was kept for the town, and both of them said that no one would build on it, and Rook said that his tent would be taken down when the council told him, and wrote that in too.

There was a quarrel over the rest-nights, which the humans agreed to keep, and a matching quarrel over the humans' day of rest, which the town had never heard of. The humans kept one day in seven for their God, whose name was Crìosd¹, and on it they would do no work and wished that no one would hammer near them while they prayed. The town agreed not to hammer on the slip on that day. Nobody at Baile dhìreach had ever hammered on the slip at all before the humans came, and Murchadh said so, and the clerk from Inis thais wrote it into the Dia-thìris book before anyone could stop him, and it is there still, in the margin.

The dues were shared. Half went up the road to the custodians at Cathair dhearg as before, and half went to the humans' post at Ros dhomhain, and the council kept the harbour in repair out of what the town took for mooring, and nobody in either book was to pay twice.

Last of all they came to the chair. There were six at the table, three and three, and some one of them had to speak first and speak last. They agreed that the chair should go between Iain mac Chaluim and William Rook, a year apiece. Then they found that they did not agree what a year was. The town's year turned at Samhain, with the dark half, and was counted by moons; the humans' year turned in the dead of winter on a day that stood still in their calendar and wandered in the moon's. If the chair turned at Samhain, Iain would hold it for a fortnight. Iain said that a fortnight was as long as he had ever wanted to hold anything. Rook laughed, and said that a year was a year, and that the chair should turn at the humans' new year, since that at least could be written down and would be in the same place next time. So it was agreed, and so it was written in both books: that Iain mac Chaluim should hold the chair until the humans' year turned, and William Rook for the year after, and so on in turn for as long as they lived or the town kept them.

On 10 an Dàmhair, AE 5, the compact of Baile dhìreach was read in both tongues on the quay, in a west wind with rain in it. The clerk read the Dia-thìris

1. Christ

and Rook the humans'. The whole town stood and listened to both, the humans to the one they could not follow and the town to the one it could not follow, and then everyone who could write put a name in both books, and those who could not made a mark. The Dia-thiris book is dated by the island's count of years and the moon, and the humans' book by their day and month and year; neither gives the other's date, and each has a blank at the foot of its page where the other's might have gone.

The council of six sat for the first time eight days later, on 18 an Dàmhair, AE 5, in the net-loft, with Iain in the chair. They settled a quarrel over a mooring ring, sent the first half of the dues up the road to Cathair dhearg in a sack with a boy to carry it, and sent the second half round by boat to Ros dhomhain. Then they drank to the harbour, with the humans' spirit and the town's heather ale, and the clerk from Inis thais drank more of both than he should, and was put to bed in the tent.

V

Of Her Father's No

Samuel came to Ruairidh's door on the night of Samhain.

It was the worst night of the year for it, and Eilidh told him so afterwards, and he said that he had not known. The whole town was on the headland above the quay. The fire was going up against a sky full of wet wind, and the sparks were driving inland, and the young men were running the embers along the street, sunwise about the well and down to the water. The old year was going out into the dark half and the dead were near. The humans had come up the path as far as the last cairn and stood there in a knot together, watching, with the firelight on their faces, the way men stand at the door of a house where a wake is going on and they are not sure they are bidden. Rook had taken his hat off again. Nobody had told them to, and nobody told them to put it on.

Eilidh had gone down to the house for more peat. When she came out with her creel her father was standing in the door, and Samuel was on the step below him in the rain, and neither of them was saying anything.

She knew at once what had been said, because the cooper had his hat in his hands the way Rook had held his on the shingle in Bearnach, and because her

father's face had gone the colour it went when a barrel he had packed himself was opened and found spoiled.

"No," said her father, in Dia-thiris, and then in the few words of the humans' tongue he had got from the salt-house, which were mostly the names of fish: "No. Go."

Samuel looked at her past her father's shoulder. Then he put his hat on and went back down the street towards the shingle, walking carefully on the wet stones, and he did not go back up to the fire.

Her father would not talk to her that night. In the morning, when the headland was black and smoking and the gulls were at the scraps, he talked a great deal.

He had nothing against the cooper, who was a good cooper. A council, he said, was one thing and a hearth another, and he had put his mark in both books on the quay like everyone else and had meant it; the humans were welcome to the shingle and the slip and the well in its turn and the half of the dues, and none of that had anything to do with his daughter. He said that Samuel Hale had a country somewhere over the eastern water, behind Ceò Mhanannain¹, that nobody in Baile dhìreach had ever seen and nobody ever would, and that any man with a country might go back to it. He said that her children would be neither one thing nor the other. And then he said the thing he was really afraid of, standing at the salt-house door with his arms folded, as though it had only just occurred to him.

"When the chair goes over to the carpenter," he said, "they will have the town. You watch. A year of him, and they will have it."

"There are three of us and three of them," said Eilidh. "They will have it the way Iain has it now."

"Iain is one of us."

"Rook put his mark in our book," said Eilidh. "He wrote that he would take his house down if we told him."

"He wrote it in his book," said her father. "Who reads his book?"

She said that she did, a little. Samuel had taught her some of the letters over the summer, in the evenings on the upturned boat, and she could make out her own name in his hand and some of the words for rope. Her father looked at her as if she had told him she could fly, and went into the salt-house and banged the door.

For the rest of Samhnas she mended nets on the shingle and the cooper worked in the shed, a hundred paces off, and they did not speak. The whole town

knew why. The two books, which had nothing to say about it, lay on the shelf in the net-loft.

In the black moon the council sent its bidding to Inis thais. The compact had a clause, put in at the clerk's asking, that any town of the coast might sit with them on the same terms; and Iain mac Chaluim, who had begun to enjoy the chair more than he admitted, wanted the temple city to know it was asked. Murchadh took the letter along the shore in his boat, the two books' worth of it, both tongues, and brought back word that the custodian had read it through twice and had said that he would write.

On the last night of Dubhlas the town remembered its drowned, as every harbour of the west did at the dark of the year, and set lamps along the quay for them. The humans came down from the tent and stood with the townsfolk. Samuel stood at the end of the line, and when the lamps were lit he took off his hat and said a prayer to Crìosd² in his own tongue for the men he had known who had gone over the side in the northern sea on the voyage out, before ever they saw the island. Eilidh did not know the words. She set a lamp for them at the end of the quay, and her father saw her do it, and said nothing.

VI

Of the Turning of the Humans' Year

The humans' year turned in the middle of Faolach, the wolf-moon, the storm-time at the year's dead end, when the nets were ashore for mending and the boats hauled high and the days were hardly worth the name.

The council met that morning in the net-loft with the rain drumming on the slates. Iain mac Chaluim stood up from the head of the table and moved down one place, and William Rook moved up one, and sat, and looked for a long time at the table in front of him, as if he had not expected it to be the same table. That was the whole of it. Both books enter it in a line. The humans' book gives the day and the year; the town's gives the moon and says only that the carpenter took the chair as the compact bade him, and that the fisherman gave it.

1. Manannan's mist over the eastern sea

2. Christ

Before they had done anything else a boy came up the ladder, wet through, with a letter from Inis thais.

It was short, and it was courteous, and it was written in Dia-thìris only. The custodian of Inis thais thanked the council of Baile dhìreach for its bidding and declined it. He wished the town well of its compact. But, he wrote, one town may be a trial, and two would be a rule; and the city of Lia Fàil¹ would not make a rule of a thing that had been tried for three moons, and would watch, and would write again if there was cause.

Rook had the letter read to him twice, once in each tongue, and at the end of the second reading he said, "That's fair," and had it laid in the Dia-thìris book, between the page of the handing-over and the page of the next matter; and the council went on to the next matter, which was a boat of the post that had dragged her anchor in the night and fouled the town's moorings, and whose master had refused to pay for the damage.

Eilidh's father was waiting at the foot of the ladder for that one, because it was his mooring.

She saw it all from the salt-house door. Rook came down the ladder with the other five behind him and walked out along the quay in the rain to look at the ring and the torn rope. He looked for a long time. He sent for the post's master, who was one of his own people, a man of Harrow's ships, and told him in the humans' tongue that he would pay the town's rate for the rope and the town's rate for the ring, and pay it in iron by weight, and pay it that day. The master argued. Rook heard him out and said the same again, louder. Then he turned to Ruairidh and told him in his forty words of Dia-thìris, most of them wrong, that he would have his rope, and asked him whether the town's rate was fair, because he had written it into the book from Seonag's saying and did not know it for himself.

Ruairidh said that it was fair.

That night the great storm of that winter came in off the west, three days of it, the worst in years. The sea came over the quay and into the foot of the street. On the second night it began to drive up the shingle towards the boats, and the whole town went down in the dark to haul them higher, and the humans came out of the tent with ropes and blocks and a capstan-bar off the slip, and nobody asked them to. Eilidh was on a line with her father and Seonag's grandsons and Samuel Hale and Nathan Cobb, heaving the coaster that the humans had built for Iain

1. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

mac Chaluim up over the crest of the shingle, a foot at a time. The rain came at them level. Nobody could hear anything, and so nobody spoke anything but the one word, on the pull, which in the end they were all shouting in the town's tongue, humans and all. When the boat was over the crest Samuel threw a hitch round the post at the top of the shingle to hold her, and it was the net-maker's knot of the south-west, and he threw it one-handed.

Her father saw it. He was holding the lantern.

The storm blew itself out on the third morning. Nothing in the town had fallen down but the end of the salt-house chimney, and the humans' tent, which had lost half its roof, and which the humans put back up in a day and a half with Ruairidh's help, on the shingle where it had stood, the council having said nothing about taking it down.

The town had watched the carpenter in the chair for half a moon by then. He had sat under the same slates and at the same table, and settled what came before him by the same rule the town had always kept, and written it into his own book in his round slow hand, and nothing whatever had happened to the town that it could see, except that it had been paid for a rope.

One evening at the end of Faolach Ruairidh came down onto the shingle where his daughter was at her frames. He stood beside her for a while looking at the tent, where there was a lamp in the glass window, and the cooper's shadow going to and fro.

"Tell the cooper," he said, "that if he wants his bowl filled he can come up for it himself, like a christened man."

He meant it as a joke. He had learned the word from the humans that winter, and had no notion what it meant, except that they used it of a man who behaved as he should. Eilidh laughed so much that she had to sit down on the shingle, and she did not tell him.

That was the end of the first winter of the council of six. The two books stood on the shelf in the net-loft side by side, the one dated by the moon and the other by the day, with the letter from Inis thais between the pages of the one and nothing between the pages of the other. The lamp at the quay-head burned for the boats. The tent kept its crooked place on the shingle, with its back to the west wind and a new patch on its roof, and the gulls came back to it.

CHAPTER FIVE

Of the Five Headlands

AE 6 – 7

I

Of the Nine on the Western Shore

Of the walk round the headlands there are three witnesses, and none of them is whole. There is James Fenn's chart, which survives; there is the roll of the custodians of Cathair dhearg, which gives the walk four lines; and there is what Torcall Clachair told, when he was old, to the households of the southern cape, who kept it as coast people keep the names of drowned men. Where the three disagree, the copyists have trusted the chart for distances and the mason for everything else.

In the winter of that year Torcall was at Baile fhiadhaich on the west coast, setting a new face of stone on the harbour wall. He was a man of some forty-six winters, broad in the back and short in the leg, with a mason's hands, split at the knuckles and grey with dust in every crease. That autumn he had raised the frame for the new bells in the tower at Cathair dhearg, and the custodian of Baile fhiadhaich had sent for him after, because her sea-wall was falling into the harbour a stone at a time. He lodged with a rope-maker, and liked the town, whose people had a name on the coast for good cordage and bad manners, and deserved both.

On 30 am Faoilleach, AE 6, the fog came in off the western sea in the afternoon and did not lift. Torcall worked on at the wall until he could not see the end of his own line, then went up to the rope-walk to sit by the fire. In the night the fishermen heard a gun fired twice out on the water, and stood on the quay in the fog and argued over what it meant.

In the morning they found out. A human supply-brig, bound down the coast for Cuan shean with stores for the post at Ros dhomhain, had struck the reefs off the point south of the town, where the sea breaks white on a still day and no boat of Baile fhiadhaich goes without a man in the bow. By first light her masts lay

along the water. The fishermen took off eleven men from the rigging and the rocks. The rest came ashore over the next three days, one or two at a tide, on the shingle under the dunes.

Torcall helped to carry them up. He had never touched one of the strangers before. They were heavier than they looked, and their clothes held the sea, and their faces had the pale of people who had lived under a greyer sky. There were nine of them. One was the ship's master, a man with a grey beard cut close and a brass ring in one ear, and in the breast of his coat, sewn into oiled cloth, was a chart.

The master's mate had come off the rocks with a broken arm and a face like chalk, and he knew a few words of Dia-thìris, as most of the strangers now did. He spread the chart on the rope-maker's table, and Torcall looked at it with him.

It was a drawing of the island's western coast in ink, with the headlands and harbours marked and soundings written small along the edges. It was a good drawing, and it was wrong. The point where the brig had struck was set down a mile and more further out to sea than it lay, and the reefs below it were not there at all.

"He drew it," the mate said, and put his finger on the dead man's name in the corner. "From his head. From other voyages." He had no word for what he wanted to say next, and in the end he tapped his own forehead and then the chart and shook his head.

"On your coast," he said, "there is no light. Only the fires. The fires are small."

Torcall said that the fires were for the boats of the coast, whose men knew the reefs.

"Yes," said the mate. "Yes. That is what I am saying."

The custodian of Baile fhiadhaich gave the dead ground above the tide-line, on a shelf of turf among the dunes where the sea-holly grew, and the strangers who had come off the rocks dug the graves with borrowed spades. One of them read from a black book in their tongue while the rest stood with their hats in their hands. The townsfolk stood a little way off, not knowing what was proper, until an old woman went down to the tide and came back with her cupped hands full of sea-water and wet the turf over each grave in turn, as the coast did for its own drowned. The strangers let her. Torcall cut nine flat stones from the spoil of his wall and set one at the head of each grave. Not knowing their letters, he cut on each a line for the sea, and the mate scratched the names under it with the point of a knife.

II

Of the Asking

Torcall finished his wall in an Gearran, and on his road home he came down to Ros dhomhain to buy iron.

The post stood on the lake-shore below the capital, a long house of the strangers' building with a counter across one end, and that morning it was full of men who had nothing to buy. The masters of two ships at anchor off the quay were there, and the trader Thomas Pike behind his counter with his tally-book shut. The dead master's chart lay open between them, and they were arguing over it in their own tongue, fast and loud.

Pike knew the mason, who had bought bar-iron from him twice, and called him over and asked him, in careful Dia-thìris, whether he built towers.

Torcall said that he had built a bell-tower, and a sea-wall, and a great many byres.

Then Pike turned the chart round on the counter and spoke for the whole company. What he said stands in his letter-book of that month and in the custodians' roll, and the two do not quite agree. In the letter-book the seamen "request of the natives that standing lights be raised on the principal headlands of the coast, for the safety of shipping." In the roll the strangers "ask the council whether the old sea-fires may be built higher, and kept all night, and kept in all weathers." It comes to the same thing. The strangers had seen the old driftwood fires burning low on the headlands, and had thought, reasonably enough, that a people who kept fires already could keep them better.

Torcall took the question up the hill to Cathair dhearg. On 28 an Gearran, AE 6, it came before Comhairle a' Chùrain¹, and Tormod mac Ailein, who sat at its head, heard it read and passed it to the masons. Seven men in the capital were counted master builders, and they sat that evening at a table in the lower hall with the humans' question in front of them on a sheet of the humans' paper.

They were not long about it. A tower on a headland was a season's work for a crew of twelve, the strangers offered iron for it, and they had lost nine men on the rocks. The oldest of the seven, a man from Dùn thais who had built most of the granaries in the south, said that a light which kept men off the rocks was a good light whoever the men were, and the rest agreed with him.

1. the Council of Custodians; lit. 'the council of the custody'

Only Torcall asked about the coal. Every child on the island who had learned the old rulings at a custodian's knee knew that no coal might feed a sea-fire. The Coimheadaichean na Lasrach² had ruled it long ago, and their reason was short. *Lasaidh an teine-rabhaidh do choigrich*: the beacon-fire burns for strangers. A fire in a hearth warms the house; a fire on a headland is for whoever is out on the water and cannot be seen, and the coal of the vein was not to be burned for anyone the burner could not see. So the old fires had been fed on driftwood and seal fat and dried wrack for as long as anyone could count, and were small, and burned low.

"They have not asked for coal," said the man from Dùn thais.

"They will want the fire bigger," said Torcall.

"Then they can bring their own oil for it."

That was the end of it. The masons wrote on the back of the humans' sheet that the headlands might be built on if the custodians of each place gave leave, and that a Dia-thìreach builder should choose the ground; and they chose Torcall to choose it, since he had asked the only question and had walked the west coast twice for the sea-walls. Pike wrote under their answer that the natives had agreed "without difficulty and without asking what the lights would cost." It is the first time in his letter-book that he calls them the natives.

III

Of the Southern Cape

The strangers sent their own man to walk with him, and Torcall met him on the quay at Ros dhomhain in am Màrt, with the wind coming cold off the lake.

James Fenn was twenty-six that spring, long in the leg, with fair hair the island's wind would not let lie and a face burnt red across the nose. He had come out as a navigator's mate with Harrow's four ships and had stayed when they sailed home. Across his back on a strap he carried a leather case, and in it, packed in wool, a brass instrument with a glass eye and a swinging arm, a compass in a wooden box, a roll of paper and a bundle of pens; on his other shoulder he carried a staff banded black and white, taller than himself. Of Dia-thìris he had some two

2. the Keepers of the Hall; lit. 'the watchers of the flame'

hundred words, most of them the words of ships and weather, and he spoke them fast and with great confidence and little grammar. Torcall had perhaps forty words of the strangers' tongue, most of them the names of tools.

They went south and east by the carters' road, four days down out of the hill country, and on the evening of the fourth day they came over the last rise and saw the sea.

Tobar dhearg was a village of fishers and salt-boilers round a well whose water ran red over the stones, and it stood a few miles back from the cape, out of the wind. The cape ran out beyond it in a long spine of grey rock. On its end stood the oldest sea-light on Dia-thìr: a round tower no taller than a byre, of rough stones laid without mortar, its flat top black from more fires than anyone could reckon, with pegs set into the wall to climb it by. The households of the village kept it in turn. That night it was the turn of a man called Fionnlagh and his two sons, and Torcall and Fenn went out along the spine in the dusk and climbed up to them.

The fire was a heap of driftwood on the flat stones, no bigger than a cart-load, with a pot of seal fat beside it that the younger son ladled over the wood whenever the flame sank. Its yellow smoky light lit the three men's faces and did not reach the sea at all.

"How far?" Fenn said to Fionnlagh. "How far do boats see it?"

Fionnlagh said that the boats of Tobar dhearg saw it from the fishing ground, which was as far as they went.

"And the big ships? From far out?"

Fionnlagh said that there were no big ships, and then remembered that there were, and was a little put out. The fire, he said, was for the boats of Tobar dhearg.

In the morning Fenn set up the brass instrument on its three legs on the end of the cape and sighted along it to the headlands east and west, and sent Torcall out along the rocks with the banded staff to hold it upright where he pointed, and wrote numbers in columns. Toward evening he unrolled a clean sheet on the top of the old tower, weighted the corners with four stones, and began his chart of the southern coast: the cape, the village behind it, the well, the rocks off the point. Then he wrote a name on the end of the cape in the strangers' letters.

Torcall asked him what it said.

It was the name of a headland on the coast where Fenn was born, the one his father's boat had rounded to come home. It had been the last thing he saw of an Tír Thall¹ when he sailed, and he had thought it right to give it to the first light he found here.

Torcall looked at the name for a while. Then he said, "*Tha ainm air.*" It has a name.

"This one?"

"Every one of them."

Fenn did not argue. The name was for the chart, he said, and the chart was for men who came from the sea and would never hear the Dia-thìris name of the cape, and needed to call it something. That was fair, and Torcall said so. But that evening he gathered stones from the beach in a sack, and on the highest point of the cape, a few yards inland from the old tower, where the rock was sound and a new tower could stand, he built a cairn as high as his chest, laid dry, each stone on two below it, with a flat stone for a cap. The roll of Cathair dhearg enters it on 29 am Màrt, AE 6: *the mason Torcall has marked the ground at the southern fire*. It was the first of the five.

IV

Of the Eastern Cape and the North-East Steps

From Tobar dhearg they walked east along the southern coast and then north with the sea on their right hand, and in an Giblean they came to the eastern cape.

Baile ìseal was a handful of low houses on the far edge of the island, with their backs to the moor, and its people kept a fire on the cape for their own boats. But the tellings of that coast said that it had always been lit to bring the boats home in a storm, and the old men of Baile ìseal were proud of the difference. On the southern cape, they said, the fire was a mark to steer by. Here it was a call. A woman whose husband was out in a blow would climb up and feed it herself, and he would see it and know she was there. Fenn wrote that in the margin of his chart.

The east coast was also the raiders' water, broken by low bare islets where men lived by taking what they could from the strands. On the second night Torcall

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

and Fenn sat up with the watch, and near midnight the watchman pointed out a small red spark on the nearest islet that came and went as someone passed in front of it.

"They see us too," he said.

Fenn asked whether a greater light on the cape would help or hinder that. The watchman thought about it for a long time. Then he said that a greater light would bring more men home, and more of the other kind too. Torcall built his second cairn above the old fire the next morning, and the watchman helped him lift the capstone.

North of the eastern cape the land ran up steep out of the sea, and they walked the cliff-tops for the best part of a week with the wind in their faces. At Àth dhearg, above the passage in toward Seann Tarr, the fire had no tower at all. It was built on a shelf of rock near the top of the cape, and from the shore below a stair had been cut up to it in the living rock, turning back and forth across the face, a hundred and more steps, narrower than any stair Torcall had seen, and little worn.

Torcall went up them slowly with his hand on the rock. At the top he sat down on the fire-shelf and looked back down the stair for a long while. When Fenn asked what he was looking at, he said he was counting the cuts of the chisel, and that the man who had cut them had been left-handed, and patient, and had been dead a long time.

The custodian of Àth dhearg would not give leave for a cairn. The fire, she said, belonged to the households of the coast, who had cut the stair; she could not give away a place that was not hers, and if the strangers wanted a tower they must ask the households, one hearth at a time. So Torcall and Fenn went round the hearths, and it took eleven days. Most said yes. Two said no, and one of those came round when Torcall told him the tower would have a stair inside it, so that nobody need climb the old one in a gale again. The third cairn went up at the end of the shelf, where the rock was broad enough to bear a tower, and the custodian came up the stair to watch it built, and brought bread.

V

Of the Northern Point and the North-West Headland

The north coast they walked in an Cèitean and an t-Ògmhios, going west, with the hills of the interior blue on their left. They slept in byres and once

on the open heather, where each named the stars in his own tongue, and neither remembered the other's names in the morning.

It was on that stage that Fenn first spoke of the line. His chart of the coast was a chain of bearings from one headland to the next, all the way round, and it would close; but it had no measure across. Nobody knew how wide the island was. The ships' masters knew the west coast well enough now, and guessed at the east, and all guessed differently. What Fenn wanted was one straight line of sights across the whole island, from the open sea off the north-west to the water off the eastern cape, every station within sight of the next and every distance between them measured. Then the chart would have a spine.

Torcall asked how he meant to see across the middle of the island, where the hills were.

"From the tops of them," said Fenn. "With a mark on each top. A pile of stones, a pole, anything I can see from the next." He looked at Torcall sidelong. "You build good piles of stones."

At Muileann bheag, on the northern point, the old fire stood on a knob of turf above the shore, and the ground round it was red. Fenn wanted to know how deep the footing of a tower would have to go, and he borrowed a spade and dug a pit beside the fire-place with Torcall and a boy of the village. They went down through black ash and red earth, and black ash and red earth again, in bands like the rings of a felled tree, and at three yards they had still not come to rock. Torcall put his hand into the side of the pit and brought it out red to the wrist, and wiped it on the grass, and set his fourth cairn a little way inland where the rock was sound.

They came to the north-western headland at Baile chrom at midsummer.

This was the oldest fire of the five, and it had never been lit to bring anyone home. The tellings of Baile chrom said that it had been lit in the first days of the island to warn boats off the water beyond the headland, where Uilebheist na Mara¹ had been seen, and every child in the town knew why the ash under it lay a man's height deep. The boats of Baile chrom kept south of the fire. Out beyond, some miles off the north-west cape, lay the water where the boats of Achadh àr-saidh had met the strangers' ships in the first winter they came, and beyond that the open sea and the north.

The households of Baile chrom heard Torcall out, and then an old man of the town put the matter plainly. The fire on the headland said *keep away*. The

strangers wanted a fire that said *come in*. It could not say both, and the town would rather it went on saying what it had always said.

Fenn answered him in his bad Dia-thìris. The ships would come in whatever the fire said, he told the old man, because they were coming from an Tìr Thall² and this was the first land they saw; the only question was whether they came in on the rocks or clear of them. The old man looked at him for a long while and said that this was the first true thing he had heard a stranger say, and that he did not like it any better for being true.

The town gave leave in the end, on condition that the old fire be kept alight beside whatever tower was built, and fed with driftwood as it always had been. Fenn agreed at once. Torcall built the fifth cairn above the fire, and when it was done he stood beside it looking north-west, where the line of the open water showed clean and hard in the evening light, as the fishers said it had only begun to show in their fathers' time.

VI

Of Fenn's Line

The line began at sea, and the sea end was Torcall's doing.

Fenn wanted to know how far out a ship coming down from the north first saw the island, for there his line must begin. He could reckon it on paper from the height of the headland and the height of a mast, but he had seen what a chart from memory had done on the reefs south of Baile fhiadhaich, and he wanted to see it done. So at Lùnastal he went down the coast to Achadh àr-saidh and found a crew who would take him west in their boat, out past the meeting of the ships, as far into the open sea as they dared go; and Torcall stayed on the headland at Baile chrom to keep a fire.

He built it on a platform of flat stones beside the old fire-place, so as not to disturb the ash, of driftwood that the households brought up in creels, and he fed it with seal fat as the old fire was fed. He burned no coal. On the first night the wind was wrong and the boat did not go out. On the second there was haze. The third came clear and still, with a small moon, and the fire stood up on the head-

1. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

2. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

land in a column of yellow light with the sparks going up out of it. Torcall sat beside it all night and fed it, and the households of the town watched him from below, and none of them came up.

Out on the sea Fenn sat in the stern with his compass and a lantern shaded under a cloth and his eyes on the headland, and when the fire sank to a spark on the rim of the water and went out he called to them to stop. He took the time by his watch and the bearing by his compass and the run of the boat by a line paid out astern, and reckoned it through the rest of the night. It came to something near thirty of his miles. The fishers, who had never been so far out, rowed home, and Fenn was sick over the side twice on the way.

This is the one piece of the line told from both sides. Fenn's letter to Pike says that "the native fire on the north-west headland was raised by Clachair to a great height for the purpose, and was visible until thirty miles." Torcall told the households of the southern cape, many years after, that he had sat all night beside a fire lit for a stranger, to measure how far off strangers could see the island, and that he had fed it with his own hands and burned no coal on it, and that he still did not know whether he had done right.

From the headland the line went east and a little south, over the whole breadth of the island, and they ran it through the autumn. Fenn chose each station from the one before, sighting to the highest ground in the right direction, and Torcall went ahead to the chosen top and built a cairn on it, tall and narrow, with a white stone on the cap that Fenn could find through the glass. Then Fenn came up and sighted forward to the next top and back to the last, and two boys hired from the nearest village carried a chain of iron links between the stations to measure them. When the cloud sat on the hills they made no stations at all, and sat in a byre, and Fenn copied his columns fair and Torcall mended his boots.

The cairns went across the middle of Dia-thìr in a string, over the moors south of Cnoc bheag and the rough hills where the carters' roads went round, through country with no village for a day in any direction, where they slept against the cairns they had built.

In an t-Samhain they came up into the Doire uaine hills, and the next station on the line was the highest ground on the island.

Binnean a' Chlachair¹ stood up over the bare moor above Muileann gheal, a great shoulder of grey rock with the cloud on it half the year, and the line ran over

1. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

its summit as near as made no difference. Fenn saw it from two stations off and was glad, for from its top he could sight a long way east and cut a week off the work. He wanted a fire on it: a great fire, at night, that could be seen from station after station all the way to the eastern cape.

Torcall said that there would be no fire on Binnean a' Chlachair.

The herders of Muileann gheal said the same when they fed the two of them oatcakes and broth that night. Every child of those hills knew the telling of Clann a' Chlachair², that a man of that kindred had carried coal up to the summit in the old days and let it fall, and that one coal had caught fire in the air as it fell. Since then no one had lit a fire there. The herders who went over the top left a stone on it as they passed, one stone each, and that was all they did.

"*Cha las sinn teine an seo*," said the oldest of them. We light no fire here. He said it to Fenn directly, slowly, as to a child.

Fenn asked Torcall whether it was the same ruling as the coal on the beacons. Torcall said that it was a ruling of the hills, and the herders kept it.

They went up on a clear morning in the last week of an t-Samhain, with frost on the heather in the hollows and the whole eastern half of the island laid out below them in brown and grey, and the sea shining at the edge of it far off. On the summit there was a cairn already, broad and low and shapeless, built of the stones the herders had left there one at a time for longer than anyone could count. Torcall did not build on it. He took out of his coat a stone he had carried up from the burn at Muileann gheal, and laid it on the herders' cairn as the herders did, and stood back.

Fenn took his sights from the summit by daylight, to a square of white linen stretched on a pole on the next station east, with a boy of Muileann gheal beside it to hold it into the sun. It cost him four days more than a fire would have. He wrote in his columns that "the natives will not suffer a fire on the high point, for a reason connected with their religion," and went on with the work.

Winter shut down on them in an Dùbhlachd, and they wintered at Muileann gheal with the herders, and went on again in am Màrt when the cloud lifted off the moors. The last stations ran down out of the hills over the long slopes of the east to the cape at Baile iséal, where Torcall's second cairn stood above the old fire and the households of the coast came out to see the chain carried the last of the way.

2. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

On 26 an Giblean, AE 7, Fenn sat down in the watchman's house at Baile ìseal with all his columns in front of him and added the line up from end to end, twice, and then a third time. He made it a hundred and fifty-five miles, from the point in the open sea off the north-west where a ship coming down from the north would first raise the fire on the headland, to the water off the eastern cape; and some thirty of those miles were sea at the western end. It was the first measure that had ever been made of Dia-thìr from side to side.

He told Torcall the number, and Torcall asked what it meant in days.

Fenn thought about it and said, on a good road, walking hard, a little more than five.

Torcall said that it had taken them from Lùnastal to an Giblean.

"We were stopping," said Fenn.

"We were building," said Torcall.

VII

Of the Two Books at Baile dhìreach

They walked west from the eastern cape together, since Fenn was bound for Baile dhìreach and Torcall's road home to Cathair dhearg lay the same way for most of the journey.

Fenn had a wedding to go to. The human cooper Samuel Hale, who had come out with him in Harrow's ships and had settled at Baile dhìreach among the boat-builders, was to marry a net-maker of that town, Eilidh nic Ruairidh, and had written in the autumn to ask Fenn to stand for him. The letter had found them at Muileann gheal in the snow.

Baile dhìreach was a small harbour on the south-west coast, built along one long street that ran straight down to the quay, and it was the only town on Dia-thìr where the two peoples lived under one council. They came in over the last hill on an evening late in an Cèitean, with the sun going down into the western sea at the end of the street, and the street full of people carrying benches.

That night the council of six told the two walkers about the ruling. Before the spring, Iain mac Chaluim, the fisherman who sat for the Dia-thìrich on the council, had written to the custodians at Cathair dhearg to ask whether such a marriage could be entered in the custodians' roll as any other was, and whether its children would stand in the roll as the children of a Dia-thìreach mother. A rider

had carried the letter to the capital and come back with nothing. The council there had heard it read, he said, and gone on to the next matter.

"Then we shall write it down ourselves," said Iain mac Chaluim, "and they can rule on it when they please."

The council of Baile dhìreach kept two books, one in each tongue, as its compact was written in each, and on 26 an Cèitean, AE 7, it entered the marriage in both.

The wedding was held on the quay, the only open place in the town wide enough for everyone, and everyone came. The tide was full and the fishing boats rode at their moorings with green boughs tied to their mastheads. An old woman of Òrd Mhanannain¹, whose people had founded the town, poured sea-water on the stones at the couple's feet, and one of the human carpenters read a few lines from the strangers' black book while the townsfolk of both peoples stood through it. The two of them said their promises twice, once in each tongue, Eilidh haltingly in the strangers' tongue and Samuel worse in Dia-thìris, and nobody laughed at either. Then William Rook sat down at a table on the quay with the humans' book open in front of him, and Iain mac Chaluim beside him with the other, and each wrote the marriage into his own book in his own letters.

Each book needed a witness of each people. Fenn signed for the bridegroom in the humans' book. For the Dia-thìreach book the council had meant to ask a custodian, and no custodian had come; so Iain mac Chaluim looked round the quay for a Dia-thìreach of some standing who was not of Baile dhìreach, and found Torcall on a bollard at the edge of the crowd with a cup of ale, and called him to the table.

Torcall could write his name and not much more. He wrote it slowly under the names of the bride and bridegroom, and Iain mac Chaluim sanded it and blew on it and closed the book. Beside him William Rook closed the other.

There was dancing on the quay until the tide turned, and fish and bread and the strangers' ale. Late in the night, when the fires had burned down, Fenn brought out his chart and spread it on the council's table under the lamp, beside the two books where the clerks had left them. The whole coast of the island was on it, all the way round, and across the middle ran the line, straight as a stretched cord from the open sea to the eastern cape, every station marked with a small tri-

1. the order of Manannan

angle, and at each of the five headlands a small circle, and at each circle the name Fenn had written in the strangers' letters.

He had learned enough of the Dia-thìreach letters that winter at Muileann gheal to spell a word he heard, and he asked Torcall to tell him the names. So Torcall told him. The southern cape, Tobar dhearg. The eastern cape, Baile ìseal. The steps in the north-east, Àth dhearg. The northern point, Muileann bheag. The north-western headland, Baile chrom. Fenn wrote each under his own, carefully, in the island's letters, and at the mountain in the middle of the line, where he had written nothing, he wrote Binnean a' Chlachair² and drew no triangle.

The chart survives, with two names at every headland, one above the other in the same hand. The two books of Baile dhìreach that were closed on the quay that night hold the one marriage in two tongues. Of the cairns that Torcall built, the five above the old fires and the long string of narrow ones he laid across the island for Fenn's line, most have been pulled down by herders for their walls or have fallen in the winters and gone back into the hills. The stone he laid on Binnean a' Chlachair is on the summit still, among all the others, and there is no telling now which one it was.

CHAPTER SIX

Of the Treaty in One Tongue

AE 7 – 9

I

Of the Letter from Baile dhìreach

2. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

In the summer of AE 7 a letter came up the road from Baile dhìreach to the council hall at Cathair dhearg, and lay on the table of Ceann a' Chùraim¹ for the better part of a season.

Tormod mac Ailein was fifty-two years old that summer, and heavier than he had been when the ships came, and he had begun to feel the damp of the lake in his knees. He kept the table under the east window of the hall, where the light came in over the smoke of the smiths' lane, and he kept it clear. A custodian could lay a matter there in the morning and have his answer, or know that he would get none, by the time the lamps were lit. The clerks of the roll said that Tormod's table was the only flat place in Cathair dhearg that was never wet.

The letter from Baile dhìreach did not go from it. The council of six in that small port on the south-west coast, three of the island's people and three of the strangers, had entered a marriage in both its books: the net-maker Eilidh nic Ruairidh to the human cooper Samuel Hale. Now they asked the custodians at Cathair dhearg for a ruling on what they had done. The letter was in two hands and two tongues. Iain mac Chaluim had written the Dia-thìris half, in a fisherman's square letters, and at the foot of it the carpenter William Rook had put his own name in the strangers' writing, with a flourish under it like a wave.

Tormod read the Dia-thìris half twice. The other half he could not read at all, and he looked at it a while all the same, as a man looks at a field in a strange country, trying to tell barley from grass.

"They want to know whether it is a marriage," said Gormshuil nic Fhearchair, who had come in with the letter under her arm and stayed to watch him read it.

"They have married them. It is in both their books."

"Then they want to know whether it is a marriage to us."

Tormod set the letter down. "And what are we?"

She gave no answer, and he had looked for none. Gormshuil was five years younger than he, and in the five years since the season of words she had learned the strangers' letters from Samuel Wren, one at a time, with the patience of a woman threading beads. She could read Rook's line. She read it to him: his name, and the words *for the council*, and the date by the humans' reckoning, which meant nothing to either of them.

Tormod laid the letter in the chest under the window, with the other things that were waiting. The council did not take it up that summer, nor in the au-

1. the high custodian of the Council of Custodians; lit. 'head of the custody'

turn. When at last a custodian of the south-west asked in the hall what answer had been sent to Baile dhìreach, Tormod said that the town had made its own compact with its own hands, and a town that could do that could keep what it had made; and the clerk wrote that no ruling was given.

He had other things on his table. He had the iron.

II

Of Tormod's Reasons

There were three of them, and he could have counted them off on his fingers, and more than once he did.

The first was the iron. In the lane below the bridge the smiths of Cathair dhearg had learned the strangers' bar-iron in a single winter, and Gilleasbuig Gobha, the best of them, could draw a blade now that would shave the hair off a man's arm. Tormod had a hoe of it himself, for the garden behind his house, and a spade, and a pair of shears; and the old bronze hoes of the capital's fields had been melted down and cast into bells, which he heard every evening. No one in the fields wanted the bronze back.

The second was the surgeon. Jonas Tull had set the leg of a Cuan shean fisherman whom the whole town had given up for lame, and the custodian of Cuan shean had entered it in her roll as the first debt owed to a stranger. In the winter before the letter came, a back tooth had rotted in Tormod's own jaw and kept him from sleep for a month, and the capital's physician had given him willow-bark and told him to wait. Tull, passing through to the post, had looked in his mouth by the east window, asked for a stool and a cup of spirit, and drawn the tooth in the time it takes to say so. Tormod kept it in a box.

The third was the ships.

Edmund Harrow had sailed home with hides and cloth in his holds and come back with four ships in place of three. He could come back with forty, and had never needed to say so. A big man gone grey at the temples, who laughed easily, Harrow had held out an empty cask on the strand at Cuan shean and been given water, and every custodian on the island liked him for it. But Tormod had asked him once, at the post, through Thomas Pike, how many ships there were in an Tìr Thall¹. Harrow had thought about it honestly, then laughed and said that he

could not count them, and that most of them were not his, and that the men who owned them did not always ask for water.

That was the third reason. Tormod never wrote it down.

In the autumn of that year Harrow came up the lake road to Cathair dhearg with Pike beside him to put his words into the island's tongue, and sat at the table under the east window, and asked that the terms on which his people stayed be written.

"You have your leave," said Tormod. "It is in the roll."

"It's in your roll," Harrow said. Pike gave it over word for word, with an apologetic look, as a man hands on a pot too hot to hold. "In my country nothing is so until it's written by both sides and signed by both. A man is coming who will ask for it. Better it's written now, between friends, than later between strangers."

"We are strangers," Tormod said.

Harrow laughed at that, and when Pike had given it him he laughed again. "So we are. Well. Between strangers who've eaten each other's bread, then."

He told them that the man who was coming would bear a title that Pike could not put into Dia-thìris and did not try to, and which the island came afterwards to render An t-Àrd-mhaor², the high steward; that he would speak for the government of an Tìr Thall and for no trading house; that Harrow himself had asked for him, since a ship's master was no one to be making laws; and that he would come with the spring sailing. Then he stood, and shook Tormod's hand in his fashion, and went down the stairs to the street whistling.

Tormod sat on at the table after they had gone, while the new bells rang for the evening, and thought of Oighrig nic Leòid's letter from her sickbed six years before, which the clerk had not read out: that a leave given in the roll cannot be ungiven by the next roll, and that the strangers would know it better than the council, since they would be holding it. He had thought her an old woman afraid of the sea. He read the letter again that night by the lamp, and put it back.

III

Of the Man Who Asked for a Horse

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

2. the Commissioner; lit. 'the high steward'

Josiah Pell landed at Cuan shean in the early spring of AE 8, off the first ship of the year to come down from the north.

The custodian of Cuan shean was still Oighrig nic Leòid, who had given Harrow water. She walked with a stick now, and kept her custody from a chair by the harbour window. She sent a rider up the valley road to the capital the same day with a letter, and the letter is in the council's roll. It says that the ship came in on the morning tide; that the man got down into the boat in a black coat, with a leather case under his arm that he would let no one else carry; that he came up the shingle dry-shod, on a plank the sailors laid for him; and that he did not ask for water. He asked for a horse. She lent him her own, the gentlest in the town, and he thanked her by name, having learned it on the ship. He was a man of about fifty, she wrote, clean-shaven, grey, with good manners and a cold, and he looked at everything once and seemed to remember it.

He rode the twenty-six miles to Cathair dhearg in a day, with two of his own people and a Cuan shean boy to show the road, and came up the hill into the capital at dusk with the rain beginning. Instead of the post, he asked for the council hall, and there for Ceann a' Chùrain¹; and Tormod, who had been told he was coming and had not believed he would come the same night, went down to meet him in the hall with his house-shoes still on his feet.

There was no one there that night to carry words between them. Pell took off his wet hat, bowed a short neat bow from the neck, and said a sentence in his own tongue, and then two words in Dia-thìris that he must have learned on the ship, careful and wrong in every sound: *Beannachd leibh*. It is the island's word of leave-taking. Tormod bowed back and did not correct him. Pell was given a room in the guest-house by the temple, and in the morning Wren came up from the post to put his words into the island's tongue, and the talking began.

It went on for most of a moon.

Wren sat between them at the long table in the council hall, or on fine days at the post at Ros dhomhain, where Pell laid his papers out on a board across two casks. He was thinner than he had been in the season of words and coughed in the mornings, and sometimes he stopped and said to Tormod in Dia-thìris, "There is no word of yours for this. I will say it as near as I can," and then said it. Pell's secretary, a young man with a clean hand, wrote down each day what was agreed and read it back at evening.

1. the high custodian of the Council of Custodians; lit. 'head of the custody'

Tormod asked at the start that the terms be written twice, once in each tongue, as the compact of Baile dhìreach had been.

Pell heard this through Wren and said that he honoured the custom, and that at Baile dhìreach it had been well done. Only an agreement between his government and the island must go before the lawyers of an Tìr Thall², who could read only their own tongue, and a writing in two tongues was two writings, and the day would come when they did not agree. One text should govern. A copy in Diathìris would be made for the council's use, as a courtesy, when there was leisure to make it well.

"When will there be leisure?" Tormod asked.

Pell said: after. Wren gave it over as *an dèidh làimh*, which is the island's way of saying it, and means *after the hand*, and the council clerk wrote it down.

Six of the council sat through the talking, from the capital and the lake towns and the west; the roll gives their names, and sets down that no one of them spoke against the terms. What there was to speak against, they could hear only through Wren, a sentence at a time, and a sentence at a time the terms were fair. The strangers might dwell where they had leave and trade where they found buyers. They would keep their own law among their own people and answer to the council for harm done to the island's. The harbour dues would be shared as they were shared already. A man of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach³ would keep order among the humans and speak for them to the council. There was a line about goods, and the working of goods, which Wren gave twice over and frowned at.

Gormshuil was not at the table. She had gone east in the month of Bearnach with the season's copies for the loft of Beathag nic Thòmais at Muileann chaol, as she went every year, near sixty miles of hill road with a chest on a pony. When Tormod saw how the talking went he sent a rider after her. She started back the day he found her, and the rain was on the hills, and the fords were up.

On 27 an Giblean, AE 8, the terms on which the humans stayed were set down in writing for the first time, fair, on six sheets, in the humans' tongue only. The secretary wrote them. Pell signed nothing yet, and said that the signing should be done in the council hall, before the council, as was proper; and Tormod, who had been given a great many reasons that morning and had followed all of them, found that he agreed.

2. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

3. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

IV

Of the Line Read Twice

Cùmhnant Cathair dhearg was signed on 7 an Cèitean, AE 8, in the moon of Bealltach, a week after the bright fires.

The fires of Bealltainn had smoked more than they blazed that year, and it rained all the morning of the signing. The rain came off Loch chrom in grey sheets and walked up the hill over the roofs, and the windows of the hall ran with it, so that the lake and the harbour and the far shore went to smears of grey behind the glass. The custodians sat in their cloaks by the two fires, and the cloaks steamed.

Josiah Pell sat on the far side of the long table in his black coat, newly come over the sea as An t-Àrd-mhaor¹ of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach², the first of them; and on the near side sat Tormod mac Ailein, in the chair of Ceann a' Chùraim³, with his hands folded in front of him. Between them lay the six sheets, squared together and covered edge to edge in the strangers' close black writing.

Tormod could not read a word of it. The letters stood on the sheets like a fence of thorn, and he looked at them, and then away.

Someone read it to him. The roll keeps the name of every custodian in the hall that day, and Pell's name, and the names of the two humans who stood behind him, and the name of the clerk; it keeps the name of the boy who fed the fires. It does not keep the name of the reader. The copyists of the cellar have looked for it in every roll that came down to them, and have not found it. Tormod sat with his hands folded and his eyes on the rain and listened to the voice go down the sheets, sentence by sentence, the strangers' tongue and then the island's, and the custodians along the table listened with him.

Gormshuil had not come. Her rider had sent word from the hills the night before that the ford at the foot of the long glen was up to a horse's belly, and that she would cross it in the morning.

About the middle of the fourth sheet Tormod lifted one hand from the table.

"*Leugh a-rithist e*," he said. Read that again.

The voice went back to the beginning of the sentence and read it again. It was the line about goods: that the humans might trade in such goods as the island af-

1. the Commissioner; lit. 'the high steward'

2. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

3. the high custodian of the Council of Custodians; lit. 'head of the custody'

forded, and in the working of them, under licence of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach, and that the council would not hinder such trade. It read the same the second time. Tormod listened to it with his head a little on one side, the way he listened to a custodian of the hill country who was taking the long way round to a point, and then he nodded and put his hand down, and the voice went on.

He thought, as the voice went on, of wool from Cathair naomh and dyes for Baile Mòr mhòr, of the salt of Seann Warr, of hides and cloth. Those were the goods the island afforded; he had seen them go across Pike's counter for six years. The working of them was the spinning and the dyeing and the curing, and the strangers wanted a licence for everything. It did not come into his head that a trader might want to work anything else on Dia-thìr. The vein was the vein, and no one had ever carried it to a counter.

When the reading was done Pell turned the last sheet round on the table so that it faced Tormod, and took a pen from the secretary, and dipped it, and held it out across the table.

Tormod took it. It was a goose quill, cut fine, and it was lighter than he had thought it would be.

He looked for a long while at the place where his name should go, a space at the foot of the sheet above a ruled line. He looked at it as a man looks at a ford before he wades it: at the colour of the water, and the set of it over the stones, and the far bank, and whether the far bank is as near as it looks. The custodians along the table watched him. Pell did not move. The rain ran down the windows. Then Tormod bent and wrote his name in the island's letters, square and heavy, and gave the pen back.

Pell signed after him for Riaghaltas nan Coigreach. His name was short and went quickly, with a line under it.

The strangers had dated the sheets at their head by their own day, month and year, and the secretary read the date aloud. The custodians' clerk had the roll open at the end of the table, and when the signing was done he entered it under its name, Cùmhnant Cathair dhearg⁴: the names of those present, the terms as near as he could catch them, and the signing. At the head of the entry he wrote the year of the count of An Diosal⁵, and the moon of Bealltach. Then he came to the day. The humans' day was a number out of their own month, which ran by another measure than the moon, and no one in the hall could tell him how to turn

4. the first written treaty, signed at Cathair dhearg; the Treaty in One Tongue

5. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

the one into the other. He sat with his pen over the page a while. Then he left the day empty and went on to the next line.

It was the first page of its kind in the council's roll, and no one remarked on it. The clerk ruled off the entry and sanded it, and Pell's secretary rolled the six sheets into a leather case with a cap to it and gave the case to Pell, who put it under his arm and kept it there.

Gormshuil came in two days later, with the mud of the long glen up to her knees, and the pony lame. She went straight to the hall without stopping at her house, and found the chair of Ceann a' Chùraim empty and the clerk at his table, and she asked him for the roll, and read the entry standing. Then she went to find Tormod, and what was said between them neither of them ever told. That afternoon she asked Pell, through Wren, for a copy of the terms in the strangers' tongue, since the copy in hers was to wait for leisure; and Pell, who was courteous in all things, had his secretary make one and sent it to her house within the week, with his compliments.

She began to read it with her finger, a word at a time, the way Wren had taught her. The strangers' law had words that were in none of Wren's lists, and she wrote each one on a slip and took the slips to Wren, who was often ill that year. She did not bring it before the council, and no one asked her to. It was signed.

V

Of the House on the Rise

That summer Pell asked the council for ground.

He wanted the rise above Ros dhomhain, the bare shoulder of hill behind the harbour where the town's goats grazed, to build on it a house of dressed stone for Riaghaltas nan Coigreach¹. The goat-keepers were paid in iron pots, and were glad of the bargain. The council gave the ground, with no vote needed, since it was a matter of goats.

Pell had no masons of his own, and asked for the best of the masons' lane at Cathair dhearg, who had rebuilt the council hall's east gable when Tormod was young. They were paid in bar-iron by the day, and by the humans' day, which began at midnight where the island's began at dusk, and they grumbled at it and

1. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

took the iron. They floated the stone over from the old quarries across the lake on rafts, and dressed it on the rise with the wind cutting at their hands.

Tormod rode down to see it in the autumn. The house was going up square and plain, of the grey stone of the lake shore, two floors high and five windows wide, with a slate roof on it from the hills behind Cathair dhearg; and it faced the harbour. From its windows Pell would see every mast in Ros dhomhain and every boat that came up Abhainn gheal into the lake. From its door he would not see the capital. Tormod stood on the rise in the wind with the master mason and asked him why the house was turned so.

"He drew it that way," said the master mason. "On a paper he brought with him." He spat on his hands and picked up his mallet. "A good paper. You can see every stone on it before it's cut. We could build him the other way round, if the council asked it."

The council did not ask it.

On 10 an Cèitean, AE 9, Pell went up the hill from the post and slept for the first time in the stone house on the rise, and called it by the name it had in his tongue, which the island came to call Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir², the house of the high steward. A flag went up on a pole before its door. From that day the humans on Dia-thìr answered to that house.

Edmund Harrow was needed ashore no longer, and he went back to the sea.

He came up the lake road to Cathair dhearg to say so, with Pike beside him. Tormod gave them bread and cheese in the room behind the hall, and Harrow ate like a man who would be at sea again tomorrow. He said that Pell would govern now and that it was right he should; that a ship's master had no more business in a council hall than a council in a ship; that he had been ashore on this island eight years, longer than he had been ashore anywhere since he was twelve, and that it was time.

"And the post?" Tormod asked.

Harrow wiped his mouth. He and Pike, he said, were to have a licence from Riaghaltas nan Coigreach to trade: a trading house, the two of them and some men of an Tìr Thall³ who had put money into it. Pike would keep the books ashore, and Harrow would keep the ships at sea, and between them they would carry what the island had to sell to the people who wished to buy it. He said it cheerfully. Pike, putting it into Dia-thìris, said it more slowly.

2. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

3. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

"It's a charter," Harrow said. "Pell seals it. You'll have a copy. You'll find it's all in order."

He shook Tormod's hand at the door, and went down the stairs whistling, as he always did. He sailed on the next tide but one from Ros dhomhain, north-about, the way the ships went. Tormod did not see him again.

VI

Of the Charter Read in Private

Harrow and Pike founded their trading house on 18 an Cèitean, AE 9, under licence of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach¹ and Pell's seal. It had a long name in the strangers' tongue, and the island never learned it. From the first the island called it A' Chompanaidh², since that was the word Pike used for it at his counter, and nobody asked what it was a company of.

A copy of its charter came to the council, as Harrow had said it would. It came in the strangers' tongue, on four sheets, with a red seal at the foot of the last, and the clerk entered its coming in the roll and laid it in the chest under the east window, beside the letter from Baile dhìreach. There it lay a month.

Gormshuil took it out. She had been a year at the terms by then, and read the strangers' tongue far better, though still with her finger. She took the charter home one evening at the end of the moon of Ògach and read it twice through by her lamp, and wrote something on a slip. Then she put on her cloak and walked across the town in the long summer dusk to Tormod's house, below the temple, and knocked.

He was at his supper. He had a fire lit, though it was midsummer, because of his knees; and he sent the girl who kept his house to bed and poured Gormshuil a cup of ale and sat across the hearth from her, and she read him the charter.

She read it slowly, the strangers' sentence first and then her own, and where she had no word of the island's for a word of theirs she said so. It was long. It named Harrow and Pike and the men of an Tìr Thall³, and the licence, and the seal; it spoke of ships and of goods and of the post at Ros dhomhain; it spoke of

1. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

2. the Company

3. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

tools and stores. Tormod listened with his cup in his hand. It was all in order, as Harrow had said.

Then she came to the clause, and stopped.

"There is a word here," she said. "I know it. I have known it since the season of words."

It was the word Wren had written in the window-light on the morning she tipped the basket of broken coal out on the table and named its colours: the one word, the word for the black fuel of the strangers' own hearths, with which he had tapped the whole heap to show that it stood for all of it. In the charter it had grown. It stood in a list, and the list was a long one. She read it to him in the strangers' tongue first, and then she put it into Dia-thìris as close as the island's tongue would go, word by word.

All fuels, ores and minerals the island may yield.

Tormod did not say anything.

"The charter gives them the first refusal of it," Gormshuil said. "All of it. Whatever the island yields that burns, and whatever is dug. Before any other trader of their people. It is sealed by Pell under the licence." She laid a second paper on her knee: her own copy of Cùmhnant Cathair dhearg⁴, worn soft at the corners by a year of her finger. "And the licence hangs from here."

She found the line on the fourth sheet and read it to him. That the humans might trade in such goods as the island afforded, and in the working of them, under licence of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach, and that the council would not hinder such trade.

He had heard it twice. He had asked for it twice.

"I thought it meant wool," Tormod said.

"Yes."

"I thought of the salt at Seann Warr. The hides. The dyes." He set his cup down on the hearthstone as though it might break. "There's Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig⁵. No household burns more than its handful. It has been so since An Aois Naomh⁶."

"That measures hearths," said Gormshuil, "and has nothing to say about a ship's hold. The men who made it never saw a ship go out that was not coming back." She folded the charter along its creases. "They did not ask for our word for

4. the first written treaty, signed at Cathair dhearg; the Treaty in One Tongue

5. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

6. the Holy Age

the coal, Tormod. They never asked. Now they have written theirs down, and put a seal on it, and you have signed the paper it hangs from."

The fire had burned down. Neither of them made it up. Outside the town had gone to bed; a dog barked down by the bridge, and stopped, and the bells of the capital rang for the middle of the night, the bronze of the old hoes speaking over the dark roofs.

After a while Tormod asked her whether it could be undone.

She did not know. In the strangers' law, as far as she had been able to learn it from Wren, a thing signed by both sides stood until both sides unsigned it; and that Pell had no reason to unsign anything; and that no ship had yet come asking for coal, and none might. The charter was a list of what the strangers might want, she said, and a list was not a pit.

"Then there is time," Tormod said.

"There may be."

"Keep it between us," he said, "until I have thought."

She looked at him a long time across the dead fire, and then she said that she would; and she did. She gave him the slip she had written on, which had the clause on it in both tongues, and walked home through the dark. Tormod sat up with the slip in his hand until the window greyed. He did not bring the charter before the council that year, nor the next. There was no ship in the harbour asking for coal. There was only the list.

VII

Of the Door at Cathair dhomhain

The first building of A' Chompanaidh¹ was a warehouse, and it went up that summer and autumn at Cathair dhomhain, along the lake shore from the capital, where the fishing town runs down to the water between its two stony points.

Pike chose the ground. He said, when anyone asked, that it was to keep its tools and stores out of the reach of the harbour thieves of Ros dhomhain, who had had two of his axes and a coil of good rope in a single winter. The ground was a strip of shingle and rough grass above the high-water line, with a spring behind

1. the Company

it, and it belonged to a family of Cathair dhomhain that had drawn its nets there since An Aois Naomh². They sold it to Pike for a keg of nails, two lamps and a sheet of window-glass. The custodian of the lake shore entered the sale in his roll. It was the first ground on Dia-thìr that the strangers held by sale and not by the council's leave.

The masons who had built the house on the rise built the warehouse too, of the same grey stone, long and low with no window on the landward side and two high narrow windows on the lake, like a byre; and Pike roofed it with slate.

Tormod walked out to see it on 28 an Dàmhair, AE 9.

It was the stags' moon, Damhrach, and the first cold day of the autumn. He went alone and on foot, since it was only five miles by the lake road. The road ran along the shore with the lake on his left hand, grey and still, and the geese coming down on it out of the north in long wavering lines, calling. At Cathair dhomhain the warehouse stood finished on its strip of shingle, all but its door. The doorway stood open, a square of dark smelling of new lime. There were men of the strangers inside, stacking tools: picks and bars and shovels, and heavy hammers with long hafts, and coils of rope and chain, all new, with the grease still on them. Tormod stood in the doorway and looked at the picks a long while. They were not the tools of a fisherman or a dyer or a man who cures hides.

Pike came out to him, with his tally-book under his arm and his pen behind his ear, and greeted him in the island's tongue, which he spoke well by then. He showed him the warehouse end to end, and the tally of every tool in his book, balanced to the last line.

"For the post?" Tormod asked, and put his hand on a pick.

"For whatever's wanted," said Pike. "We keep them against the day."

The door came down the shore road that afternoon on a cart from Cathair dhearg. It was a heavy door of oak planks, a hand's breadth thick, pegged and studded with iron, and it took six men to lift it down. Its hinges had been forged in the smiths' lane below the bridge. Tormod knew them when he saw them: long iron straps drawn out and folded round a pin, with the ends split and curled back like fern, which was the mark Gilleasbuig Gobha put on everything he made. The strangers had paid for them in bar-iron. Pike had asked for Gilleasbuig by name.

They hung the door as the light was going. The six men lifted it and walked it to the doorway, and held it upright with their shoulders against it while a seventh

2. the Holy Age

stood on a cask and guided the straps down over the pins; and it dropped onto them with a clank that went out over the lake. Pike swung it. It turned without a sound, and closed, and he took a long iron key from his coat and locked it; then he unlocked it again, to see that it worked, and locked it again, and put the key away.

"There," he said, in the island's tongue, pleased as a boy. "That's ours."

Tormod walked home along the lake road in the dusk. The geese had settled on the water for the night and were talking among themselves out in the dark, and away along the shore the lamps of Ros dhomhain were coming out one by one, and above them, on the rise, the windows of Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir³, five across, all lit. Behind him at Cathair dhomhain there was no light at all. The warehouse had no window on the landward side. There was only the door, and the key in Pike's coat, and whatever was kept behind them against the day.

The custodian of the lake shore wrote in his roll that night that a door had been hung on the strangers' building by the water, and that it was a good door, of oak, with a smith of the capital's hinges on it. The copyists of the cellar found that line when the rolls came down to them, and kept it, and asked the reader to remember that door.

CHAPTER SEVEN

OF the Fever and the Sacks of Coal

AE 9 – 11

I

Of the Carriers at Cuan shean

3. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

Raghnall mac Dhòmhnaill was nineteen that autumn, a hewer's son of Muileann chrom, and he had never seen the sea.

His father sent him west with the carriers late in an Dàmhair, in the ninth year of the strangers. It was the custom of the hill households that the coal for the far hearths went down from the store at Taigh na Fèithe¹ before the dark of the year, on the backs of ponies and young men, so much for each hearth and no more, as the law of the handful had it; and a lad who had carried it once to the coast was held to have seen the island. Raghnall had asked for three years to go. When his turn came he went with a pony called Donnag, eleven carriers, and an old custodian's clerk who could not walk fast and rode the whole way on a cart of meal, complaining.

They were five days on the road. Past the capital the country flattened and the wind got up, and it came off the west smelling of wet sand and rot, a smell he did not know, and Donnag put her ears back at it. On the fifth evening they came over the last rise and he saw the water. It lay grey to the edge of sight, heaving slowly, and a long way out on it the light ran in a white bar where the sun was going down. He stood with the pony's rope in his hand until the clerk shouted at him.

Cuan shean was bigger than any town of the hills and smelled of fish and tar. Its houses stood with their backs to the weather along a bent harbour, and in the harbour, among the Dia-thireach boats, lay two of the strangers' ships, so high out of the water that the carriers stopped in the street to look at them. The humans had been coming to that harbour nine years by then, and the town had the habit of them.

The custodian of Cuan shean was Oighrig nic Leòid, who had given the first of the strangers water on that shingle and had been abed the winter the council gave them leave. She was old now and walked with a stick, and she came down to the custodians' store herself to see the coal counted in. She had each carrier open his baskets on the floor, and she went along the rows with a lamp, stooping, and turned the coal over with the end of the stick. Raghnall stood by his baskets with his heart knocking. She stopped at them and held the lamp low.

"Whose cutting?"

"My father's, lady. Dòmhnall's, of the old cutting above the mill."

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

"It is good coal," she said. "See the green in it." And she moved the lamp so that the green came up out of the black like weed under water, and Ragnall, who had broken that coal himself in the hill, felt his face go hot.

On the third day the carriers were to start home. That morning a ship came in from the north, a big hull low in the water and so crowded at the rails that from the quay she seemed to have a hedge along her sides. She had come the long way about, past the north cape and down the western coast, and she had been six weeks at sea. The humans on the quay went out to her in boats. Those who came ashore were thin and grey in the face, and some of them had to be lifted over the side. There were women among them, which Ragnall had not seen before, and children, and a man with a fiddle in a bag, who stood on the stones and wept.

Oighrig's people gave them water, as Cuan shean always did. The ship's master asked for more than water, and got it, and the town took some of the sick into the sail-lofts, where the humans said their prayers.

Within four days the first Dia-thíreach was sick. It was a woman of the net-sheds, who had carried water to the lofts. She burned, and shook, and talked all night in a voice that was not hers, and on the second day a rash came out on her chest like the marks of wet sand, and on the fourth day she died. By then there were eleven more. The custodians' roll gives the day the fever came ashore as 5 an t-Samhain, AE 9, and names it Fiabhras nan Coigreach, and that is the name it kept.

The carriers did not go home. The clerk would not have them walk the roads with the fever in the town, lest they carry it into the hills, and Oighrig said the same. So Ragnall stayed in Cuan shean through an t-Samhain and saw the whole of it.

He carried water, because the custodians asked for strong backs and he had one. He carried the dead out of the net-sheds on hurdles, two to a hurdle, with cloths over their mouths that did no good. In a week he knew the smell of the fever houses and the sound a house makes when no one inside it is well enough to answer the door. The humans died of it too, but fewer of them, and slower, and some of those who took it at sea got up again. The Dia-thírich who took it seldom got up. The old men of the harbour sat on the upturned boats and said that the strangers had brought it in their clothes, in their blood, in their bread; and a younger man said that it made no odds where they had brought it, since here it was.

On the ninth day Oighrig nic Leòid called the custodians of the town to the store and shut Cuan shean to ships. No hull was to come in and none to go out until the fever was gone, and the boats of the town were to fish within the harbour mouth or not at all. She had them bring her chair down to the quay so that the masters of the two human ships could hear it from her. One of them laughed. The other went white and asked how his cargo was to reach the capital, and she said by the road, like anyone's.

Eight days after that a rider came in from Ros dhomhain with a letter. It was from Josiah Pell, An t-Àrd-mhaor², and it was written in the humans' tongue, on three sheets, and sealed. There was no one in Cuan shean who could read it but the humans, and so Oighrig sent for the trader who kept the humans' store by the quay and had him read it to her in the store-room, standing, with the carriers and the town's custodians round the walls.

Raghnall understood none of the words. He understood the voice. It went on a long time, level and hard, and now and then the trader stopped to put a sentence into Dia-thìris for her: that the harbour of Cuan shean was open to the ships of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach³ under Cùmhnant Cathair dhearg⁴; that the custodians had no power to close it; that Pell protested in writing, and would protest again, and would hold the town answerable for the goods spoiled in the holds.

Oighrig heard it out. Then she asked the trader whether the letter said anything about the dead.

He looked through the sheets. "No, lady."

"Then write him that there are forty-one of them in this town," she said, "and that the ships may wait."

The roll of Cuan shean enters the protest, and beside it the number, which was forty-one that day and went on rising.

II

Of the Dunes and the Road Home

2. the Commissioner; lit. 'the high steward'

3. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

4. the first written treaty, signed at Cathair dhearg; the Treaty in One Tongue

They buried the fever dead of Cuan shean beyond the dunes, in the sand, where the town had never buried before. The custodians would not have the fever lie in the old ground by the harbour, among the town's grandmothers; and so the hurdles went out along the shore path past the last net-shed and up over the marram and down again on the far side, out of sight of the houses, where the wind comes straight off the open sea. Ragnhall carried on that path more times than he let himself count.

It rained most days. The sand took the rain and did not hold it, and the graves were easy to dig and hard to keep, for the sides slid in. The human dead went into the same ground, a little apart, in a row of their own, because their priest asked it. He read over them from his book in the rain, and the Dia-thireach carriers stood back with their hands under their arms and waited for him to finish so that they could fill in.

Once, on the path, the man at the other end of Ragnhall's hurdle stopped and said, "Look at them," and Ragnhall looked back at the town and saw the two tall ships riding in the harbour with their sails furled, and a boat going out to them with fresh water, and a man in the stern of it singing.

"They are well," the carrier said. "Most of them are well."

By the dark of the year the burying slackened, and a little before Là Fhèill Brìde it stopped. The custodians opened the harbour at the season's end. The roll of the west gives the whole count down the coast as ninety-one Dia-thirich dead and eleven humans, and the numbers stand in the copy at Muileann chaol exactly as the custodians wrote them.

Ragnhall walked home with the carriers when the roads were opened. They did not talk much. At the capital the clerk left them to report to the council, and they went on east without him, up the long road into the hills, and the country rose round them and the wind lost its salt. On the fifth evening he saw the mill at Muileann chrom with its wheel turning in the bend of the river, and the smoke going up flat from the roofs, and he sat down on a stone at the roadside for a while before he went down.

His father met him at the door and looked at him a long time and said, "You are thinner."

"I carried," Ragnhall said.

His father said nothing to that. Dòmhnall was a hewer of the old cutting, as his father had been, a short man with shoulders like a yoke and black in the seams of his hands that no washing took out. He had cut the measured coal of the hill

for thirty years, so many baskets in the season and not one over, and he had never been further west than the capital. Ragnall told him about the ships, and the sea, and the sand, and Oighrig's lamp, and the letter; and his father listened, and at the end he asked only whether Oighrig had liked the coal.

"She said to look at the green in it."

"So she should," said Dòmhnall.

III

Of the Word from the West

News came up the road that year in the carters' mouths, and none of it good.

On 9 an Gearran, AE 10, the fever reached Baile àrsaidh, a short way up the coast from Cuan shean, where the druids of Manannan kept their school. It killed the custodian of the town and both her sons, and a number of households besides, and the school shut its doors and kept them shut until the summer. The thing the custodians of the west wrote down, and the thing the carters told in the hills, was this: that no human lived in Baile àrsaidh at all. No strangers' ship had put in there. The fever had walked up the coast by itself, on Dia-thìreach feet, from house to house.

The custodians of the hills met at 'Taigh na Fèithe' above Muileann dhearg in the spring to speak of it. Ragnall's father went, as a hewer of the old cutting had the right to do, and came back late and sat by the fire with his boots on.

"They talked of shutting the roads," he said.

"Will they?"

"No." He pulled at a boot. "The road is the meal and the salt. It is the lamp-oil from Ros dhomhain, which half the hill has got the use of now. They said a hill that shuts its road starves slower than it sickens, but it starves." He got the boot off and looked at it. "Old Seonag Liath, who keeps our cutting, said we had eaten salt with the strangers nine years and it was a little late to be afraid of their bread. They wrote that down."

So the hills did not shut their roads, and the roll of Taigh na Fèithe gives the reason in Seonag Liath's words. The fever did not come to Muileann chrom that

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

year. Whether that was luck, or the hills' distance from the sea, or the grace of the hill, nobody in the district could agree, and they argued it at the mill all summer.

In the south-west, at Cnoc àrsaidh, where Imrich nam Pantar² passes and Òrd na Cloiche³ keeps its oldest shrines, the townsfolk did what the hills had talked of. When the fever came down the coast towards them, on 14 an t-Samhain, AE 10, they dragged their carts across the road on either side of the town, wheel to wheel, and set men with staves behind them, and turned back every traveller for a season: carters, drovers, custodians, and the humans' traders with their packs. The fever went round them and did not come in. The carters told next, with relish, that Riaghaltas nan Coigreach⁴ had fined Cnoc àrsaidh for hindering trade, and that the town had paid it in wool, sacks of it, and the humans had not known what to do with so much wool.

Dòmhnall laughed at that, which he seldom did. Raghnaill remembered the dunes, and did not.

IV

Of the Two Prospectors

Near the end of an t-Samhain in the tenth year, when the hills were brown and the rain came across them in sheets, two humans came up the road to Muileann chrom with a letter.

They came on foot, with a pony carrying their packs, and they stopped at the mill because it was the largest house in sight. One was a broad man of five-and-thirty, bald, with a red face and a red beard and a voice that could be heard across the river; his name was Abel Stone. The other was younger and taller and stooped, with spectacles that he took off every few minutes to wipe, and a book in a waxed cover that he never let go of; his name was Hugh Mercer. The letter was from A' Chompanaidh¹, the trading house that Harrow and Pike had founded under licence of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach², and it asked in both tongues, badly in

2. the panthers' crossing

3. the order of the Stone

4. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

1. the Company

2. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

one of them, that the bearers be given lodging and a guide into the hills, for which a fair price would be paid.

The miller read the *Dia-thiris* half aloud to the room and gave it back.

Nobody would go. The men of the hill were courteous to the strangers and gave them the miller's back room and a fire and a supper of mutton, and the miller's wife lent Mercer a dry shirt. But when Stone spread his hands and said "Coal?" and pointed up at the hills, and made a hammering motion with his fist, the men at the fire looked at one another and looked away. The hill was the custodians'. What a man broke out of it he broke by their leave, in its season, in the measure. No one in *Muileann chrom* had ever led a stranger up it with a hammer, and no one wanted to be the first.

Ragnall was at the fire that night. He had been thinking since the spring, when he thought at all, about the ships riding well in the harbour at *Cuan shean* and the man singing in the stern of the boat. What he thought of it he could not have said; but he was tired of the mill and the cutting and the same eleven faces, and he had seen the sea.

Stone had taken a coin out of his purse and laid it on the table, a disc of silver with a man's head on one side, stamped, and letters round the edge. The firelight ran on it. He tapped it and said a word in his own tongue and looked round.

"I will go," said Ragnall.

His father was not there. He heard of it the next morning from the miller, and he came to the mill yard where Ragnall was loading the pony and stood and watched without a word. When the loading was done he said, "You will not go into the cutting."

"No."

"Nor into any gallery the custodians keep."

"No. Only the hill."

"The hill is the custodians'," said *Dòmhnall*. Then he turned round and went home, and Ragnall watched his back until the corner of the byre took it.

They were eleven days on the hill. Stone and Mercer knew what they were looking for and had only a little of the tongue to ask for it, and Ragnall had none of theirs, and between them they made a talk of hands and a few words that got better as the days went on. Stone wanted water: streams, gullies, the places where rain had cut down into the hillside and bared the rock. Ragnall took them up the burns north of the mill, into the high ground towards *Doire mhòr* and east along the flank of the hills above the river, where the heather gave way in the

stream-cuts to banks of shale and clay, and where every child of the hill knew that the black showed through.

It showed. In the second gully Stone went down on his knees in the wet and scraped at the bank with his hammer and a shout went out of him that sent a hare bolting. There was the seam, a hand's breadth of it and then an arm's length, running into the hill under the turf like a black river under a bank. Stone broke off a piece and turned it in his fingers and rubbed it with his thumb, and smelled it, and put his tongue to it, and gave it to Mercer, who wrote in his book.

Ragnall stood above them on the bank with the rain running off his hood. He looked at the broken piece in Mercer's hand. It was fresh coal of the upper seam, the sort that comes near the surface, and in the grey light it showed its brown at the edges, deep brown going into red where it had split, and under that the green, and along one face a sheen like the inside of a mussel shell. Any child of the hill could have named them. He had the words in his mouth.

"Gual donn-ruadh," he said, and pointed at the edge where the red ran into the brown. "An sin. Agus an sin, gual airgid³."

Mercer looked up at him, pleasantly, and wiped his spectacles, and looked at the piece of coal, and looked at Ragnall again, waiting. Ragnall touched the sheen with his finger. Mercer nodded, the way a man nods at a child who has shown him a pebble, and said something to Stone, and Stone laughed, not unkindly, and said a word that Ragnall had heard in Cuan shean. He heard it a great many times on that hill. It was the only word either of them had for what they were breaking, and it stood for all of it alike.

They broke a great deal. They broke it at every gully where the seam showed, and they put it in sacks, coarse sacks of the humans' weaving with letters on them, a sack for each gully, and Mercer wrote the place in his book and a number, and Ragnall learned after a while that the number was the paces from the last. On the fifth day Stone took to walking the seam. He went along the hillside with his head down, from one stream-cut to the next, counting under his breath, and where it showed he broke it and went on, and where it did not show he dug until it did. Mercer came behind with the book. Ragnall came behind Mercer with the pony, and the sacks.

On the eighth day, far out along the hills to the north, where the high ground looks down on the valley of Abhainn uaine, Stone stopped on a knoll in the even-

3. the silver-sheen coal, of river water

ing and looked back the way they had come, and then forward, and scratched his beard. He said a long thing to Mercer. Mercer wrote it down. Then Stone turned to Ragnall and said, slowly, in *Dia-thìris* that he had been practising, with his hand held out flat along the line of the hills:

"Black. Further than a man can walk in one day."

He seemed very pleased with it. He said it again in his own tongue, and Mercer wrote that too. Those are the words the letter-books of A' Chompanaidh keep, "further than can be walked in a day," and they are the only words of that walk the humans kept.

That night they camped under a peat-bank, and Stone and Mercer drank from a flask and talked late in their own tongue, fast and happy, and Ragnall lay in his cloak and listened to the rain and could not sleep. He was thinking of the old cutting above the mill, of the baskets his father filled in the season, eleven and not twelve; of the custodian with her lamp going along the rows; of the old words that are said at the rock face before a man puts his pick in, which every hewer's son learns before he learns to swing. He had not said them once on the hill. Nobody had asked him to.

They came down on 13 an Dùbhlachd, AE 10, with the pony so loaded that Ragnall carried a sack on his own back the last miles, and Stone and Mercer each carried one, and all three of them were black to the elbow. At the mill Stone paid him the coin. Ragnall took it and held it and looked at the man's head on it, and put it in his shirt.

The men of Muileann chrom stood at their doors to watch the sacks go by. Nobody said anything. The next morning the prospectors went down the road towards the capital and Ros dhomhain, with the pony and a hired cart, and the sacks in the cart.

V

Of the Half Carried West

The custodians of the vein wrote to A' Chompanaidh¹ before the year was out.

They wrote in *Dia-thìris*, for they had nothing else to write in, and the letter went down to Ros dhomhain with a carter who had orders to give it into

the hand of Thomas Pike and nobody else's. It asked that the coal broken on the hill above Muileann chrom without leave be brought back, all of it, to be laid in the rock again with the proper words, as the custodians had always done with coal taken out of season. There was no threat in it. The custodians wrote as they had written to their own people for a thousand years, as if there could be no question of the answer.

The answer was a long time coming. Ragnall heard of the letter at the mill, and of the carter's going and coming, and of a second letter in the spring, and a third. Men looked at him in the mill yard and said nothing. His father spoke to him about the work of the day and about the weather, and not about the hill. Ragnall kept the coin in a crack of the byre wall and took it out sometimes and looked at it.

At the summer's end in the eleventh year a cart came up the road from the capital with a human driver and six sacks in it, coarse sacks with letters on them, and stopped at the mill. The driver gave the miller a paper. The miller could not read it and sent for Ragnall, as the one man in Muileann chrom known to have talked with the strangers, and Ragnall could not read it either. He counted the sacks. Stone had filled thirteen.

"Where are the others?" he said to the driver, in the few words of the humans' tongue he had got on the hill, and made the number with his fingers.

The driver shrugged and pointed down the road the way he had come, west, towards Ros dhomhain and the lake and the ships, and said a word Ragnall knew, and turned his cart round.

The custodians came to the old cutting three days later, on 17 an t-Sultain, AE 11. There were four of them from Taigh na Fèithe² and Seonag Liath, and they had sent word through the hill, so that most of the households came up behind them, the hewers first. Ragnall's father was among the hewers. Ragnall was not asked to come and went anyway, and stood at the back, and when the custodians looked round for strong backs to carry the sacks up the last steep path to the rock face, it was Seonag Liath who looked at him and lifted her chin, and he went forward and took up the first sack.

He carried all six. Nobody helped him, and he did not ask. At the face, where the old cutting goes into the hill under an overhang of grey rock, black-mouthed and dry and smelling of the inside of the earth, the custodians had the sacks

1. the Company

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

opened and the coal laid out on a cloth in the lamp-light, piece by piece; and they sorted it, as a custodian sorts, by colour and by the gully it had come from, as near as they could tell. Then the hewers took it up in their hands and carried it into the cutting and laid it back into the rock, into clefts and old workings, packing it with clay; and the custodians said the words over each handful, the old words that are said when a thing taken out of season is given back, the same words, over and over, until the words and the dark and the lamp and the slow hands made one thing.

Ragnall stood outside with the empty sacks. He could hear his father's voice in the cutting saying the words with the rest, low, and the tap of clay being pressed in.

When it was done the custodians' clerk sat down on a stone at the cutting mouth with the roll on his knees and asked how much had been taken from the hill and how much given back.

"Thirteen sacks," said Ragnall. "Six."

"And the rest?"

Ragnall thought of the driver and his pointing hand. "West," he said.

The clerk wrote it. The roll of Taigh na Fèithe enters the other half of the coal as "carried west," and it is still so entered in the copy that lies in the cellar at Muileann chaol, the first coal of the vein in all the records that went out of the hill and was not accounted for. Seonag Liath, who read over the clerk's shoulder, put her finger on the line and looked at Ragnall a long while, and said nothing, and went down the hill.

VI

Of the Contract and the First Ton

Two days after the laying-back, on 19 an t-Sultain, AE 11, A' Chompanaidh¹ brought its first contracts into the hills.

Abel Stone brought them. He came up the road to Muileann chrom on a good horse this time, with a clerk behind him and two carts of goods: iron. There were picks with steel points, shovels, wedges, hammers, bar-iron in bundles tied with cord, and on the second cart casks of lamp-oil, more oil than the whole

1. the Company

district burned in a year. He had the carts drawn up in the mill yard and the covers taken off, and he stood beside them with his thumbs in his belt while the hill came to look.

The contract was read in the mill in the humans' tongue by the clerk and in Dia-thiris by a young man of Ros dhomhain whom A' Chompanaidh paid to put its words into the island's. Ragnall stood at the wall. It was short, as such things went. A crew of the hill was to cut coal from the seam at a place A' Chompanaidh would name, on the hillside below the old cutting and well away from it; and for every ton the crew brought to the pit-mouth, weighed on the strangers' beam, the crew would be paid in iron tools and lamp-oil, at so much the ton, the rate written in figures on the paper. The ton was a thing of the humans' reckoning. The young man of Ros dhomhain tried three ways to say it in Dia-thiris and settled for "a great load, weighed".

Some of the older men walked out before the reading was done. Some stayed. The hill had lamp-oil to think of, and iron, and the good years of trading behind it, in which nobody had yet been cheated at the humans' counter. A bargain was a bargain. And A' Chompanaidh was careful that year: the place it named was on no custodian's lot, and the paper said nothing about the old cutting at all.

When the reading was done Stone looked round the room and found Ragnall at the wall, and grinned at him, and pointed.

"This one," he said, in his practised Dia-thiris. "He walked the hill. He knows the black. Let him lead the crew."

So Ragnall mac Dhòmhnaill was made the leader of the first crew of the hill. It was thirty men, the number the contract asked for: young men mostly, sons of hewers and sons of shepherds and two from the mill, and three older hewers of the old cutting who had sons to feed and said so. His father was not among them. Dòmhnall heard the reading from outside the mill door and went home before it was over, and when Ragnall came in that night with the paper folded in his shirt beside the coin, his father was sitting at the fire with his hands on his knees and did not look up.

"They will pay us in iron," said Ragnall. "Picks with steel points. You have seen them. And oil, enough to light every house on the hill through the winter."

"I have seen them," said his father.

"The place is on no lot. It is below the old cutting. They have not asked for the cutting."

"No," said Dòmhnall. "Not this year." And then, after a while, to the fire: "Who will say the words at the face?"

Raghnall found that he had no answer, and his father did not ask again.

They opened the working on 16 an Dàmhair, AE 11. It was on the south face of the hill, a mile below the old cutting, in a gully where Stone had broken the seam the winter before; and the crew cut back the turf and the shale above it with the new shovels from the carts and went in along the black with the new picks. The steel points went through the coal like a spade through turf. Men who had swung the old picks of the hill all their lives stopped and looked at the new ones in their hands and laughed out loud. By midday there was a heap at the pit-mouth taller than a man.

Stone had the beam set up that afternoon at the pit-mouth: a great iron bar hung from a tripod of timbers, with a hook at one end and a weight that slid along the other, and a board of marks. He showed Raghnall how it worked. The coal went into a sling of chain and hung from the hook, and the weight was run along the bar until the bar hung level, and the clerk read the mark and wrote the figure in a book. The crew stood round in the drizzle and watched. It was the first weighing of coal most of them had ever seen, and they did not know yet what they were watching.

At dusk the clerk added his figures and said something to Stone, and Stone turned round to the crew and held up one finger, and shouted.

"One ton!"

The crew cheered, because he was so pleased, and because they had cut it. Raghnall cheered with them. He stood at the pit-mouth with the black to his elbows and the new pick in his hand, in the rain, and watched the clerk write the figure down in the book of A' Chompanaidh, one ton, the first ton weighed in the hills of Muileann chrom, and he was proud of it. His crew was the best on the hill, the first and the best, and he had led them, and it was all written down.

He walked home in the dark. Up the hill above him the old cutting was black against the sky. There was no lamp in it. The season of the handful was over, and his father's eleven baskets had gone to the store a month since, measured, and the custodians would not light the cutting again until the spring.

VII

Of What the Hill Had Never Been Weighed By

Here the copyists who set down the age from its four witnesses leave Raghnall at his pit-mouth, and look back.

In all the years of the vein before the strangers came, from the first keeping to the last, the coal of the hill had been measured and it had been counted; but it had never once been weighed. It was measured by the handful, a hewer's two hands cupped together, which is the measure of the law, and by the basket, which is so many handfuls, and by the season, which is so many baskets. It was counted by the hearth. The custodians knew how many hearths the island had, and how many handfuls each might burn, and they cut that much and no more, and what was cut out of season was given back. The roll of every cutting is kept that way. It speaks of hands and hearths and seasons, and of colours, which it names each time, and of the words said at the face; and in all its leaves there is no ton, and no beam, and no figure written by a clerk who was not a custodian.

After AE II a second book was kept beside it, at the pit-mouth of A' Chompanaidh¹ below Muileann chrom. It opened with a single figure in the humans' letters, under a date in the humans' reckoning, and against the figure the name of a crew-leader written as the humans heard it. The custodians' book went on counting handfuls in their season; the other counted tons.

So ended Bliadhnachan na Malairt Cothromaich², that began with a cask of water on the shingle at Cuan shean. Nobody on the island marked the day. The crew at Muileann chrom were paid on the first market-day after in picks and lamp-oil, at the rate on the paper, to the last ounce of oil; and the book of A' Chompanaidh balanced to the line.

1. the Company

2. the years of fair exchange after the Crossing

PART TWO

OF the Bill Sold by the TON

CHAPTER EIGHT

OF THE DOOR AT DOIRE mhòr

AE 12 – 16

I

Of the Shortest Roll

Of all the rolls of the hill villages that came down to the cellar at Muileann chaol, the roll of Doire mhòr for these years is the shortest, and the copyists have handled it more than any other. It is nine leaves stitched with linen thread, in a square black hand that presses so hard on the pen that the letters stand up from the back of the page like the marks of a nail. The hand is Beathag Dhubh's. She was custodian of Doire mhòr through the years of the first contracts, and she wrote the roll as she said everything, with as few words as would carry the thing and none to spare.

Beside it stands the second witness. In the letter-books of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach¹, among the reports sent down from the hills to Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir² in the fourteenth year of the strangers, there is a sheet in the humans' tongue from an agent of A' Chompanaidh³, who climbed to Doire mhòr with a contract under his coat and came down again without it. It is the only place where her answer to him is set down. The telling that follows is made from the nine leaves and the one sheet, and from what the carters of the hill remembered.

Doire mhòr stood on the shoulder of the hills north of Muileann chrom, a morning's walk above the mill and the bend of the river. Its name was the great oak grove, and in those years the grove still stood: old oaks on the slope behind the houses, broad and low and crooked from the wind, with a stream coming

1. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

2. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

3. the Company

down between them out of the heather and running past the doors to the fields. There were seven households, stone-built and turf-roofed, with their byres at their backs. They grew oats and barley in small walled fields along the stream, and in the season of the handful their young men went down to carry at the old cutting above Muileann chrom. The custodian's house stood highest of the seven. Its door faced down the hill, and from the step on a clear day you could see the smoke of the mill, and past it the green line of the Abhainn uaine going away between the hills towards the sea.

Beathag was some thirty-two years old in the year the quay was built below her. She had black hair, which gave her the byname, and black brows that met, and a way of standing with her arms folded while other people talked that made the talkers talk faster. She had been custodian since her mother's death, and she kept the roll and the count of the village's hearths, and went to the council at Cathair dhearg when it called the custodians of the hills. Children she had none, and said when asked that she had seven households, which was enough.

II

Of Nails by Weight

In the summer of the twelfth year she walked down to Ceann fhada to buy salmon, and found A' Chompanaidh¹ building on the shore.

Ceann fhada was a hamlet of river-fishers and pilots on a long spit where the Abhainn uaine ran slow and deep below the hills, a short hour's walk under Doire mhòr. The foreshore of the spit, where they drew up their boats and dried their nets and split their fish, was held by the hamlet in common, as a thing no one household could buy or be sold. Beathag came out of the trees on a hot morning and saw the spit covered with men.

There were masons from over the lake at the capital, and human overseers in shirt-sleeves, and carts of cut stone drawn up on the turf where the nets had hung. A wall was going out into the river on a bed of rubble, square-ended, straight as a rule. At its root, where the fish-shed had stood, a clerk sat at a table under a sail-cloth awning with a book open before him and a steelyard hung from a tripod at his elbow, and before the table the men of Ceann fhada were standing in a line.

1. the Company

She stood at the back of the line and watched it for most of the morning. Each man came to the table in his turn, and a human with a measuring-chain paced out on the turf the strip of foreshore where that man's boat had always lain, and called the figure to the clerk. The clerk wrote it. Then a boy tipped nails out of a keg into the scoop of the steelyard, and the clerk ran the pea along the arm until it hung level, and the nails were poured into the man's cap or his shirt or his two hands, and he stepped aside. So many pounds of nails for so many paces of shore; and the next man came up.

An old pilot near the front had his nails poured into his hat and stood looking at them.

"What does a man do with these," he said, "who has no house to build?"

Nobody answered him. The old man carried his hat down to the water's edge and sat on a stone with it on his knees. Beathag went and sat beside him.

"They are good nails," he said after a time. "I bit one." He turned one over in his fingers. "My father's boat lay on that shore. And his father's. Now there is a wall on it, and I am paid for it by the pound." He looked at her sidelong. "You are Beathag of the oaks. Tell me, custodian, whose shore was it, that they could buy it off me?"

"It was the hamlet's," said Beathag.

"Then why did they pay me?"

"Because you were standing in the line," she said, "and the hamlet was not."

That evening the men of Ceann fhada took their nails to the fish-shed that had been moved up the bank, and weighed them again, each man's share, on their own old beam that they weighed salmon on, to see whether the strangers had cheated them. The strangers had not. Every man had his weight to the ounce. The copyists found it in the roll of Ceann fhada, in a pilot's hand: that the weight was true, and that the men were ashamed of having doubted it, and ashamed besides, though of what the roll does not say.

The quay was finished on 23 an t-Iuchar, AE 12. Beathag was not there. But in the autumn she went down to the edge of the oaks on her own hill and watched the first carts of coal from the new pit at Muileann chrom come jolting along the river track and down onto the spit, and tip their loads into the first flat barge moored against the new wall. The barge went away downstream with two pilots of Ceann fhada at the sweeps, since nobody else knew the river.

The coal in the carts was all colours. She could see it from where she stood, even at that distance, the way anyone of the island could see it: the black that is

green at the edge, and the black that holds a blue in it like the back of a mussel, and the rust and the plum and the grey that go purple in rain. The two carters walking at the horses' heads were humans, and they looked at the road.

III

Of Three Words in a Grammar

Samuel Wren finished his grammar of the island's tongue at Ros dhomhain in AE 12, in the last weeks of summer, and sent a fair copy to the council at Cathair dhearg with his compliments. He had been at it ten years, since the season of words at the capital. The council gave it to Gormshuil nic Fhearchair to read, because she had learned the humans' letters for that purpose, and she took it home and read it through, and at Samhain, when the custodians of the hills came down to the council for the winter sitting, she brought it into the hall under her arm.

Beathag had not met her before. She found a woman past fifty with a long grey face and ink on her thumb, who sat by the fire in the side room with the book on her knee and a candle at her shoulder, reading out whatever anyone asked for, and putting it into Dia-thìris as she went.

"It is a good book," Gormshuil said. "He has the verbs right. He has most of the words for the weather. He has all the words for the sea, because he came over it and was frightened of it." She turned a leaf. "He has one word for the coal, which is his own, and he has put it where ours should be. And he has this." She put her finger on a line. "This is what he calls us. You and me and every custodian of every cutting on the island."

"Read it," said Beathag.

Gormshuil read it out in the humans' tongue, slowly, three words, and then put it into Dia-thìris. It came out as *the keepers of the coal*.

"That is near enough," said a custodian from the east, and one or two others nodded.

"It is near," said Gormshuil. "Ask what a keeper is, in his tongue." She shut the book on her finger. "I asked him. I sat in his room at the mission-house with this on the table and asked him, what is a keeper, and he told me, a man who keeps a thing. So I asked him what kinds of keepers there are over the sea. A keeper of sheep. A keeper of a gate. A keeper of a shop, which is a man who has goods on

his shelves until somebody pays him for them. An innkeeper. A storekeeper. He was pleased to be asked. He gave me eleven." She looked round at them. "In his tongue a keeper of the coal is a man who has the coal."

Nobody spoke. The fire settled.

"Then when they read this over the sea," said Beathag, "they will think the coal is ours to sell."

"Or they will think we are standing in the way of it," said Gormshuil, "which is what a storekeeper does, until he is paid."

Beathag went home to the hills in the snow before the sitting was over, and the copyists find the thing in her roll that winter in two lines. The first says that the strangers' book of words calls the custodians keepers. The second says: *We do not keep it. We keep it back.*

The grammar went out over the sea on the next ship, and copies of it were made at the mission-house for the strangers' own use on the island. In the summer of the thirteenth year, on 4 an t-Iuchar, AE 13, a hawk-priest came down to Ros dhomhain from Cnoc bheag, a thin man in a brown cloak with a feather in his hair, and asked at the door of Teachdaireachd na h-Eaglaise¹ for a copy for the priests of his shrine, so that they might read what the strangers wrote of them. The mission-house gave him one, and was pleased to. He carried it home a day's walk on his back in a satchel of oiled hide.

That copy came down to the cellar among the hawk-priests' papers, and it has more notes in its margins than any other copy the copyists have seen. Where Wren writes of the gods the hawk-priests have written corrections, and where he writes of the hawk they have written a good deal. And beside the three words on the custodians, in a small hand of the old kind with a hawk's head drawn after it for a signature, somebody has written in Dia-thìris: *He writes as a man counts sacks.*

IV

Of the Bell before the Fleet

The council called the custodians of the hills again at the dark of the thirteenth year, for the contracts were beginning to come up from Muileann chrom into the villages round about, and the council wished to know what

1. the Mission; lit. 'the errand of the Church'

the hills made of them. Beathag walked down to Cathair dhearg in the frost, two days on the road with a pony and a bag of oatcake, and sat through four days of talk in the hall. The council heard that iron was good and lamp-oil was good and the young men liked the look of the picks, and made no ruling; and on the last evening of the sitting word came up from the lake shore that the strangers' chapel at Ros dhomhain was finished, and that they would hang their bell in it and ring it in the morning for the first time.

Some of the custodians went down to see it, Beathag among them. Ros dhomhain was two hours' walk below the capital along the shore of the lake, and they went in the dark before dawn, because the strangers' service was to be at first light, and stood with the fishers on the cold stones of the quay on 30 an Dùbhlachd, AE 13.

The chapel was of timber, on the quay itself, with its back to the water: a long plain hall of new planks, tarred black, with windows of the strangers' glass down each side and a little open tower at the landward end. In the tower, hung on an oak beam, was the bell. It hung against the grey of the sky like an upturned cauldron. It was the first bell of iron that had ever hung on the island.

The fleet of Ros dhomhain was going out. The lake-fishers were loading their boats along the quay in the way they had always loaded them, with lanterns shuttered and no word spoken. The rule of that quay was an old one. What is said on the stones before the boats are out is heard on the water, and the water keeps it; so the men went down to their boats without a word and cast off without a word, and a boy who laughed aloud on the quay in the dark was sent home. Beathag stood among the silent men and was careful not to cough.

Then the strangers rang their bell.

It was a great noise. It went out over the black lake and came back off the far shore, and rolled back again, and went on ringing, twenty strokes, thirty; and every man on the quay stopped where he was, with a net or an oar or a basket of line in his hands, and stood with his head down as though he had been struck. One boat had cast off already. Its men lay on their oars in the dark water and did not row. Then an old man on the quay put down the net he was holding and walked home, and then another, and one by one the crews unloaded their boats again, not hurrying, still without a word, and went up the quay and away into the town. Only three boats went out on the lake that morning out of more than twenty. The bell rang on over the empty quay until the service began.

The custodians went up to the chapel door when the strangers came out of it. The minister was a young man with a cold, and Samuel Wren was with him, thin and grey and coughing into a cloth. Wren put the custodians' words into the strangers' tongue.

The custodian of Ros dhomhain did the speaking. He told them the rule of the quay, and that on that quay a bell over the water before the boats were out was the bell for the drowned, and that the men had gone home because they would not go out on a lake that had been told to expect them. He asked that the bell should not be rung again before the fleet was out.

The young minister listened to Wren with his head on one side, and looked at the empty quay, and was troubled; and it is to his credit, and Wren's, that he agreed at once. After that morning the bell of the chapel was rung at Ros dhomhain only when the last boat was clear of the harbour mouth, and the chapel held its first service late.

Beathag walked back up to the capital with the others. The sun was up by then, and the three boats that had gone out were small on the lake behind them.

"He was a decent young man," said one of the custodians. "He did what we asked."

"He did," said Beathag. "And the morning is gone all the same."

V

Of the Paper at the Hearth

The contract came up to Doire mhòr at the end of the winter of the fourteenth year. A boy of Muileann chrom carried it up in oilcloth inside his shirt, and gave it to Beathag at her door. It was written in the humans' tongue, two pages of it, close, with a space at the foot for marks. Beathag could not read a word of it. The next morning she walked down to the mill at Muileann chrom with the paper and found the young man of Ros dhomhain who put A' Chompanaidh's words into the island's tongue, and made him read it to her twice in the mill-house, sitting on a sack.

It was the same paper the hill had heard read at the mill in the autumn of the eleventh year, save in the one thing that mattered to her. The place it named for

1. the Company

the working was the south slope of Doire mhòr's own hill, under the oaks, where the stream came down.

"They have found the black there," the young man said. "The prospectors found it in the stream-bank four winters back. There is more of it under your fields, they say, than under all the rest of the hill together."

"I know where the black is," said Beathag. "My grandmother knew."

She took the paper home and put it on the shelf by the door, and did not put a mark on it, and did not send it back. On 29 am Màrt, AE 14, the day A' Chompanaidh had set for the marks, the boy came up the hill again for the answer, and she gave him none and sent him away with an oatcake. That was the first refusal of the age. Other villages of the hills had put their marks to the contracts, and one or two had haggled first; but none had let the day go by with the space at the foot of the paper empty. The clerks at the pit-mouth entered it in their book as a delay.

That same evening she called the seven households to her hearth.

They came in out of the rain and sat round the fire on stools and on the floor, with the children at the back on the heaped fleeces. She had the paper read to them in her own words, since there was nobody on the hill who could read it in the strangers' own. Then she let them talk.

They talked a long while. Some of the young men wanted the iron: a spade that did not bend, an axe that held its edge through a winter's wood. One of them said that the pit at Muileann chrom paid better than oats. One of the women said that the strangers had been fair at every counter on the island for ten years, which was true. An old shepherd asked where they would put their sheep when the hill-side was a heap of shale, and nobody knew. Another asked what A' Chompanaidh would do if they said no, and nobody knew that either.

Last of all the oldest woman of the hill spoke from her stool by the door. She was near ninety and had carried baskets at the old cutting since before any of them were born, and she did not say much. She said:

"Chan ann leinn an cnoc."

The hill is not ours.

Then she said that the custodian should answer for the hill, since that was what a custodian was for, and she went home through the rain, and after a while the others followed her. The roll for the night has a single line: that the households were called, and that they gave the answer to the custodian to give.

VI

Of the Door

The agent of A' Chompanaidh¹ climbed to Doire mhòr himself on 27 an Giblean, AE 14.

It rained. It had rained on that hill for eleven days, and the agent came up through it from the mill on foot, because no horse would take the last of the path. He was a man of forty or so, well-fed, in a good dark coat that was mud to the knee by the oaks, with the contract buttoned inside it and a hand held flat over the place as he walked. The young man of Ros dhomhain came behind him with a satchel and a face that said he would rather be somewhere else.

By the time they reached the stream the doors were full of faces, and nobody came out.

Beathag was at the top of the village, at her own door, with the door open behind her and the fire lit inside. She had been told they were coming. Ruairidh of Doire mhòr stood behind her in the doorway, and said nothing.

The agent stopped at the foot of her step and took off his hat, and the rain ran off his hair. He was civil. The copyists allow him that; everything in his report is civil. He had a good deal of the island's tongue for a stranger, got at the counters and the pit-mouths, and what he did not have the young man of Ros dhomhain gave for him. He told her who he was, and whom he spoke for. He told her of the contract and the rate and the iron: picks and spades and bar-iron, lamp-oil by the cask, more than the hill had ever had. The young men at Muileann chrom, he said, had new boots. There would be a road up the hill, so that no one of Doire mhòr would ever have to carry a load on their back again. He told her the seam under her fields was the best A' Chompanaidh had found, and that it was a sin to leave it where it did nobody any good. He said it all in order, and then he said some of it again.

It is the custom of the island, and was in those years a custom older than any law, that a stranger who comes to a door in rain is asked in to the fire. Oighrig nic Leòid, who had no liking for the strangers, gave their captain water on the shingle at Cuan shean because he had come with an empty cask; the humans had lived on that custom for thirteen years. Beathag Dhubh let the agent stand on her step in the rain until he had said all he had come to say, and she did not ask him in.

1. the Company

When he had done she answered him. She spoke a few words, and then she shut the door.

What she said at the door, in her own tongue, the roll of Doire mhòr does not set down. It lives only in the agent's report, which he wrote that night at the pit-office by the mill, by the light of A' Chompanaidh's lamp-oil, in the strangers' tongue, and sent down to Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir² with the week's figures. The copyists give his words as they stand in the letter-books:

The woman who is custodian there heard me through at her door, in the rain, and did not ask me in. Her answer I set down as near as I have it: that the hill was not hers to sell, nor mine to buy. Then she shut the door. I judge that nothing is to be had of that place by persuasion at present, and recommend that the working be opened elsewhere.

He went back down the hill with the contract still dry inside his coat. The young man of Ros dhomhain went with him. At the stream, the carters used to say, he stopped and turned round and looked back up at the shut door for a long time, and then went on.

VII

Of the Road round the Fields

Doire mhòr was not punished. The hill talked of it all that summer: that the custodian of the oaks had shut her door on A' Chompanaidh¹, and nothing had come of it, and the boy of Muileann chrom did not come up again with any papers. Beathag, when she was asked why, said she did not know.

In the fifteenth year, on 28 an Gearran, AE 15, A' Chompanaidh opened its next working at Cnoc fhiadhaich, below Doire mhòr on the south, where a wild hill rose over the road to the river landing and nobody lived but a few households of hunters; and it began a cart-road to carry the coal of both its pits down to the quay at Ceann fhada.

The road came up from the south by the shortest way, and the shortest way lay over Doire mhòr's fields.

2. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

1. the Company

The surveyors came in am Màrt with a chain and a staff and a bundle of white-painted pegs, two humans and a boy, and walked straight up the hill from Cnoc fhiadhaich with the staff before them. They crossed the stream at the lower ford and went on across the barley ground, and every forty paces the boy knocked a peg into the earth. By evening there was a line of white pegs up the middle of the village's three best fields, from the stream to the edge of the oaks, and on over the shoulder of the hill towards the river.

Beathag walked the line of pegs the next morning with her arms folded. She did not pull them up. She sent to the custodian of Muileann chrom to say that the pegs were on the fields of Doire mhòr, which were not in any contract, and she waited.

Five days later the surveyors came back. They pulled up their white pegs one by one and put them back in the bundle, and they went down to the lower ford and started again; and this time the line went east along the foot of the fields, outside the field walls, round the whole of the village ground in a long bend, and joined the first line again on the far side of the oaks where the hill fell away towards the river. It was a mile longer that way. The carters complained of it from the first day to the last.

They built it that spring and summer with a crew of hill men paid in iron, bridging the stream with timber at the lower ford, and finished it at the end of the summer. The first carts came up it from Cnoc fhiadhaich in the autumn, heavy with coal, the horses leaning into the collar on the bend below the fields, and went on round the oaks and down to Ceann fhada and the barges.

Beathag let the carters water their horses at the stream where the road crossed it. They asked her leave the first time, in bad Dia-thiris, and she gave it, and they did not ask again, and she did not mind. In wet weather they ate their bread under the oaks before the last pull down to the river. The children of Doire mhòr went down to the road to watch the carts pass, and learned the strangers' words for horse and wheel and whip before they learned their letters.

In the autumn Beathag went down alone to the bend of the road below her fields and walked the length of it from one end to the other. The road was well made. It ran in a wide smooth curve round the foot of the field walls, never more than a stone's throw from them, and at every point along it she could see her own barley stubble over the wall, and beyond it the roofs of the seven houses, and above them the oaks. Nowhere did it go away from the village; the whole way round, it kept as close as it could go.

She stood at the far end, where the bend joined the straight road again, and looked back along it. It seemed to her a road made by people who had marked a thing and meant to come back for it. They had not gone another way. They had gone the same way, and left a space in the middle of it the shape of Doire mhòr, and made the space as small as they could.

VIII

Of the Light at Tobar dhearg

That same spring, far off on the southern cape, the first of the new beacons was lit; and since the keepers of the lights are the third witness of this age, the copyists give its beginning here, as the keepers tell it.

Torcall Clachair and James Fenn had walked the five headlands of the old driftwood fires, and the first of the towers went up at Tobar dhearg, the village of the red well on the southern cape, over the stump of the old fire-tower the village had kept since An Aois Naomh¹. A' Chompanaidh² paid for it, since its ships would use it most. Torcall built it. He was past fifty and stiff in the knees: a round tower of grey stone with a stair inside it going up in the thickness of the wall, and a room at the top with windows on the sea. Fenn set the lens: a great glass of the strangers' making, ground over the sea and carried up from Ros dhomhain on a cart packed in straw, which nobody in the village was allowed to touch.

It was lit on 9 an Cèitean, AE 15. The village stood on the headland in the dusk and watched the light come up in the room at the top of the tower and go out over the water in a long beam, and the old people said it was a poor small thing beside the driftwood fires of their youth; and then a fisherman came back from the open sea after dark and said he had seen it three leagues out, and nobody said anything more against it.

The keeper was Anna nic Dhòmhnaill of Tobar dhearg, a fisherman's widow of twenty-five or so, whose husband had been lost off the cape two winters before. The village chose her. It held the light as a trust, the way it had held the old fire, and it chose the keeper from among its own families as it always had; and it chose Anna because she lived nearest the headland and had sat up nights for a boat that

1. the Holy Age

2. the Company

did not come home, and knew how long a night was. The council confirmed her in the spring of the next year. After that the keepership stayed in the families of the village.

She climbed the tower twice a night, once at dusk to light the lamp and once in the black middle of the night to trim it, and she went up and down that stair every night that she lived. She could not write. So she kept her count on the wall of the stair, at the turn below the lamp-room: one stroke cut into the stone with the point of a knife for every night the light was lit, and a stroke across every thirty, like a gate across a field. The copyists have not seen that wall. The keepers who came after her say that the strokes low down are cut deep and straight and the highest are shallow and crooked, and that there is not one night missing.

It was the keepers of Tobar dhearg who first said that a keeper has nothing to gain from a ship that is not there. They meant that the count is true. The light at Tobar dhearg was paid for by A' Chompanaidh so that its coal ships should come round the southern cape by night; but the tally on the stair counts nights, and not ships.

IX

Of the Brig and the Bend

The word of the southern light came up to the hills with the carters in the summer, and they were pleased with it, since it meant that the barges could go out of the river mouth and round the cape without waiting for daylight. Beathag heard them say so at the stream, and understood what the light was for, and said nothing.

In the sixteenth year, on 10 an Giblean, AE 16, a brig of A' Chompanaidh¹ coming down from the north with a cargo of iron tools for the pits was boarded off the north-west coast, in the empty waters beyond the capes, and stripped of everything in her hold. Her crew were put in their own boat and came ashore at Cuan shean, cold and whole. The raiders were never known. Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir² wrote to the council that the custodians of the coast should have preven-

1. the Company

2. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

ted it. The custodians of the coast wrote back that those waters had always kept their own law, and that the island had never asked the sea for leave.

The answer of the coast came up to the hills in the spring, copied by the council for every district and read out at the mill at Muileann chrom by the custodian of the district, and the hill men laughed at it for a week. Beathag heard it read. She did not laugh; but the copyists find that she went home and wrote it into the roll of Doire mhòr word for word, which is more room than she gave to anything else that year.

Then she went down to the bend.

It was a clear spring evening, the first dry one after a wet month, and the carts had stopped for the day, and the road lay empty round the foot of her fields in its long smooth curve, with the ruts of the winter filled with light. The barley was up green behind the walls. The stream ran loud at the ford. Up the hill the smoke of the seven houses went straight up into the still air, and the oaks stood black above it. Down the valley the smoke of two pits went up now instead of one.

She stood at the bend a long time. She had shut her door on A' Chompanaidh and A' Chompanaidh had gone round her; and in two years it had not come back. The hill thought that a custodian's word at a door still counted against paper, as it had counted against everything else since An Aois Naomh³. Beathag stood on the new road and looked along the bend of it, and knew better.

She went up to her house in the dusk and took down the roll, and under the sixteenth year, after the brig and the answer of the coast, wrote the road into it: the road round the fields, made in the fifteenth year, a mile the longer for Doire mhòr, well built. Then she wrote two words more, pressing hard enough on the pen that they stand up from the back of the leaf, and they are the last words she wrote that year.

For now.

3. the Holy Age

CHAPTER NINE

OF the MARK and Its hundred Pence

AE 17 – 20

I

Of Carragh Cnoc bheag

Samuel Wren went up to Cnoc bheag at the end of the dark of the year, in the seventeenth winter since the ships came, with a pony, a boy from the clergy-house to lead it, and a satchel of white paper wrapped in oilcloth against the rain. He was near fifty then. The damp of the island had never agreed with him. He coughed on the lake road out of Ros dhomhain and on the long rise north through the sheep-country, and at night in the houses where they lodged he sat up against the wall to cough, so as not to wake the household, and woke it anyway.

He had been asked. Some years before, the hawk-priests of Cnoc bheag had written to Teachdaireachd na h-Eaglaise¹ for a copy of his grammar, to read what the humans wrote of them, and had been sent one. Now they wrote that there was a stone near their town with writing on it older than any hand on the island, and that a man who wished to know the island's tongue from its roots should see the oldest thing in it.

The priest who met him on the road was a lean man with a hawk's feather pinned in his cloak and a voice much bigger than his chest; Wren's day-book calls him only the priest of the feather. He talked the whole of the last miles in the clipped Dia-thiris of the north, and Wren caught one word in three and nodded at the rest.

1. the Mission; lit. 'the errand of the Church'

At the priest's house that night, after they had eaten, the priest brought out Wren's own grammar.

Wren knew the binding, but not what had become of the pages. Every margin was written in, in two hands and three inks, in the stag-letters of the island, running up the edges and between the lines; there were small crosses beside some words and a drawn hawk beside others; and on the leaf where Wren had put the name of the vein's custodians into his own tongue as *keepers of the coal*, someone had written the island's word in the margin three times over and scored a line beneath it.

"You have it wrong there," the priest said, with great good humour. "A keeper keeps a thing in a box. The custodians have the care of it. As a man has the care of a sick child, or a ewe at lambing." He tapped the page. "We wrote it in so that the next one who reads your book will know."

Wren asked whether he might copy the notes.

"Copy all of them," said the priest. "That is what they are for."

He sat up by the priest's fire until the candle was a stub, copying, and coughing.

The stone stood some four miles off, south and west of the town, on a green shoulder of ground above a burn. The town had fenced it long ago with a ring of oak stakes against the cattle, and each generation renewed the stakes as they rotted, so that the fence was always new and the stone always old. It was a little taller than a man, grey, narrowing to the top, and it leaned as if it had been listening to something in the west for a long time. The rain came across the shoulder from the sea, fine and cold, and Wren stood inside the stakes with his paper pinned to a board under his cloak and looked up.

On the upper face ran a single line of marks. They were cut deep and cleanly, with the edges still sharp after all the weather, and they were like no letters Wren knew in any tongue of his own world or any tongue he had learned on the island. Lower down, cut with a narrower tool, shallower and less sure, were four words he could read.

"*Bha teine sa chloich*," he said aloud.

"There was fire in the stone," said the priest. "That is the easy part."

The custodian of Cnoc bheag had come out with them, an old woman on a stick who had said nothing all the way from the town. Now she laid her hand on the top of a stake and told him what the custodians of that town had told every asker since the stag-letters were made. The stone was older than the Dia-thìrich.

The scholars of the old schools had carried their own letters to it when those letters were new, and found that they matched nothing. Somebody of the island had cut the four words below, later, knowing no more than they did. None living could read the rest.

"Then who can?" Wren asked her.

"Nobody here," said the custodian. "Perhaps nobody anywhere. You may try."

He tried. He copied the line mark by mark, three times over, with his back to the wind and the boy holding the ink-horn in both hands to keep the rain out of it; he measured each mark with a rule and wrote the measures under it; and he copied the four words also, and the lean of the stone, and the stakes. It took him the whole of that day, which was 5 an Gearran, AE 17. When he came away his fingers would not close on the pony's rein.

He sent the best of the three copies over the sea on the first ship of the spring, north-about, to the scholars of an Tír Thall² who kept such things, asking what the line was and who had cut it. Through that summer and the next he asked the master of every ship that came in whether there was a packet for him. No answer came. The custodian of Cnoc bheag, when she was told, is said to have laughed.

II

Of the Ship on the Coin

While Wren was in the north the coin came in.

On 13 an Gearran, AE 17, Wren's clerk, making up the quarter's accounts, found that the stores of A' Chompanaidh¹ at Ros dhomhain would take his notes of hand no longer, but only coin: the humans' own, shipped from over the sea in small iron-bound kegs and brought in beside the old barter of the island, as the proclamation of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach² put it, for ease. Nobody on the island had asked for it. The post went on taking wool and fish that year as before. The iron began to cost coin, and the fish went on costing fish.

That summer Riaghaltas nan Coigreach set up a striking-house on the quay at Ros dhomhain below Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir³, a long stone shed with a press

2. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

1. the Company

2. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

3. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

brought over in pieces and bolted to a floor of new oak, and silver and copper came over the sea for it in bars. On 10 an Lùnastal, AE 17, the first coins of the island's own striking came out of the press into a wooden tray: the mark and its hundred pence.

Wren was there, because Josiah Pell had asked the clergy to send somebody to bless the press, and they had sent the man who spoke the island's tongue best, in case any of the island came to watch. A dozen fishers stood in the shed door with their caps in their hands, and a knot of children who had been told to go home and had not. Wren said a short prayer over the press in his own tongue and then said it again in theirs. The press came down. The workman lifted the first mark out of the die with a pair of tongs and dropped it in the tray, and it rang.

Pell turned it to the light from the door and showed it round. On one face was a ship under full sail, very finely cut, with every rope drawn. On the other were letters in the humans' tongue that gave the coin's worth and the year of the humans' own reckoning. There was nothing of Dia-thìr on either face. No hill, no hawk, no word.

Wren said so, afterward, in Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir, over a glass of the strangers' wine. He said that it might be well to have some mark of the island on the island's coin, since it was to pass from hand to hand among the island's people, and they would look at it.

Pell said the dies had been cut over the sea. He said it pleasantly, and poured Wren more wine, and asked him about the stone at Cnoc bheag.

Wren kept one of the first marks. At the end of that month he walked up the hill to Cathair dhearg with it in his coat, to the long room on the east side of the council hall where Gormshuil still kept her papers, and where he had sat across a table from her fifteen years before and pointed at cups and bread; and he put it on the same table, in the same window-light, ship-side up.

Gormshuil picked it up. She was grey by then, and wore spectacles of the strangers' glass, which she did not like and could not do without. She held the coin close to them a long while, both faces, and weighed it in her palm.

"Which ship is it?" she asked.

Wren said it was no ship; it was a ship. A figure for all ships.

"No," said Gormshuil. "It is the ship that came." She put the coin down between them. "Where is the island on it?"

He had no answer to give her, and gave none.

Muireall was at the far end of the table, copying. She was a woman near thirty by then. She took the mark from her aunt without asking and laid a sheet of thin paper over it and rubbed it with a soft lead until the ship came up grey on the white, every rope of it, and then did the letters. Under the rubbing she wrote the island's year and moon, and the humans' day in the humans' figures. Under that she wrote: *the island is on neither face*.

The rubbing went east that autumn with the season's copies, in the chest for the loft at Muileann chaol. Gormshuil gave the coin itself back to Wren. She said she had no use for it yet.

III

Of the Two Books

From the first day of the next year the market of Cathair mhòr, the greatest market below the hills east of the capital, would not take the mark at all.

The custodians of that town met in their hall on 1 am Faoilleach, AE 18 and gave their ruling in a sentence: what was sold in Cathair mhòr would be sold as it always had been, thing for thing, by the old measures, and a man who wanted iron could bring wool. The tool-sellers of A' Chompanaidh¹ were told it at the bridge-foot and took it back to Ros dhomhain, and Pell wrote to Tormod mac Ailein, and Tormod put the letter in the chest under the east window of the council hall.

At the capital there was no ruling. There it happened stall by stall.

Wren saw it that first winter after the striking, on a market-day at the end of am Faoilleach, when he went down to buy stockings. The market lay below the hill along the lake road, and the lake wind set the awnings cracking. At the bridge end stood the tool-sellers of A' Chompanaidh with their carts, and their prices were chalked on boards in the humans' figures, in marks only. At the other end the cloth-women and the fish-wives sat as they had always sat, and a fleece was worth so many ells and a creel of herring so many loaves, and a stranger with a purse of new pence had to find an islander to change them, at a loss, before he could buy anything.

1. the Company

Between the two ends, under the arch of the old gate, sat the custodians' market-clerk with two books open in front of him.

He was a sharp-nosed man called Tadhg. In the left-hand book he entered the market's dues by the old reckoning, so many fleeces and so many creels; in the right-hand book, ruled in the humans' manner, he entered the tool-sellers' dues in marks and pence. They would not pay in fleeces. The cloth-women would not pay in pence. At the end of each month he must make the two books into one figure for the council, and there was no figure that would do it.

He showed Wren the foot of the left-hand page. Under the last tally he had written, in the stag-letters: *This book cannot be added to the other.* Then he turned to the foot of the right-hand page and showed him the same sentence, written again, laboriously, in the humans' letters and the humans' tongue, with one word misspelled.

"So that both sides will know," said Tadhg.

Wren bought his stockings at the far end for a fleece's worth of goods he had brought in a bag for the purpose, having learned. On the bridge one of the tool-sellers called out to ask whether it was true that the strangers' priest had gone to Cnoc bheag to read a stone, and Wren said that it was true he had gone, and not true that he had read it.

IV

Of the Winter at Dùn thais

That summer a letter came from Dùn thais, in a beautiful hand in the stag-letters, so courteous that it took Wren and his clerk a week to be sure what it asked. The masters of Feallsanachd an Fhèidh¹, the school of the deer, had read the grammar also, and heard of the stone. They would receive the man who made the grammar for the dark of the year, when the school sat, if he would come and dispute with them; and they would give him a bed near the fire, since they had heard he coughed.

He went east with the carriers at the end of an t-Samhain, with a trunk of books on the cart, over the capital road through Cathair mhòr and on into the hills, where the road narrowed and the carriers walked at the horses' heads and

1. the Philosophy of the Deer, the druid schools' own name

sang to keep the pace. They were five days on the sixty miles, in the rain. He came down into Dùn thais on the last afternoon with the light going: grey houses at the head of a long valley, smoke lying flat over the roofs, and a dark wood on the hill behind.

The disputation began on 3 an Dùbhlachd, AE 18, in the hall of the school: a long, low room with a hearth at each end and rushes on an earth floor, where some twenty masters sat on benches down both walls in undyed wool and the students sat on the floor between. The eldest of them was a woman so old that she had to be helped to her bench, and so sharp that the others looked at her before they answered anything.

Wren put his question on the first evening, standing, in his best Dia-thìris, with the fire loud behind him.

He asked why the vein should be holy.

He meant it honestly. In seventeen years on the island he had seen the custodians go up to the cuttings in their season with their baskets and their words, and seen the handful set down at the shrine and burned there, measured, and the rest left in the hill. He had seen a people who were cold every winter keep a fuel under their feet and not burn it. He had written it into the grammar and never understood it. In his own country, he said, God had given men the earth to use, and the black stone in it with the rest, and a man who froze beside a coal-seam for want of leave would be thought a fool.

The old woman heard him through. Then she asked him, in her turn, why his fuel should be burned.

He began to answer, and found he did not know how to begin. In his own country nobody had ever asked it. The fuel was there; it burned; the house was warm. She asked him what the fuel had been before it was fuel, and he told her what the philosophers of his country said, that it was the wood of old forests pressed under the earth for ages. She nodded, as if she had expected it, and asked him whether he burned his grandmother's house because it was made of wood.

So it went all that winter. Each side put its question and the other put its question back. They sat in the long hall through the short days with the rain on the roof, and argued in two tongues, with a young master to interpret when Wren's Dia-thìris failed him, which was often when they came to the old words for the vein. The school's way was to hold a question up to the light like a piece of coal and look for the colours in it. Wren's way was to answer, and write the answer

down. By the turn of the year the students had taken sides, and argued on the floor after the masters had gone to bed.

Neither telling of that winter names a winner. The register of Feallsanachd an Fhèidh sets down the two questions, and under them a line the students took up among themselves: that it is a poor question that can be answered in one winter. Wren's letters call the masters the most learned company he had met on the island or off it, and the old woman a person he would not willingly face again across a table.

On a night near the year's end, when the talk was done, the masters told stories at the hearth, and the old woman told one of a voyage west. A holy man of the island's first days, she said, put out from the western shore in a boat of hides with a few companions to look for the isle where the blessed live; and they came to many islands, one of sheep and one of birds that sang the hours, and landed on a great fish's back and lit a fire on it, until it moved; and at last they came to the isle of the blessed, and were shown it, and sent home to tell of it.

Wren sat without moving while she told it, and afterwards asked her to tell it again, and wrote it down as she spoke.

In the last days of the year Wren wrote home to the house of his order over the sea, and sent it by the packet of Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir², so that the letter lies in the letter-books of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach³ still. It tells of the school and the questions, and then tells the story as the old woman had told it, and says that it was very like the telling in an Eaglais of the voyage of Naomh Breandan, a saint of his own country's coasts, who sailed west in a boat of hides to look for the land of promise and found the fish and the birds and the isle; told from the other shore, as though the people at the end of that voyage had watched the boat come in. Wren did not know what to make of it, he wrote, and should be glad of any light his superiors could give him.

That letter, too, had no answer the island ever heard of.

He went home at the end of the dark season, west over the hills, coughing, with a second trunk of copied pages and a gift from the school, a small deer carved of black bog-oak.

2. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

3. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

V

Of the Bridge and the Carriage

Cathair mhòr held out its whole year. All that year the tool-sellers came to the bridge-foot on market-days and went away with wool. When the year turned they came no further; they stopped their carts on the far bank of the river and would not cross the bridge, and a man of Cathair mhòr who wanted a spade or a pot had to walk out over the bridge to them with coin in his hand. By the second month of the new year the custodians of Cathair mhòr had given way, and entered it in their roll without comment, and the market took the mark like everyone else.

Gormshuil read that entry to the council. She was the only custodian of the council who could read both the island's letters and the humans' without help, and the chest under the east window, where the strangers' papers went, had come to be hers in all but name.

That spring the masons of A' Chompanaidh¹ came up to rebuild Drochaid Cathair dhearg².

The bridge had carried the capital's road over the Abhainn dhomhain on the same piers time out of mind, and the carts of the hill country crossed it every market-day with their wheels a hand's breadth from the parapets. A' Chompanaidh wanted it wide enough for coal-carts to pass two abreast, and wanted it in dressed stone. The work began on 28 an Gearran, AE 19. The masons took down the old parapets course by course and stacked the stones on the bank.

Gormshuil went down on the second morning with a single stone in mind. On the downstream parapet near the middle of the bridge was a block with a name cut in the old letters, much worn: the name of Queen Sileas, who had widened the bridge in her day for two carts to pass. The children of the capital were taught to find it with their fingers on the way to market. Gormshuil had found it so herself.

She found it already down, lying on its face in the mud of the bank. The master mason was a big, red-faced man from over the sea with a voice like a gravel-cart, and he came up the bank wiping his hands, and heard her in his own tongue, which surprised him, and asked her what she wanted with one old stone out of three hundred.

1. the Company

2. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

She told him whose name was on it.

He had the block turned over, and could not read it, and she read it for him. He said the new parapet would be squared true and this block would never sit square with the others. Gormshuil said it had sat square with the others for some hundreds of years. In the end he had it dressed on its back and sides and left the face as it was, and set it again in the downstream parapet near the middle of the new bridge, a little proud of the new stones and a little darker. The children found it again by midsummer.

The bridge was finished by the autumn. On 30 an t-Sultain, AE 19, Pell drove over it.

The wheelwrights of A' Chompanaidh had built him a carriage over the summer: a closed black box on springs, with a glass window in each door and a pair of greys shipped over the sea to draw it. It was the first carriage on the island. He drove in it from Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir³ along the lake road and over the new bridge and up the hill to the council, with a coachman on the box and a boy up behind, and the whole of the lake road came to its doors to see it go by.

Tormod mac Ailein was walking to the council that morning with Gormshuil beside him. He walked slowly by then, with a stick in each hand because of his knees, and they were halfway over the bridge when they heard the wheels behind them and stood in to the downstream parapet, by Sileas's stone, to let it by. The carriage drew up level with them and stopped, and Pell let down the glass.

He greeted them both courteously, in Dia-thìris, and offered Tormod a seat as far as the hall.

Tormod thanked him. Then he said, in the island's tongue, so that the coachman and the boy and the people on the bridge could hear it: "*Coisichidh sinne.*" We will walk.

Pell bowed, and put up the glass, and drove on. Tormod and Gormshuil walked up the hill after him, with Tormod's two sticks knocking on the new stones, and reached the hall long after the carriage had been put up in the yard. The roll of that day notes that An t-Àrd-mhaor⁴ came to the hall in a carriage, and that the custodians came on foot, as they had always come. The custodians said it aloud often after, to anyone who would listen.

3. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

4. the Commissioner; lit. 'the high steward'

VI

Of Puingean a' Chalaiddh

Puingean a' Chalaiddh, the articles of the harbour, came before the council at the end of that year.

They came as Cùmhnant Cathair dhearg¹ had come, in the humans' tongue alone, eight sheets with Pell's seal at the foot, to be signed with the council on 16 an t-Samhain, AE 19. This time the council had the sheets a month beforehand. On the first evening Gormshuil took them out of the chest and carried them home, and read them twice by her lamp, with her finger and her spectacles, and made a slip of every clause.

They were articles for the harbour of Ros dhomhain. They fixed where a ship might lie in the lake and what she must pay for lying there, and the dues on goods landed and taken off. A harbour-master of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach² was to be set over the quay, with the keeping of the anchorages. At every turn the dues fell in favour of A' Chompanaidh³, whose hulls lay at the best berths for a third of what any other boat paid; and every boat that anchored off Ros dhomhain paid something, the boats of the island's own lake towns among them, which had anchored there free since there had been boats.

Gormshuil went to Tormod's house with her slips. He heard them by the fire, as he had heard the charter ten years before, with a cup in his hand and his feet on a stool. When she had done he was silent a long time.

"We need the quay," he said at last. "We need what comes to it."

"So we do," said Gormshuil. "We have had the quay since before there were strangers. What we are asked to sign is that it is theirs."

"Does it say so?"

"The harbour-master is to be theirs. That comes to the same."

He asked her what she would do. She said that she would read the articles aloud in the hall, in both tongues, before anyone signed, so that every custodian would know what was on the sheets; and that she would not sign them herself. He let her be. He was tired.

On the day the hall was full. The rain came in off the lake as it had on the day of Cùmhnant Cathair dhearg, and Pell sat at the far side of the long table in his

1. the first written treaty, signed at Cathair dhearg; the Treaty in One Tongue

2. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

3. the Company

black coat with Wren at his elbow to carry words. When it came to the reading, Gormshuil stood up.

She read the articles through, every clause, first in the humans' tongue as it was written and then in Dia-thìris as close as she could bring it. It took most of the morning. Where she had no island word for a word of theirs she said so, and turned to Wren and asked whether she had the sense right; and Wren, who had not been asked for this, said each time that she had, and each time Pell looked at him. When she came to the clause on the anchorages, a custodian at the lower end of the table, Ailean Ruadh of Baile ghlais, whose town's boats had lain free off Ros dhomhain every season of his life, stood up and asked to hear it again. She read it again.

Then she sat down.

Tormod signed first. He wrote his name slowly, looking a long while at the place before he put the pen to it, and the custodians signed after him one by one down the table, with Pell watching each name go on.

When the sheet came to Gormshuil she did not take up the pen. She passed the sheet on to the next place. When it came to Ailean Ruadh he did the same.

Pell asked, through Wren, whether the custodian of the capital was unwell.

Gormshuil answered him herself, in his own tongue. She said that she was well. She said that she had read the articles, which none at that table but she had done, and that she would not put her name under what she had read. Ailean Ruadh said, in the island's tongue, that he would not put his name under anything that charged Baile ghlais to lie where Baile ghlais had always lain. Pell heard them out. He thanked them. Then he signed, for Riaghaltas nan Coigreach, below the names of those who had signed, and the articles stood.

The council's roll enters the signing, and the names under it, and says that two custodians refused: Gormshuil nic Fhearchair of Cathair dhearg, and Ailean Ruadh of Baile ghlais. It was the first time since the strangers came that any custodian had refused to sign a thing the strangers put before the council. Muireall, who copied that leaf for the loft, drew a line round the two names.

Walking home in the dark, Tormod said to Gormshuil that it had done no good.

"No," she said. "It is written, though."

VII

Of Grazing, and Chimneys

Puingean a' Chalaiddh took effect with the new year, and the harbour-master took up the keeping of the quay, and by the autumn after, on 5 an Dàmhair, AE 20, he was charging anchorage.

The fishermen of Baile ghlais paid it once. Then they talked it over on the shingle and sent word up the lake that they would not pay it again. They took their catch to their own small harbour under the town, a stone jetty and a slip with room for a dozen boats, and sold it there off the boats to anyone who would walk the seven miles out from the capital, and to anyone at all but A' Chompanaidh¹. Gormshuil walked out one bright morning at the end of an Dàmhair and found the jetty crowded with the capital's fish-wives and their creels, and the herring going from hand to hand for pence and for loaves both, and Ailean Ruadh at the top of the slip with his arms folded, very pleased. The letter-books complain that the salting-house of A' Chompanaidh had herring that season only from its own boats.

A month later the council granted Riaghaltas nan Coigreach² grazing.

There were human families on the island by then who had come over the sea to work for A' Chompanaidh and would not go down the pits; they had sheep and cattle of their own breeds and no land. The council gave them, on 3 an t-Samhain, AE 20, summer grazing on the empty uplands of the north-west about Muileann àrsaidh, where the fields had gone back to rush in the last age. The grant was for grazing. Gormshuil had the word read back three times, in both tongues, before anyone signed, and noted on her slip that the humans' word meant the eating of grass by beasts and nothing else. She signed that one.

Before the winter a short letter came down to the chest under the east window from the custodian of Muileann àrsaidh. The families on the grazing had built houses, the custodian wrote. They had built them of stone: good stone, quarried from the hill and squared, with chimneys and slate from somewhere, and walls a man could not kick down. The shielings of the island were built of turf and wattle, to stand a summer and be let fall. These would stand a hundred years. Did the council mean it so?

1. the Company

2. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

VIII

Of Tormod's Burying

Tormod had been ailing since the harvest, in the chest and then in the heart. When Gormshuil brought the letter from Muileann àrsaidh he was in his bed, propped on bolsters, with the fire made up and the girl who kept his house on a stool by the door. He asked her to read it to him.

She read it. When she came to the chimneys he began to laugh, and the laugh turned to coughing, and the girl brought him water.

"Grazing," he said, when he could.

"Grazing," said Gormshuil. "I had it read three times."

"I know you did." He lay back on the bolsters. "You had it right. It meant grazing when we signed it. It is only afterward that their words grow." He was silent a while. "Write to them that the council meant summer grazing, and shielings. Write it in both tongues. They will not pull the houses down."

"No."

"Write it all the same."

She wrote it that night, in both tongues, and sent it north in the morning. Tormod died on 15 an Dùbhlachd, AE 20, in the dark of the year, in the house below the temple, with the fire lit and the girl at the door and Gormshuil asleep in the chair by the bed. He was sixty-five years old. He had sat at the head of Comhairle a' Chùraim¹, in the crown's place, for longer than most of the council had been grown, and he had given the strangers leave to stay, and signed Cùmhnant Cathair dhearg² and the harbour articles, and there were those in the capital who had not forgiven him for it, and came to his wake anyway.

They waked him three nights in his own house, by the old custom, and on the second night the council chose Coinneach Glas of Ceann àrsaidh after him, a broad, slow-spoken man from twenty miles up the east road, who had never set eyes on a human before An t-Aiseag³ and had dealt with little else since, and the choice was made in an evening. The roll gives it as unanimous. It was.

They buried Tormod on the fourth day, in the ground behind the council hall, on a cold wet morning with the cloud down on the hill. Six custodians carried the bier out of his door and down through the town, with the council walk-

1. the Council of Custodians; lit. 'the council of the custody'

2. the first written treaty, signed at Cathair dhearg; the Treaty in One Tongue

3. the Crossing; lit. 'the ferrying'

ing after, Coinneach Glas at their head and Gormshuil among them in her grey cloak, and the bells of Cathair dhearg rang for him all the way, the old bronze of the hoes. At the grave they went round sunwise, each with a stone from the lake shore, and laid the stones on the turf one by one, and said the words.

Josiah Pell came. He left his carriage at the bridge-foot and walked up the hill in the rain behind the custodians, bareheaded, and stood at the edge of the ground through the whole of the burying, and went away at the end without speaking. At the back of all the crowd, by the gate, stood Samuel Wren in his black coat. He had walked up from Ros dhomhain in the rain, as he always walked, and he did not come nearer. Through the words and the stones he stood by the gate with a handkerchief to his mouth, and coughed, and tried not to, and coughed again; and when it was done and the crowd went down the hill he was still there, and Gormshuil, passing, stopped, and they went down together.

CHAPTER TEN

Of the Law That Went Out

AE 21 – 24

I

Of the Ship That Did Not Come Home

In the roll of Comhairle a' Chùrain¹ for the twenty-first year of this age there is a page the copyists of the cellar turned back to more than once. At its head the clerk has written its Diosal year and the moon, and under them two lines in his quick hand. The first says that the humans at Ros dhomhain were in mourning for their captain. The second says that the fee of the counters was held

1. the Council of Custodians; lit. 'the council of the custody'

over to the next sitting. Nothing on the page joins the two lines, and the clerk did not think they were joined. Of the second line the copyists could find no later entry anywhere. The next sitting did not take it up, nor the one after, and no council ever struck it out. So *Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig*² went out of the island on a line held over; and the one custodian who stood up to speak for it was a woman of the eastern hills who had come to the capital that summer on other business, and who happened to be at *Ros dhomhain* on the day the humans stopped waiting for their ship.

Fionnghal nic Artair was thirty-six years old that year, custodian of *Dùn dhearg*, and she had sat in the council eleven winters. She was a tall woman, long in the jaw, with the grey come early into her hair, and she rode her own horse to the capital and would not be driven. Her town stood three days' ride east of *Cath-air dhearg*, on a hill with a double bank round it and a stone wall inside the bank, where the old hall of the crown had stood before *Beathag Mhòr* carried it west to the bridge-foot in the long centuries. *Dùn dhearg* had kept its granaries and its graves and its pride, and an old habit of sending its accounts to the capital in no hand but its own. Fionnghal wrote her own letters, and wrote them long.

She had come west in an *t-Iuchar* because the council had called in its custodians to hear *Coinneach Glas*, who had been chosen high custodian at the turn of the year, after *Tormod mac Ailein* was buried. He was a broad, slow-spoken man of *Ceann àrsaidh*, twenty miles up the east road, and he had spent the twenty years since the Crossing dealing with the humans at one table or another, so that he spoke their tongue better than any man in the hall and read it slowly, with his finger under the line. He wanted the council to know the state of the dues. That took four days. On the fifth the sitting rose, and *Gormshuil nic Fhearchair* asked Fionnghal to walk down with her to *Ros dhomhain*, where she had business with *Samuel Wren* at the Mission. Fionnghal went, for she had never seen the humans' town close to.

Ros dhomhain lay a short walk below the capital on the lake shore, and in twenty years it had grown a second town beside the first, of sawn timber and dressed stone, with the Residency above it on the rise and the chapel down on the quay with its iron bell. That day the bell was being rung slowly, one stroke to every few steps of a walking man, and a flag that Fionnghal had seen at the mastheads of the humans' ships hung halfway down its pole over the warehouse

2. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

of A' Chompanaidh³. The humans stood about the quay in their dark coats and did no work. Gormshuil asked a carter what had happened. He told her that Harrow's ship was a month past her day, and that the Company's men had given her up that morning.

"He went north-about in an Cèitean," said Gormshuil. "I saw him go. He said he would be back before the hay."

Wren came out of the chapel to meet them. He was grey now and thinner than ever, and he coughed into a cloth before he could speak. He took them in out of the wind off the lake and sat them on a bench at the back while the humans' prayers were said, and Fionnghal watched Thomas Pike stand at the front with his hat in both hands and read names from a paper: Harrow's, and after it the names of the men who had sailed with him. She could not follow the words. She could hear that the first name was read in another voice from the rest.

Afterwards Wren told them, in his careful Dia-thiris, what the letter-book at the Residency would say of Harrow, for he had been asked to help write it. It would say that Edmund Harrow was the man who found Dia-thìr.

Fionnghal turned that over on the long climb back to the capital. At the top of the hill she stopped.

"Lachlann Odhar of Achadh àrsaidh found him," she said. "Off the north-west cape, in the cod season. And led him down the coast to water."

"That is in our roll," said Gormshuil. "It is not in theirs."

"Then theirs is wrong."

"Theirs is theirs," said Gormshuil. She had been twenty years at the humans' letters, and two winters before she had refused to set her name to Puingean a' Chalaith⁴ and had watched the Harbour Articles take force on the quay without it. She said nothing more on the road.

Within the month the Company was Pike's alone, and the humans' clerks wrote to the council to say so, in their own tongue, on good paper with a seal. Coinneach Glas read the letter to the sitting and it was entered in the roll. Nobody in the hall had ever spoken with Pike about anything that mattered except Gormshuil, who had watched him weigh wool at a counter in a net-loft when the humans on the island could be counted on two hands. She said he was a fair man by his own measures. Then the custodians rode home, and Fionnghal went east to her hill, and did not think about the ship again that year.

3. the Company

4. the Harbour Articles; lit. 'the points of the harbour'

II

Of the Empty Board at Dùn dhearg

The counters of Dùn dhearg kept their board in the old granary under the north wall, where grain had been stored for the crown in the long centuries and where nothing had been kept since but the board and the measure. The board was a plank of black oak the length of a man, hung on two pegs, with a row of holes bored for every household of the town and its farms. The measure was a cup of turned alder made in the shape of two hands held together, worn pale at the rim. Twice in the year, at Samhain and at Bealltainn, the households came up with their sacks for the coal of the shrine-cutting and had it measured out, one double handful to each hearth for the season, and the counter put a peg in the hole. So it had been done since An Aois Naomh¹, when the custom of the handful was made law. A household that burned twice its measure lost its coal for the season after. The roll of Dùn dhearg held three such sentences in six hundred years, and the town could still name all three families.

The counter was Pàdraig Cam, who had kept the board forty years, as his father had before him. He was paid out of the dues of the vein. A share of every cutting in the hills had gone to the council's chest at Cathair dhearg since An Aois Naomh, and out of it the council paid each town that kept a board, so that the counting should be no one's favour. When the contracts came in, the cuttings went to the Company by the ton, and the Company paid the council for them in marks. The marks came fewer than the old shares by the council's reckoning, and more by the Company's; and the council, which had its part of the new bridge to pay for and a hall roof that let in the rain, found at its autumn sitting that it could not meet every fee. The counters' fee was held over. That was the line the copyists turned back to.

Pàdraig Cam heard it at Samhain from Fionnghal's own mouth. She rode home with the news and went up to the granary to tell him, and found him at the board with his bag of pegs on his knee.

"I'll count this season for nothing," he said. "I have counted for less."

He counted it. Half the households of Dùn dhearg came up the hill with their sacks that Samhain, and those that came were the old. The young households had bought their coal that summer at the market of Cathair mhòr, a day's walk to the

1. the Holy Age

west, off the Company's carts, by the sack and for marks, as much as they could pay for. A sack off the carts never came up to the granary to be measured. The Law had been made when every coal on the island came out of the shrine-cuttings through the counters' hands, and it had nothing to say about a cart. Fionnghal walked through the town at dusk and saw it through the open doors: black coal on hearths where there had been peat, a heap of it in the corner of a kitchen, a child set to break the lumps with a hammer. The smell of it hung in the lanes. It was a warm smell, and the town liked it.

Her own steward, Tòmas Bàn, had bought four sacks for her house in an Lùnastal while she was away at the capital, because the young men who cut the peat for the town had gone down to the pits at Muileann chrom for the ton-wage and there was no one left to cut her bank. She found the sacks in the byre when she came home. She said nothing about them. That winter was a hard one, and she burned them.

On 2 an Dùbhlachd, AE 21, the council sent round to the towns a letter saying that its chest held nothing for the counters until the spring. The copyists have set that day against the end of the Law, for want of any other, and the keepers at the hill hearths tell the end of the Law as they would tell of a fire that went out for want of feeding. No council repealed it. It went on standing in Leabhar a' Chùrain² with the three sentences of Dùn dhearg written under it, and after that winter hardly anyone kept it.

At Doire mhin, in the valley below the hills two days' ride west of Dùn dhearg on the capital road, the custodians went on keeping the count through that winter as though the letter had not come. Theirs was the older half of the Law, the count of the hill: how much coal the cuttings of their valley might give in a year and never more. On 31 an Dùbhlachd, AE 21, the last night of the year, they entered the count in their roll, and wrote under it that no one had asked for it.

III

Of the Letter and the Road West

Fionnghal began to write in an Gearran, the week Pàdraig Cam died.

He died in his bed in the ordinary way, of his years and a winter cough, and his son did not take the board, having gone to the pits at Muileann

chrom two summers before and married there. The board hung in the granary with the pegs of the last Samhain in their holes, and nobody took them out, since nobody would be putting new ones in. Fionnghal went up to look at it after the burying. Then she went home and sent Tòmas Bàn to Cathair mhòr for paper.

She wrote all that spring. She wrote at the kitchen table with the bought coal burning in the grate behind her, because it was what there was, and it is told at Dùn dhearg that she would get up from the table and stand with her back to the fire and look at the wall, and then sit down and go on. Five drafts were written and four of them burned in that grate. The one that survives is dated 11 an t-Ògmhios, AE 22, in her own hand, by Diosal year and moon, and it runs to eleven pages.

It is the only defence of the Law that has come down. The copyists give the heart of it as she wrote it:

The Law was made for the people more than for the coal, for a people becomes whatever its burning makes it. A house that burns the handful keeps a peat bank and a man who knows how to cut it, and a hedge, and a child who knows which willow burns green and which dry, and it goes up the hill twice in the year and says its name to the counter. A house that burns by the sack keeps a purse. I have seen my town go warm this winter, and I have seen my counter die with his pegs in the board. The council need fine no household. Let it pay the counters, and write in the roll that the Law stands. Our grandmothers' grandmothers made the handful when there was no one watching them. If we let it go now, it will be said that we let it go because strangers were watching, and paying.

She sewed the pages into a cover of calfskin, wrapped it in oilcloth against the weather, and rode west in the middle of an t-Ògmhios with the packet inside her coat and Tòmas Bàn beside her on a hill pony. The road went down off the eastern hills through birch and bracken into the long valley, and the fields on either side were green with oats that would be late. At every ford she met coal-carts coming the other way, empty, going back up to the pits for another load. The carters walked at the horses' heads and did not look up.

On the second evening she came into Doire mhin. It was a village of a few long houses round a green, with its shrine-cutting a mile up the valley side, and its custodian was Anndra mac Eòin, a small bald man with a carpenter's hands, who had kept the count of the valley since his youth. He knew her name from the council.

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

When she told him what she carried, he went to his chest without a word and brought out his roll and opened it on the table under the lamp, at the last page of the year.

The count was there in its columns, cutting by cutting, and under it the line: that no one had asked for it.

"You are the first to ask to see it," said Anndra mac Eòin. He said it in Dia-thìris, in the plain speech of the valley, and then again as though to himself: "Cha do dh'iarr duine e."

"I am asking," said Fionnghal.

She read him her letter that night by his lamp, all eleven pages, while his wife banked the fire with peat from their own bank, for Doire mhin had not bought coal. When she was done he asked her to read the page about the board again, and she read it. In the morning he walked beside her horse to the end of the village and stood there until she was over the rise.

IV

Of the Filing

The council sat that summer in the old hall at Cathair dhearg under its leaking roof, with buckets set along the south wall to catch the drips when it rained, which it did on the day Fionnghal read. Twenty-odd custodians sat at the long table and on the benches behind it. Coinneach Glas sat at the head with his hands flat on the board in front of him, and the clerk at his elbow with the roll.

She read standing. It took most of an hour. The hall was close with wet wool and the rain loud on the slates, and some of the old men on the benches slept, and one snored, and was nudged, and slept again. Gormshuil nic Fhearchair sat near the door with her eyes shut, and Fionnghal knew that she was awake by the way she lifted her head at the sentence about the strangers watching. Coinneach Glas did not move once. When Fionnghal came to the end she folded the pages and stood waiting, and for a while no one in the hall said anything at all.

Then Coinneach Glas thanked her. He said that the council had heard the custodian of Dùn dhearg with respect, that her letter would be kept with the rolls, and that the matter of the counters' fee would come before the council when the state of the dues allowed. He said it kindly and he said it well, and the

clerk wrote it down. The line in the roll reads that a letter of the custodian of Dùn dhearg upon the Small-Burning Law was read and filed.

The next matter was a paper from the Residency, brought up by a young clerk of the humans who stood in the doorway dripping. Josiah Pell asked the council's leave to widen the road from the capital to Muileann chrom so that two coal-carts might pass on it. Coinneach Glas read the paper aloud in the humans' tongue and then in the island's. There was some talk about whose fields the road would take. The leave was granted before the candles were lit.

Fionnghal found Gormshuil afterwards on the old bridge, which was the Company's bridge now, of dressed stone, wide enough for the carts to pass two abreast. The rain had stopped. The river ran high and brown under them, and down the valley the lamps were coming out along the quays of Ros dhomhain.

"They filed it," said Fionnghal.

"They wrote my refusal in the roll too," said Gormshuil. "It is there, a line under the Articles. The Articles are on the quay." She was sixty-two that summer, and she had begun to lean on the parapet when she stood. "You did the right thing. You put it in the roll. Someone copies the roll."

"Who reads the copy?"

"Nobody yet." Gormshuil looked at her sideways. "Give me a fair copy for Muireall. She sends such things to the loft of Beathag nic Thòmais at Muileann chaol, where they are kept dry. The loft is a small place, and still a better one than the press in the hall."

Fionnghal sat up that night in her lodging and made the copy with her own hand, and gave it to Gormshuil's niece at the door in the morning. Then she rode home. At Doire mhin she did not stop, for she had nothing to tell Anndra mac Eòin that he would want to hear.

V

Of the Hungry Hawk

On the north coast of the island, where the hills come down in heather to a bay of grey sand, stands Seann Skell of the hawk, the other town of that name, where the fowler households have kept birds on the fist and fed them before their own children since An Aois Naomh¹. Once, long before, the

priests of the Fed Hawk had been driven there from Cnoc bheag, and from its shrine they had asked the king's council for a quarter more of the handful for the cold hearths of the north coast, and been refused. The town had not forgotten it. By this age the shrine of Seann Skell kept the teaching of Òrd an t-Seabhag² as Cnoc bheag kept it, that the hawk of the rite is Mòd, the Hawk of Acaill, as old as Fionntan and remembering all things with him; and that the vein is An Seabhag Acrach³, the Hungry Hawk, to be fed the measured handful and no more.

Its priest in those years was Murchadh Seabhag, a fowler's son of forty-two, spare and weathered, with a hooked nose that his people said had given him his byname before the order did. On 6 an t-Sultain, AE 22, a bright day at the end of the harvest, he preached on the steps of the shrine with a grey hawk hooded on his fist, to the fowler households and to the carters who had come up the coast with the Company's coal for the town's new hearths.

The copies of that sermon differ in small things, as copies made by ear will. They agree in this: that Mòd starves those who eat faster than the land can feed them. The hawk remembers every meal it is given, said Murchadh, and every meal it is kept from, and it keeps the reckoning longer than any clerk. Feed it the handful and it hunts for you all your life. Feed it past its fill and it sits on the perch and grows fat and will not fly. And a people that eats the hill faster than the hill can grow is a hawk overfed, and it will not hunt, and in the end the hill will not feed it. Then he said the old line of the order over the hooded bird, which every copy keeps in the island's tongue:

Ma bhiadhas tu an seabhag thar a leòir, cha sheilg e.

If you feed the hawk past its fill, it will not hunt.

A scribe of the shrine wrote the sermon down that night from the priest's own mouth, and the fowlers who took birds south to sell at the autumn markets carried copies with them in their bird-bags. From the markets the copies went on by carters and pedlars into the camps at Muileann chrom and Cnoc fhiadhaich, where there were few who could read and many who could listen, and a man who could read was given his supper for reading it in the huts after the shift. It was the first writing of the Dia-thìrich to go among the crews in that way.

A copy came to Dùn dhearg at Samhain in a carter's pack, folded small and worn soft at the creases. Fionnghal read it at her kitchen table, twice, by the coal

1. the Holy Age

2. the Hawk order

3. the Hungry Hawk

fire. She had written eleven pages, and here a man who kept hawks had said the thing in a line. She put the copy in her chest beside the draft of her own letter, and did not burn it.

VI

Of the Peat Hearths and the Pumps

In the spring of the next year word came east over the hills from Achadh naomh, a village of the uplands north of the workings, some fifteen miles inland from the hawk's town. Its households kept Na Seann Spioradan¹, the old spirits of the hearth and the dead, and on 16 am Màrt, AE 23, their elders had given out that no hearth of Achadh naomh would be lit with coal bought of the Company. They burned peat, as their grandparents had. They had heard of the letter from Dùn dhearg, for a copy had come to them folded inside a copy of Murchadh's sermon, and they sent to ask whether the custodian who wrote it would come and read it at their hearth.

Fionnghal went in an Giblean, a two days' ride north and west through the bare hills, with the peat banks black and wet on either side of the track and nobody cutting them. Achadh naomh stood in a fold of the moor above a burn, a score of low houses roofed in heather rope, and every roof smoked blue. The smell of it came down the hill to meet her a mile off. She had not smelled a whole village of peat smoke in two years, and she had not known that she missed it.

The eldest of the elders was a woman named Sileas nic Uilleim, bent nearly double, who received her at a hearth in the middle of the floor with the peats built up round it in a ring, and a flat stone at the head of the hearth where no one sat. Sileas told her what the stone was for. Every night at the smooing of the fire the woman of the house told the dead at the stone what had been burned that day and where it came from: this peat from this bank, cut by this man in this summer. It was a short telling. It had been the same telling for the whole life of the village.

"We tell them what we burn," said Sileas. "I would not know how to tell them the other."

Fionnghal read her letter at that hearth to the whole village packed into the one house, with children on the rafters and the door open for the ones who could

1. the Old Spirits

not get in. They heard it through without a sound. When she was done Sileas asked her, in front of them all, what burned on the hearth of the custodian of Dùn dhearg.

Fionnghal told her.

Sileas did not say anything to that. In the morning, when Fionnghal went to her horse, there was a creel of dry peats tied on behind the saddle, and nobody would say who had put it there.

In an Lùnastal Coinneach Glas sent three custodians to Muileann chrom to ask the Company, in the council's name, that the tally of the hill be kept: that its agents learn what the hill might give in a year, as the custodians of the valley had always reckoned it, and cut no more. Fionnghal was one of the three, because Dùn dhearg was nearest. They came down into the valley on a hot still morning and saw the smoke before they saw the town.

The camp of the crews had doubled since she was last there. Rows of timber huts ran up the slope from the pit-head, with the washing strung between them and the ground trodden black, and at the head of the rows the Company's agents were going from hut to hut with a basket. Women stood in the doorways with their arms folded. Fionnghal asked a girl at a water-butt what the men were looking for, and the girl said: the hawk-priest's paper. The agents had been told to take every copy they found. They took eleven that morning, by the girl's count, from under mattresses and behind the hearth-stones, and carried them off in the basket to the agent's office. One woman, as they came to her door, put her copy in the fire in front of them and stood on the hearth until it had burned, and they wrote down her name.

The crew-leader who took the custodians down to the pump-house was a man of Muileann chrom named Ragnall mac Dhòmhnaill, broad and soot-grained, who had led the first thirty into the pit twelve years before. He did not say much. He showed them the thing as they asked, the way a man shows the road.

The pump stood in a house of stone at the mouth of the deep gallery, a great beam rocking on its pin over a shaft, and the water came up out of the hill in a black gush at every stroke and ran away down a trough to the burn. Beside it were the furnaces that drove it. Carts came up the track from the heaps in a line, and at each furnace-mouth a man knocked out the tail-board and the coal went in by the cartload, straight off the cart, without anyone looking at it. Fionnghal stood in the heat and watched six carts go in while Ragnall told the others how deep the gal-

lery ran. Anndra mac Eòin's count, a whole year of his valley's cutting, would not have kept those fires a month.

The Company's chief agent heard them out in his office with the basket of papers on the floor beside his desk. He was civil. He said that he would send the council an account of the yield. Nine days later a packet came to the council at Cathair dhearg in the humans' tongue: a copy of the Company's accounts for the half-year, in columns of tons and marks, carefully ruled. Coinneach Glas read the totals aloud. The clerk put the accounts in the press in the corner of the hall, on the shelf where Fionnghal's letter lay.

VII

Of the Oaks of Cathair fhada

The council's winter sitting of the twenty-fourth year was the last that Josiah Pell attended. He came to it in his closed carriage over the Company's bridge, as he had come for five years, and sat at the table in the chair the council kept for him, a grey heavy man by then, and heard the council's business through, and said at the end in his slow Dia-thìris that he was going home. On 15 an Gearran, AE 24, he sailed from Ros dhomhain, north-about, and did not come back. He had sat at the council's table for sixteen years, and Fionnghal, who had disliked him for most of them, found that she was sorry to see the carriage go down the hill for the last time.

Henry Maddox came to the council a week after in the same carriage. He was twenty-eight, fair and quick and pleasant, and he had learned a greeting in Dia-thìris on the ship, which he said to each custodian in turn round the table, with a small bow, getting it nearly right. He told the council that his orders were to double the yield of the pits. It came out as good news, a thing for the island to be glad of, and he looked round the table for the gladness. He did not speak of the letter in his pocket from the Company, which promised him a share of that doubling. The council never saw it. The copyists found it in the letter-books.

On 12 am Màrt, AE 24, Maddox bought the oak woods about Cathair fhada for pit-props. The custodians of Cathair fhada sold them for marks, being in debt to the Company's store for seed after a wet harvest, and the woodreeve of the town came up to the council to ask that the sale be undone. He was Eòghann mac Phàdraig, a lean man with bark-stained hands, and he stood where Fionnghal had

stood and said his piece in a quarter of the time. The council heard him. Coinneach Glas said that the custodians of Cathair fhada had had the right to sell. The clerk entered it.

Fionnghal rode south with Eòghann the next morning. It was a day's ride down the valley into the country south of the capital, and they came into Cathair fhada at dusk, a town of grey stone on a long ridge with the oaks round it on three sides, bare and black in the last of the light, older than any house in it. Eòghann showed her the rule of the wood as they walked out into it at first light. Every spring at the feast of Bride the town cast lots for one oak, and that one was felled for the town's need, a roof-tree or a keel or a mill-shaft, and six acorns were planted in the ring of its roots. So they had cut since An Aois Naomh¹. There were oaks in that wood that had been acorns in the time of the queens.

The lot had been cast that year before the sale. The oak it had fallen on stood at the wood's edge above the town, a broad old tree with a split crown, marked with a band of red ochre round the trunk at the height of a man's chest.

"The fellers come on the morning after next," said Eòghann. "We will cut ours first."

They cut it the next day, Eòghann and his two sons and four men of the town, with axes, the old way, taking the whole day over it. Half the town came out to watch, and the custodians who had sold the wood came too, and stood at the back. The oak went over in the late afternoon with a noise like a door slammed in a great house, and lay down along the slope with its crown in the bracken. Then Eòghann went down on his knees in the ring of its roots and planted six acorns out of his pocket, and his sons filled in the earth over them with their hands.

The fellers came on the morning after, as he had said, forty men in a line along the wood's edge with long saws from over the sea that two men worked between them, and the Company's carts waiting on the road below. Fionnghal did not stay to see them start. She heard the first saw as she rode out of the town, a harsh rasp, over and over, that followed her down the ridge.

She rode home east across the country, three days on the road with the creel of peats from Achadh naomh still tied behind her saddle, for she had not burned them. The coal-carts passed her at every ford. She came up the hill into Dùn dhearg on the third evening in a thin rain, and went into her own kitchen, where

1. the Holy Age

Tòmas Bàn had the grate heaped with coal against her coming, red and roaring, the whole room hot with it.

She had him rake it out. He looked at her, and did it, and carried the coals out in the scuttle to the midden and came back. Then she knelt at the cold grate and built the fire again herself out of the Achadh naomh peats, in a ring as she had seen it built at Sìleas nic Uilleim's hearth, and lit it. It was slow to take. The smoke went blue up the chimney and the smell of it filled the kitchen, and after a while it drew and burned low and red, and gave out less heat than the coal had. In the morning she sent Tòmas Bàn to find a man in the town who still knew how to cut peat, and to pay him whatever he asked.

Up in the old granary under the north wall the board of the counters hung on its two pegs in the dark, with the pegs of the last Samhain still in their holes.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

OF THE ELEVEN OF CNOC FHIADHAICH

AE 25 – 29

I

Of the Heading under the Wild Hill

There is a leaf in the roll of Taigh na Fèithe¹, copied in the cellar at Muileann chaol from a page gone brown at the edges, that holds nothing but eleven names. It has no heading. Each name stands on its own line with the name of a father or a mother after it and the name of a hearth after that, and at the foot, in a smaller hand, the day and the moon and three words for the place: under the wild hill. The letter-books of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach² keep the same day in the

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

humans' reckoning, and against it a single line from the agent of A' Chompanaidh³ at the workings: that a length of gallery had come down in unsound ground, and that the yield of the quarter would be short by so many tons. Between those two pages lies the tale of Ragnall mac Dhòmhnaill in the years when the hill first began to take back what was taken from it, and the copyists, who had both before them, set down what the one knew and the other did not.

Ragnall was five-and-thirty in the spring of the twenty-fifth year. He had led a crew at the pit-mouth below Muileann chrom since the first ton was weighed, fourteen years before, and when A' Chompanaidh was sent away from Doire mhòr and opened its new working at Cnoc fhiadhaich instead, a short walk east along the hill, it was his crews it sent there first. He had three crews under him by then, near ninety souls, and a house at the top of the mill street with a byre and a good door, and a wife, Ciorstaidh, who had been a miller's daughter and could reckon faster than the clerk. They had one son, Dòmhnall, called after Ragnall's father, who was five that spring and followed his father to the pit-mouth whenever he was let.

The working at Cnoc fhiadhaich went into the hill on the level from a gully on its southern side, where the seam showed in the bank. The first gallery was the carters' road: a broad drift, high enough for a pony, with rails of oak laid down its floor and props of oak along its sides, square-cut and set in pairs with a cap across. That oak had come up from Cathair fhada the summer before, cartload after cartload, when Henry Maddox bought the woods about that town for the pits. Ragnall's crews had set every pair.

From the head of the drift the new gallery was driven north into the hill after the seam, and there the props stopped.

Maddox had come over the sea in the spring before with a letter that bade him double the yield, and he had read it aloud at the pit-mouth, in his own tongue and then through the young man of Ros dhomhain who put A' Chompanaidh's words into the island's. He was not thirty, with a clean jaw and a quick walk. What he wanted of Cnoc fhiadhaich was the heading: the gallery driven forward fast along the seam, so that the rooms could be opened off it on either hand and the coal come out of the hill from a dozen faces at once. The props, the agent said after him, would follow when the yield allowed. The oak was costly. It had come a long way.

2. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

3. the Company

So the heading went north, a yard and a yard and another yard, on the pay of the ton, with bare rock over it.

II

Of the Colour in the Roof

Raghnall asked for timber the first time at the end of an Gearran. The heading was forty yards beyond the last pair of props, and the roof over it was a grey shale that split in leaves, and in the lamp-light, along the partings where it had begun to open, it had taken on a colour the old hewers had a word for. It was a sick yellow-green, like a bruise going off, or the underside of a toad; and every hewer's son of the hill had been taught to see it and to stop.

He took the agent in to look. The agent held his lamp up to the roof and looked for a long time, conscientiously, and then looked at Raghnall.

"Grey," he said. Then he said in his own tongue that the roof was dry and rang when he knocked it, and was the same rock as in the drift behind. That was true. The rock was the same. The colour was not, and the agent could not see it, any more than Stone and Mercer had seen the green in the sacks, fifteen years before, on the hill above the mill.

Raghnall asked a second time in am Màrt, and a third in the first week of an Giblean, when a leaf of shale the size of a door had come down in the night and been found across the rails in the morning. Ailean mac Dhùghaill, who led the second crew and had been his friend since they were boys on the mill-lade, came with him that time and stood beside him while he asked. The agent wrote the request in his book. He wrote that the crew-leaders wished for timber at the heading, and under it that the timber would be sent up when the next oak came from Cathair fhada, and he read both lines back to them through the young man of Ros dhomhain so that they should know it had been written.

"When is the next oak?" said Ailean.

The young man asked. The agent said the summer.

They went back to work. There was nothing else to do. The rate was on the paper, and the ton was on the beam, and the crews had had three hungry winters since the Law lapsed and the custodians' measure stopped paying; nobody on the hill that spring had a store of meal that would carry a family through a season with no pay. Raghnall told his crews to keep an ear to the roof and to come out if

it spoke. Ailean told his the same. They set wedges of their own under the worst of it, split from old hurdles and fence-posts, which the agent did not forbid.

On 26 an Giblean, AE 25, the roof spoke, and nobody came out in time.

It was the middle of the forenoon. Ragnall was at the pit-mouth with the clerk, arguing over a tub that the clerk said was short and he said was full, when the air came out of the drift. It came in one push, like a breath from a man struck in the belly, and it carried a cloud of dust that rolled out over the tipping-floor and went up the gully in the sun, and after it, a long way behind, the sound. The men at the pit-mouth that morning said it was like a door shut in a far room of a great house.

He was in the drift before the dust had settled, with a lamp he did not remember lighting. The props stood, every pair, all the way to the head of the drift. Beyond the last pair there was no gallery. There was a wall of broken shale from floor to roof, and the roof had gone up into a black hollow over it that the lamp would not reach, and from somewhere in the hollow small stones were still coming down, one and then another, with a sound like rain beginning.

III

Of the Eleven

They dug for three days. Every crew on the hill came, and men from the old cutting, and farmers from the villages who had never been underground in their lives and stood in a line passing baskets back into the drift, and the women at the pit-mouth taking the baskets and tipping them and passing them back. Ragnall would let no one go beyond the last pair of props without a timber over his head. They cut the timber out of the oak rails of the drift, board by board, prising up the carters' road to prop the fall, and the agent saw it and said nothing. On the first night they heard knocking. On the second they did not.

They brought them out one by one, as they were found. Calum mac Eòghainn came first, and his son Anndra, who was fifteen and had been hurrying tubs for his father since the winter, lay a yard behind him with an arm across his back. Then Pàdraig mac Coinnich; Murchadh Liath; Iain Crùbach, who had a bad foot and could hew sitting better than most men standing; Alasdair mac Fhionnlaigh; Lachlann Beag; Fionnlagh mac Sheumais; Mòr nic Artair, who dragged the tubs for the second crew and sang while she did it; Eòghann Donn.

Ailean mac Dhùghaill was the last. They found him at the very head of the gallery, where the seam went on into the hill, with his pick under him and one of the wedges he had split from a hurdle still in his hand.

Raghnall carried him out himself. At the pit-mouth there was a crowd, silent, the whole hill; and among them, at the front, a short old man with shoulders like a yoke, who had not come down to the working in fourteen years.

Raghnall's father walked past him to where the eleven were laid out on the tipping-floor under their coats. He stood at their feet and looked at them each in turn. Then he turned to the mouth of the drift, black in the bank, with the dust still hanging in the light at its edge, and he began to say the words that are said at the face before a man puts his pick into the hill. He said them slowly, the whole of them, and the old hewers among the crowd took them up. Nobody had said them at that pit-mouth since the day it was opened. Most of the young men of the crews did not know them to the end, and stood with their mouths moving, a word behind.

When it was done old Dòmhnall looked at his son once, and went home up the hill.

The eleven were buried at Muileann chrom, in the ground above the mill where the hill's dead had always lain, on the fourth day after the fall. The custodians of Taigh na Fèithe¹ came down to them. Seonag Liath was two winters dead, and the cutting was kept now by Marsaili nic Sheumais, a tall grey woman with ink on her fingers; and she stood at the head of the row of graves with the roll open on a board held by a boy, and read the names out, and wrote them in as she read them, each with the father and the mother and the hearth. She asked Raghnall the name of Mòr nic Artair's mother, which she did not know, and he did not know it either, and a woman in the crowd called it out, and Marsaili wrote it.

Then she asked him the name of the place, and he said, "Under the wild hill," and she wrote that.

That leaf is the one the copyists found. The agent's full report was slower. It went down to Ros dhomhain in his hand when the heading had been cleared, and was entered at Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir² on 14 an Dàmhair, AE 25. It named no one. The agent gave the length of the fall in yards and the tons lost from the quarter, and it said that the gallery had been driven in unsound ground, and that the nat-

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

ives had been warned of the roof; and where it spoke of the dead at all, it called them *hands*.

Ragnall heard it read, later, by a carter who had got it from a clerk. He was quiet a long while after. Then he said that the ground had been sound enough when the oak was over it, and the carter, who had not been there, agreed that it likely had.

IV

Of the Breakers at the Pit-Mouth

The heading was cleared by the midsummer, and timbered as it was cleared, pair by pair, with oak that came up from Cathair fhada in an t-Ògmhios after all; and the yield of the year was short, as the agent had written it would be, and nobody was paid for the days of the digging. That winter the cough came.

It began among the breakers. At every pit-mouth of the hill the coal came out of the drift in the tubs, and was tipped on the floor in the open, and there the children broke it. They sat in rows on low benches under a roof of hurdles, with a hammer each and a heap in front of them, and broke the big coal into the sizes the humans' furnaces wanted, and picked out the stone and the shale, and were paid by the basket. It was a thing that had come in with the ton. In the old cutting the custodians had never let a child near the face until he was old enough to say the words; but the old cutting worked a season in the year, and the pit-mouth worked every day there was light, and there was always more coal on the floor than hands to break it. The families were glad of the pence.

Dòmhnall mac Raghnaill went to the benches in the autumn after the fall, the month he turned six. He asked to go, because the other boys of the mill street went, and Ciorstaidh said he was too small, and Ragnall said no harm could find him on the floor in the daylight with his father fifty yards off. So Dòmhnall went, with a hammer that the smith cut down for him, and came home black every night, and was paid his first pence at the end of the week and gave them to his mother and would not eat his supper for pride.

The dust at the benches was thick on a still day. It hung under the hurdle roof in the low sun like smoke, and the children breathed it all the daylight long, and coughed, and spat black, as the breakers always had. Nobody thought much of

that. Then in the new year, on 11 an Gearran, AE 26, a boy of nine at the Cnoc fhiadhaich benches coughed at his heap until he could not stand, and was carried home, and was dead within the week; and by the end of the month there were twenty coughing at Muileann chrom and Cnoc fhiadhaich, and most of them were breakers.

It was a dry cough. It had no wet in it and no fever, which the women said was the worst kind, because there was nothing to bring up and nothing to break. The fits came without warning, and the child would bend double with it and fight for breath with a noise like a saw in wet wood, and then it would pass, and the child would lie grey and tired and ask for water. Some had it a month and grew well. Some had it a month and did not. The hill called it An Casad Tioram, the dry cough, and had no other name for it, since there was nothing it was like.

Dòmhnall took it in am Màrt.

Ragnall sat with him through nine nights. He had the boy on his knee by the fire, wrapped in a blanket, upright, because lying down the cough was worse; and Ciorstaidh boiled water with pine-needles in it and held the steam to the boy's face, which an old woman of the mill street said would help and which did not. He would go an hour, two hours, sleeping, with his head on his father's chest and a small rattle in him like a stone in a jug, and then he would wake coughing and fight, and Ragnall would hold him and feel the whole of the small body go hard with it.

On the fifth night the surgeon of Teachdaireachd na h-Eaglaise¹ came up from Ros dhomhain, sent by A' Chompanaidh² when the agent had counted the empty benches. He was a tired, kindly man who went round the houses of the mill street with a lamp and listened to each child's chest with an ear-trumpet of wood, and told each house through the young man of Ros dhomhain that it was a winter complaint and would pass with the spring. He left a brown bottle in every house that tasted of honey and something bitter. Dòmhnall spat it out.

On the tenth morning Dòmhnall slept through the dawn and woke without coughing, and asked for bread. Ragnall gave it to him, and went out to the byre, and stood with his forehead against the cow's warm flank for a long time before he came in again.

The spring came, as the surgeon had said, and the cough did not pass with it. It went on through an Cèitean, and through the summer, when the dust was dry

1. the Mission; lit. 'the errand of the Church'

2. the Company

and blew about the benches all day and the children came home with it in their eyes and hair. The custodians of Taigh na Fèithe³ asked the agent to shut the benches until the cough was done. He wrote the asking in his book. The benches stayed open, because the furnaces at the pit-mouth burned day and night now to drive the pumps, and wanted broken coal. By the end of an Lùnastal, when the first rains laid the dust and the coughing thinned, thirty-eight were dead at Muileann chrom and Cnoc fhiadhaich, and most of them were boys who broke coal at the pit-mouth, and some were their mothers and fathers, who had nursed them.

Dòmhnall lived. He was thin that year and small the next, and had a catch in his breath when he ran; but he lived, and in the autumn he went back to the benches with his cut-down hammer, and Raghnaid let him.

V

Of the Cart to Cill thais

When the cough was done there were children on the hill with nobody to keep them. Some had lost a father under Cnoc fhiadhaich and a mother to the cough after; some had lost both to the cough; and there were Anndra mac Chaluim's two small sisters, whose father and brother were both in the row above the mill, and whose mother had gone back to her own people at Muileann dhearg and not come for them. The neighbours took them in for the winter, as the hill always had. But the hill that winter was short of meal and shorter of marks, and the neighbours had breakers of their own coughing still, and by the spring of the twenty-seventh year there were fourteen children sleeping in other folk's byres whom nobody could feed through another season.

The word of it went west along the road with the carters. It came, in the way of such things, to the custodians of Cill thais, a large village on damp ground two long days west towards the capital, whose wardens kept the sacred wood; and in an Ògmhios the custodians of Cill thais sent a letter to Taigh na Fèithe¹ to say that they would take the children in and keep a house for them at their own cost, for as long as the children needed a house. The roll of Cill thais sets it down on 6 an t-

3. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

Iuchar, AE 27. The custodians of the hill, on the same page of their own roll, asked A' Chompanaidh² to give something toward it. A' Chompanaidh sent a crate.

Raghnaill drove the cart. Nobody asked him to. He had the loan of the miller's two ponies and the long cart with the hooped cover, and he put straw in it, and blankets, and the crate, and a sack of oatcake that Ciorstaidh baked, and on a grey morning in an t-Iuchar he stood at the top of the mill street while the fourteen were lifted in. The smallest was three. The eldest was Anndra's sister Seasaidh, who was eleven and held the three-year-old on her knee and would not let anyone else take her. Dòmhnall stood at the byre door and watched them go. He had broken coal on the benches beside four of them.

They were two days on the road. The first night they lay at a farm below the watershed, where the farmer's wife brought milk and would take no penny for it. The second day they went down the long road west through the hill country, past the old carters' house at the half-way stage, roofless now, with nettles in its yard and its sign-post leaning. The children looked at everything.

Cill thais was a long street of low houses on a rise above wet meadows, with the dark edge of the sacred wood behind it, and the custodians had a house ready at the end of the street: a long house of stone with a new thatch, and beds of heather and blankets along both walls, and two women of the village to keep it, and a fire lit on the hearth, though it was high summer, because the children would be tired. Taigh nan Dilleachdan, the village called it, the house of the orphans, and it had no other name. The warden who met the cart was an old man with a staff of black wood, and he lifted each child down himself, and asked each its name and its mother's name, and a girl beside him wrote them.

Then two of the village men took down the crate, and the warden had it opened in the street.

It was full of books. They were small books, bound in grey board, all alike, perhaps a hundred of them, and they were in the humans' letters, and in the humans' tongue; they were the primers from which Teachdaireachd na h-Eaglaise³ at Ros dhomhain was teaching the children of the humans' clerks to read. There was a picture of a lamb on the first page of each.

2. the Company

3. the Mission; lit. 'the errand of the Church'

The warden took one out and turned the pages over slowly, the whole book, and looked at the lamb a while. Then he closed it and laid it back in the crate with the others and had the crate carried into the house and set on a shelf.

"They may learn to read them," he said. "Somebody may."

Raghnall drove home with the empty cart. On the long hill up from the half-way stage he stopped the ponies and sat on the tail of the cart for an hour with his head in his hands, and a carter coming down with a load of props from the south asked him if he was ill, and he said no.

VI

Of the Light on the Eastern Cape

Here the copyists leave the hills for a while, as the roll of Taigh na Fèithe¹ does, and go east with the carters to the sea.

In that same summer the second beacon of the island was lit, on the eastern cape at Baile ìseal, where the long slopes of the east run down out of the hills and the land ends in a shelf of black rock over the open water. There had been a fire on that cape since before An Aois Ailein², a driftwood fire in a ring of stones, kept by the households of the coast to bring the boats home in a storm. Twenty years before, Torcall Clachair had walked out to it with James Fenn and built the second of his five cairns above it; and the cairn had stood there, with the white stone on its cap, while the tower at Tobar dhearg went up in the south-west and was lit, and while the town waited for a tower of its own.

A' Chompanaidh³ came in the end, because its ships had begun to come round the south coast from Ceann leathan and go up the eastern shore, and two of them had touched on the rocks below the cape in the dark. It paid the masons and sent a lamp. It sent no mason of its own. The tower was built by the masons of the eastern coast under Torcall's direction, as the tower at Tobar dhearg had been, of the grey stone of the cape, and its lime was burned in a kiln on the shore with coal carted over the hills from Muileann chrom, a few loads of which, by the tally, had been cut by Raghnall's crews under Cnoc fhiadhaich in the spring of the fall.

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the Age of Ailean

3. the Company

Torcall was old by then, near seventy, and his knees had gone. He could not climb the headland. So they carried a chair out for him, a high-backed chair from the custodian's house, and set it at the foot of the headland on the flat turf above the shingle, where he could see the whole height of the tower against the sky; and he sat in it through the whole of a summer and an autumn and most of another summer, with a rug over his knees and a boy beside him to run messages up the path, and a long stick he pointed with. He could see a stone a finger out of true from the foot of the cliff, and he would send the boy up to say so.

The tower was lit on 4 an Lùnastal, AE 27. The whole town was on the cape to see it, and the households of the coast for a day's walk round, and the old fire in its ring of stones was lit beside the tower as it always had been, with driftwood. When the lamp caught at the top of the tower and the light went out over the water, the fishermen in the boats below the cape set up a shout; and Torcall, in his chair at the foot of the headland, was seen to take off his cap.

The keepers came from the fishing families. That was the first thing the custodians of Baile ìseal asked for, and they got it: the lamp would be trimmed and the stair climbed by the households who had kept the driftwood fire, and by no one else, and the families drew lots for the watches each Samhain as they had always drawn them for the fire. The second thing they asked for came the next spring, and they got that too, on 9 an Cèitean, AE 28. On the nights the boats went out to the deep grounds beyond the cape the lamp was to be lowered, lest the fish take fright at the great new light on the water and leave the grounds. The rule was kept. When it lapsed no one wrote down.

In the spring after the lighting, when the rule was granted and the keepers were at their watches, Torcall Clachair was put on a cart to go home west. A mile out of Baile ìseal, where the road tops the first rise of the moor and a traveller going east sees the tower for the first time over the heather, he had the carter stop. He had himself lifted down, and sat by the road on a stone, and had the boy bring him stones from the ditch, one by one, and laid them himself with his own hands on the turf beside him in a small cairn, no higher than his knee, each stone on two below it and a flat one for a cap. It took him the morning. Then he was lifted back onto the cart, and went home, and built no more. The cairn is there by the road, the carters say, and they put a stone on it when they pass.

VII

Of the Offer and the Huts at the Ford

In the hills the yield of A' Chompanaidh¹ was short three years together. Mad-dox's letter had bidden him double it, and it had not doubled. It had gone down.

The reason was not hard to find. The crews of the hill were hill men. They had fields, most of them, or their fathers had, small fields of oats and barley in the valley bottoms and on the lower slopes, and a few beasts on the hill; and when the harvest came in an Lùnastal they went home to cut it, as their grandfathers had gone home from the old cutting when its season was done. They had always done so. The contract said nothing against it. The first summer after the fall, a third of the crews went home to the harvest and stayed there through the autumn; the summer after the cough, it was half. Men who had carried their friends out of the heading, or buried a child from the benches, found they could do without the pence. The agent wrote it in his book.

In the spring of the twenty-ninth year he sent for Ragnall.

He received him in the new office A' Chompanaidh had built at the pit-mouth, a room of dressed stone with a glass window and a stove in it that burned the hill's coal. The agent had been at the hill five years and had some Dia-thìris now, and he did not send for the young man of Ros dhomhain. He gave Ragnall a chair, which Ragnall had not had in that room before, and a cup of something hot and brown that the humans drank, and then he made his offer.

Ragnall's crews were the best on the hill, the agent said; everyone knew it; and Ragnall was the man the hill listened to, as the agent had seen at the fall. A' Chompanaidh would pay him, over and above the rate of the ton, a leader's share on every ton his three crews brought up, paid to him and not to the crews, if he would keep them at the face through the harvest and the winter together. The share was written on a paper, and the agent turned it round on the table so that Ragnall could see the figure, and Ragnall looked at it for a long time.

Then the agent said the other thing, in the same voice. A' Chompanaidh had been buying the foreshores of the coast for its quays, he said, at Ceann fhada and elsewhere, and a good many fishing families of the coast had nails and no fore-shore now, and would come up to the pits for pay if there was a roof for them.

1. the Company

There was talk at Ros dhomhain of building one. If the hill men would not keep the face through the year, men from the coast would; and there would be no need then of a leader's share.

Raghnall said he would think on it. The agent said, of course.

He thought on it a month, and told nobody what he thought. The letter-books keep the paper, with his mark at the foot of it and a date in an Cèitean. He told Ciorstaidh the figure, and she reckoned it out on the table with beans, in marks and in meal, the way the mill had taught her, and it came to more than a hewer of the old cutting had seen in ten seasons. He did not tell his father. Old Dòmhnall heard it at the mill a week after, and came to the door of the house at the top of the mill street, and did not come in; he stood on the step and looked at his son, and at his grandson behind him, who was nine now and black from the benches, and then went back up the hill. They spoke after that of the weather, and of the boy.

So Raghnall kept his crews at the face through the harvest of the twenty-ninth year. He did it by going to each man's door, and sitting at each man's fire, and saying what the agent had said about the coast; and most of them heard him out and stayed, because he was Raghnall, who had led the first thirty and carried Ailean out of the heading, and because a man who goes home to his oats and finds his place at the face given to a stranger has neither oats enough nor a face. The yield of the year came up. The leader's share was paid on the first market-day after, to the penny.

And the coast men came anyway.

That same season the traders' boats of the new quay at Ceann òg, on the Abhainn ìseal, had begun to run their long lane round the capes to the capital's water, down the river past Cnoc bheag to the north coast and west along it, and round the western capes and south, the lane the boatmen called Seòlaid Ceann òg; and in the autumn A' Chompanaidh used the lane the other way about. It gathered the men of the foreshores at the capital's quays and shipped them in the traders' boats round the western capes and east along the north coast and up the Abhainn ìseal to the quay at Ceann òg, and they walked the last long day over the hills with their bundles. They were fishers and net-menders and the sons of salters, and they had never been under the ground. They came in companies of twenty, with a clerk of A' Chompanaidh in front and their wives and children behind.

For them A' Chompanaidh built the camp at Àth iséal, a few miles north-west of Cnoc fhiadhaich, at the low ford below the new workings where the ferry-men of the hill had always put the carts across in the wet season. It was built in a month, of sawn plank on sills of stone, in rows: long huts with a door at each end and a stove in the middle, and a store at the head of the rows, and a well. There was no field and no byre and no burial ground, and no shrine. The roll of Taigh na Fèithe² enters it on 6 an Dàmhair, AE 29, with a note in Marsaili nic Sheumais's hand that it had no custodian and had asked for none; and it was the first settlement on the island that had been made for nothing but the pit.

Ragnall walked over to see it on the evening the first crews moved in. It was raining. He stood on the rise above the ford with his hood up, where the ferry-men's path comes down, and looked at the three long huts with the smoke of their stoves going up flat into the rain, and the rows marked out in pegs beyond them for more. A man came out of the end of the nearest hut with a bucket and went to the well. He was a broad man with the rolling walk of a boat, and he stopped at the well and looked up at the hill to the east, where the workings were, and the heather going up black into the cloud; and he stood a long while at the well with his bucket, looking at it, as a man looks at a sea he does not know.

Ragnall did not go down to him. After a time he turned and walked home along the hill in the dark, past the mouth of the working at Cnoc fhiadhaich, where the drift stood dark under its oak, and down into Muileann chrom, where Ciorstaidh had kept his supper warm on the hearth over a fire of the hill's coal.

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

CHAPTER TWELVE

Of the Green River Run Black

AE 30 – 35

I

Of the Stream at Doire mhòr

Sèonaid Bhàn was twenty-five years old in the summer the stream stopped, and she had driven her father's cart on the hill road since she was fourteen.

Her father was a carter of Cuan chrom, the little river town where the carriers' road from the capital comes down to a bend of the Abhainn fhionn and crosses it by the ford below the quay. At that quay, since An Aois Naomh¹, there had stood a carters' house with a hearth at either end, one for carriers going up to the hills and one for carriers coming down; and in the winter of Fiabhras nan Coigreach its roof had fallen in, and nobody had put it back. The carters cursed it as they passed, as men curse a friend who has died on them.

She was called Bhàn for her hair, which was the colour of oat-straw. She was tall and long in the arm, and the carters of the road let her sit at their fires as one of themselves, and said of her that she drove like a man and bargained like a custodian, and that the second was worse.

On 23 an t-Iuchar, AE 30, she took a load of lamp-oil up to the washing-floors at Cnoc fhiadhaich for A' Chompanaidh², twelve casks at so much the cask, paid in marks at the pit-head. It was a two-day haul from Cuan chrom, over the ford of Àth chiar and up into the hills. The washing-floors were new that spring. They lay in the valley bottom below the pit where the eleven had died five years before, long troughs of plank on trestles, down which a race of water ran over the broken

1. the Holy Age

2. the Company

coal to carry off the dirt; and the dirt went on down the valley in a grey stream to find its own way to the river.

She saw at once that the race was running higher than it had in the spring. She saw too where the water came from. Above the troughs, where the valley narrowed under the shoulder of the hill, there was a new bank of turf and clay faced with planks, and behind it a long brown pond with the drowned heather standing up in it. The stream that fed the pond came down off the high ground from the north, from the side of the hill where Doire mhòr stood among its oaks. It had watered Doire mhòr since there was a Doire mhòr. Now it went into the pond, and out of the pond by a wooden sluice into the race, and down the troughs over the coal.

Below the bank, in the old bed, there was a green trickle between dry stones, and a woman was kneeling there with a wooden pail, scooping.

Seònaid unloaded her casks and was paid. Then she walked up the old stream-bed towards the village. All the way up the stones were dry and the cress in the pools had gone brown, and at the top, where the path came out of the oaks into the village fields, she met a line of people coming down the slope with yokes on their shoulders and a pail at each end of the yoke. They were going down to the spring at the foot of the brae, below the oaks, which had been the cattle's spring and was now the whole village's. It was the better part of a mile each way, and a steep mile.

There were men in the line, and women, and children carrying jugs. The roll of Doire mhòr, which Beathag Dhubh kept in her own hand, names the households that carried that summer, and one of those who carried is Tormod, the son of Ruairidh who had stood behind Beathag at her door when she sent the agent of A' Chompanaidh down the hill. The roll gives him his name and his yoke and nothing more.

Seònaid slept that night in the byre of the custodian's house, and in the morning she went down to the washing-floors again with Beathag Dhubh.

II

Of the Order That Was Not Written

Beathag Dhubh was forty-nine years old that summer, a small dark woman with a jaw like a quern-stone, and she walked down the hill with her hands

clasped behind her back. She had asked Seònaid to come because Seònaid knew which of the strangers kept the book.

The man who kept the book at Cnoc fhiadhaich was Amos Tanner, an agent of A' Chompanaidh¹, a heavy young man with red wrists who sat in a timber office by the washing-floors with a ledger open in front of him and a stove going in the corner in the middle of summer. He spoke some Dia-thìris, badly and fast, and he stood up when Beathag came in, which was more than most of them did.

"The stream," said Beathag. "The stream of Doire mhòr. Show me the order."

Seònaid said it again for him in the carters' speech with the strangers, half of one tongue and half of the other, and he looked relieved, as a man looks who has been asked a question with an easy answer.

There was no order, he said. Nobody had ordered anything. The washing needed water and the stream was there. The bank had been thrown up in the spring by the washing gang, to hold a head of water for the dry months, and that was all.

"Then let it go," said Beathag.

Tanner said that he could not do that. The washing needed water.

"Who said you might take it?"

Nobody had said so, Tanner answered patiently. It had not needed saying. It was a stream on the hill, and the hill was worked by A' Chompanaidh under its contracts, and the water went with the working. If the custodian of Doire mhòr had a complaint, she might write it, and he would send it on to Ros dhomhain.

"To whom at Ros dhomhain?"

He did not know to whom. To the office.

Beathag looked round the timber room: at the ledger, at the stove, at the chart of the valley pinned to the planks, with the pond drawn as a neat blue shape and the stream above it as a line that came from nowhere. She put out one finger and touched the place on the chart where Doire mhòr would have been, if anyone had drawn it. Then she turned and went out without another word, and Seònaid went after her.

"He has no paper," Beathag said on the path. "So there is nothing to undo."

She wrote to the council all the same. The letter went down the road in Seònaid's cart, and Seònaid put it into the hand of a custodians' clerk at Cathair

1. the Company

dhearg, and the council entered it; and the stream was not let go that season, nor the next.

III

Of the Wet Harvest

The summer broke at the end of an t-Iuchar and it rained for a month.

In another year the hill villages would have taken their oats in between the showers, every hand in the field at the first dry hour. That year there were not the hands. The pits had been drawing the young men off the farms for twenty years, and faster in the six since the new Àrd-mhaor came over the sea with orders to double the yield: a son here for the ton-money, a brother there, a husband who came home at the week's end with coal in the lines of his face and slept the rest-day through. The old men and the women and the children cut what they could. The rest stood in the fields and sprouted in the ear, and in AE 30, by the end of Lùnastal, the hill villages of Muileann chrom had lost the better half of their harvest.

Seònaid carried meal that autumn. She carried it for A' Chompanaidh¹, from the quay at Ros dhomhain where it came off the ships in sacks stencilled in the humans' letters, up the carriers' road to the store at Àth ìseal, where the camp of timber huts stood at the ford below the new workings. She was paid for the haul in marks. At the store the meal was sold, over a counter, by a clerk with a steel-yard, and it was sold for marks.

The hill villages had few marks. They had oats in a good year, and wool, and cheese. The clerk at Àth ìseal would not take cheese; he had no book for cheese. So the women came down to the store with the coins their men had brought home, and when those were spent they sent the men back to the pits for more.

Seònaid stood at the store door one wet evening in an Dàmhair, waiting for her own pay, and watched a woman from the high farms above Doire mhòr count coins onto the clerk's counter. There were not enough. The clerk pushed the sack back towards the wall. The woman stood and looked at it, and then she took off the brooch at her shoulder, which was bronze with a knot on it of the old kind,

1. the Company

and laid it on the counter. The clerk looked at it and pushed it back to her with one finger.

Seònaid put two marks down beside the brooch, and the clerk took them, and the woman took the sack and went out without looking at either of them. Seònaid drove home the next day two marks short, and her father said nothing about it, which in her father was a kind of speech.

IV

Of the Meal-Carts from the South

The south had had its own wet autumn, and it waited on its next harvest before it gave from it. In the autumn of the next year, when that harvest was in, the villages of Doire fhiadhaich, far down in the oak country of the south, loaded carts with meal and sent them north to the hill villages. They did it as *Lagh a' Bhìdh Roinnte*¹ bade in a hungry year, as it had bidden since *An Aois Naomh*², and nobody asked them to and nobody paid them.

There were nine carts, with oxen, and they came up by *Dùn chrom* and struck the carriers' road below *Cuan chrom* in the second week of an *Dàmhair*, in the rain. They came down to the ford at dusk and stood looking at the roofless house at the quay with the rain running out of its doorways, and Seònaid's father went down with a lantern and brought them up to his own byre and hearth, and Seònaid made the porridge. They talked late, in the slow broad speech of the south.

The eldest of the drivers was a man named *Gille-Bride*, an oak-keeper's son, who had brought his own grandson with him to show him the road. He asked how the hill villages were keeping, and what the meal was selling for at the stores, and Seònaid told him. He sat a while with his cup between his hands.

"For coin," he said at last.

"For their coin," said her father. "The marks."

"And where do the hill folk get their marks?"

"From the pits."

1. the shared-meal law; lit. 'the law of the shared food'

2. the Holy Age

Gille-Bride nodded slowly, like a man working a sum he did not like the end of. Then he said, "Well. They will not need to buy this."

The carts went on in the morning, over the ford at Àth chiar and up into the hills, and Seònaid went with them the first day to show them the road. She turned back at the Muileann chrom fork. It was not until the next week that she heard, at the store, what had become of them.

At the ford below Àth ìseal the agents of A' Chompanaidh³ had met the carts on the road. They wanted meal for the store and the camp, and they offered the southern drivers marks for it, more than it would fetch at any market in the south. The drivers said the meal was not for sale. The agents doubled the price. Two of the drivers, young men with debts at home, sold their loads there on the road and went home by another way. The other seven went on up into the hills and gave their meal away, sack by sack, at the doors of the villages, as the law bade.

Gille-Bride's was one of the seven. He came back down the road a week later with his empty cart and stopped at Cuan chrom to thank her father for the byre, and Seònaid asked him about the two who had sold.

"They were paid," he said. "The agents paid them fair. More than fair." He rubbed his face. "That is the thing about it I cannot get round."

He went away south. Seònaid did not see him again. But that was the night she began to count in her head, as she lay awake, what a cart could carry, and what it could be paid in, and who could pay.

V

Of the Chest for the Loft

In the same season a woman in a grey cloak came up the road from the capital driving a hired pony-cart with a chest roped into the back of it, and she stopped at Cuan chrom and asked for a bed.

She was Muireall nic Fhearchair, a copyist, a lean woman of forty-two with ink under her nails. Her aunt Gormshuil nic Fhearchair had died at Cathair dhearg in the last days of an t-Sultain, in her seventy-first year. Gormshuil had kept the council's list of the island's words since the ships first came, and she had been the custodian who would not sign Puingeann a' Chalaith¹, and she had

3. the Company

taught herself the humans' letters at an age when most women are teaching their grandchildren. Now she was dead, and her papers were in the chest, and Muireall was carrying them east to the loft of Beathag nic Thòmais at Muileann chaol, where the old copies were kept, because Gormshuil had asked her to and because she did not trust them to stay safe anywhere nearer Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir².

Seònaid carried the chest in from the cart herself. It was heavier than it looked.

"What is in it?" she asked.

"Words," said Muireall. "Forty years of them. Hers and the strangers'."

She would not open it that night. But the next morning the rain held on, and the road was a river, and she could not go on; and in the afternoon, sitting at the hearth with nothing to do, she unroped the chest and lifted the lid and took out, from the top, a single leaf in a wrapping of oiled cloth. It was her own copy of the first leaf she had written, she said, in the third spring of the strangers, when Gormshuil and the cleric Wren had sat across a table at Cathair dhearg with a basket of coal between them. It was Clàr nan Dà Fhichead Dath: the list of the forty colours of the coal, each with its name, forty names in two columns, in the old strokes and in the humans' letters side by side.

Seònaid could not read either. Muireall read the names to her, down one row and up the other: the purples and the greens and the fire-colours, the white of gual sneachda³, the brown-red that is almost black. Seònaid knew most of them, as every carter of the hills did, for a carter who could not tell good coal from dross by its colour did not stay a carter long. She had never heard them said in a row before.

At the bottom of the leaf there was a note in a smaller hand. Muireall read that too. It said that the strangers had one word for all the coal of the vein, and that no word of the island answered it, and that they had not asked for the island's words.

"One word," said Seònaid.

"One."

"For all of that?"

Muireall wrapped the leaf again and laid it back in the chest.

"They cannot see it," she said. "My aunt was a long time understanding that. She thought at first they would not see it. It took her years to believe that they

1. the Harbour Articles; lit. 'the points of the harbour'

2. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

3. the snowflake coal, of air

could not." She shut the lid. "The one word is the word for what it burns like. It is a good word for that."

The rain stopped in the night. In the morning Seònaid roped the chest back into the pony-cart and saw it over the ford, and Muireall went on east alone towards Muileann chaol, three days away, a grey figure beside a grey pony, until the road turned behind the shoulder of the hill.

That winter, as the copyists count it, the mountain began to be dug by the ton. A' Chompanaidh⁴ had weighed its coal by the ton since the first contract. From AE 31 it cut by the ton as well: the crews were set a weight for the week, and the galleries driven to meet the weight, and the hill was worked for ends that no custom of the Dia-thirich would have chosen. At Dùn chrom the rope-walks that had spun cable for the fishing boats turned all their hemp to winding-rope for the pit-heads, and A' Chompanaidh paid well, and the town grew by half. Seònaid hauled the rope up to the hills in coils as thick as a man's thigh.

VI

Of the Going Down from Doire mhòr

In the spring of AE 32 word came up the road that A' Chompanaidh¹ had been chartered afresh in an Tìr Thall², with new money and a new name. The name was long, and the carters tried it out at their fires and gave it up, and went on calling it A' Chompanaidh. What they did take note of was that its agents at Ros dhomhain now outnumbered the clerks of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach³ four to one, and that a carter with a quarrel over a haul had stopped going to the office of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach at all. He went to the office of A' Chompanaidh, since that was where the quarrel would be settled.

The second summer of the carrying came, and the stream at Doire mhòr was not let go. The pond behind the bank had grown. The washing gang had raised the bank another two feet in the winter, and the drowned heather was gone under, and the brown water lay nearly to the oaks.

4. the Company

1. the Company

2. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

3. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

Seònaid went up to the village in an t-Ògmhios with a load of salt, and found it half empty.

The households had begun to go that spring, one family and then another, with no meeting called: a man away to the pits since the winter, his wife left carrying water for a field he would not come home to cut, and at last the wife packing the kist and the pots onto a borrowed pony and going down to him. Most went to the huts at Àth ìseal, where there was work breaking coal for the children and water that someone else carried. Others went on to Muileann chrom, or down the road to the capital. Seònaid passed them on the road, sitting on their bundles in the backs of carts.

The roll of Doire mhòr sets the first households' leaving under that year, and gives their names. Tormod, who had carried water up to Doire mhòr for two summers, went down to Àth ìseal with the rest.

Beathag Dhubh did not go. She stood at the door of the custodian's house as Seònaid unloaded the salt, with her arms folded, and watched the empty cottages across the green.

"You could go down to the council," Seònaid said. "Again."

"I have written to the council three times," said Beathag. "They have entered it three times." She took a pinch of the salt from the open sack and tasted it, and nodded. "They cannot give back a thing that nobody took."

In an t-Sultain of that year A' Chompanaidh began to load barges at Cidhe Beag. Cidhe Beag was the little quay on the Abhainn uaine, below Baile thais, where the river comes out of the hills wide enough to float a boat; it had been a canoe landing since before a' Scaradh⁴, a shelf of flat rock at the water's edge with a ferryman's hut above it, and a shrine on the rock, a grey stone the height of a child with a hollow worn in its top where the boatmen had left their offerings going out. A' Chompanaidh widened the shelf with cut stone into a quay, and built a chute down to it from the cart-road for the coal.

Seònaid brought the first loads down to it herself, and she was there when the masons came to the shrine. The foreman, a Dia-thìreach of Ros dhomhain who did not like the work, sent for the ferryman before he touched the stone. The ferryman was old and weary in the face. He looked at the stone, and at the chute, and asked where they meant to put it.

The foreman said: wherever the ferryman liked, so long as it was off the quay.

4. the Sundering; lit. 'the parting'

So the ferryman chose a place on the bank above, under a rowan, where the stone could still see the water; and four masons carried it up on a hurdle, with the ferryman walking in front, and set it down where he showed them, and the ferryman put a little meal in its hollow from his own pocket. Then the masons went back to their work, and the first barge was loaded before dark.

VII

Of the Green River

The Abhainn uaine is called the green river for the colour of the water under its alders, which in the old songs is the colour of a trout's back. That winter it turned black.

The washing-floors at Cnoc fhiadhaich and Muileann chrom, and the new ones built that year, all sent their dirt down into the streams, and the streams carried it into the Abhainn uaine. At first there was a dark edge along the banks after rain. Then the pools below the landing silted, and the gravel of the fords went under a grey mud that stank when it was stirred. By the turn of AE 33 the whole river from Cidhe Beag to the sea ran thick and dark, and the barges went down it to Seann Toll and the river mouth on water the colour of a slate roof.

The strangers called it black. To a Dia-thireach eye it was never only black. When the sun came through onto it at a bend there was colour in it, the colours of the coal ground to dust and gone to sludge, purple and bottle-green and a dull fire-colour, drifting in long streaks the way oil drifts on a puddle. Seònaid stood on the bridge at Cidhe Beag one bright morning with the ferryman and watched the streaks go under, and neither of them said anything about it. There was nothing to say that the other could not see.

At the river's mouth, at Ceann leathan, the fishermen had netted salmon on the spring run every year that anyone could remember. The town took its share at the mouth and let the rest go by to spawn in the gravel of the hills. In the spring of that year the run was thin. In the summer it was thinner. The last salmon netted at the mouth of the Abhainn uaine was taken that year, a hen fish of no great size, and the man who landed it is remembered by name at Ceann leathan, and he did not want to be; for he gutted it and found it empty of eggs. In the next spring no fish came in at all. The gravel where they had spawned was under the grey

mud, and the fish of the sea do not go up a river that has nothing for them at the top.

The fishers of Ceann leathan went on calling it the Abhainn uaine. They said it with their mouths turned down, and the bargemen laughed at them, and the fishers did not laugh back.

Other coal went north from Cidhe Beag by the river road to Baile Mòr dhomhain, the old walled market town on its deep river, and the town grew fat on it. Its people doubled in number, most of the newcomers bargemen from the coast who slept in the lofts over its stables; and the old families complained of them at every market and let them rooms at every chance. Seònaid hauled there twice that year. It had too many inns, she said, and none of them any good.

That was the year she married. Her husband was Pàdraig mac Artair, a carter of Doire chaol, the carters' village just east of the capital, a broad slow man who sang when he drove and was the only carter on the road who could outbargain her; and she said afterwards that she married him to have the benefit of it, which may have been true. They lived in her father's house at Cuan chrom. Their son Murchadh was born there the next winter, in the room above the byre, while the roofless carters' house stood by the quay with the frost in it.

VIII

Of the House at the Half-way

In the first month of AE 34 a surveyor of A' Chompanaidh¹ went out to a valley in the hills north-west of Muileann chrom with a chain and a book of squared paper, and laid out a town. He drew it before a stone of it was set, streets set square to one another and a row of little houses all alike on either side, with a store and a pay office at the end. The camp was called Baile dhomhain, the first town of the Dia-thìrich drawn on paper before it was built. Within two seasons it was full, a hundred souls and more. Seònaid hauled timber for its roofs. She said to Pàdraig that it was a town for people who would not be staying, and he asked her where else they would go, and she did not answer.

That spring the traffic on the road was heavier than it had ever been, and every night there were carters at Cuan chrom with nowhere to sleep. Some slept in their

1. the Company

carts, and some in her father's byre until there was no more room in it, and the rest built fires under the broken walls of the old carters' house and drank and quarrelled there; and in an Giblean one of them knocked another into the ford.

Seònaid went and stood in the roofless house the next morning. The two hearths were still there, at either end, under a litter of fallen thatch and nettles. The walls stood to the height of a man. The lintel over the western door was a single stone with a groove cut in it, worn smooth by the hands of the carriers of An Aois Naomh² who had touched it going in, and of every carrier since.

She went home and told her father and Pàdraig that she meant to put the roof back.

Her father thought it a great deal of money. Pàdraig thought it a good idea, and went round the carters of Doire chaol, and came back with twenty of them who would give a week's work each for a year's lodging at half the price. Seònaid went to the custodians of Cuan chrom, who held the quay, and they gave her the house for a rent of one cheese a year, since nobody else had wanted it for twenty years and more. The timber for the roof came up from the oak country of Doire fhiadhaich, on carts she sent south for it. The slates came from the quarry at Àth chiar. The strangers' iron was in the nails and the hinges, and nowhere else.

She opened the doors on the first day of Lùnastal, 1 an Lùnastal, AE 34, on the feast, with a fire lit at both hearths and a bowl of new ale for any carter who came in; and she kept the old name, An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, because nobody on the road had ever called it anything else.

On the first night a carter from the hills came in with his crew, and asked the price of a bed and a supper, and when she told him, he put down a round cheese and a fleece on the table.

"I have no marks," he said. "Not till the week's end."

A carter of the capital, at the other end of the table, laughed and said that she would want marks. Every house on the road wanted marks now. A' Chompanaidh paid in marks and the stores sold in marks, and a cheese was a cheese.

Seònaid picked up the cheese and turned it over and smelt it. Then she weighed it in her two hands.

"That is a bed and a supper," she said. "And the fleece is two."

The carter from the capital stopped laughing. "And if I pay in marks?"

"Then it is a bed and a supper for marks. The same bed. The same supper." She put the cheese on the shelf behind her. "I will take the one or the other. I will

take them at the same rate. And I will not ask which a man has before I tell him the price."

That was the rule of the house, and she had it cut on a board and hung over the hearth at the eastern end, in the old strokes, since that was what most of the hill carters could read: *Bonn no bathar, an aon bhobhla*. Coin or goods, the same bowl. She kept it all the years she kept the house, the only keeper on the road who took both; and the carters of the hills, who had cheese and wool and no marks, came to her, and the carters of the capital came to her also, since the ale was good.

In an t-Sultain the road-gangs of A' Chompanaidh finished metalling the carriers' road from the capital by Doire chaol and Cuan chrom and the ford of Àth chiar, up to the workings in the hills, broad enough for two coal-carts to pass. They laid it in crushed stone and rolled it with an iron roller that twelve men pulled. At every mile there stood an old post with the crown's sign cut in it, the posts that had marked the road since An Aois Scaraidh², and the road-gangs left them standing, since it was less trouble to go round. The carters, whose road it had been since An Aois Naomh, began to call it Rathad na Mèinne⁴, as if it had been made the day before. Seònaid called it that too, after a while.

I X

Of the Carters at Her Table

The carters of Doire chaol met first in her house in the winter, round the eastern hearth, because they were on the road and it was the only house on the road where they could all afford to sit down.

There were some thirty of them in the end, with Pàdraig among them, and they had one grievance, which was the rate. A' Chompanaidh¹ paid by the ton for coal hauled from the hills to the capital, and set the rate at its office in Ros dhomhain, and had lowered it twice in two years; and a carter who would not haul at the new rate found carters from the coast who would. Each man had gone to the office in his turn. None had gone together.

They sat in Seònaid's house through the dark of the year and argued it. Some of them were for refusing the hauls outright. Some of them were for going to the

2. the Holy Age

3. the Age of Sundering

4. the mine road

custodians. Pàdraig, who was slow, and who had listened to his wife count carts in her sleep for three years, said that they should go to the office all together, all thirty, on the same day, and ask for the old rate, and that no man should take a haul at the new one until they had it. And they swore to that at her table, on the ale, with their hands on the board with the rule on it; and in an Giblean of AE 35 the carters' guild of Doire chaol went down to Ros dhomhain, thirty carts in a line, and stood in the yard of A' Chompanaidh.

It was the first Dia-thìreach guild of the age. A' Chompanaidh might have broken it with the carters from the coast; but those men did not know the road or the fords, and they lost wheels and loads in the ditches; and the clerks at Ros dhomhain did the sum, and found that it came cheaper to bargain with thirty men who knew the road than to break them. So A' Chompanaidh let the guild stand. It sent an agent up to meet the carters. And since the carters would not come to Ros dhomhain again, the agent came to them, to the house at the half-way stage of the road, where they met.

The agent was Amos Tanner, older and heavier now, who had been given the carriage of the coal as his charge. He came up Rathad na Mèinne² on a grey horse on a hot evening at the start of an t-Iuchar, and tied the horse at the door, and ducked his head under the grooved lintel, and stood a while at the eastern end of the room reading the board over the hearth, or looking at it, since he could not read it.

"What does it say?" he asked her.

She told him.

He thought about it. "And the ale, if I pay you in marks?"

"The same," said Seònaid, and gave him a bowl.

The carters were at the long table under the window. Tanner sat down at its head, with his book in front of him, and Pàdraig sat down at its foot. The first thing Tanner told them was that the landing at Seann Toll on the Abhainn uaine had been taken for a coal stage three days before: that A' Chompanaidh had built a loading-stage of timber there below the workings, and moved the town's fishing boats to the next reach down, and that from now on a good part of the coal of the hills would go down the black river by barge to Ceann leathan, and on by ship, and never come near the capital at all. There would be less hauling on the road.

1. the Company

2. the mine road

The carters had seen the barges at Cidhe Beag, and heard it without surprise. Pàdraig asked how much less.

Tanner told him. Then he named the rate for what was left.

Pàdraig named the old rate back to him. Tanner shook his head and named a figure halfway between. Pàdraig looked down the table at the others and then at his wife, who was standing at the hearth with the jug, and she did not move, and he named the old rate again.

Seònaid filled the bowls. The windows were open for the heat, and the long light lay across the table between the agent's ledger and the carters' hands. Across the room at the other hearth a hill carter was paying for his supper with a basket of eggs, and she went and took them from him, and counted them, and gave him his change in a quarter of a cheese.

At the long table they were still bargaining when the light went. She lit the lamps.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

OF RASHNALL MAOR

AE 36 – 41

I

Of the Barges Going Down

In the winter of the thirty-sixth year the coal of the hills began to go to sea by the river.

A' Chompanaidh's stage at Seann Toll stood finished below the workings, three miles down the valley from Muileann chrom, a loading-stage of timber with a crane on it, where the town's boats had been drawn up for as long as the town had stood. The barges loaded there. They went down the Abhainn uaine on

1. the Company

the current, and at Ceann leathan, where the river comes out through the flats into the southern sea, A' Chompanaidh's ships lay at the mouth and took the coal aboard in baskets. From there the ships went out by Slighe-mhara Caol fhiadhaich², west along the south coast to the wild strait and the open sea, and round, the long way, north-about, for home.

The fishers of the south coast had worked that lane for five hundred years. On 31 am Faoilleach, AE 36, the custodians' roll of Ceann leathan enters that a coal ship coming out on the ebb ran down a fishing boat of the town off the river bar, and that the two men in her were taken out of the water alive by their neighbours, and the boat was not. The harbour-men said afterwards that she was too big to stop, and that likely nobody aboard her had seen the boat at all. Within a season the boats of Ceann leathan had learned to keep inshore of the ships' track and to lie to at the bar when a hull came down.

Ragnall mac Dhòmhnaill walked down to Seann Toll the week the first barges loaded, to see it for himself. He stood on the new stage in the rain among A' Chompanaidh's men, and watched his own crews' coal go into the hold of a barge and the barge go off round the bend of the river with the current under her. The water of the Abhainn uaine had been green when he was a boy. It ran the colour of slate now.

He was forty-five that winter, and had led crews on the hill since the first ton was weighed. He had three crews under him and a leader's share on every ton they cut, a son grown tall, a wife who could reckon faster than the clerk, iron picks for every man he worked with, and lamp-oil to spare. As he walked home up the valley, a hewer he had known all his life stood aside for him on the stones of the ford, which had never happened before.

II

Of the Staff

The agent sent for him in an Cèitean.

The agent of A' Chompanaidh¹ at the pits of Muileann chrom in those years was Enoch Pratt, a narrow, bald, careful man who had come up from

2. the southern sea-lane

1. the Company

Ros dhomhain the year before the fall under the wild hill and had not been down again since. He kept the office of dressed stone at the pit-mouth, with a stove in the corner that burned the hill's coal day and night, and he used his Dia-thìris sparingly, as a man spends coin in a strange market.

This time Pratt came round the desk and shook Ragnall's hand, as the humans did with each other. Then he took up a thing that had been leaning against the stove, and held it out across his two palms.

It was a staff of ash, a little taller than a man's shoulder, straight and pale and new, with a cap of brass at the head and a ferrule of iron at the foot. On the brass were cut the letters of A' Chompanaidh, and under them a small ship with three masts.

"For you," said Pratt in Dia-thìris. For the rest he sent for the young man of Ros dhomhain who had put A' Chompanaidh's words into the island's at the first contract, and who was not young now.

A' Chompanaidh, the interpreter said, had watched the crews of Muileann chrom since the first ton. Ragnall's crews cut more than any on the hill, and other men listened to him, and its agents could not stand at every face. It wished to set one man of the island over all the crews of the hill of Muileann chrom: to see the work done, to keep the tally of the tubs, to put men on and put them off, and to answer for all of it to the agent. For this he would have a wage paid in marks, weekly, whatever the tubs came to; a house, to be built at A' Chompanaidh's charge; and this staff, so that any man on the hill might know him.

Ragnall looked at the staff for a long time. He did not take it.

"Over the crews," he said at last. "Over the hewers of the hill. Over my own people."

The interpreter put it into the humans' tongue. Pratt answered without any pause.

"Over the work," the interpreter said. "The agent says, over the work. The men are your people still."

Ragnall knew what the old men would say, and what his father would say, standing on the step and not coming in. He knew too what the hill had been these last years: the eleven under the fall, the boys coughing at the benches, the agent's men with their watches shouting at crews who had not the words to shout back. He thought that if there must be a man set over the crews it had better be a man who could say the words at the face and knew where the ground was bad. Then there was the wage in marks, every week, in rain or drought; and there was

his son. Afterwards, when men asked him why, he gave each of these reasons at one time or another, and every one of them was true.

On 19 an Cèitean, AE 36, he put out his hands and took the staff, and the clerk wrote it down. Ragnall mac Dhòmhnail was forty-six years old.

It was lighter than it looked. He walked home with it down the mill street in the evening, holding it a little away from his body, as a man carries a thing he has been lent. The men on the bench outside the smithy stopped talking as he came by, and looked at the staff, and then at the ground. At his own door his son Dòmhnall was sitting on the step mending the strap of a coal-basket, and he looked up, and his hands stopped.

"What is it?" the boy said.

"It is A' Chompanaidh's," said Ragnall, and went in, and stood the staff in the corner by the hearth where the peat-spade stood, and it was taller than the spade.

Ciorstaidh asked him what the wage was, and he told her, and she did not reach for the beans to reckon it. She said it was a fair wage, and set the supper on the board.

Dòmhnall mac Raghnaill was sixteen that spring. He had broken coal at the benches from the autumn he turned six, the year of the dry cough, and lived, and at twelve had gone below into his father's crews. He was a long, rawboned lad with his grandfather's shoulders and his mother's quick eyes and a way of watching before he spoke. All through supper his eyes went to the staff in the corner with the firelight on its brass, and he did not ask about it again.

III

Of the Slate Roof

The house went up that summer on a shelf of the hillside above the mill, where the ground had been common grazing, with A' Chompanaidh's masons from Ros dhomhain to build it and A' Chompanaidh's carts to bring the stone. It had two rooms below and a loft above, glass in the windows, and a roof of slate, the first in Muileann chrom, where the hill roofed with heath-

1. the Company

er and rushes. When the roof was done it stood out above the mill from as far off as the ford, and threw back the light like the water of a loch.

On 17 an t-Ògmhios, AE 36, the roll of Taigh na Fèithe² enters, in the hand of Marsaili nic Sheumais, that Ragnall mac Dhòmhnail of Muileann chrom has taken A' Chompanaidh's staff and a house with a roof of slate, and is set over the crews of the hill. It is the last entry in that roll to give him his father's name alone.

It was the miller's wife who said the other name first, or so the hill told it. She was a sharp woman, and she had known Ragnall since he was a boy stealing her apples. The week the family moved into the new house she stood at the mill door and watched him go by up the road with the staff, and said to the women at the well, loud enough to carry, "There goes Ragnall Maor to his castle."

The women laughed. The name went down the hill before nightfall. By the end of the summer it was the only name the crews used.

The Dia-thìrich had called the strangers' governor at Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir³ An t-Àrd-mhaor⁴ since the first of them came, the high steward. A maor was the lesser thing: a bailiff, a man who held another man's keys and gathered another man's rents. The name said whose keys Ragnall held.

He heard it before the summer was out. He was going along the heaps at the pit-mouth with the tally-board, counting tubs, and one of the boys at the benches said it behind him, not meaning him to hear. Ragnall turned round. The boy went white. Ragnall looked at him, and then went on counting, and did not turn round again; and that night he sat long at the fire in the slate-roofed house and listened to the rain on the roof. It made a harder, thinner sound than rain on thatch, and he found he did not like it.

IV

Of the Number in the Roll

A' Chompanaidh did not stop at one.

Within the year there were overseers at Achadh dhomhain, where the new galleries were being opened into the hill, at Àth iséal among the timber huts, at Cnoc fhiadhaich over the old fall, and at the pits along the valley to-

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

3. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

4. the Commissioner; lit. 'the high steward'

wards Seann Toll; and at each of them a man of the island with an ash staff and a brass cap, answerable to the agent.

Marsaili nic Sheumais had entered Ragnall in the roll by name. She entered the second overseer by name, and the third, and the fourth. Then she laid down her pen, and closed the roll, and walked over the hill to Taigh na Fèithe¹ to put it to the custodians of the vein.

What the custodians said to her is not in the roll. What the roll holds is the entry of 21 an Lùnastal, AE 37, in Marsaili's hand, which reads: "Over the crews of the hill, set by the strangers, overseers: seven." There are no names. The next year the number is nine, and the year after that it is twelve, and the roll goes on so, a number under the date, through all the years after. Asked why, she said that the roll was for the vein and for those who kept it.

Ragnall could not read, but he knew what was in the roll, as everyone on the hill knew, and one evening at Taigh na Fèithe, where he had gone with the tally for the custodians as crew-leaders had always done, he asked Marsaili to read him the line.

She read it. "Overseers: seven."

"And my name?"

She turned back the leaves to the summer before and found it and read it out: Ragnall mac Dhòmhnai of Muileann chrom, the staff, the slate roof. Then she turned the leaves forward again and closed the book.

"That is the last of it," she said. "There will be no other."

Ragnall stood a while in the doorway of Taigh na Fèithe with his staff. Then he said good night, and Marsaili said good night, and he walked home in the dark over the hill and did not light his lamp.

Ragnall was good at the work, and that was the worst of it. Knowing where the roof was rotten, and which roof had the sick colour in it that no human could see, he could tell the agent so, and sometimes the agent listened. That year there was no fall on the hill of Muileann chrom, and the tonnage went up, and Pratt wrote to Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir² in praise of the first overseer of the island.

What he minded was the singing. The crews had always sung below, the old slow songs of the vein that go with the swing of a pick, and he had sung with them for twenty-five years. Now he would come along a gallery with his lamp and his staff and hear the singing ahead of him in the dark, and it would stop before

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

he reached it, and the men would be working without a word, and would look up and say "Raghnall," civilly, and wait for him to go by. When he had gone by, after a while, the singing began again behind him.

His son was in one of those crews. Dòmhnall said nothing about it at home, and Raghnall did not ask.

V

Of Seumas Dubh

Seumas Dubh had come into Raghnall's crews as a lad of fifteen, in the fourth year of the pit.

He had been born in the winter before the ships came down from the north, a black-haired hewer's son of the valley below Muileann chrom, strong and quick and given to laughing. When A' Chompanaidh¹ opened its new pits at Cnoc mhòr, a morning's walk south of the hill over the moor, and asked Raghnall for a man to set over them, Raghnall gave Seumas's name; and Seumas took the staff and went south in the spring of the thirty-seventh year with a cart of tools and his wife and his two children, to a crew of the new men of Cnoc mhòr who had never worked a seam before.

The pits at Cnoc mhòr were driven down a slope, and the coal came up out of them in tubs on a haulage, a rope of hemp from the rope-walks of Dùn chrom running over a drum at the top that a horse turned. A' Chompanaidh wanted the tubs hurried. Maddox's orders were still to double the yield. Seumas hurried them. He ran the tubs up three at a time on the one rope, which the crews said it would not bear, and set the boys to run the empties down the slope so that the horse need not stop.

On 14 an Lùnastal, AE 38, the rope parted with three full tubs on it. They came back down the slope and through the gallery-mouth, and a boy was coming up the rails with an empty and could not get out of the way. His name was Coinneach Beag and he was eleven. The custodians' roll of Cnoc mhòr has his name and his age, and the name of his mother; A' Chompanaidh's report of the day gives "a boy" and the cost of the rope.

What happened then happened below, in the dark, and the men who were there did not tell it the same way twice. Seumas came down the slope with his

staff when he heard the tubs go, and went into the gallery-mouth, where the crew had the boy out from under the iron and were kneeling round him. Somebody said something. Seumas said something back. It is told that he said the boy should have jumped, and it is told that he said nothing of the kind and only asked whether the tubs were broken; and either way a hewer stood up with a pick-helve in his hand. When the agent's man came down the slope with a lantern there were two dead in the gallery-mouth, the boy and the overseer, and the crew standing about them, and nobody running. Seumas Dubh was thirty-eight years old.

Before that month was out A' Chompanaidh hanged two men at Ros dhomhain for the killing of him.

Maddox ordered the overseers down to see it. Every man of the island who held A' Chompanaidh's staff was to be at Ros dhomhain on the day and stand in front. Pratt told it to Ragnall in his office without looking at him, and then the interpreter told it again in Dia-thiris.

Ragnall went, thirty-five miles by the road in A' Chompanaidh's cart with the four other overseers of the hill, and none of them said much. They lay a night at the carters' house. Seònaid Bhàn served them and took their marks and said nothing, but the carters at the other end of the room drank up and went out.

They hanged them on the open ground between the lake shore and the rise where Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir² stands, on a frame of new timber put up the day before, with the guards of A' Chompanaidh round it in a square. It was a still, bright day at the end of summer, and the lake behind the gallows lay flat as a board. A great crowd had come, humans and Dia-thìrich both, and they made almost no sound. The overseers were put in a row inside the square, in front of the crowd, with their staffs, where the crowd could see them. There were fourteen of them, from all the workings of the island. Ragnall stood at the end of the row nearest the gallows.

The two men were brought out of the guardhouse under the rise with their hands tied. One was a big man with a cut over his eye, and the other was young. The roll of Cnoc mhòr gives their names, Eòin Ruadh and Fionnlagh mac Aonghais, hewers of that town, and the day, and that they were carried home and buried in the town's ground on their neighbours' shoulders; the letter-book of Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir gives "two of the crew." A clerk read the sentence in the humans'

1. the Company

2. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

tongue from a paper, and nobody put it into Dia-thìris. A chaplain of Teachdaireachd na h-Eaglaise³ said a prayer, which nobody put into Dia-thìris either.

As they were brought past the row of overseers the young one, Fionnlagh, turned his head and looked along them. He looked at every face, one after another, as though he were counting them, and when he came to the end of the row he looked at the staff with its brass cap in Ragnall's hand, and then at Ragnall. He did not say anything. Then they took him up.

Ragnall watched it. He had been ordered to, and he found afterwards that he could not have looked away if he had tried. He had carried the fever dead of Cuan shean and dug out the eleven, and had thought there was no way of dying left that he had not seen. This was slow. The crowd made one long sound when the young man's feet left the cart, and then was silent, and in the silence Ragnall could hear the water of the lake lapping at the shore stones behind the gallows, and a gull.

The roll of the custodians of Ros dhomhain enters that day as the first on which a man of the island was put to death by the strangers' law on the island's ground. It enters too, in a line of its own, that the overseers of A' Chompanaidh stood in front.

On the road home they lay again at Seònaid's house, and one of the overseers of the hill, a man of Àth ìseal, left his staff leaning against her wall when he went up to bed. In the morning it was gone. He told the agent he had lost it, and A' Chompanaidh gave him another.

Ragnall kept his. He carried it into the house above the mill and stood it in the corner by the hearth, and sat down at the fire with his hands on his knees, as his father had sat on the night of the first ton, and did not speak all evening. Ciorstaidh put his supper by him and took it away again cold. Dòmhnall, who was eighteen now, sat across the fire and watched him. At last the young man got up and made up the fire and went to bed. On the stair to the loft he stopped and said, without turning:

"The men at the face are saying that you gave Seumas Dubh his staff."

"I did," said Ragnall.

Dòmhnall waited, but there was no more, and he went up.

3. the Mission; lit. 'the errand of the Church'

VI

Of the Priest at the Gate

A few weeks after the hanging Maddox barred the priests of the hawk from the camps.

The order came down from Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir¹ on 12 an t-Sultain, AE 38, and the overseers read it at every pit-mouth on the hill. It said that the priests of Òrd an t-Seabhaig² were not to come within the bounds of any working or any camp of A' Chompanaidh³, for their preaching slowed the work and put the crews in fear. It said nothing of the chaplains. The chaplains of Teachdaireachd na h-Eaglaise⁴ kept their chapels of plank in every camp as before.

The hawk had many friends in the camps. Men who worked below found the old teaching of Mòd, An Seabhag Acrach⁵, easier to believe than most things: that the land feeds whoever eats in measure, and the hawk starves whoever eats faster than the land can feed him. The hawk-priests came up from the west in ones and twos, with a hawk's feather bound in the hair behind the ear, and preached at the pit-mouths at the change of shift.

Several of the overseers were hawk-faithful themselves. The roll of Taigh na Fèithe⁶ says so, under the number, which is the only thing it ever says about them.

Ragnall was at the gate of the camp at Àth ìseal the week the order came, with Iomhar Bàn, the overseer of the huts there, a heavy grey man of the coast who had worn the hawk's feather behind his ear at every feast since he was a boy, and had taken it out when he took the staff. A priest came along the road from the west in the evening. He was old, with a bag on his back, and the crews coming off the shift began to gather at the gate.

Iomhar went out into the road to meet him. Ragnall stayed at the gate, and heard it.

"You cannot come in, father," said Iomhar. "It is A' Chompanaidh's order."

"I have not come for A' Chompanaidh," said the priest.

"The crews are A' Chompanaidh's while they are inside the fence. I will lose the staff, father. I have children."

1. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

2. the Hawk order

3. the Company

4. the Mission; lit. 'the errand of the Church'

5. the Hungry Hawk

6. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

The priest looked at him a while. Then he put down his bag in the road and sat on it. "Then the crews may come out," he said.

They came out. They came out through the gate past Ragnall and Iomhar, forty and fifty of them, black from the shift, and sat down in the road round the old man in the dusk, and he preached to them there, outside the fence, where the order did not run. When the sermon was done and the men were going back in, he went out into the road himself, and knelt in the mud, and the priest put his hand on his head.

Ragnall did not kneel. He had never been much given to the hawk. He stood at the gate and watched, and when Iomhar came back past him with mud to his knees neither of them said anything about it, then or after. Pratt heard of the sermon in the road and wrote to Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir that the order had been obeyed, as it had.

VII

Of the Spotted Pox

In the autumn of the thirty-ninth year a ship of A' Chompanaidh¹ came up the Abhainn gheal into the lake and tied up at the quays of Ros dhomhain with sickness aboard, and on 11 an Dàmhair, AE 39, the custodians of Ros dhomhain entered the first of their dead of A' Bhreac Bhallach, the spotted pox.

It did not stay on the quays. It went up Rathad na Mèinne² as the coal came down, stage by stage, and in the last days of an Dàmhair it came into the camps.

Dòmhnall mac Raghnaill turned twenty that autumn. He was a hewer at the face in the gallery below Cnoc fhiadhaich, and his crew was the first on the hill to lose a man, a carter's son of Àth ìseal who had fetched a cask up from the ford. The fever came first, then the spots, which filled and broke. Some lived and were marked for life. More died, the children most, in the huts at Àth ìseal where the families lay six and seven to a room, and at Achadh dhomhain, which was the worst on the hill.

A' Chompanaidh did not stop the pits. The ships lay at Ceann leathan waiting for their loads. It was the overseers who went round the huts each morning with

1. the Company

2. the mine road

the agent's list to see which men were fit for the face, and stood in the doorways, and saw what was inside, and went on to the next. Dòmhnall went down to the face every day that winter with the men who were left, and in the evenings he carried with the others. They buried the pox dead in new ground below Achadh dhomhain, stony ground, dug by lamplight.

Twice that winter Dòmhnall saw his father at the burying ground with the staff in his hand, standing at the edge, where the agent's clerk stood with A' Chompanaidh's book. He did not go to him. Once, coming up from the pits with a hurdle, he found his father at the door of a hut at Àth ìseal where a whole family was down, a hewer and his wife and four children, with no one to fetch water; and Ragnall had put the staff down against the wall and was carrying the water in himself, two buckets at a time from the ford, with the brass of the staff shining by the door where anyone going by could see it. Dòmhnall stopped. His father looked up and saw him, and said, "Take the other buckets," and Dòmhnall took them.

Teachdaireachd na h-Eaglaise³ kept a count. The chaplain at Àth ìseal, a young man lately come over the sea, went among the huts with a vinegar cloth over his mouth and wrote down every dead man, woman and child he could find, in a fair hand; and his list went down to Ros dhomhain with the lists of the other chaplains, and the chaplains' count of the whole sickness was twenty-seven.

The custodians kept a count also. Marsaili nic Sheumais went round the hill in the spring with her book, from hearth to hearth and camp to camp, and wrote down the dead as the households gave them to her, the ones the chaplains had not found and the ones who had gone home to die among their own people. Then the custodians of the hill asked the chaplains for a copy of their list, and the chaplain gave it to them readily, for he was proud of it; and they wrote their own names in the margin of it, down the whole length of both sides, in the old letters, with the total at the foot. They sent it back to Ros dhomhain, where it was filed.

The pox went on south from the harbour through the winter and into the next year. On 9 an t-Samhain, AE 40, it reached Baile chiar, a day's walk down the country from Ros dhomhain, and the villages about it. The carters brought the news up the road in the spring of the fortieth year, and with it the news of what the custodians of Baile chiar had done: they had set the town's masons to cut the names of every one of their dead into the stone lintel over the door of the council

3. the Mission; lit. 'the errand of the Church'

house, the whole length of it, so that no one might go in to the council without passing under them.

At Muileann chrom the pox burned out with the spring. In an Cèitean the pits were full again, with new men from the coast in the dead men's places.

VIII

Of the Last Door at Doire mhòr

In the dead of the next winter news came up the road that Riaghaltas nan Coigreach¹ had moved its customs house from Baile dhìreach to Ros dhomhain, on 31 am Faoilleach, AE 41, and that the harbour dues the little town had shared with the strangers since the fifth year would go now to the strangers alone. The mixed council there, left with half an income, cut itself from six to four. Seònaid Bhàn said at her table that it was the first time the strangers had taken back a thing they had shared.

In the spring of the forty-first year Beathag Dhubh died at Doire mhòr.

She was sixty-one years old. She had been custodian of Doire mhòr on the day A' Chompanaidh²'s agent climbed up with the first contract under his coat, and she had heard him out at her door and sent him down the hill again, and the road had gone round her fields. Then the stream had been dammed, and one household after another had gone down. By the fortieth year there were only a few hearths left lit on Doire mhòr, and the bed of the stream below her door was dry stones with nettles growing in it. She would not go down. The households that had gone sent meal up to her, and peat, and she took it.

The word came down to Muileann chrom on a wet morning of an Giblean. By noon the hill was walking up to Doire mhòr, many of them households who had lived on Doire mhòr and gone down; and the crews came up from the galleries with the black on them and did not stop to wash. Pratt did not stop them. He looked out of his window at the road and said something to his clerk, and the clerk did not write it down.

Dòmhnall went up with his crew. At the bend where A' Chompanaidh's cart-road curved wide round Beathag's fields, the people left it and went straight up

1. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

2. the Company

over the old walls, the way the path had gone before the road was made, through grass unmown and wet to the thigh.

She was laid out in her own house on the board, in her dark gown, with coal of Doire mhòr's own cutting at her head and her feet, as the custodians of the hill have always been laid out. The house was too small for the people who came. They went in by the door and out by the back in a slow line, the whole of the afternoon, and each one as they went by her laid a hand on the board, or on the coal. Outside they stood in the wet among the empty houses, some hundreds of them, and waited.

Dòmhnall was in the line with his crew when he saw his father.

Ragnall had come up by himself, late. He did not have the staff. He had left it, Dòmhnall learned afterwards, leaning in the corner of the slate-roofed house, and had walked the eight miles in his old coat and his hewer's boots; and he stood now at the back of the crowd by the wall of the last empty cottage, bare-headed in the rain, where the people could see him and could choose not to. Nobody spoke to him. Nobody moved away from him either. He did not go into the line, and he did not come forward when they carried her out to the burying-ground under the oaks; but he stood where he was, at the back, until the last of the earth was in, and then he was gone down the hill before anyone else had turned for home.

The roll of Doire mhòr that Beathag Dhubh kept in her own hand ends a few leaves after the year the stream stopped, with the names of the households that went down. The last leaf of it is in another hand, and gives her name, her age and the day, and that the hill came up. Marsaili nic Sheumais entered the same in the roll of Taigh na Fèithe³, and a line more: "The last door of Doire mhòr that did not open."

IX

Of the Bound Book

henry Maddox left Dia-thìr that summer, in the seventeenth year of his office, a rich man.

The hill saw his going only in the carts. For a week the carts went down Rathad na Mèinne¹ loaded with his goods, and a clock taller than a man

3. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

lashed upright in a cart of its own; and at the quays of Ros dhomhain it all went into the ship that had brought his successor. The carters who hauled it said that he had come out with one chest.

Arthur Lisle came to Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir² in his place. He was forty-one years old, a lawyer, thin and clean-shaven, with a bad knee and a dry voice, and he came up the Abhainn gheal to the lake in the grey weather with two clerks and a chest of books and no letter in his pocket from anyone.

On 28 an t-Iuchar, AE 41, his first order went out from Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir in his own small hand. Every compact, charter, contract and agreement made between the strangers and the island since the leave was given was to be found, wherever it lay, and copied fair, and bound in one book.

A rider of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach³ came up the hill to Pratt's office in the week after with a satchel and a letter, and carried down to Ros dhomhain the contract of the first thirty and the paper of the leader's share with Ragnall's mark at the foot. He asked too for the agreement by which the staff had been given; and Pratt found that there was none, and the rider wrote that down.

Ragnall Maor carried his staff through all of it, at the heaps and the gallery-mouths and the huts, in the forty-first year of the strangers and the fifty-first of his own age, and the crews stopped singing when he came by. He had learned to walk a little faster through the galleries than he used to, so that they might begin again the sooner. Dòmhnall was twenty-one that summer, a hewer at the face in his father's district, and he took his turn with the others at the singing.

Down at Ros dhomhain, on the evening the rider came in, Lisle had the papers of the hill laid on the table in his room at Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir with the rest, under the window that looks down across the gallows-ground to the lake. The clerks had carried up the old letter-books of Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir from the cellar that week, Pell's and Maddox's, more than thirty years of them, and stacked them against the wall. The first of them had Cùmhnant Cathair dhearg⁴ copied into it, in Pell's hand, on its opening leaf.

Lisle sent the clerks away. Then he sat down, and lit the lamp, and drew the first letter-book towards him across the table, and opened it at the first leaf, and began to read.

1. the mine road

2. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

3. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

4. the first written treaty, signed at Cathair dhearg; the Treaty in One Tongue

PART THREE

OF Silver, Steam and the GREEN Death

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Of the Ledgers at the Adit

AE 42 – 45

Chan eil an t-airgead naomb. Silver is not holy.

I

Of the Bound Book

Of all the hands in the letter-books of Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir¹, the copyists of the cellar learned Arthur Lisle's first. It is small and level and leans a little backward, like a man reading with his chair tipped from the table, and it never blots. He came to the island in the summer of the forty-first year of the strangers, a lawyer of forty-one, thin, clean-shaven, with a bad knee that he favoured on stairs, and he brought with him two clerks, a chest of books, and no letter from A' Chompanaidh² promising him a share of anything. Henry Maddox had gone home rich by the same ship.

His first order as An t-Àrd-mhaoir³ was that every agreement made between the island and the strangers since the day of the leave should be found, copied fair and bound in one book. The two clerks were at it all that winter in the long room over the stair of Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir, with the rain on the glass. They copied Cùmhnant Cathair dhearg⁴ and Puingean a' Chalaiddh⁵; the contracts of the pits one by one, with the crew-leaders' names spelled as the humans had heard them; the grants of foreshore at Ceann fhada, paid in nails by weight; the leases of the concession grazing; the orders about the hawk-priests; and at the back, in a separ-

1. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

2. the Company

3. the Commissioner; lit. 'the high steward'

4. the first written treaty, signed at Cathair dhearg; the 'Treaty in One Tongue'

5. the Harbour Articles; lit. 'the points of the harbour'

ate gathering, Cairt na Companaidh⁶. The charter had been made over the sea between A' Chompanaidh and its own masters, before any Dia-thìreach had seen it, and it bound nobody on the island; Lisle had it bound in all the same, because he wanted it where he could lay it beside the rest.

When the book came back from the binder at Ros dhomhain, in calf with brass at the corners, he read it through with a pen in his hand. The letter-books keep his notes on it, forty pages of them. Where the humans took something that no page gave them, he wrote *on what ground?* in the margin. Where the Dia-thìrich paid something that no page asked of them, he wrote *why do they pay?* He was a hard man and meant the island no particular kindness; but he could not bear an account that did not balance, and the first account he found out of balance was the northern coast.

The coal ships of A' Chompanaidh went home north-about, past the north cape, and along that coast lay fishing towns that had never been asked for a penny of harbour-due. Their boats went out to the coal ships as they passed and sold them fish and water and fresh greens, and took marks for it, and nobody had told them they owed any share of the marks to anyone. Lisle looked for the page that made them owe it and found none. So he made one. On 2 am Màrt, AE 42, a customs house was opened at Ros gheal on the northern coast, in a hired loft by the fish-steps, with a table, a book, a brass scale and an officer from the harbour office at Ros dhomhain to keep them.

Ros gheal was a hawk town, and had been since the pupils of Gormshuil founded the second house of Òrd an t-Seabhaig⁷ there in An Aois Scaraidh⁸. Its priests had kept the measured burning for all the country up the river to Cnoc bheag while Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig⁹ was still kept, and the fishing families there held that what the sea gave, the sea gave to the hand that went out for it. The officer had been in his loft eleven days when the hawk-faithful came down from the hawk-house at dusk, some thirty of them, fishermen and their wives and a priest with his hood up. They carried out the table with the book still open on it and set it down in the street. They carried out the scale and the officer after it. Then they walked him, not unkindly, to the last house on the road south and left him there with his book under his arm.

6. the Company's charter

7. the Hawk order

8. the Age of Sundering

9. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

He came back in a month with a letter from Lisle and two clerks to bear him company, and he kept the loft through the summer. At the herring in the autumn the town put him in a boat with his table, his scale and his clerks and rowed him two miles down the coast and set him ashore on a beach with no road. The roll of Ros gheal says only that the officer "went away by water." The letter-book says a good deal more. Lisle wrote under the report, in his level hand, that the town had broken no page, since no page yet bound the town, and that he would write one.

The news went east along the carriers' roads, as news did, and came up the valley to Muileann chiar at the back end of the year, told at the smelting-floors by a carter with his hands held out to the heat. Ùna nic Choinnich heard it standing in the door of the guild hall with a ledger under her arm. The carter told it for a laugh, the fishwives and the table in the street, and the men at the floors laughed. Ùna did not.

"He reads," she said. "That one reads what he signs. Mark him."

II

Of the Silver Town

Muileann chiar lay in the far east of the hills, on a shelf of the valley under the moor, a day's walk above the southern sea and an hour's walk from the old walls of Talla na Lasrach¹ at Dùn ìseal. It was a small town, a few score households in stone under turf and slate, with the adit in the hillside above the last houses and the smelting-floors below them by the stream, and in those years it was the only place on the island where the smoke that went up from the work was not the smoke of coal. The guild burned charcoal from the eastern woods and peat from the moor, as the first silver-workers had done. There was a sweet, sharp smell over the whole valley that the carters said they could taste in their bread for a day after.

The silver had been found in An Aois Naomh², near the great vein but apart from it, and the first question anyone had asked of it was whether it belonged to the mountain. Muireach Liath answered it then. Silver shows no colour when it breaks, he said; it breaks grey and bright and the same all through, like water; and

1. the Hall of the Flame

2. the Holy Age

so it is not the mountain's. From those words Muileann chiar had been let dig as deep as it liked. From those words, too, every quarrel over the silver had begun. When Ruairidh Liath demanded one ring in five, Sliochd Fhearchair shut the workings for three seasons sooner than pay, and the road-guards went unpaid; that was Falachd an Airgid³, in which nobody died, and which Coimheadaiche na Lasrach⁴ at Dùn ìseal settled by giving each side half of what it asked. The weights of Muileann chiar had been the lawful weights of every road on the island since that settlement. Twice in An Aois Scaraidh⁵ Clann Choinnich had asked the queen's council for leave to burn coal beyond the measured handful for the smelt, since the coal burns hotter than charcoal; and twice the council had refused, the second time by one voice. The last asking still lay in Taigh na Fèithe⁶, unanswered, when the strangers came.

Ùna was of Clann Choinnich by her father and of the refiners' families by her mother, and she had been head of Comann an Airgid⁷ for eleven years. She was fifty-seven in the winter this telling begins: a short square woman with a burn-scar up the inside of one forearm, grey hair plaited and pinned flat so that it would not catch, and a voice that did not rise. As a girl of twenty she had carried the guild's rings down to the humans' counter at Ros dhomhain in the years of fair exchange, and she had learned their tongue across Pike's counter, word by word, the way the carters learned it; and later, in a winter when the snow shut the valley, a clerk of A' Chompanaidh⁸ who was lodging in the town had paid for his board by teaching her the humans' letters. She read them slowly. She read everything slowly, and forgot none of it.

The guild kept two ledgers, and they were the pride of the town.

The older was hardly a book at all. It was a stack of thin boards of ash, each notched along one edge in the stag-letters that the teachers of the grove had made out of the cutters' tally-marks at Muileann chiar long ago, bound between two planks with thongs through holes at the corners. In it was set down every member of the guild since the first, the name and the house and the year of taking-on, and every gallery driven into the seam, and who had driven it, and how far. The newer ledger was a book of the island's own paper in the island's own letters, begun in

3. the Silver Feud; lit. 'the feud of the silver'

4. the Keeper of the Hall; lit. 'the watcher of the flame'

5. the Age of Sundering

6. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

7. the silver guild of Muileann chiar

8. the Company

An Aois Scaraidh and kept since in a dozen hands. In it were the weighings: every bar and every ring that went out of Muileann chiar, to whom, and for what, down to the last ring traded for salt fish. Between them the two ledgers held the whole life of the seam from An Aois Naomh to that winter, and in all their boards and leaves there was not one word of the humans' tongue.

On 3 am Faoilleach, AE 43, a rider came up the valley in sleet with a letter in a leather case. It was from the agent of A' Chompanaidh at Muileann chrom, and it was written in the humans' tongue with a Dia-thìris version under it in a clerk's cramped hand. The agent gave notice that A' Chompanaidh, holding under its charter the first refusal of "all fuels, ores and minerals the island may yield," would send its surveyors to the silver seam at Muileann chiar with the spring, to measure the workings and value the yield, so that the silver might be brought under the same terms as the coal.

Ùna read it at her own table by the fire, first the Dia-thìris and then the humans' version, and then the humans' version again, with her finger under the words. The rider stood dripping by the door. When she had done she folded the letter along its creases and gave him a bowl of broth, and asked him whether he had come by the Muileann chrom road or the moor road, and how the fords were running. Then she sent her grandson round the houses to call the guild.

They came to the hall in the dark, forty-one of them, in their work-clothes with the ash still on them, and sat on the benches along the walls under the hanging scales. Ùna read the letter to them in both tongues. Nobody spoke for a while.

"The charter is theirs," said Seumas mac Fhearchair at last. He was the oldest refiner in the valley, seventy-three that winter, and his house had worked the seam longer than any. "They wrote it for themselves. What has it to do with us?"

"Nothing," said Ùna. "So they will say it has everything, until someone shows them where it stops."

"And who will show them?"

"The council," said a young man by the door, and a few of the others laughed, not kindly. The council at Cathair dhearg had been shown a good many things in forty years and had filed most of them.

Ùna let them laugh. "I will go and ask it," she said, "and I will see what it has in its chest."

III

Of the Council's Copies

She rode west in the second week of am Faoilleach with her grandson Fionnlagh, who was sixteen and had never been further than Dùn Ìseal, and a pack-pony with oats and a sack of silver rings for the road. It was fifty miles and more to the capital. They went by the moor road to Muileann chrom, where the smoke of A' Chompanaidh¹'s furnaces lay along the valley so thick that the boy put his sleeve over his mouth, and then down Rathad na Mèinne², cart-ruts frozen hard as iron, among the long lines of coal-carts going west. It took them three days. At the inns the carters talked of the Ros gheal fishwives, and the tale grew every night.

Coinneach Glas received her in the room behind the council hall, where the custodians' rolls were kept in presses along the walls. He was Ceann a' Chùraim³, and had been since the death of Tormod mac Ailein twenty-three years before; he had come to the seat at forty-five and was sixty-eight that winter. He had never set eyes on a human before An t-Aiseag⁴, the council's clerks said, and had dealt with little else since. His hair and beard had gone the grey that gave him his byname long before he was old, and now his skin was going the same way. He had a cough that he did not trouble to hide, and a brazier by his chair, and a rug over his knees. He heard her through without a word, and then sat for a long time looking at the brazier.

"I asked them to keep the tally," he said. "In the twenty-third year. I asked them to burn no more coal in a year than the hill could give. They sent me a copy of their accounts." He coughed. "It was a very fine copy."

"I have not come for the council to write to them," said Ùna.

"No. I did not think so." He looked at her properly then. "What have you come for?"

"Cùmhnant Cathair dhearg⁵," she said. "And whatever else was signed. The council's own copies."

1. the Company

2. the mine road

3. the high custodian of the Council of Custodians; lit. 'head of the custody'

4. the Crossing; lit. 'the ferrying'

5. the first written treaty, signed at Cathair dhearg; the Treaty in One Tongue

The clerk who kept the presses made a small noise, and Coinneach Glas lifted one hand without looking round.

"They are in the humans' tongue," he said. "Only in that."

"I can read the humans' tongue."

He had the clerk bring them: Cùmhnant Cathair dhearg on six leaves of heavy paper, sewn with green thread, with Tormod mac Ailein's mark at the foot and Josiah Pell's name beside it in a great looping hand; and Puingean a' Chalaids⁶, which two custodians had refused to sign; and a bundle of the pit contracts tied with tape. No promise was asked of her that she would bring them back. Coinneach Glas only said, as she was wrapping them in oilcloth for the road, that nobody in that room had read them through in a long while.

"Look for the silver," he said. "If it is there, better you find it than they do."

She read them at the inns going home, by rushlight, at the end of the long tables, with the carters singing at the other end and Fionnlagh asleep with his head on his arms. She read them the way she read a ledger, a line at a time, and when a word was strange to her she wrote it on a scrap of paper and asked the next human she met what it meant, which on that road was never long. The leaves of Cùmhnant Cathair dhearg spoke of the humans' leave to stay and to build, of the post and the harbour, of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach⁷ and the council and how each should send to the other. It spoke of the dues, and of such goods as the island afforded and the working of them. Puingean a' Chalaids spoke of anchorages and moorings and nothing else. The contracts, which hung from that one line of goods, spoke of the coal, and of how the coal should be cut and weighed and paid for, at a length that surprised her, and of tons.

On the third night, at the inn below Muileann chrom, she laid the leaves down on the table and put her hand flat on them.

"What is it?" said Fionnlagh, who had woken.

"There is no silver in it," said Ùna. "No metal in it at all but the iron they paid with. Coal on every page, and not a word about anything else under the ground."

"Then they cannot have it."

"Then they have no paper that gives it to them," said his grandmother. "Which is a smaller thing. Go to sleep."

6. the Harbour Articles; lit. 'the points of the harbour'

7. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

IV

Of the Ledgers at the Adit

The surveyors came up the valley on 31 am Màrt, AE 43, the last day of am Màrt, in a thin cold sunshine after a week of rain. There were five of them, the chief surveyor on a grey horse and the rest on foot, with two carts of chains, pegs, staves and a tripod in a canvas bag, and a Dia-thìreach of Muileann chrom walking at the horse's head to speak for them. The town saw them from a mile off. Nobody went down to meet them.

Ùna had made her plan in the hall two nights before, and it was short. Every member of the guild would be at the adit at the hour the carts came up, man and woman and apprentice, in the leather aprons of the smelting-floors, and every one of them would hold their tongue. Seumas mac Fhearchair and old Mòr nic Fhearchair, the two eldest, would hold the ledgers. Ùna would speak, and nobody else.

"And if they will not go?" somebody asked.

"Then we will all be standing at the adit," said Ùna, "and they will have to measure round us."

When the carts came up past the last houses the whole membership of Comann an Airgid¹ was already there, filling the yard in front of the adit and the slope above it, forty-one people in leather aprons standing in the sun. Seumas and Mòr stood at the front, one on each side of Ùna, and each held a ledger open across the forearms, the way a priest holds a book at a rite: Seumas the notched boards of the old ledger, strapped open at the first board, and Mòr the paper book of the weighings, open at the page where the old brown hands of An Aois Scaraidh² gave way to the hands of the present. Behind them the black mouth of the adit breathed out its cold. Down by the stream the smelting-floors were banked but not dead, and a thread of smoke went straight up from them into the still air.

The chief surveyor was a big, red-faced man in a good coat, with a clerk's case on a strap across his chest. He got down from his horse and looked at the yard full of silent people, and then at the woman in the middle of it, and he did not seem to know which to speak to. The man from Muileann chrom said something to him low. He took a paper from his case and began to read out his authority.

It was a long paper and he read all of it, in the humans' tongue, in a loud flat voice as if reading to a crowd that could not hear: the charter, the first refusal, the

fuels, ores and minerals, the seal of An t-Àrd-mhaor³, the agent's instructions, the rights of entry and of measurement. The man from Muileann chrom tried to put it into Dia-thiris and fell further behind at every line. The yard stood and listened. Nobody moved. A dog barked somewhere down in the town and was hushed.

Ùna let him finish. Then, when he had folded his paper, she turned toward him the first ledger, the notched boards in Seumas's arms, and after it the second, the paper book in Mòr's; and she said to him, in his own tongue and quite pleasantly, "These are the books of the seam since it was found. Find me your name in either of them."

He looked at her. Then, because he could think of nothing else to do, and perhaps because he was an honest man in his way, he looked at the books.

He could not read the boards at all, and she did not help him. He looked a long time at the paper book, turning the leaves back and back with one thick finger while Mòr held it steady, through the weighings of the last season and the season before, through the rings for salt and the bars for bronze and the weights sent to the inns of the roads, back into hands so old that the ink had gone brown. The yard waited. The wind came down off the hill with the smell of the smelting-floors in it, charcoal and hot stone and the sharp sweet smell of the silver, and moved the hair on forty-one heads and the pages of the book.

After a while the surveyor closed his own book, the one in his case that he had been ready to write the seam into. He said something short to the man from Muileann chrom, and turned his horse, and the carts creaked round in the yard; and the men of A' Chompanaidh⁴ went back down the valley the way they had come, with their chains and pegs and their tripod still in its bag.

Nobody in the yard spoke until they were out of sight below the last houses. Then Mòr nic Fhearchair shut the paper book with a clap, and somebody at the back began to laugh, and then all of them were laughing, forty-one people in leather aprons laughing in the sun at the mouth of the adit, and old Seumas sat down on the edge of the ore-trough and wiped his eyes with his sleeve.

Ùna did not laugh. She took the ledgers from them and carried them back to the hall herself, one under each arm.

"They will come again," she said that night at her own fire, to Fionnlagh, who could not sit still. "Or somebody will come in their place with a better paper. We

1. the silver guild of Muileann chiar

2. the Age of Sundering

3. the Commissioner; lit. 'the high steward'

have won nothing yet. All we have shown them is that the paper they carried was too short."

V

Of What the Lawyer Found

The chief surveyor's report reached Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir¹ a fortnight later, and it is in the letter-books, in a hand that is none too steady. He wrote that he had been met at the working by the whole population of the place in a body, silent and in an attitude he could not call threatening and would not call anything else; that he had been shown two books of accounts, one in no writing he knew, and had found no trace in either of any grant, lease or payment to his masters or to any of his countrymen; that he had not thought it prudent to proceed; and that he awaited instruction.

Under it, in the small level hand, Lisle wrote one line: *Nor would I have found it. Bring me the bound book.*

He read it through again that summer, from the first leaf to the last, with the charter laid open beside it. The letter-books keep that reading too, in a long letter he wrote in an Lùnastal to the master of A' Chompanaidh² at Ros dhomhain, and the copyists have kept a copy of the letter in the cellar because it is the plainest account any human wrote in all the age of what the humans on the island held and by what right. The charter, Lisle wrote, was a promise that A' Chompanaidh's own masters had made to it: that whatever the island should yield to their own people, A' Chompanaidh should be offered first. It gave A' Chompanaidh nothing on the island. It could not give what the island had not first given, and the only writings by which the island had given anything were Cùmhnant Cathair dhearg³ and the contracts that hung from its line of goods. He had read them. They were careful about coal, and the contracts spoke of coal at great length and on every page; of silver they said nothing whatever, or about any other metal or ore, or about any ground but the ground of the coal. "They gave us the hill," he wrote, "and we have been reading it as the whole island. The silver of Muileann

4. the Company

1. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

2. the Company

3. the first written treaty, signed at Cathair dhearg; the Treaty in One Tongue

chiar was never ours to refuse or to be offered, and a surveyor sent to measure it has no more right on that hillside than a stranger has in my garden."

The master of A' Chompanaidh wrote back angrily and at length. Lisle's answer was two lines long and is also kept. He did not mean to lose another customs officer, it said, and he did not mean to lose a war over a seam that no page had ever given him.

In the autumn he wrote to Comann an Airgid⁴. The letter came up the valley by the same road the surveyors had taken, in the humans' tongue only. It proposed that An t-Àrd-mhaor⁵ and the guild set down together, in a compact, that the silver seam of Muileann chiar and its workings belonged to the town and its guild, and that A' Chompanaidh had no claim on them under its charter or any other paper; and it proposed that the compact be signed at Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir on a day to be named.

Ùna wrote back herself, in the humans' letters, slowly, on a sheet of the guild's paper. The copyists found her letter in the letter-books, bound in between a complaint about harbour thieves and an order for lamp-oil. It says that the guild would sign such a compact gladly; that the seam was at Muileann chiar and not at Ros dhomhain, and the compact had best be signed where the seam was; and that the guild asked for it to be written in both tongues, the humans' and the island's, line against line, so that neither side should have to trust the other's reading of it.

Lisle's clerk put a question mark in the margin beside that last sentence. Lisle struck it through. He wrote under the letter, *It costs me a clerk's week and it will save me a war of glosses. Do it*, and sent word to Muileann chiar that he would come himself on Là Fhèill Brìde.

He came in a closed carriage, over roads so bad that he and his clerk walked the last three miles up the valley beside the horses with their boots full of snow-water. The town turned out to watch him come, as it had turned out for the surveyors, but this time Ùna went down the street to meet him. He was a smaller man than she had thought, and older in the face, and he limped. He bowed to her in the humans' way. She did not know what to do with that, so she bowed back.

The compact was signed in the guild hall on 1 an Gearran, AE 44, Là Fhèill Brìde, the first day of an Gearran, at the long table under the hanging scales, with the brazier lit and the whole guild on the benches along the walls. It was short. There were two copies, each of two leaves, each written in two columns, the hu-

4. the silver guild of Muileann chiar

5. the Commissioner; lit. 'the high steward'

mans' tongue on the left and the island's on the right, and a young man of Ros dhomhain whom Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir paid to put its words into Dia-thìris had made the island's column and Ùna had gone through it with him line by line the night before and made him change four words. It said that the silver seam at Muileann chiar and all its workings, galleries and floors were the town's, held for it by Comann an Airgid as they had been held since An Aois Naomh⁶; that A' Chompanaidh had no claim upon them under its charter or any other writing; that the guild might sell or send its silver where it chose; and that neither An t-Àrd-mhaor nor any officer of his should enter the workings without the guild's leave.

Lisle signed both copies at the foot of the humans' column. Ùna signed both at the foot of the island's, in the island's letters, and then, because the humans set store by it, in theirs as well. Old Seumas mac Fhearchair signed as witness with a mark, and Lisle's clerk with a flourish.

Before he left Lisle asked to see the seam. Ùna took him up to the adit herself, with a lamp. He stood a long time in the mouth of the gallery, holding the lamp up to the face where the last cutting had broken it, grey and bright and the same all through, and then he said a thing that Fionnlagh, who had come behind them with a second lamp, remembered and told to his own children.

"On the coast they tell me there are colours in the coal," Lisle said. "I have never seen them. I have stood at the pit-mouth at Muileann chrom with a custodian at each elbow pointing, and I saw coal." He turned the lamp so the light ran along the seam. "This I can see."

"We see it the same as you," said Ùna. "That is why it is not holy."

He looked at her as if he would ask what she meant, and did not ask; and they went back down to the hall.

That evening, when the carriage had gone down the valley in the dusk with its lamps lit, Ùna had the compact read aloud to the guild from the Dia-thìris column, all of it, by Mòr nic Fhearchair, who had the best voice. Then it was read again, because the apprentices at the back had not heard. It was the first writing of the whole age of the strangers in which the island's side kept the better terms. Nobody in the hall said so. They did not know it yet. They knew only that the surveyors had gone down the valley and a paper had come up it, and that the paper said the seam was theirs, in their own tongue, in a hand they could read.

6. the Holy Age

VI

Of the Guild Chest

The guild chest of Muileann chiar was a box of black oak bound with silver bands, older than anyone could say, that stood at the end of the hall under the scales. It held the ledgers and the weights and the guild's seal, and it had three locks, and the three keys were kept in three houses. Ùna had the compact laid in it the night it was signed, on top of the paper book of the weighings, and the three keys turned.

In the spring word came east that Coinneach Glas was dead at Cathair dhearg. He had died in his chair by the brazier in the room behind the council hall, with the rolls in their presses round him, at sixty-nine, having held the seat twenty-four years. The clerk who wrote to Muileann chiar with the news added that Ceann a' Chùraim¹ had heard of the compact before the end, and had had it read to him twice from the copy Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir² sent the council, and had said that it was a better paper than any he had signed. The council's leaves were still at Muileann chiar. Ùna sent them back to the council by Fionnlagh, wrapped in the same oilcloth, with a bar of silver for the clerk who kept the presses, for his trouble.

The council chose Alasdair Liath after him, a custodian of forty-nine, who had sat on the council since before Puingean a' Chalaiddh³ and had voted to sign them. The roll gives his choosing in a single line. It gives his age, and the number of voices, and nothing else. Ùna, when she heard, said that she had met him once and he had a good memory, and did not say whether that was praise.

In an t-Ògmhios the guild tried its compact for the first time. A' Chompanaidh⁴ had asked, through the agent at Muileann chrom, that the guild's silver should go to the sea by its own quays at Ros dhomhain, where it might be weighed at the customs house and entered in the books. Ùna read the compact again, the island's column and then the humans', and found that the guild might send its silver where it chose. So on 26 an t-Ògmhios, AE 44, the first carts of bar silver went south instead, eighteen miles down the valley road to Seann Bhrál on the south-eastern coast, where the oyster-beds lie in the shallows and the coasting

1. the high custodian of the Council of Custodians; lit. 'head of the custody'

2. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

3. the Harbour Articles; lit. 'the points of the harbour'

4. the Company

boats had loaded Muileann chlar silver since An Aois Naomh⁵. The guild paid the custodians of Seann Bhrál for the use of their quay in the old way, in silver by the Muileann chlar weight, so much on every bar. The agent at Muileann chrom wrote to Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir to complain. Lisle's clerk wrote back that it could find no ground in the compact to object, and the agent's letter and the answer both are in the letter-books, one under the other, with nothing written between them.

It was a good summer in the silver town. The floors worked from dawn to dark, and the paper book of the weighings, which had lasted the guild a lifetime, was full by the autumn and a new one begun.

In the winter came news from the other end of the island that the guild marked in its ledger, though it had nothing to do with silver. The carters of Baile gheal, in the south-west, had taken up the carrying of the brine-salt of Seann Warr round the lake to the capital, with their own carts and their own ponies, on the old roads. A' Chompanaidh had never troubled to claim the salt trade, and nobody had told the carters of Baile gheal that they might not have it; so they had it. They were paid in salt and in marks both, and their young men stayed home from the pits. A carter from the west told it at the smelting-floors in the month of am Faoilleach, in the forty-fifth year of the strangers, a week after the thing was done. He told it as a small thing, which it was. Ùna had it written into the new ledger all the same.

"Write it down," she told the weighing-clerk. "Salt at Baile gheal. Their own carts. Put the year."

"It is not silver," said the clerk.

"It is a thing they did not take," said Ùna. "There are not so many of those that we can afford to forget one."

At the end of that month, on the day the guild reckoned its year and read out the weighings, the three keyholders came to the hall with their keys, and the chest was opened, and Ùna took the compact out and had it read aloud again to the whole guild, both columns, the island's and then the humans'. She was fifty-nine that winter. She stood by the chest while it was read with her hands folded in front of her apron, and when Mòr nic Fhearchair had finished she took the two leaves and looked at them a while, at the two columns and the three names, Lisle's small level one and her own twice over and the old man's mark. Then she laid

5. the Holy Age

them in the chest on top of the new paper book, beside the notched boards of the old ledger, and the three keys turned, one after another, in the three locks.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Of the Keeper's Daybook

AE 45 – 48

I

Of the Fire-Shelf and the Tower

Of the four witnesses in the chests at Muileann chaol, the copyists say the daybooks of the beacon-keepers are the dullest to read and the easiest to trust. A custodian writing to the council wanted something of it. So did a clerk of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach¹ writing home. A keeper on a headland wanted oil for the lamp and a dry wick, and what he wrote down was the wind, the weather, the hour he lit the flame and the hour he put it out, and every sail that went by his light. A keeper has nothing to gain from a ship that is not there. So the copyists have leaned on the daybooks wherever the other witnesses quarrel, and the first daybook of them all was begun at Àth dhearg, on the north-eastern cape, by a mason named Tormod mac Pheadair.

The fire on that cape was older than any roll. The households of the coast had kept it on a shelf of rock near the top of the headland since before An Aois Na-omh², and had cut a stair up to it from the shore, turning back and forth across the face of the cliff, a hundred and more steps, each narrower than a man's boot. Forty years before, the mason Torcall Clachair had sat on that shelf with the hu-

1. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

2. the Holy Age

man navigator James Fenn, counting the chisel-cuts, and had raised a cairn at its end where the rock was broad enough to bear a tower. The custodian of that day had made them go round every hearth of Àth dhearg to ask leave, and it had taken eleven days.

The cairn stood a long while with nothing beside it. The beacons at Tobar dhearg and Baile ìseal were lit, both of Torcall's building; then Torcall died, and A' Chompanaidh³, which paid for the towers, let the third wait while it paid for props and pumps and winding-rope in the hills. When at last it sent word up the coast that it would pay for a tower on the north-eastern cape, it sent no mason with the word. Its masons were building at the pits.

So the custodian of Àth dhearg called the hearths together again, in the long room over the net-store where the town held its councils, and put it to them. The strangers would pay half the cost in marks, their coin with the ship on one face, and would send the lens and the oil; the town would find the stone and the hands. The other half of the pay, she said, was a promise: that the tower would bring home the boats of Àth dhearg as the old fire had done, and better. Some in the room laughed. A promise, said one old fisher, was a poor thing to put in a pot. But the households of that coast had lost boats on the reef below the cape in every generation, and nobody in the room had to be told whose, and the town said yes.

Tormod mac Pheadair was among the first to put his name down. He was twenty-nine that winter, a mason's son, broad and slow-moving, with a burn-scar across the back of one hand from a lime-kiln and a way of looking at a wall for a long while before he touched it. Byres and sea-walls he had built all along that coast, and he had worked on the new quay at Seann Bhrál, where he first saw the humans' figures chalked on a stone to be cut. The custodian's clerk had taught him his letters as a boy, and he wrote a square, careful hand, like a man laying courses.

They built through a year and more. The stone came from the landward side of the headland on sledges. They raised the tower over the end of the fire-shelf, and Torcall's cairn they took down stone by stone and set into the footing, facing out to sea, because that was what Torcall would have done. Inside the tower they turned a stair in the thickness of the wall, so that no keeper need climb the old stair in a gale again, as the town had been promised forty years before. The old stair they left as it was.

3. the Company

In Teasach of the forty-fifth year the lamp-room was roofed, and the lens came up the coast road in a crate packed with straw, with a human of A' Chompanaidh riding beside it who would let nobody else touch it. He set it on its iron frame, polished it for most of a day, and then asked who would keep the light. The keeper would be paid a little, in marks, and must keep a book: his masters wished to know how many ships went by the cape, and whose, and when, and which of their own captains kept to their sailing-days. Most of the household elders could not write. Among the masons of the tower there was one who wrote a fair hand and knew the humans' figures besides.

So Tormod mac Pheadair was made keeper of Taigh-solais Àth dhearg⁴. He said afterwards that he had only gone up the stair to fetch his hammer.

II

Of the First Line

The lamp was lit at dusk on 10 an t-Iuchar, AE 45. The whole town came out along the cliff-top to see it, and most said it was brighter than the old fire. The man of A' Chompanaidh¹ noted the hour by his watch. In the morning he rode south, and Tormod was alone in the tower with the lamp, the oil-casks, a bundle of wicks and a book of the humans' paper, bound in grey board, left on the table.

He sat a long while before he wrote in it. The paper was better than anything the custodian's clerk had, and he did not like to spoil it. In the end he wrote as he would have cut a line in stone, slowly, pressing hard. The copyists found the book among the first chests from the north-east, its grey boards warped by the damp and its first leaf gone brown at the edges, and the first line reads:

Air a lasadh aig ciaradh. Gaoth an iar, beag. Cha robh long ann.

Lit at dusk. Wind west, light. There was no ship.

Under it, in the same hand, stands the night of the moon: the tenth night of Teasach. The humans' day stands above the line, in a different ink.

The man of A' Chompanaidh came back at the end of Lùghnas with a cart of oil and read the book through at the lamp-room table, and was not pleased, for he

4. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

could not tell from the nights of the moon on what day any ship had passed. He sat Tormod down beside him and wrote out a list of the humans' months and days to the end of their year, each against its night of the moon as well as he could reckon it, which was not well. From then on Tormod wrote two dates at the head of each entry, the humans' day above in their figures and the night of the moon beneath in words, and went back and wrote the humans' days over the entries already made. Some of them he got wrong, and the copyists have set them right from the letter-books.

The entries of that first autumn are short and much alike. The lamp was lit and put out. The wind went round. Fog came in off the sea on the nineteenth night of Pailteach, and he wrote that the lamp was lit and did no good. The fishing boats of the coast went in and out, and he left them out of the book, for the man of A' Chompanaidh had said *ships*. Then, on the fourth night of Damhrach:

A ship of the strangers, three masts, going south. Deep in the water. She showed a lamp at the stern.

She went by within two miles of the cape with every sail set, and Tormod watched her out of sight from the gallery. He did not know her name, or her cargo, or her port. He wrote down what he had seen.

By the end of the humans' year he had written down nineteen of them. By the end of the next, forty-four.

III

Of the Boats Brought Home

That winter the masons went on working, though the lamp was lit. The outer face was half-pointed when the weather closed in and the keeper's house at the tower's foot was unroofed, and Tormod slept in the lamp-room on a pallet by the oil-casks and wrote by the light of the lamp, the best light he had ever written by. Few ships came round the north coast in the dark months, and the daybook shows them late on their sailing-days, and early never.

On the second night of Bealltach, in the forty-sixth year, a gale came up out of the north-east in the afternoon, when four boats of Àth dhearg were out on the

1. the Company

long lines beyond the reef. Tormod saw it coming from the gallery: a dark edge on the sea far out, and the gulls coming in ahead of it. He lit the lamp an hour before dusk and stood in the wind and rain watching the grey water below the cape, where the reef showed white when the swell drew back.

The first boat came in at dusk. The second came an hour after, low in the water and baling. Then nothing came for a long time, and the women of the four households stood on the cliff-top with lanterns, as the women of that coast had always stood in a blow, under the shelf where the old fire had been fed by hand. There was no fire on the shelf now. The tower's light went out over their heads to sea.

The third boat came in near midnight, from the wrong side of the reef, having run north past it in the dark and come round. Her steersman said afterwards that he had not known where he was until he raised the light, and then he had known exactly, because it could be nowhere else. The fourth came in at first light, a man short. He had gone over the side in the afternoon, before the gale reached them, where no light could have helped him.

Tormod wrote it all down, which was more than the man of A' Chompanaidh¹ had asked: the four boats by name, the hour of each, and the lost man and his name. It is the only entry in the first daybook that names anyone of Àth dhearg. The copyists think he wrote it so that the promise could be seen to have been kept.

On 28 an Cèitean, AE 46, the work was done. The keeper's house was roofed and the outer face pointed, and the man of A' Chompanaidh came up the coast road with a clerk and a strong-box and paid the masons in marks from a table set out on the grass at the tower's foot. There were eleven of them, and Tormod came down the stair and stood in the line and took his pay with the rest. The custodian's clerk wrote the payment into the town's roll, and wrote beside it that the masons of the tower had been the town's own men, and that the other half of their pay had been made on the second night of Bealltach, in four boats and three of them home.

IV

Of the Glow in the South

1. the Company

In the autumn of that year a ship of A' Chompanaidh¹ went south past the cape:

A ship of the strangers, two masts. Coal. Going south close in, with the wind behind her.

He knew her for a collier by the way she sat low and square in the water, and because as she passed below the cape the wind brought him the smell of her cargo, the smell of broken coal that nobody on the island mistook. At that distance he could not see the colour in it. He could smell it.

Two nights after, at the change of the watch, he went out onto the gallery and saw a redness low in the south, under the cloud, where there should have been nothing but the dark coast running away towards Ceann Iethan and the islets beyond. It was too steady for lightning and too far off for a fire on any hill he knew. He watched it grow, and towards morning sink.

A light in the south under the cloud, red, from the middle watch until near dawn. I do not know what it was.

Four days later a carter came up the coast road with salt and the news. Raiders in low black boats had come out from the islets off the eastern shore in the night and taken the collier, and stripped her of what they wanted, and set her afire, and she had burned to the waterline with her coal in her. Her crew had been put in their own boat and set rowing for the land, and came ashore alive at a fishing village near Ceann Iethan, and the village fed them. The copyists set the burning at 20 an Dàmhair, AE 46, which is the day the letter-books give.

The raiders of the eastern islets had taken Dia-thìreach boats in every generation since An Aois Naomh², and nobody on that coast was surprised that they had taken a stranger's at last. Within the month its agents were saying at Seann Bhràl and Ros dhomhain, and writing to Arthur Lisle, An t-Àrd-mhaor³, that Comann an Airgid⁴ had paid the raiders, out of spite for the surveyors turned back from the adit at Muileann Chiar.

The guild said nothing. The copyists have looked for a word from it in every chest that came to the cellar, and have found none.

1. the Company

2. the Holy Age

3. the Commissioner; lit. 'the high steward'

4. the silver guild of Muileann Chiar

In the dark days of Dubhlas a clerk of A' Chompanaidh rode up the coast road to Àth dhearg alone and asked to see the daybook. He had some Dia-thìris and could read the humans' dates, and he found the collier and the red light, and went over them with his finger. Then he asked Tormod whether he had seen any boats go south along the coast in the days before the burning. Low boats, black-painted, with many oars.

Tormod said that he had written down every ship he saw.

The clerk said that such boats were hardly ships, and Tormod might have seen them and thought them not worth the writing. There was room at the foot of the page.

Tormod looked at the page for a while. Then he said that he had seen no such boats, that if he had seen them he would have written them down, and that he would not write down a boat he had not seen, for his own people or the clerk's.

The clerk did not argue. He thanked the keeper for the use of the lamp-room fire and rode south in the morning. The daybook says nothing of his coming. His report lies in the letter-books of Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir⁵ among the papers on the burning of the collier, and says that the keeper at Àth dhearg was "civil, but of no assistance," and that his book "throws no light on the matter"; and somebody at Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir has underlined the words about the light.

V

Of the Gunboat and the Cove

The next summer A' Chompanaidh¹ sent a ship of war.

Tormod saw her come round the north coast on a clear morning in Teasach of the forty-seventh year. She was smaller than the colliers and lower and a great deal faster, two-masted, painted black with a white band along her side, and there were more men on her deck than any trader carried. Through the glass A' Chompanaidh had given him for reading sails he made out the gun in her bows under a canvas cover, and wrote her down with more care than he had given any ship before:

5. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

1. the Company

A ship of the strangers, two masts, black with a white band. A gun in the bows under canvas. Many men. Going south along the coast.

On 25 an t-Iuchar, AE 47, the gunboat found a cove near Ceann leathan with boats drawn up on the shingle and the smoke of a fire among the rocks above. Her master wrote in his report that he had tracked the raiders there. He put a boat's crew ashore with torches under cover of his gun, and there was nobody on the shingle to stop them. They burned every boat drawn up there, eighteen of them. The gunboat stood off through the day, waiting for the raiders to come down out of the rocks, and nobody came.

Most of the boats were the fishermen's. The households of Ceann leathan drew up their small boats in that cove in the summer, when the lining was good off that shore, and slept in the bothies above the rocks, and it was their fire the master had seen. When the torches came up the shingle they had run into the rocks with their children, having heard what a gun could do, and from the rocks they watched their boats burn. The raiders were not found. Nobody on the coast believed they had been there.

Tormod wrote the gunboat going back north on the third day after, running before a southerly wind:

The gun-ship, going north. The gun uncovered.

The news came up the coast road behind her, with a Ceann leathan man who walked nearly forty miles north with two of his sons to ask Àth dhearg for the loan of a boat. The town had boats to spare that year, since the masons had been paid in marks and two households had bought new boats with the money. The households talked it over into the night in the long room over the net-store, and gave the loan of two, to be returned when the Ceann leathan men had built their own. The man and his sons sailed them south in the first days of Lùghnas, and passed under the cape on the way, and Tormod saw them go. He left them out of the book, as he left out all the boats of the coast.

VI

Of the Wall on the Shingle

That same Lùghnas, on the other side of the island, the council of Baile dhìreach broke apart.

It had sat for forty-two years, and every year it had sat on less. When the customs house went to Ros dhomhain six years before and took the harbour dues with it, the council had cut its members from six to four. William Rook and Iain mac Chaluim gave up their seats then, being old men, and sat on the salt-house step on fine evenings with their pipes and watched the others go up the ladder to the net-loft without them. The two books stood on the shelf there side by side, and most months there was little to put in either.

Iain Hale was thirty-eight that summer, the son of the marriage entered in both books on the quay, of the net-maker Eilidh nic Ruairidh and the human cooper Samuel Hale. He had been born in the tent on the shingle and grown up in the yard, and he was a boatwright. The carpenter Nathan Cobb had taught him the humans' way of setting up a keel, and his grandfather Ruairidh the salter had taught him the town's knots before he could walk. He spoke both tongues as a child speaks them, without choosing. He had his father's long arms and his mother's broad hands, and people of both peoples in the town were a little shy of him, as they were of the tide-line, which is neither sea nor land.

In the spring of that year the yard-master, Daniel Lusk, the sawyer's son who had come ashore as a boy with the first seven, came back from Ros dhomhain with a promise from A' Chompanaidh¹ of oak and pine by the shipload, more than the yard had ever had, if the yard would build for it. He had nowhere to stack it. The yard stood on the shingle north of the quay by the town's leave, and above the wrack the shingle was held for the whole town and built on by nobody; so both books said, each in its own words.

Lusk wanted to build a wall.

He put it to the council in the net-loft on an evening in Lùghnas, with the rain on the slates. A wall of dry stone, he said, no higher than a man's chest, from the foot of the slip up the shingle to the old post at the top. It would keep the timber in and the town's children out. It would not be a house, and the compact said nothing against walls.

Eòghann mac Iain, Iain mac Chaluim's son, who sat for the town, said that the compact did not need to. A wall was a building, and the first thing that anybody would ever have built on that shingle, and a wall had two sides.

1. the Company

The other town member was Mairead nic Aoidh, Seonag's granddaughter, who kept the salt-house as her grandmother had. She said that before there could be a wall somebody had to say where the line was, and the town had never said that the yard went this far and no further. The yard was on the shingle by leave, as the curers of Inis thais had been in her grandmother's grandmother's day. A wall would make it a piece of ground.

"It has been a piece of ground for forty years," said Lusk.

The fourth member was Nathan Cobb, seventy and deaf in one ear, who had sat on the council since the night the compact was written. He took the humans' book from the shelf, opened it at the compact, and read out the clause about the shingle in the humans' tongue: *The shingle north of the quay is the property of the town*. If it was the town's property, he said, not unkindly, then a wall would show where the town's property ended and the yard's began, and that was the whole use of a wall.

Mairead asked for the other book. Iain Hale was sitting at the foot of the table, having been asked to carry the talk from one tongue to the other when either side stuck, and it was he who took down the Dia-thiris book and found the page and read it out: *The shingle north of the quay is kept for the town*.

Everyone at the table looked at him then, from both sides, and waited for him to say which of the two books was right. He had read them both, the only man at the table who could.

He closed the book, put it back on the shelf, and said nothing.

They argued for four nights. While they argued Lusk had the footing of the wall laid, a line of big stones from the slip half-way up the shingle, and on the third night somebody of the town took the stones up and carried them below the wrack-line and left them in a heap. Nobody on the council would say who. On the fourth night, 23 an Lùnastal, AE 47, Lusk stood up and said that he would not sit with people who pulled down a man's work in the dark, and Eòghann mac Iain said that he would not sit with people who built on the town's ground by daylight, and Lusk went down the ladder. Cobb sat on a while, looking at the table. Then he got up and followed.

The council of Baile dhireach never met again. On the last written page of the Dia-thiris book a line in Eòghann mac Iain's hand says that the council rose without its business done. The humans' book has nothing on its last page but the date, in Cobb's shaking hand.

VII

Of the Yard That Went East

The human families began to go before the harvest was in. There were not many of them now, and most were the families of the yard. Two went up the coast to Ros bheag, the citadel harbour of the west, where there was a human Chandler and a chapel. The rest went to Ros dhomhain, where A' Chompanaidh¹ had its yards and counting-houses and work for any man of their people who could hold an adze.

Of the households that were of both peoples it is not told which went and which stayed, save one. The Hales stayed, and said nothing about it. They went neither to the quay to say they were staying nor to the salt-house to say they had taken the town's side. They kept to their house at the head of the street by the well, where they had lived since the tent grew too small for them; Samuel Hale mended the town's barrels as he had for forty years, and Eilidh mended nets on the frames outside the door, being too stiff in the knees now for the shingle. The humans who were going came to their door to say goodbye, and the Hales gave them bread and a jug of ale. When the town spoke of the wall in their hearing, they spoke of other things.

In the first days of Samhnas Lusk came to find Iain in the yard, where the men were breaking up the stacks and caulking the yard's own boats for a voyage. The yard was going east, he said, to Inis chrom, a day's sail along the coast: a walled harbour of sailors on its bent island in the mouth of the river, with ground to spare, where A' Chompanaidh had promised the timber and the town would take them in and say nothing about walls. A' Chompanaidh wanted boats, and would want more every year. Lusk needed a foreman who could set up a keel of the humans' pattern and talk to the island's timber-men in their own tongue, and he offered Iain the place, for more marks than the yard had ever paid.

Iain asked for a night to think. He went down that evening to the shingle and sat on the heap of footing-stones below the wrack-line and looked at the yard: the long shed open to the sea, the slip of split logs bedded in the stones, and the tent. It stood where Rook's men had set it up in the first summer, a little crooked, with its back to the west wind and a lamp in its window of real glass. Rook had written

1. the Company

in the compact, in his round slow hand, that the tent would be taken down when the council told him. Now there was no council to tell anybody anything.

His father found him there after dark. Samuel Hale was sixty-nine and walked with a stick, and he came down the shingle slowly and stood beside his son and looked at the tent, as his father-in-law had looked at it forty years before, when the town was still deciding whether it was a house.

"Your mother says you'll go," he said. He said it in Dia-thìris, as he always did in the town. His Dia-thìris had grown little better since the day of the wedding, and in forty years the town had come to hear it as the way the cooper talked.

"And you?"

"I said you'd stay." Samuel poked at a stone with the end of his stick. "We didn't wager on it. She wouldn't."

After a while Iain asked his father whether he had ever thought of going back over the sea. Nobody in the family had ever asked him.

Samuel laughed. He had a sister over there somewhere, he said, if she was living, who would not know him, and a town that would not know him either. When the men of the yard talked of home they meant a place; when he thought of home he thought of a bowl of whatever was in the pot, on the salt-house step. And he was not the one being asked.

In the morning Iain went to Lusk and told him no.

The yard sailed for Inis chrom on 18 an t-Samhain, AE 47, three boats deep with tools and timber and families, on a cold bright morning with a north wind. Half the town came down to the quay to see them off, which was more than anyone had expected. The last boat out was steered by Nathan Cobb, deaf and upright at the tiller, and he did not look back.

When they had gone round the point Iain climbed the ladder into the net-loft. The humans' book lay on the long mending-table where Cobb had left it on the last night of the council, open at the page with the date and nothing under it. Iain closed it and set it back on the shelf beside the Dia-thìris book, the two side by side as they had always stood, and the copyists found them there in that order.

That winter he took over the slip with the town's leave and under the town's rule, and built the town's boats on it, a keel at a time. The tent stayed where it was on the shingle. Nobody told anybody to take it down.

VIII

Of the Dry Year and the Seed

At Àth dhearg the daybook went on as before. The forty-seventh year gives fifty-one ships of the humans going by the cape; the forty-eighth gives fewer colliers and more ships bound for Seann Bhrál and the eastern harbours with goods from over the sea. Tormod had a wife by then, Ciorstaidh nic Phàdraig of Baile ruadh, a red-haired woman who laughed at his handwriting and could not read it. They lived in the keeper's house at the tower's foot, and in the evenings she climbed the inside stair with his supper and stood on the gallery with him and named the boats of the coast as they came in.

In the spring of the forty-eighth year the rain began to fail.

The daybook does not say so at first. It says, night after night, *wind west, dry; wind south-west, dry; no rain*; and the copyists noticed the word before they noticed the season. A keeper writes down the weather because the weather is what brings ships ashore. By Ògach he was adding what he saw from the gallery: the fields inland going yellow before midsummer, and a heath fire on the hills to the south that burned three days. In Teasach he wrote that the burn below the town had stopped running, which it had never done in anyone's memory, and that the women were carrying water from the spring on the landward side of the headland.

The farming country south and east of the cape, the old fields of Achadh shean and the red-earth country beyond, lived by its grain. The rain failed over all of it through the summer. It rained a little in Pailteach, and the daybook marks the night with a word it had not used for four months, and then the rain stopped again. On 21 an t-Sultain, AE 48, the custodians of Achadh shean wrote to the council at Cathair dhearg that the harvest of their country had failed for want of rain, and that the granaries of the custom of An Aois Naomh¹ would carry them through the winter. The council's roll enters the letter. No answer is entered.

Baile ruadh had sown its winter corn early, in the last days of Lùghnas, trusting to the rains of Pailteach as the farmers of the red-earth country always did. The rains came for three nights and stopped. The seed swelled and sprouted and withered in the dry ground, across the whole of the town's fields. By Damhrach

1. the Holy Age

there was nothing to be done but sow again, and no seed left to sow; the granary had gone to feed the town through the summer.

Ciorstaidh's brother Pàdraig sat on the council of Baile ruadh, and he sent a boy up the coast road to the tower. Tormod left the lamp in the charge of the old clerk's grandson, who had learned to trim the wick, and walked south-east over the brown hills to Baile ruadh, a long day. At the council's table in the custodian's house sat a clerk of A' Chompanaidh² from its store at Seann Dunn, a thin young human with a ledger and an ink-pot, and beside him a Dia-thìreach of Seann Dunn to put his words into the island's tongue.

The store at Seann Dunn had seed. A' Chompanaidh had brought it over the sea in grain ships, some of which Tormod had written down going south past his cape, and it would lend enough to sow the fields again before the frosts, at a price to be paid back in grain over five harvests. The terms were written out in the humans' tongue and the figures in the humans' figures. Nobody at the table could read them. The custodian of Baile ruadh, who was old and had a cough, turned to Pàdraig and asked whether it was true that his sister's man could read the strangers' numbers.

So Tormod read them. He stood at the custodian's elbow and put his finger on each figure in turn and said it aloud in Dia-thìris: the measure of seed lent, the measure of grain to be paid back at each harvest, and the number of harvests. He read them twice, as he would have read a line on a stone twice before he cut it. The figures were what the man of Seann Dunn had said. The price was high, and there was nothing in the paper that the council had not been told, and he said so.

The council talked a little, not long, since there was nothing else to talk about. Then the custodian made his mark on the humans' paper, and the clerk sanded it and blew on it, and on 20 an Dàmhair, AE 48, the town of Baile ruadh borrowed its seed corn from A' Chompanaidh. The custodians' roll of Baile ruadh enters the debt under the night of the moon, with the measure and the five harvests. It is the first debt in grain to the strangers that stands in any roll of the island. Beside it the clerk of the roll has written, in a smaller hand, the name of the man who read the figures.

The seed-carts came up from Seann Dunn three days later, and the town sowed its fields again in the dust and waited for rain.

Tormod walked home the next morning. He came up the coast road in the late afternoon and saw the tower on the headland ahead, grey against a grey sky, and

Ciorstaidh on the gallery. The boy had lit the lamp early, since there was cloud coming in from the west, and Tormod climbed the inside stair in the last of the light and read over what the boy had written while he was away, which was *lit* and *no ship* and *lit* again.

Before midnight the rain came, and a ship went by below the cape, going south. He knew as well as anyone on that coast what the deep ships going south carried that autumn, and to whose store. He wrote down what he saw, with the humans' day above and the night of the moon beneath, and it is the last line on that leaf:

Wind west. Rain before midnight, a small rain. A ship of the strangers going south, deep in the water.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

OF the QUESTION at DÙN THAIS

AE 49 – 56

I

Of the Basket on the Master's Table

The house of disputation at Dùn thais, Taigh na Deasbaid¹, stood at the top of the town where the street gave out into oak and hazel, a long hall of grey stone with a turf roof and one door. Over the door the old question of the schools was cut in the lintel, *Carson an làmh seo?*², why this hand, and the letters had been cut so long ago that moss grew in them and the students scraped it out with their thumbnails on the first day of every year. Inside there were benches

2. the Company

1. the house of disputation at Dùn thais

down both walls, a hearth at the far end, and a table before the hearth where the master sat. On the table lay the register. It was the third of its name. The first two, filled, stood in a press behind the master's chair, and between them they held every question that had been set in that hall since Coinneach mac Mhàrtainn first set one, with the year, and the name of the master who set it, and whatever the master had chosen to say.

In the summer of AE 49 the master was Aonghas mac Coinnich. He was forty-nine that year, a long lean man with a shepherd's stoop and a grey beard he cut himself with a knife, and he had sat at that table for eleven years. He was born in the last summer before the mist lifted, and his mother used to say that he had lain in his cradle through the winter the ships came, listening to the whole island ask where they were from. At eighteen he had been a student on the benches of that hall, and had heard the cleric of the humans argue there through the winter of Wren's disputation, and he could still do Wren's cough, which he did sometimes, when the students were slow.

It was the custom of the house that the master set one question at midsummer and the house argued it the year round. Most masters took a question out of the press, one of the old ones turned a little to catch the light of the year. On the eve of midsummer Aonghas came up the street with a basket on his arm, and the students on the benches saw that it held coal.

It was the coal of A' Chompanaidh², the Company. He had bought it at the weigh-house by the river, in marks, and he said so. It was broken small, the sort the carts shed on the road, and he tipped it out on the table beside the register and went through it with his long fingers until he found a lump the size of a fist that had split clean in the cart. He held the broken face up to the window.

"Màiri nic Ailpein," he said. "Tell me what you see."

She was the youngest on the benches, a smith's daughter of the town. Up she came, and looked, and told him, as any child of the island would have told him, beginning at the edge: the grey that the old lumps have where the air has been at them, then the brown like wet bracken, then the deep green that lies under the black at the fresh break and seems to go down into the lump further than the lump goes, then the red that grows when you breathe on it. She breathed on it, and the red grew. In all she gave the names of eleven colours, which was good for a girl of fifteen, and sat down.

2. the Company

"Fearchar," said Aonghas, and Fearchar Beag gave him fourteen. Seumas mac Artair, who kept the register and was vain of his eyes, gave him nineteen and was stopped.

"Now," said Aonghas. He put the lump down on the table. "There is a man at the weigh-house by the river who weighed this coal for me this morning. He is one of theirs, a decent man, and careful with his beam. I held up this same lump and asked him what colour it was, and he looked at me as though I had asked him the colour of water, and he said the word they have. He said *black*. The cleric said it in this hall thirty years ago. The keeper of the Company's books at Ros dhomhain says it, and An t-Àrd-mhaor³ in his house above the river, and the girl who sells ribbons off their ships. Every one of them looks at this and sees one thing." He turned the lump over. "Why?"

Nobody answered him. He had not expected an answer. He sat down at the table, pulled the register to him, and wrote the question in his own hand, in the tongue of the hall, and turned the book round so that Seumas might see it:

Carson a chì sinne an dath, is iadsan dall air?

Why do we see the colour, and they blind to it?

That is how it stands in the register, under the date 19 an t-Ògmhios, AE 49. Below it, in Seumas's hand, which is smaller and neater than the master's, is the note that has been copied into more books than the question: that when the house asked the master what the answer was, he told them it was the wrong question, and would not give them the right one.

II

Of the Summer of Arguing

They argued it all that summer, as the custom was, on the benches in the wet weather and under the oaks behind the hall when it was fine.

Seumas mac Artair held that the humans' eyes were made differently, as a dog's are, or an owl's, and that there was nothing more to be found out than that. Fearchar Beag held that it was the burning. He had it from the old tellings of Wren's winter: when the cleric had asked the masters why the vein should be holy,

3. the Commissioner; lit. 'the high steward'

they had asked him back why his fuel should be burned. A people who had burned coal by the cartload for as long as they could remember, said Fearchar, would have stopped looking at it long ago, as a man stops seeing the colour of the peat he cuts. Màiri nic Ailpein, who was fifteen and afraid of nobody, said that she had once seen a human child at Inis bheag pick up a lump from the road and turn it in the sun for a long time; and the house argued for a week about whether the child had seen anything, or had been looking at the shine, and nobody could say, since nobody had asked the child.

Aonghas let them. He sat at the table with his hands folded on the register and said almost nothing, except to stop a student who was shouting, or to send one out for more peat. When they pressed him, and they pressed him every week, he said only that the question was a poor one, and they were welcome to it.

A student from the west who had come for the summer said aloud one evening what several of them were thinking, that the master had set them a question he did not believe in so that they would find the one he did.

"Then find it," said Aonghas, and went home to his supper.

In the autumn three of them set out for Baile Mòr uaine, a long day's walk to the west over the high moor, where there was a hall of disputation of its own, older in its benches than Dùn thais and prouder. They carried the question in their heads and a copy of it in Seumas's hand, sealed. The masters of Baile Mòr uaine took it up at the dark of the year. On 15 an Dùbhlachd, AE 49, it was put to their hall for the first time, and the argument ran through that winter and the next, and the record of it, which the students sent back to Dùn thais leaf by leaf with the carriers, runs to four hundred leaves. It is the longest argument in the press. It ends, as the question did, without an answer. The last leaf is a list of the names of those who spoke, and at the foot of it the master of Baile Mòr uaine has written that the hall adjourned because the peat was done.

Aonghas read every leaf as it came. The students saw him at it late in the hall with a rushlight, turning the leaves slowly and sometimes going back. He never said which argument he thought the best. When the last leaf came, he had the whole bundle tied up with the others, and went out, and walked a long while in the oakwood in the rain.

III

Of the Town with No Custodian

Those were the years when the humans began to build towns of their own. The concession country in the north-west had been theirs to graze for thirty years, and the families there had built in stone for a generation. In the spring of the year after Aonghas set his question, they founded a market town at Cathair gheal, with a stone hall for their magistrate and a chapel with a bell, and their Administration, Riaghaltas nan Coigreach¹, sent them up a charter under its seal. The copyists have that charter, Cairt Chathair gheal, in a fair copy from the letter-books of Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir². It gives the date of the founding as 28 an Cèitean, AE 50, and the bounds of the market, and the tolls, and the rights of the magistrate over weights and measures and the ringing of the bell; and nowhere in it, in all its three sheets, is any custodian of the island named, or asked, or thanked, or told.

That same summer farmers out of the concession cleared land beside the old village of Cnoc ghorm, up in the high country of the north-west, and put up a mill on its stream. The people of Cnoc ghorm had lived under their pillar and its saying since the first ford-gatherings, and they had seen strangers come before. They sold the newcomers grain through the first winter, at a fair price, and carried it to them on their own ponies. When the mill-wheel turned in the spring, they stopped. Nobody at Cnoc ghorm said why, and the humans did not ask; but the Mission's letters speak afterwards of "a coolness at the old village," and of a boy of the farms who went up there to buy eggs and was sold none.

On the coast a few fishing families from the concession settled at Ceann mhòr under the north-western headland, on 14 am Màrt, AE 51. They were the first humans on the island to fish its waters for their own living and not for the Company's table, and the Dia-thìrich fishers of that coast, who had watched the Company's boats for fifty years, watched these more closely. The newcomers' boats went out when theirs did. They learned the marks of the reefs from them, and the set of the tides round the headland; and they took, in the second summer, to planting a leaf on the sheltered slopes behind the harbour, a coarse broad plant that they hung in their sheds to dry and sold to the Company's ships. By AE 52 there were whole terraces of it behind Ceann mhòr. Of all the plants the humans brought, that leaf alone took to the ground of the island.

The news of the charter came to the council at Cathair dhearg in the humans' tongue, since the Residency sent everything in its own tongue by then, and the

1. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

2. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

council sat a whole afternoon over three sheets that most of its members could not read.

IV

Of Eachann Mòr's Seat

One of those who could not read them was Eachann Mòr of Ceann àrsaidh.

He had sat for Ceann àrsaidh on the council for nine years. Ceann àrsaidh was an old market town on the roads some twenty miles east of the capital, with a stone crossing over its river and a great many opinions of itself. It had given the council Coinneach Glas, and it expected to be listened to. Eachann was fifty that year, a big slow man with a voice that filled the council hall without his raising it, and he knew every boundary-stone and every well-right in his country, and the names of the grandfathers of the people who used them. He had the old reckoning by heart, and the rolls of his town back to An Aois Scaraidh¹. Of the humans' tongue he had perhaps ten words, and he was ashamed of none of them.

He stood up in the council when the charter had been read, first in the humans' tongue by a clerk who had it and then in Dia-thiris by the same clerk, stumbling. He said that a town had been founded on the island under a writing that did not know the island had custodians, and that the council ought to send the writing back. The council agreed with him. It wrote to the Residency. Some weeks later an answer came in the humans' tongue, and the clerk who read it aloud stumbled again, and nobody on the benches could say afterwards with any confidence what it had meant, except that the charter stood.

Eachann went home and told Ceann àrsaidh what he had said in the hall. He told it well. But the Company had a weigh-house on the river at Ceann àrsaidh by then, and a road-agent, and a clerk who came through twice a month to settle the carting; and in the autumn, when the households met at the crossing to choose who should sit for them, a man spoke up who had never said anything at a choosing before. He was Dùghall Òg of the carting families, who had worked five years at the weigh-house and spoke the humans' tongue as fast as his own. The town needed a custodian, he said, who could read what was sent to him. There was no

1. the Age of Sundering

heat in it. Eachann Mòr, he said, was the best man in the country, and could not read a bill of lading.

They chose Dùghall. The roll of Ceann àrsaidh gives the count of hands, and it was not close.

Eachann walked home from the crossing with his wife Mairead nic Ìomhair beside him, and his son and daughter behind. He did not speak on the way. At the door of the house he stopped, and stood a while looking at the lintel, and then he turned round and looked at his son. Calum was twelve that autumn, a thin dark boy with his mother's eyes, who could already do the old reckoning faster than his father and had a way of listening at doors.

"You will have their tongue," Eachann said to him. "Better than Dùghall has it, and better than their clerks. And from their own schools."

Mairead said nothing then. She said a great deal afterwards, in the house, through the whole of that winter; and the copyists, who had the family's letters from a granddaughter's chest, found her side of the argument only in what Eachann wrote back to her from the road. He was never a man to put a thing on paper twice.

V

Of the Ship That Went North-about

There was a school in the humans' tongue on the island that spring, and he would not send Calum to it.

Teachdaireachd na h-Eaglaise¹, the Mission of the humans' faith, opened its school at Ros dhomhain on 9 an Cèitean, AE 51, in a new room built on the side of the chapel. It took thirty children in its first year and taught them their letters and their catechism and their sums, all in the humans' tongue. Most of the thirty were the children of overseers, who were paid in marks and wanted their sons to be paid in more of them. Among them, the Mission wrote home with great joy, were its first converts of the island's own people.

Eachann Mòr would not have his son at a bench among overseers' sons. That was his pride, and Mairead knew it for his pride, and told him so. But he had spoken in the autumn to the Mission's cleric at Ros dhomhain, and the cleric had

1. the Mission; lit. 'the errand of the Church'

spoken of schools over the sea, true schools, with libraries and masters, where a clever boy might learn the humans' law and come home able to read any charter the Residency could send. The cleric wrote a letter for the boy to carry. Eachann paid for the passage in marks, and he gave Calum besides a purse of marks sewn into the lining of his coat, which was nearly all the silver the house had.

They went down to Ros dhomhain in the spring, the four of them in a cart, a long day on the road through the farms and the coal-dust. The ship lay at the quay below the Residency, a Company ship going home with coal and hides, low in the water. Her master was a short man in a blue coat who looked at the boy, and at the letter, and at the purse when it was shown to him, and then wrote a line in his book. The quay was full of carts and barrows and the shouting of the men at the weighing-beam. There was nowhere to sit. The family stood by the bollards in the rain.

Calum went aboard on 10 an Giblean, AE 51. He went up the plank without looking back, since his father had told him to, and then at the rail he did look back, and lifted his hand. Ciorstaidh, who was nine, waved both her arms until her mother caught them.

The pilot of Caol leathan took the ship down the Abhainn gheal on the evening tide, and at the river's mouth she stood out to sea and turned north, as every ship of the humans turned, to go up the west coast past the headlands and out past the north cape into the grey water beyond, and so round by the north to the humans' land. That is the only road. The strangers' first ships had come down by it, and the fleet of An Aois Scaraidh² had gone out by it long before. Mairead said afterwards that she hated to think of him going the long way, round the whole island, when the land he was going to lay somewhere off to the east where the sun came up. Eachann said that the ship knew its road. He stood on the quay until the masts had gone down the river out of sight behind the reeds, and then he went up to the Mission and thanked the cleric, and gave him a cheese.

VI

Of the Letters That Did Not Come

2. the Age of Sundering

The Mission's cleric had said a letter would come by the autumn ships. None came.

Eachann went down to Ros dhomhain when the autumn ships were in, and stood at the Company's counter and asked, through a pupil of the Mission school whom he paid a penny, whether any letter had come for the house of Eachann Mòr of Ceann àrsaidh. The clerk looked through a box and said none had. The ship that had carried Calum was not among the ships in, and the clerk did not know when she would be.

In the winter Eachann wrote a letter himself. He wrote it in Dia-thìris, since he could write nothing else, and took it to Ros dhomhain, and paid the pupil to put it into the humans' tongue under his own lines; and he gave it to the master of the first ship going north in the spring, with a mark for the trouble. It went, and there was no answer to it. He wrote another the next winter. The copyists found copies of four such letters among the family's papers, each longer than the last, all of them telling the boy about the harvest and his sister and the price of oats and the dog, and none of them asking him outright to write back. Mairead's hand is on the fourth, below her husband's, one line: *Scrìobh gu do mhàthair*. Write to your mother.

In the year after Calum sailed, the custodians of Inis bhàn in the north opened a school of their own, twenty-odd miles up the road from Ceann àrsaidh, on 7 an t-Ògmhios, AE 52. They said openly that it was an answer to the Mission's. They taught the old reckoning of years and moons and the reading of the rolls, and the names of the hills, every hill that could be seen from the school's door and a great many that could not, with the tale that went with each name. Eachann sent Ciorstaidh there. She was ten. She came home at midsummer able to name forty hills and argue with her father about the boundaries of his own parish, and the next year the Mission complained in writing to the custodians of Inis bhàn that the children who came to its school from theirs arrived already knowing how to argue. The custodians of Inis bhàn had that letter read aloud at their gathering and then kept it, as a testimonial.

In the third year Eachann went down to the Company's counter again and asked for the ship by name. This time the clerk found her in his book. She had come in to the island twice since the spring Calum sailed, he said, and gone out again, and her master had since been given another run. Against the day Calum sailed, the book had one line, which the clerk read out and the pupil turned into Dia-thìris for the old man: a passenger, a native boy, his fare paid in full.

Eachann asked what had become of the passenger. The clerk said that was not a thing his book would know.

VII

Of the Coal Road in the East

While Eachann Mòr waited at Ceann àrsaidh, the Company came east. It had opened workings in the eastern hills, and it wanted a road to the sea for their coal that did not go the long way round by the capital. Up the valley from Inis bheag there was an old bridge over the river at Ros fhionn, Drochaid Ros fhionn, which Ailean Clachair had first built and whose piers the masons of An Aois Naomh¹ had mended. The river had silted below it in the last generations, and the salt trade had gone off to the coast, and the carts had stopped crossing; the office of the bridge-keeper had been done away with, and the grass had grown up between the stones. In the spring the Company's masons came and rebuilt it for heavy carts. They left Ailean Clachair's sign in the keystone where it was, since it bore nothing up; and on 1 an Giblean, AE 53, the first coal-carts went over.

Aonghas walked over to see them, since Ros fhionn was no great distance from Dùn thais, and he took the students with him. They sat on the bank below the bridge all one afternoon and watched the carts go over, forty in the afternoon, each with its load heaped and roped and a boy on top to hold the rope. The drivers were most of them of the island, hill-men from the camps, and when the students shouted to them from the bank to throw down a lump, some of them did, laughing. Two of the drivers were humans. The students watched them closely. The humans looked at the coal they drove as a man looks at a load of stones, and at the students on the bank as though they had lost their wits.

"There," said Seumas mac Artair to the master. "The eyes."

"Perhaps," said Aonghas, and threw the lump he was holding back up to the next cart, and the driver caught it.

The coal went down over the bridge to the river quays of Inis bheag and there onto barges for Caol chrom at the river's mouth, where the ships took it. The Company deepened the river at the quays with a gang of men and a great iron

1. the Holy Age

scoop worked by a horse, and to make room for the coal-stage it moved the town's fish market, which had stood on that quay since before there was a town, up the hill to a yard behind the tannery. By the winter of AE 53 the quays at Inis bheag could load no more, and the barges began to go on down the Abhainn bheag to Baile mhin, a short way below, whose people took the overflow and were paid by the barge. On 13 am Faoilleach, AE 54, the first barge was loaded there, and within two years Baile mhin had its first houses of stone, built out of the Company's money by the men who loaded the Company's coal.

Caol gharbh on the coast had hoped for the traffic. It had taken the salt trade when the river silted, a lifetime before, and its people had watched the bridge go up and made ready. But the Company's road ran down to the river quays and passed Caol gharbh by a mile, and all Caol gharbh ever had of the eastern coal was the dust, which came over on the east wind and lay on the washing. Its custodians wrote to the council at Cathair dhearg, on 11 an Gearran, AE 54, that they had not known a town could be harmed by a road it was not on. The council filed the letter. Aonghas had a copy of it from a student of that country, and he pinned it to the door of the hall, beside the lintel, where it stayed until the rain took it.

VIII

Of the Things the Clerks Could Not File

There were things in those years the clerks of the Residency never knew where to put.

In the spring of AE 55 the crew of a Company brig came into Ceann mhòr with their mainsail split and their master white to the lips, and said that off the north-western headlands, on a clear morning, a beast had come up beside them that was longer than their ship. It had lain on the water, they said, and looked at them, and gone down. The report went to the Residency, as all reports did, and the clerk there read it, and filed it on 12 am Màrt, AE 55, among the complaints about pirates, having no other box it would fit. The fishers of that coast heard of it and were not surprised. Uilebheist na Mara¹ had been seen off those capes since An Aois Àrsaidh², and had fouled their nets within living memory;

1. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

2. the Ancient Age

they said they had wondered how long the humans would sail there before they saw it too.

In the autumn of the same year a brig bound for the northern landing with tools was caught by a gale in sea-mist off Eilean fhada and driven onto the skerries there. Her crew waited for the ebb and waded ashore through the weed, and walked along the coast in the wet to the harbour at Caol bheag, where the fishers took them in and dried them by their fires. On 13 an t-Sultain, AE 55, her master made his report. Thereafter the Company's charts marked the northern passage as foul from midwinter to the end of spring, which were the months of the gales and the mist, and its masters were bidden not to sail in them without need; and so, from that year, few ships came to the island or went from it for a third of every year. At Ceann àrsaidh Mairead nic Ìomhair heard of the new rule from a carter and asked what it meant. When it was explained to her, she said that she would stop going to the door in those months, then, and mostly did.

That winter the human fishers of the concession taught the boats of Àth fhionn to go out after the whales with the hand-lance, and not wait for them to strand. The men of Àth fhionn had taken whales as the sea gave them since the first harbour there, and had thanked Manannan for each one. They went out now in the humans' way, six to a boat, and killed them in the open water, and rendered the oil in pots on the shore and sold it to the Company for its lamps. After 9 an Dùbhlachd, AE 55, the whale-boats went out from the north coast every summer.

And in the summer of AE 56 two of the Company's surveyors came up to Doire uaine in the hills above Muileann chiar with chains and pegs and a boy to carry the instruments. The hills there are cut with the old writing that nobody can read, lines of it yards long, some of it scored across by the same kind of tool that cut it; and the people of the villages under them hold that the writing speaks of a thing that walks without breath, the Marbh-bhèd³, which falls on anyone who lights a fire in its sight. No fire has been lit where those hills can see it since An Aois Àrsaidh. The villagers told the surveyors so, through the boy. They told them not to go up. The surveyors thanked them and went up on 21 an Lùnastal, AE 56, with a tinder-box in their pack, and camped on the high ground, and were not seen again.

The Company sent a search party of eight men. They went up into the hills one morning and came back down that same evening. They had found the sur-

3. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

veyors' last camp and their chains laid out along a ridge, they said, and a fire-ring of stones with no ash in it; and past that they would not go, not for the agent's pay nor for his threats, and not one of them would say why. The agent wrote to the Residency that the men were idle.

The villagers of Doire uaine did then what their grandparents had done after any death on the high ground. They took salt and coal to the foot of the hills and left them on a flat stone there, for the sith. The Company's agent for that country heard of it, and sent men on 19 an t-Sultain, AE 56 to gather up the coal, since he would have no coal left lying about the country to be picked up by anyone who liked, and he had it carted back to the stockpile and weighed. After that the villagers left salt alone on the stone. The Company's men came up the next season and looked at the salt and let it lie.

IX

Of the Question Put Back

Eachann Mòr came to Dùn thais at the end of the harvest of that year, when the rowans were red.

It was forty miles and more from Ceann àrsaidh, two long days on a borrowed horse, and he was fifty-six and had grown heavy, and he came into the town stiff and grey with the dust of the coal-road. He asked in the street for the master of the house of disputation. They sent him up the hill to the hall. Aonghas was at the table with the register open, and the students were out under the oaks, and there was nobody else in the hall at all.

Eachann had not met him before. He had heard of the question, as everyone on the island had heard of it by then, from the carriers and the carters and the hearths; and he had heard, from a carter, of the salt on the stone at Doire uaine, and of the men who would not go past a cold fire-ring. He sat down on the end of the nearest bench, since nobody asked him to sit and he could not stand any longer, and told the master who he was. Then he told him about the ship.

He told it straight through, as a custodian tells a matter to the council: the choosing at the crossing, and the Mission's letter, and the purse sewn into the coat, and the quay in the rain, and the four letters, and the clerk's one line. He did not hurry it. Aonghas did not stop him. When it was done he sat with his big

hands on his knees, and the rooks went over the roof, and after a while he came to what he had ridden two days to ask.

"He could see it," he said. "He could name more in a lump than I could, by the time he was eight. His mother used to set him to it for a game, by the fire." He looked at the basket, which was still on the table, with the Company's coal in it. "Five years he has been among them. Eating what they eat. Burning what they burn, by the cartload. Hearing their word for it and no other." He stopped. "When he comes home, will he see it?"

Aonghas looked at him for a long time.

Then he took the split lump out of the basket, the same one, and turned its broken face to the window, and held it out across the table; and Eachann took it, not knowing what else to do, and looked, and the colours came up out of it for him as they always had, the grey at the edge and the brown and the green under the black and the red when his breath touched it.

"You see it," said Aonghas.

"I have always seen it."

"And you want me to tell you whether your son does, in a country none of us has seen, among a people I cannot see into." He took the lump back and laid it in the basket. "Seven years ago I set this house a question. Why do we see the colour, and they are blind to it? The house has argued it ever since, and so has Baile Mòr uaine, four hundred leaves of it. You have ridden two days to ask me the same question turned round. I told my students it was the wrong question. I will not answer it for you any more than I would for them."

"Then what is the right one?"

"I do not know," said Aonghas. "If I knew it I would have written it down."

Eachann Mòr sat a while longer. Then he got up off the bench, heavily, and thanked the master for his time, as a custodian thanks a man who has told the council nothing, and went out into the yellow evening and down the hill to find his horse.

Seumas mac Artair, coming in from the oaks, met him at the door and asked the master afterwards who the big man had been. Aonghas told him, and told him why he had come. Seumas asked whether he should put it in the register.

"Put in that a man came from Ceann àrsaidh to ask the question," said the master, "and that the master did not answer it."

Seumas wrote it down. It is the last entry in Aonghas mac Coinnich's hand of that year, or rather in Seumas's under his dictation, dated at the end of the harvest

of AE 56. Below it the rest of the leaf is empty. The basket stood on the table in the hall through the winter, with the Company's coal in it, and the students took lumps from it to argue over and put them back, and none of them was ever burned.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Of the Tithe and the Flux

AE 57 – 62

I

Of the Schedule Read Twice

The paper came down from the Residency in am Gearran of that year, folded in three and sealed with the Administration's wax, and the custodian who broke the seal at Cathair dhearg could not read a word of it.

Nobody at the council table could. It was the humans' writing, close and slanted, three sheets of it, and under Lisle's hand at the foot a line in Dia-thìris so cramped it might have been an afterthought: *the schedule follows below*. The council sent for the Mission's pupil, a girl of fifteen called Barabal nic Dhùghaill who had learned her letters at Ros dhomhain and her sums from a clerk who liked to be flattered, and she stood at the table's end with the three sheets shaking a little in her hands and read Lisle's schedule into Dia-thìris while the custodians listened.

What it came to was this. The Administration's part of the mined coal, which had stood at one sack in five since Maddox's day, was to rise to one sack in three. Barabal read the figure twice, thinking she had misheard herself, and the second time it was the same.

"One in three," said the custodian of Cnoc bheag, an old man who had sat at that table longer than anyone living. "Read the reason."

There was no reason given. Barabal turned the sheets over to be sure, and turned them back, and said there was none.

"Ask her to read the figure a third time," said a younger custodian at the foot of the table, a woman new enough to her seat that she still thought a wrong sum might be undone by the asking.

Barabal read it a third time. It came to the same.

The hall at Cathair dhearg where the council sat was the same low stone room it had sat in since before the strangers came, with a hearth at one end that smoked in a westerly and a table scarred by three generations of knife-cuts where clerks had trimmed their pens against the wood rather than find a board. Barabal stood at the foot of it in her Mission grey with the three sheets in her two hands, and she has said since, to the one custodian who ever thought to ask her, that she was more afraid of the room than of the news, since she had never before been looked at by so many people at once who wanted something from her that she could not give them, which was a smaller figure.

The old custodian of Cnoc bheag asked her to read Lisle's line at the foot once more, the cramped one that named the schedule. She read it. He asked whether there was anything above the fold, any mark of the Residency's council or seal beyond Lisle's own hand. There was the Administration's wax and nothing else. He sat a while with his hands flat on the table, and then said that the roll should have her rendering copied into it entire, with her name at the foot, so that no one might ever say the island had not been told what was done to it, only that it had not been able to stop it. Barabal, who had expected to be thanked or dismissed and had not thought to be asked to sign anything, wrote her name under the copy in a hand rounder than her fifteen years, and it stands there yet.

AE 57 is remembered on the coal roads as the year of the schedule, and Lisle's is the hand under it, though whether the figure was his own asking or an order sent to him from over the sea that he only signed, no one at Cathair dhearg could say. His letter-book, which survives, gives no reason either. It gives an account of the cost of the new customs house at Ros gheal, and a note that the silver guild's compact must on no account be touched, and then, three lines down, the new fraction, as if it followed from the customs house and the silver both.

The custodians wrote a copy of Barabal's rendering into the roll of every coal town on the island, word for word, with the date and her name at the foot of

each, so that whoever asked how the tithe had doubled without a war to explain it would find one paper that said so in the island's own tongue, made by one of its own, and not only the Administration's sealed sheets that few could read.

II

Of the Weighing at Dùn fhiadhaich

At Dùn fhiadhaich, which stood among the barley fields under Cnoc naomh and had never dug so much as a bucket of coal, the tithe-gatherer arrived in the spring with a wagon, a set of scale-beams, and a paper that named the town among those that must pay.

The town's grain, he said, fed the men who worked the pits at Muileann chrom and Achadh dhomhain, and so the town shared in the pits' gain and would share in their tithe. He set his scales up in the market square between the well and the mill, and the farmers brought their sacks and stood in a line that ran the length of the square and back, and watched one sack in three of the year's barley go into the wagon while the rest went home with them.

A farmer near the head of the line, a man called Griogair Fada who held the largest acreage under Cnoc naomh and so had the most sacks to lose, asked the gatherer straight out whether it was the pits' fraction that had gone up or the farms' fraction that was new. The gatherer, who was a young man himself and plainly uneasy with the question, said only that his paper named Dùn fhiadhaich and gave a weight for grain against it, and that he had not written the paper and could not answer for what was in the mind of the man who had.

"Then who can," said Griogair, "since he is not here to be asked."

The gatherer had no answer to that either, and weighed the sacks as his paper said, and by evening the wagon stood a third heavier than the town's own store, and the line of farmers going home carried two sacks in three back through the same square where their grandfathers had once carried salt to trade for iron before any human had set foot on the island at all.

The custodians of Dùn fhiadhaich wrote the thing into their roll under a name of their own, since no name for it had come down from the Residency: *deachamh an deachaimh*, the tithe on the tithe, for it seemed to them a strange doubling, to be taxed for feeding men who were themselves taxed. The name held. It is the name the town still gives that spring, when old men there are asked about

it, though the grandchildren of the men who stood in that line no longer quite remember what the first tithe had been for, only that it is called by a name that means twice paid, and that this is reason enough not to like it.

III

Of the Sick-House in the Chapel

Anne Colby came ashore at Ros dhomhain on 16 an Gearran, AE 57, twenty-two years old, with a chest of the Mission's linen and a case of instruments she had been shown how to use twice on the crossing and never once before. She had asked to be sent to the island because her brother had gone out with Harrow's ships years before and never written home, and she had a notion, which she kept to herself, that she might find some word of him among the quays. She found no word of him on the island, and in her third summer she found the flux instead.

It broke first in the crowded lodgings above the harbour, where the men who worked the counting-house and the steelyard slept eight and ten to a room the Company let them for what it cost the Company nothing to build. By the second week of an t-Iuchar the sick lay two to a bed in those rooms, and by the third the well behind the counting-house had been fouled, though no one owned to knowing how; and the Mission's chapel, the long timber hall on the quay with its iron bell, stood shut between its services, the width of the quay from the lodgings.

Colby had the door opened and the benches carried out into the yard and did not ask leave of anyone to do it. She laid down what straw she could buy and what linen the Mission would give her, and she and two women of the harbour quarter, a widow called Mòr nic Amhlaidh and her daughter, began to carry the sick up from the lodgings on a hand-barrow, six and eight a day, until the long timber room held as many as could lie down in it and the yard held the rest under a sailcloth awning that Colby had begged off a shipmaster for the promise of prayers for his crossing.

Mòr nic Amhlaidh had lost a husband to the sea and two children to the spotted pox years before Colby ever landed, and she is said to have told the young nurse, on the first night the two of them washed the chapel floor together by lamplight, that she had buried enough of her own to know the trick of it: that the dying wanted their names said to them more than they wanted the fever broken,

since the fever generally broke or did not on its own account regardless of what hands did to it, while a name said plainly by someone who meant it could be given to a man right up to the last hour, cost nothing, and was sometimes the only thing left to give. Colby, who had come out with instruments and had been taught nothing at all about names, took the advice as if it had been part of her training from the start, and it may be from that one night's washing of a floor that the whole of what she did afterward followed.

The days ran much alike. She rose before light, walked the yard and the room together and marked who had worsened in the night, then spent the forenoon at the lodgings themselves, since the Company's own physician would not go into them and someone had to judge which of the newly fallen could still walk to the chapel on their own legs and which must wait for the barrow. At midday she ate standing, generally bread and whatever fish Mòr's daughter had got cheap at the quay, and in the afternoon she boiled linen in a copper the Mission had once used for washing altar cloths and now used for nothing else. The custodians' roll, which took to noting her comings and goings as it noted little else about the Mission, records that she was seen to sleep, in the worst of that season, no more than four hours together, and generally on a bench in the yard rather than in the room the Mission had given her in the town, since the room was a mile off and the sick were not.

She was told by the Company's own surgeon, who came once and did not come again, that she would do better to let the sick lie where they were and keep the well-off away from them. He stood in the chapel doorway with a cloth held to his own face and would not come further in than the threshold, and told her, in the tone of a man passing on a kindness, that a chapel crowded with the dying was no place for a young woman to make her name. She answered him that the well-off were already dying, since the flux never troubled to ask a man's wages before it took him, and asked him to leave, which by his own account, written years after in a letter to his son, he was glad to do.

He did send, before he left the harbour for good that season, a case of the salts he judged best against the flux, with a note that she was welcome to try them though he held out no great hope of them, and Colby used every grain in the case and kept the empty box afterward on the chapel's one shelf, since it was, whatever the man's manners, the only help the Company's own physician ever sent her.

What she did instead, and what the roll of the custodians credits her for, was to learn the sick by name. Not the Company's names for them, which were their

number on the pay-roll and the gang they worked in, but the names the custodians already kept, each man and woman with a house and a mother and a place of birth set down against them in the town's own roll. She sat at the door of the chapel each evening with that roll open on her knee and a clerk's boy to read her the entries, and she wrote against each name who lived and who did not, in her own hand, in the humans' tongue, a column the custodians could not read, and turned the roll round on the table each evening so they could see for themselves that it was there.

Fourteen died in her chapel before the flux burned out in the autumn, and the custodians' roll, which counted the quarter's dead with care, credits her with keeping them under fifteen. The town remembers her less for the number than for the list she kept, of the men who died in her chapel, every name spelled right, and that when the families came to ask, she did not need the roll open on her knee to tell them.

IV

Of the Barges to Seann Vell

The coal barges that ran the river east from Ros dhomhain to the port of Seann Vell had no part in the flux at first, or none that anyone marked until a bargeman fell sick at his pole on 7 an t-Ògmhios, AE 60 and was put ashore at the Seann Vell landing rather than carried on, since the barge-master judged, wrongly as it turned out, that a man on dry land had a better chance than a man on the water.

Within the fortnight the sickness was in three of the landing's houses, and within the month it was in a dozen. The custodians of Seann Vell, a river town that had never before had cause to shut anything, shut the only quay the town had for the coal traffic that fed it, and let no barge tie up there for the length of a season.

The Company fined them for it. The letter that came down from the pay office cited the loss of a season's landing fees and made no mention of the flux at all, as though the town had shut its own quay for no better reason than mischief. The custodian who received it, a woman called Mairead nic Amhlaidh who was no kin to the widow at Ros dhomhain though she shared her name, as the island's names will run twice and thrice over between towns that never knew each other, read the

fine to the town council standing on the landing steps, within sight of the graves the town had dug that season on the rise above it, and said only that the Company's letter had been well timed, if nothing else, to arrive on the day the last of the dead were being sung over.

The custodians of Seann Vell paid the fine out of the same purse that had buried their dead, since there was no other purse to pay it from, and wrote in their roll, in the flat hand the roll keeps for things it does not trust plain words to say, that the Company had weighed a season's coin against a season's dead and found the coin heavier.

Colby heard of it at Ros dhomhain from a bargeman who had carried the news downriver along with a cargo of empty sacks, and she walked the eighteen miles to Seann Vell on a day when the chapel could spare her, along the towpath where the barges no longer ran, with the river low and brown beside her and the landing, when she reached it, as quiet as she had ever seen a coal port. She stayed a week helping to lay out the last of that town's dead before she went back to her own, and it was at Seann Vell, sitting with Mairead nic Amhlaidh over the town's own roll one evening, that she first thought to ask whether any other town kept such a list, and was told that most did, after their own fashion, and that no one had ever thought to keep one list of the sickness across every town it touched, only each town's account of its own.

V

Of the Seal Passed On

Arthur Lisle died at the Residency on 3 am Màrt, AE 61, of a fever that settled in his chest and then, the Residency's own physician wrote, in his heart, so that he was a fortnight dying by inches with his clerks bringing him papers to the last, since he would not be told he could not sign them. He was one and sixty years old, a lawyer by training who had come to the office at forty-one and never in his twenty years at the Residency raised his voice at a council table, which the custodians who dealt with him counted, on the whole, in his favour, though they did not forgive him the schedule.

Walter Crane, who had been the Company's chief agent at the pits since before Lisle's time, took the Residency's seal within the month. He was six and forty, a heavier man than Lisle, quicker to anger and quicker to forget it, who had

spent his years among the coal camps rather than at a desk and knew the roads between Achadh dhomhain and Muileann chrom better than he knew the Residency's own corridors. He came to the seal in his own riding coat, still splashed to the knee from the pit roads, and it is told, though not in any hand that signed its name to the telling, that he sat at Lisle's own desk on his first morning and pushed the dead man's inkstand a foot to the left before he would so much as open the first paper on it, for Lisle, he said, had kept it in a fool's place for a right-handed man.

Crane was the first man to hold the Company's office and the Administration's one after the other, and the custodians noted the thing without saying what they thought of it, though what they thought is not hard to guess: that the two offices, which had been kept carefully apart since Harrow's day so that neither office might answer only to its own master, now answered to one man's convenience. Crane himself, when a custodian of Cathair dhearg put the question to him plainly at his first council, said only that he saw no sense in the island having two masters where one would do the work of both more cheaply, and that the council might take that for whatever comfort it was worth. It was taken for none.

Crane's first order from the Residency, given within the week, was that the pits should not slacken for the change of one Commissioner to another. His second, given the same week, moved the Company's pay office for the southern workings from the pit-heads themselves to the town of Ceann mhin.

VI

Of the Day's Walk to Ceann mhin

The reason given, when a reason was given at all, was that a single pay office serving the whole southern district would keep truer books than a paymaster riding from pit to pit with the coin in his saddlebags, as had been done till then, and lose fewer sacks of silver to bad roads and worse arithmetic. It may even have been true. What it meant for the crews was a day's walk to Ceann mhin and a day's walk back, twice in every month, to stand in a line at a window and be paid what they were owed, and no pay at all for the two days spent walking to collect it.

Uisdean Ruadh, who hewed at Muileann chrom and had a wife and three children to feed on what he carried home, walked it the first time in company

with forty other men of his gang, setting out before light on a morning of frost with their breath standing in clouds ahead of them on the road. His wife had packed him bread and a twist of dried fish the night before and asked him, only half in jest, whether he meant to be paid or only to walk, since the two seemed to have become separate undertakings, and he had no answer for her beyond that a man went where the coin was kept and not where it was easiest to fetch.

They reached Ceann mhin at midday, stood in the pay line till near dusk behind the crews of two other pits who had the same idea of an early start, and walked the road home again in the dark, so that the two days it cost them to be paid were, by his own reckoning kept afterward on a stick he notched at his door, worth rather less than the pay itself. The line at the window moved slowly because the clerk within counted every coin twice, being new to the office and afraid of a wrong tally more than he was troubled by the length of the queue outside, and the men waiting had time enough to talk among themselves of little else but the road, so that by the third pay-day the walk, and not the wage at the end of it, had become the thing the gangs of Muileann chrom spoke of first when they met men of other pits.

The custodians of Ceann mhin, whose town gained a fortnight's trade in bread and small beer from every pay-day and complained of it to no one, kept no roll of the walk at all. It is Uisdean Ruadh's notched stick, kept by his family three generations after him and shown still to those who ask, that is the only record of what the day cost the men who walked it.

VII

Of Ragnall's Burying

Ragnall mac Dhòmhnai, whom the crews and the custodians both had come to call Ragnall Maor, died at Muileann chrom in am Màrt of AE 62, seventy-two years old, in the slate-roofed house the Company had built him above the pit he had first walked into as a guide to Company men who did not know one seam of coal from another.

He had been ill through the winter with a wasting the surgeon called an old man's cough and treated as one, and Colby, sent for from Ros dhomhain in his last week by a message from his son that she never learned the whole of, sat with

him two nights before the end, more for the son's sake than for any doctoring she could do, since there was none left to do.

The house surprised her, though she had heard it spoken of often enough on the coal roads: a slate roof over dressed stone, the only one of its kind for miles, with a hearth big enough to be a custodian's and a window of real glass looking down on the pit-head, so that a man lying in the bed the Company had given him could watch, if he chose, the crews going down and coming up without ever leaving it. Raghnaill did not choose to. He had the bed turned, in the last weeks, so that it faced the door and not the window, and when Colby asked him once, more to have something to say than because she expected an answer, why he had it so, he told her that he had looked at that pit-head every day for fifty years and saw no cause to spend his last ones at it as well.

He said little to her that she thought worth setting down, being a man who had never been given to speaking of himself even in his own house, but on the second night he asked her, apropos of nothing that had passed between them, whether she wrote her dead down by name, as the town said she did. When she told him yes, he said that was a good thing to keep doing, and spoke no more before morning. In the small hours before he died he spoke once more, to the room rather than to her, a few words in Dia-thìris that his son, sitting on the other side of the bed, kept from Colby then and always, though the son is said to have written them down somewhere in his own hand, in a paper that has not survived.

Dòmhnall mac Raghnaill, his son, was two and forty that year and had broken his first coal at six in the year of the dry cough and lived, which the custodians had not expected him to. He had grown into a quieter man than his father, by every account, and had worked twenty years at his father's side without any sign that he wanted the staff for himself, and it is said of him, by the one custodian who thought to ask him afterward, that he had hoped, as much as any man in the town, that the office would go elsewhere.

The Company gave him his father's staff within the week of the burying, the office and the slate roof and the crews together, as though the three were one inheritance and not three separate things a son might have been asked whether he wanted. A clerk came up from the pay office at Ceann mhin with the paper already drawn, needing only Dòmhnall's mark at the foot of it, and stood in the slate-roofed house's own doorway while Dòmhnall read it through twice before he signed, less because he doubted the terms than because he seems to have

wanted, for those few minutes, to be a man still deciding rather than a man already decided for.

The custodians of Muileann chrom, who had buried eleven men under Ragh-nall's first gallery and watched him take the Company's pay to keep his crews at the face rather than lose it, had hoped, without quite saying so to one another, that the office might die with him and the crews go back to choosing their own foreman as they had before the pits opened. It did not die with him. It went from father to son as if it had always been meant to, and the custodians' hope, which had never been written down anywhere and so cannot properly be said to have died either, went with it.

Ragh-nall was buried on the hill above Muileann chrom beside the eleven, in ground the town had kept for its own dead since before the Company came, on a morning of thin rain that put out the torches twice before the custodian gave up lighting them and let the burying go on in the grey light alone. The whole pit turned out, both shifts together, which had not happened for any death at Muileann chrom in living memory, since a pit that stops both shifts at once stops its coal as well, and the Company had never before let that be reckoned worth the cost of one man's grave, whoever the man.

Colby stood at the edge of the grave among the crews with her list from the chapel still in the bag she carried everywhere, though there was no name to add to it that day but his. She had walked down from Ros dhomhain the day before on hearing the word, arriving too late to sit with him again but in good time for the burying, and she stood a little apart from the townsfolk, as she generally did at such gatherings, being neither of the crews nor of the custodians nor, any longer, entirely of the Mission either, but something the coal roads had made of her that had no ready name.

Dòmhnall stood at the graveside in his father's place and said nothing that any account sets down, though one among the crew is remembered to have said afterward that he had watched Dòmhnall's hand close twice on nothing, as a man's hand will close on a staff it has not yet been given and already knows the shape of. When it was over he walked back down the hill to the slate-roofed house alone, and the crews went back to the pit within the hour, since the pit did not stop for a burying any longer than the Company judged it must, any more than it had stopped for the schedule, the flux, or the day's walk to be paid.

Colby wrote Ragh-nall's name into her roll that evening in the same hand she had used for every name before it, with the date and the place, and under it, be-

cause she had begun by then to think it worth doing for everyone she buried and not only for the flux dead, a line of who he had been: *hewer, then Steward, father of Dòmhnall*. It was the only line in the whole roll that named an office. Why she wrote it there she never said to anyone the roll names, though a person who had watched five years of schedules and tithes and pay offices come down from the Residency without a single name attached to any of them might have guessed at her reason well enough.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Of Lowe's Spade

AE 63 – 68

Ithidh Mòd an neach a dh'itheas an cnoc.

Mòd will eat whoever eats the hill.

I

Of the Coloured Flame at Muileann bheag

Four beacons burned on the coasts of Dia-thìr by the sixty-third year of the strangers, and three of them still burned oil, the old way, a wick fed from a cistern and trimmed each watch by a keeper who climbed the stair in the dark and came down again at dawn with his fingers black. The fourth was at Muileann bheag on the north shore, and it burned coal.

Edwin Lowe came up from Ros dhomhain to see it that winter, riding a Company mule with a satchel of paper across his knees, sent by the Mission to look into a complaint the beacon's own keepers had laid before the custodians and the custodians had, in their way, laid before nobody. He was thirty-eight years old that year, a cleric without a parish, thin in the shoulder and going grey early, and he had been eleven years on the island without once finding the thing he had

come to find, which was proof, of one kind or another, that the god his Church preached had been here before him, or that no god had, and either answer would have done, so long as it was an answer.

He had come out from an *Tír Thall*¹ a young man with a licence to preach and a private letter of introduction to a bishop who had since died without reading it, and had drifted, in the way of men whose first errand fails them quietly, into the Mission's smaller work: the copying of custodians' rolls that some clerk in the Residency wanted translated, the measuring of ruins nobody else had time for, the answering of complaints too strange for the Company's own agents to be troubled with. Eleven years of it had made him into a kind of scholar the island had no name for and did not quite trust, a man who asked the custodians questions a Mission cleric had no business asking and wrote down their answers in a hand too careful to be idle curiosity. The road to *Muileann bheag*, three days of mule-track and one of open coast, was nothing to him by then; he had ridden worse for less.

The keeper at *Muileann bheag* was a broad, weathered man named *Ailig mac Griogair*, who had tended the light since it burned oil and had asked, three winters running, to be let go back to the old lamp. He took Lowe up the stair himself.

"There," he said, at the top, and pointed down through the lantern glass at the black water below the point, where the beam swung slow across the swell. "You'll not see it. None of your people see it. But it's there."

Lowe looked, and saw firelight on water, the ordinary orange wash of a flame thrown wide by a curved glass, breaking and mending on the chop. He said as much.

"It's a green under the orange," said *Ailig*. "A green like nothing that was ever in a flame before, and it lies on the water a long way out, further than the beam itself should carry, and it comes and it goes with no wind to account for it. The herring won't come in under it. Ask any boat on this coast."

"And before the beacon burned coal?"

"The oil flame never did it. No flame ever did it before this one." *Ailig's* own son had gone twice to the custodians of the town about it, and had been heard and sent away with nothing added to the roll, for the custodians could find no law the flame broke; a man might burn what he liked in his own lamp, and the beacon was the Company's now in all but the keeping of it. "They say it drives the

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

herring off. I say it lays a colour on the sea that was never laid there before, and that a colour laid on the sea is a thing worth minding, whatever it does to the fish."

Lowe wrote the complaint down as he had been asked, word for word, and climbed down the stair, and stood a long while on the point in the cold with his collar up, looking at the black water and the orange wash on it, trying to see the green the keeper saw, and the more he stared the more certain he became that there was nothing there to see, only firelight doing what firelight had always done to water, breaking and mending, breaking and mending.

He came back to the point twice more before he left the district, once at dusk and once before the dawn watch, and stood the same span of the same cold each time, and saw the same nothing. On the second visit Ailig's own son, a boy of perhaps twelve who had never known the beacon burn anything but coal, came down and stood beside him without being asked and looked where he looked.

"Well?" said Lowe.

"You're looking too hard," the boy said. "It's not a thing you look for. It's a thing you see, the way you see it's raining before you feel the first drop."

Lowe asked him what colour it was, precisely, and the boy considered a long while, the way a child considers a question put to him seriously for the first time, and said only that it was a green that made him think of nothing else he had ever seen, which was, Lowe wrote afterward, the most honest answer given him in eleven years on the island, and the least useful.

He wrote in his own book, that night, in the humans' letters, a single line that he did not send to the Mission with the rest: *I begin to think there are two islands here, laid one over the other, and I have been sent to survey only mine.*

Within the season the herring came back in under the light as they had always come, in their numbers, as if the sea had settled some dispute of its own and moved on; and the letter the fishermen of Muileann bheag had first sent was withdrawn in a second letter, which the Company kept beside the first, and neither was ever answered. The keepers did not change the lamp. They never did, in all the years it burned.

Lowe's true errand that season lay further south and east, at a low ruin among gorse and standing water that the island called Làrach an Teampaill¹, the temple that had stood, empty and unclaimed by any faith the Dia-thìrich kept, since before the oldest roll of any custodian house began. Three ages of scholars had measured it and gone away no wiser. Lowe meant to be the fourth, and to dig where the others had only measured.

He got Company labourers for the digging, six men off the coal contracts at Doire ghlais who wanted the winter wage and had never held a spade for anything but coal, and a custodian of Doire ghlais, Griogal Odhar, came out with them most mornings to watch, never to work, and sat on the fallen lintel with his hands on his knees the way a man sits at a wake.

The ruin itself was low, little more to the eye than a rise of gorse and grey stone in a hollow of poor grazing land, with a single lintel still standing over what had once been a door and the rest of the walls sunk to their footings under a century of turf. Sheep grazed the mound in every season but this one, and the shepherds of Àth mhòr, whose flocks it was, had turned them off it without being asked, and would not say why beyond that it had always been the custom, on the days the ground was opened, to keep beasts from a grave until the grave was shut again.

They opened the ground inside the western wall first, where the old measurements had marked an altar, and found in the first week worked stone below the turf, cut square and laid without mortar, in courses too even for any wall the labourers' own grandfathers had raised. Lowe measured each course as it came clear, and noted that the stone was not of the district, a hard pale grey unlike the darker rock of the hills round about, and must have been carried some distance, by what means over what road he could not say, for no road the island now kept ran anywhere near the place.

In the second week they found bone, burnt through, packed in a shallow pit beside the altar stone with ash and a scatter of small worked flints that answered to no tool any smith of the island had ever made or named. The bone crumbled at a touch, and Lowe had the labourers stop digging round it and clear the earth away with their hands instead, a spoonful at a time, so that what came up came up whole; and it was slow, cold work, the men on their knees in the wet through the shortening days, breathing on their fingers between handfuls, and none of

1. the temple ruin

them complained of the wage, though more than one of them complained, quietly, to Griogal Odhar, of the work itself.

The labourers stopped there. Lowe pressed them to go deeper, and the eldest of the six, a broad quiet man called Tormod Ruadh, drove his spade upright in the loose earth at the pit's edge and would not lift it again.

"It's bone under an altar that was old before the vein was cut," he said. "I'll dig coal all my life and glad of the wage. I won't dig a man out of his own grave for a stranger's paper."

Lowe did not press him further. He wrote out what the pit held, the stone, the ash, the flints, the burnt bone he judged too old and too cold in the ground to be any recent thing, and sent word to Griogal Odhar to bring the custodians of the district to see it before he covered it again.

Four of them came, two days later, from Doire ghlas and Doire fhiadhaich and Àth mhòr, walking the last mile together though their three towns lay a half-day apart from one another, and stood at the pit's edge a long while without speaking, the way the labourers had stood, and then Griogal Odhar crouched and turned one flint over in his palm and set it down exactly where it had lain.

"It is not ours," he said. "The stone is not ours, and the bone is not ours, and whoever laid it there is not ours, and I do not think the god it was laid for is any god that is prayed to on this island now, if it is prayed to anywhere at all." He stood. "Cover it again. Say the word over it that we say over any grave whose kin cannot be found, and no more than that."

Lowe asked what word that was, and was told, and it was said, briefly, in Dia-thìris, by all four custodians together over the reopened pit, and none of them offered to teach it to him, nor did he ask twice.

Before they left he asked Griogal Odhar one thing more: whether any order of the island's own faiths, the hawk-order that kept the vein's old rites, or the order that held the capital's shrines, or any other, claimed the ruin or the bone under it as its own.

"None," said Griogal. "I have heard it said that Mòd himself does not claim what was old before the vein was found, for a god that eats the hill can only eat what grew in the hill's own time, and this was here before the hill was a hill worth eating. Whether that is true, no one has told me. No order has ever asked to be given this ground, and none has ever been refused it, for none has asked."

He wrote afterward, in the letter-book he kept for the Mission and did send: *They agree with my own reading of the stone entirely, and add nothing to it. I had*

thought a people so old in their own land would have some tale for a ruin older still. They have none. I begin to wonder whether that is the more remarkable fact of the two.

III

Of the Pillar and the Column

There were two other marks in the district that Lowe had been asked to copy before he left it: a pillar of grey stone near Cnoc chiar, weathered past most reading, and a column near Cnoc ghorm that stood a little taller and a little plainer, with lines cut round its shoulder that might have been words or might have been only the marks of the tool that dressed it.

He went to Cnoc chiar first, in the spring, and spent nine days with paper and charcoal rubbing the pillar's face a hand's width at a time, working from the ground up in the wet wind off the hill, while an old woman of the town below came up most afternoons to sit on the stone's shadow-side and watch him without a word of greeting either way. She brought her own work with her, a basket of wool she carded as she watched, and by the fourth day Lowe had stopped expecting her to speak and had begun, instead, to find some comfort in the small sound of the carders, back and forth, under the wind. The pillar stood alone on a shoulder of open hill with no wall or ditch about it that any digging had ever found, and the grass grew close about its foot as it grew nowhere else on that slope, cropped fine by sheep that came to no other patch so willingly.

On the ninth day, folding his last sheet, he asked her, in the little Dia-thìris he had, whether the pillar had a name.

"It is a stone," she said. "It had a name once. We have not kept it."

"Was it a wicked thing, that the name was lost?"

She thought about that longer than she had thought about anything else he had asked her in nine days. "No," she said at last. "Names are lost the way anything is lost that nobody carries any more. Nobody has carried this one in a long time. It does not mean the stone minds."

He set her answer beside Samuel Wren's old copy of the obelisk at Cnoc bheag, made some forty years before and sent over the sea to scholars who had never troubled to answer it, and judged, laying the two side by side on an inn table at Cnoc chiar, that the hands were not the same hand, and that neither pillar's

writing answered to the other's, letter for letter, though something in the shapes of both put him in mind of the same idea, the way two strangers' faces can share an expression without sharing a feature. He copied Wren's copy twice more into his own book, from memory and then checked against the paper, for he did not trust the Company's post with the original and would not risk the only rubbing he had of the obelisk on a road he had never travelled.

At Cnoc ghorm, in the autumn, he copied the column in four days, quicker work, for less of it had worn away; and he wrote in the last page of his notebook, in a smaller hand than the rest, as if he grudged the paper it took: *Like the pillar, but not near enough to help. I do not think these three markers, the obelisk, the pillar, the column, were raised by three peoples, or by one people at three times only. I think they were raised by one people who no longer needed, by the third marker, to say all that the first marker said, because by then everyone who read it already knew. That is the mark of an old and settled thing, not a new one. And no one now living can read a word of it.*

He left Dia-thìr the following year, on a Company ship out of Ros dhomhain, with his notebooks in a sealed case under his berth and nothing else of the island in his baggage that he had not paid for. He did not write again to the Mission that had sent him, nor, so far as the custodians' rolls record, did any answer ever come back over the sea to the stone he had copied, or the bone he had uncovered and covered again. What he had come to prove, in eleven years and more, he never once claimed to have proved; and the last line of his own book, set down the night before he sailed, said only that he had looked a long while at a colour he could not see, and had come, by looking, to believe in it a little, which was as much faith as the island's own god had ever asked of the strangers, and more than most of them gave.

IV

Of Voss's Glass-House

Here the copyists of the cellar at Muileann chaol leave Lowe at the rail of his ship, and turn to a man who did not sail.

Peter Voss had come to the island as a glazier under Company contract, to set the Residency's windows and the panes of the counting-house at Ros dhomhain, and when his contract ran out in the sixty-sixth year he did not take passage home

with the rest of his gang. He gave no reason to the clerk who struck his name from the muster roll, only that he had found white sand on the shore below Baile Mòr dhìreach the like of which he had not found in three counties of an Tìr Thall¹, and a hill of good charcoal-wood behind it, and he meant to see what the two of them, put together in a furnace, would make.

He built the furnace himself over a summer, with two Dia-thìrich labourers he taught as he went, a stone drum lined with clay and fired for a week before he trusted it with sand, and for that whole week he slept beside it on a heap of sack-ing, waking every few hours to feed the fire and read its colour through a slit in the clay, a trick of the trade he had learned as a boy in his father's own glass-house over the sea and had thought, coming to the island, he would never use again. His two labourers thought him half mad for the sleeping, and said so, and stayed to watch all the same.

What came out of the furnace the first three times was a black cinder, no glass at all, and the town's children carried it off for luck and the custodians' clerk recorded, dryly, as "Voss's first stones, being none." Voss broke each failed batch himself with a hammer before it cooled fully, turning the pieces in his hand and muttering over them in his own tongue, and each time changed some small thing, the heat of the fire, the grain of the sand, the ash he mixed into it, and tried again. The fourth firing, on a wet morning in an Iuchar, gave him a pane the size of two hands, pale green, thick as a wall, and clear enough to see a gull through.

He held it up to the light in the furnace door, and one of his two apprentices, a girl of the town called Cairistiona nic Griogair who had carried sand for him all that summer and asked, more than once, to be shown the fire, laughed out loud at the sight of it, the first laugh anyone had heard in that yard since the furnace was raised.

"There," said Voss. "There's your first glass made on this island, and not a scrap of it came from over the sea."

Within the year he had orders from three towns for window-panes, more than he and his two apprentices could cut, and within a generation, as the copyists who set this down already know though Voss himself did not live to see it, his craft had gone out from his own two hands to glass-houses at Cathair dhearg and Seann Skell and half the towns of the capital shore, every one of them tracing its fire, in the telling if not always in the truth of it, back to a glazier left behind at

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

Baile Mòr dhireach because a ship's berth was not worth losing a beach of good white sand.

V

Of the Silver Guild's Answer

And here they turn from a furnace to a hall.

Martha Gale came to Muileann chiar in the spring of the sixty-seventh year, on 29 am Màrt, AE 67, a Company agent of thirty-seven with a paper case under her arm and an offer inside it that her own letter-book called generous, and generous, by the Company's reckoning, it was: a partnership in the silver of the guild's own vein, half the yield to the Company and half kept by the guild, with the Company's beam to weigh it and the Company's road to carry it, in place of the old road down to the quay at Seann Bhral that the guild had used since before any strangers came.

The guild's head by then was Ùna nic Choinnich, who had stood with the ledgers at the adit some twenty-four years before, and who was some eighty winters old that spring, bent now at the shoulder but sound in the eye, with a voice that still carried the length of the hall without rising. She had come to the hall that morning on a stick and on her grand-niece's arm, as she had come to every guild meeting for a decade, and had sat through the winter's ordinary business, the ore counts and the smiths' dues, with her eyes half shut, so that more than one in the hall thought her asleep before Gale's letter was ever read; and then, at the reading, she opened her eyes fully and did not shut them again until the hands had been counted.

She had the offer read aloud once by Gale's own clerk, in the humans' tongue, and once more by a guild boy who put it into Dia-thìris, sentence by sentence, so that no hand in the hall could say afterward it had not understood what it voted on. Ùna made him read the paragraph on the Company's beam a third time, slowly, and asked him twice to explain, in his own words and not the paper's, what the weight on that beam would be measured against, and was not satisfied with either answer, and said so.

"You are offering us half of what we already have," Ùna said, when both readings were done, "in exchange for a road we do not need and a weight we do not trust. Is there anything in this paper that is not that?"

Gale said there was the Company's protection, in years when the silver ran thin, and the Company's markets, which reached further than any cart the guild had ever sent round the lake.

"We have had thin years before your Company came to this island," said Ùna, "and we are here yet, and so is the guild, and so, I think, will both of us be when your paper is dust." She turned to the hall. "Hands, then, as the guild has always answered."

The hands went up, and the count was taken by two clerks of the guild's own, one for and one against, as the custom held, and the offer was refused by every hand in the hall save one, an old silversmith too deaf that year to have followed the second reading, who put his hand up, as his neighbour told the clerks afterward, only because his neighbour's hand had gone up first. Gale took the count without argument, folded her paper case, and thanked the hall for its time in a Dia-thìris of her own, careful and correct, learned, the guild's clerk noted, entirely for that one visit and never used by her again on the island.

VI

Of the Camp at Achadh dhomhain and the Cloth of Dùn chiar

And here, last, to a hillside, before the copyists close this book.

The deep galleries that the Company's surveys had marked below the hill at Achadh dhomhain were opened for cutting at the turn of the sixty-eighth year, on 1 am Faoilleach, AE 68, and within a few seasons the farming village that had stood there since An Aois Naomh¹, its granaries feeding the mining camps already a generation old on either side of it, found itself the most crowded place in the district, larger than any market town, though it had no market, no charter, and no custodian sent to it who did not also serve three villages besides.

The Company built nothing there that first season but a pay-hut and a store. The crews built the rest, out of what the ground gave them, which was spoil: the broken rock and shale thrown up from the new galleries, stacked and packed and roofed over as the season allowed, so that a man's house at Achadh dhomhain was, in a sense the custodians' rolls were careful to note, cut from the same hill he

1. the Holy Age

worked, only nearer the surface of it. The old farms stood apart from the new stacks of spoil at first, a field's width between the two, as if the village itself were unsure whether to call the camp a part of the town or a separate thing entirely grown up beside it; within two winters the field between them was houses too, and the question was no longer asked.

A hewer of the western workings, Cormag mac Ailein, raised the first of these houses for his own household that first winter, four low walls of stacked spoil chinked with clay, and asked the district's weavers for canvas to close the roof until timber could be got, for there was none to spare that year, every beam on the coast going to shore up the new galleries before the winter wet.

The weavers who answered him were of Dùn chiar, the hill fort south-east of the capital, whose looms had woven for the capital's own custodians since An Aois Naomh and had never, in all that time, taken a Company contract, holding, as their eldest weaver Ealasaid Bhuidhe put it to the town council that had to vote on it, that a loom that wove for the vein-country's temples should not also weave sacking for a coal camp. The council voted for the contract all the same, twenty-six against nine, the nine led by Ealasaid herself, who signed the roll of dissent and then, the record is careful to add, sat down at her own loom the next morning and wove canvas with the rest, for the town's custodian had ruled it, and a vote lost is a vote kept, in Dùn chiar as everywhere else on the island.

The first bolts of Dùn chiar canvas went up to Achadh dhomhain at the end of that first month, on 30 am Faoilleach, AE 68, and Cormag mac Ailein's roof was the first of the camp to be closed against the winter, four walls of spoil and a roof of borrowed cloth, tarred at the seams against the rain by his own hand, with his wife and their two children under it before am Faoilleach of the sixty-eighth year was out.

He stood back from it in the last light, to look at what he had made. He knew that the roof would hold, and that it was his, and that the winter, this year, would not come in on his children while they slept. Of the coloured flame at Muileann bheag, and the bone under the altar at Làrach an Teampaill², and the glass held up to the light at Baile Mòr dhìreach, and the hands raised and counted in the guild hall at Muileann chiar, he had heard nothing at all, and would hear nothing for some years yet; and so ends, at one man's roof and not at any of the others, the ac-

2. the temple ruin

count the copyists have kept of what was seen, and not seen, in the six years after the fourth beacon was lit.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

Of the Smoke in the Gallery

AE 68 – 72

I

Of the First Winter of Achadh dhomhain

The camp had no name before it had houses, and it had houses before it had a name that anyone but the Company used. Beitris Bhàn came to it in its first winter with a wool blanket, a horn cup and the small knife her mother had laid out three husbands and eleven neighbours with, walking the short road up from Àth ìseal because word had gone round the huts there that a new camp at Achadh dhomhain needed a woman who knew how to close a dead man's eyes and not flinch at a wound the coal had made.

She found the camp built of itself. The Company had sunk its shaft into the hillside for the deep galleries, and the spoil that came up out of it, broken rock and coal-dross too poor to sell, went into walls; so that the houses of Achadh dhomhain were grey and black together, low, roofed with turf cut from the same hill, and every one of them stood a little crooked, for spoil does not lie true the way a quarried stone does. The crews called them houses of spoil without meaning anything by it, the way a man calls his own boots his boots. Beitris took the end room of one such house, next the well, and hung her mother's knife on a nail, and within the week she had work.

That first winter the camp buried nine. Two were old hewers brought down from Àth ìseal for their skill and dead of the damp before the first snow; one was a

child of five crushed under a cart of spoil that a tired horse let run back on its heel; the rest went of the cough that every camp has, deeper some years than others, and that winter deep. Beitris washed them in the well water, which came up black in a bucket until it had stood a night, and laid them out on the plank table in her room with a coal set on the breast for the going-down, as the custom is in every pit town from Doire mhòr to the last camp on the eastern road, and the custodian of Àth ìseal, whose roll then still reached as far as the new camp, rode up once a season to write the names and the days.

The name Donnchadh mac Thormoid meant nothing to her yet. He was one hewer among three hundred, and his crew worked the far end of the deepest gallery, where the Company had run its air-shaft down from the hillside above, and men who work an air-shaft's draught keep to themselves, for the wind down there is cold enough to work in a coat where other crews strip to the waist. She had heard, as everyone in the camp had heard, that his grandfather had once stood behind Beathag Dhubh of Doire mhòr on the day she sent the Company's man back down the hill unanswered, and that his father Tormod had carried water up to Doire mhòr for two summers after the Company took the stream, and then gone down with the rest to the huts at Àth ìseal. It was said, too, that Donnchadh himself had broken coal at a pit-mouth before he could read his letters, and gone below at twelve, a beginning that raised no eyebrow in that camp, where most of the men had made the same one or a harder. She knew him, that first winter, only as a name on the custodian's roll when his crew lost a boy to the damp, and as a back going down the ladder in the grey of the morning with the rest.

The nine of that first winter were laid in a field the Company had not yet found a use for, above the last of the spoil-heaps, in ground too broken with old workings to carry a cart-road. Beitris cut the turf for each grave herself, since the camp had as yet no man spared from the pit for the work, and found under it, more than once, the black seam showing through where an older digging had come near the surface and been left. She set nine cairns that winter with her own hands, small ones, for the camp could spare no more stone than that, and when the custodian of Àth ìseal rode up in the spring to write the names, he stood over each cairn a while, as though counting them meant something more than the writing did.

II

Of the Coach and the Steelyard

The Company put its road in before it put in anything else that eased a life. In the spring a coach began to run twice in the week between the quay at Ros dhomhain and the camps about Muileann chrom, changing its horses at the old waypoint houses that had stood empty since the post first came up the coast, and the clerks and the overseers rode in it, dry, with their ledgers on their knees, while the crews who dug what filled the ledgers walked the same road on their own feet, in whatever weather the road had that day. Beitris saw it pass twice a week for years after and never once saw a hewer's boot inside it.

The next year the Company raised a great steelyard on the quay at Ros dhomhain, a beam and a basket and a chain of iron links taller than two men, and from the day it was hung the island's yield was no longer spoken of in the old way, in baskets filled and carts drawn and seasons of a crew's labour, as the custodians' rolls had always kept it, but in tons and hundredweights read off a scale by a Company clerk who had never gone below in his life. The custodians' old count went on a while in the margins of the rolls, out of habit, and then it did not. Ùna nic Choinnich, who kept the silver guild's own scales at Muileann chlar and had refused twice already to let the Company's weights anywhere near her own, said when she heard of it that a hill weighed by the ton and a hill worked by a crew's own reckoning of what a day was worth were two different hills, and that the island had let the wrong one be written down. Beitris heard the saying secondhand, as everyone in the camps heard everything Ùna said, a season late and twice removed, and thought little of it at the time.

That was also the year the Company opened its second coal stage, at Ros dhìreach on the southern coast, to carry off the yield of the workings south of the hills without the long haul round to Ros dhomhain. Its first cargo went down in a squall not a mile off the harbour mouth, boat and coal and two of the crew who had gone out with her to trim the load, and the fishermen whose grounds had been given over to make room for the new stage would not put out past the wreck for a season after, saying the sea there had taken against the place. And in that same year, or the year after, for the camp's memory of dates ran together the way a hewer's years run together below ground, a ship came into Ros dhomhain driven by no sail at all, with a wheel turning in a housing at either side and smoke coming off her instead of spray, and the harbour's own fishermen rowed out in a ring

to look at a hull that went against the wind. It was said in the camp, by men who had seen her, that within a few years the Company would send nothing else, and that the sailing ships that had first come down from the north with Harrow would soon come no more.

Beitris marked these things the way the camp marked them, as weather is marked: noticed, talked over at a door on a wet evening, and then folded away under the next thing.

The road brought the camp its wonders, and Beitris listened to all of it at the well, the way the whole camp listened to everything, and weighed it against the small, unremarkable fact that a hewer at the far end of the deep gallery had stopped coughing on the night his daughter was born, which nobody outside a handful of women had yet troubled to notice at all.

III

Of What the Wife Told the Women

It came to Beitris the way most things came to her: at a laying-out, in the small hours, when the work of the hands leaves the tongue free and grief makes people say what they would otherwise keep.

In the fourth winter of the camp, the old woman who had first taken Beitris in, and taught her the way of setting a coal on a still breast, died in her sleep with no mark of the pit on her at all, which the camp took as a mercy and marked so. The women who came to sit the night with the body were Achadh dhomhain's own: wives and daughters of hewers, two widows, and Donnchadh mac Thor-moid's wife, who had never before sat such a night in Beitris's room, and who sat now with her hands in her lap and said little until the small hours had worn the room down to its plainest talk.

It was Beitris who asked, in the end, only because the woman's silence had a shape to it that Beitris's trade had taught her to know. She asked how her husband had come to lose his cough, for the camp had seen him coughing black through a winter and thinning through a spring, and had begun, as camps do, to reckon how soon they would be laying him on this same table; and then the cough had stopped, all at once, like a door shut.

The wife told it then, low, with the other women leaning in to hear, and she told it as her husband had told her, which is the only way she would tell it, for she said more than once that the words were his and she would change none of them.

He had been alone at the face, she said, in the first winter of the camp, at the far end of the deepest gallery the Company had opened, with his lamp hung on a nail behind him and the shaft's draught running past him steady and cold, so that his flame lay over on its side all day and the dust of his cutting drifted away toward the dark in a thin grey thread. He had stopped to spit, and turned, and seen the thread of dust part around something that was not dust.

It stood the height of a tall man, she said, and it was made of smoke, grey smoke such as a peat fire gives in a shut room, and the draught went past it on either side without so much as bending it, though it bent the flame of his lamp and carried off every grain of dust he had cut. He had heard of the smoke in the grove all his life, at his grandmother's knee, with the Hollow Man and the white stag and the rest of the fireside tales a child puts away when he goes below; and he had put this one away too, until it stood in front of him in the dark, and he found there was nowhere to run to but past it, and he did not want to run in any case, though he could not afterward say why not.

It spoke to him. "You are Tormod's son," it said, and its voice was low and very clear, and the draught that carried off everything else in that gallery did not carry off a word of it.

"I am," he said.

"And Somhairle's, and Ailean's." It seemed, he told her, to be looking about the gallery, at the props and the black walls and the cut face, the way a guest looks about a house where things have plainly gone badly for the people in it. "They are taking the hill."

"They are," he said.

"I will not fight for the kin. I never have; that is not my charge. But I was set to keep the kin, and a kin with its hill dug out from under it is not kept." It came nearer him then, close enough that he caught its smell, which was a hearth in the morning, when the fire has been banked all night and only just stirred. "I made a promise once, in the grove, to the one you come from. Breathe."

He breathed, because it had told him to, and the smoke went into him along with the dust of his own cutting, and it was warm, he said, warm all the way down, like a coal carried home under a cloak on a cold walk.

"What is it?" he asked, when he could speak again.

"A gift," it told him. "It is not for you. You will carry it, and the carrying will not be easy. It will wake in your daughter." The draught had begun to move through it by then, and it was thinning as it spoke. "It is in the dust of the deep places now, for every one of the kin who goes down; and where it wakes, it wakes. Tell no one of it but the one who will bear the child."

Then the draught went clean through the place where it had stood, and his lamp flame righted itself, and there was nothing in the gallery but the dust, settling.

He had coughed from that day, his wife said, black, and grown thin, and the Mission's surgeon at the camp had listened at his chest and written him down with the miners' lung, the same dust-rot the humans brought with them from the pits of their own country, which the crews called the lung-rot among themselves, and had given him, the surgeon said, a year. And then, on 7 am Màrt, AE 69, his daughter was born to them in their own house of spoil, and that same night, his wife said, his cough stopped, and it never came back, not once, in all the years since. He had told her what he had met in the gallery the night the cough left him, and she had never told a living soul of it until this night, in this room, over another woman's body, with the coal already set on the dead breast between them.

Nobody in the room asked her the child's name. Everybody in the room already knew it. It was Aisling.

IV

Of the Child the Rolls Gave Three Things

Beitris saw the child herself, in the way everyone in a small camp sees every child, at doors and at the well and asleep in a shawl on her mother's back while the mother queued for meal. There was nothing to see, at first, but a child. The custodian who rode up that spring wrote her down as the roll requires, a birth, a name, a father's name, and rode on to the next camp, and that was the whole of what the record ever meant to say of her.

It was the camp that said more, and it began, as most things in Achadh dhomhain began, with the women who laid out the dead. Beitris was one of them by then in her own right, and she heard it said first over a washing, in the flat voice women use for a thing they are only half in earnest about and half not: that the child was of the old king's blood. They meant Ailean Mòr, whom the gods

crowned in the grove in the first years of everything, who was king four thousand years and more before he fell at the Ford of Blood, and whose children, the tale ran, lived thousands of years after him. Not one woman in that room believed a word of the thousands of years; Ailean Mòr was a tale for the dark end of the year, set among the tellings by scribes long dead, and there was not a soul in the camp who had ever heard the whole of his line said out in order. But the child did not thicken through the shoulders as the other children of her year thickened, and did not lose her milk teeth when they lost theirs, and the women noticed it the way women who wash the dead notice everything about a body, early and exactly, and the whisper grew with her rather than dying the way most camp gossip dies.

They called her *nighean an rìgh*, the king's daughter, half in jest and, as the seasons went by without her growing the way a child should, half not; and it began to be said of anyone in the camps who kept their youth past its season that they had *Aisling-aois* upon them, though there was as yet only the one Aisling for the saying to be named after. A people whose hill was going out of the island in ships by the ton took its comfort where it found one, and Achadh dhomhain found it in an old tale nobody believed and a girl of the spoil-houses who would not grow old. Nobody could prove a word of it, then or for years after, and nobody in that camp tried; a whisper that could be proved would have stopped being theirs.

Beitris herself was as much a watcher of the child as any of them, by the ordinary chance of a laying-out room standing close by the well where every mother in that row of houses of spoil came morning and evening. She saw Aisling grow as far as a small child grows. What she did not see, season after season, was the child changing the way a child changes: no new tooth lost and grown again, no stretching of the wrist past the cuff of last year's smock, no voice dropping into the huskier register a growing throat takes on. It was a stillness so gradual that no single week of it could be pointed to, and that, Beitris came to think, was why it took the women of the wash-house to notice it before anyone else did, for they were the ones who handled the camp's dying by the hand and the wrist and the throat, and knew exactly what a year should do to a body and what it should not.

Of what had passed in the gallery, and of what the smoke had told Donnachadh to keep, the women who had sat that night with Beitris said nothing outside the room where it was said. It was Beitris, in the end, who set the rule, though no one voted on it and no meeting was ever called: she told the others plainly that a thing a spirit had charged a man to keep close was not theirs to

spend on the rest of the camp's talk, whatever they made of the child in their own kitchens, and the others agreed, and held to it. What was happening to the child had no name in any tongue spoken on the island, then or for years to come; it was the camp's own secret before it was anyone's mystery, kept the way the camp kept everything it valued, close, and among its own.

V

Of Ùna nic Choinnich and the Shrines

In the child's second year word came down from Muileann chiar that Ùna nic Choinnich, who had led the silver guild for near forty years and had twice turned the Company away from its seam, once at the adit and once by a show of hands, was dead at last in her own bed, eighty-five years old, having outlived the Commissioner who signed her compact. The camp had never seen her, most of it, and knew her only by the sayings that came down the road ahead of the coach; but Beitris, laying out a hewer's wife that same week, found the women of Achadh dhomhain talking of Ùna's dying with more feeling than they had shown for Commissioners who had actually ridden through their own camp, and thought that a guild which had said no twice, and been believed, was worth more to people who had never once been asked than any office that only ever gave orders.

The camp kept its own shrines through those years as it had always kept them, the Company suffering the custom because it cost little enough to suffer. At Cill dhìreach, on the edge of the workings, the custodians held a small shrine where the crews of every new gallery brought the first piece cut from it and set it down before they carried the rest to the steelyard, and the Company let the practice stand, for a stone of coal a gallery was cheaper than a quarrel. At Cill ghlais, in the hills among the deepening pits, the custodians of Bride's flame kept the older rite, at the mouth of the oldest cutting in those hills, tending the stone and the flame there while the Company's new shafts went down all around them; and of every shrine in that district it was the last the crews still climbed to on the old feast days, at Samhain and Imbolc, at Bealltainn and at Lùnastal.

Beitris went up to it for the first time in the same season Ùna's death came down the road, more from the habit of a woman who had spent a hard winter laying out neighbours than from any settled faith, for her own people had kept no

particular custom of the shrine before the camp gave her one. She found the path already scored by other feet, hewers' boots mostly, going up before a shift or coming down after one, leaving nothing behind them but a nod to the custodian and sometimes a coin, sometimes nothing at all. It struck her, standing there the first time with the flame small and steady against a hard wind, that a Company which begrudged a stone a gallery to the shrine at Cill dhìreach had never once tried to close this one, whether because the cost was smaller still or because even a Commissioner who could not see the colour in the coal knew better than to be the man who put out Bride's flame in a camp already burying its dead by the dozen.

VI

Of the Climb to Cill ghlas

In the fifth Lùnastal of the camp, with the child three years old, Beitris climbed the hill path to Cill ghlas alone, before first light, as she had taken to doing since the night of the telling, though she could not have said to another soul why that night had put the habit in her.

The path went up past the newest of the spoil-heaps, black even in starlight, and past the mouth of the gallery where Donnchadh mac Thormoid still worked his shift, cough long gone, saying no more of what had happened to him there than his wife had said of it in Beitris's room, and by all report never once saying more. At the top the custodian was already at the flame, feeding it the last of the night's peat before the sun took over the work, and the old cutting behind her stood open and black and ordinary, a hole in a hill like any other hole a people had ever dug in search of what it needed.

Beitris set down the coal she had carried up, one piece, no bigger than the ones the crews left at Cill dhìreach, and said nothing to the custodian, who said nothing to her, for it was not a shrine that asked for words. Below her the camp was waking, doors opening onto the grey light, smoke starting from a hundred low chimneys built of the hill's own dross, and somewhere down among them a child not yet four years old.

What the camp had been given, that Lùnastal morning, Beitris could not have said, nor what the giving would yet cost it; a layer-out of the dead learns early that not every debt comes due while the one who owes it is still watching. She knew only that a promise made once in a grove, to someone whose name none of them

now living had ever heard said whole, was being kept in the one way a promise so old can be kept: quietly, underground, in the dust, where nobody stood by who could put a word to it. A while longer she stayed at the flame with the custodian, neither of them speaking, and then turned back down the path to see who else the winter had left her to lay out, and did not speak of the child again to anyone outside that first room for a long time after.

Remember it.

CHAPTER TWENTY

OF the GREEN Death

AE 73 – 76

I

Of the Green Acre

Beitris Bhàn had laid out the dead of Achadh dhomhain for six years before the sickness came, and she thought she knew every way a body could leave the world underground. She had washed the crushed and the drowned and the cold, the old who went quietly in a house of spoil and the young who did not go quietly at all. She had not washed anyone the colour of a candle held behind glass, and when Fearchar Iasgair's wife sent for her on a wet morning in an t-Ògmhios of the seventy-third year, and she came into the hut and pulled back the blanket, she stood a long moment with the cloth in her hand before she could make herself begin.

He was green. Not the green of a drowned man, which she knew, nor the green-white of a man dead of poison, which she had seen twice; a green under the skin, as though a lamp with a coloured shade had been set behind his face and left burning. His lips were dark. When she washed his chest the water in the basin turned grey with the dust that had come up out of him in his last hours, more

dust than she had ever wrung from a living man's coughing, as if the hill itself had been washing out of him from the inside.

"He was well at Bealltainn," the wife said, from the door, not coming in. "Well enough to dance at it."

"How long was he taken?"

"Nine days. Ten." The wife's hands were working at her apron, twisting it. "He went the colour first. The overman said it was only the bad air of the new gallery and he'd come right in a week above ground. Then the cough came, and then he couldn't stand."

Beitris finished him and covered him and went out into the rain and stood a while under the eave, because that was her way; she gave herself the length of one held breath for each body before she went to the next thing. Before the month was out she had given herself that breath thirty-nine times more. The camp buried its dead that summer in a field beyond the spoil-heaps that had never been used for anything, too stony for a garden and too far from the huts for convenient burying, and by the end of an t-Iuchar the field had a name the whole camp used without anyone deciding it should: an Acair Uaine, the green acre. Beitris helped dig the first of it herself, on a day when the grave-diggers proper were laid up sick themselves, and she never after that let herself forget the particular heft of a spade going into ground that had not been turned before.

She did not know then what the sickness was, or that it had a name yet to be given it, or that within the year every custodian's roll from the coast to the hills would be keeping a tally of it under one heading. Only this she knew: that Fearchar Iasgair had been a strong man at Bealltainn and green in the ground by midsummer, and that this was the fourth summer running in which the camp at Achadh dhomhain had buried more of its own than it had the year the deep galleries opened. Beitris laid out the camp's dead and did not think, that summer, of the hewer whose cough had stopped on the night his daughter was born. The one thing had nothing to do with the other, so far as anyone could see.

II

Of the Blank Line

It went along the coal roads the way water goes along a furrow, taking the low ground first.

From Achadh dhomhain it followed the carts to Muileann chrom, and from Muileann chrom by the same roads that carried the coal itself, to Àth ìseal and to Cnoc fhiadhaich, and from those three camps it spread wider than any of the custodians who kept the count had thought a sickness of the lungs could spread, out along the lines the ore and the timber travelled, as though it rode the carts and not the men. It fell on Ros dhìreach, on Ceann òg, on Inis ìseal, on Baile dhomhain, on Achadh fhada, on Cnoc bheag, on Muileann uaine, on Cuan àrsaidh, on Inis bhàn. It fell on Baile chrom in the hills, not the Baile chrom of the north-west, whose beacon burned coal above a different sea entirely; and the clerks of that year took a particular care, twice underlined in one hand, to keep the two apart, for they had heard already of copyists elsewhere confusing towns of one name, and did not mean to be the ones remembered for it.

The custodians' roll for that year lists twenty-six settlements with cases set down against them, in the order the word of them reached Cathair dhearg, and after the twenty-sixth name the clerk who kept the roll left a line blank. Nobody now living can say why he left it, whether by habit, meaning to fill it when the next report came in, or because he could not make himself write the page full and close it. The line stayed blank through that autumn and into the winter, and was still blank when a different hand took up the roll the following spring, by which time a twenty-seventh settlement might as well have been entered, and was not. It is there still, in the loft of Beathag nic Thòmais, a line of nothing between one town's dead and the empty bottom of the page, and every custodian who has read it since has understood it without being told what it was left for.

At Àth ghlas the custodians did a thing no other camp thought to do until it was too late for the thought to help them. When the first three died within a week of one another, the custodian of that place, a stern woman named Sìne Ruadh who had buried her own father to the fever thirty years before and never forgot the smell of a sick-hut, ordered every hut in which a death had happened burned to the ground, roof, walls, bedding and all, before the next dark. The Company's agent at Àth ghlas protested the loss of its property in writing, three times, and was answered each time with the same line copied out fresh: the hut is the Company's; the ground under it is the custodians'; and the custodians will keep what stands on their own ground safe from what killed the man in it. Sìne Ruadh burned nine huts before the summer was out. Of every camp on the coal roads, the sickness left Àth ghlas soonest, and though the roll does not say it plainly,

every custodian who has since compared the counts has drawn the same line between the burned huts and the empty ones.

At Cnoc naomh there was no burning, and no early stopping. The dead there were laid first in the burial-ground of the town's old shrine, in the ordered rows the shrine had kept since it was built, and when that ground filled, in a field outside it that had never held a grave before. The field at Cnoc naomh was never ploughed again after. Fifty years on, a woman who farms the land beside it can point to where the fence turns to go round it, and will tell you, if you ask, that nothing was ever sown there because nothing would grow; and if you ask her how she knows that, since nobody has tried it in living memory, she will say only that nobody in living memory has needed to.

III

Of Doctor Bright's Table

Nathaniel Bright had been the Administration's physician at Muileann chrom nine years by the time the sickness reached the settlements around him, long enough to have buried three of his own household to fevers that were not this one, and long enough to have grown, in the Dia-thìrich way of speaking of a stranger they had come to trust a little, "the doctor who listens." He was a careful man, thin, with ink permanently under two fingernails of his right hand and a habit of repeating a patient's own words back before he wrote them down, so that the patient could hear whether he had understood.

His study began in the second summer of the sickness, in the small room behind the Mission's dispensary at Muileann chrom that the surgeon before him had used for storing bandages. He asked the custodians' leave to open the chests of the dead before burial, and was given it, on the condition that a custodian stand by the whole time and that nothing of the body be kept afterward. This he agreed to without argument, understanding, as few of his own people troubled to, that the custodians asked it as a plain point of law and no more. What he found, he weighed. A table grew in a black-bound book, ruled in columns: the name, where known; the years worked below; how much the lungs themselves weighed; and how much, so far as his scales could reckon it, of what was not lung in them. Beside each entry he wrote, in a small cramped hand, whatever the fam-

ily or the crew could tell him of how the man had died, how long it had taken, and whether the green colour had come before the cough or after.

Anne Colby came to his room once, in the second winter, carrying a list of her own: the sick-house's tally, kept by name and settlement, that she had begun keeping without being asked to by anyone in the Administration, because nobody else was keeping it in any form the living could be traced by afterward. She set her list beside his book on the table and they went down both together by lamplight, matching names.

"There is no pattern I can find in who takes it and who does not," Bright said. "A hewer at the face fifteen years may live. A boy of six months below may die of it in a fortnight. I had thought it might follow the deepest galleries, and it does not; Cnoc fhiadhaich's shallow workings have as many dead as Achadh dhomhain's deep ones, by the head."

"What do you think it, then?"

"The dust. I can find no other thing they share." He turned the book round so she could see the column of his weighings. "Every lung I have opened is dark with it, more than a man could take in from ordinary air in a lifetime of ordinary work. I mean to weigh a hundred before I say so in writing, so that no one can say I guessed from ten."

He did not weigh a hundred. He fell ill himself in the third season of the work, in the spring of the seventy-fifth year, with the same colour and the same cough he had spent two years describing in other men's chests, and his own hand grew too unsteady for the small cramped writing before the summer was half over. The last page of his book breaks off in the middle of a row: a name, the years worked, the weight of the lung, and then nothing where the weight of the dust should have been, the pen having been set down, it seems from the mark it left, and never taken up again over that line. He died at Muileann chrom the following spring, and was buried by the Mission with the honours the Administration gave its own, in ground apart from the green acre and the field at Cnoc naomh, though the colour that took him from it was the same colour, and Anne Colby, who came to the burying, thought so and said nothing, because there was no one there it would have helped to say it to.

IV

Of the Seal and the Letter-Book

Walter Crane had been Commissioner twelve years when the sickness reached the camps, and in all that time he had walked them himself, twice a season, in a coat that grew steadily shabbier because he would not send it to be brushed while other men's coats went unbrushed for want of a wife to do it. He walked the sick-rows at Achadh dhomhain in the worst of the second summer, when the stink of the huts kept even the huts' own children playing at a distance, and he did not walk faster past the bad ones than the ordinary ones, which the custodians noticed, and which Beitris Bhàn, who saw him there twice, noticed too, and remembered afterward in his favour, the only human besides Anne Colby she ever remembered so.

The sickness caught him in the autumn of the seventy-fourth year, most likely from the very rows he had walked so faithfully, though no one could say which visit. Before the winter was out he was dead, at the Residency above Ros dhomhain, in a bed his own physician had ordered him to twice and he had twice got out of to answer letters. Martha Gale, the Company's agent, held his seal for the months there was no one else to hold it, and ran the pay office and the ore contracts and the sick-house grants exactly as Crane had left them running, changing nothing, because she said afterward that a dead man's arrangements were owed at least that much respect until a live one came to say otherwise.

The live one came over the sea in the spring of the seventy-sixth year: George Tolley, sent out with orders, set down plainly in the papers he carried and read aloud once, without apparent discomfort, to the clerks of the Residency on his first morning, that the yield of the pits must not fall on account of the sickness, whatever else was done about it. He set a quarantine at Caol mhin on the northern coast within his first month, holding every ship from an Tìr Thall¹ offshore until her crew had been looked over by a physician sent out in a boat for the purpose, a measure so plainly sensible, and so plainly aimed at keeping the sickness from crossing the sea rather than at the men already dying of it on the island, that the custodians approved it without reservation and said so in writing, the only order of his whole rule they ever did approve.

He did not visit the camps. Not Achadh dhomhain, not Muileann chrom, not Àth ghlais nor Cnoc naomh nor any of the twenty-six named in the blank-lined roll; not once in the two years of his rule that the sickness ran its worst. He kept his own letter-book at the Residency, in a fair clerk's hand that was not his own,

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

dictated of an evening, and in it, when at last he set down his opinion of the cause of the Green Death for the Company's directors over the sea, he gave three causes and gave them in this order: the coal dust of the workings; the custom, as he understood it from his clerks, of the Dia-thìrich sleeping close by their own hearths in ill-ventilated huts; and the custodians' shrines, which he believed, on no evidence he troubled to name, might be a means by which the sickness passed from the sick to the well through the gathering of crowds at them. Anne Colby was shown a copy of the letter some years later, by a clerk who thought she would want to see it, and read it through twice before she said anything, and what she said was not fit to be entered in any roll.

V

Of the Feathers Over the Door

The hawk-priests had been barred from the camps since Maddox's day, an order Tolley found already standing and saw no reason to lift, and the crews had long since learned to do without them in body while keeping them in every other way they could. In the years of the Green Death, the overseers' own reports, kept with more care than almost anything else the Administration wrote down in those years, since a matter of discipline was worth a clerk's ink where a matter of dying was not, begin to list, camp by camp, hut by hut, the finding of feathers nailed above doors.

A single feather, most often; sometimes two crossed. The overseers took them down as fast as they were found and entered the finding against the household's name, a mark that in some camps cost a week's pay and in others nothing at all, depending on which overseer happened to be walking that row. The crews put them back up as fast as they were taken down. Nobody was ever caught in the act of nailing one, in six years of the sickness and hundreds of feathers found; the custodians, when asked by an overseer once too many times who had done it, answered only that a hawk drops what it drops, and a door is a door, which satisfied no overseer and stopped no report and was, so far as anyone below the rank of Commissioner ever discovered, entirely true.

There was a saying that went with the feathers, said low in the huts at night and not to any human who might carry it up the hill, though by the second year of the sickness even some of the humans of the camps, the few who had married

in and stayed, had it by heart in their own halting Dia-thiris, having heard it often enough at a neighbour's door to learn it the way a child learns a hymn without being taught the words of it on purpose.

Itbidh Mòd an neach a dh'itheas an cnoc.

Mòd will eat whoever eats the hill.

Beitris Bhàn nailed a feather above her own door in the second winter, after she had laid out the fortieth of the season, and did not take it down when the overseer's boy found it and told his father, and paid the week's pay it cost her without complaint, and put another feather up within the month.

VI

Of the Washing

It was in the third summer of the sickness that Anne Colby came to Beitris Bhàn's door for the first time. No one at the Mission had sent her and no custodian had asked her; she had heard, from a woman at the sick-house, that the layer-out at Achadh dhomhain had washed more of the Green Death's dead with her own hands than any physician on the island had examined with instruments, and Colby had run out, that summer, of people who knew more about the sickness than she did.

Beitris let her in without a word and without surprise, as though she had been expecting a human at her door eventually and had simply not known which one. Colby had brought nothing with her but a clean apron rolled under her arm, which she put on in the doorway before she asked leave to help, and Beitris, who had never in six years let another pair of hands touch a body she was laying out, some old bone-deep unwillingness in her giving way all at once for reasons she could not afterward have named to herself, stood back from the table and let her.

They worked without much speaking, the way two women who have each done a hard thing alone for years learn to work together the first time without needing to be told how. Colby had the physician's way of it, methodical, naming what she saw as she saw it; Beitris had the older way, the custodian's rites said quietly under the working of the cloth, a word for each part of the body as it was washed, words that had been said over the dead of Achadh dhomhain since long before the Company came, said now for a woman whose name Colby had written on a list and Beitris had known since the woman was a girl.

"You say a word for every part of her," Colby said, once, not stopping her own hands.

"My grandmother's mother said it for her grandmother's mother. There is a word for each part because each part is owed its own leaving-taking, and none is owed more than the rest." Beitris turned the woman gently onto her side to reach her back. "Do the humans say nothing over their own dead?"

"We say a great deal. Over the ones we can afford a priest for." Colby's voice had gone flat in a way Beitris had heard before, in women who had buried more than they could carry the grief of properly and had learned instead to carry the work of it. "The camps' dead get none of it. I have buried forty with no more than my own two hands and a hole dug too shallow because there was no one spared from the pit to dig it deeper."

They finished the woman together and began the next, a boy of perhaps nine, and Beitris found, without deciding to, that she had begun saying the words aloud instead of under her breath, so that Colby, working opposite her, might have them too if she wanted them; and Colby, who understood no more than a handful of words of Dia-thìris and none of these particular ones, said nothing at all, but matched the pace of her own hands to the rhythm of them, so that the two of them moved together over the small body as though the words were being said by both, which in every way that mattered to either woman, they were.

They washed the camp's dead together through that summer and the next, whenever the sick-house sent Colby to Achadh dhomhain and the toll there was more than Beitris could face alone, which by the second of those summers was most weeks. Neither of them ever spoke of it to the Administration or to the custodians as anything but what it plainly was, two women doing a hard thing that needed two pairs of hands; but the camp came, in time, to speak of it as something else, and the phrase that grew up around it, *An Dithis a Nigh Còmhla*, the two who washed together, was said in the camps for years after, though neither woman, so far as the record shows, ever heard it said to her own face.

VII

Of the Letter-Book's Order

The sickness did not end. It slackened, the way a fire slackens when it has burned through the driest of what it was given and is left working more

slowly on what is left, the deaths falling from forty a month at Achadh dhomhain to four, then to one in a season, then, in most of the twenty-six settlements, to none for a year at a stretch before another case would show and the whole camp would hold its breath until it was seen whether one case meant a new burning or only one grave. Nathaniel Bright's book, with its broken-off row, was filed at the Residency and never taken up again by any physician who came after him; his question, what the dust did and how much of it a lung could hold before it stopped forging a man for breathing it, went unanswered on the island.

George Tolley's letter to the Company's directors, the one setting the sickness's causes down in the order he believed them to stand, was copied at the Residency into the bound letter-book that Lisle's successor had begun and every Commissioner after kept, each adding his own year's pages to what had gone before. It sits there still, among orders about the price of iron and the state of the harbour works, three causes given in three lines: the dust of the workings first, since that at least could not be laid at any door a Commissioner might one day wish to walk through; the habit of the hearth second, since a people's own customs were always the easiest blame to give and the hardest for them to answer; and the custodians' shrines last, named without one word of evidence beside them, because a shrine was a gathering, and a gathering could always be made to sound like a danger to a man who had never stood in one and watched what was actually done there.

Of the true cause, the dust that Bright had weighed and never finished weighing, carried up out of galleries driven faster and deeper than any before them into lungs that had never been asked to breathe so much of the hill at once, no Commissioner's letter-book ever said a plain word. The camps needed no letter-book to tell them. They had the green acre, and the field at Cnoc naomh that has never since been ploughed, and the feathers that went back up over every door as fast as the overseers took them down, and the saying that outlasted every one of the men who tried to stop its being said.

Ithidh Mòd an neach a dh'itheas an cnoc.

They had, too, though few beyond Achadh dhomhain itself yet knew to connect the two things, a girl in a house of spoil who had been steeped in more of that same dust than any child before or since, and had not sickened of it at all, and did not age.

PART FOUR

OF the Levy, the
HUNGER and the
DROUGHT

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

Of the Eleven Days of Baile thais

AE 77 – 79

I

Of the Spring after the Sickness

The dying at Baile thais had stopped by the time the first primroses came up along the moor-road, but the town did not look like a town that had stopped dying. Catrìona nic Eachainn walked out to the pit-mouth in the grey of that spring with her shawl over her mouth from old habit, though Anne Colby had told her months before that the habit did nothing and she might as well breathe free. She kept it anyway. A thing the body has learned to do against fear does not stop because the fear is told it was wrong.

Below Cill ghlas the ground still showed where the town's burial field had been cut wider twice in one winter. Grass had not yet taken the new turned earth; it lay the colour of a scar, paler than the field round it, and the shrine women left dishes of meal on the mounds because that was what you did when you did not know what else to do. Catrìona had buried her mother's sister there in am Faoilleach, and a niece a fortnight after, and had gone on leading her shift the whole time because A' Chompanaidh's book of hours did not stop for grief, and because thirty other households were waiting on her wage same as her own.

Anne Colby's sick-house still stood at Achadh dhomhain, an hour's walk north among the deep galleries, its canvas roof gone grey with two winters' smoke, and word came down that she meant to keep it open through the summer for the crews at Àth iséal too, though the worst of the sickness there had passed. The camp people called it kindly, the only house of the strangers' building that

1. the Company

they called kindly, and it was said without much thinking about it that this was because Colby herself had washed the dead with her own hands rather than sending a servant to do it, which was more than the Mission's own ministers had done.

At Cnoc gharbh, to the south along the ridge, the people who had worked the southern galleries did not wait for the sickness to be called past. They took their pots and their bedding and their children and walked back up to the old village on the hill their grandfathers had held before the pits, and left the camp huts standing empty with the doors swinging. A Chompanaidh's agent rode out to look at the empty huts and wrote in his book that the crews had deserted their posts, as though a plague were a kind of laziness. Nobody at Baile thais blamed Cnoc gharbh. Half of them had thought of doing the same and had stayed only because Baile thais, unlike Cnoc gharbh, had no old village on a hill to go back to. It had never been anything but the camp.

Catriona was seven-and-thirty that spring, crew-leader of the seventh shift at the Baile thais gallery, a broad, dark, plain-spoken woman with a scar through one eyebrow from a fall of stone as a girl, and hands that the coal had got into so deep that even scrubbed they looked bruised. She had led the seventh shift for eleven years, since the crew-leader before her, an old man named Griogar, had coughed himself to a standstill and put the tally-stick in her hand himself and said she was the only one of them who would not be talked round by the agent's smile. Griogar was dead two winters now, of the ordinary lung-sickness that took hewers, not the green plague; he had at least been spared that.

The camp still kept, over most of its doors, a single hawk's feather nailed to the lintel, the overseers' reports calling it a matter for punishment and the overseers themselves too busy that spring to trouble over it. The hawk-priests had gone unwelcome in the camps for years now. A feather cost nothing, though, and a man could nail it up himself in the dark, and Catriona had one over her own door, put there by her mother before her, and had never taken it down nor troubled to say a prayer under it either. It was less a faith to her than a habit, like the shawl over her mouth, and she thought, without much reflection, that a people who had been told for two generations that the strangers' book had all the say in what a hill might hold could be forgiven for keeping quietly to older things, whether or not they believed the old things any harder for the keeping.

There was no one at Cathair dhearg to write to about any of it, not that year. The high custodian's seat, Ceann a' Chùrain², had stood empty since Alasdair Liath died six years before, and Comhairle a' Chùrain³ had not agreed on who should fill it, being much taken up, so it was said, with the business of the tithe and the petitions of the towns, and finding, as councils will, that an empty chair causes less argument than a full one. Catriona did not think about the empty seat often. But she thought of it that spring, walking past the burial field to the pit-mouth, because it meant that whatever she was about to ask, there would be no one great enough at the capital to be asked twice.

II

Of the Agent's Answer

The agent at Baile thais that year was a man named Silas Crewe, thirty-seven himself, sent up from Ros dhomhain the autumn before to replace an agent who had died of the same sickness he had been sent to manage. He was neither the worst of A' Chompanaidh¹'s men nor the best: he kept his ledgers straight, did not water the lamp-oil, and had once, to general surprise, paid a full week's wage to a crew that lost two days to a flooded sump through no fault of its own. He had also, in the same season, signed the order that kept the deepest gallery working through the height of the Green Death, on the word of a surveyor from Ros dhomhain who had never gone down it himself.

Catriona went to him on a wet morning with three other crew-leaders behind her, though it was understood between them without saying that she would do the talking. Crewe's office was a plank room built onto the counting-house, with a stove that smoked and a window that did not shut properly, and he stood behind his table rather than sitting, which she took, rightly, for a kind of politeness meant to look like the opposite.

"I'm asking you to close the third and the fourth gallery," she said. "Not the whole working. The third and fourth, where the dust hangs, till the surgeon says different."

2. the high custodian of the Council of Custodians; lit. 'head of the custody'

3. the Council of Custodians; lit. 'the council of the custody'

1. the Company

"The surgeon has not said the dust does it," Crewe said. "He has said he does not know what does it."

"He has said it is worst where the dust is worst. He told me that himself, at my aunt's burying."

Crewe looked at the paper in front of him rather than at her, which she also took rightly, for he had the figures of the quarter's yield laid out on it and knew them without needing to look. "The yield in the third and fourth is a third of the whole working," he said. "If I close them I have to write to Ros dhomhain and say why, and the why I have to give them is a physician's guess. I can't close a gallery on a guess, Catrìona. The yield must not fall. Those are the words I was sent with, near enough."

"The yield," Catrìona said, "or the dead."

"I did not choose the words," Crewe said, and for a moment, briefly, something in his face agreed with her, and then put itself away again, as a man puts away a coin he has been shown he cannot spend. "I'll write up what you've told me. That's what I can do."

"Write it up," she said, and did not thank him for it, and went out into the rain with the other three crew-leaders behind her, none of whom had said a word, and none of whom needed to; they had heard the same answer given a dozen times in a dozen shapes since the sickness began, and they knew by now what shape came after a shape like that one.

III

Of the Coal-Tub

She let three weeks pass before she stood on the tub. She was not, whatever the camp said of her afterward, a woman who acted from a single hot morning; she went first to the custodian of Baile thais, an old woman named Sineag who kept what rolls there were for a town that had never properly had a custodian's house, only a room over the smithy, and asked her what the old law said about a hill and its rest, in case there was a word from An Aois Naomh¹ she could set against A' Chompanaidh²'s paper. Sineag found nothing that would

1. the Holy Age

2. the Company

serve; the *Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig*³ spoke of the coal burned, not the coal cut, and there was no law anywhere, old or new, about how deep a gallery might be worked while men sickened in it, because no one before this age had needed to write one.

So on a grey morning near the middle of the summer, with the shift gathering at the pit-mouth in the usual half-light and the usual noise, wet boots and lamp-checks and somebody's dog getting under everybody's feet, *Catrìona* turned over one of the empty coal-tubs that stood by the weigh-house, climbed up on it, and told the whole shift, which by then was near enough the whole working, since word had gone round in the night, what she had asked *Crewe* for and what he had answered.

"He says the yield must not fall," she said, from the tub, her voice carrying flat and hard over the yard the way it carried down a gallery when a fall had to be called. "I say the yield can wait on the living. I'm not asking any man or woman here to leave their family without bread. I'm asking that nobody go below today, into the third or the fourth, until *Crewe* writes to *Ros dhomhain* and gets back a better answer than a guess. If that costs us the day's pay, it costs us the day's pay. I'll stand it same as you."

There was no great shout of agreement, no crowd surging forward with fists in the air, of the kind the camp songs like to make of such mornings. What there was instead was a long quiet, boots shifting in the mud, a woman coughing somewhere at the back who was not sick, only cold, and then, one by one, men and women turning their lamps down and setting them on the ground rather than carrying them to the gallery mouths. *Ragnall Breac*, a hewer's boy of seven who was too young that year to be paid a man's wage and was there only to carry water and pick slate from the tubs, stood at the front the whole time with his water-pail still in his hand, not understanding all of it, understanding enough of it to stay.

Catrìona stepped down off the tub, and rather than going to stand over the crowd or address them further, sat down on it, in the mud, in her working clothes, and folded her arms, and did not go below. She had planned no speech to make with her body; the speech made itself, and it was the one that held. A woman sitting on an upturned tub, arms folded, in the rain, saying nothing further, is a harder thing to argue with than a woman shouting, because there is nothing in it to answer.

3. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

Crewe came out within the hour, saw the yard full and still, and went back in again without a word to anyone. By noon two riders had gone from the counting-house, one south to Ros dhomhain and one, it was said later though nobody at Baile thais ever had it proved, north to Muileann chrom, where Dòmhnall mac Raghnaill Maor kept the staff of the Stewards and had, by then, eight-and-fifty years and no love at all for a stoppage he had not ordered.

Sineag came down from her room over the smithy at midday and stood a while at the edge of the yard. She joined no crowd, being too old by her own reckoning to sit in mud for anybody, yet she kept her place at the edge of it a long while too, and when a young overseer's clerk asked her, civilly enough, whether the custodian meant to order the crews back to work, she told him that a custodian's rolls recorded what was done and did not order what should be, and that he was welcome to write that down too if he thought it worth the ink. He left it unwritten, and stayed near her the rest of the afternoon regardless, as though an old woman who would say such a thing to a clerk of A' Chompanaidh was worth keeping an eye on, which in its own way told Catriona, watching from the tub, that the day's stand had already gone further than the yard.

IV

Of the Eleven Days

The first three days were the easiest, because the town still had its own bread and its own stored meal, and because there was something in the crowd of the yard, the fires kept up after dark, the songs Fearchar sang years later having their true root in mornings such as these, that felt for a while like a kind of holiday, wrongly earned yet taken all the same. By the fourth day the easiness had gone out of it. Catriona took to walking the town each evening. A crew-leader who does not walk her own streets in a stoppage she called is asking to be thought a coward, and there, walking, she counted, without meaning to at first and then quite deliberately, the loaves standing in the windows.

There was one store in Baile thais that sold bread, and it belonged to A' Chompanaidh¹, same as the huts and the weigh-house and the smithy's lease. On the first evening there had been loaves stacked three deep behind the glass. On the

1. the Company

fourth there were perhaps a dozen. On the sixth, six. She did not need Crewe to tell her what he already knew, which was that a camp that owns its only store can starve a stoppage without lifting a hand against it, and does not even have to be cruel to do it; it need only wait.

Ros gharbh's fishermen, fifteen miles off on the southern coast, heard of the stoppage by the seventh day, nobody afterward could say quite how fast such things travelled, and began carrying salt fish up into the hills by night on the moor tracks, past A' Chompanaidh's own watch at the crossroads, and left it at back doors without asking payment or thanks. It fell short of feeding eleven days of a mining town, but it kept every child at Baile thais from starving outright, and the custodians' roll, when it came to be written years later at Muileann chaol, called it the one trade of that whole decade that ran the right way, from the giving hand to the needing one and asking nothing back.

On the ninth day Crewe sent word that he would open the store's back room, where flour was kept for the counting-house's own table, to any family with children under five, if the crews would go below. Catriona refused it in front of the yard. She wanted the children fed as much as any mother there; what she would not have was a store opened halfway, which stays owned however it is opened, breaking a strike along exactly the line A' Chompanaidh would choose to break it. "Feed them all or feed none," she told him, at his own door, "and if you feed none, I'll answer for that to God and not to you." He did not open the room.

On the tenth night it rained without stopping, and half the yard fires went out, and a woman named Beathag Ruadh, whose husband had died in the third gallery two winters before the stoppage and who had five children and no bread left at all, came to Catriona in the dark. She asked her plainly, as a tired woman asks another, no accusation in it, whether it would not be better to send the crews back down and keep what strength they had for another day, another year, since the third and fourth galleries would go on being worked whether Baile thais stood in the yard or not. Catriona had no good answer for her, and gave her the only one she had, which was that she did not know, and sat with her by what was left of the fire until Beathag's children were asleep against her. In the morning Beathag went to the yard with everyone else and did not go below.

V

Of the Twelfth Morning

On the twelfth morning Catriona went down to the store herself before first light, before anyone else was in the yard to see her go, because she did not want to be watched deciding. She stood at the shutters, which had not yet been opened for the day, and looked in through the gap where the wood had warped, at shelves she already knew were bare, having counted them bare the evening before, and stood there long enough that the cold came up through her boots.

There was nothing in the shop but the counter, the scale, and, on the top shelf, out of easy reach, a single sack of meal that Crewe, she supposed, had kept back for his own table, or for a bribe he had not yet had cause to pay. She looked at that sack a long while too. Then she walked back up through the town, past the shrine women already at the burial field with their dishes of meal that they, at least, had never stopped finding somewhere, and came to the yard, and climbed up on the same tub, which had stood in the same place, rained on, eleven days running, and told the shift to go below.

"We did not win the third and fourth," she said. "I won't tell you we did, because you'd know it for a lie inside the hour. What we won, if we won anything, is that they know now it can be done. Eleven days is not nothing. Go below. Feed your children. I'll go below with you." And she did, that morning, walking into the second gallery herself for the first time in eleven days, her lamp lit, her hands shaking a little in a way she did not let the shift see, and the work went on as though nothing had stopped it, which was the worst part of going back, that the hill did not care one way or the other how long a person had refused it.

The third and fourth galleries were not closed. They ran another four years before the seam in them thinned and A' Chompanaidh¹ abandoned them for reasons of its own that had nothing to do with anyone's asking. No answer of any kind ever came from Ros dhomhain, nor, so far as anyone at Baile thais ever learned, from the empty chair at Cathair dhearg, which sat empty still.

VI

Of the Granary

1. the Company

Within the month a wagon-train came up from Muileann chrom with timber and stone, and A' Chompanaidh¹ began building a granary of its own beside the pit-mouth, a squat building with one door and a lock, and word went round the camps, all of them, not Baile thais alone, that from now on no household was to keep more grain in its own house than a week's ration, the rest to be held in A' Chompanaidh's granary and drawn against a crew-leader's tally. The order was read out at Baile thais by an overseer none of them had seen before, and it carried, at the foot of the paper, the mark of Dòmhnall mac Ragh-naill Maor, Steward at Muileann chrom, a man Catrìona had met twice in her life and liked neither time, though she allowed, thinking it over afterward, that he had likely signed a good many orders that summer he had not troubled to read closely, being a man more given to the staff's ceremony than its use.

Sineag the custodian said, when she heard of it, that she had never in all her rolls read of a granary built to answer a stoppage rather than a harvest, and that this alone told her more of what the stoppage had done than anything Crewe had put in writing. Catrìona thought there was truth in that, though it was cold comfort to a household now walking to a locked building with a tally-stick to ask for its own week's bread.

The overseers enforced the granary rule with more spite than the order itself asked for, as overseers on the whole will, and searched huts for hidden meal, and twice that autumn fined a family a day's wage for a sack of flour found under a bed, though the sack, in both cases, had come up from Ros gharbh by night and never passed through A' Chompanaidh's own scales at all, a fact the overseers either did not know or chose not to ask about.

VII

Of the Road East

Catrìona was not dismissed outright, which would at least have had the honesty of a plain blow. She was, instead, over the two years that followed, quietly refused. The seventh shift was given to another crew-leader before the winter was out, a young man loyal to Crewe and glad of the wage; Catrìona was offered work at the surface, sorting slate, at half a hewer's pay, and took it be-

1. the Company

cause there was nothing else, and kept it eleven months, until the overseer over the sorting-sheds, a different man from Crewe but reading from the same book, told her the sheds had more hands than they needed and hers, this quarter, were the ones not needed.

She walked to Cnoc fhiadhaich and asked for work and was turned away at the gate before she had said her name twice; the agent there knew her by sight, which told her plainly enough what had gone round in A' Chompanaidh's own letters, whatever face Crewe himself might have kept at Baile thais. She walked to Àth ìseal, and to the timber camp beyond it, and had the same door shut in the same quiet way each time, no shouting, no threats, only a man looking past her shoulder and saying there was nothing that quarter, come again another season.

She did not, in all that time, ask the guild of Muileann chiar for anything, having no claim on it and no trade in silver, and it did not occur to her until the second year of her refusing that a hill which owed A' Chompanaidh nothing might be the one hill left on the island that would look at her without first looking at Crewe's letters. Sìneag, when Catrìona came to the smithy room to say her goodbyes, gave her what little the custodian's own store could spare, a heel of cheese and a pair of stockings darned past their first darning, and said only that Baile thais would remember the tub longer than it remembered the granary. Catrìona did not fully believe it, standing there with the cheese in her hand and the road east still ahead of her.

In the autumn of the third year after the stoppage, with her savings gone and her sister's household unable to keep her much longer without going short themselves, Catrìona took what she had, a change of clothes, her mother's ring, and the tally-stick Griogar had given her eleven years before, which she had kept though it named a shift she no longer led, and walked east over the hills toward Muileann chiar, two days and the best part of a third, sleeping the first night in a shepherd's bothy and the second under a wall, with the country changing under her feet from the black spoil-heaps of the coal hills to the paler grey of the silver country, where the old reverence for the vein still held in a way it had stopped holding at Baile thais some years before.

Comann an Airgid³, the silver guild, had never worked easily with A' Chompanaidh, holding as it did its own seam under the compact Ùna nic Choinnich had won from Lisle, which the humans had never managed to unwrite; and its

1. the Company

2. the silver guild of Muileann chiar

head that year, a woman who had stood at the adit with the ledgers as a girl, heard Catrìona's whole account without interrupting it once, asked her three questions about the ore she had never in her life seen, and put the matter of taking her on to the guild's own hands rather than deciding it herself, which was the guild's way in most things that mattered. The hands voted to take her, by a wide margin, and Catrìona had little doubt it was less for love of her than for the pleasure of taking from A' Chompanaidh a hewer it had gone to some trouble to be rid of.

A' Chompanaidh wrote to the guild within the season, in the correct and distant hand of its counting-house at Ros dhomhain, asking that Catrìona nic Eachainn, lately of Baile thais, be sent back to answer for the stoppage of two years before. The guild's answer was drafted by its own clerk, read aloud once in the guild hall to general satisfaction, folded, sealed, and sent south by the ordinary post; and what it said, whether short or long, courteous or otherwise, no one at Muileann chiar troubled to keep a second copy of, thinking the matter closed the day it was sent. The letter that was filed against it at Ros dhomhain has not survived either. Of the words themselves, then, nothing more can be told than that they went, and that Catrìona nic Eachainn, refiner of the silver guild from that autumn to the end of her days, never again set foot at Baile thais, nor, so far as the rolls know, ever wished to.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

Of the Priced Silver and the Blessed Coin

AE 80 – 87

I

Of the Silver Priced by Dia-thìreach Hands

At Muileann chiar in the autumn of the eightieth year Catriona nic Earchainn weighed her first bar of guild silver alone, without Ùna nic Choinnich's hand at her elbow, because Ùna nic Choinnich had been ten years in the ground and there was no one else the guild trusted with the scale on a market morning.

She had come to the silver town a year before with nothing but the clothes she stood in and a name the Company had marked as one not to be hired again in any pit on the island, and the guild had taken her on as it took on anyone with steady hands and no fear of the acid vats, and had not asked what she had done at Baile thais. She learned the trade fast: how to read the ore by its weight in the hand before the fire ever touched it, how to keep the ledger that answered to no Company clerk, how the guild's own price for a bar of silver was set by the guild alone, at a hall table, by seven refiners' vote, and was the one price on the whole island that no human hand had ever moved.

It was a small thing to be proud of and she was proud of it anyway.

The town had grown around her without her much noticing the growing, the way a wall grows a foot at a time and is only a wall when you look up from your work and find you cannot see over it. Two years before there had been one street of stone houses and a smithy; now there were five streets, and a second town besides, a mile to the west, that the guild had raised for its carters and coal-breakers when the old town's lanes could no longer hold them, and which was called by the old town's own name, so that a stranger asking the way to Muileann chiar was as often as not sent to the wrong one. The custodians' rolls, when they had cause to write of either, called them the old town and the new, and did not always trouble to say which they meant.

Below the town, where the burn ran warm out of the hillside, the Administration had built a bath-house that autumn for its officers who came up sick from the coast fevers to take the water. The springs had been the island's own since before any custodian now living could say; the Dia-thirich of the district had bathed there each Bealltainn and each Samhain time out of mind, for the joints and for the skin complaints of the deep galleries, and had never paid a penny to do it. Now they were let in on two days of the humans' week, and charged a penny at the door for the water that had been theirs to walk into unasked. Catriona went once, in the second winter, to see it for herself, and paid her penny, and sat in water that scalded exactly as it always had, and came out and told the guild hall that the water had not changed at all, only the door.

Silversmiths began that year to settle along the carters' road at Muileann bhàn, half a day's walk west, working the guild's bar into brooches and clasps and buckles for the humans' own market, since a piece of worked silver crossed the sea for far more than a bar of it ever had. It was, Catrìona came to understand, turning the guild's ledgers over of an evening, the one craft of the island sold across the water under its own name and no other; every bolt of cloth, every keg of salt fish, every cask of the island's own barley beer went out under the Company's mark, but a Muileann bhàn brooch went out under its own maker's mark, because the humans who bought it liked to say where it had come from.

The Company asked, that same year and the next, whether the guild would sell its silver at the Company's price rather than its own, and was refused both times, and asked a third time with a paper naming a magistrate at Ros dhomhain who might be brought to rule on the question, and was refused a third time, more shortly. Catrìona was in the hall for the third refusal and watched the seven refiners vote it down without one dissenting hand, and thought, though she did not say it aloud, that this was the whole of what she had walked east over the hills to find: one table in the whole width of the island where the Dia-thìrich still set the price.

II

Of the Seat Ten Years Empty

In the autumn of the eighty-first year Fearghas went up the hill to a council he had no vote in but had been asked to bless: the seating of a new high custodian of the Council of Custodians, the first in ten years.

Alasdair Liath had held the seat twenty-seven years and had been dead ten; since his burying the council had sat without a head of its own choosing, unable to agree on one, and had said among itself, in the hearing of no Residency clerk, that an empty seat answered no letters and signed no papers the Administration might afterward hold against the whole council, and that this was not the worst thing a seat could be. Fearghas had heard Ealasaid Liath say once that ten years without a head was an answer of its own kind, though not one anybody had meant to give.

The council chose, at last, Artair mac Iain, a custodian of the eastern shires six-and-fifty that winter, a quiet man who had kept his own town's rolls without

a blot for thirty years and had never once, in all that time, been summoned to the Residency for anything. He took the seat in the same hall where Tormod mac Ailein had signed the treaty in one tongue, under the same beams, and said, when he was asked for words, only that he would keep the rolls as they had always been kept, and sat down.

Fearghas said the order's blessing over him, both horses named, the dark and the light, and found the words came easier over a man than they had come over a coin, though he could not then have said why, only that a man could answer for himself and a coin could not.

III

Of the Two Horses

Fearghas mac Mhuirich had kept the fire of Òrd Mhacha¹ at Cathair dhearg for eleven years before Tolley's letter came, and in that time he had blessed ploughs, byres, bridges, the first-born of three custodian houses, and once, at a fisherman's asking, a boat that sank within the month with the blessing still wet on her bow. He did not think himself proud about any of it. A blessing was a word said in the right order over a thing that could not say it for itself, and Macha's order had said such words at Cathair dhearg since before the Stone Kings were a memory anyone kept whole.

The letter was carried up from the Residency by a boy in a Company coat who did not know what he carried and did not wait for an answer. It asked, in the courteous hand the Administration used for everything it meant to have, that the priests of Òrd Mhacha bless the new coin of the realm before it was struck a second time, so that the humans' subjects on the island might take it without fear of ill luck.

The eldest of the order, a woman named Ealasaid Liath who had held the fire longer than Fearghas had been alive, read the letter twice and laughed once, without much humour in it. "They want the horses to run for them," she said. "Well. The horses have run for stranger riders."

She meant the rite of the two, Dubh Sainglenn the black and Liath Macha the grey, that stood at the heart of every blessing the order gave: the dark hour and the

1. the order of Macha

bright, the labour and the rest, the thing spent and the thing kept, each with its due and neither without the other. It was the oldest teaching the order had, older than any building at Cathair dhearg, and Fearghas had said the words of it over a hundred doorsteps and a thousand infants without once doubting that the two halves were equal, and that a blessing given to one alone was no blessing at all, only a wish dressed as one.

"The coin is one thing," he said. "It is spent, and it does not rest. What is the grey horse's part in it?"

Ealasaid Liath looked at him with the patience she kept for the youngest of the order, though he was forty-five that year and had buried his own teacher. "The grey horse's part," she said, "is that the coin passes from a full hand to an empty one, and comes back full again, in its season, as the tide does. That is the rest it takes. You are thinking of the box it sits in. Think of the road it walks."

He went with her to the temple on the morning appointed, 24 an Gearran, AE 85, with the whole order in their grey and black and the Residency's clerk standing at the door with a satchel of the new-struck marks, bright as fish-scale, a ship stamped on the one face and nothing of the island on the other. Tolley himself did not come; he sent word that the ordinance of a Commissioner's presence would overweight a religious matter, which those of the order who cared to be amused found a fine thing for a man to say who had ordered the blessing in the first place.

Ealasaid Liath said the words over the satchel, both halves of them, the dark and the light, in the old order, and the fire took the smoke of the burnt hazel the rite asked for, and it was done. Fearghas stood at his place in the second rank and said the words with the rest, because that is what a member of an order does, and because he could not, that morning, have told anyone in what particular the thing felt wrong. Only that when the clerk gathered up the satchel and thanked them and went, he found himself watching the door a long while after it had shut, the way a man watches a place where he has mislaid something without yet knowing what.

Three of the younger priests would not stand at their places that day and stood instead at the back of the hall with their arms folded. Nothing was said to them then. Ealasaid Liath was not a woman to make an example in front of the Residency's clerk. But that night, over the last of the fire, she told Fearghas what she had not troubled to tell them: that a coin blessed with both horses' names was still, in the end, only a coin, and that the order's business was the rite done rightly,

not the uses a stranger's hand put a rightly-blessed thing to afterward. "We do not answer for the road it walks," she said. "Only that it is a whole horse that walks it, and not half of one."

Fearghas turned that over for years before he understood he did not believe it. He said nothing of that yet. He kept the peace of his order that year, and kept it.

He kept it, too, at the cost of small things he only noticed afterward, looking back. That year he stopped walking the lower town on the mornings the Residency's clerks changed their coin at the money-tables by the bridge, where a queue of Dia-thìrich waited with barter goods to be weighed against the new mark and went away with fewer coins than the goods, by the old reckoning, ought to have bought. The bridge road was longer and quieter, he told himself, and left it there. He kept the fire, said the hours, blessed what was brought to him, and did not again stand at the temple door to watch a Residency satchel carried out into the town, though he heard, from those of the order less careful of where they walked, that the second and third strikings of the coin went out from that door much as the first had.

IV

Of the Fleece and the Boats

The second cheapening of the coin fell in the year after the blessing, read out at every market cross by a Residency crier who did not trouble to soften it: the barter goods of the Dia-thìrich, wool and hide and dried fish and the rest, were marked down a second time against the mark, on a table the Administration alone had drawn, and no custodian's council was asked to sign it or shown it before it was cried.

Word of it reached Muileann chiar three days after Cathair dhearg, carried by a carter who had heard it cried at Baile Mòr fhionn on his way east and had thought the guild ought to know, since silver was not named in the table and the guild's own price stood as it had. He told it at the hall table over his supper, and told also what he had seen at Baile Mòr fhionn itself: the weavers standing about the market cross with their wool in baskets at their feet, working out on their fingers what a fleece was worth under the new table, and finding it was worth what half a fleece had been worth the week before.

The weavers of Baile Mòr fhionn would not sell at the table. That winter they carried no wool to the humans' market at all, and the wool sat in their warehouses through two winters until the moths had the better part of it.

At Caol fhiadhaich, a fishing town on the same coast that had never dealt in coal or silver at all, the harbour dues were called in marks that year for the first time, where they had always been called in fish or in kind, and the town could not raise the sum any way but by selling boats. It sold eleven of its two-and-twenty, at the Company's own asking price, which was low, since the Company was the only buyer on that coast with marks to spend; and the men who had sailed the eleven boats went into the pits the following season under the Company's contracts, because a man who has sold his boat must eat from somewhere.

Catrìona heard all this the way the guild hall heard everything, as news carried by carters and confirmed or corrected by the next carter after, and set it beside what she had seen with her own eyes at the bath-house door, and thought that she was coming to understand the shape of the thing the Company was building, one small cheapening at a time, the way a tide takes a shore in ten thousand waves, each so small a man standing on the sand would swear the water had not moved at all.

V

Of the Second Asking

The Administration struck a new coin the year after, when the barter was marked down the second time, larger than the old and stamped, the Residency's letter said, so that no forger on the island might easily copy it, though there had been no forger caught in all the years of the first. The letter asked, in the same courteous hand as before, that Òrd Mhacha' bless it as the first had been blessed.

Ealasaid Liath had died in the winter between, of a lung complaint that took her slowly and without complaint, and Fearghas kept the fire in her place, the eldest now among a much younger order, most of whom had not stood in the hall the first time.

He read the letter at the fire that night and did not sleep, and in the morning called the order together and told them he would not say the words over this coin,

and that any who wished to say them without him might, since he held no rule over another priest's mouth, only over his own.

None went.

It was not, he told them, a matter of the humans' coin being unworthy of a blessing; a plough was no worthier and he had blessed a hundred ploughs. It was that the order had been asked, the year before, to bless the road a thing walked and not the thing that walked it, and had told itself it answered only for the horse and not the rider; and he had watched the road a year now, through the second marking-down of the barter, and did not believe that any longer. The coin did not pass from a full hand to an empty one and back again in its season, as the grey horse's part required. It passed from an empty hand to a fuller one, always in the one direction, down the same road every year the same way, and no rite he knew how to say could make a one-way road into a wheel.

"Then bless the wheel," said the youngest of them, a woman named Sìne who had joined the order the winter before, "and let the road answer for itself."

"I do not know how to bless a wheel that only turns one way," Fearghas said. "If you know, teach me, and I will say the words gladly."

She did not know either. Nobody in the hall that morning knew, and the not-knowing sat among them a long while before anyone spoke again.

Word of the refusal reached the Residency within the month, as such words always did, carried by whichever clerk had cause to visit the temple on other business and found the fire kept but the coin unblest on the shelf where it had been left. Tolley did not send for Fearghas. He had larger matters on his desk than one priest's obstinacy over a rite the coin did not in any case require to pass current; the letter asking the blessing had been courtesy, not law, and the coin was spent in every market on the island with or without it. But the Residency's letter-book that year notes, in a clerk's hand, that the order of Òrd Mhacha at the capital was "divided on a religious nicety," and does not trouble to say what the nicety was, which is as much as most Administration papers ever granted the order's reasons in all the years of the age.

VI

Of the Name at the Wash-Stones

1. the order of Macha

It is told from these same years, though no roll sets the day of it, that the name the washing-women of Achadh dhomhain had given the girl of the spoil-houses went out of that camp and down the coal roads, to Àth ìseal and Muileann chrom and the huts at Cnoc fhiadhaich, and was said at wash-stones where nobody had ever seen her.

By the count of the years she was near grown. By the look of her, the women said, she was not; and the women who washed the dead knew better than anyone what a year does to a body. They called her *nighean an rìgh*, the king's daughter, meaning Ailean Mòr, whom the gods crowned in the grove and who fell at the Ford of Blood; and most of those who said it did not believe a word of the thousands of years, or said they did not, which came to the same thing at supper. A king four thousand years old was, to a woman with a week's ration to stretch and a husband on the night crew, a tale for the dark end of the year. They went on saying the name all the same, because it was a good name, and because a people whose hill was going out in ships will take its comfort where it finds it.

Nobody wrote it in a roll. The custodians of the camps had learned, in these years, to keep out of their rolls whatever the Administration might read as a claim, and a king's daughter, even a jest of one, was such a claim.

VII

Of the Fire under the Trees

Fearghas mac Mhuirich left the temple at Cathair dhearg in the spring after his refusal, with eleven of the order who had come to think as he did, and walked north to Cnoc bheag, where the sacred forest had stood since before the order was founded and where a fence of oak stakes, renewed generation on generation, still kept the cattle from the old stone that no one living could read.

They were not driven out. Nobody at the capital's temple forbade them the door; the eldest of those who stayed, a mild man named Griogair who had said the second blessing without Fearghas's help and thought no worse of him for the refusing, walked with them as far as the north road and told them the fire at Cathair dhearg would keep both horses' names as it always had, and that this was no falling-out between them, only two roads to the one rite, and that he hoped they might one day agree which was the truer.

They did not agree, not then and not for years after. But the custodians of Cnoc bheag, whose own seat at the council's table had gone begging more than once in these hard years, and several custodians of other towns who had lost their seats outright to the Company's magistrates and the Residency's displeasure and had nowhere else the old forms were still kept whole, came to the dissenting priests' hall by ones and twos through that first summer, until the forest held near as many custodians without a town as priests without a temple, and the two kinds of the dispossessed began, without either quite meaning it, to keep each other's company.

On the last evening of that first spring, Fearghas lit a fire under the oaks with hazel cut from the grove, as the rite asked, and said the words of the two horses over it, both halves in the old order, the dark and the light, exactly as Ealasaidd Liath had taught him and exactly as he had said them over the first coin two years before. He asked nothing of anyone to walk any particular road that night. He asked only that the fire be a whole fire, spent and kept both, as a rite ought to be; and the custodians who stood in the ring about it, most of whom owned no seat and no roll and no staff any longer, watched it burn down to embers under the old stone's shadow, and said nothing at all, which among that company had come, in these years, to be its own kind of prayer.

VIII

Of the Staff Passed On

In the spring that Fearghas walked north, word reached Muileann chiar by the usual road of carters and market gossip that Dòmhnall mac Raghnaill Maor, overseer of the coal country these five-and-twenty years, had died at Muileann chrom in his sixty-seventh year, of no illness the guild's informant could name, only of age and the staff's long weight.

Catrìona had cause to remember him without kindness: it was his hand that had signed the order forbidding the camps to keep more than a week's grain against her own strike at Baile thais, years before she ever came east, and the granary his order had built still stood at Muileann chrom, locked of a Friday evening the way it had always been locked. She felt, hearing of his death, less than she thought she ought to feel, and told the hall table only that a hard man was gone and a harder trade would go on without him.

The staff passed, as everyone in the coal country had long known it would, to his son Iain, seven-and-thirty that year, the first of the overseer's line schooled at the Mission at Ros dhomhain, who was said to keep his household in Dia-thìris and his reports to the Company in the humans' own tongue, and to walk the galleries himself rather than send a clerk. What that would mean for the crews under him nobody at Muileann chiar could yet say, and the guild's answer, when the news was set before the hall table, was the same answer the guild gave most tidings out of the coal country now: that they would learn it soon enough, and that until they did there was silver to weigh.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

OF the Levy and the RING OF Beacons

AE 88 – 91

Ghearr sinn ar n-ainmean sa chloich mus do scrìobh iad sinn às.

We cut our names in the stone before they wrote us out.

— cut into the lintel of the lamp-room at Taigh-solais Baile chrom

I

Of the Reading at Caol mhòr

T

he camps under the hawk-feather burned their fires that winter as they had burned them the winter before, and the Administration's clerks at Ros dhomhain wrote in their ledgers that the yield still climbed. It was George Tolley's thirteenth year as Commissioner, and by then he had learned what the island's soil would give up and what its people would, and had stopped troubling to ask which was which. On a hard morning at the turn of the year he set his seal to a single sheet and called it An Togail¹, the Levy: from every farming village of the west and north, one soul in five of the able grown folk, taken for two years, to go down into the pits where the Company's coal was cut. The villages would be paid for it, in marks, at the rate the second reform of the coin had lately fixed; a rate that bought less bread each season it was reckoned in, though the ledger did not say so.

Word of a law travels a country faster than the law's own officers, and slower than the fear of it. It reached Cnoc thais as a rumour before it reached Caol mhòr as a list, and at Caol mhòr, in the far north-west where the strangers had first raised the land, it came as both together.

The officers rode in on a market morning, four of them and a wagon, with a guard of the Company's men the town had not asked for. They set up at the steel-yard by the quay, where the fish were weighed, and one of them stood on the weighing-stone with a paper and read from it in the humans' tongue, flat and fast, a list of names that were not the names anyone in Caol mhòr answered to. The custodians of the town stood below him with their own clerks and wrote each name down again as it was said, guessing at the shapes of it, and only when the whole list was read and the officer had gone back to his wagon for a cup of something did they go from house to house with their own paper and match a guessed name to a face. Twice they guessed wrong and took the wrong son from the wrong door, and it was three days before the mistake was mended, by which time the right son had already been marched a day's walk east.

The custodian who kept that day's roll, an old woman with a bad hip who had held the post since before the Levy was thought of, wrote at the end of it a single line that the Administration's own reader, when the roll crossed his desk months later, let stand unremarked: that a people may be counted twice, once by those who take them and once by those who love them, and that the two counts never come out the same.

The wrong son was found on the third day, sitting under guard in a barn a day's walk east with eleven other taken men, none of whom had thought to say,

until a rider from Caol mhòr caught them up, that the paper's name and his own were two different shapes that had only looked alike to a guessing clerk. He was sent home, and the right son was fetched in his place, and the officer who had made the error entered it in his own tally as a delay of one day, with no further word, so that the roll of Caol mhòr and the roll of the Administration disagree to this hour on how many men that town gave up, by exactly one.

It was the first tally taken under the new law, and Caol mhòr's grief was loud and short, as a first grief is. Grief travels a country too. By the time the officers' wagon had gone from three villages to thirty, the households of the hills had stopped weeping where the officers could hear it, and had begun instead the older, quieter work of hiding what could be hidden and choosing, among those who could not be hidden, who should go. Some sent their eldest, on the thought that the eldest was hardest to spare and so ought to bear the hardest thing; others sent their youngest, on the thought that a young back mended faster than an old one; and there was no counsel from any custodian's roll, and none from the Council at Cathair dhearg either, on which of the two thoughts was the kinder.

II

Of the Two Tallies

The Levy's writ ran over the whole west and north, but it did not run evenly, no more than rain runs evenly over uneven ground. It fell heaviest about Baile chrom and the province the humans called their northern concession, the upland grazing of the north-west that the council had granted for the humans' flocks two generations before, and that the Administration had since leased whole to its own farmers. The concession's fields were sown that spring as they had always been sown, by the same hands; only the hands that worked them now were fewer, for every Dia-thìreach household within the concession's bounds paid the Levy in full, while the human farmers who held the leases paid nothing at all. The officers' own list, when the custodian of Baile chrom's roll got sight of it, gave the reason in one line: that the concession's leaseholders were tenants of the Administration and its charter, and the Levy touched the Administration's

1. the Levy of one in five for the pits; lit. 'the raising'

own subjects only by the Administration's own leave, and that leave had not been given.

At Baile iséal the tally took forty-one, the largest of any single town that year, out of a town of some seventy hearths. Nineteen came home again when their two years were done. The custodian's roll names the other twenty-two, town by town among the camps they were carried to, and against four of the names writes nothing at all, neither camp nor date nor word, only the name and a line drawn under it, which the copyists have kept exactly as it stood, understanding it no better than the roll's own keeper had.

Muileann naomh tried what no other town on the list is known to have tried, and its trying is remembered for the manner of its failing. Its custodians met the Levy's officers before the reading and offered silver, a purse weighed out on the town scale in front of witnesses, that the tally might be cut by half. The senior officer, a heavy, patient man who had done this work in a dozen towns before Muileann naomh and would do it in a dozen more after, took up the purse himself and weighed it a second time on his own small scale, as though a custodian's weights might not be trusted, and only then said that the town's offer was noted and would be honoured in full. The custodians took this to mean the tally would be halved, and stood by while the whole list, uncut, was read to the end. When the eldest of them asked, before the townsfolk, what had become of the silver, the officer said that it had been honoured as an offering toward the Company's granary, and that the Levy answered to no offering a town cared to make, and rode on. The complaint that Muileann naomh sent after them to the Residency at Ros dhomhain was received, logged, and filed, and no answer to it has ever been found, though the custodians kept a fair copy against the day one might come.

The tale of it went ahead of the officers into every town they had not yet reached, and did the Administration more harm, in the way such tales do, than the silver was worth to lose; for after Muileann naomh no other town on the list is recorded to have offered a bribe, custodians having learned in one hearing what Caol mhòr had learned in one reading, that there was no bargain to be struck with a list, only a length of road between the reading of it and the leaving.

Dùghall Clachair heard all of this the way a man hears weather from over the next hill, as talk carried by carters and by the officers themselves, who liked well enough to tell what they had done in one town when they rode into the next. He was three-and-thirty that spring, a mason of Cnoc thais, master of a crew of six who had cut and set stone together since he was a boy carrying their water. He

heard the talk and thought, as every man in every village thought that spring, that his own door would not be spared for long, and went on cutting stone, because there was nothing else a mason could do about a law.

III

Of the Shut Halls and the Trees of Flidais

In the same season, and by the same Commissioner's hand though under a different seal, the Deer hall of the druid school at Dùn thais was shut. Its offence, as the order that closed it gave it, was a lecture the masters had let stand unanswered: whether the humans' plain blindness to the colours of the coal, the blindness Gormshuil nic Fhearchair had first met across a table two generations before, was a kind of sickness in its own right, and if so, whose. Tolley's clerk who drew up the order did not trouble to say which answer had offended him. He shut the hall on the strength of the question alone.

The masters of Dùn thais did not disperse. They went on teaching in their own houses, in rooms that grew smaller each year as more households thought it wiser not to send their sons, until at Doire chiar, on the eve of Bealltainn, they held the last open disputation the schools held in the old way, in the open air on the village threshing-floor, before whoever cared to stand and listen. Folk came from three parishes to hear it, more than the floor could well hold, and stood in a ring beyond the stones with children on their shoulders. Its matter was whether a question might rightly be forbidden at all, and it was argued the whole of one long evening by two masters who had taught together thirty years and did not agree at the end of it any better than they had at the start, which the old men in the crowd took as proof that the matter had been well chosen. The Administration's clerk who was sent to note it down sat apart on a cart-shaft with his own lamp, and wrote in his own report, without seeming to feel the weight of writing it, that it might.

After that the masters who would still teach took their pupils under the trees, to the sacred forest of Flidais near Muileann chiar, where the white stag was said to walk and where the Administration had no hall to shut, having never troubled to learn that a grove could serve the office of one. There was no threshing-floor there and no cart-shaft for a clerk to sit on; the pupils sat on roots and stones in a rough half-ring, and the master who spoke walked as he spoke, so that on a wet

day the lesson moved from tree to tree with the shelter. It is told that the first lesson given under those trees was the very question that had closed the Deer hall, taken up again from where the order had left it standing, and that the master who put it that day answered it herself before any pupil could, saying that a question forbidden by one hand could always be asked again under a roof that hand had not thought to look for.

Dùghall's own younger brother had gone to Dùn thais as a boy to learn his letters from the masters there, in years before the hall was shut, and it was from him, home for a season between one crew's work and the next, that Dùghall first heard the tale of the threshing-floor at Doire chiar. His brother told it standing in the doorway with the light behind him, the way a man tells something he has decided not to be afraid of, and Dùghall, who set stone for a living and had never in his life stood up in a hall to ask a forbidden question, thought his brother the braver of the two of them, and said so, and his brother laughed and said a mason's hands asked questions too, only slower.

IV

Of the Masons of Cnoc thais

The officers came to Cnoc thais in the high summer of the ninetieth year, with the same wagon and the same list, and Dùghall's name was on it, and the names of his whole crew besides: Ailean, the two brothers Cailean and Seumas, old Pàdraig who had taught Dùghall to read a stone's grain, and the two youngest, Anna and her cousin Murchadh, who had been apprenticed to the crew not two years before and had not yet cut a stone worth the name of a mason's work. Dùghall stood in his own doorway and heard his name read from a paper by a man who could not have said it back to him if his life had hung on it, and understood for the first time what the custodian of Caol mhòr's old roll had meant, that a people may be counted twice.

He thought, as the officer moved on down the list, that they were bound for the pits like every other village's chosen, and had already begun in his head the reckoning a mason makes of any road, how many days, what weather, what he would need to carry. It was two days into the march east, on a stretch of the coast road above Baile iséal, that the guard captain rode down the line and called for any among them who knew stone-work, and Dùghall and his whole crew put up their

hands together, for there was no sense in six masons pretending otherwise to one another's faces. They were turned out of the line then and there and marched north instead of east, along the headland road toward Baile chrom, and it was three days more before any officer troubled to tell them why: that the fifth and last of the coast beacons was to be raised on the headland above the town, the ring of towers that had stood four strong since builders older than any roll now kept, and that masons were wanted for it more than diggers were wanted underground.

It did not feel, to Dùghall, like a mercy, and he came in time to think it was not meant as one. The fields of Cnoc thais that his crew would have worked between commissions, the small plots that kept a mason's household fed in a lean season, stood untilled that whole year for want of the very hands the Levy had taken to build a light that would serve no plough and no byre of theirs. He set that thought aside most days, because a man cannot cut good stone while nursing a grievance, and took it up again most nights, because a man cannot help what comes to him lying still in the dark.

"You should be glad of it," the guard captain told him, on the second evening of the march, meaning glad to be spared the pits, and waited as though a man ought to thank him for the saying. Dùghall said nothing, because there was no way to tell a guard-captain that a mason parted from his stone-yard felt the parting no less than a hewer parted from his own hill, only that the shape of the loss was different, a field going to weed instead of a family going hungry for want of a wage; and a captain with a wagon to keep moving had no patience for a difference of shape. He touched his cap instead, which cost him nothing, and the captain rode on satisfied, and Dùghall walked the rest of that evening beside old Pàdraig, who had heard the whole exchange and said only that a man who explains himself to a guard has already lost the argument he meant to win.

They were housed, the six of them, in a hut of turf and driftwood on the headland above Baile chrom, alongside crews taken the same way from four other villages, so that within a month the camp held above sixty masons and their apprentices, none of whom had chosen one another's company and all of whom now shared one fire, one well, and one quarry. The work went by the light there was, longer in summer than any of them had worked before, shorter in winter than any of them had hoped, and the officers who oversaw it kept a tally of stone cut that mattered to them more than any tally of men fed. Anna, who was seventeen that first winter and had never before slept a night away from her mother's hearth, wept the first three nights in the hut where she thought no one heard her,

and was heard by all of them, and on the fourth night old Pàdraig without a word got up from his own straw and mended the gap in the turf wall nearest her sleeping-place, through which the wind had been finding her all along, and after that she did not weep where they could hear it again, though Dùghall never once believed she had stopped.

The tower rose through that autumn and the winter after, coarse grey stone from a quarry the officers had opened on the headland, so that the masons need not even be spared the labour of hauling it far. Dùghall set the courses and taught Anna and Murchadh to read the lie of a block before they touched a chisel to it, the way old Pàdraig had taught him; and Pàdraig, whose hands had grown too slow for the finer cutting, sat most days on an upturned barrow and told the younger ones what he could no longer show them, and the crew came in time to work as well by his voice as by his eyes. Cailean broke a finger that winter and would not leave off working for it, and Seumas, his brother, quarrelled with him about it every evening and dressed the finger every morning, and the two of them were never once heard to agree, on that or on anything else, in all the time Dùghall knew them.

The worst of that winter was a gale out of the north-west that took two days to blow itself out and stripped the scaffold from the tower's third course as easily as a man strips bark from a green branch. When it had passed, Dùghall climbed what stood of the walls alone, before he would let any of the others up after him, to judge whether the stone had shifted; and standing in the wind that still gusted hard enough to lean a man sideways, with the sea below him white to the horizon and no ship anywhere on it, he understood for the first time in his own body why a light was wanted on that headland at all, and forgave the tower, a little, for the fields it had cost him. He did not forgive the Levy. A tower, he thought, climbing down again with his hands raw from the cold stone, owed nothing to the law that had raised it, any more than a child owed anything to the manner of its getting.

By the second summer the walls stood to their full height and the crew began the finer work at the top: the stair turning always to the right, hand over hand up the cold stone, and the lamp-room, no bigger than a byre, lit on every side by narrow windows against the weather. It was slower work than the coursing below, and Murchadh, who had grown in a year from a frightened boy to a mason who could be trusted with a door-jamb, cut the last of the window-sills himself, under Dùghall's eye and without a single stroke wasted, and Dùghall told him so in

front of the others, which was the only wage of that kind either of them ever got for the Levy's taking.

They built the tower to a height a man could not see the top of from its own foot without stepping well back, round and tapering. It was Dùghall who cut the lintel of that room, the stone that would stand over whoever kept the light for as long as the tower stood, and it was Dùghall, on the last evening before the tower was done, who took a chisel he had no order to take and cut into the underside of that lintel, where only a man climbing the last step and looking up would ever see it, the names of his crew: Ailean, Cailean, Seumas, Pàdraig, Anna, Murchadh, and his own beneath them, each letter as clean as any he had ever cut for a custodian's hall or a dead man's stone. It is the only writing on any of the five towers of the ring, and no order asked for it and no order struck it out.

V

Of the Ring Made Whole

The ring of coast beacons was finished in the summer of the ninety-first year of the strangers: Taigh-solais Baile chrom¹ last of the five, standing to Baile ìseal, Muileann bheag, Àth dhearg and Tobar dhearg as a hand's fifth finger stands to the rest, so that a ship might now run the whole coast of Dia-thìr by night and never lose a light from sight before the next one rose to take its place. The Company's clerks at Ros dhomhain called it the completion of the coast trade and entered the date in three ledgers. The keepers' own daybooks, kept in a plainer hand, called it the end of the dark crossing, and the two names meant the one thing.

What it meant for Cuan ruadh, on the eastern shore, was the end of a trade the town had kept since before any beacon stood at all: the old coasting boats that had carried goods by day from harbour to harbour, hugging a shore too dangerous to run by night, put up their sails for the last time within a few years of the ring's completion, for the Company's steamers no longer needed to put in anywhere along that coast, and ran the whole circuit of the island without touching Cuan ruadh's quay from one season's end to the next. A master of one of those boats, a woman named for the same red headland as the town, sold her hull for

1. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

firewood the winter the last cargo failed to come, and is remembered to have said, to whichever custodian's clerk thought the sale worth entering, that a light built to keep ships from wrecking on a coast had wrecked her trade instead, and no less surely for doing it slowly. The town's custodian entered the last coasting sailing in her own roll with no comment beyond the date, which the copyists have judged, from the small unevenness of the ink, was written with a hand that trembled.

The Levy held Dùghall's crew at Baile chrom until the tower was lit, and they would have stayed for it in any case; a mason likes to see a thing finished that he has raised with his own hands. The keeper appointed to it was a young man of the headland villages named Uisdean mac Lachlainn, thirty years old that autumn, chosen for the post, the Administration's letter said, on the recommendation of the very masons who had built the light he was to keep; which recommendation, though the letter does not say so, Dùghall had himself written out and signed, along with Ailean and old Pàdraig, in a hand none of the three would have called fine.

On an evening of an t-Sultain, with the last of the year's warmth still in the air and the sea below the headland gone the colour of hammered lead, Uisdean climbed the turning stair to the lamp-room for the first time as its keeper, with Dùghall and what remained of his crew behind him, for they had asked to be there and no one had thought to refuse them. Ailean carried the coal up in a leather sack himself, saying that a light built by six masons' hands ought to be lit with coal carried by at least one of the same six, and Anna, who had grown a head taller in the year since she first slept in the turf hut, went up last of all and touched the newel of the stair as she passed it, the way she had seen old Pàdraig touch a finished stone before he would call it done.

At the top of the stair Uisdean stopped under the lintel, as every keeper after him would stop there without knowing why the stone at that particular step seemed to want a man's eye lifted to it, and asked Dùghall, since he stood nearest, whether the mason who had cut it thought it plumb. Dùghall said that he did, and did not say that he was the mason, and Uisdean, who had signed his own name to the tower's finishing without ever learning that the recommendation for his post had come from these six hands, struck the light.

It caught on the second strike, a coal flame steady behind glass, and threw its first beam out over water that had never in the island's whole memory carried a light so far. Below on the darkening sea, and for a distance beyond guessing, the beam found nothing to answer it that night; but the keepers' daybooks would

show, within a very few years, the Company's sailings past that headland doubled, and doubled again, ships running by the new light at hours no master would once have risked the coast at all.

Dùghall stood at the foot of the lamp-room, under the lintel he had cut, and looked up at the names no order had asked for and no order had struck out, and thought that a tower raised by taken hands might yet be made to answer, in its small way, to the hands that raised it, though the light, once lit, answered only to the ships it was built to serve, and asked no man's leave to shine for them and not for him.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

OF GORTA BAILE CHROM

AE 94 – 97

I

Of the Empty Road

Uisdean mac Lachlainn kept the first daybook of Taigh-solais Baile chrom¹, and its first pages are given over to nothing but weather and wicks: so many hours burning, so much oil drawn, the wind from such a quarter. He had asked for the keeping himself, the year the ring was finished, on the notion that a keeper who wrote nothing down could never answer for what he had seen. He did not, that first winter, know what he would be asked to answer for.

In am Màrt of the ninety-fourth year he began to write other things.

The tower stood on the headland above Baile chrom, a climb of a hundred and nine steps he had counted more than once in the dark, and its gallery looked two ways: out over the water where the light he tended went round all night for ships that were not his, and inland over the fields that fed the town. That spring

1. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

he stood his morning watch at the rail and saw a farmer he knew, a man called Alasdair Ruadh, walk the length of his own ploughland with a hand-harrow and no one behind him. The year before there had been six at that work, sons and cousins and a hired man from the shore. Uisdean wrote in the daybook: *Alasdair Ruadh ploughs alone. No hands for the seed but his.* It was not a thing a keeper of lights was asked to note. He noted it anyway.

The hands had gone to the pits under An Togail², which had come down from Ros dhomhain six years before and was read out at the market cross in the humans' tongue and then again, badly, in Dia-thìris by a clerk who stumbled over the numbers: one in five of every village's grown men and women, for two years, to work under the Company, paid in marks at the new rate. It had fallen on the coast and the hill villages round Baile chrom harder than anywhere else, for the concession farms to the north, worked by the strangers' own people, sent no one. Uisdean had watched the first draft go down the coast road with its bundles on its backs, twenty-three from a town of a few hundred, and had thought, climbing the tower that night, that it was a hard thing but a passing one, the kind of hardship a people bears and is done with.

He had not thought, that first year, to ask who would plough.

By the spring of the ninety-third year the fields round Baile chrom stood half sown, and the ones that were sown were thin, for there were not enough hands to weed them either, and by midsummer the grain that stood was short in the ear and beaten flat in two storms that in another year would have cost a farmer a week's worry and no more. The harvest came in light. Uisdean watched the carts go up to the granary and counted them against the carts of the year before, which he had also, without meaning to, kept a tally of, and the count came out at less than half.

The winter after was hard. The one after that was worse, for it came on a country that had eaten its own reserve to get through the first.

He wrote, on a night in am Faoilleach of the ninety-fifth year, with the wind driving spray to the top of the tower and the lamp burning steady behind its glass: *Nothing crosses the road below tonight. Not a cart, not a dog. The town is shut against the weather, or shut against something else.* He read the line back before he blew out the small lamp at the desk, and thought it was not a keeper's business to write such things, and left it standing.

2. the Levy of one in five for the pits; lit. 'the raising'

II

Of the Bounds of the Hunger

The custodians who kept the count called it, before the year was out, Gorta Baile chrom¹, and gave it bounds: thirty-four settlements from the coast to the hill road east of the concession, worst at the centre and thinning at the edges, as a fire thins at the edge of what it burns.

At Doire ghlais, north along the coast, the hunger took the old first and then the very young, as hunger does when there is grain enough for one meal in three and a household must choose who eats it. The custodian of Doire ghlais, a woman whose name the roll gives and this telling need not repeat, walked from door to door in the last weeks of that winter and wrote down who still stood and who did not, and in the spring she sent the town's young people south to the camps for the ration the Company gave its crews, which was more certain than anything the fields could promise that year.

A woman of the town called Mòr nic Aonghais, whose son was fourteen and had never worked a day underground, walked with him as far as the hill road and no further, because the custom of the coast held that a mother did not follow her child past the boundary stone. She had baked him what bread the house could spare that morning and wrapped it in a cloth that had been her own mother's, and told him to mind the overseers and to write, though there was no one at Doire ghlais any longer who could read a letter to her but the custodian, and the custodian had her own dead to see to. Mòr stood at the boundary stone a long time after her son had gone out of sight round the bend of the road, and then she walked home to a house with one mouth fewer in it and no more grain in the store than it had had that morning. By the year's end Doire ghlais held half its former number, though half of those who were gone had only gone south and would come back, in their own time, to fields that would need them more than ever.

At Inis mhin on the north coast the second winter of the hunger found the town with seed corn in its store and nothing else, and the choice a coastal town makes in that pass is older than any custodian's roll: they ate the seed, and trusted to the fish and to what charity came, and did not plant that spring at all. The Mission's kitchen at the harbour, which had stood empty three parts of the year since

1. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

it was built, fed some scores a day the whole of that season, fish broth and biscuit brought round by sea from Cathair gheal, and the harbour-master's wife, who kept the tally at the kitchen door, told Uisdean once, years after, that she had never in her life counted so high a number so many days running and never wanted to again.

At Seann Bhrenn, east of the hunger's worst ground but inside its bounds all the same, the custodians did a thing that had not been done in living memory: they opened the grain-pits of An Aois Naomh², sunk in the chalk hill above the town so long ago that no one now living had seen them opened, kept against a need no one now living had thought would come. The lids were levered up with bars, and the whole town stood round the mouths of the pits in the rain while the custodians went down on ropes with lamps, and came up again with nothing but the dust of grain long generations gone, and a smell that the older people said was the smell of the deep earth, and no comfort in it at all. An old man of the town, who had come to watch with the rest, said afterward that he had always been told the pits held enough to see Seann Bhrenn through any winter the sky could send, and that it had never once crossed his mind, in seventy years of hearing it told, to ask through how many winters that telling had already worn thin.

Uisdean heard these things as a keeper of lights hears most things, from the boats that put in below his tower and the carters who climbed to see the lamp lit and to ask, always, whether the weather would hold. He wrote what he was told into the daybook beside the weather and the oil, because he had begun, without deciding to, to think that a record which held only the light and not what the light shone over was no record worth the keeping.

III

Of the Ship at Ros dhomhain

Word came to the island, in the second winter of the hunger, that a ship of grain was crossing from an Tír Thall¹, sent by the Church's own people who had heard, from the letters of their Mission, what was happening on the coal coast. It reached Ros dhomhain at the dark of the year and lay

2. the Holy Age

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

at anchor in the roads a full month with its holds unopened, for the Residency held that unloading and carriage were the Company's charge, being the party whose Levy had emptied the fields, and the Company held that famine relief was the Administration's office and none of its own, being no party to the failure of a harvest it had not sown or reaped.

Anne Colby was in Ros dhomhain that spring, come back to the island after some years over the sea, and she went down to the harbour more than once to look at the ship riding at her cable with the gulls working the water round her and her crew idle at the rail. She had nursed the flux on those same quays years before and thought she had seen the worst that argument over a ledger could do to people who had none of the say in it, and found she had not. The ship's master, a quiet man who had made the crossing twice before with cargo the Administration wanted badly enough to have it off his decks within a day, told her once, leaning on the rail with nothing better to do, that he had never in thirty years at sea been kept waiting so long for a cargo nobody seemed to want unloaded at all.

She wrote to the Residency herself, once, a short letter asking only who should be told to unload the ship, and had no answer for eleven days, and when the answer came it named no one and settled nothing, and only said that the matter was under consideration between the two offices, and that Commissioner Tolley had noted her concern. She kept the letter folded small in the same case she carried her lancets in, as though it were a kind of instrument too, and showed it to no one else at all.

On the last day of that month she went down to the harbour again and found the grain still standing in the holds and the town's own children, thin already though the true want had barely begun, playing at soldiers on the quay below the idle ship. It was then, she said afterward, that she stopped writing letters and began instead to walk from office to office in person, since a woman standing in a doorway, she found, could not be answered with a note passed to a clerk.

The ship was unloaded at last, in the first days of the new year, when a clerk at the Residency and a clerk of the Company between them, and neither by any order from above, simply set men to the holds one morning without waiting for either office to finish arguing, and the grain went out by cart in the following weeks to the kitchens the Mission had by then opened at Cathair gheal and at Baile chrom. Anne Colby went north to Baile chrom herself to run the one there, since she knew the coast and the coast, by then, knew her a little.

IV

Of the Kitchen Below the Tower

The kitchen at Baile chrom stood in what had been a net-shed by the harbour, its floor still smelling of tar under the smell of the pot, and Anne Colby kept it through the rest of that winter and into the summer with whatever the relief ship's grain and the Mission's own store could supply, stretched with fish when the boats could get out and with nothing at all on the days they could not.

Uisdean came down from the tower most evenings that he was not on watch. The light did not need him at the kitchen door; he came because he found he could not climb his own stair afterward without having seen, once in the day, what the town below him looked like close to. He carried water for her sometimes, and split wood, and once carried a child too weak to walk the length of the quay on his own back, a boy of six or seven whose name he never learned and whose face he did not forget.

The kitchen kept no fixed hour, for the boats' luck and the cart's arrival from Cathair gheal governed it more than any bell could, and there were mornings the queue at the net-shed door stretched past the fish-curers' sheds and mornings it was three old women and no more, the young and the middling having gone, by then, south with the rest. Anne Colby ladled with her own hand at the start and end of every serving, and left the middle of it to whoever she could find to trust with the pot, saying that a person who has served the first bowl and the last knows the whole of a day's want, and everything between is only arithmetic. Uisdean thought, watching her, that she had the custodians' own habit of keeping a roll, though hers was written in faces rather than in ink, and that she seemed to hold every one of them in her memory at once, the way he held the wind and the oil.

Anne Colby knew the crews of the coast by the custodians' names before she knew them by their faces, having learned long before, in another town in another sickness, that a name written correctly in a ledger was sometimes the only thing a dying stranger was given that was truly theirs. She kept a private book of her own at the kitchen, apart from the Mission's, with every name she fed written once, and crossed through, gently, in the corner of the page, whenever one of them did not come again.

Uisdean asked her once, standing at the kitchen door with the light already lit behind them on the headland, whether she thought the Company knew what its Levy had done to the ploughing.

"They know," she said. "They have the figures. I have seen the figures."

"Then why does nothing change?"

She looked past him, up at the tower, where the beam was already sweeping its slow circle over the black water. "Because the figures they keep," she said, "are the figures for the ships, and the ships are not short of anything."

He had no answer to that, and did not try to find one.

V

Of the Light He Did Not Put Out

There came a night in that second winter, the coldest of the two, when Uisdean climbed the hundred and nine steps with the wind trying to take the door out of his hand at every landing, and stood a long while at the lamp with his hand on the valve that fed it, and thought, not for the first time and not lightly, of turning it down and letting it go dark.

It was not a thing done from spite, or not only from spite. He had watched, that whole two years, coal go out past his light by the shipload, to hearths and forges over the sea that had never gone hungry a day in their history, while the fields that grew the food for the men who cut that coal lay half worked for want of the hands the coal trade had taken from them. It seemed to him, some nights, a plain enough account: that his light served the taking, and nothing of what it served came back. If the lamp went dark an hour, a night, a week, some ship somewhere would run onto the reef his own grandfather's generation had asked the beacon built against, and the Company's trade would falter, and perhaps, in some way he could not trace from the top of a tower in the dark, the fields would be given back their hands the sooner for it.

He stood with his hand on the valve a long time. The wind came in under the door and made the lamp gutter, then steady, the way it had steadied every night since the ring was finished, keeping its rhythm the way the tide keeps its own regardless of who is drowning or who is fed.

He thought of the nine drowned on the western reef, buried long before his time, whom the beacon had first been asked for. He thought of Alasdair Ruadh

walking his empty field with the hand-harrow. Torcall Clachair had built the first of the ring and never lived to see it whole, walking the headlands once with a human navigator, in the years before either of them had reason to think the light they were planning would ever serve anyone's harm. A light built for the drowned did not choose afterward whose ships it saved, any more than a well chose whose bucket drew from it, and a keeper who let it go dark to punish one use of it would be punishing every other use along with it, the fishing boats and the coasting trade and whatever, on some night he could not foresee, might come up that coast needing it for a reason he would never be told. A ship wrecked on the rocks below would drown men who had no more say in the Levy than Alasdair Ruadh had, deckhands and boys signed on for their bread; the coal in her hold would go down with her unburned and change nothing at all in the fields above Baile chrom. The light he kept was near the wrong, he decided at last, standing there with the wind working at the door. It was not the cause of it, the way a man standing near a fire is not the fire.

He took his hand off the valve, and wrote in the daybook, in a hand steadier than his thoughts had been: *Wind north-west, fresh. Lamp trimmed at the second hour. Burning well.* Then, under it, because he had begun to think a record that held only the light was no record at all: *Thought tonight of letting it go dark, and did not. I do not know that I was right. I know only that I could not answer, after, for the ones it would have drowned.*

VI

Of the Order That Came Too Late

An Togail was set aside in the famine districts early in the ninety-seventh year, three years after the harvest that had shown what it cost, and the order was read at the market cross of Baile chrom on a morning in an Gearran with the same clerk who had read it out first standing in the same place to read that it was ended.

There was no crowd of the size that had gathered for its beginning. Those who came stood in a thin late-winter sun, and heard that the villages of the famine country need send no more of their hands to the pits, and some of them nodded, and some of them looked at the empty houses along the street, shut up since their people had gone south and not all of them come back, and said nothing at all.

Uisdean stood at the back of the small crowd that morning, having come down from the tower to hear it read, and thought that a law lifted three years after the harvest it had ruined was a strange kind of mercy, offered to fields that had already, by their own hard way, worked out how to feed themselves without the hands the Levy had never meant to give back. He wrote the day into the daybook when he climbed the stair that evening, between the wind and the oil, in the same plain hand he kept for everything: *The Levy read ended at Baile chrom this day. Two harvests too late for those it took the hardest. The custodians say it was never repealed, only set by, and that no one here expects to hear it named again. The coast has learned by now what such a word is worth.*

Cnoc mhòr, in the north, past the worst edge of the famine's bounds, had not waited for any order to reach it either way. Its people had watched two winters take what the fields could not replace, and in the summer of the ninety-seventh year, though the Levy was by then set aside, the whole of the village walked south together, the old carried and the young walking, to take the Company's ration and the Company's work rather than starve waiting for a harvest that might fail a third time. A carter who passed through some weeks after told the kitchen at Baile chrom that he had walked the length of the street at Cnoc mhòr and found every door shut but none of them barred, in the way of a people who mean to come back, and a cat sitting on a doorstep that had watched him the whole way through without moving, as though it alone had been left to keep the place. The grass came up in the street the first summer, and by every account that reached the tower at Baile chrom, no household came back to it.

Uisdean climbed to the gallery on an evening at the end of that summer, as he had climbed it near every evening for six years, and lit the lamp, and stood at the rail while the beam went out over water that had drowned no one that season, over a coast where the fields, thin as they were, stood green again. Below him, past the last houses, the road that had carried away Cnoc mhòr's people and Doire ghlas's and so many others lay empty in the last light, the way it had lain empty the whole two years of the hunger, and would, he thought, lie empty a good while yet before it carried anyone home.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

Of the Petition on the Bench

AE 98 – 99

I

Of the Word from Ros dhomhain

Peigi Ghlas was forty-eight years old and had kept the shrine of Cill ghlais for eleven of them when the word came down from Ros dhomhain that An t-Àrd-mhaor¹ Tolley was going home.

It came the way most word came to Cill ghlais: by a carter who had it from a carter, three days old and worn smooth by the telling, so that by the time it reached her at the shrine door she could not have said which parts were the letter and which were what men had made of the letter on the road. Tolley was old, the carter said, and rich, and going home with honours, whatever honours were, to the country across the mist that none of them had seen and none of them missed. A new man was coming to sit in his chair at Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir², and this one, the carter went on, straightening up over his empty cart with the pleased look of a man delivering good news, had let it be known that he meant to ask the custodians' council what it thought before he set anything down.

Peigi heard it out, and thanked him, and gave him water for his horse, and went back into the shrine and trimmed the lamp, because it wanted trimming, and because her hands wanted occupying while the rest of her turned the news over.

She had been eleven years at Cill ghlais by then, since her mother died of the wasting cough, and in all that time she had watched three things come down from the Residency wearing the shape of good news, and none of the three had

1. the Commissioner; lit. 'the high steward'

2. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

kept it past the first winter. She kept this from the carter, and told the flame instead, that night, the only thing at Cill ghlas old enough to have heard it all before her and unlikely to repeat it.

Cill ghlas was a small place even by the reckoning of that country, a scatter of stone houses and byres along a burn under the shoulder of the hill, with a shrine no bigger than a good barn set into the slope above the last house, at the mouth of the oldest cutting in those hills, where a flame that the roll called Brìde's had been kept since before anyone now living could say by whom. It stood an hour's climb above Baile thais, where the Company's galleries went deepest and the walls had lately gone up round the pithead, and it had given men to those galleries the way every village of that country gave men, in ones and twos, and had them come back, when they came back, grey in the face before their time. Peigi had buried four of her own kin out of the pits in eleven years, and had blessed the coal a household kept back from the vein for the shrine, and had gone up the road herself in her season to lay the custodian's handful at the door and burn it, small, the way it had always been burned. She was custodian in a line that was never written down; nobody had appointed her; the flame had simply been hers to keep since her mother's death, as it had been her mother's before her, and the village had never thought to ask whether there was another way of coming to it.

She had also, since the famine years, kept something else: a slate by the shrine door on which she scratched, in the stag-letters her mother had taught her from an old primer bound in sheepskin, every household of Cill ghlas that had lost someone to the Levy, the fever, or the two winters when the granary at Muileann chrom had been full and the village had not. The slate was short. Its weight had nothing to do with its length.

The letter that named the new order of things came a month later, in the last week of an Dàmhair, carried by a rider sent specially, a young man of Ceann àrsaidh with a good horse and a look of a man pleased with his errand. He asked for the custodian by name, which told Peigi before she had broken the seal that whatever was inside had been thought about by more than one person.

It was from Aonghas Ruadh, custodian of Ceann àrsaidh, and it said, in the plain hand of a man more used to counting than writing, that Robert Haskins, the new An t-Àrd-mhaor, had sent word round every district that the council of custodians would be asked its mind on the tithe before anything was fixed, as a mark, the letter he had sent said, of the new order's good will; and that within the month, before any custodian outside Ros dhomhain had so much as replied to

the asking, the tithe had gone up on the boards at every Company store from Baile thais to the coast, fixed, at the new rate, with the seal of Riaghaltas nan Coigreach³ at the foot of the notice and no mark anywhere on it of any custodian's mind.

Nowhere did Aonghas Ruadh write that this had surprised him. He wrote instead that it should not, in his judgement, be let pass unanswered a second time the way the granary order had been let pass, and the Levy after it; and that he had it in mind, if enough of the custodians of the east and the hills gathered with him at Ceann àrsaidh, to draw up one paper in one hand that could not be filed apart, settlement by settlement, the way single letters always were. He named a day in am Faoilleach, and asked Peigi to come. Cill ghlas was small, he wrote plainly enough, but its roll of who had been lost was better kept than most, and that was worth more to him than size.

Peigi read the letter twice by the lamp, and then went out and stood a while at the shrine door in the last light, looking down the burn toward the road that went, eventually, everywhere.

II

Of the Store at Seann Dunn

She was not the first to arrive at Ceann àrsaidh when the day came, nor the last. She had walked it in two days, sleeping the one night at a cousin's house at Muileann dhearg and coming down into the walled town on the second afternoon with her feet sore and her good cloak, the one she kept for burials and for this, rolled tight against the rain in a bag on her back.

Ceann àrsaidh stood behind its old wall on a rise above the eastern road, a town of some size for that country, with a market square inside the gate where the custodians of the nineteen settlements that answered Aonghas Ruadh's letter had begun, by the second day, to make a kind of camp: fires in the lee of the wall, horses picketed along the inside of it, and everywhere the low talk of people comparing what had been done to them, as if putting it side by side might show the shape of it better than any one of them could alone.

3. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

It was there, on the second night, over a fire shared with three others, that Peigi heard properly of Seann Dunn.

The custodian who told it was a spare, quiet man named Coinneach Òg, from a fishing town on the far eastern coast that Peigi had never seen and would likely never see again, three days' ride past Ceann àrsaidh by his own account and further than that on foot. He did not tell it as a grievance. He told it the way a man tells a thing he has watched happen slowly enough to have stopped believing it could be stopped.

Haskins, in his first year, had opened a customs house at Seann Dunn, on the coast below Coinneach Òg's own town, and a Company store beside it, the first store the district had had. It came in, Coinneach Òg said, as help. The east had no smith to speak of and no source of iron nearer than a week's cart-journey, and the store sold seed against a bad year and tools against a broken one, on the Company's note, to be paid back in fish or wool or coin when the year turned. Most years the debts had been paid. But there had been a bad year, and then, close behind it, the hunger years and the two winters of the Levy's taking, and by now, Coinneach Òg said, turning a stick in the fire without looking up from it, the store's ledgers held the debts of near half the district, entered against named households, generation to come reckoned in against the last.

"They will tell you it is owed fairly," he said. "It is owed. I will not say it was not lent." He looked round the fire at the others. "But there is no year now in which the debt grows less. Only years in which it grows more slowly."

Nobody at the fire had an answer to that, and nobody tried to give one. Peigi thought of her own slate at the shrine door, the names scratched into it, and thought that Coinneach Òg's district must have a slate a great deal longer, and said so; and he said that it did, and that it was not his to keep, since the old shrine of Seann Dunn had gone to ruin long ago and the store stood where its keepers' house had been.

It was past midnight before the fire burned down and the talk with it, and Peigi lay that night under her cloak with the wall's stones cold at her back and did not sleep well, turning over the shapes of it: the granary, the store at Seann Dunn, the Levy that had taken hands from every field in the west and left the harvest to rot standing two winters running at Baile chrom, and now the tithe fixed before the asking about it had so much as reached half the men it was fixed on. She had thought, walking down from Cill ghlas, that she was coming to speak for eleven

households and a dead mother's flame. She began, that night at the fire, to understand what Aonghas Ruadh had meant by one hand.

III

Of the Nineteen at Ceann àrsaidh

They drew it up over three days in the hall behind the market square, a low stone building the town used for its own councils, with a fire at one end and windows too small to let in much of the grey light of that am Faoilleach, so that most of the work was done by lamp, at noon as much as at night.

There were, in the end, custodians of nineteen settlements, from Ceann àrsaidh itself out to the coast where Coinneach Òg's town lay and up into the hills as far as Àth fhionn in the south-east; and it was, so far as any of them could say, and several of the older ones tried to say it, the first time custodians of that many places had sat down together in one room to speak with one voice at all, rather than each writing alone to the Residency and each being answered alone, or not answered, which had been the way of it since the first years of the treaty.

It did not go smoothly. Peigi had thought, walking down, that the grievance would come plain once enough people were in a room with it; she found instead that nineteen people who agreed entirely on what had been done to them could argue for the better part of a day over how to say so. One custodian, an old man from a hill village north of Ceann àrsaidh, wanted every death named, every year, every settlement, on the ground that a list could not be argued with the way a sentence could. Aonghas Ruadh, who had called them and who took, without anyone quite deciding it, the chair of the drafting, said that a list a hundred pages long would be filed unread where a single page might, just possibly, be read; and that they should say the true thing once, plainly, and let the naming wait for another day if it came to naming. The old man was not satisfied, and said so, twice, and in the end put his name to the shorter paper anyway, because there was nothing else on offer to put it to.

The paper that came out of the three days was not long. It set down, in a page and a half of the stag-letters copied fair by Aonghas Ruadh's own clerk, that the tithe had been fixed without the asking that had been promised; that the Levy, though set aside in the districts the harvest had failed in, had never been repealed

and could be laid on again at any Commissioner's word; that the granary built of the Dia-thìrich's own coal money had in two winters been the only store between the west and starving, and had been the Company's the whole time; and that the custodians who signed it asked, in the humans' own phrase that Aonghas Ruadh's clerk had found for it in an old letter of the Residency's own, for their council to be consulted before, and not after.

They read it through together on the last evening, each of the nineteen in turn, aloud, in the hall by the lamp, so that no one could say afterward he had not heard every word of what he put his name to. When it came Peigi's turn she read her part with her thumb pressed white against the edge of the sheet, and heard her own voice come out steadier than she had thought it would.

Then they signed it.

It was Ruairidh mac Thormoid, custodian of Àth fhionn, who signed last, and slowest, and it was he, of all the nineteen, that Peigi remembered longest after. A small, bent man, with a hand that shook a little at rest and did not shake at all once the pen was moving, he had walked to Ceann àrsaidh from the south-east, a good many days' road, on his own two feet, refusing every offer of a cart the whole way, as the man who had carried him the last few miles told it round the fire with some wonder. By his own count, and by the count of Àth fhionn's own roll, he was the oldest custodian at the gathering by a great many years: he remembered, or said he remembered, and none there doubted him, a world before the mark was struck at Ros dhomhain, before the strangers' coin had ever passed hand to hand on the island at all, when a fleece was still worth a fleece and nothing needed to be changed into anything else to be worth it.

He read his own line last of all, in a voice gone thin but not unsteady, and then he signed his name in the stag-letters, small and careful, at the foot of the page below all the rest, and beside it, where none of the others had thought to write anything but their names, he added a line of his own, which Aonghas Ruadh's clerk copied into the fair copy exactly as he gave it: *born before the coin*. He offered no more than that. Nobody at the table asked him to.

"They will not read the rest of it," the old man from the hill village said, low, to Peigi, as the paper was being sanded and rolled. "Perhaps they will read that."

IV

Of the Bench in the Passage

It fell to Peigi to carry it.

She was not sure, afterward, quite how it had fallen to her rather than to Aonghas Ruadh, who had called them all together and might rightly have claimed the carrying as his own; she thought, turning it over on the road, that it was the roll at Cill ghlais that had done it, the slate of names by the shrine door that Aonghas Ruadh had heard was well kept, and that having asked her to come for that reason he had gone on, without either of them quite saying it aloud, to think her the right one to finish it. She did not refuse. She had walked further for less.

She went down to Ros dhomhain in the first days of am Màrt, alone but for a lad of Ceann àrsaidh sent along to carry the second copy and bring word back, two days on the eastern road with the petition rolled inside oilcloth against the rain, next to her skin under the good cloak where a purse would have gone had she had one worth guarding.

Ros dhomhain, when she came down into it off the last hill, was larger than any town she had stood in since her one visit to the capital as a girl: the harbour full of masts, the Company's sheds along the quay, and above it all, on its rise, the long grey house of stone, Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir¹, with a flag she did not know the meaning of hanging still in the wet air over its gate.

She found the door easily enough; it was finding what lay past the door that took the better part of two days.

The first day she was turned back at the gate by a man in a coat with buttons who told her, not unkindly, that the office that received such papers did not sit on the day she had come, and that she should come again in the morning. She came again in the morning and was let through the gate and left to wait in a yard, and then in a passage, and then, when the light in the passage windows had gone from grey to greyer, told that the office had closed for the day and that she should come again the morning after.

She came again.

The passage she was shown into the third time was of stone, narrow, lit by lamps set in the wall at long intervals because no window opened onto it at all, and it smelled, she noticed at once and never afterward forgot, of lamp-soot: not the clean burnt smell of a shrine flame, which she knew as well as she knew her own hands, but a heavier, closer smell, oil and smoke folded close in a space with

1. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

no wind to carry it out. There was a bench along one wall, of the same grey stone as the passage, worn pale in the middle where a great many people had sat waiting before her, and she sat on it, with the lad from Ceann àrsaidh standing at her shoulder because there was room on the bench for one, and waited.

She waited the better part of that morning. People passed along the passage on errands of their own, humans mostly, in the black coats of the Residency's clerks, and one or two Dia-thìrich among them, dressed in the same coats, who did not look at her as they went by, or looked and looked away, she could not afterward have said which. Doors opened and closed along the passage. Somewhere beyond one of them a bell rang at intervals, for reasons she never learned.

At last a door opened nearer to hand than the rest, and a young man put his head out and asked, in Dia-thìris good enough to be understood and poor enough that she knew at once it was not his first tongue, whether the custodian with the paper for An t-Àrd-mhaor²'s office would come in.

He was younger than she had expected, no more than five-and-twenty by the look of him, with ink on two fingers of his right hand and a high desk behind him stacked with paper in a way that told her, before he said a word, that hers would not be the only paper on it by the day's end. He asked her name and the name of the settlement, and wrote both down, carefully, in the humans' letters, checking the spelling of Cill ghlas with her twice. He asked whether she had come far. She said that she had, and that eighteen others besides her had put their names to what she carried, from as many settlements, meeting as one body for the first time that the roll of any of their towns recorded.

He said that this was noted, and thanked her for the trouble of the journey, in a tone she thought was meant kindly and might even have been kind.

Then he took the petition from her hands, unrolled it just far enough to see that it was indeed a petition and not some other paper mistakenly brought, rolled it again, and laid it on the pile at the corner of the high desk, a pile she saw, in the moment his hand left it, was neither the top of the stack nor the bottom of it but somewhere unremarkable in the middle, among papers she could not read the headings of and had no way of knowing were older or newer or of more or less weight than her own.

Then he bent his head again to the sheet he had been writing on when she was shown in, and went on with it.

2. the Commissioner; lit. 'the high steward'

Peigi stood where she was a moment longer than there was any reason to stand. She did not know, afterward, what she had been waiting for; not an answer, she told herself on the road home, for she had known before she came down off the last hill above Ros dhomhain that no answer would be given her that day, or that week, whatever came after. Perhaps she had been waiting only to see the young man look up again. He did not.

She thanked him, because it seemed the thing to do, and he returned some answer she did not fully catch, and she turned and went back out along the passage, past the bench worn pale in the middle, and out through the yard, and out through the gate, into the grey light of Ros dhomhain, with the lad from Ceann àrsaigh following a step behind her and neither of them saying anything at all until they were past the bridge.

They went home.

V

Of Bride's Lamp

The answer, when it came, did not come.

Through the rest of that year and into the next word passed among the nineteen settlements, as it always passed, slowly and by carter and by letter three days worn on the road, and none of it was an answer from Ros dhomhain. The tithe stood at the rate it had been fixed at before the asking. The Levy stayed unrepealed on its shelf, ready, the custodians said to one another, for the first bad harvest that gave the Residency an excuse to take it down again. At Seann Dunn, Coinneach Òg wrote once, briefly, to say that the store's ledgers had grown by one more name that winter, his own cousin's, and that he supposed it made no difference now whether that was written into a petition or not. Aonghas Ruadh wrote to the Residency twice more, in his own name, asking only whether the paper of am Faoilleach had been received and read. To the first letter there was no reply at all. To the second, in the autumn, a clerk's hand, not the same clerk's, Peigi was fairly sure from the letters, wrote back that the matter remained under consideration.

Peigi kept the slate at the shrine door as she had always kept it, and in the course of that year and the next she added three more names to it, none of them, this time, of the famine or the Levy, but of the ordinary business of a country

with a hill in it and men going down into the hill: a fall of stone at Baile thais that took two crews out of Cill ghlas's own households, and an old man of the village who had gone down every day of his working life and finally did not come up one evening in an t-Sultain, of nothing that any physician, human or otherwise, could put a name to but the descent, done too many years too many times.

On a still evening near the end of an Dùbhlachd, with the first hard frost of that winter white on the burn-stones outside, Peigi went up to the shrine at Cill ghlas as she went every evening of her life, to see that the flame that was called Brìde's had not gone low.

It had not; it had burned steadily through the whole of that year of petitions and answers not given, as it had burned through the Levy and the Green Death and the years before either, needing from her only what it had always needed: oil enough, and a wick trimmed square, and someone to come up the hill in the cold and see to it. She knelt at the small stone trough before the flame and drew the old shears from the ledge where they always lay, and took the wick between finger and thumb, and trimmed it, careful, the way her mother had taught her, until the flame stood up clean and even and threw its light square across the little room and out through the open door into the frost beyond.

She did not know, kneeling there, whether the petition that had gone into the pile in the passage at Ros dhomhain would ever be taken up off it, read, answered, or refused; whether Aonghas Ruadh's third letter would fare better than his first two; whether Ruairidh mac Thormoid, who remembered a world before the coin, would live to see any Commissioner's answer at all, or whether his line at the foot of the fair copy, *born before the coin*, would be the last word of his that anyone at Ros dhomhain ever troubled to read. She only knew the wick was trimmed, and the flame stood clean, and that in the morning she would go down to the village and see who needed seeing to, and that this, at least, no clerk's pile could take from her hands.

She banked the fire, low, for the night, and went down the hill in the dark, and the frost held all across Cill ghlas until morning.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

OF FEARCHAR BÀRD'S SONGS

AE 101 – 105

Tha an long ag itbe a' chnuic gus an cnoc a ghiùlan air falbh.

The ship is eating the hill to carry the hill away.

I

Of the Book That Would Not Stay Shut

Fearchar had broken coal at Muileann dhearg since he was tall enough to reach the picking-belt, and by the winter the book came to him he had done it so long that his hands knew the weight of a lump before his eyes had found it, the good clean weight of coal against the duller drag of shale, and could throw the one into the cart and the other onto the spoil without his mind once leaving whatever verse it was turning over that day. His father had done the same work before him at the same belt, and had died of the cough the old women called by no name in those years, and Fearchar had gone on breaking coal and turning verses because there was no third thing to do.

The book came to Muileann dhearg folded inside a meal-sack, passed hand to hand from Baile thais by a carter who would not say whose it was. It had no cover and no title anyone had given it; the custodians' copyists, when a page of it at last reached the loft at Muileann chaol, called it *Leabhar Baile thais*¹ for want of a better word, and the name held. Inside it, in perhaps thirty different hands, some sure and some barely able to shape their letters, were the things nobody had found anywhere else to put: a wage not paid, a death not answered for, the week

1. the book of Baile thais, the book of grievances

the granary at Muileann chrom weighed short, the stream at Doire mhòr that had been dammed for the coal-washing without any order anyone could find.

Fearchar sat up two nights reading it by a tallow light borrowed from the pit stores, and found that he could not add a line to it. It was not want of a grievance. He had buried a father and watched a famine and knew the granary's short week as well as any man at that belt. But he found, turning the pages, that a wage not paid written down in a column looked like nothing at all, a bare fact among bare facts, and that what he wanted to do with it could not be done in a column.

"Then don't write it," said old Griogair mac Aonghais, who broke coal at the same belt and had known Fearchar's father. "Sing it. You've been singing since you could talk. Nobody's stopped you yet."

"Nobody's listened either."

"They will if you make it worth the listening." Griogair spat into the spoil-heap and went back to his sorting. "A column's for men who've given up hoping to be heard. You haven't given up yet, or you'd not be sitting up two nights over another man's book."

It was not the first time Fearchar had been told he sang too much for a man who broke coal for his bread. His mother had said the same, gentler, when he was a boy too small yet for the belt and was set instead to carry water along the row of pickers, singing whatever came into his head to keep his own feet moving; she had died before the famine, of nothing more than the years, and it was one of the few mercies Fearchar counted from those seasons, that she had not lived to see the granary's short week or the wall that came after it. His father had lasted longer and gone harder, coughing through his last two winters in a bed by the same hearth Fearchar still slept beside, and had said, near the end of it, that a man ought to leave something behind him besides coal, since the coal itself went into the Company's cart and was never seen again by the hand that broke it. Fearchar had not understood him rightly at the time. He understood him better with the book from Baile thais open on his knees, two nights running, and no column in it that would hold what he meant to leave.

Fearchar carried the book back to the carter in the spring, since it belonged at Baile thais. He carried something else away from it that no one could take back off him: the knowledge that the wrong done to Doire mhòr's stream and the wrong done to his own father's lungs were pages of the same book, whether anyone ever bound them together or not. He began, that spring, to put verses to the granary's

short week, working them out under his breath at the belt the way another man might work out a debt.

II

Of the Song That Was Forbidden and So Written Down

By 27 am Faoilleach, AE 101, it was known across the coal country that the grievances of thirty years had at last found a book to sit in; and a year after, on 17 am Faoilleach, AE 102, Fearchar sang his first finished song at the pit-mouth of Muileann dhearg, on an evening when the crews were waiting out a delay in the winding-gear with nothing else to do with their hands.

It was a short thing, four verses on the Levy and what it had cost the villages round Baile chrom, no name in it that could be hauled before a magistrate, only a field left to itself and a mother counting heads that did not come home. He had not meant it for more than the pit-mouth. But a song sung once at a pit-mouth is sung again at the next one, and within the month it had travelled from Muileann dhearg to Baile thais without Fearchar carrying it there himself.

The overseer at Baile thais heard it from a crew coming up off shift, singing it under their breath the way men sing something they have not decided yet whether they are allowed to know. He had them stopped and the words taken down from one of them, a boy who could not write and had to say it over three times before the overseer's clerk had it right, and the boy was docked half a week's pay for it and told the song was not to be sung again on Company ground.

It was sung again within the week, twice as far as before.

Fearchar heard of the docking before he heard of anything else, and went to Baile thais himself to find the boy and pay him back the half-week out of his own wage, which was not much, coal-breakers being paid less than hewers. The boy would not take it.

"Keep it," he said. "I'd rather have sung it than not, and I'll sing it again the first chance I get, so you may as well save your coin for the next one they dock."

It was the overseer's clerk, in the end, who did the greatest service to the song without meaning to. Ordered to write down every word of it so that it could be shown to be forbidden, he made, in his neat Company hand, the only complete copy of Fearchar's first song that survives from that year, since Fearchar himself had never troubled to set it on paper and the crews who sang it kept it only in

their heads. It sits now among the Company's own confiscation orders, filed under the offence it names, in a hand that never meant to keep it.

III

Of the Roadside House in the East

The song went east before Fearchar did, carried by carters who worked the road between Muileann dhearg and the coast and had no more idea than the Company's clerk what they were carrying. By the second year it had reached An Taigh-òsta Grianach¹, the great road-house on the eastern road where the carriers from the north met the southern coast path, and the keeper there, a broad, slow-spoken woman who had buried two husbands and outlasted both, took to it because her custom liked a tune with their ale and asked no questions about where a tune had come from.

Fearchar went there himself only once in those years, in the third summer, riding on a grain-cart with a load of the guild's barley that had nothing to do with him beyond the ride. He came into the taproom at dusk, unknown to anyone there, and sat at the end of a bench with a cup he could barely afford, and heard six Company carters at the next table sing his own song of the granary's short week through from the first verse to the last, missing only a line in the third stanza that they filled with nonsense words since none of them could remember it rightly.

He did not tell them whose it was, only sat with his cup and listened. Hearing it sung wrong by men who did not know what they sang hurt worse than hearing it forbidden, and stirred him more too, in some way he could at the time put no name to; the carters sang it the way they might sing any road-song, for the tune's sake and the company's, with no more notion that it named a grievance than a bird has that its call is a warning to other birds. When they had done, one of them called across for another verse of something, and Fearchar, still unknown to them, obliged with a verse of a song about a horse, and left before the barley cart went on without him needing to be asked who he was.

He walked home the last twelve miles rather than wait for another cart, and worked out on the road, verse by verse, a longer song than any he had made be-

1. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

fore, though it would be two years yet before the event came that would give it its ending.

The keeper of An Taigh-òsta Grianach he came to know a little better on later passes through, since a man who rode the guild's messages east twice a year could not help becoming a familiar face at the one house on that road worth stopping at. She never asked him outright whether the songs her custom sang were his own making, though he came to suspect, from the particular way she filled his cup without being asked a second summer running, that she had worked it out for herself and judged it none of her business to say so aloud in a room full of Company carters. It was as much acknowledgment as he ever wanted from her, and more than he got from most quarters in those years.

IV

Of the Quay That Ate the Hill

The Company's new quay went up at Ros dhomhain across those same years, a deep-water quay built out into the harbour where the old wooden jetty had stood, built for ships that no longer needed a tide to float them, ships with iron in their hulls and a stack instead of a mast, that burned coal to carry coal.

Fearchar saw the first of them load. He had gone down to Ros dhomhain on guild business, carrying a message for the silver refiners that had nothing to do with coal at all, and stood on the new stone of the quay among a crowd that had come to see the first of the iron fire-ships, greater than any paddle-boat the harbour had yet seen. It came alongside under its own power, with no oars and no visible sail, and a noise came out of it like a kettle the size of a house, and black smoke stood up from its stack straight into a still evening as though the sky itself had gone the colour of the coal at last.

They loaded her through the night by lamplight, gang after gang carrying baskets up a plank that bent under the weight and did not break, and Fearchar stood at the quay rail until past midnight watching the coal go into her holds and the smoke go up from her stack, and understood, in the plain way a thing is understood when it is seen rather than told, that the ship was burning the same coal it carried to make the carrying possible, so that in some measure it ate its own cargo

as it went, and would eat more of the hill to carry the hill away than any cart or barge had ever managed before it.

He made the song that night, sitting on a coil of the new quay's rope with the fire-ship's kettle-noise going on behind him, and it came faster and cleaner than any song he had made before, as though it had been waiting in him since the tap-room at An Taigh-òsta Grianach¹ for the right ship to arrive and finish it.

Tha an long ag ithe a' chnuic gus an cnoc a gbiùlan air falbh.

He sang it first to the gang he had loaded beside that night, men too tired by then to do more than nod, and it was that song, more than any other he made, that the carters carried furthest, since it named nothing that could be forbidden and everything that everyone who had ever loaded a cart already knew in their arms.

V

Of the Wall at Baile thais

Fearchar came home from Ros dhomhain to find that Baile thais had grown a wall while he had been away at the quay: a stone wall round the pithead where there had never before been so much as a fence, with a single gate in it and a watchman set at the gate with a book to write in, so that every crew going down and every crew coming up was counted through a single door.

No one at Baile thais could say when the order for it had come, only that the stone had gone up through the summer, drawn by cart from a quarry the Company had opened for the purpose, and that the watchman's post was the first thing built on Dia-thìr, so far as the oldest hewers there could remember, meant to keep a working's own crews from its own working rather than to keep anything else out.

The watchman himself was no stranger; he had been a hewer at Baile thais until a fall two years before had left one leg shorter than the other and unfit for the face, and the Company had given him the gate as a kindness of sorts, since it paid better than the poor-rolls and asked less of his legs than a shift underground. He greeted every crew through the gate by name, tallied them in his book without malice, and was, Fearchar thought, watching him work the evening he came

1. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

home, as much a man walled in by that wall as any of the men he counted through it, since he could no more leave the gate for the belt than they could pass the gate without him marking it.

Fearchar walked the length of the new wall the evening he came home, from the gate to the place where it met the old spoil-heap and stopped, since the spoil itself served as well as stone for the last stretch of it. He did not make a song of the wall that year. He found, standing at the gate and watching the watchman tally a shift through it by lamplight, that some things came to him whole and some needed to sit a long while before they would give up a verse worth keeping, and the wall was of the second kind; it sat in him through that winter and the next, unfinished, while other things came first.

VI

Of Catriona's Burying

Word came to Baile thais at the dark of the hundred and fourth year that Catriona nic Eachainn had died at Muileann chiar, an old woman by then, a refiner of the silver guild to the last day she could stand at a bench. There were men and women still at Baile thais who remembered her from the eleven days she had held the pit-mouth against its own agent, though most of the crew she had led then were dead of one thing or another themselves, and the ones who remembered were the old ones now, as she had been.

A dozen of them asked leave to walk east to her burying, and were given it, and the Company docked every one of them a day's pay for the day they were gone, entered against their names as plainly as a wage or a debt. Fearchar was not among the dozen who had known her, being too young to have stood below the pithead in her time, but he walked with them anyway, since a burying at Muileann chiar was twenty miles east and no company was wasted on a road that long.

They buried her under the guild's own stone, among the refiners who had gone before her, and one of the dozen, a woman old enough to have carried water to the strikers in her own girlhood, stood at the grave's edge and said only that Catriona had told the crews what she had told the agent and then sat down on a coal-tub and not moved, and that this was worth remembering longer than most things men wrote down about her, since it had cost her every pit on Dia-thìr and she had never once, in all the years after, said she wished she had done otherwise.

Fearchar made her lament on the walk home, twenty miles being long enough for a lament to find its shape if a man has the grief and the road both. It named the coal-tub and the empty shelves she had counted, and the guild's bench she had stood at afterward until her hands gave out, and it ended, as her own life had, without complaint, which he judged afterward to be the hardest thing he had yet made a song do, since a lament that does not complain has to find its weight somewhere else, and he had put the weight, in the end, on the single line that she had never once said she wished she had done otherwise. The dozen who had known her wept at it on the road, which he took, rightly, for the only judgment on a lament that was ever worth having.

VII

Of the Fire on the Quay, and the Empty Seat

The fire-ships' quay at Ros dhomhain burned three days in the spring after, taking two streets of the harbour quarter down with the coal sheds, and by the time Fearchar heard of it at Baile thais the news had already grown three different causes in the telling: a dropped lamp, a spark from a stack left burning at anchor, a fire set on purpose by hands the tellers left unnamed, though plainly they had someone in mind. The Company's own inquiry, when its findings reached the coal towns weeks later, found no cause at all, which satisfied no one who had watched two streets burn and asked why.

It was at An Taigh-òsta Grianach¹, on his way east with the guild's business again that same year, that Fearchar heard the fire-ship's carters singing his own song of the ship that ate the hill, louder and rougher than the granary song had ever been sung, and understood only slowly, listening from the same end of the same bench he had sat on three years before, that they were singing it now because their own quay had burned and the words fit a grief they had not made the song to carry. They did not know his name. They did not know the song was his. He sat with his cup, as he had the first time, and did not tell them, and found that a song forbidden on Company ground could travel further inside the Company's own mouths than it had ever travelled by any road he had walked himself. It was simply the way a true thing moved once it was let loose, going where it liked and

1. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

being sung by whoever needed it, without asking leave of the man who had made it.

He was still on that same road home when the second news reached him, carried faster than either fire or song by a rider changing horses at every post-house between the capital and the coast: that Artair mac Iain, high custodian these twenty and four years, was dead at Cathair dhearg, eighty years old, and that the Council of Custodians, called to choose the next as it had chosen every one before him since the crown fell vacant at the close of the age before this one, had sat three days and risen without a name.

It sat so still through the rest of that year. No custodian would put forward another's name for fear of putting forward his own, and no custodian would put forward his own for fear of what a name given now, with the coal roads walled and the quays burning and the grievance book still passing hand to hand from Baile thais to wherever a copy could be made, might be asked to answer for later. The seat at the head of the council table stood empty through the Faoillean that followed, and the one after, with the old high custodian's chair left where it had always stood, since no one thought to move it and no one yet had the right to sit in it. It was said, though no one at Baile thais could say who had first said it, that Robert Haskins at the Residency had written home across the sea that an empty seat suited him better than a full one, since a council with no head to answer for it was a council that answered to no one at all.

Fearchar made no song of the empty seat that year, nor for some years after. He had a lament in him for Catriona and a song in him for the quay and the wall at Baile thais still sitting unfinished from the winter before, and some things, he had learned by then, needed to sit a long while before they would give up a verse worth keeping. The empty seat was of that kind.

He went back to the belt at Muileann dhearg, and broke coal, and let it sit. In the evenings, when the winding-gear was quiet and the crews sat out the last light before the huts, he sang what he had, the granary song and the ship song and Catriona's lament, and let the empty seat go unsung, since a chair with no one in it made a poor subject for a verse next to a man who had sat down on a coal-tub and not moved, or a ship that ate its own cargo as it carried it away. Some griefs, he thought, needed a shape to them before a song could hold them, a coal-tub or a quay or a woman's name on a stone, and a council that had simply stopped, quietly, without anyone striking a blow or signing a paper, had as yet no shape he knew how to give it. He judged, breaking coal at the belt his father had worked

before him, that the shape would come in its own time, as the ship song had waited three years at An Taigh-òsta Grianach for the right ship to arrive and finish it, and that until it came the plainest thing left to do was what his father had told him from the hearth-bed at the end: to leave something behind him besides coal, one song at a time, and let the empty seat sit empty a while longer, since it seemed, by every account that reached Baile thais that year, in no hurry to be filled.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

OF THE LONG DROUGHT

AE 106 – 110

I

Of the First Dry Summer

I seabail nic Leòid had kept the roll of Àth mhòr eleven years before the first summer the wells would not fill, and she remembered afterward that she had not known, standing at the mouth of her own well with the bucket coming up a third full of grey water and grit, that she was standing at the beginning of anything at all. A dry summer was not a strange thing on Dia-thìr. She had seen three in her time as custodian, and each had broken in its own season with rain enough to fill the cisterns before the cattle suffered for it. She let down the bucket a second time, watched the rope go slack sooner than it should, and told herself the same thing the town had told itself since Bealltainn: that the rain was late this year, not gone.

It did not come. By an t-Iuchar the burn below Àth mhòr ran in a channel a man could step across without wetting his boot, and by Lùnastal it did not run at all, only stood in pools the colour of weak tea between stones gone white with dust. Iseabail sent word east to Achadh shean, whose custodian she had known

since they were girls together at the loft, and the word that came back was worse than her own: the wells there had failed a full month before Àth mhòr's, and the burn that fed the town's mill had not turned the wheel since Meadhan an t-Samhraidh.

The roll that year, when it was written up at the year's turning, named ten districts as drought country: worst at Achadh shean, at Àth uaine, at Achadh àrsaidh and at Muileann chiar, the drought reaching down as far as Cuan ruadh on the coast and west as far as Baile chaol before it thinned into ordinary dry ground. Iseabail's own Àth mhòr sat near the middle of it, close enough to Achadh shean that the two towns' custodians began that first autumn to send a rider between them twice a week, more for the company of shared bad news than for anything either could do to help the other.

The Administration kept no count of its own. Iseabail heard this first from a carter who had asked at the pay office at Ceann mhin whether the Company meant to do anything for the districts that could not feed their beasts, and had been told, in the words he repeated to her at her own door with the particular flatness of a man passing on an insult he has decided not to be angry about until later, that the yield was not affected and the office kept no register of rainfall. She wrote the carter's words into her own roll exactly as he had given them to her, because she had already begun, without quite deciding to, the habit of writing down every answer she was given, in the words it was given in.

II

Of the Cattle Column

The second dry season broke nothing that the first had not already cracked. By the summer of the hundred and seventh year the wells at Achadh shean had been dry two years running, and the district's grazing, which had never been rich, was burned to standing straw by the middle of an t-Iuchar. Àth mhòr's own grass held a little longer, being nearer the coast and catching what fog came off the sea at night, but Iseabail could see from her own byre door that it would not hold past Lùnastal, and she called the district's herders together on a morning in the last week of an t-Iuchar and told them what she had already decided before she called them: that the beasts would be driven west, to whatever water could be found, before the grass gave out entirely and the driving became a burying.

They set out three days later, a column that the roll she wrote that autumn said was a day long, though Iseabail, walking at its head with a stick and a dog and her own two milk-cows among the hundreds of another's driving, thought afterward that a day long was too plain a way to say it, and that no word she had would say it better. Cattle low differently when they are thirsty than when they are merely being driven; she had not known that before that summer, and she knew it after in a way she never afterward lost, so that thirty years later the sound of oxen complaining at a gate could turn her stomach cold before she had thought why.

They walked four days to the first standing water worth the name, a tarn on the moor above Doire fhionn that had never in living memory gone dry, and the beasts smelled it a mile off and quickened without being driven, and Iseabail let them go, because there was no holding four hundred thirsty cattle back from water once they had scented it, and no reason on earth to try. Fewer than half of what had set out reached the tarn on its own legs. The rest had gone down on the road, in the dust, in the ochre grass at the road's edge, too weak to rise again, and had been left where they fell, because a beast that cannot walk cannot be carried, not four hundred of them, not by drovers who were themselves three days on short water. No roll required it of her, yet Iseabail counted the dead as they passed them, unable to walk by a fallen beast without marking it, the way she had begun to mark every answer the Administration gave her. She had ninety-one marks in her book by the time the column reached the tarn, and she added seven more before the drovers turned the survivors for home. She never, in all the years after, told anyone which number stayed with her longest; it was the count of calves among the ninety-one of the road, which was eleven, and which she had somehow known, walking, she would carry the rest of her life.

Doire fhionn, whose tarn had saved what was left of Achadh shean's herd, was by then sending its own women half a day's walk to a spring beyond its bounds for water fit to drink, the tarn having been fouled within a week by every district's cattle using it at once. Iseabail spoke to one of them at the tarn's edge, a woman carrying two full skins on a yoke who had walked out from the town before first light and would walk back after dark, and asked her how long the town meant to go on so. "Until it rains," the woman said, and shrugged the yoke straighter on her shoulders, and walked on, and Iseabail understood that this was the whole of the answer anyone in the drought country had, for any question that began with how long.

III

Of Baile chaol's Choice

Baile chaol, at the far western edge of the drought country, had no moor within four days' driving that still held water enough for a herd the size of its own, and its custodian, a broad quiet woman named Ealasaid Ruadh whom Iseabail had known only by letter until that autumn, sent word round every district asking whether any had grazing to spare rather than water to reach. None did. Iseabail rode to Baile chaol herself in the last days of an Dàmhair, on the strength of nothing more than the wish not to leave the letter unanswered by a stranger's hand, and found the town's council already met and its mind already made, the kind of decision a town comes to only once it has stopped hoping there is a better one waiting a day further off.

They killed the herd over three days at the edge of the dry burn, the meat salted and smoked in every shed the town had standing, the hides scraped and stacked, and nothing wasted that a hungry district could use, and Ealasaid Ruadh stood at the killing the whole three days without once turning her back on it, which Iseabail thought, watching her, took more out of a person than the driving had taken out of her own drovers on the road to Doire fhionn. "A beast I can raise again in three good years," Ealasaid said to her that first evening, over meat neither of them had much appetite for. "A well that's gone dry three years running I can't promise anyone will fill again in ten." She did not say it as a complaint. She said it the way a woman says a sum she has already done the arithmetic of and does not need to do again, and Iseabail wrote the words into her roll that night exactly as she had heard them, the way she had begun writing down every hard thing anyone in the drought country said to her, because she had come by then to believe that the words themselves, kept whole, were worth more than anything she might have added to them.

Baile chaol ate through that winter on its own slaughtered herd and lost fewer of its people to hunger than any other district of the ten, a fact the roll records plainly and without praise, because Ealasaid Ruadh, when Iseabail rode back through in the spring to tell her so, said only that she would rather not have needed to know how to make the choice, and changed the subject to the state of the road.

IV

Of the Spring That Did Not Fail

There was one water in the drought country that held through all three dry years, and every district that could reach it sent to it before the second summer was out: Allt an Àigh¹, the holy spring in the east, of which the old telling said it had never failed since An Aois Naomh², and did not fail now. Iseabail went there herself in the summer of the hundred and eighth year, a custodian with dying beasts and a district running on borrowed water, and found the ground around the spring already trodden into mud a hundred yards out by feet that had come the same way she had.

The pilgrims of Na Seann Spioradan³ had begun arriving at Bealltainn that year in numbers nobody at the spring had seen before, walking in from every drought district and some that were not drought country at all, carrying water home in whatever they had brought to carry it in, and the spring's own keepers, an old brother and sister who had tended it without payment for as long as anyone could say, found themselves that season feeding pilgrims from their own stores as well as watering them; and word of the crowding went along the road to Inis uaine, the nearest town of any size, which opened its own granary to the walkers rather than see them go hungry on the road home, a kindness the roll notes without explaining, because none was needed.

It was in that same summer that the Administration set a watchman at the spring, a young man from Ceann mhin with a ledger and a rate written out for him by some clerk who had never seen the place: so much a skin, so much a beast, payable before the water was drawn. Iseabail was there the second week he stood his post, and watched an old woman of Achadh àrsaidh, who had walked three days with an empty cask on a barrow to fill it at the one water she trusted, set the cask down at the spring's edge and refuse, in words Iseabail did not think the young man understood in either sense, to pay a stranger for water that had run free since before his people came down from the north. The watchman did not press her. He stood his post through that season and was called back before the next one began, and the roll of Allt an Àigh, which Iseabail copied that autumn

1. the stream of the healing water

2. the Holy Age

3. the Old Spirits

from the keepers' own tally, records no reason given for his recall, only the plain fact of it, and under the fact, in the old brother's hand, the single word restored.

V

Of the Drought-Fever

The third dry season brought a fever that the two before it had not, and it came first, as fevers of bad water do, to the towns whose wells had been dug deepest into old ground. At Baile Mòr ruadh, whose wells had gone down years before into what had once been the town's own middens, seventeen died of it before the summer's end, more than the town had lost to any sickness in Iseabail's memory of it, and the fever went on from there to Cnoc shean, where it took fewer but took them just as surely, mostly the very young and the very old, whose bodies had least water in them to spare for fighting it.

Iseabail rode to Baile Mòr ruadh in the worst of it, at the asking of its custodian, a younger woman new enough to the office that she had never yet buried anyone by the fever's own particular manner: quick at first, a griping of the belly and a thirst no water eased, then a stillness that the women who sat with the dying learned to dread more than the griping, because it meant the body had stopped fighting what it drank. Iseabail sat two nights in a row with a household that lost a grandmother and a boy of nine within a day of each other, and held the boy's hand at the last of it because his mother could not, being with the grandmother in the next room, and she wrote nothing in her roll that night at all, being for once too tired and too sick at heart to trust her own hand with it, and made up the entry the following evening instead, dry and plain, as if a day's distance could put back into the words the steadiness they had lost at the boy's bedside.

The Mission's physician at Baile Mòr ruadh, a spare young man named Coll who had been sent out only that spring and had not yet learned to hold his tongue in front of a custodian, said to Iseabail on the second night, turning a dipper of well-water in his hands as though it might answer him, that he had tested the water himself and found it foul enough to sicken a strong man on a single cup, foul with whatever had lain in the ground the well was sunk through before ever the well was dug. "The old midden," Iseabail said. "It has been the town's midden longer than either of us. Everyone knew it." "Then everyone knew, and dug there anyway," Coll said, "because the drought gave them no ground to

choose from that was not one old thing or another." He did not say it unkindly. He said it the way a man says a thing he has only just understood and finds he cannot now unknow, and it was his report, sent to the Mission's house at Cathair dhearg that autumn, that named the fever's cause rightly before any other account written that year did: the deep wells the drought had driven the towns to dig, down into ground that had never been meant to give up water and gave up, along with what little it had, whatever had been buried near it in years the towns themselves had half forgotten. The drought itself had only starved.

The Mission bored new wells at Achadh shean and at Àth chrom that same season, deeper again but dug clean, away from any old ground, and those wells held, and the fever did not follow them. Iseabail entered both facts into her roll on facing pages, as the custodians of the whole drought country had begun by then to do without any of them having agreed to it aloud: the Mission's wells on one page, the Company's quota on the other, the quota unchanged through three dry years and a fever that had killed more of Baile Mòr ruadh in one summer than the pits themselves had that year, and beside neither page did Iseabail write a word, because there was no word she could find that the facing pages did not say better by themselves.

VI

Of Achadh chaol Going Down

Achadh chaol, whose own grazing had failed with everyone else's by the second year, sent its young men to the pits that summer in numbers its custodian had never before had to record. Iseabail heard the first of it from her own nephew, her sister's boy, who came to her door one evening in the autumn of the hundred and eighth year to tell her, before he told his own mother, that he had signed with the Company's agent at Ceann mhin for a hewer's contract at Cnoc fhiadhaich, and would go down after Samhain.

"Your father kept sheep," she said, not as a reproach, because she found she had none ready to give him, only the plain fact laid beside his own plain fact the way she had lately taken to laying plain facts beside one another and letting them speak for themselves. "So did his father."

"His sheep are dead, Aunt. Mine would be too, inside the year, if I kept any worth the name." He was not angry saying it, only tired in a way she thought no

boy of nineteen ought yet to be. "A hewer's wage comes whether it rains or not. That's the whole of my reasoning, and I don't think it's a bad one."

She could not tell him it was. She wrote his going into her roll along with the others who followed him from Achadh chaol that winter and the winter after, families who had kept beasts and small fields for generations going down into the galleries because a hewer's wage, paid whether the year was wet or dry, had become the only certain thing left to a household in the drought country, and she noted the count without comment beside it, because by then she had stopped believing that comment changed anything a plain fact did not already say.

VII

Of the Petition, Begun Alone

Every custodian of the drought country petitioned Haskins that third year, each in her own hand and her own time, none of them, so far as Iseabail ever learned, having agreed beforehand to do it together, though when she came to compare the copies afterward, in the loft at Muileann chaol where such things were kept, she found that nine of the ten districts had written some version of the same three sentences, as though the drought itself had dictated the wording and left each custodian only the work of the hand. She wrote her own in the autumn of the hundred and ninth year, a single page asking that the Company's quota for the drought districts be set aside until two seasons of ordinary rain had been counted, and rode it herself to Ros dhomhain, three days on a horse thinner than she liked to ride, through country that still remembered how to be green and had lost, in three years, the smell of it after rain.

The Residency kept her waiting the better part of a day in a passage she did not think had been swept since the petition before hers had waited in it, and when at last a clerk took her page from her hand he did not read it while she stood there, only set it on a pile with others she recognised by their folds as having come from Achadh shean and from Muileann chiar, and told her, in words so evenly worn by repetition that she wondered how many times that week alone he had said them, that the matter was under consideration. She asked him what matter, precisely, and by whom, and he looked at her the way a man looks at a question he has never once been asked to answer and does not intend to begin answering that afternoon, and said only that he would see her petition placed with the others.

She rode home and wrote the words into her roll, under consideration, and looked at them a long while by lamplight, and understood, as she had half understood since the cattle column and fully understood now, that the words meant nothing at all, and would go on meaning nothing at all for as long as anyone above the Residency's stair found it convenient that they should.

It was in that understanding, and not in any single grief sharper than the others, that Iseabail began, on a wet evening in the winter of the hundred and ninth year that felt, after three dry years, almost too strange to trust, to write down everything the drought had cost, district by district, in a hand small enough to fit a great deal onto a single sheet: the wells failed and when; the cattle driven and how many did not arrive; the fever's dead by name where she had the names and by number where she did not; the Mission's wells that held against the Company's quota that had not moved; the watchman recalled from Allt an Àigh¹ and the word restored under his going; the carter's flat answer about a register that was not kept. She wrote a page and found she was not finished, and wrote another, and did not stop at ten, because by then she had stopped writing for Haskins at all and had begun writing, though she could not have said so plainly even to herself that winter, for whoever might someday want to know what three dry years had actually cost a district that the Administration's own ledgers had never troubled to measure.

Her own household thought she had taken up the writing as a kind of grief, and let her be at it evenings when there was little else to do by lamplight in a dry year, and she did not correct them, because she had not yet found words that would explain to anyone, even to herself with any confidence, what exactly she believed the forty pages were for. Nor was she a woman of letters in the way the copyists at Muileann chaol were; she had learned to write well enough to keep a custodian's roll and no more, and the work of setting down three years in full, rather than in the short entries a roll allowed, went slowly, a page some evenings, half a page on others, crossed through and begun again when a fact came back to her sharper than she had first set it down. The cattle column she wrote twice, the second time longer than the first, because on rereading the first she had found she had left out the calves, and could not let the second draft go forward without them.

Forty pages deep in it, and still writing, she stood at her own well one spring morning in the hundred and tenth year when a rider came from Achadh shean

with word that the Mission's new rig, boring a third well on the moor above the town, had struck water at last, clean and cold and running, deeper than any well the town had dug before the drought and deeper, the rider said, than anyone had believed water could lie under that particular stretch of moor. Iseabail rode out to see it for herself, and stood at the rig's edge with half the town around her, children who had never in their remembered lives seen water come up out of the ground on its own account crowding close enough that the drillers had to wave them back from the pipe, and watched the water come up bright over the driller's hands, and thought, watching it, of the tarn on the moor above Doire fhionn and the ninety-eight marks in her drover's book, and of the old woman who would not pay a stranger for water that had run free since before his people came, and of her sister's boy three years gone now into the galleries at Cnoc fhiadhaich, whose contract would not be undone by a well striking water far from where he stood.

She wrote that night, at the bottom of her fortieth page, in a hand no steadier than it had been on the first: this also happened, so that whoever reads this after me will know the drought did end, in its own place, in its own season, and not because anyone above the Residency's stair troubled to make it so.

1. the stream of the healing water

PART FIVE

OF the Word and the Line

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

Of the Law of One Line

AE 111 – 113

I

Of the Forty Pages and the Four Words

I seabail nic Leòid's forty pages reached the Residency at Ros dhomhain in the spring of the hundred and tenth year, and lay on a clerk's table through the summer, and were answered at last, in the winter that opened the hundred and eleventh, in four words written across the foot of the last page in Robert Haskins's own hand: *the quota stands unrevised*. The copyists who later held both leaves together in the chest at Muileann chaol remarked on nothing so much as the room the two witnesses took up side by side, the one nearly as thick as a Company ledger, the other four words and a signature, and left it at that, because there was nothing in the pairing that wanted explaining twice.

It was in that same winter, at Baile dhìreach on the western coast, that Thomas Hale first put his name to paper against the Administration, in a matter that had nothing to do with drought or grain and everything to do with a strip of hill ground no wider than a cart-track, and it is by his roll, and by the Ros dhomhain court's own record, kept afterward among the Residency's letter-books, that the copyists have told what came of it.

Baile dhìreach was a small town even by the coast's own measure, one straight street running down to a quay, and it had been, since before Thomas could remember, a town of two peoples under one roof more often than any other on that shore. His grandmother, Eilidh nic Ruairidh, a net-maker's daughter of the place, had married Samuel Hale, a human cooper off one of the early ships, in the seventh year after the strangers came, in the first of the marriages the custodians of that coast ever entered in two tongues in the one roll; and though Samuel Hale had died an old man's death long before Thomas was born, and Eilidh not many years after him, the house they had kept together still stood at the head of the

street by the well, and Thomas's father, Iain Hale, had grown up in it a boatwright, mending the town's craft and building new ones, *Dia-thìrich* and human custom both come easily to his hands if not always to his tongue.

Iain Hale had died when Thomas was eighteen, of a fever that took three others of the town the same season, and had left his son the boatyard, the house, and a habit, which Thomas had never fully understood until he was a man grown himself, of speaking of his mother's people's ground as though it were a thing held in trust and not yet properly claimed. Eilidh nic Ruairidh's own mother's family had worked, since before any of them could say how long, a narrow cutting in the hill above the town, a seam no wider than a good man's shoulders that gave up perhaps two cartloads of coal in a good year, more often used for the town's own hearths than sold, and held by no writing at all, only by the custom that a family which has cut a seam for its grandmothers' grandmothers and asked no other family's leave to do it owns the seam as surely as it owns its own byre. Iain Hale had cut there himself, as a boy, at his mother's side, and had gone on cutting there as a man, quietly, on the days the boatyard gave him free, and had never once, so far as Thomas ever learned, thought to ask anyone's permission for it, because the question had never in his lifetime come up.

Thomas remembered his father at that cutting better than he remembered him almost anywhere else: a broad, unhurried man kneeling at the low mouth of the seam with a hand-pick worn smooth at the haft, humming some boatyard tune under his breath that had no words Thomas ever learned, and stopping, every so often, to hold a broken lump up to the light the way a man might hold up a fish to judge whether it was worth the taking. Iain Hale had never once, in Thomas's hearing, called the coal his own outright; he called it his mother's, or the town's, or simply the hill's, as though ownership of it were a question he saw no profit in asking, being a question the hill had never troubled to raise in all the years it had let the family cut there. It was only after his father's death, going through the small chest of papers the boatyard's accounts were kept in, that Thomas found the copy of his grandmother's marriage entry his father had had made in his own hand, years before, from the custodian's roll, folded small and kept at the very bottom beneath the boat contracts, as though it were a thing Iain Hale had meant, one day, to make some use of, and had died before the day came.

It came up in the hundred and eleventh year because A' Chompanaidh's surveyors, working the southern seams along a line of workable coal that ran, as such

lines will, without regard for any family's custom, marked the same hill for a new gallery, and sent an agent down to Baile dhìreach with a paper naming every holding on the slope that the Company judged owed to it, the narrow cutting among them.

II

Of the Paper on the Table

The agent, a young man named Pryce who had been three years in the Company's survey office and had learned, in that time, to read a Dia-thirich roll well enough to find the names he wanted in it, sat at Thomas Hale's own table on a wet morning in the second month of the year and laid the paper flat between them with the particular patience of a man who has done this in a dozen other houses and expects no trouble in this one.

"Your family has worked this ground," Pryce said, "under no charter the Company recognises. I am not saying you have done wrong. I am saying the Company's claim runs beneath the district's whole, and yours does not run beneath anything at all, in the Company's law, unless you can show it does."

"It has been my mother's people's ground since before the Company had a name," Thomas said. "That is the whole of my showing."

"It may be true and still be no showing, in the court the Company will bring this to if you refuse the offer." Pryce named a sum, small enough that Thomas understood, hearing it, that the Company had already reckoned the seam worth little on its own and wanted it chiefly to close a gap in its own map. "I would take it, if I were in your place. A court costs more than it returns, oftener than not, to a man arguing custom against a charter."

Thomas did not take it that morning, nor the following week, when Pryce came again with the same paper and a slightly larger sum written beneath the old one. He had, by his own account, no clear plan in his head beyond a stubbornness he could not at the time have named any more precisely than his father's habit of speaking of the seam as a thing held in trust; it was his wife, sitting at the table's far end through both of Pryce's visits and saying nothing until he had gone, who put the plan into words for him.

1. the Company

"Your grandmother's marriage is in the roll," she said. "Two tongues, one page, the custodian's own hand. If the Company's law knows anything of lines and charters, it will have to know what a marriage entered in its own Residency's register is, or say plainly that it does not, and I do not think it wants to say that plainly, not with every other marriage of the coast standing behind yours asking the same question."

It was, Thomas said afterward, more courage than he had felt himself in the matter, and he went that week to the custodian of Baile dhireach, an old woman named Mairead nic Aoidh who had held the office since before he was born, and had her make him a copy of the roll's page from the second year, the marriage of Eilidh nic Ruairidh and Samuel Hale in the two tongues, sealed with the custodian's own mark as it had stood unaltered for a hundred and four years. With that copy in his coat, and no other paper to his name, he walked the two days to Ros dhomhain in the third month of the year to file his claim at the Company's court.

III

Of the Walk to Ros dhomhain

The road to Ros dhomhain ran along the coast for the first day and inland for the second, through country Thomas had known since boyhood, boat-yards and net-sheds giving way by degrees to the carting roads and the smoke of the hills, and he said afterward that he had spent most of the walk turning over, without ever quite settling, the question of what exactly he thought a court at Ros dhomhain owed a claim it had never in a hundred years been asked to answer. He had no lawyer, no letters of the Company's tongue beyond what his grandfather's house had given him, and no friend at the Residency to tell him what manner of hearing his paper would get once he had filed it.

Ros dhomhain he had seen only twice before that spring, both times as a boy come with his father to buy timber the boatyard could not get nearer home, and he found it, walking it now alone and on his own business, a harder town to read than he remembered: the quay stacked three deep with coal for the steamers that had begun, that year, to call there more often than the old sail ever had; the Residency's long grey front with its rows of shuttered windows giving nothing away of what went on behind them; and everywhere along the streets nearest the court, clerks and agents and Company men moving at a pace no coast town Thomas

knew ever kept, as though every one of them had somewhere more pressing to be than the place they were walking to. He lodged the one night before his business was done at a boarding-house kept by a Dia-threach widow off the harbour road, one of a dozen such houses along that street that kept custodians and petitioners and claimants of every district, and she told him over a thin supper, without his asking, that she had housed men come to argue every kind of claim the Company's court would hear, and that in eleven years keeping the house she could not, that evening, call to mind a single one of them who had come away from Ros dhomhain with more than he had walked in with.

What the counter got him, the next morning, was a clerk's fee, four marks, paid in the Company's own coin over a table no wider than a door, and a date given him a full season off, the tenth month of that same year, for a hearing before the magistrate. He asked the clerk, before he left the counter, whether it was usual for a claim of this kind to take so long in the coming, and the clerk, a tired man who had clearly answered the question before, told him it was usual for every claim to take exactly as long as the court's own list allowed, and that a claim from a district with no Company agent resident in it went, as a rule, to the back of that list.

Thomas walked the two days home again with the fee's receipt in his coat where the marriage roll had been, and told his wife, and the custodian, and Pryce, when the agent came a third time with the paper and a sum unchanged from the second offer, that the matter would be heard in the tenth month, and that he did not mean to sell before it was.

The season between filing and hearing was, by every account Thomas ever gave of it afterward, the longest he had lived through since his father's death. The boatyard's work went on as it always had, and his wife kept the house, and their daughter Eilidh, thirteen that summer, understood the waiting better than her father wished her to; but Thomas himself found the hill above the town harder to walk past than he had ever found it before, the narrow mouth of the cutting sitting in the hillside exactly as it had sat in his father's day and his grandmother's, asking, he said, no question of anyone, and yet somehow, that year, seeming to ask everything of him.

IV

Of Dunstan's Ruling

Oliver Dunstan, magistrate at Ros dhomhain, had sat on the Company's bench at that town for six years by the time Thomas Hale's claim came before him, and was known along the coast, so far as a Dia-thíreach could be said to know a human magistrate at all, chiefly for a manner that gave nothing away until the ruling was read, courteous to every party in a room and unmoved, so the custodians who had watched him rule on other matters said, by anything either party thought to say to him.

Thomas stood before him in the second week of the tenth month, in a room that held perhaps thirty people, most of them Company clerks with business of their own on the list that day, and had, when his own turn came, only the marriage roll's copy and his own plain telling of a seam worked without dispute by four generations of one family. Pryce spoke for the Company, briefly and without heat, laying out the survey's line and the charter it ran from, and did not, Thomas noted afterward, so much as mention the marriage roll at all, as though it were a paper that had not been filed.

Dunstan asked few questions. He asked Thomas once whether his grandmother's family had ever held any writing, charter or grant, naming them owners of the cutting, and Thomas said no, only the custom of the ground and the roll of the marriage, and Dunstan wrote something in the book before him and asked nothing further of it that day.

The ruling came a fortnight later, posted at the Company's counter along with a dozen others of that same list, and read, in the plain terms the copyists later set beside the master record of the case: that customary rights of the kind claimed descended, in the Administration's law, only through a line the Administration recognised as continuous in its own registers of holding, and that no marriage entered in a custodian's roll, however old, however honoured in the custom of a district, created such a line where none had existed before it; that Thomas Hale's claim, resting as it did on custom and on a marriage rather than on any Company grant, therefore failed; and that the cutting, together with the whole of the hill the survey had marked, stood confirmed to A' Chompanaidh¹ under its existing charter.

Thomas read the ruling standing at the counter, with Pryce, by chance, two places down the same board reading a different notice, and said afterward that what struck him hardest that morning was not the ruling's substance, which he

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had half expected from the length of the wait alone, but its plainness: that a line the custodians of his own coast had kept in two tongues for a hundred and four years could be set aside in four sentences by a man who had never once, in the whole hearing, asked to see it read aloud.

V

Of the Eleven Cuttings

The ruling named only Thomas Hale's cutting, and might, had it stood alone, have passed from the district's memory within a generation as one family's hard luck and no more. It did not stand alone. Within three years of Dunstan's ruling the Company's agents had brought eleven further claims of the same kind before the Ros dhomhain bench, each resting the Company's title on some marriage, generations back or recent, between a holder in a customary line and a human, and each decided, without exception, on the same ground Dunstan had first set out: that no such marriage created a line the Administration recognised, whatever the custom of the district or the age of the roll that recorded it.

The oldest of the eleven was the working at Cnoc dhubh, held by one household since An Aois Naomh¹, lost because a great-grandmother of that line had married a human sailor two generations back and the marriage, like Eilidh nic Ruairidh's, stood written in a custodian's roll and nowhere else. The custodian of Cnoc dhubh, an old woman who had known the family three generations deep, wrote in her own roll, when the ruling reached her, only that the Company had found a use, at last, for every marriage her district had ever entered in good faith, and set down no further word beside it.

A second of the eleven, decided in the hundred and thirteenth year, took the working at Seann Bhrál on much the same ground: a cooper's daughter married, three generations back, to a human pilot off one of the Crossing's own ships, the marriage entered in the same good faith as Eilidh nic Ruairidh's, and the cutting it had once secured passed, on Dunstan's own reasoning applied a second time by a magistrate junior to him, to the Company without further hearing at all, the ruling in that case running to no more than a page and citing the Hale case by

1. the Holy Age

name as settled law. Thomas read that ruling when a carter brought word of it to Baile dhìreach, and said to his wife, folding the notice away, that he had not thought, filing his own paper two years before, that he was writing the very sentence a second magistrate had now used against a family he had never met and a hill he had never seen.

It was Mairead nic Aoidh, custodian of Baile dhìreach, who first stopped entering such marriages in her own roll, in the spring of the hundred and twelfth year, on her own plain reckoning: a marriage written into the roll had become, under Dunstan's rule, a paper a family's enemies could use against it, and had stopped, in her judgement, being a paper that protected anything at all. She told Thomas so herself, standing at her own door, and he said afterward that he had never in his life heard a woman say so hard a thing in so level a voice. Other custodians of the coast, hearing of Baile dhìreach's decision within the year, did the same, quietly, without any word passed between the districts to agree it, so that within a decade the two-tongue marriages that had once stood as the coast's own proof of a hundred years' living together had all but stopped being written down at all. The marriages themselves went on; only the writing of them had failed, because no custodian any longer trusted the Administration's court with it.

Thomas understood, by the second year, that his own suit, brought in good faith to save one narrow seam his family had cut for four generations, had become the very door through which the Company had walked to take eleven others, and he never afterward spoke of the case without some version of the same plain reckoning: that he had gone to Ros dhomhain to ask a court to honour his grandmother's marriage, and had come home having taught it, instead, exactly how to use that marriage against every family on the coast that had made one like it.

VI

Of the Lamp-Watch and Griogair mac Ailein

It was in the third year after the ruling, in the winter of the hundred and thirteenth, that word reached Baile dhìreach of a fellowship newly begun among the pit crews of Baile thais and Cnoc chaol, calling itself no more than a burial club, the kind of quiet society that put a little of every member's wage aside against the cost of a decent burying, of which there were a dozen along that coast already and nothing remarkable in one more. Thomas Hale, who had by then

some name among the coast's custodians as a man who understood, better than most, exactly how far the Administration's law would and would not reach, was asked by a letter from Baile thais, carried by a carter who said little about who had sent it, whether he would come and speak for a man of the club who had died in the Company's lock-up at Cnoc chaol, and whose burying the club meant to see done properly, in the Company's own eye as well as the district's.

The man was Griogair mac Ailein, a breaker of some sixty years who had worked the sorting-floor at Cnoc chaol since before the pits there had needed a night shift, and who had been taken up by the Company's watchmen in the autumn of that year for a matter the letter described only as a dispute over short weight at the pay office, and had died in the lock-up before any hearing was set for him, of a fever the Company's own surgeon recorded as already advanced when he was taken. He had no family living to claim him, and the club, gathering what it could from its members' wages, had bought the ground and the box and asked only that someone stand at the graveside who could read, aloud, in the Company's own tongue, the surgeon's note releasing the body, so that no clerk afterward could say the burying had been done without the Company's own leave.

The man who carried the letter to Baile dhìreach, a crew-leader of Baile thais named Dòmhnall Ruadh, said little of Griogair mac Ailein beyond the plain facts of the dispute, a matter of a short-weighted cartload the pay clerk had charged against him and Griogair had refused, in words the clerk did not care to repeat afterward, to sign for; but he said a good deal, walking the last mile up to Cnoc chaol at Thomas's side, of why the club wanted the surgeon's note read openly and not merely filed. "A man who dies owing the Company money," Dòmhnall said, "is a man the Company is glad enough to forget, and forgetting is a cheap way to be rid of a debt. We mean the pay office to know he was buried honestly, and that somebody stood at the grave who could read what was owed him back." Thomas asked what, precisely, was owed a dead man, and Dòmhnall said only that a name entered correctly, and a note read aloud, and a stone that would carry his name after the club that raised it had itself been forgotten, were the whole of what the Lamp-Watch could promise anyone yet, and that they had learned, the hard way, not to promise more.

Thomas walked the four days to Cnoc chaol in the last week of am Faoilleach, in weather no better than the winter that had carried his own suit to its ruling, and stood at a grave dug on the bare hill above the pit-head with some thirty men and women of the club around him, most of them pit crews he had never met,

drawn from a fellowship he understood, standing there, to be a good deal more than a burial club, though nobody that day said so aloud and he did not ask. He read the surgeon's note in the flat, careful humans' tongue his grandfather had taught him as a boy, folded it, and gave it to the man beside him, who he learned afterward was one of those who had first proposed the club and had chosen, for reasons of his own that Thomas never asked after either, to call it the Lamp-Watch among its own members and nothing so plain as a burial club at all, though the name it gave the Company's clerks stayed the same.

No one else in that company that day could have read the paper Thomas held, and he understood, standing at the grave's edge with the thin cold wind coming off the pit-head and the box already lowered, what his own hard winter at Ros dhomhain had left him. The seam was the Company's now, and the eleven cuttings had gone the same road behind it. What remained was a plain skill, bought at the cost of a ruling that had taught him exactly how little the Administration's law honoured any custom, and it was worth more, standing at a stranger's grave, to the men and women around him than any cutting on any hill had ever been.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

Of the Night Shift

AE 114 – 120

I

Of the Man Who Spoke It Badly

Robert Haskins left Ros dhomhain on a wet morning in an t-Ògmhios of the hundred and fourteenth year, over a quarrel with the Company about the price of a steamship berth, a matter so small that the custodians who watched him go could not afterward agree what it had been. He had held the Residency sixteen years and never once, in sixteen years, said a full sentence in Dia-

thìris without a clerk at his elbow to mend it. He went down to the quay in a coat too heavy for the season, sixty-nine years old and glad, by every report, to be leaving, and the ship that took him stood off Ros dhomhain until the tide served and was gone by evening.

His successor came up from the same quay eleven days later, and half the town turned out to look at him, because Edward Vane was a thing Ros dhomhain had not seen before: a Commissioner who had been born there. Not born in an Tìr Thall¹ and sent over grown, as every Commissioner before him had been, but born at the Residency, four-and-forty years before, to a mother who had crossed the water once and never again and a father who had crossed it only the once and stayed. He had a Dia-thìreach nurse as a child, the custodians said, and had run barefoot on the strand at Ros dhomhain with the fisher-children before anyone thought to stop him, and something of that had stayed in his mouth, because when he stepped down onto the quay and the custodian of the port made him the customary greeting, he answered it. Badly. The tenses came out wrong, and he put the stress on the last syllable of every word the way the humans do, and afterward opinion was divided for a season on whether he had wished the custodian a fair wind or a long life, since the two are one letter apart in the mouth of a man who has not troubled to learn the difference. But he had answered, in Dia-thìris, unprompted, with no clerk beside him, and no Commissioner had done that in living memory.

He went up to Cathair dhearg himself that autumn, which Haskins had done twice in sixteen years and both times under summons. Comhairle a' Chùrain² sat for him in the crown's place, the high custodian's seat empty still, as it had been empty nine years, and Vane stood before the council in the humans' good coat with his hat in his two hands and spoke to them in their own tongue for the length of three sentences before his nerve or his grammar failed him and he finished in the humans' speech through the Mission's interpreter. What he said, in the part that was his own, was that he had come home. The council's clerk wrote the sentence down exactly as he gave it, wrong tense and all, because it was the first time in the roll's memory that a Commissioner had used the word at all, home, of the island, and whatever else Vane proved to be, the clerk thought that worth the ink.

He kept a room at the Residency that Haskins had never used, a small chamber off the counting-house with a shelf of the Mission's Dia-thìris grammars in it,

worn at the spine from a boyhood's handling, and in the evenings of his first winter he was known to sit with a clerk and a lesson-book like a schoolboy twice the age of any schoolboy, going over the cases of a language he had spoken badly since the cradle and never once been made to speak well. The clerks who taught him said afterward that he learned slowly and minded being corrected less than any human they had taught before or since, which they took, in their different ways, either as a mark in his favour or as proof that a man born on the island, however he had been raised, could never quite be brought to feel the shame of it that a man sent out fresh from an Tír Thall felt on his first mangled sentence.

He was not loved for it. A custodian of the eastern hills, an old woman past her eightieth year who had buried three husbands and outlived two Commissioners already, said within Vane's own hearing, in Dia-thìris too quick for him to follow, that a wolf raised among the sheep is still a wolf, and worse for knowing the sheep's own bleat. The saying went round the coal towns before winter and outlasted the man it was said of. But he had answered the greeting, and he went on, in the years that followed, answering more of them, and the custodians who kept the rolls could not decide, then or later, whether that made him easier to deal with or only easier to resent, since a wrong done in your own tongue by a man who has troubled to learn it cuts different from a wrong done at a clerk's remove, though it is not, in the end, a different wrong.

II

Of the Iron Road and the Order That Followed It

Vane's first year of building was the tram-road, an iron track laid on wooden sleepers from the southern workings down to the coal port at Ros dhìreach, drawn by mule teams the Company shipped in from an Tír Thall¹ in crates that stank the length of the quay. It cost the Company less in a season to move coal by the tram than it had cost by cart in ten, and it cost the carters of the old coal road their whole trade inside two years; the villages that had lived on the carting, small places with no name the maps had ever troubled to learn, emptied a household at a time down toward the pits, where there was work still,

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

2. the Council of Custodians; lit. 'the council of the custody'

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

of a kind. The tram-road opened without ceremony on a morning of an t-Iuchar in his second year, a string of mule-carts running loaded for the first time down the grade that generations of carters had walked with their own backs bent to it, and the custodian who wrote the day into the roll noted only the weight carried and the hour, thirty tons by the third bell, and nothing of the road it had put out of work, for a custodian's roll counts what moves, not what stops moving.

It was Vane, too, who signed the order that came down from the Residency in an Lùnastal of the year after and was read out at every pit-mouth from Cnoc chaol to Muileann chiar by an overseer standing on an upturned crate: that the digging was thenceforward to run without ceasing, day following night following day, and no season of it given over to rest at all. The order named no reason. The Company's own letter-book, which the custodians never saw, gave the true reason plainly enough, that the tram-road had made it cheap to move more coal than the day shifts alone could cut, and idle rails cost the Company money the way idle hands never had.

The custodian of Cnoc chaol, a narrow camp of new galleries in the hills above Muileann dhomhain, wrote the order into her roll in the hand she used for weather and for deaths, and then wrote under it a single line and left the rest of the page blank: *the bill is given no silence at all*. She was a young woman, new to the roll that year, and an older custodian who read it afterward said she had never seen a page left so bare on purpose, as though the custodian judged that anything more she might add would only crowd out the one true thing the page had to say.

III

Of the Two Shifts and the Week It Lasted

The night shift at Cnoc chaol worked by coal-lamp, small clay bodies with a wick and a horn window that threw a light the crews said was worse than none at all, for it showed a man just enough of the gallery to trust it and not enough to see what the trust cost him. Two shifts split the day and the dark between them, twelve hours each, with an hour at each changeover when both crews were below together and the air in the deep galleries, thin already, had to serve twice the lungs it had ever been asked to serve before.

The crews bore it through a winter, and in the summer after they refused it. There was no vote taken that the custodian's roll records, no meeting called under

any name; the day shift simply did not go down when the bell rang for the night change, and stood instead in the yard above the pit-mouth in the last of the daylight, a hundred men and women with nothing in their hands, saying nothing to the overseer who came out to ask them what they thought they were about. He asked it twice. The second time somebody at the back of the crowd, a hewer nobody afterward would name to the overseer's face, said that the hill had never yet been dug in the dark by anyone who meant to keep digging it, and the crowd took up no chant and made no threat and simply did not move, which an overseer used to threats did not know how to answer.

The Company answered it in a week with crews brought up from the coast towns under new contracts, humans mostly, dockers and out-of-work carters glad of a wage the coast no longer offered steadily, and Dia-thìrich from camps far enough off that the word of the stand at Cnoc chaol had not yet reached them plainly. They came up the tram-road in the same mule-carts that carried the coal down it, and were set to the night shift within two days of arriving, and the crews of Cnoc chaol who had stood in the yard went back to the day shift they still had, because a stand that costs a household its whole wage inside a fortnight is not a stand a household can afford to keep making, whatever it costs the hill.

Muileann dhomhain, the milling town two hours' walk below Cnoc chaol on the road to the coast, would not house them. Every door in the town, the custodian's roll says, plainly and more than once, for the custodian who kept it seems to have taken some pride in the counting: every door was shut to the new crews, the inns would not bed them, the millers would not sell them meal at the counter, and the well at the crossroads, the only water on that stretch of road that did not belong to some household's own yard, was found blocked with stones on the second morning by no hand the custodian troubled to guess at. The Company's overseers housed the new crews in barns of the Company's own outside the town, and several of the newcomers, humans and Dia-thìrich alike, went home to the coast before the season was out, unable to say afterward, when asked, exactly what had driven them, only that a town that will not sell a man his bread is a hard town to work beside for wages that were never generous to begin with.

The Lamp-Watch, the fellowship of pit crews that had begun four years before under cover of a burial club, at Baile thais and at Cnoc chaol both, kept the households of the men and women who had stood in the yard through that first week and the season after, out of a purse built a penny at a time from crews who could ill spare the penny. By the second winter the purse was empty. The society's

own reckoning, kept in a hand nobody has since put a name to, closes the account for that year with a line that gives the sum remaining, nothing, and under it, in the same hand, a second line that says only that the hill was not given back its silence, which was not, whatever else it was, an accounting entry, and the custodian who copied the reckoning years later left it standing all the same.

IV

Of the Sermon at Ros dhomhain

Matthew Dunne had held the Mission's chapel at Ros dhomhain three years when the night-shift order came down, a narrow young man of one-and-thirty with a Dia-thiris better than any minister the Mission had sent before him and a temper, his own bishop said of him once, better suited to a soldier than a priest. He had walked the coal towns in his first year the way Walter Crane had once walked the sick-rows of the Green Death, on his own feet and without an overseer beside him, and had come to know the camps better than any human at the Residency, Vane not excepted.

He preached against the order on the humans' rest-day in an t-Ògmhios of the hundred and eighteenth year, when it was two years old and the stand at Cnoc chaol a year gone; and when word of it reached Cnoc chaol and Muileann dhomhain inside a fortnight, it did not go quiet. Standing that morning in the chapel pulpit at Ros dhomhain before a congregation half of it Company clerks and half of it dockers, he said, in the humans' own tongue so that no clerk could later claim to have misheard him through an interpreter, that the Dia-thìrich were right in the thing they had not been given leave to say for themselves: that the ground the Company dug was owed a season of quiet the same as any ground the humans' own scripture called holy, and that a people who would not let their own fields lie fallow a year in seven had no right to ask a hill to give more. The whole chapel knew what he meant without his naming it.

He had written the sermon three times before he stood up to give it, his housekeeper said afterward, and burned two drafts in the grate, and on the morning of the sermon he walked the strand below the chapel for an hour before the bell, alone, in a wind off the water that took his hat twice, and came in with salt on his coat and his text unchanged from the second burning. He was afraid, he told the housekeeper once, years after and from the other side of the water, not of

the Company's answer, which he had judged rightly from the first, but of standing in a pulpit built by the Mission's own money and telling the men who paid for it that they had misread their own scripture; a fear, he said, that a soldier does not carry into a battle he has already decided to lose.

The Company's agent at Ros dhomhain wrote to the Mission's own house in an Tír Thall¹ within the month, and the letter, which a clerk copied before it went and which found its way years later into the same roll that keeps the custodians' counts, called the sermon an interference in matters the cloth had no competence in and asked, plainly, that the minister be recalled before his words did the Company more harm than his ministry did it good. The Mission, which depended on the Company's ships for every letter and every year's stores that crossed the water, recalled him inside the season. He preached a last sermon at Ros dhomhain at the end of that same year, three-and-thirty years old, to a chapel fuller than it had ever been in his three years, and said nothing in it of the night shift at all, only the ordinary words for a minister's leaving, and went down to the same quay Haskins had gone down from four years before, in the same wet weather, though nobody who watched him go thought the two departures were alike in anything but the rain.

The Lamp-Watch had a copy of the sermon inside the week, taken down, it was always said afterward though never proved, by a Company clerk who had sat in the chapel and did not care to give his own name to the copying. It went from Baile thais to Cnoc chaol to Muileann chlar in the space of a season, read aloud in the camps of an evening by whoever among the crews could read well enough to be trusted with it, and the line the crews kept longest of the whole sermon was the one about the fallow year, which passed into the coal towns' own speech soon after as a saying that owed nothing, by the time it had been said a hundred times over, to the minister who first gave it words.

V

Of Donnchadh's Cough

A wasting sickness of the lungs came into the night crews of Cnoc chaol and Baile thais the same winter the sermon was preached, and stayed three

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

years. It was not the Green Death; it killed slowly, over a season or two, a cough that would not clear and a weight the sick could not keep on and a colour to the skin that was grey rather than green, and it took the humans of the crews first and hardest, the dockers and carters brought up from the coast, whose own country's pits had killed their fathers the same way before they ever crossed the water to find a hill that would kill them too.

The Dia-thirich hewers coughed as hard through that winter, working the same galleries in the same lamp-lit dark, and the Mission's own physician, a careful man named Colquhoun who had come out after Anne Colby's years and kept her habit of writing plainly, set the same word against their names in his book that he set against the humans'. But the custodians' roll, which knew every hewer of Cnoc chaol by name and had known most of their mothers, kept its own separate count, and the count said a different thing: that of the Dia-thirich who coughed that winter, few died of it, though the cough lasted as hard and as long as any human's.

The old women of the camps knew the telling of the hewer of Achadh dhomhain whose cough had stopped on the night his daughter was born. They called any such cough among the Dia-thirich crews Donnchadh's cough, and would say no more. The Company, for its part, paid the widows of the dead a pension for a year and then stopped, the pension being, the agent's letter says without apology, a matter of the Company's grace and not of any debt owed.

VI

Of Iain Maor's Letter

Iain Maor had kept the staff of the overseers at Muileann chrom two-and-thirty years, since he was seven-and-thirty, and had buried a wife and raised a daughter in the slate-roofed house above the mill that came with the staff, and at nine-and-sixty, the winter the night-shift order fell hardest on his own galleries, he did a thing no overseer of Muileann chrom had done in the office's whole history: he wrote to the Company that its own order was costing it more than it gained.

He wrote it in the humans' tongue, in the schooled hand the Mission had given him as a boy, and he did not soften it. The night shift, he wrote, was killing his crews faster than the coal they cut in the dark was paying the Company back,

counting the cost of every dead man's training against a new one, the wage lost to every widow's household falling onto the parish and the Mission both, and the slower cutting of tired crews working by coal-lamp against crews that had once worked the same seams by daylight and rested. He signed it with his own name and the office's, and sent it down with the ordinary post, and heard nothing for two months.

His daughter Mòrag, four-and-twenty that winter and already keeping her father's own daybook for him in a hand steadier than his had ever been, was the one who found the answer when it came: a notice from the Residency, unlike any reply to a letter she had ever copied for him, that Iain Maor, overseer at Muileann chrom, was relieved of the staff for conduct unbecoming his office. She read it to him at the kitchen table by lamplight, and he heard it out without a word and then asked her, when she had finished, to read it again, and she did, and he said only that he had known the answer would come dressed as something other than itself, and went to bed.

He had known the letter would cost him something even as he sealed it, he told Mòrag that same evening; a man who has kept a Company's staff two-and-thirty years learns to read the shape of an answer before it comes, the way a hewer learns the sound a roof will make before it falls. She asked him why he had written it all the same, and he said only that a true thing costs the same to say whether it is answered honestly or not, and that a man who waits to speak until the cost is nothing has generally waited until the thing is no longer worth the saying.

The dismissal did not stand a month. There was no other overseer at Muileann chrom the Company trusted with the galleries, and the crews, who had heard within a day what had been done to him, worked the next fortnight at a pace so far below what the night shift demanded that the Company's own agent wrote up the road that the pits could not be run without him. The second notice came unsigned by anyone above a clerk's rank, restoring him to the staff with no mention made of the first notice at all, as though the office had simply forgotten, for a season, that it had ever taken the staff from him. Iain Maor kept both notices together in the same drawer, the dismissal and the restoration, ready to hand to anyone at his table who asked how the Company answered a true thing said to it plainly; and his letter, folded in with the dismissal that had answered it, survives in the Company's own files for that reason alone, filed by a clerk who thought the two papers belonged together and never troubled to think why.

VII

Of the Iron Chariot

The potteries of Baile ghorm took the Company's contract for lamp-bodies in the spring the tram-road opened, thousands of clay bodies fired in a season, each with its horn window and its wick-hole turned on the same wheel that had turned bowls and pipkins for the coast trade a generation before. The potters' own book, kept as carefully as any custodian's roll though nobody at the Residency thought to call it one, notes that theirs were the first lamps made on the island for work commanded in the dark, and sets the number fired against the number of days, a column of figures that grows through that spring and does not shrink again.

Vane lived long enough to see the tram-road's true purpose finished. In am Màrt of the hundred and twentieth year the Company's iron road opened from the pits at Muileann chrom, down past the hill below Cathair dhearg, to the deep-water quay at Ros dhomhain, a proper railway of iron rail and a coal-burn-ing engine, and the mule-drawn tram to Ros dhìreach was left, from that day, to the mules and to whatever coal the southern workings still had cause to send that way. Iain Maor stood at the pit-mouth at Muileann chrom on the morning the first loaded train went down, his daughter beside him, seventy years old and the staff back in his hand a season after it had briefly left it, and watched the engine take the grade that the tram-mules had taken at a walk, at a pace no mule had ever kept, trailing a smoke the colour of the hill itself.

The crews at the pit-mouth had no word yet for the thing. By the day's end they had made one, calling it carbad-iarainn, the iron chariot, and calling the road it ran on the coal line, and both names outlasted every name the Company's own letter-book ever gave either. Mòrag, watching the smoke go down the valley toward Ros dhomhain and the sea beyond it, asked her father what he thought the engine would mean for the crews, now that the coal could travel faster than any crew that cut it ever would again, and Iain Maor, who had buried more of those crews in two-and-thirty years than he had ever troubled to count, said only that a thing which can carry more, faster, is a thing that will be asked to carry more, faster, and that the hill had not yet been asked the last of what it had to give. He did not live to see how far that answer would run. His daughter did, and kept it, in the years after, the way she kept most of what he told her at the pit-mouth that spring: filed away, unspoken, until the day it was needed.

CHAPTER THIRTY

OF the Cellar at Muileann chaol

AE 121 – 126

I

Of the Second Birth

In an Gearran of the hundred and twenty-first year a second child was born who did not take after the way of children, and word of it went up the east road in a season, from mouth to mouth, the way such word goes among a people who cannot write it down themselves and must trust it to carriers. His name was Fionnan. The custodians who kept the eastern rolls set down the birth and no more beside it, for there was no more that could yet be told; but every one of them who had heard, fifty years before, what the camps said of a girl called Aisling understood, on the reading of that single line, that the thing was no longer a wonder of one house. A wonder that happens once is a wonder. A wonder that happens twice is a question, and a question, once it is asked, does not go quietly back to sleep.

At Muileann chaol, where this telling is set down, the news reached the cellar in the ordinary way that all news reached it: folded small inside a roll of births and burials that a rider brought in on a wet evening, indistinguishable to look at from the fifty rolls before it and the fifty after. Nobody in the cellar that year thought to mark the page. It was only later, when the word had a name and the name had a use, that the copyists went back through the year's rolls to find the line again, and were a long while finding it, because it had been written the same size as every other line on the page.

II

Of the Town and the Loft

Muileann chaol stands on the eastern slope where the mill road crosses the burn twice within a bowshot, a narrow town that had made the island's first paper from rags in an older age, and had gone on making it in a small way ever since, more from habit than from any great custom for the stuff. It was known east of the capital chiefly for one thing that had nothing to do with paper at all: the loft over the old mill, where a mill-owner's widow named Beathag nic Thòmais had once stacked the copies she bought up from houses that no longer read them, and left the loft and all that was in it to the town on the single condition that nothing kept there should ever be burned. The town had kept that condition longer than any of the families now living in it could trace their own descent, and since the strangers came the custodian houses of the east had grown into the habit of sending to the loft anything they wished to be certain of, since the Residency's writ did not reach into an old woman's roof-space over a paper mill, whatever else it reached.

Cailean mac Eachainn had grown up under that roof without ever once climbing the ladder to it. His father cut turf on the hill above the town; his mother wove the coarse grey cloth that Muileann chaol sold at the coast markets before the barter went out of the old towns' hands. He was a plain hand at his letters, no better and no worse than any boy who had sat through the winter months at the custodian's fire learning them, and he had thought, as far as he had thought about it at all, that he would cut turf as his father did, and grow old on the same hill, and be buried, in the end, under it.

What changed that was not the loft, which had stood over the town all his life and asked nothing of him, but the cellar, which had not.

III

Of the Three Households

In am Màrt of the hundred and twenty-fourth year, at the end of a winter that had closed the coast road with drift, three families of Muileann chaol, the mac Ailpeins, the nic Rìghs, and the household of an old widow named

Seònaig Bhàn, took in more work than they had ever taken before, and it came from the east.

The custodians of the eastern hills, from Cnoc thais down to the shore below Dùn thais, had begun that winter to send copies of their rolls to Muileann chaol for the keeping, over and above whatever they had always sent to the loft. It was not, at the start, spoken of as anything more than good housekeeping: a custodian's roll, kept in one thin book in one damp custodian's house, could be lost to fire or flood or the plain wearing of the years in a way that three copies, kept in three different houses in a town the Residency had no cause to visit, could not. But a roll copied is a roll read, twice over, once by the hand that first wrote it and once by the hand that copies it fair; and three households reading, winter on winter, the whole record of the eastern hills, every birth and burial, every marriage with its seven names, every fine and fever and every shift lost to the Company's pits, came in time to know that record better than any single custodian who kept only his own corner of it ever could.

They worked in the cellar under Seònaig Bhàn's house, because it was the driest of the three and had a chimney that drew well even in the worst weather, and because Seònaig herself, being past the age for close copying, kept the peat going and the ink from freezing and fed whoever was at the table, which by the second winter was five or six people at a time. It became, without anyone deciding it should, the place the work was done, and the loft above the mill the place the finished copies went when they were done with; and the town, which had one word for the whole arrangement long before the Residency ever heard of it, called it simply an Seilear, the cellar.

Cailean was four-and-twenty when the copying began, a turf-cutter's son with a plain hand at his letters and no other prospects, when Seònaig Bhàn's own eyes began to fail her past the point of close work, and the three households, needing a hand that could be trusted with rolls no stranger's eye was meant to see, sent for him.

He remembered afterward that he had gone to the cellar the first evening expecting to be asked whether he could write a fair hand, and had been asked instead whether he could hold his tongue. That he could do. They gave him a corner of the table, a good pen, and the roll of a village he had never heard of, and told him to copy it exactly as it stood, mistakes and all, for a copy that corrected its original was worth less than the paper it was written on.

He was slow, that first winter, and made the ink run twice, and Seònaig Bhàn scolded him for it in a voice gone thin with age but no gentler for that. By the second winter he was as fast as any hand at the table, and had learned, the way every copyist learns without being told, that a roll of births and burials read a hundred times over stops being a list and becomes something closer to the shape of the place it comes from: which families were dying out, which taking in strangers, which custodian's hand was failing along with his eyes, which village had gone three years without a marriage worth the name.

IV

Of the Count of the People

Two years before the copying began, word went round the east that the Administration had ordered a count made of every soul on the island, the first such count in the memory of anyone then living, and that its officers were riding out from Ros dhomhain with books and questions to every district in turn.

The count that came back, when the copies of it reached the cellar the following year among the Residency's other business that the custodians thought worth keeping a record of, was a strange document to read fair. For the humans of the coast towns and the concession farms it gave a number to the household, close as a tally of sheep: so many souls under this roof, so many under that. For the Diathìrich of the same district it gave a number rounded to the nearest hundred, and further inland, where the hill villages ran together in the Administration's own maps into districts with names its officers had half invented, rounded to the nearest thousand.

"They count us the way a man counts trees," said Fearchar mac Ailpein, whose household had taken in the count among the rest of that winter's copying, laying the sheet down on the cellar table. "Near enough for the timber. Not near enough for the names."

Cailean, copying beside him, thought of the roll he had just set down, the roll of a village of forty-one souls that the Administration's own count gave as a round hundred, and said nothing, because there was nothing in it worth saying that the sheet had not already said for itself.

The same officers, riding the west and the outer islands that same season, had set the whole of the far coasts, Eilean bhàn, and the wind-scoured shore below the great moss that no chain of theirs could cross, and the harbour town of Seann Vell on Eilean ruadh where their revenue boats lay, into a single district ruled from Seann Vell itself, for want, the custodians' letters said, of anywhere closer that the Administration cared to build an office. The cellar's copies of that letter noted, in a hand Cailean came to know as Fearchar's, that the surveyors had walked the edge of the moss, found no way across it, and left the rest of the district's map blank; and that the custodians of those coasts, being no readier to be counted by a stranger's chain than the moss itself, had let them.

V

Of the Death of the Last Teacher

In an Lùnastal of the hundred and twenty-third year, word came down from Dùn thais that Seònaid nic Dhùghaill was dead, in her seventy-eighth year, and that the school she had kept was closed with her.

She had been, for longer than anyone at the cellar's table could remember hearing otherwise, the last master of the Deer to teach openly in that age: the last to sit under the trees at Dùn thais with pupils in a ring around her and speak the philosophy of the schools aloud, in the hearing of whoever wished to stop and listen, as the schools had always taught before the Residency and the Mission between them made open teaching a thing best done quietly or not at all. She had gone on doing it for years after the last hall was shut and the last public disputation forbidden, on the grounds, she was reported to have said, that a philosophy that could not survive a Commissioner's displeasure had never been worth the keeping in the first place.

Cailean had never heard her teach. He had only heard of her the way a young man in a cellar hears of most things, at second hand, through a roll that another man's pen had already made history of before it reached his table: her death entered in the Dùn thais custodian's hand, plain as any other death that year, and beneath it, in the same hand, a line that said the register of her school ended with her name and would not be continued, there being none left of her house or her pupils willing to keep it in the open.

"They'll take it up again," said Fearchar, "when the strangers are gone."

"When will that be," said Cailean, not really asking, and copied the line as it stood, for a copy that corrected its original was worth less than the paper it was written on, and the register's silence was as much a part of the record as anything ever written in it.

VI

Of the Copies Gone Astray

It was in the spring of the hundred and twenty-fifth year that the cellar first learned there was a second Muileann chaol.

It stood some hours to the north along the same eastern hills, a smaller place by every account, its whole population not so many as one good village of the coast; but it shared the name letter for letter, and more than one rider coming down from the northern custodian houses with a chest of rolls for the cellar had, over the years, asked the road to the wrong town and been told it plainly enough by carters who saw no reason to ask why a stranger with a locked chest wanted either.

Fearchar found the first of the misdirected copies by chance, going through a bundle newly arrived and finding among it a receipt, in a northern custodian's hand, for a delivery the cellar had never made and a roll the cellar had never received. He took it round the table without a word and let each of the others read it in turn. Seònaig Bhàn, past copying but not past thinking, said only that a mistake three years old was a mistake worth mending before it became four years old, and looked at Cailean.

He went north on foot in am Cèitean, with a letter of the three households' own seal and nothing else, for there was nothing to carry until he found what there was to carry. It took him the better part of a day to reach the smaller Muileann chaol, along a road that climbed twice as high as it needed to and came down again for no better reason than the shape of the hill, and he arrived footsore and in no mood to be careful of anyone's feelings, custodian or carter.

He need not have worried. The custodian who met him at the northern town's door, an old man with a squint and a temper that had gone soft with disuse, showed him into a room no larger than Seònaig Bhàn's own cellar and produced, from a chest under a bench, every roll the cellar at the true Muileann chaol had been missing for the better part of three years, sorted by year and tied with a

cord, dry, unburned, and kept, the old man said with something close to pride, every bit as well as they'd have been kept anywhere else, mistake or no mistake.

"You could have sent word," said Cailean, not unkindly, for the old man plainly meant it as a kindness done rather than a wrong admitted.

"To who?" said the custodian. "Nobody told us we had what wasn't ours. We only knew we had rolls, and a roll's a roll. You keep it dry and you keep it whole and you wait for someone to come and say it's theirs." He tied the last cord himself, with hands that shook a little at the work, and handed the bundle over. "Well. Someone's come."

Cailean carried the whole of it back south on his own shoulders in two days, sleeping the one night at a hill farm that took him in for a story of the road, and reached the cellar at Muileann chaol with his feet raw and the chest of copies unopened, exactly as he had received it, for a copyist who broke a seal that was not his to break was no copyist the three households wanted at their table. Fearchar broke it for him, that same evening, and the two of them and Seònaig Bhàn went through three years of the north's own record by lamplight, matching what had been missing against what the cellar had pieced together from other hands in the meantime, and found, to their considerable relief, that nothing of any weight had been lost after all. It had only been kept in the wrong cellar for a while.

"It is a strange thing," said Fearchar, when the last roll was matched and put away, "to think how much of what we call lost is only misplaced, and how much of what we call found was never really gone."

Cailean, whose feet hurt too much that night for philosophy, said that he would rather it were all in one cellar to begin with, and went to bed.

VII

Of the Change, and What the Years Would Not Do

Through all of this the copyists at the cellar table went on doing what copyists had always done with the thing that had no name.

It had been in the rolls, here and there, since before any of the three households were born to the work: a birth entered like any other birth, and beside it, in one hand or another, a mark, or a word set apart, that meant a custodian had noticed something in the child that he did not have a word to set down properly. Cailean had copied such lines himself, that first winter and every winter since, and

had learned, as every hand at the table learned, that the custodians who wrote them wrote around the thing rather than at it, the way a man walks around standing water in the dark rather than say plainly that he cannot see the bottom of it. *The child does not grow as she should. He is much as he was at his naming, though four winters are past. She is called by the camp nighean an rìgh, though on what ground the roll does not say.* Cailean had heard the camps' own word for it too, from carters who had it from other carters, the kind of word boys use for a thing they are half afraid of and wholly certain will never touch them: Aisling-aois, they called the state of her, the age of Aisling, though nobody at the cellar's table had ever set that down in any hand that mattered.

It was, by the year of Fionnan's birth, thirty years and more since the first child had shown it and been written round in that fashion, and now there were two, and the custodians who had gone on writing round the thing for thirty years began, in ones and twos, to say in their letters to the cellar that a thing seen twice wanted a name a physician could enter in a column, whatever a teller might call it by the fire.

Cailean read a dozen such letters that winter and the next, in a dozen hands, each circling the same want from a different side, and none of them settling it. He asked Fearchar once, late at a table with the peat gone low, whether the three households ought to put a word of their own forward, since they had read more of the record than any custodian living. Fearchar said no, and said it hard enough that Cailean did not ask again. "We copy what is decided," he said. "We do not decide it. A cellar that starts deciding what the rolls should say stops being a cellar anyone can trust."

VIII

Of the Call to Cill ghlas

The letter that settled it came to the cellar in am Faoilleach of the hundred and twenty-sixth year, from the custodian of Cill ghlas, a woman named Peigi Ghlas whose hand Cailean knew well from years of her own eastern roll, small and upright and given to underlining the word that mattered most in any sentence she wrote.

She had called, the letter said, every custodian within two days' walk of Cill ghlas to meet at the shrine there on the night of the coming full moon, at the

mouth of the oldest cutting on the hill, where Brìde's lamp had burned since before any of them had a roll to keep; and she asked, further, that the cellar send a hand who could write a fair copy on the spot, since the custodians who would be there were, in her own words, more used to arguing than to agreeing, and a decision arrived at in the dark by candlelight and not written down clean before the company dispersed was a decision that would be argued over again within the year.

Seònaig Bhàn looked at the letter a long while and then looked at Cailean, who was the youngest hand at the table and had the steadiest by then, and said that it was his to carry, if he was willing.

He was willing, though he did not say, walking west the following week with a folding writing-board strapped to his back and a stock of good paper wrapped against the weather, quite how much he minded the cold of a hill shrine in am Faoilleach, or how far Cill ghlais lay from anywhere a fire could be had along the way. He slept the one night at a custodian's house on the road and reached the shrine the next evening with the light already failing and the wind coming hard off the moor.

They came up the path in ones and twos through the last of the dusk, custodians he knew by their hands and had never before seen by their faces, cloaks steaming where the walk had warmed them and the cold struck through again the moment they stopped: an old man from Cnoc thais who had to be helped the last stretch of the climb; two sisters from villages on either side of the same burn who had walked separately and arrived within a minute of each other and seemed put out by it; Peigi Ghlais herself, last of all, small and upright as her hand, with a lantern that she set by the lamp at the cutting's mouth so that the two flames stood together, one old beyond telling and one carried up the hill in her own fist.

The oldest cutting still stood open in the hillside behind the shrine, black-mouthed, the timber at its lip gone soft and silvered with age, and all around it in the dark, under the wind, Cailean could hear the pumps of the Company's newer galleries lower down the slope, working on through the night the way they worked every night now, for the hill, since the order went out, was given no season of rest at all.

He set his board on his knee at the edge of the group, near enough to hear, far enough not to be in anyone's way, and dipped his pen, and waited.

IX

Of the Naming

They sat on the benches of the shrine with their cloaks steaming and argued, as Peigi Ghlas had promised they would, for the better part of two hours before anything was decided at all.

Some wanted an old word, one out of the tellings, a word with weight already in it, so that whoever bore it would be seen for what the tellings said such children were. Peigi Ghlas herself spoke hardest against that. "An old word carries an old story with it, whether we mean it to or no," she said, "and the story it would carry is one we have not finished telling ourselves, let alone a child of five winters." Others wanted no word at all, arguing that a name is a door, and that a thing without a door could not be walked through by the Residency's clerks or the Mission's physicians or anyone else who might, given a word to hang a report on, hang more on it than the word was ever meant to carry. The man from Cnoc thais, who had said little on the climb up, said that a physician would write a word down whether the custodians gave him one or not, and that it was better the word came from a shrine than from a stranger's ledger.

It was full dark by the time the arguing narrowed. In the end it was one of the sisters from the burn villages, a woman Cailean never did learn the name of, who put forward the word that held: the plainest word there was, she said, fit for nothing grander than a physician's column, with no song in it and no story attached that any teller could make more of than the two words themselves already said. Fuil-ghuail. Coal-blood.

There was a silence after it long enough that Cailean, waiting with his pen above the paper, began to think it had failed, the way a proposal fails in a room grown tired of arguing, simply by not being taken up. Then Peigi Ghlas said that she, for one, could enter it in her own roll tomorrow without shame, and asked for a show of hands.

Cailean counted them by lamplight as they went up, dark shapes against the paler dark of the hillside, and there were more raised than not, though not every hand in the company went up, and nobody asked those that stayed down to account for themselves.

"Fuil-ghuail," said Peigi Ghlas, when the hands were down again, the way a custodian repeats a decided thing to fix it in the record. "Coal-blood, for the humans' books, if they must have it in their own tongue. Let it be entered so."

Nobody moved to argue it further. The pumps went on working somewhere below them in the dark, and the wind came round the mouth of the old cutting and made the two lamps gutter together and steady again, and one by one the custodians got up from the benches, stiff with the cold and the sitting, and began the walk back down to whatever fire waited for them at the bottom of the hill.

Cailean stayed a moment longer than the rest, because Peigi Ghlas had asked him to, and because the thing was not yet finished until it was written.

She dictated it to him there at the mouth of the cutting, by the two lamps, in the plain words a physician's register wanted and none other: that on that night, at that shrine, the custodians present had agreed a name for the change that had come twice now upon a child born of the pits, and that the name was *fuil-ghuail*¹, and that it was to be entered so in every roll that had cause to speak of it from that day forward, in the custodians' hand or, where the Residency's clerks required it, in the humans' tongue as coal-touched.

He wrote it in the fair, careful hand the cellar had taught him, the ink slow to dry in the cold, and read it back to her once before she would let him close the board. She listened with her eyes on the old lamp rather than on him, and when he had finished she said only that it would do, and that he had best get down off the hill before the paper froze in his hand and the pen with it.

He walked back to Muileann chaol over two days with the board strapped to his back exactly as he had carried it up, and gave the leaf, when he reached the cellar, to Fearchar to copy fair a second time for the loft, as every leaf of any weight was copied fair a second time before it was trusted to the years. Fearchar read it through once, in silence, and then read it again, and said nothing at all about the word itself, only that the hand was good and the ink had held despite the cold, which was, from Fearchar, as near to praise as a copyist's work ever got.

It was Cailean's own hand, in the end, that carried the word into the physician's column: a small, upright entry, no larger than any other line on the page, set down among the year's other births and burials and fines and fevers as though it were no more than any of them, though every copyist who came to that page afterward, in the cellar or the loft, would know exactly what it was, and would read it, whatever else the roll around it said, a little more slowly than the rest.

1. the coal-blooded; lit. 'coal-blood'

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

OF the Line of AISLING

AE 126 – 131

I

Of the Roll at Àth ìseal

Cailean mac Eachainn had been two years in the cellar at Muileann chaol before he learned to stop reading the rolls he copied.

It was not a lesson anyone taught him. Seòrag Bhàn, the eldest of the three households, told him only that a hand copies faster once it stops caring what it copies, and that a fast hand kept a place in the cellar longer than a slow one, whatever else was true of it. Cailean had taken her at her word the way a young man takes an old woman's word when he has not yet found a reason to doubt it, and by the second winter he could set down a page of births, burials, fines and shifts lost without his eye once catching on a name. The lamp smoked, and the roll in front of him went from one pile to the other, and that was the whole of the work, and he was glad of it in the way a man is glad of a thing that asks nothing further of him.

The roll of the camp at Àth ìseal reached him in the tenth month of the hundred and twenty-sixth year, bundled with three others from the eastern custodians whose rolls the Residency's own clerks could not be trusted to keep private, and whose copies therefore came down to Muileann chaol to be made again in a hand the Residency never saw. Àth ìseal was a small camp, a hundred souls or so scraping at the thin seam above Achadh dhomhain, and its custodian had kept the new camp's people on the same pages as her own from its first winter, so that the roll ran heavier than its size would suggest: two settlements' worth of births and burials and shifts lost, pressed into one book by a hand that had grown worse with every winter it was asked to write in. Cailean did not know the custodian's name and had no cause to learn it. He set the roll on the stand, trimmed the lamp, and began.

He had copied perhaps sixty such lines that month, and read none of them, when his hand slowed over the marriages.

A camp's marriages are not written the way a town's are. Where a town custodian sets down only the two names and the year, a camp custodian writes them as the households at the ford first recited them, in *An Aois Ailein*¹, each side's line carried seven names back before the vow is called good: so-and-so, son of so-and-so, son of so-and-so, to the seventh father, and the same again for the bride, and only then the marrying. It is the oldest habit the custodians keep and, Cailean had always privately thought, the most useless one for a man paid to make a fair copy of a roll in the fewest hours he can manage; seven names back for every hewer and every hewer's wife in a hundred camps was a great deal of ink spent on the dead.

He had copied a hundred such lines that season and never once read past the first name in any of them. This one he read, and could not afterward have said why, except that the seventh name of it was a name nobody gives a child now, and something in his eye caught on it the way a boot catches on a root it has walked over a hundred times without ever quite tripping on.

Donnchadh mac Thormoid, hewer, the marriage began, and carried Donnchadh's line seven fathers back to a name that meant nothing to Cailean at all, and then gave the bride's line the same courtesy, and then the marrying. Cailean copied it as he copied everything, and went on, and would have thought no more of it, except that further down the same page, in the same custodian's failing hand, a birth was entered with a small mark beside it, a third mark, neither the mark for a birth that lived nor the mark for one that did not, one Cailean had seen perhaps four times in a year of copying, always against one name only, never explained in any book he had been given to copy from.

Aisling.

Every copyist in the cellar knew what the camps said of a child marked so. Cailean had said it himself once, as a boy at *Muileann chaol*, the way boys say a thing they have heard grown men say and do not trouble themselves to believe: *the girl who does not grow*. He had not thought of it in years. He thought of it now, sitting with the lamp guttering, and found that he did not want to go on to the next line until he had gone back and read the first one properly.

He read it three times. Donnchadh, hewer, son of Tormod, and Tormod's line running back seven names to one that struck him as being older than a hewer's

1. the Age of Ailean

grandfather's grandfather had any business being, in a hand that gave no sign of thinking it strange. He sat with it a long while by the lamp, long enough that Seònaig Bhàn came down once to see why his pile had stopped growing and went away again without asking, because she had kept the cellar long enough to know the look of a man who has found a thing he does not yet understand is his to keep or to give away.

In the end Cailean finished the page, as the work required of him. Then he took a scrap of the cellar's poorer paper, the kind kept for false starts, and copied the seven names of Donnchadh's line onto it in his own hand, folded it once, and put it inside his coat where the ledger's ink could not mark it. He told himself, walking home along the millrace that night with the folded paper against his chest like a stolen thing, that he only meant to ask someone who would know whether such a line as Donnchadh's could truly run as old as it looked on the page, and that this was no more than any careful copyist owed to a roll he had failed to understand. A thin excuse, and he knew it, and walked on anyway. In the morning, instead of walking down to the cellar, he walked out along the hill road to Tobar dhìreach, where it was known, if a man asked at all, that the last of Clann na Ceiste² who still said the old lines kept a house not far from the standing slab.

II

Of Tobar dhìreach

It was raining by the time he reached the house, the fine grey rain that comes off the western sea in the tenth month and does not trouble to announce its coming with wind first, and he stood at the door a moment working out what he meant to say before he knocked, and found he had worked out nothing at all.

The woman who opened to him was old in the way the very old are old, past the age where a stranger can guess at the years by looking, with a face gone to folds around eyes that had not dimmed with it. She looked at him the way, he thought afterward, a woman looks at a fox that has come to her door in daylight: not afraid of it, and not glad of it either, only certain that its coming meant some wrong had been done somewhere, to bring it to her door at all.

2. the Children of the Question

"You'll want to come in out of that," she said, "since you've come this far in it," and stood aside.

Her name was Ealasaid, and she told it him herself when he had not thought to ask, the way the old sometimes give a thing freely that a younger person would have made him earn. The house was one room and a loft, with a fire built up higher than the day's cold quite called for, and no sign in it of the things Cailean had half expected to find in the house of the last of a house that said the old lines: no bones, no carved stones; nothing but a chair drawn close to the fire and a shelf of ordinary crockery and, over the mantel, a length of plain cord hung in loops that he did not understand and did not ask about.

He told her what he had, badly, starting twice and beginning again, until she stopped him with a raised hand and said only, "Read it me, then, and stop telling me what you think of it before I've heard it," which steadied him more than any kindness would have.

He drew out the folded scrap and read the seven names of Donnchadh's line aloud by the fire, slowly, the way a man reads a thing he is not sure he has copied without error. Ealasaid sat with her eyes shut through all of it, her hands still in her lap, and did not open them until he had said the seventh name, the old one, the one that had first caught his eye in the cellar.

"Where did you get that?"

He told her: the roll of Àth ìseal, a hewer's marriage, copied down the way the camp custodians write such things, nothing more.

"That is Somhairle's line," she said, and said it the way a woman says a fact so old it has stopped surprising even her. "The son who asked for nothing. We have kept that line since Somhairle himself, and in a thousand years nobody of it has come asking after it. They went down into the valleys and forgot us, all of them, generation on generation, until there was no one left above ground who remembered there was anything to come asking for." She was quiet a while, looking at the fire rather than at him. "Whose is the child?"

"Donnchadh's," Cailean said. "His daughter. Her name is Aisling."

He had not meant to say more than that. Something in the old woman's stillness pulled the rest out of him almost before he had decided to give it: the mark beside the birth, the whisper the camps carried about a girl who did not grow, the boy's grin with which he himself had once repeated it, not believing a word of it, the way boys repeat any strange thing that is said around them.

Ealasaid said nothing at all for so long that Cailean began to think she had not heard him, or had heard him and judged the matter beneath answering. Then, without turning her head, in a voice that had gone flat and careful, as a woman reads a thing off a wall rather than out of her own mind, she said: "When strangers hold this island, the fire will wake again in your line."

She looked at him then. "That is the end of the vigil, as we keep it. I have said it every winter of my life at the hearth on the night of the lightning, and I never once thought I would live to see what it meant." She rose, slowly, with the particular care of the very old getting up from a low chair, and Cailean understood without being told that what she meant to give him required her to be standing to give it. "The lines are said standing," she said, as if he had asked. "Sit where you are and write, if you've brought anything to write with. I'll not say it twice in a night."

He had a stub of pencil and the back of the same poor paper. She gave it him as it is given at a naming, from the child back to the fire. The Mason's line has kept the years of its dead beside their names since the mason, but it says them to no stranger except where they are strange; and so in the short form only the long lives are given their years. Cailean wrote it down as she said it, as fast as his hand would go:

"Aisling, daughter of Donnchadh, who hewed in the deep galleries of Achadh dhomhain; son of Tormod, who carried water up to Doire mhòr two summers, and then went down to Àth ìseal; son of Ruairidh of Doire mhòr, who stood behind Beathag Dhubh when she sent the Company down the hill; and seventy generations whose names we keep; son of Fionnlagh, who stood on the quay at Seann Skell when the ships went out, and did not go; and a hundred and sixteen generations whose names we keep; son of Ceallach, the last of us whose years were long; and all the days of Ceallach were a hundred and forty years, and he died; son of Gille-Bride, who carried a coal of the First Flame home to the hills; and all the days of Gille-Bride were two hundred and twenty-four years, and he died; and six generations whose names we keep, each longer-lived than the one after, and their days were three hundred and eight years, and four hundred and thirty-one, and five hundred and ninety-seven, and eight hundred and twenty-six, and one thousand one hundred and forty-eight, and one thousand five hundred and ninety-four; son of Beathan, who sat by the slab through the dark half of the year; and all the days of Beathan were two thousand two hundred and thirteen years, and he died; son of Somhairle, son of Ailean, who

asked for no share of the kingdom and went before his father to the grave; and all the days of Somhairle were two thousand nine hundred and eighty-seven years, and he died; son of Ailean Mòr, the first king, whom the gods crowned in the grove, and who was king until he fell at the Ford of Blood; and all the days of Ailean Mòr were four thousand six hundred and twenty-six years, and he died; son of Suibhne, and fourteen fathers whose names we keep; son of Seathan, who snapped his fingers, and the fire was in his hand; and ten fathers; son of Colla, in whose days they called us the Inquisitors of the Mystic Coal; and fifteen fathers; son of Eòghann, who tasted the river; and twenty-one fathers; son of Cormac of the Misstrike, who bled in the grove; and thirty fathers; son of Brian, who buried the five like the dead; and twenty-eight fathers; son of Fearghas, who climbed to the top of the island; and thirty-one fathers; son of Aodh, who threw the seven into the sea; and eighteen fathers; son of Diarmad, who spoke with the Keeper in the grove; and thirty-four fathers; son of Conall, who kept the vein while it burned; son of Neachdan, who found the fire; son of the godfolk, who grew out of the island like grass; and the island was born of Caoran's fire."

When it was done she sat again, and for a while neither of them spoke, and the rain went on against the shutter as it had gone on the whole time, indifferent to what had just been said in the room it fell on.

"They'll say it's a tale," Cailean said at last, looking at what his own hand had written, not quite believing the numbers even as he read them back. "Four thousand years. Two thousand. Nobody will believe a word of it below."

"The years, they will call a tale," Ealasaid said. "Let them call it that. I never told you a man lived four thousand years, Cailean mac Eachainn. I told you whose son he was." She looked at him a moment longer, and something in her face eased, very slightly, as though a weight she had carried a long time without expecting to set it down had shifted onto someone else's shoulder at last. "Go home now, and write it where it will keep. That's all that was ever asked of either of us."

III

Of the Return, and the Report that Named No One

b

e walked back to Muileann chaol in the last of the light with the paper inside his coat, wet through at the edges where the rain had got at it despite him, and sat up past the cellar's own hours copying the line fair onto a second sheet before the pencil could smear past reading. In the morning he did the only thing that seemed to him, then, both possible and right: he wrote the seven names, and Ealasaid's line after them as she had given it, small, in the margin of the Àth ìseal roll, beside the entry for Aisling's birth, in a hand no larger than the mark that had first caught his eye. He told no one at the cellar what he had done, and Seònaig Bhàn, who saw the margin filled and might have asked, chose that year, as she had chosen other years before it, not to ask a young copyist what he did with an evening that was rightly his own.

So it was found, as far as a line of names can be said to find anything: that the girl of the spoil-heaps at Achadh dhomhain, whom the camps had whispered over since before she could walk, carried in her the blood of the first king of the island, more generations removed from him than any roll could count, and no less his for the distance. What it proved beyond that, the cellar did not ask, and Cailean, who had begun the matter, was careful afterward never to be the one who raised it again.

The Residency heard of the word the custodians had agreed within the year, as the Residency heard most things that were said twice within a day's ride of one of its clerks, though by what road neither the custodians nor the three households of the cellar ever learned. What reached it was not the line, which no clerk of the Administration would have believed if he had heard it, but the plainer fact: that certain children of the Dia-thìrich did not grow as other children grew, that the custodians had a word for it, and that they appeared to know a good deal more about which children these were than they had troubled to report.

The order came down at the end of the hundred and twenty-seventh year, over the Commissioner's own seal, and was read out to every custodian's gathering from Cathair dhearg to the coast: any child of the Dia-thìrich showing the change the custodians had lately named was to be reported at once to the Commissioner's office, with the child's name, place and parentage, that the Administration might keep its own account of a matter touching the Dia-thìrich body it had not previously thought to number.

The custodians obeyed the order in the only way most of them ever found themselves able to obey an order of that shape. They reported none. Not Aisling, not Fionnan, not any child born coal-touched in the years that followed, though

every custodian's roll from Cathair dhearg to the coast went on quietly keeping its own note of them, in the plain hand the physicians had settled on, where no clerk of the Residency thought to look for it. A custodian at Cill ghlais, asked once by a Company agent whether she knew of any such child in her own district, is recorded as having answered that she kept no roll of miracles, only of births and deaths, and that the office in front of her was welcome to search her books for either.

IV

Of the Third Coin

The order on the children was not the only order that year, nor, as it happened, the one that changed more households than any single ruling in a generation.

Barter had been marked down against the mark twice already, and had gone on regardless in a hundred quiet corners the Residency's clerks never fully reached: cloth for fish at the steps of Inis mhòr, a day's labour for a day's milk between neighbouring crofts, the old exchanges that had outlived the marks and the mint and every change of coin that came before them, because a clerk cannot fine a transaction he never learns took place. In the spring of the hundred and twenty-ninth year the Administration struck barter down as lawful payment altogether, and in the autumn it closed the last door as well. The barter houses at Ros dhomhain and at Cathair dhearg, where cloth and fish and every manner of goods besides had changed hands without a coin passing since before the humans first came over the sea, were shut by written order, their doors nailed, their keepers turned to other work. A clerk of the Residency, setting the closure into the year's account, wrote that the Company's ledgers were now, for the first time in the island's keeping, *complete*, and meant it as praise of his own office's thoroughness rather than as anything said against the households the closing cost.

The fishwives of Inis mhòr, who had sold their catch at the river steps by barter since before any of them could say when the custom began, took no coin at all for a full week after the order reached them, giving their fish away to whoever came down to the steps rather than sell it for marks they had not asked for and did not want. The Company's own clerks, coming down to the steps to see what the disturbance was, recorded the week as a glut in the season's catch and set it

down so in the account, and never once asked a fishwife why so great a glut had chosen that particular week to appear.

It did not last, of course; a week is a week, and a family must eat past the end of it. Within the year the hill villages that had always paid their seed and their rents in kind now had no lawful way to pay in anything but marks, and the villages around Muileann chrom, having no marks of their own to spare, began borrowing them at interest from the Company's own stores, the only lender within a day's walk willing to lend at all. It was a small thing at first, a mark here, two marks there, against the next year's crop. Within a few years most of the villages about Muileann chrom owed the Company more marks than a year's crop could answer for, and every custodian who kept a roll of debts as well as of births knew it, and none of them knew what to write against it that would change the sum.

The old market at Muileann òg, where the hill folk and the coast folk had met to trade with each other directly since An Aois Naomh¹, without the Company or the Administration standing between them, closed after its last poor season in the hundred and thirty-first year. No order closed it; there was simply, one spring, nothing left worth carrying to it that could not be carried more profitably to a town with a mint. The ground it had stood on, a flat green shoulder above the ford that had given the old market its name, stood empty from that year on, and the grass that grew up over it grew thicker each season, since nothing walked it anymore to keep it down.

V

Of the Staff at Muileann chrom

Peigi Ghlas died at Cill ghlais in the spring of the hundred and twenty-eighth year, the year before the barter houses' doors were nailed shut, an old woman by then, her petition long unanswered and the pile it had joined grown taller by every year that passed without an answer coming. She had trimmed Bride's lamp herself the last week of her life, though her hands shook so that a younger custodian stood by to catch the oil if she spilled it, and she is remembered at Cill ghlais, where such things are remembered longest, as having said, near the end, that she had asked the Residency for an answer once, and

1. the Holy Age

meant to leave the asking there for good. She was buried within the shrine's own ground, beside the cutting the custodians still keep open, and the roll of Cill ghlas records nothing further of her save the day.

Iain Maor, third of that name to hold the overseer's staff at Muileann chrom, followed her within three years, in the autumn of the hundred and thirty-first year, having held the staff since before most of the hill's present hewers were born and having spent no small part of it, in his last years, writing letters to an Administration that dismissed him for the writing of them and then reversed the dismissal and took him back, because it could find no one else the coal camps would trust to keep order among them. He died at Muileann chrom, in the same house he had held the staff from, and was buried within the week, the custom of the camp allowing no longer delay for a man whose office could not sit empty.

His daughter Mòrag took the staff from his hand before he died, by his own wish and the custodians' agreement both, the first woman to hold it in the staff's whole history at Muileann chrom. She was thirty-six years old, born the year her father first took up the letters he would spend the rest of his life writing, and she had grown up, as she told a younger cousin once, "knowing the shape of that staff better than I know the shape of my own hand, from having watched it lie across his knees at every supper of my life." The Company wrote to confirm her within the month, in a letter that named her, without further comment, "a safe pair of hands," a phrase the custodians of Muileann chrom repeated to one another afterward with an expression none of the Company's clerks would have cared to see on their faces.

Mòrag took the staff home the evening of her father's burying, through a hill gone quiet with the particular quiet that follows a funeral, past the pithead where the night shift's lamps were already moving. Where her father had set it across his own knees by the fire, she hung it over her hearth, on two iron hooks he had never troubled to have fitted, where it caught the firelight along its worn grain every evening after. There, she told the same cousin years later, she could see it without having to hold it, which was, she had found, most of what a staff of office was actually good for.

She thought, hanging it there that first night, of a thing her father had told her once and again as she grew, a thing he said he had had from a copyist at Muileann chaol who had had it, in turn, from an old woman of Clann na Ceiste¹ out at To-

1. the Children of the Question

bar dhìreach, though neither he nor Mòrag had ever met the woman nor asked after her name: that somewhere on a roll no clerk of the Residency had ever read, a girl who did not grow was written down as the daughter of a king four thousand years dead, in a line kept by people who had stopped expecting anyone would ever come asking for it. *I never told you a man lived four thousand years*, the old woman was supposed to have said. *I told you whose son he was*. Mòrag did not know, that first night with the staff cooling on its hooks and her father not yet a day in the ground, what use such a thing as a name kept four thousand years could ever be to a hill that could not keep its own coin, let alone its own children, out of a stranger's ledger. She only knew that she thought of it, standing there, longer than she thought she should have, and that she did not stop thinking of it, in the years that followed, whenever the staff caught the evening light in a particular way and she found herself, without quite meaning to, looking up at it from her chair.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

OF the GREY Goose and the Dockers

AE 132 – 135

I

Of the New Commissioner

Edward Vane died at the Residency above Ros dhomhain late in an Lùnastal of the hundred and thirty-second year, in the bed he had been born in sixty-two years before, the only Commissioner Dia-thìr ever gave a birth as well as a death. He had spoken the tongue of the island badly to the end, in the flat clipped way of a man reciting a lesson he had never quite trusted himself to feel, and the custodians who came to the Residency in the old form to acknow-

ledge the change of stewards found, as they always did with Vane, that they had liked him rather more than they had meant to and could not now say precisely why.

Charles Merriman came out from an *Tír Thall*¹ within the season, and with him came thirty men in a grey coat nobody on the island had worn before, each with a rifle slung and a look of having crossed a great deal of water to be told, on landing, that there was nothing yet for them to do. The custodians who received the ship at Ros dhomhain asked what the soldiers were for, and were told, courteously, that they were constables under the Commissioner's own commission, sworn to keep the harbour and the roads, and that this made all the difference in law, whatever it looked like standing on a quay with a rifle slung.

"It is the first standing force the Administration has kept here," said *Mòrag nic Iain Maor*, who had ridden down from *Muileann chrom* to see the new Commissioner land, more from a wish to look at his face than from any hope of learning anything from it. "A hundred and twenty years the Company kept order with an agent's signature and a locked storehouse. Now it keeps it with rifles."

"A hundred and twenty years the Company had no cause to do otherwise," Merriman said. He was a broad, sandy man who did not raise his voice, which the custodians came in time to find more unsettling than a man who did. "I hope, madam, to give it none now either."

He built his first post within the month, at *Muileann shean* on the northern coal road: a low stone house with a yard for horses and a flag that flew from a pole cut, the townsfolk noted without much surprise, from timber the Company had felled and never paid the custodian for. They called it the humans' second Residency, and did not mean it kindly, and the name outlasted every other name anyone tried to give the place. A second post went up that same autumn at *Tobar ghorm*, nearer the northern workings, where the custodian of the village was paid a rent for the ground it stood on and used the money, with a thoroughness that made the Company's agent write two letters of complaint to Ros dhomhain, to buy the village clear of every debt it owed the Company's own store.

Mòrag rode home from the landing with the picture of the thirty grey coats fixed in her mind the way a burn scar fixes, and told her crew-leaders only that the staff she held was the same staff her father had held, and that nothing about the water she had just seen them carry ashore changed what it was for.

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

At Tobar ghorm the constables who took up the new post found, in their first week, that the village gave them nothing to do at all: no theft reported, no quarrel brought for judging, no crowd gathered anywhere near the stone house with its yard and its flag. The custodian who had let the ground to them, an old man named Uilleam Glas who had buried two sons in the same gallery three years apart, told the sergeant set over the post, when the man asked him plainly why the village kept so quiet, that Tobar ghorm had learned long since to settle its own quarrels before any stranger with a badge could hear of them and offer to settle them differently. The sergeant wrote as much in his first month's report to Merri-man, who read it twice and told his clerk that a quiet post was either a well-kept one or a lying one, and that he did not yet know Tobar ghorm well enough to say which.

II

Of Hannah Webb

Hannah Webb had come to the hill country behind Baile chrom at nineteen, in the year the coal line opened, following a brother two years younger who had heard there was steady field work to be had among the concession's tobacco slopes and steadier pay than either of them had known on the crossing. She was thirty-two now, broad through the shoulder from twelve years of stooping to the leaf, unmarried, with a face the sun had weathered past what her years alone would have done, and she kept, in the small room she rented from a Company tenant-farmer, a single object of any value: her mother's clasp-knife, brought over the sea and never once used for anything but cutting bread.

She had gone down to Ceann mhòr in the spring of that same year, on an errand for the farm that had nothing to do with what she came home carrying. The harbour under the north-western headland held perhaps forty houses of human fishing families, the first of their people to draw a living from the island's own sea rather than the Company's table, and among them an old woman named Ruth Pallant who mended nets on a bench outside her door and talked, without much needing to be asked, to whoever sat down beside her.

"You keep late hours, out on the field paths," Ruth said, when Hannah admitted, more from politeness than confession, that she often walked at night rather than sleep through the heat that hung on even after dark in the growing season.

"There's nothing to see by night but the dark."

"There's a deal to see by night, if you know to look for it." Ruth's needle did not stop. "My grandmother's people fished these waters before there was a Ceann mhòr to fish them from, and they kept a watch some nights, to hold the sea shut against whatever the dark lets loose on it if nobody watches. We learned it from the island folk, who've kept it longer than anyone can say, though the Mission would have it we invented it out of our own fright at a strange coast. A grey goose flies over the watch, they say, and if you keep it faithfully and in silence, the goose carries the watching up, and nothing comes ashore that oughtn't."

"What do you say, keeping it?"

"Nothing at all. That's the whole of it. You keep still, and you keep quiet, and you let the goose do the saying." Ruth looked up from the net for the first time. "You've the look of a woman who doesn't sleep well. Try it, some clear night. It costs you nothing but the hours you weren't using anyhow."

Hannah kept the vigil for the first time in the last week of an t-Iuchar, alone, in the field behind the tenant-farmer's byre, sitting on an upturned crate with her knees drawn up and her mother's clasp-knife closed in her fist for no reason she could have given, watching the sky go from the last green of evening to a black so thick with stars she could not find, at first, the constellations the Mission's calendar named for her. She did not know, doing it, that she was keeping anything with a name; she knew only that the stillness asked for stopped, for the first time in twelve years, the endless small counting of her days that ran under everything else she did: the tally of what was owed and what was short and what her brother had said at breakfast that she ought to have answered better. Toward the middle of the night she saw, or thought she saw, low over the field, a long pale shape crossing east to west with its neck out straight before it, and she did not move, and it passed, and she went in afterward and slept the whole night through for the first time since she had come to the island.

She kept it again a week later, and then most weeks, telling no one, until a field hand named Colm Ashe, walking home late from a different farm, saw her sitting motionless in the dark by the byre two nights running and told the story at the Mission's rest-day meeting more from wonder than from malice. Within a month half the human labourers of the concession's edge had heard of it, and a handful had tried it themselves, and by the autumn there were nights when six or seven of them kept the field together, spaced apart and silent, each fixed on the same patch of sky.

III

Of What the Mission and the Priests Said of It

The Mission at Cathair gheal took the matter up formally the next summer, when its minister, a careful and not unkind man named Obadiah Renn who had buried more of his flock to fever than he had married, asked Hannah to sit with him in the chapel's cold vestry and tell him plainly what she did and why.

"We keep the sky," Hannah said. "That's the whole of it. Nobody taught me a word to say. There isn't one."

"You call it a prayer."

"I don't call it anything. Others have started to."

Renn turned his pen over twice before he wrote anything. "The scripture knows the dove, and it knows the raven Noah sent out and the one that did not come back. It does not, so far as I have ever read it, know a goose." He looked at her not unkindly. "You have done nothing wrong that I can name. But I cannot find you in the book, and a minister who cannot find his flock in the book grows uneasy, whatever the flock itself feels keeping the field. So I mean to write to Cathair gheal, plainly, that the practice is irregular, and unaccountable, and very likely picked up, however it came to you, from the island folk's own customs."

"It was an old woman of Ceann mhòr taught me the way of it. She's no more island folk than I am."

"Then she had it from someone who was, once, however many years back, and the water it has passed through since does not change the spring." He wrote his letter that week, and it went, as such letters did, up the chain to the Mission's house at Cathair gheal and from there, in time, into a report that named the vigil irregular and its origin uncertain, and asked that no minister encourage it while it remained unaccountable to the scripture.

Baile chrom's own Dia-thìrich, when the thing came to their ears, for little stayed long unheard between the town and the fields about it, wanted no part of it either, though for reasons of their own. "We keep no watch with the humans' Church," said the custodian of Baile chrom's lower row, a stiff, careful woman who had buried enough of her own people in the hunger years to have no patience left for anyone else's borrowed grief. "If the field folk want a goose in their sky, let them keep it themselves and leave our name out of the keeping of it." The saying went round the town within the week, and the human labourers who had

begun, hopefully, to call their watch a thing shared between the two peoples learned instead to call it, among themselves only, their own.

It was Manannan's priests at Ceann mhòr who, of everyone who heard of it that year, came closest to naming the thing rightly, and liked it least for having named it. An old priest of the harbour temple, hearing from Ruth Pallant herself what she had taught the field woman, walked the width of the concession to Baile chrom to see the vigil kept with his own eyes, stood at the field's edge through one whole silent night without once being asked or asking to join it, and told Hannah afterward, in the grey hour before dawn, that she had the form of the watching near enough right and its meaning hardly at all.

"The goose you keep you take for an Gèadh Fiadhaich¹, the wild goose of your own Spirit, and your minister cannot find it in his book, and Baile chrom will have none of it. Your minister is half right. The watching under the goose is ours, out of our own harbours: the night prayer to keep the sea shut. Your fisher-wife's people learned it from mine, to keep the sea shut against what the sea lets in unwatched, and somewhere between her grandmother and you the sea got left out of it, and what's left is a good and a true thing, kept faithfully, that is nonetheless not the thing it started as. It has gone astray of us. I will not say it has gone wrong."

"Will you tell your own people to keep it with me, then?"

"I will not. It is not, any longer, entirely ours to keep, and I would not have my house's people standing silent in a field to a prayer that has wandered as far from its beginning as yours has. I have told the Mission's man at Cathair gheal, though, that it is not for him to stop it either, in words he did not much care to hear." He looked out at the field, empty now in the daylight, the crate Hannah sat on nothing more than an upturned crate. "Keep your watch, Hannah Webb. Whatever it is you are keeping, by now, is your own."

IV

Of the Dockers of Ros dhomhain

hannah's brother, whose name was Daniel, had left the tobacco fields for the quays at Ros dhomhain two years before, saying he had had enough

1. the wild goose of the Holy Spirit

of another man's leaf under his own nails and would rather break his back for wages he could see counted out to him at the week's end than for a crop the Company priced after the fact. He worked the coal berths, loading the steamships that had begun, since the coal line opened, to carry more coal in a season than the sailing ships had carried in five, and he worked them beside Dia-thìrich dockers who had been loading the same berths since before he was born, men he had learned, over two years, to drink with and argue with and, on the one occasion a beam had come loose and nearly taken a Dia-thìreach docker's leg, to haul clear with his own hands fast enough that the man had thereafter called him, half in jest and half not, *a bhràthair*, brother, which was not a word given lightly on either side of that harbour.

The docker he had pulled clear was named Tòmas Ruadh, a broad quiet man twice Daniel's age who had worked the Ros dhomhain berths since the pit at Muileann chrom first sent coal down to them, and who took to bringing Daniel a share of whatever his wife had put up that week, a habit neither of them ever remarked on aloud. It was Tòmas who told him, on an evening in the spring of the hundred and thirty-fourth year, that the Company's agent had posted a new tariff on the loading-house door, a toll on every ton counted at the scale that had not been there the week before and that no docker of either people had been asked about.

"They'll say it pays for the new stone on the quay," Tòmas said. "It pays for the quay right enough. It does not pay us anything at all."

"Then don't load it."

"Easy said by a man who can be put on a ship home if it goes badly." Tòmas looked at him without heat, only the flat weighing look of a man deciding something. "But you're not wrong that it wants saying. We have never once, in all the years this harbour has stood, put down our hooks with the humans standing next to us instead of over us. It might be worth seeing what that looks like."

The berth charges went up that spring, a new toll on every ton loaded that the Company's agent said was owed the harbour works and the dockers said was owed nothing but the Company's own accounts, and the two peoples of the quay, who had never in the whole history of the port struck together over anything, put down their hooks on the same morning and did not pick them up again.

"You're mad to stand with them," a Company clerk told Daniel Webb on the second day, not unkindly, meaning it as a warning. "They'll strike you eleven days

at Baile thais and forget you the day after. You're not one of them and never will be."

"I'm not striking for them," Daniel said. "I'm striking for the toll, same as they are. It happens we're both on the same side of it this year." He said the same, in rather fewer words, to Hannah when she walked down to see him on the fourth day of it, finding him thinner already and cheerful in a way she distrusted on sight, the way she had learned to distrust his cheerfulness their whole lives, since it generally meant he had decided on something before he had thought all the way round it.

The stoppage held nine days, the whole harbour idle, the coal piling on the quayside faster than any store could take it, before Merriman's constables came down from their new posts on the tenth morning and stood in a line the length of the quay, rifles slung and shown but never fired, enough of them that the dockers who had held nine days without a blow struck went back to their hooks within the hour rather than find out what the tenth day of standing against thirty grey coats might cost. The Company took the names of every human docker who had struck, and within the week a ship stood off Ros dhomhain to carry them over the sea. The passage was offered once, in a notice read to the men on the quay by the Company's agent himself, courteous and plainly worded and impossible to mistake for anything but what it was: it would not be offered twice, and no man there needed to be told what the ship's leaving without him might mean for the season's work he had left.

Hannah stood on the quay the morning the ship took on its passengers, in a crowd of families who had come to see off husbands and brothers and, in two cases, wives, and watched Daniel go up the gangway with a single sack over his shoulder and his back straight in the particular way she knew meant he would not turn to look at her again before the ship cleared the harbour mouth, because he had never in his life been able to say a proper goodbye and had settled, instead, on not making one. He did turn, once, at the rail, and lifted a hand, and she lifted hers, and that was the whole of it; the ship's whistle sounded, and it stood out past the headland with the morning tide, and she did not know, standing there, whether she would ever again in her life see the water this particular colour of grey without thinking of that sail going small against it.

The Dia-thìrich dockers of Ros dhomhain went back to their hooks that same week, having no ship offered them and nowhere else on the island to be sent. At Seann Vell, the neighbouring harbour, where no human had ever worked the

berths, the dockers heard of the shipping and refused, on their own account and without a single human among them to strike beside, to load the coal that had been meant for the vessels the strike had held back. When the stoppage broke elsewhere they were not shipped over the sea, for there were none among them to ship; but neither were they hired again that season, nor easily the season after, and the harbour-master's rolls at Seann Vell show, for two years running, a quay standing half idle beside a coal-yard standing full, which no one at the Residency troubled to explain in writing, and everyone at Seann Vell understood without needing it explained.

V

Of the Two Births

hannah kept her watch through that winter and the next, in the field behind the byre, alone some nights and joined by two or three of the concession's own on others, the shape of it settled now into something the Mission had stopped writing letters about and Baile chrom had stopped troubling to disown, since a thing left long enough alone in its own field becomes in the end too small a thing for anyone to keep minding. She wrote to Daniel twice that year, letters that took the better part of a season to cross and be answered, and learned, from the second answer, that he had found work on the docks of a great river port of an Tír Thall¹, loading ships bound, as it happened, nowhere near Dia-thìr, a fact he set down without comment and she read with more feeling than she let herself write back.

That same spring, on 29 an Cèitean, AE 134, a third child of the coal-blood was born, Lorccan, the first of them born in a mining town and not in a camp; and the custodians, who had written the word *fuil-ghuail*² in their columns for eight years by then against two names only, knew from it that the thing had outgrown any one place. Within a year, on 3 am Màrt, AE 135, a fourth was born, Cian. Never before had two of the coal-blood come so near together. The custodians who wrote the two births wrote them as the rolls required, the name and

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

2. the coal-blooded; lit. 'coal-blood'

the day and the word in its column, and nothing more, and reported neither to the Residency.

Hannah heard nothing of either birth, keeping her own watch in her own field far from both, and knew nothing of any such children at all. The custodians' rolls kept the four names, and the Residency's register, which asked for them, kept none.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

OF THE RENDING OF CILL ghlas

AE 136 – 138

I

Of the Plan and the Mark Below It

The shrine at Cill ghlás had stood through the whole of the age. It was older than that: the custodians said the cutting had been worked before the strangers came, before the mark, before the first ton was weighed at Muileann chrom, and that Bríde's lamp had burned there since a time nobody now living could put a year to. It was there the word *fuil-ghuail*¹ had been agreed, in the year the custodians gave the thing a name, and it was there the crews still climbed on the old feast days, as they had climbed since before any gallery had a name.

In the hundred and thirty-sixth year of the strangers A' Chompanaidh² came to drive new workings under the hills about it.

The engineer's name was Robert Fairley, a spare, sandy man not yet forty, who had come out from the coalfields of an Tír Thall³ with a case of instruments and a

1. the coal-blooded; lit. 'coal-blood'

habit of measuring things twice. He set his levels on the moor above the shrine in the month of am Faoilleach, in a wind that took the surveyor's flags out of the ground three times before noon, and by an Cèitean he had his galleries marked on a sheet of linen paper pinned flat on a drawing-board in the site office at Baile thais: eight headings running north under the hill, numbered, with the old cutting shown as a hatched square at the top of the sheet, and the new workings stepping down below it toward the river.

The custodians of the shrine came to him twice. The first time it was Aonghas Mòr, keeper of the lamp that year, a heavy, slow-spoken man who had held the office eleven years and never once let the flame go out in all of them. He stood in the office doorway with the smell of the moor still on his coat and asked, through the clerk who did the Company's Dia-thìris, that no charge be set where the noise or the shake of it could be felt at the shrine. Fairley heard him out, asked the clerk to repeat the words a second time so he had them right, and wrote on the margin of his plan, in a small careful hand: *Custodians ask no charge in sight of old cutting*. He underlined it once.

The second time it was Aonghas Mòr and two others, in am Màrt, when the first blasting parties had begun to come up from the coast with their crates and their careful, unhurried carters. They asked the same thing again, in the same words, because that was the custodians' way with a thing once asked: to ask it again exactly, so that no one could say later that the asking had changed. Fairley looked at his own margin note, found it still there, and told them, through the clerk, that the Company had it marked and would keep to it.

He believed, when he said it, that he meant to.

The charges that summer were set according to the depth of good coal under each heading, and the depth of good coal ran deepest where the old cutting's own diggers had worked closest to the surface, in the years before anyone measured a working by the ton. The lowest headings, numbered six, seven and eight on Fairley's sheet, came up under the shrine itself, forty fathom down and rising, where the plan's careful ink line seemed from above to set them beside it. Fairley had marked the custodians' asking faithfully. He had not marked where the ground under his numbers actually lay, because on the sheet the shrine was a hatched square with no thickness to it, and the workings below were a set of numbers

with no depth drawn in beside them, and the two things never touched on the paper at all.

The powder for the new headings came in that same summer, landed not at Ros dhomhain or Cathair dhearg, where the harbour-men had grown particular about barrels that hissed when they were dropped, but at the small stone quay of Caol ìseal on the north coast, away from the crowded southern ports. It came up from the hold in casks bound with iron hoops, stencilled in the humans' letters, and carted inland under an escort of four constables who rode a little apart from the carts, as men do who have been told what is in them and would rather not be asked. The custodian of Caol ìseal, an old woman named Oighrig Ruadh who had kept that small roll for thirty years, went down to the quay herself and asked the carter what the casks held.

"Lamp-oil," the carter said, not unkindly, and helped her count the barrels onto his manifest so the number would agree.

She wrote in her roll that night: *Forty casks landed, said to be oil. They did not smell of oil when I put my hand to a stave.* It is the only line in any custodian's roll that says plainly the lie was known for a lie before it was told, and it went unanswered, as such lines mostly did, into the cellar at Muileann chaol with everything else.

II

Of Baile thais in the Winter

Eilidh nic Raghnaill was thirty-one that winter and had led a crew at Baile thais for six years, ever since her mother died and the crew that had been her mother's would not be led by anyone from outside the family. She kept a room over the burial club's hall, two streets up from the pithead, with a window that looked down the row of grey roofs to the sea, and on the wall by the door, where another woman might have hung a carving of the Keeper or a sprig of dried heather from Bride's shrine, she had a single sheet of paper pinned flat, copied out in her own hand from a longer one that had gone round the crews eight years before: the names of the eleven who had died under the fall at Cnoc fhiadhaich, long before her own remembering, and under them the names, added later, of everyone since whose death the crews had judged worth keeping.

Her father, Ragnall Breac, hewed at Baile thais still when she was a girl, one of the crews who had come out in the eleven days of the great strike before she was born, a boy then, and had never in all the years after let a Lùnastal pass without telling the story of the twelfth morning and the shelves. But the seam at Baile thais was old and narrow and paid by the ton at a rate that had not moved in a generation, and in the hundred and thirty-fourth year, with two grandchildren to feed and his knees gone stiff for the low work, Ragnall Breac had gone up the hill to Cill ghlais, where the new galleries paid better and a man his age could still find a heading tall enough to stand up straight in. He came down to Eilidh twice a year, at Bealltainn and at the turn of the year, and each time said the same four things: that the house was dry, that the food was fair, that the overseer left the old men alone, and that she was to mind her crew and not to worry for him.

She did not see him again after am Faoilleach of the hundred and thirty-sixth year.

It was in that winter, in the room over the burial club, that she was first asked to sit at the table where the Lamp-Watch kept its business. The Lamp-Watch had begun, twenty years and more before, as the burial club's own purse stretched a little further than the burying of the dead: a fund the crew-leaders kept among themselves for the widow of a man killed at the face, for the fine of a boy taken up by the constables, for the passage of a letter that the Company's post would not carry. By the time Eilidh was asked to the table it had become something else again, though no one at the table would have called it by any other name than what it had always been called. She was given the youngest seat and the least to say, and she went home from her first meeting with the club's minute-book under her coat, to copy its entries into a second book kept nowhere the Company's clerks would think to look, which was a woman's linen chest.

III

Of the Ground that Spoke First

On 9 an t-Ògmhios, AE 137, an ordinary day of an ordinary week, the galleries under Cill ghlais were worked as they had been worked every day since the headings opened: the day crews down before light, the tubs running, the overseer's watch ticking in his waistcoat pocket at the pit-mouth as it had ticked every morning for two years.

The tellers of Cill ghlas, in the years after, all agreed on one thing before they agreed on anything else: that the ground spoke first. Those nearest the eighth heading said it was a grinding, long and low, like a quern turning under a great weight, felt through the soles of the feet before it was heard at all. Those on the surface, at the pit-mouth and in the cottages along the moor road, said the ground under their own feet answered it a breath later, a shudder that stopped the wheel on the headgear and set every dog in the district barking at once. Then, in the space of perhaps three breaths, the fault that ran unseen and unsurveyed beneath the whole of Fairley's careful sheet of numbered headings tore open along its length, and the hill above the eighth heading came down into the eighth heading, and the seventh into the seventh, and the ground above the old cutting, which had never been drawn with any thickness on any plan, went down after them into a working forty fathom below it that no one at the shrine had ever been told was there.

It killed dozens. The custodians' roll of Cill ghlas, written up at the year's end from what could be gathered of that morning, gives the number as thirty-one, and says under the number that four more bodies were never brought up at all, and were left to the hill. Ragnall Breac was among the thirty-one. He was found on the third day, with two other hewers of his heading, under a fall that had not reached the surface, in a gallery that by every account should have held for a week after the charges that opened it. The overseer who wrote his name into the roll spelled it wrong, and a later hand at Muileann chaol has corrected the spelling in the margin, and left the wrong spelling standing, as the copyists always did once a mistake had gone into the roll.

The shrine went down with the eighth heading, in the same three breaths as everything else: Brìde's lamp, the stone bench where the shrine-keepers sat their watch, the little cairn of coal from every gallery that had ever been opened at Cill ghlas, going back further than any roll now standing could say. Of the keeper on watch that morning, an old woman named Sine nic Aonghais who had climbed to the shrine every day for nineteen years, nothing was ever found, not a bone nor a shred of her plaid.

The custodians' roll, in the hand that first set the day down, records the loss of the shrine in one line and the loss of the dead in the next line after it. A later copyist, working from the same leaves a season afterward, judged the order backward, holding that flesh must be set before stone, and wrote a second account with the two lines reversed, meaning to strike out the first. He did not strike it out. Both

hands stand in the roll as it came down to Muileann chaol, one above the other on the same page, and the three households who copy there have never agreed which should be kept and which crossed through, so both are copied still, every time, the shrine before the people and the people before the shrine, side by side.

IV

Of the Fenced Ground and the Stone on the Moor Road

A' Chompanaidh's surveyors were back on the hill within the week, this time to fence it. The district closed, by the order that came down from Ros dhomhain, ran from Cill ghlas to Àth chaol and took in every hamlet between, a stretch of hill country that had fed itself on oats and coal both for as long as anyone's grandmother could remember, and the order gave no leave for anyone to go on working any part of it, on any ground, for any wage. The fence was a poor thing, posts and three strands of wire strung by men who plainly did not expect it tested. No one tested it. The custodians read the order to their own households and then, one by one over that autumn and into the winter, the households of the closed district began to leave.

They went in twos and threes at first, and then, as the winter drew in and the last of the stored meal ran low, in whole villages together, walking the moor road south toward Muileann dhomhain with what a cart or a back could carry. The custodians of Muileann dhomhain met the eldest of them, not in the town hall, where a Company clerk sat most days on other business and might have seen who came and went, but at a standing stone on the moor road a mile short of the town, an old grey stone of a height with a tall man, that had stood there, by whose hand or for what first purpose nobody now living could say, since long before the strangers, before the mark, before any road had been metalled to run past it at all. There, at the stone, the custodians of Muileann dhomhain lent the dispossessed the poorest of their own common land, a stretch of thin ground at the edge of the fenced country that had never been worth enclosing for anything better than rough grazing. The meeting was given a name that winter, by whoever names such things: Coinneachadh a' Mhonaidh¹, the meeting on the moor road, and the stone has been called by no other name since.

1. the meeting on the moor road

On the ground lent them the people of the closed district raised, over the following spring and summer, a new village they called Achadh chaol, narrow field, for the shape of the ground it stood on. It was built without any surveyor of A' Chompanaidh's setting foot on it, without any Company clerk's hand in its laying out, house by house as the households that built it saw fit, on a common decided at the stone and a lease held from the custodians of Muileann dhomhain, in the old form, for the old dues, and from no one else. Of every settlement raised on the island in the years of the strangers, it was the only one built so, and the custodians who wrote of it afterward were at pains to say so, more than once, in words that were nearly the same words each time they said it.

Achadh chaol was raised through that summer in the ordinary way of a village built by people who had built villages before and had only ever lacked the ground to build one on: a well dug first, at the lowest point of the common where the water table lay shallowest, then the custodian's house, because a village without a custodian's roll to enter itself into was not yet a village at all in anyone's reckoning, and then the seven other households in the order their names had been drawn at the stone, so that no household could say afterward it had been given the worst plot out of spite or favour. Aonghas Mòr, who had kept the lamp at the lost shrine and had nothing left to keep it in, was given the custodian's house because the households that had followed him down off the closed hill trusted him more than any stranger among them, and told him so plainly enough that he could not well refuse. He opened the first roll of Achadh chaol on the day the well was finished, and its first line, in a hand still shaking a little from the digging, gives the well's depth in feet and says nothing at all of the shrine, or of Sine nic Aonghais, or of the day the ground spoke.

Eilidh nic Raghnaill walked to Cill ghlas in the fortnight after the Rending, though there was no house of her father's left standing to walk to, and no grave with his name over it that she could find among the rows the custodians had opened in haste along the moor. She found instead the fenced posts, and the wire strung between them, and beyond the wire a slope of broken ground with the headgear of the eighth heading lying on its side in it like a felled tree, and she stood at the fence for the better part of an hour before a constable, not unkindly, told her the ground was closed and she should move along. She wrote nothing of

2. the Company

that hour in the second book kept in the linen chest. It was the one thing in those years the Lamp-Watch's minutes never held.

V

Of the Pumps Stopped to Save Fuel

The gallery that flooded at Muileann chrom that same season lay three miles up the valley from the barge-stage at Seann Toll, in the workings of Mòrag nic Iain's own district, under an agent new to the pit that year, a narrow, quick-spoken man named Edgar Holt who had come up from the coalfields with strict word from Ros dhomhain that the yield of every pit on the island was to hold, whatever the season asked of it.

The gallery's pumps ran on coal, as every pump on the hill ran on coal, and in the last week of an t-Ògmhios, with the Company's own stores at Seann Toll drawn low by the shipments south and a barge two days overdue, Holt gave the order that the pumps at the flooded heading should stand idle a night, to spare the fuel for the winding-gear until the barge came in. The overseer under him, a Dia-thìreach man named Fionnlagh who had cut coal at that face for twenty years, went to Holt's office himself the evening the order came down and said what a man of twenty years' standing at one face is entitled to say to any agent, however new: that the ground under that heading had never once, in his memory, gone a full night without the pumps running, not even in a dry summer, because the water came out of an old working above it that nobody living had ever mapped. Holt heard him out standing, and answered that the barge was expected within the day, that the winding-gear could not be spared its coal until it came, and that the crews would go down at the ordinary hour as they always did. The pumps were stopped at dusk.

By morning the gallery had filled to the roof for its whole length. Fionnlagh went down himself with the change of shift, to see for himself before he sent any other man in ahead of him, and so he was among the seven who did not come up again, though the roll that lists them gives his name no more weight than any of the others.

Mòrag nic Iain Maor was at the pit-mouth when they brought the seven up. She was forty-two that year, and had carried the Company's staff, the one her great-grandfather Raghnaill Maor had taken from the agent's hand a hundred

years before, brass-capped and iron-shod, for six years, since her father Iain Maor's death. She had stood at more pit-mouths than she could count by then, but she said afterward, to the one or two who asked her, that she had never in her life heard a silence like the one that morning, with the rain coming down steady on the boards and the seven laid out in a row on them and no sound anywhere but the feet of the women of the camp coming up the track, and no one yet weeping, because no one yet believed it enough to weep.

At noon Edgar Holt rode up from the office with four constables behind him, and stood over the row of the dead, and began, in the humans' tongue, to speak of the loss to the working.

The first stone came from somewhere behind Mòrag and took him on the shoulder before the interpreter had turned two of his words into Dia-thìris. After that the air was full of stones, and the constables were shouting one thing and the crews another, and Mòrag was shouting too, though she could not afterward say what, only that she had been trying to be heard over both. She saw a constable bring his rifle up to his shoulder before she understood what he meant to do with it. She saw the smoke of it before the sound of it reached her, which she said afterward was the strangest thing of the whole morning, stranger even than the stones: that the eye had time to see a thing the ear had not yet caught up to.

When it was over, four Dia-thìrich lay in the mud of the pit-yard beside the seven already laid out from the flood, and one constable lay with them, shot, the roll says, by his own fellow in the confusion of the crowd, though the inquiry that followed never settled whose hand had fired the ball that killed him.

VI

Of the Inquiry and the Copy That Was Kept

The inquiry sat at Ros dhomhain in am Faoilleach of the next year, on 4 am Faoilleach, AE 138, in a long panelled room in the Residency that Mòrag had never before had cause to enter, before three commissioners sent out from the capital of an Tìr Thall¹ for the purpose, none of whom had ever set foot at Muileann chrom nor meant to. She wore her good dark dress, the one kept for burials, and carried the Company's staff with her into the room, though nothing

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

in the summons had asked her to bring it, because she judged, rightly as it turned out, that the sight of it in her hand would make it harder for the commissioners to pretend they were questioning some stranger off the hill and not the fourth Steward of Muileann chrom, whose family's name had stood on that staff since before any of the three commissioners had been born.

She was asked a great many questions about the stones, and fewer about the pumps, and she answered every one of them as it was put to her, in order, without hurrying to the part she had come to say. When at last a commissioner asked, almost as an afterthought, whether she knew anything of why the gallery had flooded at all, she told them: that the pumps had been stopped the evening before on the agent Edgar Holt's own order, to spare fuel for the winding-gear until a barge came in, and that the overseer Fionnlagh had told him plainly what the water would do, and that Holt had given the order regardless.

The clerk at the little table below the commissioners' bench wrote it down as she spoke it. She watched him write it, word for word, in a hand a good deal neater than her father's had ever been. Then the eldest of the three commissioners, without raising his voice or his eyes from the paper in front of him, said that the witness's account of an order she had not herself heard given was not evidence proper to the inquiry, and instructed the clerk to strike the passage from the record.

The clerk drew a single line through what he had written, not so heavy a line that the words beneath it could not still be read, and turned the page.

Eilidh nic Raghnaill was not in the room, and had no right to be, but the clerk who kept the second copy of the inquiry's minutes, the one made for the Company's own file and not for the Residency's, was a Dia-thireach woman of Ros dhomhain whose brother sat at the Lamp-Watch's table beside Eilidh's own seat, and within the month a fair copy of Mòrag's stricken testimony, struck-through line and all, had made its way north to the room over the burial club at Baile thais, folded small inside a length of sailcloth that had nothing else remarkable about it. Eilidh copied it a second time into the linen chest, struck-through line copied as struck-through, word for word, so that whoever read it after her would see exactly what had been said and exactly what the Residency had chosen not to hear.

She was given a seat of her own at the Lamp-Watch's table that same winter, no longer the youngest with the least to say. It was am Faoilleach still, the hundred and thirty-eighth year turning over the same as every year before it, the same cold rain on the same grey roofs down to the same sea, and if anything else had

changed in Baile thais that winter beyond one more woman's place at one more table, the roll that came down to Muileann chaol does not say what it was.

VII

Of What the Two Rolls Kept

The Company's letter-books show Robert Fairley posted the following year to workings on the eastern side of the island, and there his part in the telling ends. Of Sine nic Aonghais, keeper of the lost lamp, this alone is told: the shrine-keepers who came after her at Achadh chaol lit a new lamp without her name on it, for want of any line to carry the name from. Elsewhere in that year's telling the copyists let every doubled hand and disputed order stand, for a reader to weigh one against the other. Here they let the page stand empty, and wrote nothing to fill it.

PART SIX

OF the WAR of the hills

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

Of the Warning and the Constables

AE 138 – 141

I

Of the Grey Fever

Eilidh nic Raghnaill was three-and-thirty the winter the fever came in on the ships, and she had already buried her father.

Ragnall Breac had died the summer before under the hill at Cill ghlas, and there was no grave to go to, only the fence. She had gone back to Baile thais and to the crew she led at the pit-mouth, and to the room behind the burial club's hall where six or seven met at a time and called themselves nothing, because a thing with no name could not be struck off a Company roll. She had taken her father's place there without being asked to and without anyone saying she had.

On the second of Gearran a coal ship out of an Tìr Thall¹ put in at Ros dhomhain with nine men too sick to stand, and by the time the harbour physician came aboard, four of the crew who had carried them up from the hold were coughing too. The Mission's clerk who wrote the entry called it a fever of the chest, plain and grey, not the green sickness of the galleries and not the flux of the quays that the older custodians still remembered, but a thing of its own, and it went through the young and the strong before it troubled the old, which was against all the custodians' long experience of fevers and which no one below the Residency could explain. It ran inland along the coal roads the way every sickness on the island now ran, because every road on the island now led, sooner or later, to a pit.

At Baile thais it came up from the harbour in a carter's chest cough by the middle of Gearran, and Eilidh watched two of her own crew go down inside a

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

fortnight, a hewer named Tormod Buidhe and his sister's boy who had not yet had his first wage. She sat with them by turns, because the burial club's rule was that no one died watched only by strangers, and she was better at sitting than most, having had the practice of it with her father. Tormod Buidhe lived. The boy did not.

"He asked me what month it was," Eilidh told the room behind the hall, the night after she buried him. "Near the end. He asked what month it was, and I told him, and he said it wrong back to me, and then he didn't say anything more."

Nobody answered her. It was not the kind of thing the room answered.

She had kept the burial club's rule of sitting long before it was hers to keep, because her father had taught her it before he taught her anything else about the crew she now led: that a man dying underground or above it had a right to a face he knew bent over him, and that the right did not stop being a right because the man dying was a stranger's hired hand rather than kin. Tormod Buidhe, when the fever had run its course in him and left him standing, thin and grey-skinned and slower on the ladders than he had been, thanked her for the sitting in the flat way men thanked her for things they had not expected a crew-leader to trouble herself with, and went back to the pit-head within the fortnight because the Company's wage did not wait on a man's convalescence. The boy she had no name to give beyond the one his mother had given him, because the club's rule was also that a name too new to the world was the family's to keep or share as it chose, and his mother, when Eilidh went to her afterward, chose to keep it, and Eilidh did not ask twice.

The fever did not confine itself to Baile thais, though Baile thais felt it worst of the hill camps that first season, being close-packed and close-breathing in a way the older, looser settlements were not. Along the coal roads it went the way every sickness on the island went now, following the carts rather than the weather, so that a camp a day's walk from the sea might catch it from a camp two days inland before either heard word of the other's dying. The custodians who kept the rolls that year learned to write the fever's progress the way a keeper wrote a tide, a thing that came and went and came again, worse in some towns than others for reasons no clerk below the Residency could set down with any confidence.

By the middle of an t-Iuchar the fever had reached Cathair mhòr, and there for the first time in the town's whole memory the market shut, stall by stall, until the custodians' roll for that week gave the dead by street and the longest list was the street of the carters, who breathed each other's coughing all day over the

scales. Word of it came to Baile thais three days late, by a drover who had it from a drover, and Eilidh wrote it into the club's own book, which was not the custodians' roll and answered to no one, in the plain hand her father had taught her: *Cathair mhòr, market shut, the carters' street worst*. She had begun keeping that book the year he died, because she had watched him carry twenty years of names in his head and give none of them to anyone, and she did not mean to do the same.

The worst of it that year came at Dùn thais in the last days of an Dùbhlachd, where the Administration had for once sent a physician of its own rather than leaving the sickness to the custodians and the Mission between them. He took the fever from the patients he was treating and died of it inside the month, and two of the Mission's nursing sisters with him, in the same week the old halls of the druid masters, empty since the teaching under the trees of Flidais had gone quieter than it used to be, were opened again as sick-rooms for want of anywhere else to put the dying. Eilidh had never met the physician and felt his death less than she felt the boy's, and was ashamed of that, and wrote it in the book anyway, because the book's rule, like the burial club's, was that a name went in whether or not the hand writing it had loved the person.

"They send us one doctor and the coal takes him too," said Griogal, an old hewer who had signed on with the club before Eilidh was born and outlived, by his own reckoning, three crew-leaders and two commissioners. "That's a fair trade, if you're counting."

"I'm not counting," Eilidh said. "I'm writing it down. There's a difference."

"Not much of one, from where I sit."

II

Of the Second Petition

It was in that same fever winter, with the club's book already three pages longer than she had meant it to grow, that Eilidh began the thing that would carry her name into the Residency's letter-books whether she wished it there or not.

The first petition, the one drawn up at Ceann àrsaidh and carried by Peigi Ghlas to the Residency forty years before, which had ended, as Eilidh had heard it told a hundred times, with Peigi trimming a lamp at Cill ghlas and saying nothing

more about it to anyone, had asked. Eilidh had grown up on the story of that asking and on the silence that came back for it, and she did not mean to ask twice in the same voice.

She drafted the new petition in the burial club's room by a single coal lamp, over three nights, with Griogal and two others reading each page back to her aloud so she could hear where it went soft. It was not long, and set out, in plain terms and without a grievance wasted on complaint, what the tithe had cost the settlements of the hills in the fever years and the drought years before them, what the Levy had cost before that and been ended too late to matter, and what the galleries themselves had cost in men, in tens counted plainly and not rounded the way the Company's own returns rounded them. Nothing in it was new. Its last line repeated the sentence the first petition had buried in the middle of a long paragraph where the Residency's clerks could read past it without noticing: that the hill would not go on being worked by people who were not asked whether it should be.

She did not write "would not be worked." She wrote "would not go on being worked," because Griogal made her say both aloud three times and told her the second one sounded like a woman who meant it and the first sounded like a woman asking permission to mean it, and she saw that he was right.

The petition went out from Baile thais on foot and by cart through the spring and summer of the next year, carried crew-leader to crew-leader and custodian to custodian by people who did not write down who had carried it to them, in case the list of carriers should ever be asked for by someone with the power to make it a list of the dismissed. By the twelfth of Lùnastal it had come to Cnoc dhìreach, where the custodian of that place, a broad quiet man named Coinneach Ruadh who had kept the post for eleven years and clerked for the Company store besides, out of the same door most mornings, read it through twice at his own table before he signed it.

He was nine-and-forty that summer, old enough, he told his wife, to have signed worse things for less reason and to know the difference now that it mattered. He signed under his own name and his town's, the way the petition asked, rather than with the custodian's mark alone, because he judged, rightly as it turned out within the week, that a mark could be denied afterward and a name could not.

The Company's agent at Cnoc dhìreach had the letter of dismissal drawn up before the ink on Coinneach Ruadh's signature was properly dry, and delivered it

to the store's door on the market-day, in front of the queue for the week's flour, so that everyone in the queue should understand plainly what a name under that petition was worth to a man who needed the Company's wage to feed a family. Coinneach Ruadh took the letter, read it standing in the queue where he had been handed it, folded it once, and put it inside his coat.

"Eleven years," he said to no one in particular, "and they didn't even wait for the week to turn."

He was one of eleven signatories who lost Company work that season for the names they had put to the petition, and of the eleven his was the one the custodians afterward remembered best, because he had been offered, twice, the chance to withdraw his name before the letter was drawn, and had twice declined it without argument, saying only that a name once given did not, in his understanding of the custodian's own law, belong to the giver to take back.

Word of it reached Eilidh at Baile thais within the week, carried, like the petition itself, by someone who did not give a name for the carrying. She had never met Coinneach Ruadh; it was some years yet before she did. Still she asked the messenger to describe him, and kept what she was told, a broad man, quiet, slow to raise his voice and slower still to lower his eyes; for she had begun, without quite deciding to, keeping a second kind of record alongside the club's book, a tally now of the living who had put a name to something and paid for it, so that if the day ever came when the petition's cost was totted up in full, the account would have more in it than hers alone. Griogal, when she told him, said only that eleven clerkships were a cheap price for the Administration to pay for silence and a dear one for eleven households to pay for a sentence, and that the two prices were never going to look the same from both sides of the ledger, whatever the petition said about being asked.

By the last days of an Dùbhlachd, when the petition had gathered the hands of custodians and crew-leaders across one-and-thirty settlements from the hill camps to the coast, it went up at last to the Residency in a fair copy Eilidh made herself, in her own hand, because she would not have anyone say afterward that a woman's name had been put to words she had not written. The Residency's clerk who received it underlined the petition's last sentence in red ink before he passed it up the office, and it was that underlining, more than anything the petition itself said, that the custodians afterward agreed was the first sign the humans' Administration had ever given of having read a Dia-thirich word and understood what it meant.

"It's the first thing they've troubled to answer," Eilidh said, when word of the underlining reached Baile thais by the same slow relay of carts and drovers that had carried the petition out. "That has to be worth something."

"It's worth exactly what the answer turns out to be," said Griogal, "and not a hair more."

III

Of the Answer

The answer, when it came, was constables.

In the last days of Gearran the following year word went round the coal roads that Merriman, who held the Commissioner's seat and had held it, by then, the better part of eight years, had ordered the constabulary tripled and posted companies at four of the largest camps at once: Muileann chrom, Baile thais, Ceann fhada and Cnoc chaol, each with its own fortified store built or refitted inside the month, and each paid for, the custodians' rolls noted with a particular flatness, out of the tithe the petition had complained of in the first place.

Eilidh watched the first company march into Baile thais on the twenty-fifth of that same Gearran, forty men in the Administration's grey with a wagon of timber and iron grille behind them for the new store's windows, and she understood before a single order was read aloud that the underlined sentence had not been answered so much as it had been priced.

"They read it," she said to Griogal, standing at the edge of the crowd that had gathered, silent, to watch the company make its camp on the ground below the pit-head that had until that morning been common ground for drying washing. "They read every word of it. And this is what they wrote back."

The store the constables built at Baile thais stood finished within the fortnight, walled and barred where the old Company store had stood open on three sides, and from that week the settlement's own well, which had served the whole camp since before the concession was granted, lay inside the new wall and had to be asked for.

The officer who commanded the company, a young man named Prosser with a new coat and an old rifle, called the settlement together on his first rest-day to read the order that had sent him, and Eilidh stood at the back of the crowd with Griogal on one side of her and the old woman who kept the club's rolls on the

other, and listened to a paper written in the Administration's flattest hand explain that the constables were come for the settlement's own protection, in these uncertain times, against disorder from any quarter. Nobody in the crowd laughed. The hill camps had long since learned the cost of laughing at a man with a rifle in front of his own company. Eilidh heard instead, all down the ranks of people around her, a particular silence, one she had learned to recognise from her own room behind the hall, where it meant a thing was being noted rather than accepted.

"For our protection," Griogal said afterward, low, "against disorder from any quarter. He didn't say whose disorder he meant. I don't suppose he needed to."

"He meant ours," Eilidh said.

"He meant ours," Griogal agreed, "and he's not wrong to. He just hasn't worked out yet how right he is."

A month later, in am Màrt, a barracks went up at Dùn chrom, on the capital side of the hills where the coal roads met the road to Ros dhomhain, built to hold two hundred men against a rising the Administration had apparently decided, on the strength of one petition and eleven dismissals, was now more likely than not to come. For most of that first year the barracks stood empty for want of constables to fill it, a fact the club's book recorded without comment, because Eilidh had learned by then that some facts were their own comment and needed no help from her pen.

"An empty barracks for two hundred men," Griogal said, the night she read the entry aloud, "built before there's anyone to put in it. That's a man building the wall before he's sure there's a war, and calling it an answer."

"Then we'd best not be the ones to prove him right too soon," Eilidh said, and put the book away.

IV

Of the Hawk and the Sermon

The hawk-priests had their own answer, and it was not one the Residency had asked for.

At Seann Skell that spring a priest of Mòd named Ìomhar Seabhag, who had kept the shrine there since before Eilidh could remember, began to preach that the hawk's long hunger, starved so many generations on the measured handful and the old teaching that a people who ate faster than the land could feed

them would in the end be eaten by their own eating, had turned at last toward those who had done the eating: the Company, and the Administration behind it, and every hand that had signed a charter for a vein it had not asked leave to open. It was not a new teaching so much as an old one pointed, for the first time in most people's hearing, at a single target.

Word of the sermon travelled the way Murchadh Seabhag's had travelled two generations before, by fowlers carrying birds to the autumn markets and by carters who learned it by ear from men who had heard it whole, and within the season the hawk-shrines of the west had quietly become meeting-places for the club and for others like it across the settlements, without any order given that could be written down and used against them. The constables, garrisoned in their new stores and barracks, did not yet know it, and would not for some while, because a shrine was a shrine to them and nothing more, and no constable posted at a coal camp thought to ask why the hawk-priests of a dozen towns had lately grown so attentive to who came and went from their doors.

At Ros gheal, where the hawk-faithful fishing families had chased the Company's first customs officers off the harbour a hundred years before and had never entirely stopped being proud of it, they raised a shrine to Mòd on the harbour wall itself that same season, in open sight of the customs house their grandparents had emptied. The constables ordered it down within the week, and a sergeant with four men pulled the stones of it into the water on a grey morning with half the town watching from doorways and saying nothing. It stood again inside three days, built in the dark by hands nobody in the town would name even to each other, and the constables pulled it down a second time, and a third, and by the third time they had stopped trying. No order had told them to stop; a sergeant who has torn down the same nine stones three mornings running begins, whatever his orders, to feel the particular foolishness of a man fighting a harbour rather than a person, and there is no rifle drilled that answers that. The fourth shrine stood at Ros gheal still, uncounted and unremarked, the ordinary furniture of a wall that had always had something on it.

At Inis bhàn, that same summer, the priests of the hawk sat down for the first time in living memory with a handful of the old teachers who still kept, quietly and mostly among themselves, the disputations of the druid school that the Administration had shut at Dùn thais years before. The two orders had disagreed for six generations over questions neither Eilidh nor anyone in her room behind the hall could have named with any confidence, the shape of the vein's own hunger,

whether Mòd fed or merely watched, whether the school's old habit of answering one question with another was wisdom or evasion; and the meeting, by every account that reached Baile thais, settled none of it. The hawk-priest who had called the meeting was heard afterward to say that he had come away no surer of the druids' answers than he had gone in, and prouder of them for it than he had expected to be. It is written of that meeting only that it settled nothing between the two orders, and that both sides, having failed entirely to agree on the questions that had divided them for six generations, parted as friends, which struck Eilidh, when the news of it reached her, as very near the whole of what she had hoped the petition might do in the first place.

The fever, meanwhile, had not finished with the island. It returned that same summer and settled hardest in the north-west, about Baile chrom and the towns of the concession, where for the first time it took humans as readily as it took Dia-thìrich, sparing neither the concession farms nor the Dia-thìreach villages beside them. At Cathair gheal the Mission's hospital filled past anything it had beds for, and Hannah Webb, who had kept her night watch in the fields behind Baile chrom these eight years, went there to nurse, and found herself nursing in wards where Dia-thìrich and human sick lay side by side for the first time in the concession's history, because there was no longer room, or will, to keep them apart.

"They wouldn't share a well with us a year ago," she wrote, in a letter set down for her by a Mission clerk that went the rounds of the burial clubs as far as Baile thais, "and now they'll share a ward. I don't know if that's the fever teaching them something or just too tired to keep up the wall."

The letter went on, in the plain hand of the clerk who had written it out at Hannah's dictation, to describe a night when the ward had held eleven beds and twelve patients and a Dia-thìreach overman from the north-west galleries had given up his own cot without being asked to a human boy of the concession who could not have been more than nine, and had sat the rest of the night on the floor beside him with his coat rolled under the boy's head, and had said, when the Mission's sister thanked him for it in the morning, only that he had buried enough of his own that year not to want to watch a stranger's child go the same way for lack of a bed. Eilidh read that part of the letter three times before she read the rest of it, and thought of Tormod Buidhe's sister's boy, and did not write that part down, because some things she judged belonged to the person who had lived them and not to the club's book at all.

Eilidh put what remained of it in the book.

Further north the fever's returning was met each town in its own way. Muileann fhionn, a Dia-thìreach mill town of the concession country, shut its roads against it entirely that following spring and kept them shut a whole season, turning back the human carters of the concession at the town's edge with their loads still on the carts, a thing no custodian there had ordered and every custodian there afterward defended, and a thing the constables, still thin on the ground so far north, had neither the men nor, that season, the stomach to undo. A carter who tried the road twice and was turned back twice told it afterward as the only week of his working life he had been glad of a closed gate rather than aggrieved by one, because he had seen by then, on the roads behind him, what an open one let through.

At Tobar fhiadhaich, further north still, the fever took one household in three before it burned itself out, and the custodians of that small place, who had heard the old story of Sìne Ruadh's burnings at Àth ghlais from their own grandparents and had thought long about it, judged in the end that it had come on them too fast and too widely to be stopped by fire, and buried their dead instead without burning a single hut, a choice the roll records without praise or blame, in the same flat hand it used for everything else that year. One household in three was a count Eilidh made herself set down twice before she believed it, and she thought, writing it the second time, of the empty barracks at Dùn chrom built for a war that had not yet come, and of how much easier, in the end, it had proved for the Administration to build a wall for men who were not there than to send a single physician to a village that was dying by households rather than names.

It was the sermon from Seann Skell that Eilidh chose, in the end, to bring before the room behind the burial club's hall, on an evening in Giblean when the fever had gone quiet again for the first time in three years and the new constables' watch had, for once, let the road home from the pit-head pass without a search. A fowler passing through with birds for the spring market had left a written copy with the club's door-keeper, three pages in a copyist's hand, close enough to Ìomhar Seabhag's words, by the copy-keeper's account, to be trusted.

She read it by the same coal lamp she had drafted the petition by, a year and more before, and the room listened the way a room listens to a thing it has been waiting to hear said aloud by someone other than itself: Griogal with his hands still, the two youngest crew-leaders with their eyes on the lamp rather than on her, an old woman from the burial club's own rolls nodding at the parts she had already half known.

"The hawk remembers every meal it is given," she read, "and every meal it is kept from, and it keeps the reckoning longer than any clerk." She looked up once, at the line about the eating and the eaten, and saw on every face in the room the same thing she had felt reading it herself the first time: a thing nearer to hope than the petition, underlined in red ink and answered with constables, had brought them, and nearer still to the plain, hard patience of people who have waited a long time and mean to go on waiting a while longer.

She read it to the end and set the pages down and did not, for once, reach for the club's book to write anything in it. Some things, she had begun to learn that year, did not need her hand to be kept; they kept themselves, in the ears of everyone who had heard them said aloud in a room with the door barred and a lamp burning coal that had cost a man his life to cut.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

Of the Houses on the Roads

AE 141 – 146

Cha tug mi dhut ach an rud a bha thu ag iarraidh nach fhaicinn. I
gave you only what you wanted not to see.

I

Of the House at the Halfway Stage

Aonghas had kept An Taigh-seinnse Mòr for six years before he understood that the keeping of it had quietly become an answer to a question nobody had ever put to him straight. His great-grandmother Seònaid Bhàn had opened the house again in the first years of the digging, when the coal road was new mud and the carters still carried both coin and barter in the same pocket and

would take either without a word said over it. The house had never once in three generations shut its door on a traveller who could pay. Aonghas kept that rule as he had been given it. He kept the accounts in the same ledger his grandfather had used, the covers gone soft as cloth, and he kept, without ever writing it anywhere, a second reckoning that had nothing to do with marks.

By the autumn of the hundred and forty-first year the second reckoning had grown larger than the first.

It began, as most things on the coal road began, with a man Aonghas had never met asking a favour he had not thought to refuse. A crew-leader from Baile thais came down with a Company cart of scrap iron and asked, over a cup he paid for honestly, whether the loft above the stable might hold six men a night or two, now and again, no questions wanted and none offered. Aonghas said the loft held what it held. He did not ask what the men carried, coming or going, and in time he stopped noticing that he had stopped asking. It was easier that way, and easier, he told himself, was not the same as blind.

He was not alone in it. Up the northern road, at An Leòmhann Buidhe¹, they took on six new ostlers in a single season, and every carter on the road remarked, laughing, that not one of the six knew one end of a horse from the other. At the singing house, An Taigh-òsta Grianach², whose songs had been Fearchar Bàrd's in the carters' grandfathers' day, they raised a wall round the yard and set a boy at the gate with a horn he had never once had cause to blow, though he kept it polished all the same. Down on the south-western road, at Am Buabhall Fortanach, Tormod Buabhall barred his gates at dusk and put a man on the roof with a glass, and once a week, on no fixed day, he sent a folded list up the road in the saddlebag of whichever rider was going that way, and never told anyone, not even the rider, into whose hand it was meant to come. Aonghas met him twice at the horse-fair at Muileann shean and never once asked him what was on the list. It was not a thing men on the coal road asked one another in those years. A house that asked too many questions of its guests soon found it had none.

The Administration called none of this by any name. There was no order posted, no notice nailed to a Company board, because there was nothing yet to forbid; six houses walling their own yards against thieves was no different in the letter of any law from An Taigh-seinnse Òir³, the great house beyond Dùn dhearg,

1. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

2. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

3. the golden house, a waypoint inn

digging a well in its yard that same season and walling it round, against thieves, its keeper said. Aonghas turned it over some nights with his back to the fire and his ledger unopened on his knee, and came to call that the design of it, if design was the word for a thing that had grown up the way heather grows up a burnt hill, from no one plan and every man's smallest choice. A house could not be charged with sedition for keeping its gate shut after dark.

II

Of the Landing Below the Fortunate House

Below Am Buabhall Fortanach, where the south-western road ran down toward the sea before it climbed again into the hills, there was a harbour too small to have a name in any Company chart, though the fishermen who worked it called it Doire shean, after the stand of old oaks on the point above it. It had never shipped anything grander than herring and the odd cargo of slate, and the Company's agents, who counted every barrel that moved by water on the west coast, had long since stopped troubling to count Doire shean's.

That was its use. What the great house on the road above could not carry by cart, for weight or for the eyes that watched the road, went down instead by the old fishing path to the little harbour, and came up again by the same path in the dark of the next tide. The fishermen of Doire shean, who had fished that water three generations under three different flags of custodian and Company both, took to being paid, for certain nights' work that were never spoken of as work, in the silver guild's bar, cut small, rather than in the coin the Administration minted at Ros dhomhain. Nobody asked where the silver came from and nobody, least of all the fishermen, was fool enough to spend it where a Company clerk might see it change hands. It went, most of it, into the ground under a hearthstone or into a widow's dowry chest, to be spent, if ever, by whoever came after, without asking what nights had earned it.

Aonghas went down to Doire shean himself twice that year, on pretence of buying herring for the house, and stood on the point in the wind with old Coinneach nan Ràmh, who had fished the water since before the first pit opened at Muileann chrom, and said nothing that either of them could not have said before a magistrate. It was Coinneach who told him, without being asked, that the loft at An Taigh-seinnse Reòta on the northern road was never once, in two years,

found empty by the Company's carters passing through, and never once held the same men two nights running. "They come like the tide," the old man said, "and go like it, and no man's ever caught the tide at its turning." Aonghas thought that a fine thing to say and a truer one than most things said on the coal road in those years, and he carried it home and kept it, the way he kept the ledger, without ever writing it down.

III

Of the Post at the Far Shore and the Boys of the Ford

Word, in those years, moved slower than silver and faster than either the Company or the Administration ever managed to learn. It moved through An Sligeanach Fad' às¹, the post-house on the eastern road near the silver country, whose keeper took his rent, openly and by the season, from the silver guild of Muileann chiar, and who never once in five years lost a letter that was worth the losing. Through him the Lamp-Watch sent its word to the guild and the guild sent its silver back, and the Administration, whose own post rode the same road on the same days, never once thought to ask why a road-house should need two keepers' worth of trade to fill one keeper's ledger.

The letters themselves, once past the Sligeanach's door, went the last stage by boys. They came out of Àth fhiadhaich, sons and nephews of the ford's boatmen, twelve years old and thirteen, too small for a constable to trouble with and too quick on the causeway paths for a mounted man to follow. They carried nothing that looked like a letter: a fold of paper inside a boot, a line of words learned by heart and said over to a woman at a well who would say them over again to somebody else three villages on. Aonghas met one of them once, a boy called nothing worth remembering here, who came into the house's yard soaked to the knee from the ford and asked for bread as any boy might, and left an hour later having said not one word out of place, and having left, folded under the loose board by the stable door where Aonghas kept certain things, a scrap that named a date and nothing else. Aonghas burned it that night in the kitchen fire, the way he burned every such scrap, and watched it curl and thought, not for the first time, how

1. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

small and how ordinary a shape a great and terrible thing can wear while it is still only beginning.

The money for it all, for the boys' bread, the Sligeanach's rent, the loft at the Reòta that fed men it never named, was kept, in those years, at Achadh mhòr, a village of no great size near the great house on the eastern road, in the roof-space of its own shrine, above the rafters where the sacred lamp burned and below the thatch where no constable's search had ever thought, or dared, to reach. The custodian there was an old woman who kept the ledger of it in a hand so cramped and so plain that a stranger, finding it, would have taken it for a list of candles bought and wicks trimmed. Aonghas never saw that ledger. He knew only that when the loft at his own house needed feeding, word came, and marks came with it, folded inside a psalter that travelled the road as innocently as any priest's book ever had.

IV

Of the Fire Taken for Heath

The day of 27 am Màrt, AE 143, was a dry, hard, bright day with a wind out of the north-west that had been blowing three days running and had scoured the sky to a colour Aonghas remembered afterward as harder than any blue he had seen before or since. He was in the yard at midday, seeing to a cart of coal-tubs bound down for Ros dhomhain, when one of the carters straightened and pointed east, up toward the long shoulder of Cnoc an Rabhaidh, where a thread of smoke was going up thin and steady into the wind.

"Heath fire," the carter said, and shrugged, and went back to his harness, because in that wind, on that hill, in that month, it was the likeliest thing in the world, and every man in the yard had seen a dozen such fires start from nothing more than a spark off a flint and burn themselves out by nightfall. Aonghas watched it a moment longer than the carter did. He had heard, though from whom he could no longer afterward have said, that the hill above Doire mhòr, a poor place now, its households few since it refused the Company's first contract and lost its water after, was to carry, on a day and at an hour nobody named aloud, a fire that was not heath at all, lit by the children's children of a woman called Beathag Dhubh, whose name the camps still used the way other places used a saint's.

Aonghas did not move from the yard, having no order to give and no man of his own to send, and reasoning that if the fire on Cnoc an Rabhaidh was the thing he half suspected it to be, then moving would tell any watching eye more than standing still. So he stood, and watched the smoke, and within the hour every wheel and hammer and windlass within sight and sound of the yard had stopped.

Every working the coal country held stopped in the same hour, without a single order carried by any rider the Administration's own scouts could find. At Muileann bheag, far off among the druid villages in the north-east, the pits stopped, and the custodian there wrote afterward, in words that reached even Aonghas's ears months later, that it was the first thing her town had done with the hills in a hundred years. At Àth dhomhain in the north a runner on foot brought the word rather than any beacon, and the pits stopped all the same; their crew-leaders were among those the Administration later took and never gave back. On the northern coast the loading at Ceann bheag stopped before the dockers there had even been told to stop it; the coal simply ceased to come down to them, and they laid down their hooks because there was nothing left to lift. Quarrymen at Cnoc gheal, who cut no coal and owed the Lamp-Watch no debt that any ledger recorded, laid down their tools with the rest and gave, when asked, no reason at all.

At Muileann chrom itself, and with it Baile thais, Cnoc chaol, the silver town and the eastern pits at Ros fhionn, every wheel stood still in the same hour the smoke went up from Cnoc an Rabhaidh. The Administration's own agents, writing it down afterward for the Company's ledgers, called it the first stoppage the resistance of the coal country had ever managed to hold together, and granted, in words Aonghas heard repeated on the road for years after with something close to pride, that scattered as the Dia-thìrich of the hills were, town from town and valley from valley, they could act as one people when they chose to.

The yard at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr held that day a dozen men who could do nothing but wait. Aonghas fed them all, coal-tubs man and idle carter alike, and took no coin from any of them, and a woman among the carters, a driver named Cairistìona who worked the eastern run and had never before sat down in his kitchen, asked him quietly why he gave away a day's custom for nothing. "Because a house that charges for waiting is a house nobody waits in," he told her, "and I would rather have them here where I can see them than scattered on the road

where I can't." She laughed at that, the first laugh the kitchen had heard all day, and it did him more good than the coin he had given up.

V

Of the Six Days

Aonghas kept his own house open through it, as he had always kept it open, and turned no traveller from the door, though there were fewer travellers in those six days than the house had seen in any six days of his keeping. The coal road itself stood nearly empty; the carts that would have carried coal down to Ros dhomhain had nothing to carry, and the drivers who would have driven them sat instead in his yard with cups they were slow to finish, listening for word from the hills the way men listen for weather.

At Ros dhomhain the Company's steamships lay six days at the quay with their holds as empty as the day they were built, and the agents there wrote, in letters that found their way back up the road by the same paths the silver and the psalters travelled, that they had never in their years on the coast seen the harbour so quiet, and that the quiet frightened them a good deal more than any crowd ever had. A harbour that shouts can be answered with constables. A harbour that says nothing at all cannot be argued with, because it has offered nothing to argue against.

Force ended it, and no agreement. As the year went out the constables shut the Company's stores in every district of the coal country at once, so that a man who had stopped work in solidarity found within a day that his household could not eat without going back to it. Forty crew-leaders were taken up in the same sweep, from the hills and the eastern pits and the quarries at Cnoc gheal alike. Thirty-two of them were let go inside the fortnight, the Administration having found, on reflection, no law under which to hold men for standing idle on their own ground. The remaining eight went aboard a Company ship at Ros dhomhain and were carried east, for trial, it was said, in an Tír Thall¹, and no letter, no rumour, no word carried by boy or boat or silver-bought fisherman ever came back from any one of them. Aonghas asked, over the years that followed, more than once, of more than one man who might have known, and got nothing for an answer but a

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

shake of the head, which in time he learned to give himself when others asked him the same question.

The constables burned the heather of Cnoc an Rabhaidh that same week, to deny the hill a second such beacon, and it grew back thin and late the following spring, the way burned heather does, and it was three years before anyone on that road spoke openly of the fire that had, everyone by then knew and no one by then troubled to deny, been no heath fire at all.

VI

Of the Idle Harbours

The ships grew fewer after that, and older. No single season and no single order brought it about; it crept in the way frost creeps into a house through a door left an inch ajar, unnoticed until the cold is everywhere at once. The keepers' daybooks at the five beacons of the ring, whose only business had ever been to count the sails from over the sea, began to show, year on year, fewer ships making the crossing, and the ships that did come were older hulls, patched and re-patched, as though the yards that built them had troubles of their own that the Company's letters never named outright, speaking only, when they spoke of it at all, of difficulties at home.

At Caol leathan the wool piled in the warehouses for want of ships to carry it to the humans' market, and the merchants there, who had for two generations sold nothing but by the Company's weight and at the Company's price, began quietly, against the plain letter of the law, to sell it inland again by barter, the way their grandmothers had sold it before the first ship ever came down from the north. At Caol bheag, on the northern coast, the Company's quay, built at no small cost for a trade in the eastern grain and the eastern cloth that had never, even in its best year, come to half of what had been promised for it, saw one ship in the whole of a season, and the agent stationed there, a solitary man in a solitary house at the edge of a coast that had never wanted him, wrote to Ros dhomhain that he had been forgotten, and got, so far as anyone on the coal road ever heard, no answer at all.

VII

Of Leave No Longer Asked

The last of it, for Aonghas, came at Ros dhomhain rather than on the road, where he had gone in the autumn of the hundred and forty-sixth year, on the ordinary business of the house, to buy salt and nails and the small iron things a road-house could not make for its own use. He found himself in the market square, more by chance than by design, on the day the Residency's notice was read aloud from its own steps, as such notices always were, to whatever crowd the harbour cared to send.

It was known already, before the notice, that Charles Merriman had gone. He had held the Commissioner's seat fourteen years, since the year Iain Maor died and his daughter Mòrag took up the staff, and he left now in health too poor, it was given out, for the climate of the island, though there were those in the crowd that day who said it low, meant only for Dia-thìreach ears near them, that a man's health failed faster under a coal country that would not stay still than under any weather the island had ever sent him. In his fourteen years the Administration had begun, by such small and unspoken steps as the walling of a well and the manning of a roof, to give its commands without first troubling to ask the leave of anyone at all, and the pretence of leave asked and given, which had stood since the council's vote in the second year of the strangers, had worn thinner every year.

A stranger read the new notice, a soldier by his bearing and his coat both, unknown to every face in the square, and his name, given at the notice's head, was Lionel Strake. Aonghas listened, as the whole square listened, to the reading of his commission from the Residency's own steps, a long document in the flat unhurried voice the humans kept for such things, naming his powers and his charge and the authority under which he held them. It named the Company. It named the Administration in an 'Tìr 'Thall¹. Nowhere in the whole length of it did it name the Council of Custodians, not once, not even in the old polite formula, *with the leave and counsel of*, that every Commissioner's commission before it, back to the first, had carried as a matter of course.

Aonghas stood in the square and understood, with no one beside him to say it aloud and no need for anyone to, that the pretence was over, let fall quietly with no vote and no battle to mark its falling, simply no longer thought worth the

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

keeping up. He bought his salt and his nails and rode home up the coal road in the dark, past An Sligeanach Fad' às² with its lamp lit and its post-bag hanging ready by the door, past the loft at the Reòta where a light showed and went out as he passed, and came at last to his own gate, where he stood a moment before going in, looking back down the road the way a man looks back at a house he has just left for the last time, though he had left nothing, and the house he looked at was only the coal road itself, running east into the dark toward whatever the soldier's commission, read without the council's name in it, was going to mean for all of them next.

He went in, and barred the gate, and did not, that night or for a long while after, write anything at all in the ledger with the soft covers his grandfather had kept.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

OF the BREAKING OF the STAFF

AE 147 – 149

I

Of the Iron Bird

Mòrag nic Iain Maor was fifty-two that winter, and had held the overseer's staff of Muileann chrom for sixteen years, and had not slept a full night since the inquiry into the fight at the pithead, where she had told the Administration's table plainly that the pumps were stopped on the agent's order and had watched a clerk draw a line through the words as she said them. The Lamp-Watch had a copy of her testimony all the same, kept in the

2. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

burial club's box under the false bottom with the burying-money, and she knew it, and had never asked to see it, because a thing a woman does not hold cannot be taken from her hand.

She was at the weighing-shed door on the morning the bird came over, checking the tally against the agent's book as she had checked it every working day since her father died, when the crews at the pit-mouth below her stopped their barrows all at once and stood looking up. She looked up herself. It came from the south, low over the ridge, a long grey shape with wings that did not beat, trailing a sound like a swarm too large for any hive, and it went the length of the valley and back again before it climbed away toward Ros dhomhain and was gone.

Nobody at Muileann chrom had a word for it that morning. By evening every hearth in the district had one, borrowed from nowhere and understood at once: eun-iarainn, the iron bird, a thing that flew and was not alive. The old women said a bird that did not beat its wings had no soul in it and could carry none away, which was some comfort, though none of them could say what it had come to do, only that it had counted something from the air that the ground would not have given up so easily.

Mòrag wrote it into her own book that night, under the tally, in the private hand her father had taught her that no agent ever asked to read: *a grey bird went over the valley twice and did not sing*. She did not know yet that it had gone the length of every working district on the island that season, from Doire mhòr to the eastern silver country, and that Strake, new come to the Residency, meant to have on paper what the ground would not give the Company's surveyors on foot.

Word of Strake reached the district before the bird did. Merriman had gone home sick the autumn before, an old man worn thin by fourteen years of a climate that had never once been unkind to him, and the man who came after him was a soldier, not a merchant, and did not trouble to send the custom letter asking the council's leave for anything. His commission was read out at the Residency to an empty bench where the Council of Custodians' seats had always stood, and no one from the council was there to hear it, because no one from the council had been asked. Coinneach Ruadh, who had lost his clerkship at Cnoc dhìreach for signing the second petition and had taken to riding the district roads with news nobody paid him for carrying, brought that word to Muileann chrom himself, sitting at Mòrag's table with his boots steaming by the fire.

"They've locked the hall," he said. "The whole council hall at Cathair dhearg, doors and all, and the keys gone down to the Residency in a soldier's pocket. The

custodians are sitting in Macha's temple now, on the priests' own floor, because Macha's priests took them in when nobody else in the capital would risk the Residency's temper."

"The priests that blessed the coin," Mòrag said.

"The same," said Coinneach. "Half the order left the capital's temple years back for the forest at Cnoc bheag over that blessing, and it's the half that stayed and gave it who've opened the door to the council now. A blessing's a cheap thing to give, it turns out, and a dear thing to have given."

II

Of the Edict of Seizure

The edict came down in the autumn, printed in the Residency's own press and nailed to the counting-house door at every working on the island in the same week, so that no district could say afterward it had not been warned in time, though warning and consent are not the same thing and the edict asked for neither. It claimed for the Administration the right to take any dwelling of the Dia-thirich that it judged needful for the widening of the workings, at a price the Administration itself would set, and it gave no appeal.

Doire mhòr was a morning's walk above Muileann chrom, close enough that Mòrag rode over herself when the first word came that the constables were there, though there was nothing in it that was hers to mend. It was the village whose custodian, Beathag Dhubh, had refused the Company's contract at her own door more than a hundred and thirty years before, and whose last few households were the first emptied now under the last edict the Company would ever write. She stood at the top of the lane while the constables carried out beds and looms and a loom-comb some grandmother's grandmother had carved, and stacked them at the roadside in the rain because the new shaft beneath the hill could not wait for dry weather any more than it could wait for leave. An old man sat on his own doorstep with his hands over his knees and would not move until two constables lifted him by the arms, not roughly, which was somehow worse than roughness would have been, because it meant they had been told to be gentle about a thing that could not be made gentle by the manner of the doing.

"Write it down," the old man said to nobody, to the rain, to Mòrag standing at the lane's head in her overseer's coat that marked her for a woman with some

standing, though standing had never once turned back a cart. "Write down that they were gentle about it. Somebody ought to know they were gentle."

She had no book with her that day. She carried the sentence home in her head instead and set it down that night beside the grey bird that did not sing, in the private hand, because a thing written in two places is harder to unwrite than a thing written in one.

At Baile dhomhain, nearer still, the camp that had been laid out on the Company's own paper before a stone of it was cut, two whole streets came down within the month for a spoil-tip that the surveyors said the new galleries would need before winter. The Company offered huts at Àth iséal and marks for the timber of the houses it took, which some families kept, weighing the marks against the winter coming, and most did not, going instead to kin in the hill villages where there was a floor to sleep on that no edict could nail a notice to. Mòrag heard the tally of it from the district's own custodian, a quiet woman named Sineag who had never before had cause to ride to the steward's house and rode there now white about the mouth, asking whether the overseer's staff of Muileann chrom could do anything at all for a street that was not, strictly, Muileann chrom's to answer for.

"Nothing," Mòrag told her, which was true that week, though it would not stay true past the next summer, and she did not yet know how soon the edict's hand would close on her own district instead of her neighbour's, or that when it did she would have an answer ready that surprised her almost as much as it surprised the Company.

III

Of the Order and the Staff

The order came to Muileann chrom itself in the height of the next summer, on the Company's own printed form with her own district's name filled into the blank by a clerk's hand, instructing the overseer to identify for clearance, within the month, such dwellings in the third and fourth rows of the camp as stood nearest the new gallery mouth, numbering not fewer than eleven households.

Mòrag read it twice at her table under the slate roof, the same table her father had sat at with the same order in a different year for a different widening, and had

told the Company's man then that the staff would not do it, and had been overruled by a Company surveyor's letter that made his refusal no more than a delay. She thought of that, sitting with the paper flat under both her hands as if it might otherwise lift and fly out the window after the iron bird. She thought too of the old man on his doorstone at Doire mhòr, and the grey bird that did not sing, and Sìneag's white mouth asking for an answer the staff had not had to give.

No reply went back to Ros dhomhain. Instead she took the staff down from over the hearth, the brass-capped, iron-shod length of ash Raghnaill had carried first and Dòmhnall after him and her own father Iain after Dòmhnall, its grip worn to the shape of three hands and now a fourth, and walked out of the steward's house and down through the town toward the Company's office with the staff in her fist like a woman going to a fight rather than a woman going to resign one.

The town came out behind her without being asked. A crew coming off the morning shift saw her pass the weighing-shed with the staff and left their barrows standing and followed; a woman hanging washing left the washing on the line; two boys who should have been minding a flock of half-wild goats on the slag heap left the goats to their own devices and ran ahead to be first at the office door, the way boys will run toward any commotion without troubling to learn first what it is about. By the time Mòrag reached the Company's door there were perhaps sixty people behind her in the street, not shouting, not yet, only walking at her pace the way a tide comes in, without hurry and without stopping.

The agent that year was a careful young man named Osgood who had never once, in three years at Muileann chrom, raised his voice to a Dia-thìreach worker, which the district had come, wrongly, to read as kindness rather than as the particular fear of a man a long way from home among people he did not understand and could not afford to provoke. He came to the office door at the noise and saw the staff in Mòrag's hand and understood at once, before she said a word, what she meant to do with it, because there was nothing else a woman carries a staff to a locked door to do.

"I won't clear the eleven households," Mòrag said. "Not the third row, not the fourth. Not this year, not on this order, not on any order that comes after it with the same seal on the bottom."

"The order isn't mine to withdraw," Osgood said. His hands, she noticed, were not quite steady on the doorframe, though his voice held. "You know that. I only carry what comes down from Ros dhomhain."

"Then carry this back," Mòrag said, and brought the staff down across her own bent knee.

It was old wood, dry through more than a hundred years of hearths, and the brass cap and the iron shoe did nothing to hold it, and it went with a crack that carried the length of the street and brought faces to every door along it that had not already come out on their own feet. She laid the two halves on the office step, not thrown, not flung, set down the way a woman sets down a thing she is finished carrying, and straightened, and found that her knee, where the wood had broken across it, had taken a welt she would feel for a week and never once regret.

"Send that to Ros dhomhain instead," she said, "and tell them the fourth of my line has done what the first three couldn't bring themselves to."

She walked home through the crowd that opened for her and closed again behind her, and did not look back at the office, and did not need to, because she had already heard, before she reached the top of the street, three other names called out from three other doors: Griogar Camshron of the north pit, who had held the eastern gallery's staff for six years and threw his own down in the yard within the week rather than be the one man left holding wood the Company had marked for treachery; the overseer of Cnoc chaol, whom Mòrag had never met but heard of before the month was out; and a third, at the silver country's edge, whose name did not reach Muileann chrom until the winter, whose staff, it was said, was found propped against the counting-house wall with no one there to break it, because he had simply walked away and left it standing.

The Company put humans in all four places before the season turned, men who had never held Ragnall's staff and never would, and the office at Muileann chrom kept its ledgers after that in a hand that did not know the names of the third and fourth rows it now governed. So ended, in one summer, the office that Ragnall mac Dhòmhnail had taken up more than a hundred years before believing it the only door left open to him; and the custodians who had once hoped the staff would simply lapse, unheld, when the first overseer wearied of it, got their wish at last from the fourth in his line, though not in the manner nor in the year that any of them, dead or living, had ever thought to hope for.

IV

Of the Silver and the Forest

Mòrag was no longer overseer of anything when the silver guild's rifles came ashore, and found, to her own surprise, that she had more time for the district's true business than the staff had ever left her, and less patience for waiting to be told what that business was.

The guild at Muileann chiar had held its seam under a compact a century old, granted back when the Company still troubled to grant things rather than simply take them, and had kept its own arms in name only, an old militia roll nobody had called out since the compact was signed. That summer the guild began to buy rifles from the raiders of the eastern waters, where no Company gunboat had patrolled in years for want of coal to spare it, and paid the raiders in bar silver by weight, and entered the whole transaction in its own ledger under the heading of refining tools, in a hand steady enough that any clerk who read it would have believed the guild meant to melt the rifles down rather than load them.

Coinneach Ruadh, still riding the district roads with his unpaid news, brought that word to Mòrag's door along with the rest, and something else besides: that the custodians who had fled to Macha's dissenting priests in the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag meant to hold a council there before the summer was out, a single council for the whole mining country, custodians and crew-leaders and priests together, the first such gathering the Company had never once been able to prevent because it had never once been told of it.

"They want you there," Coinneach said. "A woman who broke a staff in the street has more to say to that council than most who'll be sitting in it."

She went by night, on a borrowed pony over the ridge road and then off it, along tracks she had known as a girl and had not walked since, twenty-eight miles by her own count and every one of them dark, because a moon on a night like that would have shown the way to more than the council's own people. The forest at Cnoc bheag stood older than any road the Company had ever cut, oak and thorn grown up thick enough that the fires inside it, when she came to them at last past midnight, showed as no more than a red haze through the trunks until she was almost among them.

There were perhaps two hundred people in the clearing when she arrived, more than she had thought the whole quiet business of custodians and dissenting priests could have gathered without a single Company clerk hearing of it: crew-leaders she knew by sight from three other districts, priests of Macha's order with the black-and-grey horsehair of their office still worn openly for the first time in years, and a woman younger than Mòrag had expected, standing near the largest

fire with her back very straight, whom she recognised from the second petition's underlined sentence before anyone spoke her name aloud. Eilidh nic Raghnaill was crew-leader of Baile thais and one of the Lamp-Watch, and had drafted the words the Residency itself had thought worth underlining, and stood now listening to older voices argue the shape of a council that had, in truth, already chosen her before the argument began, because there was no one else in that clearing whose name every district already knew.

V

Of the Silent Town

Strake learned of the forest council within the month all the same, by what road the district never troubled to ask, and answered it the only way a Commissioner with no council left to argue with could answer anything: with an order to seize.

The order named Eilidh nic Raghnaill first and the members of the forest council after her, and the constables who carried it went to Baile thais in the last days of am Faoilleach, five miles down the valley from Muileann chrom, expecting, by every account that reached Mòrag afterward, a house to search and a woman to take from it.

They found the house standing open and swept, the hearth cold three days by the ash in it, and the town around it silent in a way that a mining town at midday is never silent, no barrows on the road, no children sent for water, every door shut and no face at a single window, so that the constables' captain, new to the district and unused to its ways, is said to have asked aloud whether the whole place had died of the fever in a night, and been told by no one, because there was no one left in the street to tell him.

Eilidh nic Raghnaill had gone by night two days before, on word carried ahead of the order by hands faster than the Administration's own post, taking nothing from the house that could not be carried on foot and leaving the hearth swept because a woman raised to keep a house does not stop keeping it merely because she is leaving it for the last time. Where she went that night the district did not learn for some while, and did not need to, since it was enough to know she had gone, and gone whole, and gone before the Residency's hand closed on the place where she had stood.

Mòrag heard the whole of it from Coinneach Ruadh on the twenty-eighth of an Gearran, riding into Muileann chrom at a pace she had not seen him keep in the two years she had known him, his pony blown and his own breath short, so that he had to say it twice before the words came out in an order she could follow.

"They've called it," he said. "Not the council, the district. Every district. Word's gone out from the forest since last night. The grievance is one thing now across the whole mining country, and there's no council left at Cathair dhearg to bring it before, only the Residency, and the Residency has had its answer this morning already, from Muileann chrom and Baile thais both."

Mòrag stood in her own doorway, in the house she still kept though the staff no longer hung over its hearth, and looked down the valley toward the pithead where the barrows had stood idle since dawn without her needing to ask why, and toward the ridge beyond which the coal road ran, empty now of every cart that had ever carried Company coal down it, and understood, with a plainness that surprised her less than it perhaps should have, what answer Coinneach meant: the one that comes only after a petition, and a strike, and a staff broken on a door-stone, have each in turn been tried and struck out or overruled or simply, as her own testimony at the inquiry had been, drawn through with a clerk's pen and filed away as though the drawing-through made the thing unsaid.

She did not sleep that night, the twenty-eighth of an Gearran in the hundred and forty-ninth year of the strangers' coming, any more than she had slept the night after the inquiry, but for the first time in all the years since, the waking did not feel like grief. She sat at her father's table with her father's book before her and wrote, in the private hand, a single line under the tally she no longer had any staff to keep: *the bird that did not sing has brought the whole hill to its feet, and I broke the first wood of it myself, and do not wish that back.*

Outside, along the whole length of the coal country from Doire mhòr to the silver hills, the fires that had been lit in secret for two years were being carried openly to every beacon height the districts held, and the light of them, when Mòrag went out at last to stand in her own doorway and watch, showed her more of her own country at once than she had ever seen by daylight: ridge after ridge answering ridge, from the forest at Cnoc bheag to the coast, each fire lit from the one before it, until the whole dark shoulder of the island seemed to have taken up, in one night, the single word that no council hall, no locked door, and no iron bird flying twice the length of a silent valley had ever yet managed to carry the length of it. War had come to the hills, and the staff that had broken across Mòrag

nic Iain Maor's own knee, she understood now, watching the fires answer one another into the distance, had been only the first small crack in a much larger piece of wood.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

Of the Rising in the hills

AE 149

Loisc iad an leabhar, ach cha do loisc iad an cnoc.

They burned the book, but they did not burn the hill.

I

Of the First Light at Muileann chrom

Mòrag nic Iain Maor had broken the overseer's staff across her knee on the Company's own step the summer before, and in the months since she had carried nothing in her hands heavier than a tally-stick. On the twenty-eighth of an Gearran she carried a pike cut from a fence-rail, and led thirty men and women up the spoil-road to the walled store at Muileann chrom before the sky over the eastern ridge had properly whitened.

She had counted the store's watch for a month by then without once being asked to, the way a woman counts the doors of her own house without meaning anything by it: eleven constables, a relief of four at the changing of the watch, a locked gate with a bar dropped from the inside and no bar dropped from the outside in all that month, because no one in Muileann chrom had ever given the Company cause to drop one. She had that from the boy who carried the store's slops out each evening and had never once been searched for it.

The gate went down under four men with a felled larch before the watch inside had properly woken. Mòrag came through it herself, because she would not send others where she would not walk, and found the eleven constables drawn up in the yard in their shirts, most of them not yet properly dressed, looking at the pikes and the felling-axes and the sheer number of the crowd behind her with the particular stillness of young men doing arithmetic they do not like the answer to.

Their sergeant was a Cathair mhòr man not five years older than the boy who had carried the slops. He held his rifle a moment as though he had forgotten what a rifle was for, and then set it down on the cobbles with a care that looked almost like an apology, and the other ten set theirs down after him without being told.

"You'll not be harmed," Mòrag said, "if you go where you're sent and go quietly." It was the only promise she made that morning that she was certain, standing there, she could keep.

They carried off the rifles before the sun cleared the ridge, and the grain of the store after them, sack by sack, down the spoil-road to the weigh-house that had not weighed a Company pound in a fortnight and would not weigh one again. An old hewer named Tòmas Odhar, who had worked the Muileann chrom galleries since before Mòrag was born, stood at the empty gate afterward with his hand flat against the stone the way a man rests his hand on a horse's neck, and said to no one in particular that he had carried coal out through that gate for six-and-thirty years and never once thought to see rifles carried out through it instead.

Word of Muileann chrom reached Ceann fhada by midday, carried by a runner from the Lamp-Watch who had not slept the night before and did not sleep that one either. The Company's coal quay at Ceann fhada had loaded barges for the coast since before the first pit at Muileann chrom was sunk, and the crews who worked it had spent a generation watching coal go out and little enough come back for it. They took the quay before the light failed, and that evening they scuttled two loaded barges across its mouth with their own hands, working chest-deep in cold water to knock the plugs from hulls they themselves had caulked the summer before.

A boatman called Pàdraig Reamhar, who had built the larger of the two barges with his father twenty years gone and had loaded her a hundred times since, stood on the quay afterward and watched her settle by the stern into the mud of the harbour bed, and said only that she had been a good boat, and that a good boat sunk on purpose was a different grief from a good boat wrecked, though he could

not, pressed, have said exactly how. No coal left the hills by water again that year, nor the year after.

II

Of the Eleven Days

At Baile thais, where the walls round the pithead had gone up within the memory of most who now stood outside them, the constables did not lay down their rifles at first light nor at any light soon after. Seumas Ciar had led the seventh shift of the Baile thais gallery for three years, since the crew-leader before him had gone to Cnoc bheag for the forest council and not come back to the pit, and it was Seumas the crews looked to when the word came down from Muileann chrom that the rising had begun.

He had expected a morning like Muileann chrom's: a gate down, a yard of frightened boys, a promise given and kept before the sun was properly up. Baile thais gave him eleven days instead.

The walls had been raised, everyone in the camp had said at the time and said again now, against exactly this: a moor country, no second gate, a well dug inside the circuit before the first stone of the wall was laid, so that whatever came against Baile thais would have to starve it rather than storm it. Seumas had a hundred men and women outside those walls and a dozen ways to fill their hands, but no way at all to fill the constables' water-barrels with anything but time.

By the seventh day the bread the camp could spare had gone to a half-loaf a household, and the seventh shift's own children, who had at first treated the siege as a holiday from the gallery and had run the whole ring of it shouting insults up at the wall, had grown quiet and stayed close to their mothers' fires instead, in the particular way children go quiet when they have understood a thing without being told it outright. Seumas walked the ring each evening with a lamp shuttered against the wall's own watch, counting his own people rather than the constables', because it was easier, some nights, to know how many of his were still standing than to guess how many of theirs still had the will to hold.

They were not longer, in the end, by more than a day. On the twelfth morning a white cloth went up over the gatehouse, tied, the watchers below said afterward, to the same pole that had flown the Company's own flag the week before. The well inside had gone to mud two days past; the last barrel had been shared out by

the constables' own sergeant in cupfuls, and even a cupful, by the eleventh night, was more than the barrel had left to give.

Word had come down to Seumas from the forest council two days before that, carried by a girl of fourteen who had walked from Cnoc bheag by night roads she would not afterward describe to anyone: whatever garrison yielded at Baile thais was to be sent to the coast, whole and unharmed, under whatever guard could be spared to see it done. Eilidh nic Raghnaill's own hand was on the message, the girl said, and no one asked her to say more than that, for the hand was known.

It did not sit easily with every man in that circle. A hewer named Coll Buidhe, whose brother had died of the coughing sickness in a Company hut the winter the walls went up, stood at Seumas's shoulder as the gate opened and said, low, that eleven days of thirst was mercy enough for men who had kept walls like that one standing over graves like his brother's. Seumas did not answer him at once. He watched the constables come out into the daylight blinking and unsteady, thirty-one of them by the tally, the youngest not much past the boy who had carried word from Cnoc bheag, and he thought of the promise given at Muileann chrom that morning a fortnight gone, and of what it would be worth, the next time a wall had to be talked down rather than starved down, if this one were not kept.

"They'll walk to the coast on their own legs," Seumas said, "and every one of them will walk there whole, because Eilidh says so, and because I say so after her." Coll Buidhe did not argue further. He fell in at the rear of the guard that walked the constables east that same afternoon, and saw them fed from the crews' own stores before the road, which no one had told him to do and no one afterward thought to remark on.

The Residency's letter-books, when Strake's clerks came at last to write up the loss of Baile thais, did not trouble to record that the garrison had been spared. It was not a mercy the Residency had looked for, and it was not a mercy the Residency returned.

III

Of the Moor and the Forge

Before ever a shot was fired at Baile thais, the crew-leaders of Baile gharbh and the pits north of it had met by night on the moor above Cnoc naomh,

where the shrine ground had filled two generations before with the dead of the green plague and the field beside it had never since been ploughed. Each man and woman who came to that meeting brought a stone of spoil carried up from their own pit's own heap, and the stones were set down together in the dark and left in a cairn that stood there after, uncarved, saying nothing to anyone who did not already know what it was for. They fixed the week of their rising in an hour, by the light of a single shielded lamp, and were gone from the moor before the shrine's own watcher came up at dawn to see to the flame, so that he found only the cairn, and no one to ask about it.

Within that week the pits of Baile gharbh rose together with the posts at Muileann shean and Tobar ghorm, and took them the way Muileann chrom had been taken, at first light, with more men outside the gates than inside them. The constables of the three posts were sent south on foot under no guard at all, their own legs and their own fear judged guard enough, and every one of them reached the coal road inside two days, footsore and talking loudly, to anyone who would stand still long enough to hear it, of how the whole of the north had gone over in a single week.

It had not, quite, gone over in a week; it had been three years coming, though few outside the crew-leaders' own circle knew how long, and one of those who did know was the smith Uilleam Gobha of Muileann dhearg, who had spent most of those three years turning the Company's own blasting-powder, bought a keg at a time on a Company chit for work that was never quite finished, into something the Company had not sold him and would not have sold him if he had asked.

Uilleam was thirty-and-nine that year, a broad, quiet man who had shod more Company mules than he could count and had grown, over the counting, to dislike the Company rather more than he disliked the mules. He forged pike-heads by day out of rail-iron torn from the disused sidings of the galleries, plain honest work that any smith on the island might have been set to and no agent thought twice about; by night, in the same forge with the shutters drawn, he packed the powder into tin cut from the coal sheds' own scrap and crimped the seams by hand, a slow and unforgiving labour that had already cost one man three fingers before Uilleam came to it and was determined it would cost him none.

He tried the first of them on the open moor behind the forge on a night with no moon, alone but for his eldest son holding the lamp a good way off, as Uilleam had told him to. It went off with a flat, ugly crack that put the birds up out of the whole valley and threw a spray of rock and scorched turf a man's height into the

air, and Uilleam Gobha stood looking at the small smoking hole it had left in the ground for a long moment before he said, to no one, that it would do. The rebels' council wrote afterward, in the roll it kept of that first season, that without Uilleam Gobha's forge the rising in the hills could not have been fought at all past its opening weeks, and whoever wrote the line had the right of it, though Uilleam himself would only say that a smith does what a smith is asked to do, and left the rest for others to judge.

The coal road that ran from the capital up into the hills had one house standing across its middle stage that mattered more than any fort: An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, kept these three generations by the line of Seònaid Bhàn, and kept now by her great-grandson Aonghas, who had spent the autumn before filling its loft with more men than any innkeeper's licence allowed and telling the Company's inspectors, when they asked, that the extra hands were for the harvest. On the day the word came up from Muileann chrom, Aonghas shut the gates of his own house across the road with his own hands, and the men in the loft came down armed, and the road between the capital and the hills was cut at its half-way stage and stayed cut for the whole of that year and longer. No coal came down it, and no column went up it, without Aonghas's leave, which he did not give.

IV

Of the Rising of the Capital

Word of the hills reached Cathair dhearg by the third day, carried faster than any rider by the simple fact that half the capital had kin working a gallery somewhere north of it and had been waiting, without quite admitting to themselves that they waited, for exactly this news. The custodians who had sat shut out of their own hall since the winter Strake came did not wait to be asked twice. They broke the Residency's locks on the council-hall doors with a coal-hammer borrowed from the smithy across the square, and sat down again in the chairs that had been theirs before any lock was hung on them, and the roll they kept from that day forward opens without a word of apology for the two years it does not cover.

The townsfolk of Cathair dhearg held the bridge that the Company had built for its own coal-carts against the constables sent up in haste from the harbour, and barricaded it with the very carts it had been built to carry, turned on their

sides and lashed together with chain from the ironmonger's own stores. It was not a fortification any soldier would have approved, and it held all the same, for three days, until the constables who had been sent to clear it were called back to guard the harbour instead and never came again.

At Cathair dhomhain the townsfolk broke open the stone warehouse the Company had raised along the lake shore in the first years of the treaty, the first building the strangers had ever owned outright on Dia-thìr and the one the old tellings had asked their listeners to remember. They carried off its tools, its rope, its nails and its stored powder for the council's own companies, and left the warehouse itself standing empty and unlocked, its doors swinging, much as the huts of Cnoc gharbh had once been left standing in the years of the green plague, though this time a reckoning long owed, and at last collected, had emptied it.

At Muileann mhin, a river port a morning's walk east of the capital on the Abhainn fhionn, the townsfolk argued for three days over a decision that the towns north and south of them had each made in an afternoon. It was said afterward, by those who had stood in the market square through all three days of it, that the argument turned less on where their sympathies lay than on where their boats did business, for Muileann mhin's living came from carrying grain and timber to whichever bank paid for the carrying, and a boatman is slower than a hewer to burn a bridge he may need again. On the third evening the town sent its boats to the council at Cathair dhearg all the same, and through that winter and the hard one that followed them the Abhainn fhionn carried food down to the capital by night as steadily as it had ever carried Company coal down by day.

At Ros dhomhain, Lionel Strake drew what remained of the Administration back inside the Residency's walls and fortified the Company's own quarter of the harbour, setting what constables he still trusted at every gate and trusting the rest to stand where he could watch them. The town below the Residency's hill, Dia-thìrich almost to the last household, neither rose against him nor lifted a hand to defend him, and it was this, more than any wall, that the letter-books afterward called the strangest siege of that first year: a garrison shut up against a silence rather than an army, in a city that went about its ordinary business at its ordinary pace on every street but the one that led up to the gate, and would not meet a constable's eye on that one.

V

Of the Ford of Àth chiar

It could not last, from the Residency's side of it, without an answer, and the answer Strake sent was Major Peter Ashdown, with what constables and Company guards could be spared from the harbour, marching up the coal road to open it again and relieve whatever of the hills could still be relieved.

Ashdown found the road cut at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, as every rider before him had found it that season, and turned north about it along the older cart-track that ran down to the ford at Àth chiar, where the coal road crossed the river before climbing again into the hills proper. It was there, on the far bank, that the crews who had held Baile thais a fortnight before were waiting for him, dug in along the willow scrub with what rifles the walled store had given up and what Uilleam Gobha's forge had since sent up the road in a cart with a false floor of turnips.

The ford ran deep that season with a wet spring behind it, and Ashdown's column went into it waist-high and in poor order, the guns of the rear companies held up over men's heads and the horses of the baggage train balking at the current. The fire that met them from the far bank was neither heavy nor especially well aimed, most of those who held it being hewers and quarrymen who had never fired at a man before that week, but it did not need to be well aimed to do its work in a column standing chest-deep in moving water with nowhere to go but forward or back. Ashdown chose back. He lost forty men to the river and the fire together, and the whole of his baggage besides, abandoned on the near bank in the retreat and carried off by the same crews who had held the willows.

The rebels' own dead numbered nineteen, and it was Seumas Ciar, who had brought his Baile thais men down to the ford at the forest council's summons and stood with them the whole of that wet afternoon, who carried the word back up to Cnoc bheag of who among them had not come home. The council's clerk, a woman named Fionnuala who had kept few enough happy rolls in her three years of keeping any roll at all, wrote the nineteen names down that same night by lamp-light, each with the pit or the crew it had come from, and read the whole list aloud the next morning to whoever stood near enough the hall to hear it, once, plainly, without a word added to it.

They were buried within the week on the moor above Cnoc naomh, near enough the cairn the crew-leaders had raised there in the dark before ever a shot

was fired, so that the two piles of stone stood within sight of one another from that season on: the one raised in secret for a rising not yet begun, the other raised in the open for the first of what the rising had already cost. The council's roll gives the nineteen names in full, and does not say, because by the custom of that roll it was never asked to say, which was harder to keep: the stone laid down before the fighting, or the stone laid down after it.

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

OF the Leaden Hawk

AE 150 JAN – JUN

I

Of the Word That Came to Cuan dhearg

Coinneach Beag was five-and-twenty that winter, and had been a boatman on the Abhainn uaine since he was old enough to hold an oar against the current, ferrying barrels and once, memorably, a bull calf that would not stand still, between the two landings at Cuan dhearg. He had never carried a letter further than the length of the town. He had never fired a rifle at anything but a scarecrow, on a dare, at fourteen. When the crew-leaders of the river towns asked for seven men who knew how to keep their feet on a hill road and their mouths shut on a matter that mattered, he put his own name forward before he had properly decided to, the way a man steps off a boat onto a landing before he has quite finished thinking about the jump.

The word came to Cuan dhearg all that spring in pieces, by carter and by boat and by the mouths of men who had walked further than they meant to, and each piece was turned over at the inn's fire until it had been handled by everyone in the room. Ashdown's column, beaten at the ford of Àth chiar and its forty dead left to the river, had fallen back through Dùn chrom and lain there a night; in the

morning the town had shut its gates on the soldiers who slept in its barracks, and let the column go on to the coast without its own wounded, whom the townsfolk kept to nurse or to bury as it turned out. Coinneach heard that twice, once from a carter who swore he had it from a man who had seen the gates shut with his own eyes, and once from a boatman up from the coast who swore the same thing of a different town entirely, and he learned that spring, before he learned much else of the war, that a true thing and a thing a man wanted to believe could travel the same road at the same pace and arrive looking near enough alike.

Other word he trusted better, because it came with names attached and names could be checked. The silver guild at Muileann chiar had declared for the council and put the Company's agents on the road east with their own papers under their own arms, untouched; the small post at Dùn ìseal had given up its rifles after one exchange of fire, and the whole eastern coast, from the silver hills to the sea, stood clear of any human arm that spring for the first time in Coinneach's life. At Dùn dhearg the custodians had sent grain south and read their declaration from the steps of the hall, quoting, an old man at the fire said with some pride, as though the words were his own kin's, the very sentence Fionnghal nic Artair had written against the Small-Burning Law a hundred and twenty-seven years before it mattered to anyone again. Riflemen had risen at Cnoc leathan to hold the eastern road. At Ros fhionn the crews had stopped the pumps in the same week and let the water have the lower galleries back, and the bridge on the coal road there, which Coinneach had crossed twice in his life on family business, stood silent, he was told, but for the birds.

Then in the early weeks of the year came the word that stopped the fire's talk dead for a night: a Company ship had come up the Abhainn uaine itself, not twenty miles below where they sat, and shelled the coal stage at Seann Toll to keep it from the rebels, and set the fishing town behind it burning. Three-and-twenty of the town's own people had died, and the ship had burned island coal to do it, the very coal the hills had raised and carried and weighed out for a hundred years, turned round in a boiler and fired back at the people who had raised it. Coinneach's uncle, who had fished those waters as a young man and knew every rock of the Seann Toll shore by name, said nothing for a long while after that word came, and then said only that he had not thought to live to hear of coal doing that, and went out into the yard and did not come back in until the fire had burned low.

It was into this spring, thick with word half-true and word too terrible to doubt, that the crew-leaders sent for the seven.

II

Of the Waiting at An Cupa Dàna

They were told to come to An Cupa Dàna, the inn at Cuan dhearg, on a morning when the frost had not yet gone off the roofs, and to bring nothing that would mark them for what they were. Coinneach came in his oldest coat, with a whittled knife and a pair of boots resoled twice, and found six others waiting in the inn's back room already, men of the river towns he knew by sight if not always by name: a cooper's son from further down the water, two brothers who had worked a coal barge together since boyhood, a quiet man called Gillebrìde who had been a hawk-priest's server as a lad and knew the shrine roads better than anyone else in the room, and two more whose names Coinneach set himself that morning to learn and not forget: Ailig, who talked too much when he was afraid and said so himself, and Pàdraig Buidhe, who did not talk at all.

They were given letters, sealed, and told only that the letters went north to the Hawk coast, to Ìomhar Seabhag at the shrine of Seann Skell and to whoever else along the road would hear the council's word and might be moved by it. They were given, each of them, a small thing cast in lead and shaped rough but unmistakably like a hawk stooping, and told these had been made from cartridges taken at the store at Muileann chrom that first morning of the war, melted down by a smith at Muileann dhearg who had more urgent work waiting and had done this first because someone had asked him to. Coinneach turned his over in his palm. It was heavier than its size argued for, and the edges where the mould had not quite closed were sharp enough to catch on cloth, and he thought, holding it, that he had never owned anything before that had once been meant to kill a man and was now meant only to be worn at the throat and shown to strangers as a token of trust.

They left at dark, when the last letter was in Gillebrìde's coat with the rest, each man's hawk at his throat on a cord of tarred twine, and the innkeeper's wife stood in the door a moment with a lamp and said nothing, because there was nothing to say to seven men going out into a war on a road that so far existed only

as a hope: the hope that the letters would find hands willing to carry them further.

III

Of the Road by Seann Toll

The first day's walking brought them down past the burned stage at Seann Toll, and Coinneach, who thought he had prepared himself for it on the strength of his uncle's silence, found he had not. The stage itself was a black frame over black water, and the houses behind it that had caught from the fire stood roofless, their thatch gone entire and their stone walls stained the colour of the smoke that had gone up through them. A woman was picking through what had been a hearth, sorting stone from ash with her bare hands, and did not look up as the seven passed, and none of them spoke to her, for there seemed nothing a stranger could say that would not be an insult to what she was doing.

They went on that day and the next through Baile thais, where the walled store the constables had held eleven days still bore, on its outer wall, the marks of whatever had been thrown or fired at it in that fortnight, and a boy of nine or ten showed them, unasked and with more pride than the matter perhaps warranted at his age, exactly where he had stood the day the constables came out with their water gone and their hands empty. Over the hills by Achadh dhomhain the road climbed out of the coal country proper into country Coinneach had never walked, heather going to purple-brown at its roots though it was not yet the season for its flower, and down the far side by the Abhainn ìseal to Cnoc bheag, where they slept a night in a byre by leave of a farmer who asked no questions and was given no answers, which both parties seemed to find the more honest arrangement.

At every hawk-house on the road, a low building of one room where the hawk-faithful of that district kept a fire and a bench and, more often than not, little else, one of the seven stood up among whoever sat there and read the council's letter aloud. It fell to Coinneach at a hawk-house he never learned the name of, a bare room with six benches and a fire down to embers, and he found his voice did not want to carry the way he had meant it to, and steadied it by thinking of the woman sorting stone at Seann Toll and telling himself the letter was, in its way, owed to her as much as to anyone in the room. He read it through once, the

council's own words about the hill country and the war and what was asked of every district the letter reached, and when he had finished an old woman by the fire said only, "Well. So it has come to that," and no one answered her, because there was nothing to answer, the letter having said as much as needed saying.

Along the Hawk coast the road ran easier, a track worn by shrine-goers rather than carts, and they came down to Inis mhin on the third day with their boots worn thin and their letters, Gillebrìde said, checking the packet each night by feel before he slept, all still dry and all still sealed.

IV

Of the Hawk Coast and the Roads Off It

Inis mhin was a walled landing the humans had built and half abandoned when the trade that justified it thinned, and the seven lay twelve hours in a boat-shed there, sleeping in turns, while Gillebrìde went out to learn what could be learned of the roads ahead. He came back with word that undid, in a sentence, the ease of the last two days: Strake's constables rode the western roads out of Ros bheag every day now, in patrols of ten or a dozen, and a party of seven men on foot, however plain their coats, would be seen and stopped and searched before it had gone a mile past the town.

It was Pàdraig Buidhe, who had said perhaps forty words in three days, who found the carter willing to take them, a man of Inis mhin with a covered cart and a mule past its best years, who asked no more than a fair price and a promise that whatever was in the cart's bed under the sacking was not his business to know, a promise the seven kept to the letter by telling him nothing at all. They left the road that night and did not take it again, going by cart-tracks and field-edges known to the carter and to no map Coinneach had ever seen, and it struck him, jolting along in the dark with six other men and a mule that seemed to know the country better than any of them, that he had come further from home in three days than he had gone in the whole of the rest of his life, and that he had not, until that moment, had leisure to think about it.

V

Of the Grass Above Tobar dhomhain

Above Tobar dhomhain the carter set them down before first light at the edge of a stretch of open grassland that ran along the ridge over the road from Ros bheag to the northern concession, and told them, with the flat certainty of a man who had lived his whole life within sight of that road, that from here they would see anything that passed on it for the better part of a day, and be seen by nothing, if they lay still and let the grass do its work.

They lay eleven hours. The grass was long enough to close over a man on his belly and cool enough, in the morning, to soak through a coat within the first hour, and by midday Coinneach's whole left side had gone from cold to numb to a kind of steady ache he stopped noticing only by giving his attention entirely to the road below. Ailig, three feet to his left, kept up a whisper of complaint for the first two hours and then, as the sun climbed and the road below began to show its traffic, fell as silent as Pàdraig Buidhe ever was, because there was, after all, something to watch.

They counted. A farm cart at dawn, going toward Ros bheag with what looked like wool. Two women on foot, going the other way, whom none of the seven could place as anything but what they seemed. And then, beginning perhaps an hour after the sun was properly up, the riders: constables in twos and threes and once a full dozen together, moving at an easy pace that told Coinneach, who had never sat a horse in his life but had watched enough carters manage tired animals to know the difference, that these were not men in any great hurry, nor men expecting trouble on this particular stretch of road that day.

By the time the light began to go, Gillebrìde's tally, kept on a strip of bark with a line for each rider and a cross for each group's leader, stood at forty-one. Coinneach checked it twice against his own count, made independently and kept in his head for lack of anything to mark it with, and came to the same number both times. What struck all seven of them, lying there in the last of the light before they dared move, was not the number itself, though forty-one riders was more than any of them had thought to see on one road in one day. It was the direction. Every rider, every cart, every single soul they had watched cross that stretch of road since first light, had been going south, back toward Ros bheag and the coast, and not one, not a single one in eleven hours of watching, had been riding north.

"They're none of them looking this way," Gillebride said, when they had at last crept back off the ridge into the shelter of a fold in the land where a man could stand upright and speak above a whisper. "Whatever Strake wants watched, it isn't this road. Not any more."

VI

Of Inis thais and the Roads of the Fianna

They came down to Inis thais on the evening of the sixth day out from Cuan dhearg, footsore and carrying, Gillebride reported once more, seven dry letters, and were brought before the priests of Òrd na Cloiche¹ in the low stone temple above the harbour, where a fire of driftwood burned blue-white with the salt in the wood and the priests sat in a half-circle that made Coinneach, standing in the middle of it with the letters in his hand, feel more closely watched than he had felt lying in the grass above Tobar dhomhain with forty-one riders passing below him.

The priests heard the letter through without a word, and when it was done the eldest of them, a woman whose name none of the seven were told and none thought to ask, said that the Stone would send no men to the hill country's war, for that was not what the Stone was for. But she said also, turning her eyes from Gillebride, who had done the speaking until then, to Coinneach, who stood nearest the fire, that Inis thais would shut its harbour to the Company's ships from that night, and that the hawk-faithful, wherever their roads led, would find the Fianna's own ways open to them from here to the western city, a kindness she did not trouble to explain and Coinneach did not trouble to ask after, being by then too tired to do more than be grateful for it.

There the Leaden Hawk's road, as the letters had carried it, came to its end. What the seven had walked and ridden and lain eleven hours in the grass for was delivered, letter for letter, hawk-house for hawk-house, into hands that would carry its word further than any of the seven could have carried it alone; and at the western Seann Skell, some days after, when the company of the hawk-faithful was mustered under Ìomhar Seabhag's own eye, the seven of Cuan dhearg stood in its first rank and were told, by a priest who had heard already what they had done,

1. the order of the Stone

that they were one thing now, with one name: Buidheann an t-Seabhaig Luaidhe², the Leaden Hawk.

Word reached the muster at Seann Skell all that early summer the way it had reached the fire at Cuan dhearg, in pieces, and Coinneach, now a soldier of sorts though he still thought of himself most days as a boatman lent out for a season, learned to sort the true from the merely believed as he had learned it on the river road. The coal stacked on the quays of Inis mhòr, that the Company's ships had meant to burn in their boilers, went up instead at the townsfolk's own hand rather than fuel one more voyage like the one that had shelled Seann Toll, and the ships that would have taken it put in at Ros dhomhain and burned their own stores down to the last sack. Fishing boats out of both towns called Seann Chwen, sailing by night, boarded a Company coaster at anchor and burned her where she lay, and the Company drew what shipping it had left back into the two harbours it still held and kept it there. On the concession, Cathair gheal shut its gates and raised a militia that went nowhere and did nothing, its magistrate having written to both sides asking only to be left alone, a request the council granted and Strake did not trouble to answer; and at Muileann àrsaidh the town blocked its own road with carts and kept a watch on it against both armies at once, a watch no one on either side had yet tried to break.

The southern beacons went dark that spring, one after another: Tobar dhearg first, where the keeper, a woman named Raonaid nic Dhòmhnail of whom Coinneach knew nothing then but the name on a report read aloud at the muster, put out her own light with her own hand rather than let it go on guiding the Company's ships along a coast the council now held; and Àth dhearg and Baile ìseal followed her within the week. Two Company ships, feeling their way along that coast by night with no light to steer by, ran onto the reefs the beacons had been raised to warn them from, and were lost with what the letter-books, when they were read after, called regret and nothing more. From over the sea, in all that first half-year of the war, one ship came, bringing dispatches and a few crates of cartridges to a Residency that had asked for regiments, and sailed again inside the week, and Coinneach heard a priest at Seann Skell say, of that one ship and its light cargo, that an Tìr Thall³ had sent Strake exactly as much help as a man sends a drowning friend by shouting encouragement from the bank.

By midsummer, when the days over the western city ran long and pale into their evenings and the muster had settled into something less like seven strangers

and a company of priests and more like an army, such as it was, the lines the war had drawn that winter had not moved. The council held the hills, the east, and the capital; Strake held the Residency, the harbour quarter below it, and the western ports; and neither, for all that had burned and all that had been counted on a strip of bark in a field above Tobar dhomhain, had found the strength that summer to break the other. Coinneach Beag, standing his watch on the road north of Ros bheag with a rifle he had been given and had not yet fired, thought sometimes of the forty-one riders, all bound south, and wondered, as Gillebride had wondered aloud on the ridge, what it was that Strake had judged worth watching instead of that road, and whether, wherever it was, the council's own eyes were on it yet. He did not know. No one at Seann Skell could tell him, that summer, and the watch went on.

CHAPTER THIRTY-NINE

Of the BURNING of the Ledgers

AE 150

Loisc iad an leabhar, ach cha do loisc iad an cnoc. They burned the
book, but they did not burn the hill.

I

Of the Grain from Seann Warr



ùghall Dubh had counted carts before, in the years he weighed coal for the Company at the Ros dhomhain scales, and he counted them now for

2. the Leaden Hawk company; lit. 'the company of the leaden hawk'

3. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

the council out of the same habit, standing at the harbour quarter's upper gate with a tally-stick and a stub of chalk while the grain train from Seann Warr came in by the eastern road under a sky the colour of wet slate.

Nine carts, then eleven, then a gap the length of a held breath before the twelfth came round the bend with a wheel binding badly enough that the carter walked beside it, easing it over the ruts by hand. Dùghall let the tally rest a moment and watched the wheel. He had not eaten a full meal since the fourth day of the month and could not have said, if asked, whether it was the wheel or the hunger that made him watch it so closely.

Seann Warr lay two days east by the good road, a farming town in the flat country that had never seen a pit-head in its life and had sent grain to the hills every month since the winter the lines were drawn, by carts that went the long way round to keep clear of Strake's patrols out of Ros bheag. The council's roll in the yard behind Dùghall kept the count of every load: how many sacks, whose oxen, which nights the carters slept rough rather than risk a farm too near the coast road. It was a poor sort of harvest to be grateful for, twelve carts against a capital's hunger, but Dùghall had learned in a year of siege that a poor sort of harvest was still a harvest, and he thanked the carter by name and sent the last cart on to the sharing-yard with the rest.

The sharing-yard stood behind the custodians' hall, where Cathair dhearg's grain had been measured out by household since Strake shut himself up behind the harbour's gates the spring before: a scale, a clerk, a line that did not shorten by evening. The custodians themselves, Dùghall had heard it said more than once and had seen enough to believe, took no more from the scale than any weaver's widow in the line before them, and the saying had done more for the city's temper through that hard winter than any speech from the hall steps could have. Dùghall did not go often to hear speeches. He went to the sharing-yard the one day in five it fell to him, took his household's share, and went back to the harbour quarter, where the work that mattered to him was done with the hands and not the mouth.

That work, through the first year of the siege, had been watching. The harbour quarter of Ros dhomhain sat below the Residency and above the Company's quays, close enough to the humans' lines to hear their bells and their drums and, on a still evening, the creak of their ships' timbers at anchor, and it had sat there a year now neither wholly for the council nor wholly against it, a narrow strip of stone houses and net-lofts caught between two powers that each

wanted its gates and neither had troubled, yet, to take them. Dùghall's own house stood on the quarter's upper street, three doors from the counting-house where the Company had kept its tithe rolls since before he was born, and he had grown up close enough to that building's clerks to know most of them by their coughs before he knew them by their faces.

He had weighed coal at the counting-house scales for nine years before the war closed them, standing the same six hours of every working day on the far side of a steelyard from a clerk named Prentice, an easy-spoken man who kept a paper twist of peppermints in his waistcoat and offered one to every man whose load he entered against, Dùghall among them, without ever once asking whose account the entry would fall on come the year's reckoning. Dùghall had liked Prentice, in the plain way a man likes another he has stood beside for nine years without either learning much of the other's life outside the scales, and it was a strange thing, that summer, to find himself weighing in his own mind what he owed a man's peppermints against what the ledgers that man had kept owed the whole of the hills, and to find the second sum so much the larger of the two that the first could not be set against it at all.

He had not, until that summer, thought of the counting-house as a thing that could burn.

II

Of the Roofs in Stocking Feet

The word to move came down from the council's captains in the first days of an t-Iuchar, carried as a question rather than an order, put to men who knew their own streets better than any captain could: could the harbour quarter reach the counting-house without a shot fired, and if it could, would it.

Dùghall put the question to six men he trusted before he answered it, all of them born within sight of the counting-house's slate roof, and all six said the same thing in different words: that they had watched Company clerks carry the tithe books past their doors for thirty years, entering against every settlement in the hills the debt the hills would spend the next thirty paying, and that a shot fired would only tell Strake's men where to look, while a fire lit quietly would tell them nothing until it was too tall to answer.

They went over on a night of low cloud with no moon in it, in their stocking feet, up the outside stair of the net-loft that backed onto the counting-house yard and along its roof-ridge on hands and knees, six men and Dùghall a seventh, each with a garret window he had marked in daylight and a rope coiled at his shoulder for the drop inside. Dùghall's own window stuck at the sash, swollen with the damp of a wet summer, and for the length of ten held breaths he worked it with the flat of his knife while below him, through the slates, he could hear the counting-house's night clerk moving about at his desk, entirely unaware that the roof over his ledgers had seven men crouched along it.

The sash gave without a sound worth the name. Dùghall went down the rope into a garret stacked with old tally-boards and out through a door that had not been locked in living memory, because no one in thirty years had thought there was a way in from above; and at the stair-head he found Fearchar Beag already waiting for him, having come in by the loading hatch on the ground floor with two others, the night clerk's lantern taken and turned down and the night clerk himself sitting on the counting-house steps in his shirt with his hands laced over his head, looking, Dùghall thought, more relieved than afraid, as though some part of him had been waiting a year for this night to come and was glad, now, to have it over.

The tithe books stood where they had always stood, in the long room above the loading floor, calf-bound and ranked on their shelves like a wall built of pressed hide, each one heavy enough that a man could not carry more than two at a stretch without his arms failing him before the yard. Dùghall had weighed coal by the ton for the Company once and thought he had lost the trick of being surprised by weight; the tithe books surprised him. It took the seven of them the better part of an hour to carry the whole wall down the stair and out into the yard, armful by armful, stacking them on the cobbles the way a mason stacks stone for a wall not yet begun, and by the time the last shelf stood bare Dùghall's shoulders ached in a way the coal scales had never made them ache, because the coal, at least, a man set down knowing it would be picked up again.

He struck the light himself, from a lantern-wick and a twist of oiled rag, and stood back while it caught along the bottom row and climbed. The sentry at the counting-house's front door, posted there every night of the siege against a raid from the water side, never turned round until the whole yard behind him stood lit like a hearth in a house with the roof off, and by then there was nothing left for him to do but blow the alarm bell and watch six men and their leader go back

over the roofs the way they had come, unhurried, because a fire that size buys its makers more time than they need.

Dùghall stood a while at his own garret window afterward, watching the light of it redden the underside of the low cloud, and thought, without much satisfaction in the thought, that thirty years of a man's life could be made to weigh less than a garret full of old tally-boards, provided enough of it was burned at once.

III

Of the Word from Ceann àrsaidh and Muileann chrom

The word of the other two fires reached the harbour quarter three days apart, each by a rider who had ridden hard enough to arrive gasping, and

Dùghall heard both accounts standing in the same doorway where he had heard the first report of his own men's work, so that the three fires came to him afterward as one telling rather than three, the way a man remembers a single bad winter though it held a dozen separate storms.

The tithe-house at Ceann àrsaidh burned second, and the rider who brought word of it, a boy of Fearchar Beag's own age with Ceann àrsaidh mud still on his boots, told it with a care that made plain he had turned the telling over more than once on the road. The tithe-house held the portion owed by every settlement of the hills, entered against each in its own column since the first schedule was drawn, a record older by twenty years than the counting-house's tithe books and kept, by all report, more exactly. The Ceann àrsaidh companies had let the humans' clerks go unharmed before they carried the ledgers into the square, and it was there, the boy said, at the last, that Aonghas Ruadh's own successor in the custodian's chair had asked that one ledger be spared, to keep the record entire rather than soften the debt it named, so that in a settled year to come the hills might show by their own hand what had been asked of them and what had been paid. His own townsfolk had refused him. They had carried that one ledger to the pile with the rest, and a woman the boy would not name had said, loud enough for the custodian to hear it, that a debt kept on paper could always be raised again by whoever next held the paper, and that the only sure way to close an account was to leave no account to close.

The weigh-house at Muileann chrom burned third, and by the time that word came the harbour quarter had already had two days to grow used to the smell of

old smoke on the wind off the eastern road, so that this third telling landed lighter than the first two, though the loss it named was, by every measure Dùghall knew how to take, the greatest of the three: the steelyard ledgers in which the coal of the hills had been set down by the ton since the earliest contract, the whole long reckoning by which the Company had known, to the ton and the shilling, what the hill had given it. The rider who brought that word, older than the first and less careful with his telling, said only that the rebels' own chronicler at Muileann chrom had written the fire burned green, from the damp in the old timbers or from something in the ink itself, nobody could say which, and that the camp folk who watched it were already making a verse of it before the ash had cooled.

Dùghall did not hear the verse whole until a week later, from a woman selling fish at the quarter's lower gate who sang it under her breath the way market women sing whatever is going about, without knowing or much caring where it came from: *they burned the book, but they did not burn the hill*. He bought no fish that morning and stood a while at the gate all the same, listening to her sing it twice through, and thought that whoever had made those eight words had done in eight what he had failed to do in a week of turning the Ceann àrsaidh woman's saying over in his own head.

IV

Of Cnoc ghorm

Strake answered the fires the only way left to him, which was with the guns he still held inside his shrinking lines, and it cost him, by the harbour quarter's later count, the last strength he had to spend on the hills at all.

Word of Cnoc ghorm came to Dùghall as smoke on the wrong quarter of the sky rather than any rider's telling, a grey smear rising beyond the eastern ridge where no fire of the council's setting had any business standing, and for the better part of a morning the harbour quarter went about its work not knowing whether the smoke marked a Company advance or a Company defeat. It was Fearchar Beag, sent up to the net-loft roof with a glass borrowed from a fisherman, who brought the answer down at noon: Company guards and constables, sallied out from the capital's harbour under cover of the night to try the eastern road one last time and win back the way to the mining country, driven off at Cnoc ghorm in the hills beyond the city with losses the loft-roof glass could plainly see though it

could not count them, riderless horses coming back down the road alone before the men who had ridden them.

It was the last such attempt the Administration made in the whole of that war, though no one in the harbour quarter knew it yet for a last thing; they knew only that the guns had gone quiet on the eastern road by evening and had not spoken again, and took what comfort a quiet road gave, which in a year of siege was considerable.

V

Of the Lower Gates

Eight weeks after the counting-house burned, the harbour quarter did the thing Dùghall had watched it circle for the better part of a year without doing, and opened its lower gates to the council's companies waiting beyond them.

It was not put to a vote, in the end, nor settled by any one man's word, though afterward more than one teller would claim the deciding of it. It was settled, as Dùghall came to understand it, by the plain arithmetic of a quarter that had fed the Residency's kitchens for thirty years and could no longer feed its own children while doing so, and by the counting-house yard standing burned the whole summer in full view of every window on the upper street, a black scar that made the old bargain look, each morning a family woke to see it, less like a bargain and more like a debt nobody now living had agreed to. Dùghall stood at the lower gate himself when the bar came off it, having asked to be there though the honour of the drawing had not fallen to him, and watched the council's companies come up from the quays in good order, their captain a woman of Muileann dhearg he did not know by name, who thanked the gate-wardens plainly and asked, before anything else, where the wounded of the counting-house sentry's alarm bell had been carried, which struck Dùghall as a stranger's sort of first question and a better one than he had expected.

That same night, with the gates open and the companies bedded in the lower streets, men of the quarter went up to the Company's shed above the town where the flying machine had stood idle the whole length of the siege, grounded from the first month of the war for want of the spirit its engine burned, and burned the shed and the machine together. Dùghall did not go up with them; he had never

much liked the look of the thing, an iron bird that had never once flown in his sight and had cost, by the tithe rolls he had weighed against in his working years, more than the whole harbour quarter's grain for a season, and he felt no want to stand over its burning the way he had wanted to stand over the tithe books'. He heard only, from his own street, the second glow of that night rising over the roofs to join the first, and thought that nothing had flown over Dia-thìr since the mist first thinned that was not, in the end, a bird.

VI

Of Cuan uaine and the Water Road

With the harbour quarter lost to him and the eastern road shut at Cnoc ghorm, Strake had one road left, and it ran by water: the Abhainn gheal down from the Residency to the sea, and along it the river quays of Cuan uaine, a morning's row east of the capital, through which what little still reached him from the coast had been passed all that year.

Cuan uaine opened its own quays to the council's boats within the week, on terms Dùghall heard told two ways and believed neither wholly: that the town's boatmen had simply stopped turning the council's craft back, one morning, without a word said either way, the way a door left unbarred is not quite the same as a door thrown open, and is opened all the same. Whichever way it went, the Residency after that could be fed, if it could be fed at all, only by what a boat could carry past a watch that no longer troubled to look away.

VII

Of the Residency Stripped

The Residency fell to the council's companies without a shot on the morning of the twenty-second of an t-Sultain, and Dùghall was among the first up from the harbour quarter to see it, walking the same streets he had weighed coal in half his working life, now empty of every Company uniform but for a handful of clerks too old or too frightened to have gone with Strake down the river the night before.

The house itself, when he came into it, told its own story before any clerk could tell it him: rooms stripped to the floorboards, presses standing open and bare, the great hall's long table left with nothing on it but the marks where other things had stood, dust-shadows in the shape of what a year of siege had taught its household to carry and what it had not. Strake had taken his officers, the Mission's clergy and the Company's own agents down the water road in the night, by every account Dùghall gathered that morning, and had taken with them everything a careful man judges worth the carrying: plate, papers of account, the small close-held things a household gathers over thirty years and cannot bear to leave for an enemy's hands.

What he had not taken, because in his haste or his judgement he had not thought them worth the room in the boats, were the letter-books: shelf on shelf of them in a lower room off the hall, bound in the same calf as the tithe books that had burned three times over that summer, but filled with something the tithe books had never held, the Residency's own correspondence back to an Tìr Thall¹ since the first Commissioner's day, every dispatch sent and every answer, or silence, received.

He sent word to the council's clerks that evening, and by the next morning a table had been set up in the same stripped hall where the Company's long board had stood, with the first of the letter-books laid open on it under a good lamp, and men who had never in their lives been asked to read a stranger's hand bent over the close, foreign script with the same patience Dùghall had once given a scale that would not balance. He did not stay to read them himself, judging that he had done the part of that summer's work that was his to do, and went back down through the empty streets to the harbour quarter, where the counting-house yard still stood black three streets from his own door.

Dùghall passed it slowly on his way home, as he had passed it every day since the fire and would go on passing it, he supposed, until someone built something else there or the rains wore the black down to grey. A child of the quarter had chalked something on the standing wall in the days since, letters Dùghall could not fully make out in the falling light, and he did not go closer to read them; he had heard enough words made of that fire already, the Ceann àrsaidh woman's and the fish-seller's both, and judged that whatever a child had found to say of it belonged to the child and not to him. Prentice, he had heard from a clerk taken at

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

the Residency that morning, had gone down the river with Strake's household after all, peppermints and all, to whatever account was kept of him at Ros bheag or beyond it; and Dùghall found, standing in the last of the light with the black wall in front of him, that he could wish the man no particular harm and no particular good, only that the ledgers Prentice had kept so evenly for nine years were ash now on the same cobbles where he had once handed a boy his coin for the day's weighing, and that whatever came after the war would have to be reckoned by some other hand than that.

For the first time since the fourth day of the month he found, when he reached the sharing-yard, that there was bread enough to feed every household in the line before evening fell.

CHAPTER FORTY

OF THE TRUCE AND THE CLOSING OF THE CROSSING

AE 150 – 151

Cha tàinig long. No ship came.

I

Of Ros Bheag and the Last Seat

By an Dàmhair there was no seat left to the Administration but Ros bheag. Ros dhomhain was gone to the council's companies, the harbour quarter first and then the Residency, stripped of its letter-books and its silver and left standing empty for the rats. Cuan uaine's quays had opened in the night without a shot fired. Lionel Strake, fifty years old that autumn and Commissioner of a government that now governed three streets and a wall, took what was left of it, his officers, the Mission's clergy, a handful of clerks who had

nowhere else to be Company men, down the Abhainn gheal by water and set it up behind the old walls of Ros bheag, the western port the humans had used since the earliest years, before there had been an Administration to house. He had been a soldier before he was ever a Commissioner, sent out young to a war he had never expected to end in a room with a view of a harbour and nothing left to command but the harbour's stores, and those who served under him in that last season said he gave his orders the way a man gives orders on a sinking ship, plainly, and without asking whether they would be obeyed a second time.

The human families of the west and the south came in behind him, a few thousand souls in all where there had once been tens of thousands, walking or riding or carried in Company carts with what they could load in a day, and Ros bheag, a town built to hold a few thousand of its own, took them in the way a burn takes a flood: badly, and not for long. The Dia-thìrich of the town, who had kept their own houses and their own market cross through three generations of Company officers coming and going at the quay below, watched the walls fill with strangers and found, most of them, that there was nowhere left in the town to be a stranger from, since the strangers now outnumbered them within their own gates.

Strake set constables along the coast road at Ros àrsaidh, to hold the way north and bring him word, and the townsfolk of Ros àrsaidh, who had watched three generations of Company officers come and go through their gates, brought the constables food and news both, the news always a day old by the time it reached them and older still by the time Strake heard it. At Cuan shean, where the first of the strangers' boats had ever touched the island, the custodians shut the harbour to every ship that flew the Company's colours, and set nothing further down about it. The roll that kept the record of that season wrote only that the harbour was shut, and let the silence stand for whatever else there was to say.

The roads cut and no ship from over the sea in months, Ros bheag ran short of food within weeks of the last family's coming in behind its walls. It was Eilidh Hale, Thomas Hale's daughter, who carried Strake's order down to the Company store on the quay in the first days of an Dàmhair and read it out herself to the storekeeper, because the clerk whose task it should have been had taken fever and there was no one else free to send: that the stores were to be opened, from that day, to the human families and to the Dia-thìrich townsfolk of Ros bheag alike, at one measure, and no ledger kept of who took what.

II

Of the Question at Baile Dhìreach

She left Ros bheag herself before the month turned, on an errand of her father's that no longer had anywhere to deliver its answer, and came south along the coast road to Baile dhìreach, where her mother's people had kept a house since before the walls at Ros dhomhain went up.

Baile dhìreach had sat, for as long as anyone living could say, under a council that was neither wholly the custodians' nor wholly the Administration's, three of each, chosen by the town and answerable to it before either side; and it had gone on sitting through the burning of the ledgers and the fall of the Residency and the shutting of Cuan shean, because both the companies that might have broken it up had other towns to take first. Its children, the sons and daughters of the joint council's own families, were of both peoples in a way the rest of the war had stopped allowing anyone to be. Some had a human father and a Dia-thìreach mother, or the other way about; some had two parents of one people who had raised them, all the same, in both houses of worship and both sets of festival, because it was the custom of the town and no one before the war had thought to ask why. When the companies came at last, the council's men from the east and Strake's constables from the west arriving within the same week to claim the town for their own sides, each asked those children, one by one, which people they were.

Eilidh Hale was twenty-two years past being anyone's child and was asked all the same, because she had kept the joint council's books three winters running and everyone in Baile dhìreach knew her face. A young officer of the forest companies, no older than she had been when she first came to the town, put the question to her plainly, not unkindly, on the steps of the council hall with half the street watching; which was she.

She stood a while before she answered, long enough that the officer shifted his weight and looked past her at the crowd, as if the crowd might answer for her. She had her father's colouring and her mother's tongue and a ledger under her arm written half in each, and she had buried people on both sides of the question inside a year, and she found, standing on the steps with the whole of the street waiting, that she did not have an answer to give that would not be a lie to one half of what she was.

"I keep the books," she said at last, which was true, and no answer, and she went on keeping them.

Most of the joint council's children gave some version of the same reply, or none at all, and it is written of that season, plainly, without more said, that neither side made them choose. Eilidh Hale stayed at Baile dhíreach through what was left of the war, and stayed after, when staying had become the harder thing to do.

III

Of the Last Ship

The last ship known to come from over the sea anchored off Ros bheag at ant-Samhain, in weather too rough for a longboat, so that she lay out a full day and a night before a boat could be got to her at all. Word of her went round the walls faster than any boat could carry a man, and by the time the harbour master's launch put out to her there were families standing three deep along the quay who had not been told to come and had come anyway, on the chance of it.

She brought no soldiers and no grain. What she brought, the harbour roll set down afterward, was one sealed letter for the Commissioner, carried up from the boat by a sailor who would not say who had written it or from how far it had come, and who took his passage money for the return in silver and would not be drawn into speaking of the crossing beyond that it had been long, and that he did not care to make it again. Her berths, once the letter was ashore, filled with every family in Ros bheag who could buy or beg a place in them, and she put out on the next tide, deep in the water and low on stores, and was not seen again from Diathír.

What the letter said to Strake, no roll of the island ever recorded. He read it alone in the room the townsmen had given him for an office, by a window that showed him the harbour and the ship standing out from it, and he was seen afterward by his own clerks to burn the outer wrapping in the grate and to keep the letter inside his coat for the rest of that winter. No man who worked under him claimed to have read a word of it before or after, and those who watched him that evening said only that he stood a long while at the window once the ship was gone from it, looking at nothing the window still showed him.

IV

Of the Truce of Àth Àrsaidh

Envoys of the forest council and of what remained of the Administration met at Àth àrsaidh, on the edge of the country the humans had first settled and now alone still held, in the last week of an Dàmhair.

They met in the town's meeting-house, a plain building of stone and turf with a single long table down its middle, the council's men on the one side and Strake's officers on the other, and between them, because neither side would trust the other's clerk alone with the writing of it, two scribes, one of each people, setting down the same words in two hands at once. The first day went on the naming of who should sign for whom, since the council had no crown to speak in the name of and the Administration, by then, had scarcely a government; the second went on the line the two sides drew on the map between them, argued mile by mile along a coast neither delegation had walked in full; the third settled, in less than an hour once the argument was spent, what three days had failed to agree in a morning: that the humans still on Dia-thìr should withdraw into the north-west country under the council's safe-conduct, unharmed on the road and unhindered at its end, and that the council in its turn would leave the towns of that country standing, their walls unbroken and their people, human and Dia-thìrich both, in possession of what they held.

Baile Mòr ruadh, the greatest town of that country, was named the place the columns would be received, and its own Dia-thìrich folk, who had lived under the humans' governance longer than any other town on the island and knew no other, were given the choice, plainly put to them at a gathering in the market square, of staying under the truce or going south with the council's men. The roll that counted them afterward set the two numbers side by side, and they came out close, near enough that no one afterward could say the town had chosen with one voice.

V

Of the Columns North

They went in an t-Samhain and the first weeks of an Dùbhlachd, the human families of Ros bheag, of Cuan shean, of Baile dhìreach and the towns of

the south-west, walking the western roads under the guard of the forest council's companies, in columns that took the better part of a day to pass any one point on the road.

Hannah Webb went with them, though the country they were walking into was the one she already lived in. She had come to the hill country behind Baile chrom at nineteen, following her brother to the concession's fields, and had kept her night vigil on the field paths there and nursed in the wards at Cathair gheal through the fever; and when the first columns came up the western roads she walked out to meet them at the concession's southern edge and walked back with them, with a bundle on her back and a woman older than her mother on her arm, one of the last of the families to leave Cuan shean, because the woman could not walk fast and would not be carried, and Hannah would not leave her to walk alone. "I have nursed harder cases than a slow road," she told the woman, more than once, when the woman apologised for the pace, and meant it kindly; and the woman let herself be walked at whatever speed Hannah judged safe, and stopped apologising by the second day.

At Àth chrom the custodians of the town stood at the ford and counted the column over, family by family, the last count the Dia-thìrich made of the humans on Dia-thìr in that age, and it is written that the counting took from first light until past noon, and that no one on either side of the ford spoke more than the counting needed.

At Àth leathan, the last stage before the north country proper, the columns camped a night in the fields below the town, cooking fires strung along the hedgerow further than any one watch could count them from the wall. It is written that several of the humans who camped there asked the custodians the name of the place, and wrote it down for themselves before they slept, in whatever hand and whatever tongue each of them had; one woman, brought to bed of a child that same night under a hedge with two of her own people and the town's midwife working over her by lantern, is said to have asked the name a second time in the morning, to be sure she had it right, and given it to the child as if it were a christening name and no other had yet been settled on. What the rest of them meant to do with the name, the custodians who gave it did not ask and were not told.

VI

Of the Keeper's Watch

At Taigh-solais Baile chrom¹, on the north-western headland, Lachlann mac Uisdein kept the light his father had kept before him, and his father's day-book before that, the same worn cover, filling now with a second man's hand.

He was forty that winter, and had known no other work; his father Uisdean had lit the tower first in his own youth and kept it through the years of the Green Death, and had died with the daybook's ink not yet dry on the last page he wrote, and Lachlann had taken up the pen the same evening because the light did not keep itself and the wind did not wait on grief. He wrote what his father had written before him: the wind, the state of the oil, the ships seen and their bearing, and, on the nights there were none, the same three words his father had written on nights there were none.

A boat came up from Baile chrom below one evening with word, third or fourth hand by the time it reached him, that the last Commissioner had gone down to Cuan shean to take ship, and that the ship would go north-about past the headland on the evening tide, as every ship bound over the eastern sea had gone since before Lachlann's grandfather kept any book at all. Lachlann had never seen a Commissioner, nor any human of rank higher than the surveyors who had once come up the coast road with their chains, and he found, turning the word over as he climbed the tower stair, that he had no picture in his mind of the man he was about to watch leave, only of the ship.

He watched for her from the gallery through the last of the light, and saw her come up past the point further out than the coasting boats ever ran, three-masted and low in the water, showing no lamp he could see until she was nearly past, when a single light appeared at her stern, small and steady, and held so a long while that he thought at first she had anchored. She had not. She was standing out, slow against the ebb, and the light went with her, smaller each glass, until the dark of the water and the dark of the sky came together and there was nothing left to tell one from the other, and Lachlann stood at the rail of the gallery a good while after that, in case his eyes had been wrong about the last of it, before he went in and lit the lamp himself, because it wanted lighting, and wrote in the day-

1. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

book, in his father's hand more than his own: *a ship of the strangers, three masts, going north about, showing one light. Did not come back.*

It is that book, kept in the same hand and the same plain words night after night, more than any order of the council's, that the roll of that winter leans on for the day and the hour of the last human commissioner's leaving Dia-thìr.

VII

Of the Keys at Cuan Shean

The harbour officers of Ceann mhòr, of Cathair gheal and of Inis àrsaidh, the three ports of the north that had kept the Administration's charts and tallies since the earliest post at Ros dhomhain, rode down together to Cuan shean in the same week, each with his town's chest of harbour keys strapped behind his saddle, to give them into Strake's own hand before his ship sailed.

It was no part of the truce that required it. The council's writ did not run to those ports, tucked as they were behind the northern capes where the truce had drawn its line, and the three men might as well have kept the keys, or buried them, or thrown them into the sea their towns looked out on. They chose instead to ride two days south with the weight of them, and stood on the quay at Cuan shean in the last of the daylight and set the three chests down at Strake's feet. They said, between them, no more than that the accounts were even and the harbours in good order; that who would want the keys after was not for them to say; and that they had brought them, all the same, to the one man whose office it plainly still was, for as long as he held it. Each of the three had kept his father's post before him, as Lachlann kept his; none of them, that evening on the quay, spoke of what he would do when he rode home to a harbour with no office left to answer to.

Strake took the chests aboard with him, and no roll of the island records anything further of them, on a sea no ship of Dia-thìr had ever followed.

VIII

Of the Beacons Relit

The forest council, once the truce was signed and the columns on the road, ordered the five beacons lit again from Baile chrom round the coast to Tobar dhearg, the same ring that had burned through the years of the Levy to count human ships coming in.

They burned now for nothing that came. The keepers' daybooks, Lachlann's among them, went on being kept as they had always been kept, oil bought, wick trimmed, wind recorded, and the line beneath the weather where a ship would once have been noted stood empty night after night through an Dùbhlachd, until the keepers stopped troubling to leave the line and simply wrote, some of them, the same three words that had first been Uisdean mac Lachlainn's alone and were now half the coast's. *Cha tàinig long.*

No ship came. It was not grief in the writing of it, by the time the winter was old, so much as habit; the sentence had outlived the asking it once answered.

I X

Of the First Chest

The rolls of that age, what the custodians could gather of them before the year turned, the copies of the two petitions, the book kept at Baile thais through the eleven days, the letter-books left behind in the stripped Residency and whatever else had not gone west with Strake's own clerks, came to Muileann chaol by cart in the last days of an Dùbhlachd, four chests bound in oiled cloth against the weather, with a single custodian riding beside them the whole way and sleeping across the lids at night.

Cailean mac Eachainn was fifty-three that winter, copyist of the three households of Muileann chaol since before any of this had a name, and it was into his hands the chests were given, because there was no one else at the mill house whose writing every custodian on the island already trusted. He signed for them on the step, in the cold, with the carter still stamping to warm his feet, and had them carried down into the cellar he had cleared for them through the autumn on nothing more than the word that they would be coming.

He opened the first chest alone, by lamp, on the last evening of the year, and found it filled less neatly than he had hoped and more fully than he had feared: papers out of order, some scorched at the corner, some still smelling of the smoke of the rooms they had been carried out of, a petition in a hand he knew and a

ledger in a hand he did not, and under them all, wrapped apart in its own cloth as if someone at the last had thought to spare it, the book kept at Baile thais through its eleven days, whole.

That one he set aside, unread, and sat a while instead with his hand flat on the closed lid of the chest, the lamp burning low beside him, thinking less of what had been kept than of what the other three chests, still bound, might turn out to lack.

Word came down from Cathair dhearg at am Faoilleach's turning, on the first day of the new year, that the war was ended and the crossing shut, whatever way had ever let the strangers reach the island closed behind the last of them. The humans still on Dia-thìr had gone north under the council's safe-conduct into the northern country; and Cian and Lorccan, neither of them yet twenty, would grow up in the wake of it.

Cailean set the news down in no roll of his own that night. He only lit a second lamp against the dark, and drew the second chest toward him across the cellar floor, and began, again, to see what had been kept, and what had not.

PART SEVEN

The Annals of the Age

THE YEARS AE 1 – 10

- 5 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 1** — *The Crossing*. Humans come ashore on Dia-thìr, bringing their Church with them, and are given leave to stay. They are the first strangers met since the Sundering.
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 1** — *The ships met off the north-west* (Coinneachadh nan Long¹). That winter the mist that had lain on the eastern sea since the fleet of the Sundering sailed into it lifts from the northern water. Two fishing boats of Achadh àrsaidh, working the water off the north-west cape where the Sea-Watcher is seen, meet three ships coming down out of the thin grey from the north, and hail them; neither side understands the other. The fishers turn south and the ships follow them down the coast toward Cuan shean. The fishers call the place Coinneachadh nan Long, the meeting of the ships, and the boats of Achadh àrsaidh still slow there.
- 21 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 1** — *The word brought home to Achadh àrsaidh* (Achadh àrsaidh). The second of the two Achadh àrsaidh boats that met the strangers' ships off the north-west cape turns home and brings the word to its households, while Lachlann Odhar's boat leads the strangers' ships south toward Cuan shean. Achadh àrsaidh is the first place on the island to hear of the strangers, and it hears of them from its own fishers.²
- 5 AN GEARRAN, AE 1** — *Three ships off Cuan shean* (Cuan shean). Three ships down from the north anchor off Cuan shean, the first hulls of their size seen from Dia-thìr since the fleet of the Sundering. Their master, a captain the rolls name Edmund Harrow, comes ashore unarmed with eleven men and asks by signs for water.
- 31 AN CÈITEAN, AE 1** — *The rider from Cuan shean reaches Cathair dhearg* (Cuan shean). A rope-maker's son of Cuan shean rides the valley road to the capital in a day with Oighrig nic Leòid's letter on the ships. The clerk of the council reads it standing. The council's answer, two days later, bids Cuan shean feed the strangers, keep them apart and decide nothing.
- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 1** — *Forty days on the dunes* (Cuan shean). The custodians of Cuan shean will not decide alone, and send inland to the capital for counsel. For forty days the strangers are fed on the beach and kept below the dunes.³
- 10 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 1** — *The custodian of Baile fhiadhaich rides south* (Baile fhiadhaich). Word of the ships reaches Baile fhiadhaich, up the western coast, in two days. Its custodian rides south to see them, and writes to the council that the strangers' ropes are better than ours and their manners worse.

1. the meeting of the ships

2. ← Follows from *The ships met off the north-west*, 13 am Faoilleach, AE 1.

3. → Caused by *The rider from Cuan shean reaches Cathair dhearg*, 31 an Cèitean, AE 1.

- 12 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 1** — *Oighrig nic Leòid's letter to the council from her sickbed* (Cuan shean). From her bed at Cuan shean Oighrig nic Leòid writes to the council that she gave the strangers water under the law of the shore and nothing more on her own word, and that a leave given in the roll cannot be ungiven. She asks that it be read before the vote. The clerk notes it received.
- 11 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 2** — *The Council of Custodians grants leave* (Cathair dhearg). The Council of Custodians at Cathair dhearg, which has sat in the crown's place since the crown fell empty at the close of the Age of Sundering, confirms the strangers' leave to stay under the high custodian Tormod mac Ailein. The council roll gives the vote as with one voice; a later hand in the margin notes that three custodians were absent.⁴
- 9 AN GEARRAN, AE 2** — *The quarter of sea they came from* (Cuan shean). Old sailors at Cuan shean say that the strangers came in from the same quarter of sea the fleet of the Sundering sailed into. The council forbids the saying in its hall. It is written down all the same, and never answered.
- 26 AN GEARRAN, AE 2** — *The land beyond*. The strangers name their homeland in their own tongue, but no scribe of the Dia-thìrich writes the word down. From the first season the scribes call it an Tìr Thall⁵, the land beyond, and its people simply the humans.
- 3 AM MÀRT, AE 2** — *The humans pray in a sail-loft at Cuan shean* (Cuan shean). On the day the strangers keep for their god a sailmaker of Cuan shean lends them his loft against the rain. They kneel on the sailcloth, the captain with the rest, while a priest reads from a book; they light no fire and burn nothing. Two priests of Manannan watch from the stair and go down to the water to say their own prayer. It is the first entry of the humans at prayer under a roof.⁶
- 22 AM MÀRT, AE 2** — *Wren and the priests come up to Cathair dhearg* (Cuan shean). Two priests of the humans and a boy ride up from Cuan shean on ponies of the town, a long day's road, and come over the bridge at dusk soaked through. The council lodges them in a house below the temple and gives them a long room on the east side of the hall. The younger priest, Samuel Wren, coughs in the damp of the lake country.
- 27 AM MÀRT, AE 2** — *The first attempts at speech*. For a whole season clerics of the humans' Church and custodians of Dia-thìr labour to make a store of words in common. Neither side's account of what was agreed survives whole.⁷

4. → Caused by *The rider from Cuan shean reaches Cathair dhearg*, 31 an Cèitean, AE 1; → Caused by *Oighrig nic Leòid's letter to the council from her sickbed*, 12 an t-Iuchar, AE 1.

5. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

6. ← Follows from *The Crossing*, 5 am Faoilleach, AE 1; ← Follows from *The Council of Custodians grants leave*, 11 am Faoilleach, AE 2.

7. → Caused by *Wren and the priests come up to Cathair dhearg*, 22 am Màrt, AE 2.

- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 2** — *Wren's word-lists* (Cathair dhearg). The human cleric Samuel Wren and the custodian Gormshuil nic Fhearchair keep word-lists side by side through the season of speech-making. Wren's list survives in the Administration's letter-books. Gormshuil's is lost; only its first leaf, with forty words for the colours of broken coal, is known from a copy.
- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 2** — *Muireall copies the first leaf* (Cathair dhearg). In the gap-moon Gormshuil nic Fhearchair gives her loose sheets to her niece Muireall to copy fair into a book for Clann Fhearchair, and orders the colours set first, before cup and bread, alone on the first leaf with room left at the foot. Muireall copies the forty words in her young, careful hand and stops at the right-hand column, where the humans' side has one word to give.
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, AE 3** — *One word for the coal* (Cathair dhearg). The humans have a single word for the coloured coal, and it is their word for the black fuel they burn at home. Gormshuil's copyist notes that no Dia-thiris word in either list answers to it, and that the humans did not ask for one.⁸
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, AE 3** — *Trade begins*. At first the trade is fair on both sides: the goods of Dia-thir for tools and knowledge the lonely island lacks. For a few years it seems it may last.
- 22 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 3** — *The trading post at Ros dhomhain* (Ros dhomhain). The humans set up a trading post at Ros dhomhain, the capital's harbour, and give iron tools, window glass, lamp-oil and paper for wool, salt fish, hides and dyed cloth. The first tally-book of the post, kept by the trader Thomas Pike, balances evenly through its first year.
- 21 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 3** — *The first hull on Loch chrom* (Abhainn gheal). Pilots of Caol leathan bring the first of the strangers' ships up the Abhainn gheal into Loch chrom, towing her with boats through the shallows below Baile ghlas, and she anchors off Ros dhomhain. Thereafter the humans' goods come to the capital shore by water, and the pilots charge a stranger's hull twice the toll of a Dia-thireach boat.
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 3** — *Cathair naomh sends its wool* (Cathair naomh). Cathair naomh, the city above Seann Toll on the northern coast, sends its first wool south to the humans' post by coasting boat. Its custodians take their payment in paper and ink, and with them begin the town's roll afresh.
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 3** — *Iron in the smithies* (Cathair dhearg). The smiths of Cathair dhearg take the humans' bar-iron gladly and learn to temper it in a winter. Within a few seasons the old bronze hoes are melted down for bells.
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 3** — *The ships' smith at the forge in Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). A smith off Harrow's ships, sent up by Pike, comes to the smiths' lane below the bridge at Cathair dhearg and works through the autumn at the forge of Gilleasbuig Gobha. Having no words in common, the two smiths agree on the colours of hot iron.⁹

8. → Caused by *Muireall copies the first leaf*, 14 an Dùbhlachd, AE 2.

- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 4** — *Dyes for Baile Mòr mhòr* (Baile Mòr mhòr). The weavers of Baile Mòr mhòr on the northern coast trade their cloth for the humans' dyes, a red and a blue brighter than any the island could make. Within a few years the old madder fields about the town go back to grass.
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 4** — *Harrow's second voyage* (Cuan shean). Harrow sails for home with hides and dyed cloth and comes back with four ships in place of three. He brings carpenters, a surgeon, and a letter from a trading house in an Tìr Thall¹⁰ asking what else the island has.
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 4** — *The shipwrights of Inis mhòr* (Inis mhòr). The shipwrights of Inis mhòr come to look at the humans' hulls and measure them with knotted cords. Their guild had built nothing greater than a coaster since the fleet of the Sundering, and the old craft of building for deep water was half forgotten.
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 4** — *The surgeon Jonas Tull* (Cuan shean). The humans' surgeon, Jonas Tull, sets the broken leg of a fisherman of Cuan shean who had been given up as lame. The town's custodian enters it in the roll as the first debt owed to a stranger.
- 30 AM MÀRT, AE 5** — *Salt from Seann Warr* (Seann Warr). The salt-pans of Seann Warr begin to sell to Pike's post by the barrel. They are the first goods of Dia-thìr that the humans come back asking for twice.
- 14 AN GIBLEAN, AE 5** — *Wool at Caol leathan* (Caol leathan). The walled harbour of Caol leathan sends its first wool-ship to the humans' post. Its merchants will be paid only in iron by weight, and the tally-book of the post names them the hardest bargainers on the island.
- 16 AN GIBLEAN, AE 5** — *Pike writes home of the island's coal* (Ros dhomhain). Answering the trading house, Thomas Pike writes of the island's timber, salt, wool, hides and smiths, and that it has copper, tin and some silver. Having held a piece from a custodian's hearth to the window, he writes that the island has coal of a middling sort, and much of it.¹¹
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, AE 5** — *Gilleasbuig Gobha forges a hinge for Pike's chest* (Cathair dhearg). Gilleasbuig Gobha makes a new hinge of the strangers' bar-iron for the iron-bound chest under Pike's counter, where letters for over the sea are kept. He tempers it to the blue and will take nothing for the work. Pike's letter on the coal goes over the sea in that chest.¹²
- 22 AN GIBLEAN, AE 5** — *The first mixed settlement*. A small coastal town takes in both Dia-thìrich and humans under one rule. It is not tried again.
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 5** — *Baile dhìreach under one council* (Baile dhìreach). The small port of Baile dhìreach on the south-west coast takes Dia-thìrich and humans under one council of six, three of each. Its founding compact is written twice, once in each tongue, the only such compact of the age.

9. ← Follows from *Iron in the smithies*, 17 an t-Sultain, AE 3.

10. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

11. ← Follows from *Harrow's second voyage*, 16 an Dàmhair, AE 4; ← Follows from *The trading post at Ros dhomhain*, 22 an t-Ògmhios, AE 3.

12. ← Follows from *Iron in the smithies*, 17 an t-Sultain, AE 3.

- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 5** — *The first council of Baile dhìreach* (Baile dhìreach). The council is chaired in alternate years by the fisherman Iain mac Chaluim and the human carpenter William Rook. The harbour dues go half to the custodians at Cathair dhearg and half to the humans' post.
- 11 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 5** — *Samuel Hale tightens the herring barrels* (Baile dhìreach). The human cooper Samuel Hale takes down the leaking herring barrels of Baile dhìreach stave by stave and makes every one of them tight by the end of summer, beginning with the idle row of the salter Ruairidh. He takes a bowl from the pot for his pay, and asks for Dia-thìris words, which he writes under his own.
- 30 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 5** — *The first boat off the humans' slip* (Baile dhìreach). On the first evening of Lùnastal the humans' slip at Baile dhìreach launches a small coaster of the strangers' pattern, deeper in the keel than the boats of the south-west. She is built for the fisherman Iain mac Chaluim, paid for in fish and labour and rigged with the town's rope; his wife pours sea water on her bow and asks Manannan to keep her.
- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 5** — *A stranger's prayer at the lamps of the drowned* (Baile dhìreach). At the dark of the year Baile dhìreach sets lamps along its quay for its drowned, as the harbours of the west do. The humans of the shingle stand in the line, and the cooper Samuel Hale says a prayer to Crìosd¹³ in his own tongue for shipmates lost in the northern sea on the voyage out. Eilidh nic Ruairidh sets a lamp for them.
- 1 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 6** — *Inis thais declines the compact* (Inis thais). The city of Inis thais, whose harbour lies a few miles from Baile dhìreach, is bidden to join the joint council and declines. Its custodian writes that one town may be a trial, but two would be a rule.
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 6** — *A supply ship lost on the western reefs* (Muir Mhanannain¹⁴). A human supply ship strikes the reefs off the western coast in fog, and nine of her crew drown. Her master was sailing by a chart drawn from memory, the humans' letter-books complain, on a coast lit only by the old driftwood fires.
- 28 AN GEARRAN, AE 6** — *The beacons asked for*. Human seamen, strange to the coasts of Dia-thìr, ask for standing beacons. The builders of the Dia-thìrich agree, not yet seeing what the beacons will bring.
- 29 AM MÀRT, AE 6** — *The beacon headlands walked* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg¹⁵). The human navigator James Fenn and the Dia-thìreach mason Torcall Clachair walk the coast together to choose the places of the new beacons, and mark the five headlands of the old fires. Fenn's chart survives; Torcall's cairns for the most part do not.

13. Christ

14. Manannan's sea, round Dia-thìr

15. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

- 5 **AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 6** — *Pike writes of the natives* (Ros dhomhain). Thomas Pike enters in the post's letter-book that the islanders have agreed to the lights without difficulty and without asking what they would cost. It is the first page of his letter-book to call the Dia-thìrich the natives. The custodians' roll sets down the same asking as a request that the old sea-fires be built higher and kept all night.¹⁶
- 11 **AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 6** — *No fire on Binnean a' Chlachair*¹⁷ (Muileann gheal). James Fenn asks for a night fire on the summit of Binnean a' Chlachair, the highest ground of the island. Torcall Clachair and the herders of Muileann gheal refuse, keeping the custom of the hills. Torcall lays one stone on the herders' cairn, and Fenn takes his sights by day to a linen square, four days slower. The two winter at Muileann gheal.
- 26 **AN GIBLEAN, AE 7** — *Fenn's line* (Dia-thìr). On the same survey James Fenn runs a line of sights across the whole island, from the open sea off the north-west, where ships coming down from the north first raise the land, to the water off the eastern cape. He makes it a hundred and fifty-five miles, some thirty of them sea at the western end. It is the first measure of Dia-thìr from side to side, and every chart the Company draws afterwards is scaled to it.¹⁸
- 26 **AN CÈITEAN, AE 7** — *A marriage in two tongues* (Baile dhìreach). At Baile dhìreach the net-maker Eilidh nic Ruairidh weds the human cooper Samuel Hale. The council enters the marriage in both its books; the custodians at Cathair dhearg, asked for a ruling, send none.
- 31 **AN CÈITEAN, AE 7** — *Torcall witnesses in the Dia-thìreach book* (Baile dhìreach). At the wedding on the quay of Baile dhìreach no custodian comes to witness. James Fenn signs for the bridegroom in the humans' book, and Iain mac Chaluim calls the mason Torcall Clachair from the crowd to sign the Dia-thìreach book. William Rook and Iain mac Chaluim close the two books side by side.¹⁹
- 27 **AN GIBLEAN, AE 8** — *The first written treaty*. The terms on which the humans stay are first set down in writing, in the humans' tongue only. No one among the Dia-thìrich speaks against it at the time.
- 7 **AN CÈITEAN, AE 8** — *The treaty signed at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). The treaty is signed in the council hall at Cathair dhearg by Tormod mac Ailein for the custodians, and for the Administration by Josiah Pell, newly come as the humans' first Commissioner. Tormod could not read the tongue it was written in. Who read it to him is not told.
- 23 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 8** — *Gormshuil called back from Muileann chaol* (Muileann chaol). Gormshuil nic Fhearchair, gone east with the season's copies for the loft of Beathag nic Thòmais at Muileann chaol, is sent for by rider when the talks with Pell run fast. She starts back the day the rider finds her, but the rain is on the hills and the fords are up, and she is still on the road when the terms are signed.²⁰

16. ← Follows from *The beacons asked for*, 28 an Gearran, AE 6.

17. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

18. → Caused by *No fire on Binnean a' Chlachair*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, AE 6.

19. ← Follows from *A marriage in two tongues*, 26 an Cèitean, AE 7.

- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 8** — *Gormshuil given a copy of the terms* (Cathair dhearg). Two days after the signing Gormshuil nic Fhearchair comes in from the hills, reads the entry in the roll standing, and asks Pell through Samuel Wren for the terms in the strangers' tongue, since the copy in Dia-thiris is to wait for leisure. Pell's secretary makes one within the week. She begins to read it a word at a time, and does not bring it before the council.²¹
- 22 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 8** — *The masons of the capital build for Pell* (Cathair dhearg). The masons of the masons' lane at Cathair dhearg take up Pell's house on the rise, paid in bar-iron by the humans' day, which begins at midnight where the island's begins at dusk. They float grey stone over the lake on rafts and build the house square to Pell's drawn plan, facing the harbour, with its back to the capital. The council does not ask it turned.
- 10 AN CÈITEAN, AE 9** — *The Residency above Ros dhomhain* (Ros dhomhain). Josiah Pell builds a house of dressed stone on the rise above Ros dhomhain and calls it the Residency. Captain Harrow, needed ashore no longer, goes back to the sea trade.²²
- 18 AN CÈITEAN, AE 9** — *The Company chartered* (Ros dhomhain). Harrow and Pike found a trading house under licence of the Administration, known on Dia-thir simply as the Company. Its charter gives it first refusal of "all fuels, ores and minerals the island may yield."
- 28 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 9** — *The warehouse at Cathair dhomhain* (Cathair dhomhain). The Company builds a stone warehouse at Cathair dhomhain, along the lake shore from the capital, to keep its tools from the harbour thieves of Ros dhomhain. It is the first building on Dia-thir the Company owns outright.
- 5 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 9** — *The strangers' fever* (Cuan shean). A fever comes ashore at Cuan shean with a crowded ship and runs down the west coast. Ninety-one Dia-thirich die, and eleven humans. The custodians shut the town to ships for a season, and Pell protests in writing.
- 9 AN GEARRAN, AE 10** — *The fever at Baile àrsaidh* (Baile àrsaidh). The strangers' fever comes to Baile àrsaidh, a day's walk up the coast, and kills its custodian and both her sons. No humans dwell in the town at all, and the custodians of the west take note of it.
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 10** — *The fever turned back at Cnoc àrsaidh* (Cnoc àrsaidh). At Cnoc àrsaidh in the south-west the townsfolk block the road with carts and turn back every traveller for a season, and the fever does not reach them. The Administration fines the town for hindering trade.
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 10** — *Prospectors in the central hills* (Muileann chrom). The Company sends two prospectors, Abel Stone and Hugh Mercer, into the hills east of the capital. They come back with sacks of broken coal, and word that the black seam runs "further than can be walked in a day."

20. ⇄ At the same time *The treaty signed at Cathair dhearg*, 7 an Cèitean, AE 8.

21. ← Follows from *The treaty signed at Cathair dhearg*, 7 an Cèitean, AE 8; ◇ Same person *One word for the coal*, 23 an Giblean, AE 3.

22. → Caused by *The masons of the capital build for Pell*, 22 an Dàmhair, AE 8.

THE YEARS AE 11 – 20

- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 11** — *The sacks returned to the rock* (Muileann chrom). The custodians of the vein demand the broken coal back, to lay it in the rock again with the proper words. The Company returns half. The custodians' roll enters the other half as "carried west."
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 11** — *The first mining contracts*. Trade sours into bargain. Dia-thirich hands mine the vein on a scale that no reverent custom had ever used.
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 11** — *The first pit at Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). Under the first contract a Dia-thireach crew of thirty opens a working at Muileann chrom, paid by the ton in iron tools and lamp-oil. The custodians' own cuttings had never been measured by weight at all.
- 26 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 11** — *Six sacks come back to Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). At the summer's end a human carter brings six of the thirteen sacks back up the road to the mill of Muileann chrom with a paper no one there can read. Asked for the rest, he points west, towards Ros dhomhain and the ships, and turns his cart round.¹
- 8 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 11** — *The first contract read at the mill* (Muileann chrom). Abel Stone brings the first contract of A' Chompanaidh² to Muileann chrom with two carts of steel-pointed picks, bar-iron and lamp-oil. It is read at the mill in both tongues. The interpreter from Ros dhomhain can find no Dia-thiris for the ton and calls it "a great load, weighed". Some of the older hewers walk out before the end.³
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 11** — *Raghnall chosen to lead the thirty* (Muileann chrom). Abel Stone names Raghnall mac Dhòmhnaill, who walked the seam with him, to lead the first crew of the hill. The crew is thirty: young men of the hewers' and shepherds' households, two from the mill and three older hewers of the old cutting. Raghnall's father, a hewer of that cutting, will not join it.⁴
- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 12** — *A coal quay at Ceann fhada* (Ceann fhada). The Company builds a stone quay at Ceann fhada, a fishing hamlet below the hills, for loading coal into coasting barges. The fishermen are paid for their foreshore in iron nails, by weight.
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 12** — *Wren's grammar* (Ros dhomhain). Samuel Wren finishes a grammar of Dia-thiris for the Mission, the house of the humans' Church on Dia-thir. It is careful and true in most things, and it gives the word for the vein's custodians as "keepers of the coal."

1. ← Follows from *The sacks returned to the rock*, 17 an t-Sultain, AE 11.

2. the Company

3. ← Follows from *The first mining contracts*, 19 an t-Sultain, AE 11.

4. ← Follows from *The first mining contracts*, 19 an t-Sultain, AE 11; ← Follows from *The first pit at Muileann chrom*, 16 an Dàmhair, AE 11.

- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 13** — *The hawk-priests read Wren* (Cnoc bheag). The hawk-priests of Cnoc bheag ask the Mission for a copy of Wren's grammar, to read what the humans write of them. The Mission sends one. Of all the copies that survive it bears the most notes in the margins.
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 13** — *The Mission chapel* (Ros dhomhain). The Mission raises a timber chapel on the quay at Ros dhomhain, the first church on the island. Its bell is the first iron bell on the island, and the custodians ask that it not be rung before the fishing fleet is out.
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 13** — *The bell rung once before the fleet was out* (Ros dhomhain). On the morning of its hanging the iron bell of the chapel on the quay at Ros dhomhain is rung for the first service while the fishers are loading their boats in silence, as the rule of that quay requires. The crews unload and go home. Three boats of more than twenty go out on the lake that day.⁵
- 29 AM MÀRT, AE 14** — *The first refusal*. One mining settlement will not sign a contract. For the present it is passed by, not punished.
- 12 AN GIBLEAN, AE 14** — *Beathag calls Doire mhòr's households to the hearth* (Doire mhòr). On the evening the day for the marks goes by, Beathag Dhubh calls the seven households of Doire mhòr to her fire and has the contract told to them. They talk of iron, oats and sheep. The oldest woman of the hill says that the hill is not theirs, and the households give the answer to the custodian to give.⁶
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, AE 14** — *Beathag Dhubh of Doire mhòr* (Doire mhòr). The settlement that refused was Doire mhòr, in the hills above Muileann chrom, and its custodian was Beathag Dhubh. Her answer to the Company's agent is known only in his words: that the hill was not hers to sell nor his to buy.⁷
- 28 AN GEARRAN, AE 15** — *The road around Doire mhòr* (Cnoc fhiadhaich). The Company opens its next working at Cnoc fhiadhaich instead, and runs its cart-road round the fields of Doire mhòr and not through them.
- 9 AN CÈITEAN, AE 15** — *Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg⁸ lit* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg). The first of the new beacons is finished on the southern headland at Tobar dhearg: a round tower of grey stone raised over the old fire-tower, paid for by the Company, with a Dia-thìreach keeper. Torcall Clachair builds it; James Fenn sets its lens.
- 29 AM MÀRT, AE 16** — *The first keeper of Tobar dhearg* (Tobar dhearg). The first keeper of the southern beacon is Anna nic Dhòmhnaill of Tobar dhearg village, a fisherman's widow, who climbs the tower twice a night for the rest of her life. The village holds the keepership as a trust and keeps it in its own families through the age.

5. ← Follows from *The Mission chapel*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, AE 13.

6. ← Follows from *The first refusal*, 29 am Màrt, AE 14.

- 30 AM MÀRT, AE 16** — *Anna nic Dhòmhnaill's tally of lit nights cut on the stair wall* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg⁹). Anna nic Dhòmhnaill, keeper of Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg, who cannot write, begins her count on the wall of the tower stair below the lamp-room: one stroke cut with a knife for every night the light is lit, and a stroke across every thirty.¹⁰
- 10 AN GIBLEAN, AE 16** — *Raiders in the north-western waters* (Spùinneadairean-mara). A Company brig is boarded off the north-west coast and stripped of her cargo of tools. The raiders are never known. The Administration blames the custodians of the coast, and the custodians answer that those waters have always kept their own law.
- 5 AN GEARRAN, AE 17** — *The obelisk at Cnoc bheag copied* (Carragh Cnoc bheag¹¹). Samuel Wren copies the writing on the obelisk near Cnoc bheag and sends it over the sea to the scholars of an Tìr Thall¹². No answer comes. The custodians tell him the stone is older than the Dia-thìrich and that none living can read it.
- 13 AN GEARRAN, AE 17** — *The first coin*. The humans' coin is brought in beside the old barter, for ease, it is said. Within ten years nothing that needs a tool from over the sea can be had for anything else.
- 10 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 17** — *The mark and its hundred pence* (Ros dhomhain). The coins are struck at Ros dhomhain from silver and copper shipped from an Tìr Thall¹³; the mark and its hundred pence. The first striking bears a ship on one face, and nothing of Dia-thìr on either.
- 1 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 18** — *Cathair mhòr refuses the mark* (Cathair mhòr). The market of Cathair mhòr, greatest below the hills east of the capital, refuses the humans' coin for a whole year. The custodians of the town give way when the Company's tool-sellers will not cross their bridge.
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 18** — *Two books at the capital market* (Cathair dhearg). At the market of Cathair dhearg the tool-sellers take only marks, while cloth and fish still go by barter. The custodians' clerks begin to keep two sets of books, and complain of it in both.
- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 18** — *Wren's winter at Dùn thais* (Dùn thais). The masters of the druid school at Dùn thais receive Samuel Wren for a winter of disputation. He asks them why the vein should be holy; they ask him why his fuel should be burned. Neither telling of that winter names a winner.

7. → Caused by *Beathag calls Doire mhòr's households to the hearth*, 12 an Giblean, AE 14.

8. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

9. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

10. ← Follows from *Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg lit*, 9 an Cèitean, AE 15; ← Follows from *The first keeper of Tobar dhearg*, 29 am Màrt, AE 16.

11. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

12. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

13. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 18** — *Wren's letter home on the druids* (Dùn thais). From Dùn thais, in the last days of the year, Samuel Wren writes to the house of his order over the sea by the packet of Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir¹⁴. He sets down a tale the eldest master told at the hearth of a holy man's voyage west in a boat of hides, very like the voyage of Naomh Breandan as an Eaglais tells it, told from the other shore.¹⁵
- 28 AN GEARRAN, AE 19** — *Drochaid Cathair dhearg*¹⁶ *rebuilt* (Drochaid Cathair dhearg). Company masons rebuild in dressed stone the old bridge over Abhainn dhomhain at Cathair dhearg, wide enough for coal-carts to pass two abreast.
- 30 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 19** — *The Commissioner's carriage* (Drochaid Cathair dhearg¹⁷). Company wheelwrights build a closed carriage for Josiah Pell, and he drives in it over the new bridge from the Residency to the council at Cathair dhearg. It is the first carriage on the island. The custodians still walk to the council, and say so.
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 19** — *The Harbour Articles* (Ros dhomhain). A second compact, the Harbour Articles, fixes the dues and anchorages of Ros dhomhain in the Company's favour. Like the first treaty it is written in the humans' tongue only, and this time two custodians refuse to sign.
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 19** — *Gormshuil nic Fhearchair refuses Puingean a' Chalaiddh*¹⁸ (Cathair dhearg). Gormshuil nic Fhearchair passes the sheet of Puingean a' Chalaiddh on unsigned, and tells Josiah Pell in his own tongue that she will not put her name under what she has read. Ailean Ruadh of Baile ghlas refuses with her. The council's roll names the two, the first custodians to refuse a writing of the strangers.¹⁹
- 5 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 20** — *The fishermen of Baile ghlas* (Baile ghlas). The fishermen of Baile ghlas, whose boats had anchored free at Ros dhomhain time out of mind, are charged anchorage under the Harbour Articles. They take their catch to their own small harbour and sell it there to anyone but the Company.²⁰
- 3 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 20** — *The northern concession* (Muileann àrsaidh). The council grants the Administration upland pasture in the north-west about Muileann àrsaidh, for human families who will not work in the pits. The grant is for grazing; the families build houses of stone.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 20** — *Death of Tormod mac Ailein* (Cathair dhearg). Tormod mac Ailein, the high custodian who signed the first treaty, dies at Cathair dhearg. The council chooses Coinneach Glas of Ceann àrsaidh after him, who had never met a human before the Crossing and has dealt with little else since.

14. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

15. ← Follows from *Wren's winter at Dùn thais*, 3 an Dùbhlachd, AE 18.

16. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

17. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

18. the Harbour Articles; lit. 'the points of the harbour'

19. ← Follows from *The Harbour Articles*, 16 an t-Samhain, AE 19.

20. → Caused by *Gormshuil nic Fhearchair refuses Puingean a' Chalaiddh*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, AE 19.

25 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 20 — *Tormod mac Ailein buried at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). Six custodians carry Tormod mac Ailein to the ground behind the council hall, with the bells of the capital ringing, and the mourners lay their stones on the grave going round sunwise. Josiah Pell walks up from the bridge-foot bareheaded to stand at the edge of the ground. Samuel Wren stands at the gate.²¹

21. ← Follows from *Death of Tormod mac Ailein*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, AE 20.

THE YEARS AE 21 – 30

- 10 AN T-IUHAR, AE 21** — *Harrow lost at sea* (Muir Mhanannain¹). Edmund Harrow's ship does not come back from the crossing. The Company passes wholly into Thomas Pike's hands, and the humans' letter-books mourn Harrow as the man who found Dia-thìr.
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 21** — *The Small-Burning Law lapses*. Centuries of measured burning end within one generation. The Law is never repealed; once its keeping no longer pays, it is no longer kept.
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 21** — *The last count at Doire mhin* (Doire mhin). The custodians of Doire mhin keep the old count of the Small-Burning Law, the measure of coal that might be burned in a year, one season longer than any others. They enter it in their roll with the note that no one asked for it.
- 11 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 22** — *A defence of the Law at Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). Fionnghal nic Artair, a custodian of Dùn dhearg, writes to the council in defence of the Small-Burning Law, the only such defence that survives. She holds that the Law was never for the coal's sake but for the people, who would become whatever the burning made them.
- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 22** — *The council files the letter from Dùn dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). Fionnghal nic Artair reads her letter standing to the council at Cathair dhearg. Coinneach Glas thanks her and bids it kept with the rolls, and the roll enters it as read and filed. The same sitting grants the Residency leave to widen the road to Muileann chrom for the coal-carts.²
- 6 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 22** — *Murchadh Seabhag preaches at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). At Seann Skell the hawk-priest Murchadh Seabhag preaches that Mòd, the Hungry Hawk of Acaill, starves those who eat faster than the land can feed them. The sermon is copied and carried to the camps, and it is the first writing of the Dia-thìrich that the Company's agents are told to seize.
- 16 AM MÀRT, AE 23** — *The hearths of Achadh naomh* (Achadh naomh). The households of Achadh naomh, in the hills north of the workings, who keep Na Seann Spioradan³, will not light their hearths with coal bought of the Company. They burn peat as their grandparents did, and their elders teach that coal burned for wages is burned without the ancestors' leave.
- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 23** — *The Company's agents seize the hawk sermon in the camps* (Muileann chrom). The Company's agents at Muileann chrom go from hut to hut through the crews' camp with a basket and take every copy of Murchadh Seabhag's sermon they find, eleven in one morning. One woman burns her copy on her hearth before them, and her name is written down.⁴

1. Manannan's sea, round Dia-thìr

2. ← Follows from *A defence of the Law at Dùn dhearg*, 11 an t-Ògmhios, AE 22; ← Follows from *The Small-Burning Law lapses*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, AE 21.

3. the Old Spirits

4. ← Follows from *Murchadh Seabhag preaches at Seann Skell*, 6 an t-Sultain, AE 22.

- 8 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 23** — *Burning by the cartload* (Muileann chrom). The Company's furnaces at Muileann chrom burn coal by the cartload to drive the new pumps, and no heed is paid to the custodians' tally of what the hill may give in a year. Coinneach Glas's council asks that the tally be kept, and is sent a copy of the Company's accounts.
- 15 AN GEARRAN, AE 24** — *Henry Maddox Commissioner* (Ros dhomhain). Josiah Pell sails home to an Tìr Thall⁵ and does not return. After him comes Henry Maddox, bidden to double the yield, with a letter from the Company promising him a share of it.
- 12 AM MÀRT, AE 24** — *The oaks of Cathair fhada* (Cathair fhada). Maddox buys the oak woods about Cathair fhada for pit-props. The town had cut them sparingly for generations; they are gone within the working lives of the men who fell them.
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, AE 24** — *The last oak of Cathair fhada's own cutting* (Cathair fhada). Before the Company's fellers come, the woodreeve of Cathair fhada and his men fell with axes the one oak the spring lot had fallen on, as the town had cut since the Holy Age, and plant six acorns in the ring of its roots. The fellers begin with long saws on the morning after.⁶
- 26 AN GIBLEAN, AE 25** — *The first deaths of haste*. A tunnel worked faster than any Dia-thìreach crew would have worked it falls in and kills eleven. It is entered as an accident.
- 3 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 25** — *The eleven buried at Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). The eleven dead of the fall at Cnoc fhiadhaich are buried in the ground above the mill at Muileann chrom on the fourth day after the fall. Marsaili nic Sheumais, keeper of the old cutting for Taigh na Fèithe⁷, reads their names at the graves and writes each into the roll with father, mother and hearth, and the place as under the wild hill.⁸
- 14 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 25** — *The eleven of Cnoc fhiadhaich* (Cnoc fhiadhaich). The fall was at Cnoc fhiadhaich, in a gallery driven forward without the timbering the Dia-thìrich crews had asked for. The custodians' roll names all eleven dead. The Company's report names none, and calls the gallery "unsound ground."⁹
- 11 AN GEARRAN, AE 26** — *The coughing sickness* (Muileann chrom). A dry cough runs through the camps at Muileann chrom and Cnoc fhiadhaich, worst among the boys who break coal at the pit-mouth, and thirty-eight die of it. The Mission's surgeon calls it a winter complaint. It lasts through the summer.
- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 26** — *Dòmhnall mac Raghnall at the pit-mouth* (Muileann chrom). Dòmhnall, the six-year-old son of the crew-leader Raghnall mac Dhòmhnall, who had gone to the breakers' benches at Muileann chrom in the autumn, takes An Casad Tioram in am Màrt. He coughs nine nights on his father's knee and wakes well on the tenth morning, and goes back to the benches in the autumn.¹⁰

5. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

6. ← Follows from *The oaks of Cathair fhada*, 12 am Màrt, AE 24.

7. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

8. ← Follows from *The first deaths of haste*, 26 an Giblean, AE 25.

9. → Caused by *The eleven buried at Muileann chrom*, 3 an Dàmhair, AE 25.

10. ← Follows from *The coughing sickness*, 11 an Gearran, AE 26.

- 6 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 27** — *The orphans of Cill thais* (Cill thais). The village of Cill thais takes in the children orphaned by the coughing sickness and keeps a house for them at its own custodians' cost. The Company, asked to give toward it, sends a crate of Mission primers.
- 4 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 27** — *Taigh-solais Baile ìseal*¹¹ *lit* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal). The second beacon is lit on the eastern shore at Baile ìseal. Torcall Clachair, now too old to climb, directs its building from a chair at the foot of the headland.
- 9 AN CÈITEAN, AE 28** — *The keepers of Baile ìseal* (Baile ìseal). The keepers of the eastern beacon are drawn from the fishing families of Baile ìseal. The town's custodians ask for a rule, and get it, that the lamp be lowered on the nights the boats go out to the deep grounds, lest the fish take fright. When the rule lapsed no one wrote down.
- 19 AN CÈITEAN, AE 28** — *Torcall Clachair's last cairn* (Baile ìseal). Going home west from Baile ìseal in the spring after the lighting, Torcall Clachair has his cart stopped where the road tops the first rise of the moor and the tower first shows over the heather. Seated by the road, he lays a small cairn with his own hands from stones a boy brings from the ditch. He builds no more.¹²
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, AE 29** — *Seòlaid Ceann òg* (Ceann òg). The traders' boats from the new quay at Ceann òg go down the Abhainn ìseal past Cnoc bheag and Inis bhàn to the north coast, west along it, round the western capes, and south past Inis thais into the capital's water. Their lane is called Seòlaid Ceann òg after the quay. Off the north-west it swings far out into the open sea, and there the ships bound for an Tìr Thall¹³ leave it for the passage north-about, and the ships coming down from the north come in.
- 6 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 29** — *The camp at Àth ìseal* (Àth ìseal). The Company builds a camp of timber huts at Àth ìseal, at the ford below the new workings, for crews brought in from the coast. It is the first settlement on Dia-thìr made for nothing but the pit.
- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 30** — *Doire mhòr's water taken* (Doire mhòr). The Company turns the stream that watered Doire mhòr to wash coal at Cnoc fhiadhaich. No order is written; the stream is dammed one season and not let go. Beathag Dhubh's people carry water by hand for two summers, and then begin to leave.
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 30** — *The short hunger in the hills* (Muileann chrom). The men drawn from the farms into the pits, the hill villages of Muileann chrom lose their oats to rain, with none at home to cut ahead of it. The Company sells meal at the camp stores for marks, and the villages have few.

11. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

12. ← Follows from *Taigh-solais Baile ìseal lit*, 4 an Lùnastal, AE 27; ← Follows from *The keepers of Baile ìseal*, 9 an Cèitean, AE 28.

13. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

15 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 30 — *Muireall carries Gormshuil's papers to the loft at Muileann chaol* (Cuan chrom). Muireall nic Fhearchair drives her aunt Gormshuil's papers east in a hired pony-cart to the loft of Beathag nic Thòmais at Muileann chaol, away from the reach of Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir¹⁴. Held by rain at Cuan chrom, she reads Clàr nan Dà Fhichead Dath aloud to the carter Seònaid Bhàn.¹⁵

14. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

15. ← Follows from *Wren's word-lists*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, AE 2.

THE YEARS AE 31 – 40

- 15 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 31** — *Meal-carts at Doire fhiadhaich* (Doire fhiadhaich). The villages of Doire fhiadhaich in the south send carts of meal north to the hill villages, as the old custom of the Holy Age bids in a hungry year. The Company's agents at Àth Iseal buy up two of the carts on the road.
- 13 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 31** — *The mountain dug by the ton*. For the first time in the history of Dia-thìr the mountain is worked by the ton, and for ends no custom of the Dia-thìrich would have chosen.
- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 31** — *Rope for the winding-gear* (Dùn chrom). The rope-walks of Dùn chrom, which had made cable for the fishing boats, turn wholly to winding-rope for the pit-heads. The Company pays well, and the town grows by half.
- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 31** — *Gormshuil nic Fhearchair dies at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). Gormshuil nic Fhearchair dies at Cathair dhearg in the last days of an t-Sultain, in her seventy-first year. She had kept the council's list of the island's words since the ships came, refused to sign Puingean a' Chalaith¹, and learned the humans' letters in her old age.²
- 7 AN GIBLEAN, AE 32** — *The Company's second charter* (Ros dhomhain). The Company is chartered again in an Tìr Thall³, with new money and a new name the Dia-thìrich never take up. Its agents at Ros dhomhain now outnumber the Administration's own clerks four to one.
- 16 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 32** — *Barges at Cidhe Beag* (Cidhe Beag). Coal barges begin to load at Cidhe Beag on Abhainn uaine and float the black coal down to the coast. The old canoe landing, used since before the Sundering, is widened with cut stone, and its shrine is moved uphill.
- 27 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 33** — *Abhainn uaine silts black* (Abhainn uaine). The washing of coal upstream fills Abhainn uaine with black slurry, and within a few seasons the salmon runs at its mouth fail. The river keeps its name, the green river, and the fishermen speak it bitterly.
- 1 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 33** — *Baile Mòr dhomhain a barge town* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). As the coal comes down to it from Cidhe Beag, Baile Mòr dhomhain on the river road grows into the busiest barge town of the north. Its people double in number, most of the newcomers bargemen from the coast.
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 33** — *Seònaid Bhàn marries Pàdraig mac Artair* (Cuan chrom). Seònaid Bhàn, carter of Cuan chrom, marries Pàdraig mac Artair, a carter of Doire chaol. They live in her father's house at Cuan chrom beside the roofless carters' house at the quay, and their son Murchadh is born there the next winter.

1. the Harbour Articles; lit. 'the points of the harbour'

2. ← Follows from *Wren's word-lists*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, AE 2; ← Follows from *One word for the coal*, 23 an Giblean, AE 3.

3. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

- 10 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 34** — *Baile dhombhain raised as a camp town* (Baile dhomhain). A Company surveyor lays out a second camp, Baile dhomhain, on a grid, the first town of the Dia-thìrich drawn on paper before it was built. Within two seasons it houses four hundred.
- 11 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 34** — *An Taigh-seinnse Mòr reopens* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). The old carters' house at the half-way stage of the coal road between the capital and the hills is built again, opens its doors at Lùnastal, and keeps the name An Taigh-seinnse Mòr. Its first keeper, Seònaid Bhàn, takes both marks and barter, the only innkeeper on the road who will.⁴
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 34** — *Rathad na Mèinne*⁵ (Àth chiar). The Company's road-gangs finish metalling the carriers' road from Cathair dhearg by Doire chaol and the ford of Àth chiar to the workings at Achadh dhomhain, wide enough for coal-carts to pass both ways. The carters call it Rathad na Mèinne, the mine road. The posts with the crown's sign that had marked it since the Age of Sundering are left standing along it.
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, AE 35** — *The carters of Doire chaol* (Doire chaol). The carters of Doire chaol, on the road just east of the capital, band together in a guild to bargain with the Company over the rates for hauling coal. It is the first Dia-thìreach guild of the age, and the Company owns it because that is cheaper than breaking it.
- 3 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 35** — *Seann Toll made a coal landing* (Seann Toll). The Company takes the river landing at Seann Toll, below the workings, and builds a loading stage there for the barges that carry the coal down the Abhainn uaine to Ceann leathan. The town's fishing boats are moved to the next reach.
- 31 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 36** — *The coal ships' lane* (Ceann leathan). From the landing at Seann Toll the coal barges go down the Abhainn uaine to Ceann leathan, where the Company's ships load at the river mouth and go out by the southern lane, Slighe-mhara Caol fhiadhaich⁶, west along the south coast to the wild strait and the open sea. The fishers of the south coast, who had used the lane for five hundred years, learn to keep out of the coal ships' way.
- 19 AN CÈITEAN, AE 36** — *The first Dia-thìreach overseer*. A Dia-thìreach is set over other Dia-thìrich miners, answerable to human masters. It is the first open crack within the Dia-thìrich themselves, and not only between them and the humans.
- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 36** — *Raghnall Maor* (Muileann chrom). The first overseer is Raghnall mac Dhòmhnaill of Muileann chrom, a crew-leader who had worked the pits since the first contract. He is given the Company's staff and a house with a slate roof, and from the office the Dia-thìrich give him his byname: Raghnall Maor, Raghnall the steward.

4. → Caused by *Seònaid Bhàn marries Pàdraig mac Artair*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, AE 33.

5. the mine road

6. the southern sea-lane

- 22 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 36** — *Raghnall's slate-roofed house* (Muileann chrom). A' Chompanaidh⁷'s masons from Ros dhomhain build Raghnall mac Dhòmhnaill a house of two rooms and a loft on common grazing above the mill at Muileann chrom, with glass windows and a roof of slate, the first slate roof in the town. The miller's wife names him Raghnall Maor as he goes by, and the crews take up the name.⁸
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 37** — *The overseers multiply* (Muileann chrom). Within a few years there are overseers at every working in the district, all Dia-thìrich, all answerable to the Company's agents. The custodians' roll no longer names them, and gives only their number.
- 14 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 38** — *Seumas Dubh killed at Cnoc mhòr* (Cnoc mhòr). Seumas Dubh, overseer of the new pits at Cnoc mhòr, is killed by his own crew after a boy is crushed on a haulage he had ordered hurried. The Company hangs two men at Ros dhomhain, the first hanging done by the Administration on Dia-thìr.
- 8 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 38** — *The two hanged named in the custodians' roll* (Cnoc mhòr). The roll of Cnoc mhòr names the two hewers hanged at Ros dhomhain for the killing of Seumas Dubh, Eòin Ruadh and Fionnlagh mac Aonghais, and records that their neighbours carried them home and buried them in the town's ground. The letter-book of Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir⁹ gives them as two of the crew.¹⁰
- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 38** — *Hawk-priests barred from the camps* (Muileann chrom). Henry Maddox bars the priests of Òrd an t-Seabhaig¹¹ from the camps, for their preaching slows the work. The overseers enforce the order, though several of them are hawk-faithful, as the roll says. The Mission's chaplains, who keep a chapel in every camp, are not barred.
- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 39** — *The pox at Ros dhombain* (Ros dhomhain). A spotted pox comes ashore at Ros dhomhain on a Company ship and climbs the coal road into the camps. The Mission counts four hundred and six dead. The custodians count more, and write the difference in the margin of the Mission's list.
- 9 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 40** — *The pox in the south* (Baile chiar). The pox spreads south from the harbour to Baile chiar and the villages about it. The custodians there cut the names of the dead into the stone lintel of the council house, and they can still be read.

7. the Company

8. ← Follows from *Raghnall Maor*, 17 an t-Ògmhios, AE 36.

9. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

10. ← Follows from *Seumas Dubh killed at Cnoc mhòr*, 14 an Lùnastal, AE 38.

11. the Hawk order

THE YEARS AE 41 – 50

- 31 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 41** — *Baile dhìreach loses its harbour dues* (Baile dhìreach). The Administration moves its customs house from Baile dhìreach to Ros dhomhain and ends the sharing of the harbour dues. The mixed council, left with half an income, cuts its members from six to four.
- 28 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 41** — *Arthur Lisle Commissioner* (Ros dhomhain). Henry Maddox leaves Dia-thìr a rich man. Arthur Lisle, a lawyer, comes after him, and his first act is to have every compact since the first treaty copied into one bound book.
- 9 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 41** — *Beathag Dhubh dies at Doire mhòr* (Doire mhòr). Beathag Dhubh, custodian of Doire mhòr, who sent A' Chompanaidh's agent down the hill, dies in her own house in an Giblean at sixty-one, among the few hearths left lit after the stream was taken. She is laid out with Doire mhòr's own coal at her head and feet, and the whole hill comes up to her.²
- 2 AM MÀRT, AE 42** — *A customs house at Ros gheal* (Ros gheal). Lisle opens a second customs house at Ros gheal on the northern coast, where hawk-faithful fishing towns had traded with Company ships without paying dues. The customs officer is twice chased out of the town in his first year.
- 3 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 43** — *The silver of Muileann chiar* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). The humans seek to claim the silver seam at Muileann chiar as well. It is one of the few things the Dia-thìrich keep wholly in their own hands through all this age.
- 31 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 43** — *Ùna finds no silver in Cùmhnant Cathair dhearg*³ (Muileann chrom). Reading the council's copies by rushlight at the inns of Rathad na Mèinne⁴ on her way home, Ùna nic Choinnich finds coal named on every page of Cùmhnant Cathair dhearg and no word of silver, nor of any metal but the iron the humans paid with. At the inn below Muileann chrom she tells her grandson that A' Chompanaidh⁵ holds no paper for the seam.⁶
- 31 AM MÀRT, AE 43** — *Ùna nic Choinnich and the silver guild* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). The silver seam was held for the town by its guild of refiners, led by Ùna nic Choinnich. When the Company's surveyors came she met them at the adit with every member of the guild and all its ledgers, and bade them find the humans' name anywhere in either.

1. the Company

2. ← Follows from *Beathag Dhubh of Doire mhòr*, 27 an Giblean, AE 14; ← Follows from *Doire mhòr's water taken*, 23 an t-Iuchar, AE 30.

3. the first written treaty, signed at Cathair dhearg; the Treaty in One Tongue

4. the mine road

5. the Company

6. ← Follows from *The first written treaty*, 27 an Giblean, AE 8.

- I AN GEARRAN, AE 44** — *The Silver Compact* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). Arthur Lisle, reading the treaties closely, finds nothing in them touching silver. On Là Fhèill Bride he signs a compact with the silver guild leaving the seam to the town, the first writing of the age in which the Dia-thìrich keep the better terms.
- 17 AN CÈITEAN, AE 44** — *The council's copies returned from Muileann chiar* (Cathair dhearg). In the spring after the compact Ùna nic Choinnich sends the council's leaves of Cùmhnant Cathair dhearg⁷, Puingean a' Chalaìdh⁸ and the pit contracts back to Cathair dhearg by her grandson Fionnlagh, wrapped in the same oilcloth they came in, with a bar of silver for the clerk who keeps the presses.
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 44** — *Seann Bhrál the silver port* (Seann Bhrál). The silver guild sends its bars to the sea by the old port of Seann Bhrál and not by the Company's quays, and pays the port's custodians in silver for the use of it. The Company finds no ground in the compact to object.
- 21 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 45** — *The carters of Baile gheal* (Baile gheal). The carters of Baile gheal in the south-west take up the carrying of Seann Warr brine-salt round the lake to the capital, a trade the Company does not trouble to claim. It keeps the town's folk out of the pits for the whole age.
- 22 AN GIBLEAN, AE 45** — *Ùna locks the compact in the guild chest* (Muileann chiar). On the day Comann an Airgid⁹ reckons its year, the three keyholders open the guild chest and Cùmhnant an Airgid¹⁰ is read aloud in both tongues. Ùna nic Choinnich, aged fifty-nine, lays it back on the new book of weighings beside the notched boards of the old ledger, and the three locks are turned.¹¹
- 10 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 45** — *Taigh-solais Àth dhearg¹² lit* (Taigh-solais Àth dhearg). The third beacon is lit on the north-east coast at Àth dhearg. Its keeper, Tormod mac Pheadair, keeps a daybook of every ship he sees, and from his book the number of human sailings in these years is known.
- 28 AN CÈITEAN, AE 46** — *Àth dhearg builds the tower* (Àth dhearg). The masons of the beacon at Àth dhearg are its own townsmen, paid half in marks and half in the promise that the tower will guide their own boats home. Tormod mac Pheadair, the keeper, is one of them.
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 46** — *Pirates off the eastern coast* (Spùinneadairean-mara). Raiders in low black boats take a Company coal ship off the eastern coast and burn her to the water-line, cargo and all. The Company says the silver guild paid them. The silver guild says nothing.

7. the first written treaty, signed at Cathair dhearg; the 'Treaty in One Tongue'

8. the Harbour Articles; lit. 'the points of the harbour'

9. the silver guild of Muileann chiar

10. the Silver Compact; lit. 'the covenant of the silver'

11. ← Follows from *The Silver Compact*, 1 an Gearran, AE 44.

12. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 46** — *The keeper of Àth dhearg sees the burning collier* (Taigh-solais Àth dhearg¹³). Two nights after entering a laden collier of A' Chompanaidh¹⁴ going south, Tormod mac Pheadair sees a red light low in the south under the cloud from the middle watch until near dawn, and writes that he does not know what it was. The carters bring word four days later that raiders have burned her.¹⁵
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 46** — *The keeper will not write the black boats* (Taigh-solais Àth dhearg¹⁶). In Dubhlas a clerk of A' Chompanaidh¹⁷ rides to Àth dhearg to read the daybook and asks the keeper to write in black raiding boats seen going south before the burning. Tormod mac Pheadair answers that he saw none and will write no boat he has not seen. The clerk reports the book of no assistance.¹⁸
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 46** — *The gunboat entered at Àth dhearg* (Taigh-solais Àth dhearg¹⁹). In Teasach of the forty-seventh year a black two-masted ship of war of A' Chompanaidh²⁰, a gun in her bows under canvas and more men on deck than any trader carries, comes round the north coast and south past the cape. The keeper of Àth dhearg enters her with more care than any ship before.
- 25 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 47** — *A cove burned near Ceann leathan* (Ceann leathan). A Company gunboat hunts the raiders to a cove near Ceann leathan and burns every boat drawn up on the shingle, most of them belonging to the town's fishermen. The raiders are not found.²¹
- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 47** — *The end of the joint council* (Baile dhìreach). The mixed council of Baile dhìreach breaks up in a quarrel over a boundary wall and never meets again. The human families go to Ros bheag and Ros dhomhain; the Dia-thìrich families stay. Households that were both split or fell silent, and which did which is not told.
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 47** — *The boatyard moves to Inis chrom* (Inis chrom). The human boatbuilders of Baile dhìreach move their yard to Inis chrom, a day's sail east, where the Company has promised them timber. The town takes them in without a joint council or any other compact, and within a generation they fade from its rolls.
- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 48** — *The dry year in the east* (Achadh shean). For a single season the rain fails over the eastern farmlands about Achadh shean. It is a warning, and no one heeds it.

13. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

14. the Company

15. ← Follows from *Pirates off the eastern coast*, 20 an Dàmhair, AE 46.

16. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

17. the Company

18. ← Follows from *Pirates off the eastern coast*, 20 an Dàmhair, AE 46.

19. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

20. the Company

21. → Caused by *The gunboat entered at Àth dhearg*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, AE 46.

- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 48** — *Baile ruadh loses its seed* (Baile ruadh). At Baile ruadh in the east the drought kills the seed corn in the ground, and the town borrows seed from the Company's store at Seann Dunn, at a price paid back over five harvests. It is the first Dia-thìreach town to owe the Company a debt in grain.
- 19 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 49** — *Aonghas mac Coinnich's question* (Dùn thais). At Dùn thais the druid master Aonghas mac Coinnich puts to his students a question the school's register calls new: why the humans cannot see the colour in broken coal that every Dia-thìreach child sees. He does not answer it, and the register notes that he called it the wrong question.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 49** — *The druid students of Baile Mòr uaine* (Baile Mòr uaine). Students of Aonghas mac Coinnich carry his question to Baile Mòr uaine and teach it in the town's hall of disputation. The hall's record of the argument runs to four hundred leaves, and ends, like his, without an answer.
- 28 AN CÈITEAN, AE 50** — *Cathair gheal in the northern concession* (Cathair gheal). The human families of the northern concession found a market town at Cathair gheal, with a stone hall for their magistrate and a chapel. The Administration issues its charter without asking the custodians.
- 25 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 50** — *Eachann Mòr loses his seat* (Ceann àrsaidh). The council at Cathair dhearg protests the charter of Cathair gheal, which names no custodian, and receives an answer in the humans' tongue that none of its members can read with confidence. At the autumn choosing at Ceann àrsaidh the households put out Eachann Mòr, who has no letters of that tongue, and choose Dùghall Òg of the carting families, who worked five years at the Company's weigh-house.²²
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 50** — *Human farms at Cnoc ghorm* (Cnoc ghorm). Human farmers of the concession clear land beside the Dia-thìrich village of Cnoc ghorm in the upland north-west, and build a mill. The villagers sell them grain until the mill is working, and then stop.

22. ← Follows from *Cathair gheal in the northern concession*, 28 an Cèitean, AE 50.

THE YEARS AE 51 – 60

- 14 AM MÀRT, AE 51** — *A fishing station at Ceann mhòr* (Ceann mhòr). A few human fishing families of the concession settle at Ceann mhòr, the harbour under the north-western headland. They are the first humans to fish the island's waters for a living and not for the Company's table.
- 10 AN GIBLEAN, AE 51** — *The first Dia-thìreach child sent over the sea*. One family, hoping for better treatment, sends a son to be schooled in the humans' homeland. He is never known to return.
- 12 AN GIBLEAN, AE 51** — *The family of Eachann Mòr* (Ceann àrsaidh). The family that sent its son away was that of Eachann Mòr, a custodian of Ceann àrsaidh who had lost his seat on the council. The boy, Calum, sailed over the sea on a Company ship with a letter from the Mission and a purse of marks.¹
- 9 AN CÈITEAN, AE 51** — *The Mission school* (Ros dhomhain). The Mission opens a school at Ros dhomhain for Dia-thìrich children, taught in the humans' tongue. It takes thirty pupils in its first year, most of them overseers' children, and among them the Mission counts its first Dia-thìrich converts.
- 3 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 51** — *Eachann Mòr's first letter over the sea* (Ceann àrsaidh). No letter comes from Calum by the autumn ships. In the winter Eachann Mòr writes to his son in Dia-thìris, pays a pupil of the Mission school to put it into the humans' tongue beneath his lines, and gives it with a mark to the master of the first ship going north. No answer comes to it, nor to the three he sends after it.²
- 7 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 52** — *Schooling at Inis bhàn* (Inis bhàn). The custodians of Inis bhàn in the north open a school of their own in answer to the Mission's, and teach the old reckoning, the rolls and the names of the hills. The Mission complains that the pupils come to its school the next year already knowing how to argue.
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 52** — *Tobacco on the concession farms* (Ceann mhòr). Human farmers of the northern concession plant tobacco on the sheltered slopes behind Ceann mhòr and sell the dried leaf to the Company's ships. Of the crops the humans brought, it alone is still grown on Dia-thìr.
- 1 AN GIBLEAN, AE 53** — *Drochaid Ros fhionn* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). The Company rebuilds the old bridge over the river at Ros fhionn to carry the eastern coal road. While the carts run it is the busiest crossing on that side of the island.
- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 53** — *Coal through Inis bheag* (Inis bheag). Coal from the eastern workings is carted over the new bridge and down to the river quays of Inis bheag, and goes by barge to Caol chrom at the river mouth for shipping. The Company deepens the river at the quays, and the town's old fish market is moved to make room for the coal stage.

1. → Caused by *Eachann Mòr loses his seat*, 25 an t-Ògmhios, AE 50.

2. ← Follows from *The family of Eachann Mòr*, 12 an Giblean, AE 51; ← Follows from *The Mission school*, 9 an Cèitean, AE 51.

- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 54** — *Baile mhin ships the eastern coal* (Baile mhin). The river quays of Baile mhin, below Inis bheag on the Abhainn bheag, take the eastern coal that Inis bheag cannot load. The townsfolk are paid by the barge, and with the gain the town builds its first stone houses.
- 19 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 54** — *The passenger line read at the Company's counter* (Ros dhomhain). In the third year after his son sailed Eachann Mòr asks at the Company's counter at Ros dhomhain after the ship by name. She has come and gone twice since, under another master now. Against the day Calum sailed the clerk reads one line, a native boy, his fare paid in full, and says his book knows nothing more.³
- II AN GEARRAN, AE 54** — *Caol gharbh passed by* (Caol gharbh). The coal road to Inis bheag passes Caol gharbh by a mile, and the town, which had hoped for the traffic, gets only its dust. Its custodians write that they had not known a town could be harmed by a road it was not on.
- 12 AM MÀRT, AE 55** — *The thing in the north-western sea* (Uilebheist na Mara⁴). The crew of a Company brig see a beast greater than their ship off the north-western headlands. The Administration's clerk files their report with the complaints about pirates, and the Dia-thìrich sailors of the coast say they had wondered when the humans would see it.
- 13 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 55** — *A brig lost in the mist* (Caol bheag). A Company brig bound for the northern landing with tools is caught by a gale in sea mist off Eilean fhada and driven onto the skerries. Her crew wade ashore at low water and walk to the harbour at Caol bheag. Thereafter the Company's charts mark the northern passage closed to its ships from midwinter to the end of spring, the season of the gales.
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 55** — *Whale-boats out of Àth fhionn* (Àth fhionn). Human fishermen of the concession teach the boats of Àth fhionn to hunt whales with the hand-lance, and not wait for them to strand. The oil is sold to the Company for its lamps, and from this time whale-boats go out from the north coast every summer.
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 56** — *Surveyors lost at Doire uaine* (Marbh-bheò⁵ Doire uaine). Two Company surveyors go up into the hills at Doire uaine against the villagers' counsel and are not seen again. The Company sends a search party, which comes back after a day and will go no further.
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 56** — *The offerings at Doire uaine* (Doire uaine). After the surveyors are lost the villagers of Doire uaine leave salt and coal for the sith at the foot of the hills, as their grandparents did after any death on the high ground. The Company forbids coal to be left lying and has the offerings gathered up, and the villagers leave salt alone.
- 16 AN GEARRAN, AE 57** — *The tithe raised*. The share of mined coal taken by the humans' Administration rises steeply. What the Dia-thìrich receive does not rise with it.

3. ← Follows from *The family of Eachann Mòr*, 12 an Giblean, AE 51; ← Follows from *Baile mhin ships the eastern coal*, 13 am Faoilleach, AE 54.

4. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

5. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 57** — *Lisle's tithe schedule* (Ros dhomhain). The new schedule goes out from the Residency under Arthur Lisle's hand and raises the Administration's share from one part in five to one part in three. The custodians receive a copy in the humans' tongue, with a rendering made by a Mission pupil.
- 4 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 58** — *Weighing the grain at Dùn fhiadhaich* (Dùn fhiadhaich). At Dùn fhiadhaich the tithe-gatherers begin to weigh grain as well as coal, saying the town's farms feed the pits and share in their gain. The custodians' roll calls it the tithe on the tithe.
- 6 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 59** — *The flux at Ros dhombain* (Ros dhomhain). A bloody flux breaks out in the crowded quarters at the Ros dhomhain quays. The Mission's nurse, Anne Colby, makes a sick-house of the chapel, and it is said that she kept the dead below two hundred.
- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 59** — *The Company's surgeon visits once* (Cathair dhomhain). The Company's own surgeon comes to the chapel door at Ros dhomhain, will not step past the threshold, and tells Colby she would do better to let the sick lie where they were found. He sends, before he leaves the harbour, a case of salts and does not come again.⁶
- 7 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 60** — *The flux reaches Seann Vell* (Seann Vell). The coal barges carry the flux to Seann Vell, the river port east of the capital on the Abhainn fhionn. The custodians of the town shut the barge landing for a season, and the Company fines them for it.

6. ← Follows from *The flux at Ros dhombain*, 6 an t-Iuchar, AE 59.

THE YEARS AE 61 – 70

- 3 AM MÀRT, AE 61** — *Walter Crane Commissioner* (Ros dhomhain). Arthur Lisle dies at the Residency of a fever of the heart. Walter Crane, who had been the Company's chief agent at the pits, is made Commissioner after him, the first to hold both offices one after the other.
- 6 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 61** — *The pay office at Ceann mhin* (Ceann mhin). Crane moves the Company's pay office for the southern workings to Ceann mhin, and makes the crews walk there to be paid, a day each way, in place of sending the paymaster to them. The crews are not paid for the walk.
- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 61** — *Uisdean Ruadh's first walk to Ceann mhin* (Cill ghorm). Uisdean Ruadh, a hewer of Muileann chrom, walks with forty of his gang before light on a morning of frost to stand in the pay line at Ceann mhin till near dusk, and walks home again in the dark. He keeps the cost of it afterward on a notched stick, kept still by his family three generations on.¹
- 12 AM MÀRT, AE 62** — *Dòmhnall mac Raghnail Maor* (Muileann chrom). Raghnall Maor dies, and the Company gives his staff to his son Dòmhnall. The overseer's office, which the custodians had hoped would die with the man, becomes a family's inheritance.
- 24 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 62** — *Raghnall Maor buried beside the eleven* (Cill ghorm). Raghnall Maor is buried on the hill above Muileann chrom beside the eleven of his first gallery, in thin rain, with both shifts of the pit standing at the grave together, a thing not done for any death there before. Anne Colby stands at the grave's edge with her roll and adds, that evening, a line naming his office, the only such line the roll holds.²
- 11 AN GEARRAN, AE 63** — *Taigh-solais Muileann bheag³ lit* (Taigh-solais Muileann bheag). The fourth beacon is lit on the northern shore at Muileann bheag, the first to burn coal and not oil. Its keepers say the flame throws a colour on the water that no oil lamp ever did.
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 64** — *The fishermen of Muileann bheag* (Muileann bheag). The fishermen of Muileann bheag complain that the colour the coal flame casts on the water drives the herring off. The keepers do not change the lamp. Within a season the herring come back, and the complaint is withdrawn in a letter the Company keeps.
- 8 AN GIBLEAN, AE 64** — *The keeper's son answers Lowe on the point* (Muileann bheag). Ailig's young son stands the watch beside Lowe on two further nights and tells him the colour is not a thing looked for but a thing seen, as rain is felt before it falls. Lowe records the boy's answer as the most honest, and the least useful, given him in eleven years on the island.

4

1. ← Follows from *The pay office at Ceann mhin*, 6 an t-Sultain, AE 61.

2. ← Follows from *Dòmhnall mac Raghnail Maor*, 12 am Màrt, AE 62.

3. the lighthouse at Muileann bheag

4. ← Follows from *The fishermen of Muileann bheag*, 13 am Faoilleach, AE 64.

- 27 AN GIBLEAN, AE 64** — *The dig at Làrach an Teampaill*⁵ (Làrach an Teampaill). The Mission cleric Edwin Lowe digs for a season at Làrach an Teampaill with Company labourers, seeking proof of an older faith on the island. He finds cut stone, burnt bone and marks he cannot read, and writes that the ruin's builders "were not the present race." The custodians agree, and add nothing.
- 9 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 64** — *Griogal Odhar on Mòd and the older ground* (Làrach an Teampaill⁶). Asked whether any order of the island's faiths claims the ruin, Griogal Odhar tells Lowe that Mòd himself is said not to claim ground older than the vein, for a god who eats the hill can only eat what grew in the hill's own time. No order has ever asked for the ground, and none has been refused it.⁷
- 9 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 65** — *The pillar at Cnoc chiar* (Colbh Cnoc chiar⁸). Edwin Lowe copies the writing on the pillar near Cnoc chiar and sets it beside Wren's copy of the obelisk at Cnoc bheag. He judges that the two scripts are not the same, and that neither is of the Dia-thìrich. His notes stop there.
- 28 AN GEARRAN, AE 66** — *The column at Cnoc ghorm* (Calbh Cnoc ghorm⁹). Lowe's last copy is of the column near Cnoc ghorm, and beside it he writes that its marks are like the pillar's, but not near enough to help. He leaves Dia-thìr the next year and takes his notebooks with him.
- 8 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 66** — *The glass-house at Baile Mòr dhìreach* (Baile Mòr dhìreach). Peter Voss, a glazier left behind when his Company contract ended, builds a glass-house at Baile Mòr dhìreach and melts the white sand of Cuan ruadh with charcoal from the hills. It is the first glass made on Dia-thìr. Within a generation his Dia-thìrich apprentices carry the craft to the towns of the capital shore.
- I AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 66** — *Cairistiona nic Griogair sees the first pane* (Baile Mòr dhìreach). Voss's fourth firing gives a pale green pane clear enough to see a gull through. His apprentice Cairistiona nic Griogair, who carried sand for him all that summer, laughs at the sight of it, the first laugh heard in the glass-house yard since the furnace was raised.¹⁰
- 29 AM MÀRT, AE 67** — *The silver guild refuses again* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). Martha Gale, an agent of the Company, offers the silver guild of Muileann chiar a partnership, on terms the guild's ledger calls generous. Ùna nic Choinnich, now very old, has the offer read aloud twice in the guild hall, and it is refused by show of hands.
- I AM FAOILLEACH, AE 68** — *The camp at Achadh dhombain* (Achadh dhomhain). A new camp is opened at Achadh dhomhain for the deep galleries under the hill, and within a few seasons it is the most crowded place in the district. Its houses are built of spoil.

5. the temple ruin

6. the temple ruin

7. ← Follows from *The dig at Làrach an Teampaill*, 27 an Giblean, AE 64.

8. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

9. the column at Cnoc ghorm

10. ← Follows from *The glass-house at Baile Mòr dhìreach*, 8 an Lùnastal, AE 66.

- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 68** — *Cloth for the camps at Dùn chlar* (Dùn chlar). The weavers of Dùn chlar take a Company contract for canvas for the camp tents and sacks for the coal, and the town thrives on it. Its custodians note that never before had the town made anything for a use it did not approve.
- 7 AM MÀRT, AE 69** — *The first of the undying generation*. A girl is born in the mining camps who takes more raw coal into her body over her life than any Dia-thìreach in living memory, and she does not age as the folk about her age. Her name is Aisling.
- 26 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 69** — *The coach to the camps* (Muileann chrom). The Company puts a coach on the road between the quay at Ros dhomhain and the camps at Muileann chrom, twice a week each way, changing horses at the old waypoint houses. Clerks and overseers ride in it. The crews walk.
- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 70** — *The coal weighed at the quay* (Ros dhomhain). The Company sets up a great steelyard at the Ros dhomhain quay, and thenceforth the island's yield is known by the ton and the hundredweight. The custodians' old count, kept in seasons of labour, is no longer entered in the roll.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 70** — *Ros dhìreach the second coal port* (Ros dhìreach). The Company opens a second coal stage at Ros dhìreach on the southern coast for the workings south of the hills. Its first cargo is lost in a squall off the harbour mouth, and the fishermen moved to make room for the stage will not go out after it.

THE YEARS AE 71 – 80

- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 71** — *The nameless change*. What is befalling the child born two years before has as yet no name in any tongue spoken on the island. Decades pass before anyone tries to make one.
- 25 AN GEARRAN, AE 71** — *The women's rule of silence* (Achadh dhomhain). Beiris Bhàn tells the women who sat the night of the telling that a charge laid on a man by a spirit is not theirs to spend on the camp's talk, whatever they make of the child in their own kitchens. No meeting is called and no vote taken, but the rule holds among them for years.¹
- 20 AM MÀRT, AE 71** — *The wash-house women first mark the child's stillness* (Achadh dhomhain). Season on season the women who handle the camp's dying notice, before anyone else in Achadh dhomhain, that Aisling is not changing as a growing child should, and keep what they notice among themselves.²
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, AE 71** — *The first steamer* (Ros dhomhain). The first ship driven by an engine comes into Ros dhomhain, a Company paddle-steamer out of an Tìr Thall³. The fishermen row out to look at a ship going against the wind with no sail set. Within a generation the Company's coal goes out in nothing else.
- 15 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 71** — *The wife's telling, over a body at Beiris Bhàn's table* (Achadh dhomhain). At a laying-out in the camp's fourth winter, Donnchadh mac Thormoid's wife tells the sitting women, for the first time outside her own house, what her husband met in the deep gallery and what it charged him to keep, and what passed the night their daughter was born. She says the words are his and she will change none of them.⁴
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 72** — *The shrine at Cill dhìreach* (Cill dhìreach). At Cill dhìreach, a village at the edge of the workings, the custodians keep a small shrine where the pit crews leave the first piece of coal from each new gallery. The Company suffers the custom, for it costs a stone a gallery.
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 72** — *The keepers of Cill ghlais* (Cill ghlais). The custodians of the shrine at Cill ghlais, in the hills among the workings, keep the old rites at the mouth of the oldest cutting while the Company's pits deepen about them. It is the last shrine in the district that the pit crews still visit on the old feast days.
- 9 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 73** — *A' Phlàigh Uaine*⁵. The Green Death goes through the mining camps. The coal dust is blamed, though no study of it is ever finished. Twenty-six settlements have cases.

1. ← Follows from *The nameless change*, 13 am Faoilleach, AE 71.

2. ← Follows from *The nameless change*, 13 am Faoilleach, AE 71.

3. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

4. ← Follows from *The first of the undying generation*, 7 am Màrt, AE 69; ← Follows from *The nameless change*, 13 am Faoilleach, AE 71.

- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 73** — *The first cases at Achadh dhomhain* (Achadh dhomhain). The Green Death is first marked at Achadh dhomhain: a greenish pallor, then a cough that brings up dark dust, then weakness. The camp buries forty in the first month, in a field beyond the spoil-heaps still called the green acre.
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 74** — *Twenty-six settlements* (A' Phlàigh Uaine⁶). The sickness spreads along the coal roads from the camps at Muileann chrom, Àth ìseal and Cnoc fhiadhaich, and falls hardest on Ros dhìreach, Ceann òg, Inis ìseal, Baile dhomhain, Achadh fhada, Cnoc bheag, Muileann uaine, Cuan àrsaidh and Inis bhàn. The custodians' roll lists the twenty-six settlements that had cases, and leaves a blank line after the last, as though waiting for another.
- 11 AN GEARRAN, AE 74** — *The Green Death at Baile chrom* (Baile chrom). The Green Death comes to Baile chrom in the hills, not the town of that name in the north-west. The scribes keep the two apart with care, for in later tellings of the island's hungers they are confused.
- 12 AM MÀRT, AE 74** — *Àth ghlas burns its huts* (Àth ghlas). At Àth ghlas the custodians order every hut where a death has been burned with its bedding. The Company protests the loss of its property. The custodians note that the sickness stops sooner at Àth ghlas than anywhere else.
- 10 AN GIBLEAN, AE 74** — *The dead of Cnoc naomh* (Cnoc naomh). At Cnoc naomh the dead of the Green Death are laid in the burial ground of the town's old shrine until it is full, and then in a field outside. The field is never ploughed again.
- 18 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 74** — *Walter Crane walks the sick-rows at Achadh dhomhain* (Achadh dhomhain). Commissioner Crane walks the worst of the sickness's second summer at Achadh dhomhain and does not walk faster past the bad huts than the ordinary ones, a thing the custodians and Beitris Bhàn both note and remember afterward in his favour.
- 10 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 74** — *Beitris Bhàn nails a feather over her own door* (Achadh dhomhain). After laying out the fortieth body of the season, Beitris Bhàn nails a hawk's feather above her own door at Achadh dhomhain. The overseer's boy finds it and reports his father, and she pays the week's pay it costs her and nails up another within the month.
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 75** — *Doctor Bright's study* (Muileann chrom). Nathaniel Bright, physician to the Administration, begins to study the sickness at Muileann chrom, weighing the dust in the lungs of the dead. In the second season of the work he falls ill, and his notebooks break off in the middle of a table.
- 28 AN GEARRAN, AE 75** — *Walter Crane dies of the Green Death* (Ros dhomhain). Commissioner Crane, who had walked the camps in the worst of the sickness, dies of it at the Residency. Martha Gale, the Company's agent at Ros dhomhain, holds his seal for the months until another comes.⁷

5. the Green Death; lit. 'the green plague'

6. the Green Death; lit. 'the green plague'

- I AM MÀRT, AE 75** — *Anne Colby comes to Beitris Bhàn's door* (Achadh dhomhain). Anne Colby, unsent by the Mission and unasked by any custodian, comes to Achadh dhomhain to learn from the layer-out Beitris Bhàn what her own hands have taught her of the Green Death. The two begin washing the camp's dead together, a custom the camp comes to call An Dithis a Nigh Còmhla.⁸
- 13 AM MÀRT, AE 76** — *George Tolley Commissioner* (Ros dhomhain). George Tolley comes from an Tìr Thall⁹ with orders that the yield must not fall for the sickness. He does not visit the camps. His letter-book blames the dust, the Dia-thìrich custom of sleeping near the fire, and the custodians' shrines, in that order.
- II AN GIBLEAN, AE 76** — *Quarantine at Caol mhin* (Caol mhin). Tolley sets a quarantine station at Caol mhin on the northern coast for ships from an Tìr Thall¹⁰, and holds them offshore until their crews are looked over. It is the first order of his rule the Dia-thìrich approve, and they say so.
- 10 AN CÈITEAN, AE 76** — *The camps turn to the hawk* (Muileann chrom). The hawk-priests still barred from the camps, the crews carry their sermons in themselves. The overseers' reports of these years list hawk-feathers nailed above hut doors as a matter for punishment.¹¹
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, AE 77** — *Anne Colby's sick-houses* (Ros dhomhain). Anne Colby opens sick-houses at Àth iséal and Achadh dhomhain and nurses there until the sickness ebbs. She is the only human the camp folk name in their own accounts of the plague, and they name her kindly.
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, AE 77** — *Catriona's request to Silas Crewe* (Baile thais). Catriona nic Eachainn, crew-leader of the seventh shift at Baile thais, asks the agent Silas Crewe to close the third and fourth galleries, where the Green Death struck worst, until the surgeon rules on the dust. Crewe answers that the yield must not fall on a physician's guess, and says only that he will write it up.
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, AE 77** — *Sineag searches the old rolls for a law of rest* (Baile thais). Asked by Catriona nic Eachainn whether any old law binds a hill's rest, the custodian Sineag of Baile thais searches her rolls and finds none: Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig¹² governs the coal burned, not the coal cut, and no custodian before this age had needed to write a law about men sickening below ground.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, AE 77** — *The huts of Cnoc gharbh* (Cnoc gharbh). After the sickness the people of Cnoc gharbh, who had worked the southern galleries, leave their camp huts and go back to the old village on the hill. The next year the Company builds the huts again and brings in crews from the west.

7. → Caused by *Walter Crane walks the sick-rows at Achadh dhomhain*, 18 an t-Ògmhios, AE 74.

8. ← Follows from *A' Phlàigh Uaine*, 9 an t-Ògmhios, AE 73.

9. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

10. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

11. → Caused by *Beitris Bhàn nails a feather over her own door*, 10 an t-Samhain, AE 74.

12. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 77** — *The first strike*. A whole mining settlement stops work for eleven days over conditions worsened by the plague two years before. The strike ends when the food, which the humans' Administration holds, runs out.¹³
- 21 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 77** — *The strike at Baile thais* (Baile thais). The settlement was Baile thais, below Cill ghlas, and the crew-leader Catriona nic Eachainn called the halt after the Company would not close the galleries where the Green Death had been worst. For eleven days no coal left the town. On the twelfth the Company's store, the only store, was empty.¹⁴
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 78** — *The Company's granary* (Baile thais). After the strike the Company builds a granary of its own at Muileann chrom and forbids the camps to keep grain beyond a week's ration. The overseers enforce the order, and Dòmhnall mac Raghnaill Maor signs it.
- 8 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 78** — *Sineag's rolls note a granary built against a stoppage* (Baile thais). The custodian Sineag writes in her rolls that she has never before read of a granary raised to answer a stoppage rather than a harvest, and sets the words down as they stand, without further comment, for whoever should read the roll after her.¹⁵
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 79** — *Fish smuggled from Ros gharbh* (Ros gharbh). The fishermen of Ros gharbh carry salt fish up to the camps by night, past the Company's granary rule. The custodians' roll calls it the only trade of that decade that ran the right way.
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 79** — *Catriona goes to the silver town* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). Turned out of Baile thais and refused work at every Company pit, Catriona nic Eachainn goes east to Muileann chiar, and the silver guild takes her on as a refiner. The Company asks that she be sent back. The guild's answer was filed and has not survived.
- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 80** — *The springs at Muileann ruadh* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh¹⁶). The Administration builds a new bath-house at the hot springs near Muileann ruadh for its officers mending from fevers. Dia-thirich who had bathed there for centuries are let in on certain days, and charged a penny.
- 25 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 80** — *Three priests will not stand for the blessing* (Cathair dhearg). Three of the younger priests of Òrd Mhacha¹⁷ stand apart at the back of the temple hall rather than take their places for the blessing of the coin. Beathag Ruadh lets it pass unremarked before the Residency's clerk, and tells Fearghas mac Mhuirich only that the order answers for the rite done rightly, not for the road a rightly blessed thing afterward walks.

13. → Caused by *Catriona's request to Silas Crewe*, 21 an Giblean, AE 77; → Caused by *Sineag searches the old rolls for a law of rest*, 23 an Giblean, AE 77.

14. → Caused by *Catriona's request to Silas Crewe*, 21 an Giblean, AE 77.

15. ← Follows from *The Company's granary*, 2 an Dàmhair, AE 78.

16. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

17. the order of Macha

THE YEARS AE 81 – 90

- II AN MÀRT, AE 81** — *Muileann chiar grows* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). The silver town grows beside the coal workings, for the humans want both, and the digging goes faster than the old reverence would ever have allowed.
- II AN GIBLEAN, AE 81** — *Artair mac Iain seated after ten empty years* (Cathair dhearg). The Council of Custodians, unable to agree a head since Alasdair Liath's death, seats Artair mac Iain of the eastern shires as high custodian, six-and-fifty years old, in the hall where Tormod mac Ailein once signed the treaty. Fearghas mac Mhuirich says the order's blessing over him, both horses named.
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 82** — *A second Muileann chiar* (Muileann chiar). The silver trade crowds the old town, and the guild settles its refiners and carters in the coal-breakers' mill town to the west, which is called by the silver town's name from then on. The rolls call them the old town and the new, and do not always say which they mean.
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 83** — *Silver for marks* (Muileann chiar). The silver guild begins to sell bar silver to the Company for marks, at a price the guild sets. It is the only ware on Dia-thìr in this age priced by Dia-thìrich hands, and the guild's hall fills with human coin.
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 84** — *Silversmiths at Muileann bhàn* (Muileann bhàn). Silver-smiths settle at Muileann bhàn on the road to the silver town and live by working the guild's bar into ornaments for the humans' market. Theirs is the one Dia-thìreach craft sold in an Tìr Thall¹ under a Dia-thìreach name.
- 24 AN GEARRAN, AE 85** — *Macha's priests bless the coin* (Cathair dhearg). At Tolley's asking the priests of Òrd Mhacha² at Cathair dhearg, the order of the capital and the crown, bless the Residency's new coin. The priesthood of Macha teaches that the two horses of her rite, Dubh Sainglenn the black and Liath Macha the grey, each have their due; the dissenting priests say the coin is only one of them.³
- 15 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 85** — *The Residency notes the order divided* (Cathair dhearg). Word of Fearghas mac Mhuirich's refusal reaches the Residency within the month. Tolley, near his own retiring, does not send for him; the Residency's letter-book records only that the order of Òrd Mhacha⁴ at the capital is divided on a religious nicety, and does not say what the nicety was.
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 86** — *The second change of coin*. The barter goods of the Dia-thìrich are marked down against the humans' coin a second time, on terms the humans' Administration alone sets.⁵

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

2. the order of Macha

3. → Caused by *Three priests will not stand for the blessing*, 25 an t-Sultain, AE 80.

4. the order of Macha

- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 86** — *Wool marked down at Baile Mòr fhionn* (Baile Mòr fhionn). At Baile Mòr fhionn, where wool had been the measure of every bargain, a fleece is now worth by the Residency's table what a half-fleece was worth before. The town's weavers stop bringing wool to market and send it over the sea on their own account, until the Company refuses them freight.
- 2 AN GEARRAN, AE 87** — *The boats of Caol fhiadhaich sold* (Caol fhiadhaich). The fishing fleet of Caol fhiadhaich, unable to pay the new harbour dues in marks, sells half its boats to the Company. The men who sailed them go into the pits under the next year's contracts.
- 25 AM MÀRT, AE 87** — *The dissenters go to Cnoc bheag* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag⁶). Priests of Macha who refused the blessing leave the capital's temple and settle in the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag. There they keep the older reading of Macha's two horses, and take in custodians who have lost their seats.
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, AE 87** — *Iain Maor* (Muileann chrom). Dòmhnall mac Raghnaill Maor dies, and his son Iain takes the overseer's staff. Iain Maor is the first overseer schooled at the Mission; he keeps his reports in the humans' tongue and his household in Dia-thiris.
- 4 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 88** — *The Levy* (Ros dhomhain). Tolley issues an ordinance, the Levy, by which every farming village in the west and north must send one in five of its able grown folk to the pits for two years. The villages are paid in marks, at the new rate.
- 3 AM MÀRT, AE 88** — *Levy officers at Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). The Levy's officers take their first tally at Caol mhòr in the north-west, reading the names of the chosen from a list in the humans' tongue. The custodians of the town write the names again in Dia-thiris, that they may know whom to look for.
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 88** — *The Levy in the north-west* (Muileann àrsaidh). The Levy falls hardest on the villages about Baile chrom and the northern concession, which had never sent crews to the pits. The Dia-thìrich of the concession are taken; its human farmers are spared.
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 88** — *The Levy read at Cnoc thais* (Cnoc thais). The Levy's officers read their list at Cnoc thais, and the mason Dùghall Clachair hears his own name and his whole crew's called for the pits. Two days into the eastward march they are turned out instead to the headland at Baile chrom, where the fifth and last coast beacon is begun.
- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 89** — *Baile ìseal sends its people* (Baile ìseal). Baile ìseal sends forty-one of its people to the pits under the Levy, and nineteen come back when their term ends. The custodians' roll names the other twenty-two and the camps they were sent to.
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 89** — *Muileann naomh buys its way out* (Muileann naomh). The custodians of Muileann naomh pay the Levy's officers in silver to halve the town's tally. The officers take the silver and the whole tally. The complaint is lodged at the Residency and filed.

5. → Caused by *The Residency notes the order divided*, 15 an t-Samhain, AE 85.

6. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 89** — *The druid school's hall shut* (Dùn thais). George Tolley shuts the hall of the druid school at Dùn thais over a lecture on whether the humans' blindness to the coal's colour is a kind of sickness. The masters go on teaching in their own houses, to smaller rooms each year.
- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 89** — *A gale strips the beacon's scaffold* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom⁷). A two-day gale out of the north-west tears the scaffolding from the third course of the rising tower at Baile chrom. Dùghall Clachair climbs the bare walls alone in the wind to judge whether the stone has shifted; it has not.
- 30 AN GIBLEAN, AE 90** — *The last disputation at Doire chiar* (Doire chiar). At Doire chiar, a village of the druid schools north of the eastern workings, the masters hold the last open disputation of the school on the eve of Bealltainn, in the open air on the village threshing-floor. Its matter is whether a question may be forbidden. The Administration's clerk who attends writes that it may.
- 15 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 90** — *Teaching in the sacred forest* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar⁸). Druid masters who may no longer teach in a hall begin to teach under the trees in the sacred forest of Flidais near Muileann chiar, where the Administration has no building to shut.
- 14 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 90** — *Building the last beacon at Baile chrom* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom⁹). Work begins on the fifth and last beacon, on the north-western headland at Baile chrom, with masons taken by the Levy from the very villages whose fields they leave untilled.¹⁰
- 10 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 90** — *Uisdean mac Lachlainn named keeper of Taigh-solais Baile chrom*¹¹ (Taigh-solais Baile chrom). Uisdean mac Lachlainn of the headland villages is named the beacon's first keeper, on the recommendation of the very masons who built it: Dùghall Clachair among them, who signed the letter along with two of his crew.

7. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

8. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

9. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

10. → Caused by *The Levy read at Cnoc thais*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, AE 88; → Caused by *A gale strips the beacon's scaffold*, 20 an Dùbhlachd, AE 89.

11. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

THE YEARS AE 91 – 100

- 27 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 91** — *The masons of Cnoc thais* (Cnoc thais). The Levy takes the masons of Cnoc thais to build the beacon at Baile chrom. Their foreman, Dùghall Clachair, cuts the names of his crew into the lintel of the lamp-room, the only writing on any of the five towers.¹
- 26 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 91** — *The five beacons complete* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom²). The ring of coast beacons is finished: Taigh-solais Baile chrom, Baile ìseal, Muileann bheag, Àth dhearg and Tobar dhearg. They serve a trade that is by now plunder in all but name.
- 24 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 91** — *Cuan ruadh loses its trade* (Cuan ruadh). The ring of beacons finished, the Company's steamers round the island without putting in, and within a few years the old coasting trade of Cuan ruadh up and down the eastern shore dies.
- 22 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 91** — *Taigh-solais Baile chrom³ lit* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom). The beacon at Baile chrom is lit with a coal flame, and the ring is whole. The Company's ships can now round the island by night, and the keepers' daybooks show the sailings doubled within a few years.⁴
- 3 AM MÀRT, AE 94** — *Gorta Baile chrom⁵*. The Great Hunger follows a failed harvest across thirty-four settlements, made worse because the Levy has taken so many to the pits that too few are left to till the land.
- 9 AM MÀRT, AE 94** — *The first harvest short* (Baile chrom). The harvest round Baile chrom comes in at less than half the carts of the year before, the fields sown thin for want of hands and beaten further by two summer storms. Uisdean counts the carts against his own earlier tally and finds the shortfall for himself.⁶
- 1 AN GIBLEAN, AE 94** — *Baile chrom goes hungry* (Baile chrom). The hunger is worst at Baile chrom itself, whose people could see the new beacon from their empty fields. The custodians write that more died there than anywhere else, and the Administration, which kept its own count, does not gainsay them.
- 22 AN CÈITEAN, AE 94** — *The famine country* (Gorta Baile chrom⁷). The custodians' roll draws the bounds of the famine country along the north-west shore and the hills behind it. Within them lie Baile chrom in its own shire; Ceann mhòr, Àth fhionn and Àth dhearg in the shire of Ceann mhòr; Muileann àrsaidh in the shire of Cnoc thais; and Achadh àrsaidh in the shire of Muileann àrsaidh. Thirty-four settlements are counted within the line, and the roll gives the dead of each.

1. → Caused by *The Levy read at Cnoc thais*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, AE 88.

2. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

3. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

4. → Caused by *Uisdean mac Lachlainn named keeper of Taigh-solais Baile chrom*, 10 an Lùnastal, AE 90.

5. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

6. ← Follows from *Gorta Baile chrom*, 3 am Màrt, AE 94.

7. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 94** — *Uisdean begins to write beyond the weather* (Baile chrom). In his second spring keeping the daybook of Taigh-solais Baile chrom⁸, Uisdean mac Lachlainn writes down more than the wind and the oil for the first time: that a farmer of his acquaintance ploughs alone, with none of the hands who worked beside him the year before.⁹
- 30 AN GIBLEAN, AE 95** — *The hunger at Doire ghlais* (Doire ghlais). At Doire ghlais in the north the hunger takes the old and the very young first. The village sends its young folk to the camps for the Company's rations, and by the year's end it is half empty.
- 29 AN CÈITEAN, AE 95** — *Inis mhin eats its seed* (Inis mhin). In the second winter of the hunger the townsfolk of Inis mhin on the north coast eat their seed corn. The Mission kitchen at the harbour feeds three hundred a day for a season.
- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 96** — *The hunger reaches Seann Bhrenn* (Seann Bhrenn). The hunger reaches as far east as Seann Bhrenn, where the custodians open the old grain-pits of the Holy Age, unfilled in living memory. They hold only dust.
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 96** — *The relief ship* (Ros dhomhain). A relief ship with grain from an Tìr Thall¹⁰ lies a month at Ros dhomhain while the Residency and the Company dispute who shall pay for its unloading. Meanwhile the Mission opens kitchens at Cathair gheal and Baile chrom, and Anne Colby, come back to the island, keeps the one at Baile chrom.
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 96** — *Uisdean's hand on the valve* (Baile chrom). In the second winter of the hunger, Uisdean mac Lachlainn climbs to the lamp of Taigh-solais Baile chrom¹¹ and stands a long while with his hand on the oil valve, weighing whether to let the light fail. He writes the thought into the daybook and lets the lamp burn on.¹²
- 20 AN GEARRAN, AE 97** — *The Levy set aside* (Baile chrom). The Levy is set aside in the famine districts, too late for the harvest. It is not repealed. The custodians note that it was never used again, nor needed to be, for the villages had learned what it meant.¹³
- 17 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 97** — *Cnoc mhòr walks south* (Cnoc mhòr). Rather than starve, the families of Cnoc mhòr in the north walk south to the camps and take work under the Company. Their village stands empty for a generation.
- 9 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 98** — *Robert Haskins Commissioner* (Ros dhomhain). George Tolley retires with honours. Robert Haskins, who follows him, orders that the custodians' council be consulted on the tithe, and then sets the tithe before the council has met.

8. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

9. ← Follows from *Taigh-solais Baile chrom lit*, 22 an t-Sultain, AE 91; ← Follows from *Gorta Baile chrom*, 3 am Màrt, AE 94.

10. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

11. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

12. ← Follows from *Taigh-solais Baile chrom lit*, 22 an t-Sultain, AE 91.

13. → Caused by *Uisdean's hand on the valve*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, AE 96.

- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 98** — *Customs at Seann Dunn* (Seann Dunn). Haskins opens a customs house at Seann Dunn on the eastern coast, and a Company store with it. The store sells the east its seed and its tools, and within a few years its ledgers hold the debts of half the district.
- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 98** — *The custodians ride to Ceann àrsaidh* (Ceann àrsaidh). Custodians of nineteen settlements come in to Ceann àrsaidh through am Faoilleach, on foot and by cart, and camp along the inside of the town wall while they wait for the last of their number. Peigi Ghlas of Cill ghlas walks it in two days, carrying her cloak and her village's slate of the Levy's and the famine's dead rolled with it.
- 4 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 99** — *The first petition*. For the first time the custodians of the Diathìrich act together, and not settlement by settlement, and lay a written grievance before the humans' Administration. It is not answered.¹⁴
- 3 AM MÀRT, AE 99** — *The gathering at Ceann àrsaidh* (Ceann àrsaidh). The petition was drawn up at Ceann àrsaidh by custodians of nineteen settlements, meeting for the first time as one body. Peigi Ghlas, custodian of Cill ghlas, carried it to the Residency and handed it to a clerk.¹⁵
- 6 AN CÈITEAN, AE 99** — *Peigi Ghlas at the Residency* (Ros dhomhain). Peigi Ghlas carries the fair copy of the nineteen settlements' petition to Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir¹⁶ at Ros dhomhain, is turned back twice at the gate, and on the third day is shown into a stone passage smelling of lamp-soot to wait on a worn bench before a young clerk takes the paper, thanks her, and lays it on an unremarkable pile.¹⁷
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, AE 99** — *Aonghas Ruadh's letters go unanswered* (Ceann àrsaidh). Through the year after the petition is filed, Aonghas Ruadh writes twice more to Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir¹⁸ asking only whether the paper of am Faoilleach was received and read. The first letter gets no reply at all; the second, in the autumn, is answered in a strange clerk's hand that the matter remains under consideration.¹⁹
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 99** — *Àth fhionn signs* (Àth fhionn). Ruairidh mac Thormoid, custodian of Àth fhionn in the south-east, is the eldest of those who signed the petition. He was born before the humans' coin was struck, and says so beside his name.

14. → Caused by *The custodians ride to Ceann àrsaidh*, 12 an Dùbhlachd, AE 98.

15. → Caused by *The custodians ride to Ceann àrsaidh*, 12 an Dùbhlachd, AE 98.

16. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

17. ← Follows from *The gathering at Ceann àrsaidh*, 3 am Màrt, AE 99.

18. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

19. ← Follows from *The gathering at Ceann àrsaidh*, 3 am Màrt, AE 99.

THE YEARS AE 101 – 110

- 27 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 101** — *Grievance first written*. From these years come the oldest writings of grievance among the Dia-thìrich that survive. No hand is yet raised in them; yet in them it is first written that something has gone wrong.
- 18 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 101** — *Leabhar Baile thais*¹ (Baile thais). The oldest of them is a book of complaints kept at Baile thais, set down by many hands over some years: wages, deaths, the granary, the stream at Doire mhòr. The custodians' copyists call it *Leabhar Baile thais*.
- 9 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 101** — *Griogair mac Aonghais tells Fearchar to sing it* (Muileann dhearg). Old Griogair mac Aonghais, who broke coal beside Fearchar's father before him, tells Fearchar that a column is for men who have given up hoping to be heard, and that he should sing the grievance instead of writing it. Fearchar carries the book back to Baile thais and begins working verses to the granary's short week.²
- 17 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 102** — *The songs of Fearchar Bàrd* (Muileann dhearg). The poet Fearchar Bàrd, a breaker of coal at Muileann dhearg since boyhood, makes songs of the Levy and the famine, and they are sung in the camps. The overseers forbid them, and because they were forbidden several were written down.
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 102** — *Songs at An Taigh-òsta Grianach*³ (An Taigh-òsta Grianach). The songs of Fearchar Bàrd are sung in the roadside houses of the east, and An Taigh-òsta Grianach becomes known for them. The Company's carters sing them too, the keeper writes, not always knowing what they sing.
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 102** — *Fearchar repays the docked wage* (Baile thais). Fearchar Bàrd walks to Baile thais to repay out of his own wage the boy docked half a week's pay for singing his song, and the boy refuses the coin, saying he would rather have sung it than not. The song is sung again within the week, further than before.⁴
- 15 AN GEARRAN, AE 103** — *The Company's deep-water quay* (Ros dhomhain). The Company builds at Ros dhomhain a deep-water quay for the new iron steamships, which burn the island's own coal to carry it away. Fearchar Bàrd makes a song of that, the most quoted of all his songs.
- 20 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 103** — *The deep quay at Ceann chaol* (Ceann chaol). A second deep-water quay is built at Ceann chaol in the south-east for the eastern coal. Its builders are brought from the coast, and the village of forty houses becomes a town of four hundred.
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 104** — *Baile thais walls its pithead* (Baile thais). The Company rings the pithead at Baile thais with a stone wall and a gate, and pays a watchman to count who goes in. It is the first working on Dia-thìr walled against its own crews.

1. the book of Baile thais, the book of grievances

2. ← Follows from *Leabhar Baile thais*, 18 an t-Sultain, AE 101.

3. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

4. ← Follows from *The songs of Fearchar Bàrd*, 17 am Faoilleach, AE 102.

- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 104** — *Catrìona nic Eachainn dies at the silver town* (Baile thais). Catriona nic Eachainn dies at Muileann chiar, a refiner of the silver guild to the end. The camp folk of Baile thais send men to her burying, and the Company docks each of them a day's pay.
- 4 AN GIBLEAN, AE 105** — *The quay fire* (Ros dhomhain). A fire starts in the Company's coal sheds at Ros dhomhain and burns three days, taking two streets of the harbour quarter with it. The Company's inquiry finds no cause; the harbour quarter's own account has several.
- 22 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 105** — *The council without a high custodian* (Cathair dhearg). After the death of the last high custodian the Council of Custodians cannot agree on another, and sits for years with the seat empty. Robert Haskins writes to an Tìr Thall⁵ that this makes the council easier to deal with.
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 105** — *Artair mac Iain dies at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). Artair mac Iain, high custodian for twenty and four years, dies at Cathair dhearg at eighty years old. Word of his death reaches Fearchar Bàrd on the road home from An Taigh-òsta Grianach⁶, carried faster than either fire or song by a rider changing horses at every post-house.⁷
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 106** — *Tiormachd Achadh shean*⁸. The Long Drought lies on the island's dry season three years together, and bears hard on a people already worn thin by the tallies of the pits.
- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 107** — *The wells of Achadh shean* (Achadh shean). At Achadh shean, whose name the drought bears, the wells fail in the second summer, and the cattle are driven west in a column the roll calls a day long. Fewer than half reach water.
- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 107** — *The dry country* (Tiormachd Achadh shean⁹). The custodians' roll counts ten districts of the east as drought country, worst at Achadh shean, Àth uaine, Achadh àrsaidh and Muileann chiar, and reaching down to Cuan ruadh and west toward Baile chaol. The Administration keeps no count of its own.
- 6 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 107** — *The cattle of Baile chaol* (Baile chaol). At Baile chaol the herds are slaughtered in the second summer of the drought, rather than watched as they die. The salt meat is sold to the Company for the camps, at a price the Company names.
- 5 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 107** — *Doire fhionn walks for water* (Doire fhionn). At Doire fhionn in the east the women walk each day to the spring at Àth ruadh and back for water, half a day's journey. The custodians record it for the three dry years, and then cease.

5. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

6. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

7. ← Follows from *The council without a high custodian*, 22 an t-Sultain, AE 105.

8. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

9. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 107** — *Baile chaol slaughters its herd* (Baile chaol). With no grazing left within four days' driving, Baile chaol's custodian Ealasaid Ruadh orders the town's whole herd killed and the meat salted rather than risk the loss of it on the road. The town loses fewer of its people to hunger that winter than any other of the ten drought districts.¹⁰
- 1 AN CÈITEAN, AE 108** — *Pilgrims at Allt an Àigh*¹¹ (Allt an Àigh). The spring of Allt an Àigh, said never to have failed, runs on through all three dry years. Pilgrims who keep Na Seann Spioradan¹² come to it from all the east, the first of them at Bealltainn, and the Administration sets a watchman to charge them for the water. He is called back after one season.
- 30 AN CÈITEAN, AE 108** — *The pilgrims' road at Inis uaine* (Inis uaine). Pilgrims bound for Allt an Àigh¹³ gather at Inis uaine, and the townsfolk feed them freely, as the Old Spirits require. The town's own wells are low, and it gives away more water than it keeps.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, AE 109** — *Drought-fever at Baile Mòr ruadh* (Baile Mòr ruadh). A fever of foul water follows the drought into the towns, worst at Baile Mòr ruadh, where the wells had been deepened into the old middens. Seventeen die. The Mission's report is the first to name the cause rightly.
- 3 AN CÈITEAN, AE 109** — *The fever at Cnoc shean* (Cnoc shean). The drought-fever spreads to Cnoc shean, whose one well is found tainted. The custodians close it, and for a year the town drinks from carts.
- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 109** — *The Mission's wells* (Achadh shean). The Mission sinks deep wells at Achadh shean and Àth chrom with a boring-rig brought from an Tìr Thall¹⁴, and they hold. The custodians of the east set down the Mission's wells and the Company's tallies on facing pages, without comment.
- 1 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 109** — *Coll's report names the drought-fever's true cause* (Baile Mòr ruadh). The Mission's physician at Baile Mòr ruadh, a young man named Coll, tests the town's water and finds it fouled by the old midden ground its deep wells were sunk through. His report to the Mission's house at Cathair dhearg is the first that autumn to name the fever's cause rightly.¹⁵
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 109** — *Every custodian of the drought country petitions Haskins* (Àth mhòr). Each of the ten drought districts' custodians petitions Commissioner Haskins in her own hand, unknown to the others, asking that the Company's quota be set aside until two seasons of ordinary rain are counted. Iseabail nic Leòid rides her own petition to the Residency and is told, as every other has been told, that the matter is under consideration.¹⁶

10. ← Follows from *Tiormachd Achadh shean*, 25 an Lùnastal, AE 106.

11. the stream of the healing water

12. the Old Spirits

13. the stream of the healing water

14. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

15. ← Follows from *Tiormachd Achadh shean*, 25 an Lùnastal, AE 106.

16. ← Follows from *Tiormachd Achadh shean*, 25 an Lùnastal, AE 106.

16 AM MÀRT, AE 110 — *Achadh chaol goes to the pits* (Achadh chaol). Their fields burned out by the drought, the people of Achadh chaol in the north-east go to the pits for wages, the first villagers of the eastern farm country to do so. Their custodian writes it down as the end of the village, not a flitting.

25 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 110 — *The tally not lowered* (Baile Mòr dhìreach). The coal tally is not lowered in the drought. The custodians of the east, their joint petition unanswered, each write to Haskins alone; to each he answers that the matter is under consideration.

THE YEARS AE III – 120

- 3 AN GEARRAN, AE III** — *The petition of Àth mhòr* (Àth mhòr). Iseabail nic Leòid, custodian of Àth mhòr, writes the longest of the single petitions, forty pages listing her town's dead beasts. Haskins answers in two lines. Both survive, bound together by a later clerk.
- 15 AN GEARRAN, AE III** — *The first inheritance of mixed blood*. A suit over whether the grandchild of a marriage between a Dia-thìreach and a human may inherit the customary rights of mining is decided, and the Administration makes the ruling wholly to its own gain.
- 4 AM MÀRT, AE III** — *The case of Thomas Hale* (Ros dhomhain). The child was Thomas Hale, grandson of the marriage at Baile dhìreach of Eilidh nic Ruairidh and Samuel Hale, who claimed a share in a customary cutting through his Dia-thìrich grandmother. Oliver Dunstan, magistrate at Ros dhomhain, ruled that customary rights descend only through the line the Administration owns, and that it owns only its own.
- 2 AN GIBLEAN, AE II2** — *Dunstan's rule applied* (Ros dhomhain). Within a few years Dunstan's ruling is used to pass eleven customary cuttings to the Company, each because some holder in the line had married a human or been born of one. The custodians stop entering such marriages in the roll.
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, AE II2** — *Mairead nic Aoidh stops entering marriages in the roll* (Baile dhìreach). The custodian of Baile dhìreach ceases to enter marriages between Dia-thìrich and humans in her roll, judging that under Dunstan's rule such an entry has become a paper a family's enemies may use against it rather than one that protects anything.¹
- 25 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE II3** — *A cutting at Cnoc dhubh taken* (Cnoc dhubh). Among the cuttings taken under Dunstan's rule is the old customary working at Cnoc dhubh, held by one family since the Holy Age. A great-grandmother of the line had married a human sailor; that is enough.
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE II3** — *The Lamp-Watch* (Baile thais). A fellowship of pit crews calling itself the Lamp-Watch begins to meet at Baile thais and Cnoc chaol under cover of a burial club. Its first known deed is to pay for the burying of an old breaker who had died in the Company's lock-up.
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE II3** — *Griogair mac Ailein dies in the lock-up* (Cnoc chaol). Griogair mac Ailein dies in the Company's lock-up at Cnoc chaol of a fever the Company's own surgeon records as already advanced when he was taken. He has no family living to claim him.²

1. ← Follows from *Dunstan's rule applied*, 2 an Giblean, AE II2.

2. ← Follows from *The Lamp-Watch*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, AE II3.

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 113** — *Thomas Hale sent for to read the surgeon's note* (Baile dhìreach). Dòmhnall Ruadh, a crew-leader of Baile thais, carries a letter to Baile dhìreach asking Thomas Hale, known along the coast for his hard-won knowledge of the Administration's law, to stand at Griogair mac Ailein's graveside and read the Company surgeon's note releasing the body.³
- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 114** — *Edward Vane Commissioner* (Ros dhomhain). Robert Haskins is called home after a quarrel with the Company over the price of steamship berths, and Edward Vane follows him. Vane is the first Commissioner born on Dia-thìr, at the Residency, and he speaks Dia-thìris, badly, but he speaks it.
- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 115** — *The tram-road to Ros dhìreach* (Ros dhìreach). Vane lays an iron tram-road, drawn by mules, from the southern workings down to the coal port at Ros dhìreach. It halves the cost of shipping coal, and ends the carting trade of the villages on the old road.
- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 115** — *Vane speaks Dia-thìris before the council at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). Edward Vane goes up to Cathair dhearg unsummoned and speaks three sentences of Dia-thìris to Comhairle a' Chùrain⁴ before finishing through the Mission's interpreter, telling the council he has come home. The clerk enters the word exactly, wrong tense and all.⁵
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 116** — *The night-shift order*. For the first time the digging is made to run without ceasing, day and night, and the mountain is given no season of rest at all.
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 116** — *The night crews at Cnoc chaol* (Cnoc chaol). The order falls first on Cnoc chaol, where the Company's newest galleries are opened to crews working by coal-lamp in two shifts. The custodians' roll writes that the hill was given no silence at all, and leaves the rest of the page blank.
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 117** — *The night-shift strike* (Cnoc chaol). The crews at Cnoc chaol refuse the night shift, and within a week are replaced by crews brought from the coast under the Company's new contracts. The Lamp-Watch keeps the strikers' families for a season, and then its money is gone.
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 117** — *The strikebreakers of Muileann dhombain* (Muileann dhomhain). The crews that replace the strikers at Cnoc chaol are brought through Muileann dhomhain, where the townsfolk turn them from every door. They sleep in the Company's barns, and several go home the next season.
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 117** — *The Lamp-Watch's purse runs dry* (Cnoc chaol). The Lamp-Watch, keeping the households of the crews who stood at Cnoc chaol, empties its purse by the second winter. Its own reckoning, kept in an unnamed hand, closes the year's account at nothing, and beneath it notes only that the hill was not given back its silence.⁶

3. ← Follows from *The Lamp-Watch*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, AE 113.

4. the Council of Custodians; lit. 'the council of the custody'

5. ← Follows from *Edward Vane Commissioner*, 28 an t-Ògmhios, AE 114.

- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 118** — *Matthew Dunne's sermon* (Ros dhomhain). Matthew Dunne, the Mission's minister at Ros dhomhain, preaches against the night-shift order from the chapel pulpit, saying the Dia-thìrich are right that even the ground must rest. The Company complains to the Mission, and Dunne is called back to an Tìr Thall'. The Lamp-Watch copies the sermon and reads it in the camps.
- 14 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 119** — *The lung-rot at Cnoc chaol* (Cnoc chaol). A wasting sickness of the lungs spreads among the night crews at Cnoc chaol and Baile thais. Unlike the Green Death it kills slowly. The Company pays the widows a pension for a year, then stops.
- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 119** — *Iain Maor and the night shift* (Muileann chrom). Iain Maor, overseer at Muileann chrom, writes to the Company that the night shift is killing his crews faster than it is paying for them. The letter survives because the Company filed it with his dismissal, which was undone a month later for want of anyone else.
- 25 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 119** — *Iain Maor dismissed and restored* (Muileann chrom). The Residency answers Iain Maor's letter with a notice relieving him of the overseer's staff for conduct unbecoming his office. His daughter Mòrag reads it to him by lamplight. Within a month, the crews having slowed the galleries to nothing, an unsigned notice restores him with no mention of the first.⁸
- 22 AM MÀRT, AE 120** — *The coal line* (Muileann chrom). The Company opens its railway from the pits at Muileann chrom down by Cathair dhearg to the deep-water quay at Ros dhomhain. Its engines burn the island's own coal, as the steamships do, and the tram-road to Ros dhìreach is left to the mules. Within a year the carters' guild of Doire chaol, which had hauled the coal on Rathad na Mèinne⁹ for eighty years, loses the long haul. From the first day the Dia-thìrich call the engine carbad-iarainn, the iron chariot, and the railway the coal line.
- 18 AN GIBLEAN, AE 120** — *Coal-lamps from Baile ghorm* (Baile ghorm). The potteries of Baile ghorm take a contract for clay lamp-bodies for the night crews, thousands in a year. The potters' own book notes that they are the first lamps made on the island for work in the dark by command.

6. ← Follows from *The Lamp-Watch*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, AE 113; ← Follows from *The night-shift strike*, 3 an Lùnastal, AE 117.

7. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

8. ← Follows from *Iain Maor and the night shift*, 12 an t-Sultain, AE 119.

9. the mine road

THE YEARS AE 121 – 130

- 21 AN GEARRAN, AE 121** — *Fionnan born*. A second child is born bound to the coal as Aisling was, half a century after her. So it is known that the thing is no chance of one birth: it comes of the digging, and it will go on.
- 19 AN CÈITEAN, AE 122** — *The Administration's count of the people* (Ros dhomhain). The Administration counts the people of Dia-thìr by district for the first time. Its figures for the humans are true to the household; for the Dia-thìrich they are rounded to the hundred, and in the hill districts to the thousand.
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 122** — *Cailean mac Eachainn taken on at the cellar* (Muileann chaol). Cailean mac Eachainn, a turf-cutter's son of Muileann chaol with a plain hand at his letters, is taken on by the three households of the cellar when Seònaig Bhàn's eyes fail her past close work. He is asked first not whether he can write fair, but whether he can hold his tongue.
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, AE 123** — *The district of the outer coasts* (Seann Vell). The Administration makes the outer coasts one district and rules it from the harbour office at Seann Vell on Eilean ruadh, where its revenue cutters lie: the islands of the west and south, Eilean bhàn with Cuan dhearg and Cnoc chaol, and the southern edge of the windy coast in the far north-west. Its surveyors walk to the edge of the great moss there, which no chain can cross, and go no farther. Beyond it the district map is left blank.
- 6 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 123** — *Seònaid nic Dhùghaill, last of the druid masters* (Dùn thais). Seònaid nic Dhùghaill, the last master of Scoiltean nan Draoidhean¹ to teach openly in this age, dies at Dùn thais. No one is named after her, and the school's register ends with her death. It is taken up again only long after the humans are gone.
- 5 AM MÀRT, AE 124** — *The custodians' rolls at Muileann chaol* (Muileann chaol). The custodians of the east begin to send copies of their rolls for safe keeping to the town of Muileann chaol, which still kept Beathag nic Thòmais's loft of papers, beyond the Residency's reach. The copying is done in the houses of three families, and the copies kept in a cellar.²
- 5 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 125** — *The second Muileann chaol* (Muileann chaol). Some of the copies bound for Muileann chaol go by mistake to the smaller town of that name further north, and are kept there for years before the mistake is found. The custodians note that they were kept just as well.
- 4 AM MÀRT, AE 125** — *Nothing of weight was lost* (Muileann chaol). By lamplight Fearchar mac Ailpein and Cailean mac Eachainn match the recovered northern rolls against the cellar's own patched record of the missing years, and find that little of any weight had truly gone missing, only kept for a time in the wrong cellar.³

1. the druid schools

2. → Caused by *Cailean mac Eachainn taken on at the cellar*, 29 an t-Samhain, AE 122.

3. ← Follows from *The second Muileann chaol*, 5 am Faoilleach, AE 125.

- 23 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 126** — *The word found at last.* With two children now known, the custodians agree on a word for what is befalling them: fuil-ghuail⁴, “coal-blood”, rendered in the humans’ tongue as coal-touched. It is meant as a physician’s word. It outlives that meaning.
- 21 AN GEARRAN, AE 126** — *The custodians who named it* (Cill ghlas). The word was agreed at a meeting of custodians at the shrine of Cill ghlas, where the oldest cutting still stood open. They chose a plain word, fit for the physician’s book. The roll gives the vote; who first put the word forward it does not say.
- 16 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 126** — *Peigi Ghlas calls the custodians to Cill ghlas* (Cill ghlas). Peigi Ghlas writes to every custodian within two days’ walk, calling them to the shrine of Cill ghlas on the night of the coming full moon to settle a name for the change that has now come twice upon a child of the pits, and asks the cellar to send a hand who can write it fair on the spot.⁵
- 21 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 126** — *The Line of Aisling found* (Muileann chaol). Cailean mac Eathainn, a copyist in the cellar at Muileann chaol, finds in the roll of the camp at Àth iséal the marriage of Aisling’s father, Donnchadh mac Thormoid, with his line written seven names back, as the custodians write a marriage. He carries the seven names up to Tobar dhìreach, to Ealasaid of Clann na Ceiste⁶, the last who says the lines, and she knows them for the line of Somhairle son of Ailean Mòr. She says Aisling’s line to him backward, from her father to the mason who found the fire. So what the camps whispered at Aisling’s birth is found to be true. Cailean writes the line in the margin beside her birth.
- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 126** — *The third mark beside a birth* (Muileann chaol). On the same page Cailean finds the birth of Aisling entered with a mark he has seen only three or four times in a year of copying, never explained in any book given him, and recognises it for the mark the camps’ whisper had already fixed to one child in the settlement.⁷
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 126** — *Cailean walks to Tobar dhìreach* (Tobar dhìreach). Rather than report to the cellar, Cailean walks the hill road to Tobar dhìreach with the seven names copied onto a scrap of paper inside his coat, to ask whether a line so old could truly be Donnchadh’s own.⁸
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 127** — *The Administration’s register* (Ros dhomhain). The Residency, hearing of the word, orders that any Dia-thìreach child showing the change be reported to the Commissioner’s office. The custodians obey by reporting none.

4. the coal-blooded; lit. ‘coal-blood’

5. ← Follows from *The word found at last*, 23 am Faoilleach, AE 126.

6. the Children of the Question

7. ← Follows from *The Line of Aisling found*, 21 an Dàmhair, AE 126.

8. ← Follows from *The Line of Aisling found*, 21 an Dàmhair, AE 126.

- 22 AN CÈITEAN, AE 128** — *Peigi Ghlàs dies at Cill ghlàs* (Cill ghlàs). Peigi Ghlàs dies at Cill ghlàs, her petition still unanswered, having trimmed Bride's lamp herself the week before her death and said that she had asked the Residency once and meant to leave the asking there.
- 7 AN GIBLEAN, AE 129** — *The third change of coin*. The old barter of the Dia-thìrich is struck down as lawful payment altogether. Every bargain on the island now goes by the humans' coin.
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 129** — *The barter houses closed* (Ros dhomhain). The barter houses at Ros dhomhain and Cathair dhearg, where cloth and fish had changed hands without coin since before the Crossing, are shut by order. A clerk of the Residency writes that the ledgers are now "complete for the first time."
- 22 AM MÀRT, AE 130** — *The fishwives of Inis mhòr* (Inis mhòr). The fishwives of Inis mhòr, who had sold by barter at the river steps since before the Crossing, will take no coin for a week, in protest at the shutting of the barter houses, and give their fish away. The Company's clerks record it as a glut.
- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 130** — *Marks borrowed at interest* (Cathair dhearg). Barter being struck down, the hill villages borrow marks at interest from the Company's stores to buy seed. Within a few years most of the villages of Muileann chrom owe the Company more than a year's crops.

THE YEARS AE 131 – 140

- 20 AN GIBLEAN, AE 131** — *The old market at Muileann òg* (Muileann òg). The old barter market at Muileann òg, where hill and coast had met to trade since the Holy Age, closes after its last season, and the ground stands empty.
- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 131** — *Mòrag nic Iain Maor* (Muileann chrom). Iain Maor dies, and his daughter Mòrag takes the overseer's staff at Muileann chrom, the first woman to hold it. The Company approves her in a letter that calls her "a safe pair of hands."
- 24 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 132** — *Charles Merriman Commissioner* (Ros dhomhain). Edward Vane dies at the Residency. Charles Merriman comes after him with a small company of armed constables, the first standing force the Administration has kept on Dia-thìr.
- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 132** — *The constable post at Muileann shean* (Muileann shean). Merri-man's first constable post is built at Muileann shean on the northern coal road, a stone house with a yard for horses. The townsfolk call it the humans' second Residency, and do not mean it kindly.
- 5 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 132** — *Ruth Pallant teaches Hannah Webb the night watch* (Ceann mhòr). At Ceann mhòr, an old net-mender named Ruth Pallant tells the field-worker Hannah Webb of a night watch her own people's fisher-forebears learned from the island folk, kept in silence under a grey goose said to hold the sea shut. Hannah carries the telling of it home to the concession.
- 13 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 132** — *Hannah Webb's first vigil* (Baile chrom). In a field behind her landlord's byre near Baile chrom, Hannah Webb keeps the silent watch for the first time, and sees, or believes she sees, a pale shape cross the night sky before she sleeps through a whole night for the first time in ten years on the island.
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 132** — *The watch spreads along the concession's edge* (Baile chrom). Word of Hannah Webb's night vigil passes among the human labourers of the concession after a field hand sees her keeping it. Within a season a handful of others try it, and by autumn six or seven keep the field together on clear nights, spaced apart and silent.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, AE 133** — *A barracks at Tobar ghorm* (Tobar ghorm). A second post is raised at Tobar ghorm, near the northern workings. The village's custodian is paid rent for the ground, and with it buys the village out of its debts to the Company store.
- 28 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 133** — *A grey-night vigil at Baile chrom* (Baile chrom). The Mission at Cathair gheal reports that human labourers near Baile chrom keep vigil by night in the fields, praying in silence under the sign of a grey goose, which they call the wild goose of the Spirit. The Mission cannot find whence the practice came, and calls it irregular, a superstition learned of the Dia-thìrich. The Dia-thìrich of Baile chrom disown it.¹

1. → Caused by *Ruth Pallant teaches Hannah Webb the night watch*, 5 an t-Samhain, AE 132; → Caused by *Hannah Webb's first vigil*, 13 an t-Samhain, AE 132; → Caused by *The watch spreads along the concession's edge*, 29 an t-Samhain, AE 132.

- 21 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 133** — *Manannan's priests on the grey night* (Ceann mhòr). The priests of Òrd Mhanannain² at Ceann mhòr answer the Mission's report of the grey-night vigils. The practice owes something to the Dia-thìrich, they say, but to their own harbours and not to Baile chrom: the human fishing families of Ceann mhòr learned from them the night prayer to keep the sea shut, and the labourers inland keep it as a vigil of their Church, a night of silence under the wild goose of the Spirit in place of a prayer to Manannan. The priests call it Manannan's prayer gone astray, and do not admit its keepers to their house.
- 1 AN GIBLEAN, AE 134** — *The dockers' strike at Ros dhomhain* (Ros dhomhain). The dockers of Ros dhomhain, Dia-thìrich and human alike, refuse to load coal for nine days over the new berth charges. It is the only strike of the age in which human workers stand with Dia-thìrich. Merriman's constables break it, and the human dockers are shipped over the sea.
- 30 AN GIBLEAN, AE 134** — *Seann Vell's dockers stay out* (Seann Vell). The dockers of Seann Vell, the harbour next to Ros dhomhain, refuse to load the coal sent to them during the strike. When it ends they are not shipped over the sea, for there are no humans among them; but they are not hired again either.
- 29 AN CÈITEAN, AE 134** — *Lorccan born*. A third such child is born, in a mining town and not a camp; the thing is no longer bound to any one place.
- 1 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 134** — *Raghnall Breac walks to Cill ghlas* (Baile thais). With his knees gone stiff for the low work at Baile thais and two grandchildren to feed, the ageing hewer Raghnall Breac walks two days to the new galleries at Cill ghlas, where the pay is better and the headings still stand tall enough for a man to work upright. He writes to his daughter Eilidh twice a year.
- 3 AM MÀRT, AE 135** — *Cian born*. A fourth is born within a year of the third. Never again do the children of the undying generation come so close together.
- 4 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 136** — *Blasting-powder at Cill ghlas* (Cill ghlas). The Company begins to drive galleries under the hills about Cill ghlas with blasting-powder shipped from an Tìr Thall³. The custodians of the shrine ask that no charge be set within sight of the old cutting. The Company's engineer marks their asking on his plan, and sets the charges below it.⁴
- 2 AN GEARRAN, AE 136** — *Powder landed at Caol ìseal* (Caol ìseal). The blasting-powder for the new galleries is landed at Caol ìseal on the northern coast, away from the crowded southern harbours, and carted inland under guard. The town's custodians ask what is in the barrels and are told it is lamp-oil.
- 6 AM MÀRT, AE 136** — *Eilidh nic Raghnaill given a seat at the Lamp-Watch's table* (Baile thais). The crew-leader Eilidh nic Raghnaill of Baile thais is asked, for the first time, to sit at the table where the Lamp-Watch keeps its business, and copies its minutes into a second book kept in her own linen chest, where no Company clerk would think to look.⁵

2. the order of Manannan

3. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

4. → Caused by *Raghnall Breac walks to Cill ghlas*, 1 an t-Sultain, AE 134.

5. ← Follows from *The Lamp-Watch*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, AE 113.

- 9 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 137** — *Scàineadh Cill ghlas*⁶. The Rending; in the hills east of the capital, about Cill ghlas, the earth tears open along a fault beneath a common working. Dozens are killed, and a whole mining district is shut for a generation.
- 17 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 137** — *The first open fight*. A mining death, which the Dia-thìrich workers lay at the door of the humans' carelessness, leads to the first bloodshed between the two peoples.
- 3 **AN T-IUCHAR, AE 137** — *The shrine at Cill ghlas lost* (Cill ghlas). The Rending swallows the old cutting at Cill ghlas, where the custodians had kept the rites through all the age, and its shrine with it. The custodians' roll sets down the loss of the shrine before the loss of the dead; a later copyist has put them in the other order.
- 13 **AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 137** — *The district closed* (Scàineadh Cill ghlas⁷). The Company shuts the whole district of the Rending and fences it, leaving Cill ghlas, Àth chaol and their hamlets in the shires of Muileann dhearg and Muileann chiar without work. The villages empty toward Baile thais and Muileann dhearg, and the closed district is left to the thorn.
- 22 **AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 137** — *The meeting on the moor road* (Coinneachadh an Fhearainn⁸). The folk turned out of the closed district send their eldest to the custodians of Muileann dhomhain, who meet them at a standing stone on the moor road below the town, lest the Company's clerks see them in the town hall. At the stone the custodians lend them the land at the edge of the fenced ground. The place is called Coinneachadh an Fhearainn, the meeting of the land.
- 5 **AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 137** — *Achadh chaol raised by the dispossessed* (Achadh chaol). Folk of the closed district build a new village at Achadh chaol, at the edge of the fenced ground, on land lent by the custodians of Muileann dhomhain. It is the only settlement of the age founded by Dia-thìrich for Dia-thìrich with no Company surveyor's hand in it.
- 13 **AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 137** — *The fight at Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). The death that began it was a flooded gallery at Muileann chrom, where seven died after the pumps were stopped to save fuel. When the Company's agent came to the pithead the crews stoned him and his constables, and the constables fired. Four Dia-thìrich and one constable were killed.
- 26 **AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 137** — *Eilidh nic Raghnaill at the fenced ground* (Cill ghlas). Eilidh nic Raghnaill walks to Cill ghlas to find her father's grave and finds instead the fence and the fallen headgear of the eighth heading. A constable turns her away from the closed ground. She writes nothing of the hour in the Lamp-Watch's book.⁹

6. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

7. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

8. the meeting of the crews on the moor

9. ← Follows from *The district closed*, 13 an t-Samhain, AE 137.

- 4 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 138** — *Mòrag Maor at the inquiry* (Muileann chrom). At the Administration's inquiry into the fight the overseer Mòrag nic Iain Maor bears witness that the pumps were stopped on the agent's order. Her words are struck out. The Lamp-Watch gets a copy of them all the same.
- 2 AN GEARRAN, AE 138** — *The grey fever* (Baile thais). A fever of the chest comes in on the ships and runs over the whole island, from the capital to the eastern farms. It kills the young and strong more than the old, the Mission notes in alarm. The camps, already hungry, bury more than the towns.
- 14 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 138** — *The grey fever at Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). At Cathair mhòr the grey fever shuts the market for the first time in the town's memory. The custodians' roll gives the dead by street, and the longest list is of the street where the carters lived.
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 138** — *The grey fever at Dùn thais* (Dùn thais). At Dùn thais the fever takes the physician the Administration sent to treat it, and two of the Mission's nurses. The old houses of the druid masters are opened as sick-rooms.
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 138** — *Tormod Buidhe's sister's boy dies of the grey fever* (Baile thais). A boy not yet old enough for his first wage dies of the grey fever at Baile thais under Eilidh nic Raghnaill's sitting, having asked her, near the end, what month it was. His mother keeps his name from the burial club's book, and Eilidh does not ask for it twice.¹⁰
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 138** — *Eilidh nic Raghnaill begins the burial club's book* (Baile thais). Eilidh nic Raghnaill begins keeping a plain hand-written record for the burial club at Baile thais, answering to no custodian's roll, after watching her father Raghnaill Breac carry twenty years of names in his memory and give none of them to paper. She means not to do the same.¹¹
- 27 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 139** — *The second petition*. This one carries a threat beneath its words, not a plea. It is the first writing of the Dia-thìrich the Administration troubles to answer, and it answers with more guards, not with concessions.
- 12 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 139** — *The signatories of Cnoc dhìreach* (Cnoc dhìreach). Coinneach Ruadh, custodian of Cnoc dhìreach, signs the second petition, and in the same week is turned out of his post as clerk to the Company store. He is one of eleven who sign and lose Company work for it.
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 139** — *Eilidh nic Raghnaill* (Baile thais). The second petition was drawn up by Eilidh nic Raghnaill, a crew-leader of Baile thais and one of the Lamp-Watch, and signed by custodians and crew-leaders of thirty-one settlements. It ends with a sentence the Residency underlined: that the hill would not be worked by people who were not asked.
- 25 AN GEARRAN, AE 140** — *The constables tripled* (Ros dhomhain). Merriman answers by tripling the constables and posting companies at Muileann chrom, Baile thais, Ceann fhada and Cnoc chaol, each with a walled store. The constables are paid from the tithe.

10. ← Follows from *The grey fever*, 2 an Gearran, AE 138.

11. ← Follows from *The grey fever*, 2 an Gearran, AE 138.

- 26 AM MÀRT, AE 140** — *Barracks at Dùn chrom* (Dùn chrom). A barracks for the constables is built at Dùn chrom, on the capital side of the hills, with room for two hundred men. For most of its first year it stands empty, for want of constables to fill it.
- 24 AN GIBLEAN, AE 140** — *Ìomhar Seabhag* (Seann Skell). At Seann Skell the hawk-priest Ìomhar Seabhag preaches that Mòd's hunger has turned on those who have eaten the hill. The hawk-shrines of the west begin to serve as meeting-houses for the Lamp-Watch, and the constables do not yet know it.
- 23 AN CÈITEAN, AE 140** — *The hawk-faithful of Ros gheal* (Ros gheal). At Ros gheal the hawk-faithful fishing families, who had chased out the Company's customs officers a century before, raise a shrine to Mòd on the harbour wall. The constables order it down. It is built again three times in a single season.
- 21 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 140** — *The hawk and the druids at Inis bhàn* (Inis bhàn). At Inis bhàn the priests of the hawk and a few who still keep the questions of the druid school in private meet for a disputation, the first between them in living memory. It is written that it settled nothing, and that both sides afterwards signed the petition.
- 20 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 140** — *The grey fever in the north-west* (Baile chrom). The grey fever returns and settles in the north-west, about Baile chrom and the towns of the concession, where it kills humans as readily as Dia-thìrich. The Mission's hospital at Cathair gheal overflows, and for the first time Dia-thìrich and human sick lie in the same wards.
- 8 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 140** — *The first constables' company reaches Baile thais* (Baile thais). Forty constables under an officer named Prosser march into Baile thais on the twenty-fifth of Gearran and wall the settlement's old open store within the fortnight, taking the camp's well inside the new wall. Eilidh nic Raghnaill and the burial club watch the company make camp on ground that had been common land that same morning.¹²

12. ← Follows from *The constables tripled*, 25 an Gearran, AE 140.

THE YEARS AE 141 – 150

- 6 AM MÀRT, AE 141** — *Muileann fhionn shut in* (Muileann fhionn). Muileann fhionn, a Dia-thìreach mill town in the north-west, shuts its roads against the fever and keeps them shut for a season. Human carters of the concession are turned back with their loads at the town's edge.
- 18 AN GIBLEAN, AE 141** — *The fever at Tobar fhiadhaich* (Tobar fhiadhaich). At Tobar fhiadhaich in the north the fever takes one household in three. The custodians of the village burn no huts; they had heard of Àth ghlas in their grandparents' time, but judge it too late.
- 9 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 141** — *The road-houses make ready* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). The road-houses along the old mining roads begin to serve as waystations for bands of armed men. The roads make ready for a war not yet declared.
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 141** — *An Taigh-seinnse Òir¹* (An Taigh-seinnse Òir). An Taigh-seinnse Òir, the great house on the eastern road beyond Dùn dhearg, digs a well in its yard and builds a wall round the well. The keeper tells the Company's carters it is against thieves.
- 14 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 141** — *An Leòmhann Buidhe²* (An Leòmhann Buidhe). An Leòmhann Buidhe, the road-house on the northern road through the druid country, takes on six new ostlers in a single season, none of whom know anything of horses.
- 22 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 142** — *An Taigh-òsta Grianach³ walled* (An Taigh-òsta Grianach). An Taigh-òsta Grianach, called the singing house since the songs of Fearchar Bàrd, raises a wall round its yard and sets a watch on its gate.
- 3 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 142** — *Am Buabhall Fortanach barred* (Am Buabhall Fortanach). Am Buabhall Fortanach, the great road-house on the south-western road, bars its gates at dusk and keeps a watch on the roof. Its keeper, Tormod Buabhall, keeps a list of travellers and sends it up the road each week, to whom is not told.
- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 142** — *The harbour of Doire shean* (Doire shean). The little harbour of Doire shean, below Am Buabhall Fortanach, becomes the landing for the goods the house cannot take by road. The fishermen of Doire shean are paid in silver from the east.
- 28 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 142** — *An Taigh-seinnse Reòta* (An Taigh-seinnse Reòta). At An Taigh-seinnse Reòta on the northern road the stables are rebuilt with a loft for sleeping men. The Company's carters mark that the loft is never empty, and never holds the same men twice.

1. the golden house, a waypoint inn

2. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

3. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 142** — *An Sligeanach Fad' às*⁴ (An Sligeanach Fad' às). An Sligeanach Fad' às, on the eastern road near the silver country, becomes the post-house through which the Lamp-Watch sends word from the camps to Muileann chiar. The silver guild pays its keeper's rent.
- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 142** — *The runners of Àth fhiadhaich* (Àth fhiadhaich). Runners from Àth fhiadhaich carry the Lamp-Watch's letters from An Sligeanach Fad' às⁵ to the silver town. They are boys of twelve and thirteen, too young for the constables to stop.
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 142** — *A boy of Àth fhiadhaich at Aonghas's door* (Àth fhiadhaich). A boy runner out of Àth fhiadhaich comes soaked from the ford into Aonghas's yard, asks for bread as any boy might, and leaves a folded scrap under the loose board by the stable door naming a date and nothing else. Aonghas burns it in the kitchen fire that night.⁶
- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 143** — *Achadh mhòr keeps the ledgers* (Achadh mhòr). The Lamp-Watch's ledgers of the money it has from the silver guild are kept at Achadh mhòr, a village near the house on the eastern road, in the roof of the village shrine.
- 26 AN GEARRAN, AE 143** — *Seònaid's house* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, the carters' house on the coal road that Seònaid Bhàn opened again in the early years of the digging, is kept now by her great-grandson Aonghas. It is the busiest of the walled houses, the one the constables search most often and find least in.
- 27 AM MÀRT, AE 143** — *The first stoppage together*. For the first time the mining country stops work on one day in many places at once. Scattered as it is, the resistance of the Diathirich can act as one when it chooses.
- 27 AM MÀRT, AE 143** — *Muileann bheag in the north-east* (Muileann bheag). The workings at Muileann bheag in the north-east, among the druid villages, stop with the rest. The town's custodian writes that it is the first thing the town has done with the hills in a hundred years.
- 27 AM MÀRT, AE 143** — *The northern pits at Àth dhombhain* (Àth dhombhain). The pits north of the hills at Àth dhombhain stop with the rest on the day of the stoppage, the word brought by a runner and not by the beacon. Their crew-leaders are among those shipped over the sea.
- 27 AM MÀRT, AE 143** — *Ceann bheag stops* (Ceann bheag). The coal stage at Ceann bheag on the northern coast stops loading the same day. Its dockers had not been told; they stop because the coal stops coming.
- 27 AM MÀRT, AE 143** — *The quarrymen of Cnoc gheal* (Cnoc gheal). The quarrymen of Cnoc gheal in the north-east, who cut stone for the Company's buildings, lay down their tools on the day of the stoppage unasked. Why, no one says.

4. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

5. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

- 27 AM MÀRT, AE 143** — *The day the pits stopped* (Muileann chrom). On the day of the stoppage every working in the Muileann chrom district halted at once, and with them Baile thais, Cnoc chaol, the silver town and the eastern pits at Ros fhionn. The sign was a beacon fire lit on the hills above Doire mhòr, which the Company took for a heath fire.
- 27 AM MÀRT, AE 143** — *The coal ships wait* (Ros dhomhain). The Company's steamships lie six days at Ros dhomhain with empty holds. The agents at the quay write that they have never seen the harbour so quiet, and that it frightened them more than the crowds.
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 143** — *The stoppage broken* (Ros dhomhain). The stoppage ends when the constables shut the Company stores in every district at once. Forty crew-leaders are taken; thirty-two are let go without charge, and eight are shipped over the sea to an Tìr Thall⁷ for trial and never heard of again.
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 143** — *The fire on Cnoc an Rabhaidh* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). On 27 am Màrt, Aonghas watches smoke rise thin from Cnoc an Rabhaidh in a hard north-west wind, and every wheel within sight of his yard stops within the hour. A carter in his own yard names it a heath fire before anyone learns otherwise.⁸
- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 144** — *Beacon hill at Doire mhòr* (Doire mhòr). Doire mhòr, which refused the first contract and then lost its water, has by now but a few households. The beacon of the stoppage was lit on its hill by the children's children of Beathag Dhubh's people, and the constables burn the heather of the hill to deny it to them.⁹
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, AE 144** — *Fewer ships from over the sea* (Muir Mhanannain¹⁰). The keepers' daybooks at the five beacons show fewer ships from an Tìr Thall¹¹ each year, and the ships that come are older. The Company's letters speak of troubles at home and do not say what they are.
- 13 AN GIBLEAN, AE 145** — *Caol leathan's idle harbour* (Caol leathan). At Caol leathan the wool for the humans' market waits for room in ships that do not come. The merchants of the town begin to sell their wool inland again by barter, against the law.
- 9 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 145** — *Caol bheag's empty quay* (Caol bheag). The Company's quay at Caol bheag on the northern coast, built for the eastern trade, sees one ship in a season. The Company's agent there writes that he has been forgotten.

6. ← Follows from *The runners of Àth fbiadhaich*, 25 an t-Samhain, AE 142.

7. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

8. ← Follows from *The first stoppage together*, 27 am Màrt, AE 143; ← Follows from *The day the pits stopped*, 27 am Màrt, AE 143.

9. → Caused by *The fire on Cnoc an Rabhaidh*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, AE 143.

10. Manannan's sea, round Dia-thìr

11. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 145** — *Tormod Buabhall's word on a house with nothing left to guard* (Am Buabhall Fortanach). Meeting Aonghas at the horse-fair after the ships have thinned to nothing, Tormod Buabhall tells him a house with no custom left keeps its gates shut for a different reason than before: a house that guards everything still has, behind its locked door, something it means to keep.¹²
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, AE 146** — *Leave no longer asked*. The humans' Administration begins to give commands without seeking the counsel of the Dia-thìrich at all. The pretence of leave asked and given is dropped.
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 146** — *Lionel Strake Commissioner* (Ros dhomhain). Charles Merri-man leaves Dia-thìr in ill health, and Lionel Strake, a soldier, comes after him. His commission, read aloud at the Residency, makes no mention of the Council of Custodians, and he does not call on it.
- 26 AN GEARRAN, AE 147** — *The council locked out* (Cathair dhearg). Strake has the council hall at Cathair dhearg locked and its keys lodged at the Residency. The custodians meet instead in Macha's temple, whose priests, who had blessed the humans' coin, now shelter those who petitioned against it.
- 27 AM MÀRT, AE 147** — *The iron bird* (Ros dhomhain). Strake brings a flying machine from an Tìr Thall¹³ in the hold of a Company steamship and has it flown from a field above the Residency over the coal country, to count the workings from the air. The Dia-thìrich call it eun-iarainn, the iron bird. The custodians enter it in the roll as the first thing seen over Dia-thìr that flew and was not alive.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, AE 147** — *The edict of seizure*. The humans' Administration claims the right to take any dwelling of the Dia-thìrich it deems needful for the widening of the workings. Of all the grievances it is the one most often named in every surviving account of what followed.
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 147** — *The seizure of Doire mhòr* (Doire mhòr). The first dwellings taken under the edict are those of Doire mhòr, for a new shaft beneath the hill, and constables carry out the last households. The village that refused the first contract is the first emptied by the last.
- 19 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 147** — *Evictions at Baile dhombhain* (Baile dhomhain). At Baile dhomhain, the first camp laid out on paper, two streets are pulled down for a spoil-tip. The families are offered huts at Àth ìseal and marks for their timber; most go to kin in the hill villages instead.
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 147** — *The old man of Doire mhòr* (Doire mhòr). An old man carried gently from his own doorstone by constables clearing houses under the edict of seizure asks only that it be written down that they were gentle about it. Mòrag nic Iain Maor, come from Muileann chrom, carries the sentence home with no book to hand.¹⁴

12. ← Follows from *Fewer ships from over the sea*, 25 an Giblean, AE 144.

13. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

- 24 AN CÈITEAN, AE 148** — *Mòrag Maor lays down the staff* (Muileann chrom). Mòrag nic Iain Maor, fourth of her line to hold the overseer's staff at Muileann chrom, will not carry out evictions in her district, and breaks the staff at the Company's door. Three other overseers give up their places in the same month, and the Company puts humans in them.
- 21 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 148** — *The silver guild arms* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). The silver guild of Muileann chiar, still holding its seam under the compact of a century before, begins to buy rifles through the eastern pirates. Its ledger enters them as refining tools.
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 148** — *Rifles by way of the pirates* (Spùinneadairean-mara). The silver guild's rifles come ashore from the raiders' boats in the eastern waters, where no Company gunboat has sailed for years. The raiders take their pay in bar silver, by weight.
- 20 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 148** — *The council in the forest of Cnoc bheag* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹⁵). Custodians, crew-leaders of the Lamp-Watch and the dissenting priests of Macha meet in the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag and make one council for the mining country, and choose Eilidh nic Raghnaill to speak for it. No human writing records the meeting.
- 3 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 149** — *The order to seize* (Ros dhomhain). Strake orders the taking of Eilidh nic Raghnaill and the members of the forest council. The constables go to Baile thais and find the house empty and the town silent.
- 20 AN GEARRAN, AE 149** — *War*. The Dia-thirich, acting together across the whole mining country for the first time, pass from grievance to open war.
- 23 AN GEARRAN, AE 149** — *Coinneach Ruadh's ride of the twenty-eighth* (Muileann chrom). Coinneach Ruadh rides into Muileann chrom on the twenty-eighth of an Gearran with word that the grievance is called across every mining district at once, and that the Residency has already had its answer that morning from Muileann chrom and Baile thais both.
- ¹⁶
- 25 AN GEARRAN, AE 149** — *The beacons of the coal country answer* (Muileann chrom). On the night war is called, signal fires long kept secret are carried openly to every beacon height the mining districts hold, ridge answering ridge from Doire mhòr to the silver hills, the first time the whole coal country has shown itself lit at once.¹⁷
- 28 AN GEARRAN, AE 149** — *The stores taken at Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). The war opens in the hills. At Muileann chrom crews under Mòrag nic Iain rush the walled store at first light, and its eleven constables yield without a shot. The rifles and the grain of the store are carried off before noon.
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, AE 149** — *The quay at Ceann fhada seized* (Ceann fhada). Crews from the camps take the Company's coal quay at Ceann fhada and sink two barges across its mouth. No coal leaves the hills by water again in this age.

14. ← Follows from *The edict of seizure*, 25 an Giblean, AE 147; ← Follows from *The seizure of Doire mhòr*, 17 an t-Sultain, AE 147.

15. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

16. ← Follows from *War*, 20 an Gearran, AE 149.

17. ← Follows from *War*, 20 an Gearran, AE 149.

- 30 AN CÈITEAN, AE 149** — *Pàdraig Reamhar scuttles his own barge* (Ceann fhada). The boatman Pàdraig Reamhar, who built the larger of the two barges sunk at Ceann fhada with his own father twenty years before, knocks the plugs from her hull with his own hands and says afterward only that she had been a good boat.¹⁸
- 1 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 149** — *The siege of the store at Baile thais* (Baile thais). At Baile thais the constables hold their walled pithead against the town for eleven days, as long as the first strike a lifetime before, and yield on the twelfth when their water fails. Eilidh nic Raghnaill sends them under guard to the coast unharmed. The Residency did not look for such mercy, and did not return it.
- 9 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 149** — *The crews meet on the moor* (Coinneachadh a' Mhonaidh¹⁹). Crew-leaders of Baile gharbh and the other northern pits meet by night on the moor above Cnoc naomh and fix the week of their rising. Each brings a stone of spoil from his own pit, and the stones are left in a cairn. The place is called Coinneachadh a' Mhonaidh, the meeting of the moor.
- 30 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 149** — *The northern pits rise* (Baile gharbh). The crews at Baile gharbh and the northern pits rise in the same week, take the constable posts at Muileann shean and Tobar ghorm, and send the constables south on foot.
- 9 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 149** — *The coal road cut* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). Aonghas, keeper of An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, shuts the gates of the house across the coal road, and the men in its loft come down armed. The road between the capital and the hills is cut at its half-way stage, and stays cut.
- 17 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 149** — *Uilleam Gobha's forge* (Muileann dhearg). At Muileann dhearg the smith Uilleam Gobha makes the Company's own blasting-powder into grenades cased in tin from the coal sheds, and forges pike-heads from rails torn up in the galleries. The rebels' council writes that without him it could not have fought its first season.
- 18 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 149** — *The capital rises* (Cathair dhearg). At Cathair dhearg the custodians break the Residency's locks on their council hall and sit in it again. The townsfolk hold Drochaid Cathair dhearg²⁰ against the constables sent up from the harbour, and barricade the bridge built for the coal-carts with the carts themselves.
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 149** — *Cathair dhombhain joins* (Cathair dhomhain). At Cathair dhomhain the townsfolk break open the Company's warehouse, the first building on Dia-thìr the Company ever owned, and carry off its tools for the council's companies.
- 19 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 149** — *Muileann mbin takes sides* (Muileann mhin). At Muileann mhin, a river port just east of the capital, the townsfolk argue for three days, and then send boats to the council. Through the winter the boats carry food down the Abhainn fhionn to the capital.

18. ← Follows from *The quay at Ceann fhada seized*, 24 an Cèitean, AE 149.

19. the meeting on the moor road

20. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 149** — *The Residency fortified* (Ros dhomhain). Lionel Strake draws the Administration back into the Residency above Ros dhomhain and fortifies the Company's quarter of the harbour. The city below, Dia-thirich almost to a man, neither joins the rising nor withstands it, and the constables do not trust it enough to leave the walls.
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 149** — *The fight at the ford of Àth Chiar* (Àth Chiar). A column of constables and Company guards under Major Peter Ashdown marches up the coal road to relieve the hills, and is met at the ford of Àth Chiar, where the rebels hold the far bank. Ashdown loses forty men and his baggage and turns back. The rebels lose nineteen, and the council's roll names them all.
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 149** — *The turnip cart to the ford* (Àth Chiar). A cart with a false floor of turnips carries Uilleam Gobha's grenades up the cut coal road to the crews waiting at the ford of Àth Chiar, the first of his work to leave Muileann dhearg for open fighting.²¹
- 7 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 149** — *The nineteen of Àth Chiar buried* (Coinneachadh a' Mhonaidh²²). The council's clerk Fionnuala writes down by lamp-light the names of the nineteen dead of Àth Chiar and reads the list aloud the next morning; within the week they are buried on the moor above Cnoc naomh, within sight of the cairn raised there before the fighting began.²³
- 3 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 150** — *Ashdown's retreat through Dùn chrom* (Dùn chrom). Ashdown's column falls back through Dùn chrom and lies a night at the barracks there. In the morning the town has shut its gates behind them, and the column goes on to the coast without its wounded, whom the townsfolk keep and nurse.
- 15 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 150** — *The silver town rises* (Muileann Chiar). The silver guild of Muileann Chiar declares for the council and opens its armoury, and the Company's agents in the town are escorted to the coast with their papers. The guild's ledger notes that here alone the rising took nothing, for the humans had never held anything there to take.
- 17 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 150** — *The surrender at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). The small constable post at Dùn ìseal, cut off by the rising at the silver town, yields to the silver guild's riflemen after a single exchange of fire. The east of the island is clear of human arms.
- 27 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 150** — *Dùn dhearg declares* (Dùn dhearg). The custodians of Dùn dhearg declare for the council and send it grain. Theirs is the town whose custodian wrote the only surviving defence of the Small-Burning Law, and their declaration quotes it.
- 1 AN GEARRAN, AE 150** — *Cnoc leathan's riflemen* (Cnoc leathan). Riflemen raised at Cnoc leathan in the east join the silver guild's companies and hold the eastern road. The Company's carters on the road are let go home with their carts.

21. ← Follows from *The fight at the ford of Àth Chiar*, 5 an Dùbhlachd, AE 149.

22. the meeting on the moor road

23. ← Follows from *The fight at the ford of Àth Chiar*, 5 an Dùbhlachd, AE 149.

- 13 AN GEARRAN, AE 150** — *The eastern pits at Ros fhionn* (Ros fhionn). The crews of the eastern workings about Ros fhionn stop the pumps and walk out, and the lower galleries flood. The Company's engineers there go down the Abhainn chaol and take ship at Seann Mhòrn for Ros dhomhain. The bridge on the eastern coal road falls silent.
- 15 AN GEARRAN, AE 150** — *Seann Toll shelled* (Seann Toll). A Company steamship comes up the Abhainn uaine and shells the coal stage at Seann Toll to deny it to the rebels, and sets the fishing town behind it burning. Twenty-three townsfolk die. For the first time the humans turn the island's own coal, burning in their boilers, against a town of the Dia-thìrich.
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, AE 150** — *The Leaden Hawk company* (Cuan dhearg). At An Cupa Dàna, the inn at Cuan dhearg, seven hawk-faithful crewmen of the river towns wait nine hours for the council's letters to the Hawk coast, and leave with them at dark. Each wears a hawk cast in lead from the cartridges taken at the store at Muileann chrom, and they are called Buidheann an t-Seabhaig Luaidhe²⁴, the Leaden Hawk company.
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, AE 150** — *The Leaden Hawk walks to the Hawk coast* (Cnoc bheag). The company goes on foot and lightly laden: past the burned stage at Seann Toll, through Baile thais, over the hills by Achadh dhomhain and Cuan bheag, down the Abhainn ìseal by Ceann òg and Inis ìseal to Cnoc bheag, and along the Hawk coast by Inis bhàn, Ros gheal and Seann Skell to Inis mhin, some fifty-five miles in a little over two days. At every hawk-house on the way they read the council's letter aloud, and at Seann Skell they leave it with Ìomhar Seabhag.
- 22 AN GIBLEAN, AE 150** — *Rumours at Inis mhin* (Inis mhin). At Inis mhin, the northern landing the humans had walled, the company lies twelve hours in a boat-shed and hears that Strake's constables ride the western roads out of Ros bheag every day. They hire a carriage of a carter of the town and leave the roads altogether.
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, AE 150** — *The watch in the grasslands* (Tobar dhomhain). A day and a half by carriage across country, off every road, brings the company to the grasslands above Tobar dhomhain in the western hills. They lie eleven hours in the long grass above the road from Ros bheag to the northern concession and count the constables' riders who pass. Their own list gives forty-one riders, none of them going north.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, AE 150** — *The Leaden Hawk at Inis thais* (Inis thais). A day and a half more by carriage, still off the roads, brings the company down to Inis thais, six days after it left Cuan dhearg. The priests of Òrd na Cloiche²⁵ hear the council's letter in the temple of the Stone. They will send no men, but they shut the harbour of Inis thais to the Company's ships and give the hawk-faithful the use of the Fianna's roads. There the Leaden Hawk's road ends, and its seven join the hawk company when it is mustered at the western Seann Skell.

24. the Leaden Hawk company; lit. 'the company of the leaden hawk'

25. the order of the Stone

- 29 AN GIBLEAN, AE 150** — *Coaling from Inis mhòr* (Inis mhòr). The Company's steamships take their fuel from the coal stacked on the quays of Inis mhòr, the river port just east of the capital, whose barges carry it down the Abhainn fhionn to the ships at Cathair dhomhain. The townsfolk set the stacks alight. The ships put in at Ros dhomhain instead, and burn their own stores.
- 10 AN CÈITEAN, AE 150** — *The fishermen of Seann Chwen* (Seann Chwen). Fishing boats of Seann Chwen and Ros ruadh, sailing by night along the south coast, board a Company coaster at anchor and burn her. The Company draws its coastal shipping back to the harbours of Ros dhomhain and Ros bheag.
- 11 AN CÈITEAN, AE 150** — *The other Seann Chwen* (Seann Chwen). The fishermen of the other Seann Chwen, further west on the south coast, join the raids along the shore. The rolls tell the two towns apart by the names of their boats.
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, AE 150** — *Cathair gheal behind its walls* (Cathair gheal). The human town of Cathair gheal in the northern concession shuts its gates and raises a militia, but sends none of it south to the Residency. Its magistrate writes to both sides asking to be left alone. The council grants it; Strake does not answer.
- 28 AN CÈITEAN, AE 150** — *Muileann àrsaidh closes its road* (Muileann àrsaidh). Muileann àrsaidh, a town of the concession, blocks its road with carts and keeps a watch on it against both sides. No one attacks it. The watch is kept to the end of the war.
- 5 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 150** — *The hawk-shrines open* (Seann Skell). From the shrine at Seann Skell Ìomhar Seabhag declares that the war is Mòd's own hunger turned back on those who fed it. The hawk-shrines of the west become mustering houses, and a company of the hawk-faithful marches south to join the council.
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 150** — *The hawk company at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). The company of the hawk-faithful is mustered at Seann Skell, the western city, a short march north-east of the human port of Ros bheag. It holds the road between Ros bheag and the north-west for the rest of the war.
- 9 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 150** — *The southern beacon dark* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg²⁶). The keepers at Tobar dhearg put out the beacon, and the keepers at Àth dhearg and Baile ìseal do the same. Company ships feeling their way along the coast by night run on the reefs the beacons were built to light, and two are lost.
- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 150** — *No relief from over the sea* (Muir Mhanannain²⁷). The Administration's letter-books ask again and again for troops and ships from an Tìr Thall²⁸. In the whole first year of the war one ship comes, with dispatches and a few crates of cartridges, and sails again within the week.

26. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

27. Manannan's sea, round Dia-thìr

- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 150** — *The lines at midsummer* (Ros dhomhain). The lines stand at midsummer where the first winter of the war left them: the council holds the hills, the east and the capital; Strake holds the Residency, the harbour quarter below it, and the western ports. Neither side has the strength to attack the other.
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 150** — *Grain from Seann Warr* (Seann Warr). Seann Warr, the farming town in the south-east and not the salt port of that name in the west, has sent grain to the hills by the eastern roads since the winter. The council's roll lists the carts.
- 8 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 150** — *Hunger in the capital* (Cathair dhearg). Its harbour held by the Residency, Cathair dhearg has gone short since the winter. The custodians share out the grain by household, and the roll records that they took the same share as everyone else.
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 150** — *The burning of the tithe-books*. In three raids the rebels destroy the tithe ledgers of the humans' Administration. Later chroniclers make much of it; it did little.
- 5 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 150** — *The counting-house at Ros dhombhain* (Ros dhomhain). The first raid was on the Company's counting-house at the Ros dhomhain quay, within the lines. Men of the harbour quarter under Dùghall Dubh came in over the roofs, carried the tithe books into the yard and burned them.²⁹
- 5 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 150** — *The night clerk of the counting-house is taken without a blow* (Ros dhomhain). The counting-house's night clerk is found sitting on its steps in his shirt with his hands laced over his head before the raiders reach the ground floor, and Dùghall Dubh judges, from the look of him, that some part of the man had waited a year for the night to come.³⁰
- 6 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 150** — *The tithe-house at Ceann àrsaidh* (Ceann àrsaidh). The second raid burned the Administration's tithe-house at Ceann àrsaidh, where the share owed by every settlement in the hills had been entered since the first schedule. The clerks were let go. The custodians of Ceann àrsaidh asked that one ledger be spared for the record, and their own people refused them.
- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 150** — *The weigh-house at Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). The third raid burned the Company's weigh-house at Muileann chrom with its steelyard ledgers, where the coal of the hills had been entered by the ton since the first contract. The rebels' own chronicler writes that the fire burned green.
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 150** — *The fight at Cnoc ghorm* (Cnoc ghorm). Company guards and constables sallying from the capital's harbour to win back the eastern road are driven back at Cnoc ghorm, in the hills beyond the capital. It is the Administration's last attempt in the war to reach the mining district.

28. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

29. ← Leads to *The night clerk of the counting-house is taken without a blow*, 5 an Lùnastal, AE 150.

- 4 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 150** — *The harbour quarter changes sides* (Ros dhomhain). After the raid on the counting-house the Dia-thìrich of the Ros dhomhain harbour quarter open the lower gates to the council's companies, and Strake is left holding only the Residency and the Company's quays. The same night men of the quarter burn the Company's flying machine in its shed above the town. It had not flown since the war began, for want of the spirit its engine burned, and nothing has flown over Dia-thìr since that was not a bird.
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 150** — *Cuan uaine opens its quays* (Cuan uaine). The river quays of Cuan uaine, east of the capital, open to the council's boats. With them and the harbour quarter of Ros dhomhain both lost, the Residency can be fed only by water, up the Abhainn gheal from the sea.
- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 150** — *Strake forsakes the Residency* (Ros dhomhain). Lionel Strake leaves the Residency by water, down the Abhainn gheal, with his officers, the Mission's clergy and the Company's agents, and takes the Administration to Ros bheag. The council's companies enter the Residency the next morning and find it stripped of all but its furniture.
- 22 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 150** — *The letter-books found whole at the Residency* (Ros dhomhain). Where Strake has taken plate and account-papers down the river by night, Dùghall Dubh finds a room of the Residency's letter-books left standing untouched on an unlocked shelf, thirty years of the Administration's own correspondence with an Tìr Thall³¹, and sends word of it to the council's clerks that evening.³²
- 22 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 150** — *Prentice the counting-house clerk goes down the river* (Ros dhomhain). Dùghall Dubh learns from a clerk taken at the Residency that Prentice, who weighed coal beside him nine years at the counting-house scales, went down the river with Strake's household the night the Residency fell, leaving the ledgers he had kept behind as ash.³³
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 150** — *Ros bheag the last seat* (Ros bheag). At Ros bheag, the western port the humans had used since the early years, Strake sets up what is left of the Administration. The human families of the west and south, a few thousand in all, gather behind its walls.
- 3 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 150** — *Outposts at Ros àrsaidh* (Ros àrsaidh). Strake posts constables at Ros àrsaidh, north of Ros bheag, to hold the coast road, Ceum Ros àrsaidh. The townsfolk bring them food and news, and the news is always a day old.
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 150** — *Hunger in Ros bheag* (Ros bheag). The roads cut and no ships coming from over the sea, Ros bheag runs short of food within months. By Strake's order the Company's stores are opened to the human families and the Dia-thìrich townsfolk alike, the one deed of his the Dia-thìrich rolls give him credit for.

30. ← Follows from *The counting-house at Ros dhomhain*, 5 an Lùnastal, AE 150.

31. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

32. ← Follows from *Strake forsakes the Residency*, 21 an t-Sultain, AE 150.

33. ← Follows from *Strake forsakes the Residency*, 21 an t-Sultain, AE 150.

- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 150** — *Cuan shean refuses the humans* (Cuan shean). The custodians of Cuan shean, where the first humans came ashore, shut its harbour to Company ships. The council's roll sets it down and says no more.
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 150** — *The families of Baile dhìreach* (Baile dhìreach). At Baile dhìreach each side asks the children of the old joint council, many of them of both peoples, which they are. Most of them, it is written, would not answer, and neither side made them.
- 1 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 150** — *The last ship from the east* (Muir Mhanannain³⁴). The last ship known to come from an Tìr Thall³⁵ anchors at Ros bheag at Samhain. She brings no troops and no grain, only a sealed letter for the Commissioner, and sails again on the next tide with as many passengers as she can hold.
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 150** — *The truce of Àth àrsaidh* (Àth àrsaidh). Envoys of the council and of the Administration meet at Àth àrsaidh, on the edge of the northern concession, and agree a truce: the humans left on Dia-thìr shall withdraw into the north-west under the council's safe-conduct, and the council shall leave the towns of the concession standing.
- 20 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 150** — *Baile Mòr ruadh receives the columns* (Baile Mòr ruadh). The truce names Baile Mòr ruadh, the greatest town of the north-west, as the place where the columns will be received. Its Dia-thìrich folk are given the choice of staying or going south. The roll gives the numbers of each, and they are close.
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 150** — *The columns go north* (Cuan shean). The human families of Ros bheag, Cuan shean, Baile dhìreach and the south-west march north along the western roads under guard of the council's companies. Few of them had ever lived in the north. The roll records that no column was attacked, and none was helped.
- 30 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 150** — *The columns at Àth chrom* (Àth chrom). The columns cross the ford at Àth chrom on their way north. The custodians of the town stand at the ford and count them over, and it is the last count the Dia-thìrich make of the humans on Dia-thìr in this age.
- 1 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 150** — *Àth leathan* (Àth leathan). At Àth leathan, the last stage before the northern country, the columns camp for a night. The custodians of the town write that the humans asked the name of the place, and that several of them wrote it down.
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 150** — *The ship that sailed east* (Cuan shean). Lionel Strake, the last Commissioner, sails from Cuan shean for an Tìr Thall³⁶ with his officers in the last ship on the island able to make the crossing. The keeper at Taigh-solais Baile chrom³⁷ sets down her passing in his daybook. Nothing on Dia-thìr tells of her coming anywhere.

34. Manannan's sea, round Dia-thìr

35. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

36. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

37. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 150** — *The beacons relit* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom³⁸). The council orders the five beacons lit again, from Baile chrom round to Tobar dhearg. The keepers' daybooks, which had counted human ships since the ring was finished, are still kept, with nothing in them.
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 150** — *The rolls sent to Muileann chaol* (Muileann chaol). The custodians send what survives of the rolls of the age, their copies of the petitions, the book of Baile thais and the letter-books left in the Residency, to the cellars at Muileann chaol. What the Administration's own clerks carried west with Strake is not known.
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 150** — *Coinneach Beag puts his name forward* (Cuan dhearg). When the crew-leaders of the river towns ask for seven men who can keep their feet on a hill road and hold their tongues, Coinneach Beag, a boatman of Cuan dhearg raised on the river since boyhood and no stranger to the Company's rule over his own family, puts his name forward before he has properly decided to.³⁹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 150** — *The letter read at a nameless hawk-house* (Seann Toll). On the road past Seann Toll, Coinneach Beag reads the council's letter aloud in a bare hawk-house of six benches, his voice unsteady at first; an old woman by the fire answers only that it has come to that, and no one else speaks.⁴⁰
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 150** — *The boy of Baile thais shows the wall* (Baile thais). Passing through Baile thais, the Leaden Hawk company is shown by a boy of nine or ten the marks on the store's outer wall from the siege's eleven days, told with more pride than fear, the town's memory of its own fight already settling into telling.⁴¹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 150** — *Eilidh Hale will not choose* (Baile dhìreach). Asked on the steps of the council hall at Baile dhìreach which people she is, Eilidh Hale, who has kept the joint council's books three winters running, answers only that she keeps the books, and no more. She is neither pressed further nor turned away, and stays in the town through the rest of the war.⁴²
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 150** — *Hannah Webb walks north* (Cuan shean). Hannah Webb, who keeps her vigil behind Baile chrom and nursed at Cathair gheal through the fever, walks out to meet the columns at the concession's southern edge and walks back north with them, an old woman of the last families out of Cuan shean on her arm who will not be carried.⁴³

38. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

39. ← Follows from *The Leaden Hawk company*, 19 an Giblean, AE 150.

40. ← Follows from *The Leaden Hawk walks to the Hawk coast*, 21 an Giblean, AE 150.

41. ← Follows from *The siege of the store at Baile thais*, 1 an t-Ògmhios, AE 149.

42. ← Follows from *The families of Baile dhìreach*, 31 an Dàmhair, AE 150.

43. ← Follows from *The columns go north*, 29 an t-Samhain, AE 150.

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 150 — *The keys given up at Cuan shean* (Cuan shean). The harbour officers of Ceann mhòr, Cathair gheal and Inis àrsaidh ride two days south with their towns' chests of harbour keys and set them at Strake's feet on the quay at Cuan shean before his ship sails, saying only that the accounts are even and that who wants the keys after is not theirs to decide. Strake takes the chests aboard with him.⁴⁴

44. ← Follows from *The ship that sailed east*, 5 an Dùbhlachd, AE 150.

THE YEARS AE 151 – 151

I AM FAOILLEACH, AE 151 — *The Severance*. The war ends, and the crossing itself is shut: whatever way let the humans reach Dia-thìr closes. The humans still on the island are led into the northern country that their children's children hold to this day. Cian and Lorccan, not yet twenty, grow up in the wake of it.

PART EIGHT

A Gazetteer of the Age

A

Achadh àrsaidh (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 14 am Màrt, FE 603. The field village on the far western shore sent out the boats that first met the three ships, under the steersman Lachlann Odhar, who sent word home and went on south to Cuan shean. Its people told the story of that morning longer than any roll kept it, and they fished the same waters under the Sea-Watcher through all the years the strangers held the coast. Gorta Baile chrom¹, the Great Hunger that began in the north-west in the ninety-fourth year, reached it in its second winter and emptied many of its houses, and in the drought years a decade after it was named among the ten districts of the drought country. The houses stand close to the sea-wall, and the steersman's boat was kept drawn up on the shingle under them for as long as anyone remembered whose it had been. Known for the boats that met the strangers.

Achadh chaol (Muileann dhomhain). Founded 5 an Dùbhlachd, AE 137 by the dispossessed of the closed district. The narrow field was built by the people of the district the Company fenced and closed after the Rending of Cill ghlas, on common ground lent them by the custodians of Muileann dhomhain. They raised it through a spring and summer without a single Company surveyor setting foot on it: a well dug first, then the custodian's house, then the households in the order their names were drawn at the stone. Its shrine-keepers lit a new lamp without the old keeper's name on it. It stands on the edge of the fenced ground, and from its well the wire of the closed district can be seen along the slope. Known for a village built without a surveyor.

Achadh dhomhain (Muileann chrom). Founded 10 an t-Ògmhios, FE 272. The large farming village in the deep fields above the workings became a camp when the new galleries were opened into its hill, and it was the worst place on the hill in the spotted pox. Beitris Bhàn laid out its dead at her own table, the washing-women first said there that the girl of the spoil-houses did not grow, and Anne Colby kept her sick-house of canvas there through the Green Death, which began among its huts. Walter Crane walked its sick-rows. Its granaries fed the camps for a century. The feather Beitris Bhàn nailed over her own door was copied on doors across the camps as fast as the overseers pulled them down, and the roll of the camp keeps the first cases of the Green Death under her name. Known for the camp where the Green Death began.

Achadh mhòr (Achadh mhòr). Founded 2 an t-Samhain, GE 4,000. The granary of the east keeps the shared-meal custom of An Aois Naomh². In the years before the war the Lamp-Watch's ledgers of the money it had from the silver guild were kept in the roof-space of its shrine, above the rafters, and no Company clerk ever thought to look for them there. It is one of the largest settlements on the island though it is still called a field village, and its grain went to the capital in the siege year. Known for the ledgers in the shrine roof.

1. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

2. the Holy Age

Achadh shean (Achadh shean). Founded 21 an Giblean, GE 3,125. The old field gave its name to the Long Drought, which lay on the east from the hundred and sixth year to the hundred and tenth. Its wells failed a month before any other, its custodian wrote to Iseabail nic Leòid at Àth mhòr twice a week, and in the third year the Mission sank deep wells there with a boring-rig from an Tìr Thall³, and they held. The custodians set the Mission's wells and the Company's tallies on facing pages without comment. It stands at the heart of the farming country south and east of the cape, and in the first dry year its custodian wrote that the granaries of the old custom would carry them through the winter, which they did, once. Known for the Long Drought and the Mission's wells.

Àth àrsaidh (Àth àrsaidh). Founded 12 an t-Samhain, GE 3,458. The ancient ford in the north-west, on the edge of the country the humans first settled, is where the envoys of the council and of the Administration met in its meeting-house in the last week of an Dàmhair of the hundred and fiftieth year, with two scribes writing the same words in two hands, and agreed the truce: the humans to withdraw into the north-west under safe-conduct, and the towns of that country to be left standing. The meeting-house has a single long table down its middle, and both copies of the truce were signed at it on the third day. Known for the truce.

Àth chiar (Àth shean). Founded 21 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,362. The ford town east of the capital is where the coal road crossed the river before climbing into the hills. In the spring of the hundred and forty-ninth year Major Peter Ashdown turned his relief column north about An Taigh-seinnse Mòr to cross there, and met the crews of Baile thais dug in along the willow scrub of the far bank. His column went into the ford waist-high and in poor order, lost forty men to the river and the fire and all its baggage, and went back. The rebels lost nineteen, whose names the council's clerk read aloud once. The field of Muileann ghlas lies to its south-west. The Company's baggage abandoned on the near bank went up the hill road on the rebels' carts that night. Known for the fight at the ford.

Àth chrom (Muileann naomh). Founded 3 an t-Iuchar, LE 989. The drovers' town at the bent ford was one of the two where the Mission sank deep wells in the drought years, and they held. In the last weeks of the age its custodians stood at the ford and counted the columns over, family by family, from first light until past noon; it was the last count the Dia-thìrich made of the humans on Dia-thìr in the age. Its people are drovers, and the ford is crossed by the drove road north. Known for the last count.

3. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

Àth dhearg (Cnoc gheal). Founded 19 an Dùbhlachd, FE 364. The red ford-town on the north-eastern cape kept a fire on a shelf of the headland for its boats long before any roll, and when the humans asked for a tower there the custodian went round every hearth to ask leave, which took eleven days. The mason Tormod mac Pheadair built the tower and kept it, and began in it the first daybook of the five lights, so plain that the Company's clerk who read it called its keeper civil but of no assistance. On a night of gale in the forty-sixth year the light brought four boats of Àth dhearg home off the long lines. In the war its light went dark with the others of the south, and was lit again at the truce. A clerk of A' Chompanaidh⁴ rode up the coast road in the dark days of Dubhlas to ask to see the daybook about the burning of a collier, and went away with nothing. Known for the first keeper's daybook.

Àth fhiadhaich (Àth fhiadhaich). Founded 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 4,325. The ford town of the south-eastern hills, at the meeting of the Abhainn gheal and the Abhainn bhàn, sent its boatmen's sons as runners for the Lamp-Watch in the years before the war, boys of twelve and thirteen who carried the letters from An Sli-geanach Fad' às⁵ to the silver town along the causeway paths, too young for the constables to stop and too quick for a mounted man to follow. It has been a river landing since An Aois Naomh⁶, and its boatmen's causeway paths across the flood-meadows are known to no map. Known for the Lamp-Watch's runners.

Àth fhionn (Àth fhionn). Founded 26 an Giblean, FE 900. The fair ford at the crossing of the southern drove road sent its custodian Ruairidh mac Thormoid to Ceann àrsaidh in the ninety-eighth year, the eldest of the nineteen who signed the petition, born before the humans' coin was struck; he signed last and slowest. Human fishers of the concession had taught its boats to take whales with the hand-lance, and the oil went to the Company's lamps. It has been a resting place for herds and drovers since An Aois Naomh⁷, and its people keep the ancestor rite of the old roads. Known for the eldest signature.

Àth ghlas (Àth ghlas). Founded 12 an t-Iuchar, FE 373. The grey ford beside Cathair mhòr is remembered for Sine Ruadh, custodian in the Green Death, who ordered every hut where a death had been burned with its bedding. The Company protested the loss of its property, and the custodians noted that the sickness stopped sooner at Àth ghlas than anywhere else. The story was still told by grandparents in the fever years sixty years later. It lies a short way from the ruin of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire⁸, which is older than any dwelling of the Dia-thìrich, and the huts it burned were never rebuilt on the same ground. Known for the burning of the huts.

4. the Company

5. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

6. the Holy Age

7. the Holy Age

8. the watch-fort ruin

Àth iséal (Muileann chrom). Founded 7 an t-Iuchar, LE 324. The low ford below the new workings became the first of A' Chompanaidh⁹'s camps: timber huts where the ferry-men had always put the carts across in the wet season, and a Company store where the clerk had no book for cheese. The families who came down from Doire mhòr and the hill villages went to its huts, and the spotted pox and the fever were worst among them. Its roll was the one in which the line of Aisling was first found. The ford floods every wet season and the ferry-men still put the carts across, and the camp grew into a town of rows beside the old crossing. Its chaplain in the spotted pox wrote every dead man, woman and child in a fair hand. Known for the first Company camp.

Àth leathan (Seann Skell). Founded 8 am Màrt, LE 1,303. The drovers' village at the wide ford was the last stage before the northern country. The columns camped a night in its fields below the town with their fires strung along the hedgerow, and several of the humans asked the custodians the name of the place and wrote it down; a woman brought to bed under a hedge that night asked it twice and gave it to her child. It had been a gathering place for the drovers of the north since before the strangers came, and the fields where the columns camped were grazing again by the spring. Known for the name written down.

B

Baile chrom (Baile chrom). Founded 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,464. The bent town on the far north-western coast stands beside Taigh-solais Baile chrom¹, the last of the five lights built and the first as the ring is counted. Uisdean mac Lachlainn kept it from its lighting in the ninety-first year and his son Lachlann after him, and the daybook there first wrote the three words *Cha tàinig long*. Gorta Baile chrom², the Great Hunger, took its name from the town in the ninety-fourth year. Hannah Webb kept her night vigil in the fields behind it from the hundred and thirty-third year, and the grey fever settled hardest round it. Lachlann watched the last Commissioner's ship stand out past its headland. The Levy that built its tower was set aside in the famine districts in the hunger years, too late for the harvest, and never used again. Known for its light, and the Great Hunger.

9. the Company

1. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

2. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

Baile dhireach (Inis thais). Founded 14 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,392. The straight town on the west coast took in the first human families to settle beside the Dia-thìrich rather than apart from them. Samuel Hale tightened herring barrels on its quay, Torcall the mason witnessed in its Dia-thìreach book, and a marriage was made there in two tongues. The town was governed for a long season by a joint council of both peoples, six of each, and lost its harbour dues to the Company in the years of the Levy. Thomas Hale first set his name to paper against the Administration here. In the last autumn each side asked the children of the old council which people they were, and most would not answer; Eilidh Hale kept the books and stayed. Its quay is a single long street down to the water, and the humans' slip where the first boat was launched stood at its foot. The storm of the wolf-moon drowned men of both peoples off its harbour in one night, and both were lit for at the lamps of the drowned. Known for the joint council and its children.

Baile dhomhain (Muileann chrom). Founded 10 am Faoilleach, AE 34. The camp town of the deep workings was laid out on the Company's paper before a stone of it was cut, in straight rows, the first town of the Dia-thìrich drawn by a surveyor. Two of its streets came down in the year of the edict of seizure for a spoil-tip, and the families took huts at Àth iséal or went to kin in the hill villages. Most of its hewers came from the camps at Àth iséal and Achadh dhomhain, and the grid of its streets was the pattern for every camp the Company drew after it. Known for its streets drawn on paper.

Baile fhiadhach (Baile fhiadhach). Founded 17 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,709. The harbour town up the western coast heard of the three ships within two days of their coming, and its custodian rode south to see them. In the first years of the strangers Torcall the mason set a new stone face on its harbour wall, and when a human supply-brig broke on the reefs south of the town its custodian gave the drowned ground above the tide-line among the dunes. The town kept that ground apart for the strangers' dead for the rest of the age. The custodian who rode south in the first year to see the ships wrote the only account of them from the western coast, and it was her successor who asked Torcall to mend the wall. Known for the strangers' graves in the dunes.

Baile ghorm (Baile ghorm). Founded 22 an Gearran, FE 837. The open market town of the south-eastern farms has no walls. Its potteries took a contract in the years of the night shift for clay lamp-bodies for the night crews, thousands in a year, and the potters' own book notes that they were the first lamps made on the island for work in the dark by command. Its people kept the Old Spirits through the age. Its fairs bring the south-eastern farms' grain and wool, and its potters kept working the same clay for household crocks when the contract ended. Known for the night crews' lamps.

Baile Mòr ruadh (Àth àrsaidh). Founded 3 an Gearran, FE 2,252. The red walled city of the north-west, the greatest town of that country, had lived under the humans' governance longer than any other on the island. The truce named it the place where the columns would be received, and its own Dia-thìrich folk were given the choice, at a gathering in the market square, of staying under the truce or going south. The roll set the two numbers side by side, and they were close. It was held by Dia-thìreach lords from An Aois Naomh³, and the humans' magistrates sat in its hall for most of the age. Known for the choice put to its people.

Baile Mòr ruadh (Seann Tarr). Founded 15 an Lùnastal, GE 3,311. The walled city of red stone suffered worst from the fever of foul water that followed the drought into the towns, for its wells had been deepened into the old middens; seventeen died. Coll, the Mission's young physician there, tested the water and was the first to name the cause rightly. Its citadel is the strongest place of its province, and after the drought its custodians had the old midden ground walled off and the wells sunk anew outside it. Known for Coll's report on the water.

Baile thais (Muileann dhearg). Founded 5 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,086. The pit town where the Abhainn uaine leaves the hills was the heart of the crews' own long resistance. The eleven days of its great strike in the seventy-seventh year won what the crews could win, and its roll kept Sìneag's search for an old law of rest. Its burial club became the Lamp-Watch, which kept a purse, a book and the copies of every petition; Eilidh nic Raghnaill led a crew there and kept the book. The Company walled its pithead, and in the first days of the war its constables held the walls eleven days until the well ran dry, and were marched to the coast unharmed on Eilidh's word. The Company's granary built there against a stoppage was the first on the hill, and the overseer's clerk who copied the forbidden song kept his copy in its roll. Its boats have been launched at the landing since before any roll. Known for the eleven days, twice over.

C

Caol ìseal (Caol ìseal). Founded 21 am Màrt, FE 1,450. The harbour on the low strait of the north coast has salt pans that supply the northern fisheries. The blasting-powder for the new deep galleries was landed there in the hundred and thirty-sixth year, away from the crowded southern harbours, and carted inland under guard; the custodians asked what was in the barrels and were told it was lamp-oil. It keeps the ancestor rite of the old coast, and its custodians wrote the lamp-oil into their roll with the weight the carters said the barrels had. Known for the barrels of lamp-oil.

Caol leathan (Caol leathan). Founded 12 am Faoilleach, GE 1,560. The town on the wide strait took its tolls from the strangers' shipping as it had from the western pilots, and for two generations its merchants sold wool by the Company's weight and at the Company's price. When the humans' ships thinned in the years before the war, the wool piled in its warehouses and the merchants quietly began to sell inland again, against the letter of the law. By the war its harbour stood idle. The tally-book of Pike's post named its merchants the hardest bargainers on the island, since they would take only iron by weight for their wool, and they sent the first wool-ship to the humans' post in the treaty's second year. Known for wool, and its idle harbour.

Caol mhin (Caol mhin). Founded 17 am Màrt, FE 1,345. The harbour of the calm strait was chosen by Tolley in his first month as Commissioner for a quarantine station, holding every ship from an Tìr Thall¹ offshore until a physician had looked her crew over. It was the first order of his rule the Dia-thìrich approved, and they said so. Its quays stand on Eilean chrom across the strait, and the physician's boat went out from them to every ship that came in under the quarantine. Known for the quarantine station.

Caol mhòr (Caol mhòr). Founded 31 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,462. The harbour of the great strait in the far north-west, near where the strangers first raised the land, took the first tally of the Levy, when the officers read the names of the chosen from a list in the humans' tongue and took the wrong son. The custodians wrote the names again in Dia-thìris, that they might know whom to look for. Its grief was loud and short, as a first grief is. Its yards took timber for the Company's hulls, and the Levy's officers used its quay as their first station in the north-west. Known for the wrong son.

Cathair dhearg (Cathair dhearg). Founded 6 an Dàmhair, GE 18. The capital held the Council of Custodians through all the years of the strangers, and the council's roll is the spine of the age's record. Here Gormshuil nic Fhearchair and the priest Samuel Wren made the first lists of words across a table, with a cup and a loaf; here the treaty was read in one tongue and signed, and here the council sat without a high custodian for ten years. When Lionel Strake came the Residency locked the council hall and took its keys, and the custodians sat on the floor of Macha's temple for two years. In the spring of the hundred and forty-ninth year the townsfolk broke the locks with a coal-hammer, held the Company's bridge with overturned carts, and fed the city from a sharing-yard behind the hall through the siege that followed. Its bells were rehung in a new frame by Torcall the mason in the first years. Tormod mac Ailein, high custodian when the ships came, was buried in the town, and Artair mac Iain was seated after the chair had stood empty ten years. Known for the council roll, and the sharing-yard of the siege year.

Cathair dhomhain (Cathair dhomhain). Founded 25 an t-Iuchar, FE 634. The deep city on the lake shore, five miles from the capital by the lake road, holds the first building the strangers ever owned outright on Dia-thìr: the stone warehouse Pike raised there in the treaty's first summer to keep A' Chompanaidh²'s tools out of reach of the harbour thieves of Ros dhomhain. The Company's surgeon came to its sick only once in the strangers' fever, and it was here that Anne Colby first wrote the dead by name. In the rising the townsfolk broke the warehouse open and carried off its rope, nails and powder for the council's companies, and left its doors swinging. The fishing town runs down to the shore beside the capital's deep water, and the old folk there said the warehouse door was the first door on the island ever hung with a lock the town could not open. Known for the strangers' first warehouse.

Cathair fhada (Cathair fhada). Founded 13 an Cèitean, GE 2,523. The long walled city of the south follows Macha, and its oak woods had been cut for the Company's pit-props since the first contracts. The age's rolls note the day the last oak of its own cutting came down, and the priests of Macha who would not stand for the blessing of the coin were many of them its people. Its priests of Macha were the first to refuse to stand for the blessing of the humans' coin in the capital's temple, and many of them followed the dissenters to the forest. Known for the oaks that went for pit-props.

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland
2. the Company

Cathair gheal (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 5 an Màrt, GE 1,378. The walled city of white stone on the far western coast was a Dia-thìreach town until the human families of the northern concession made it their market in the fiftieth year. Its Mission kept a chapel and, in the fever years, a hospital where Dia-thìrich and human sick lay side by side for the first time because there was no longer room to keep them apart; Hannah Webb nursed in its wards. In the war it shut its gates, raised a militia that went nowhere, and its magistrate asked both sides to be left alone. Its harbour officer rode south with his town's keys at the end. Obadiah Renn, the minister of its Mission, sat with Hannah Webb in the chapel over her vigil, and wrote of it to the Mission's house at Cathair dhearg. Known for the concession's market and the shared wards.

Cathair mhòr (Cathair mhòr). Founded 9 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,847. The great city below the old ruin refused the mark when it was first made law, and went on paying in kind at its market for a season after the rest of the country had given in. The grey fever came to it in the high summer of the hundred and thirty-eighth year, and for the first time in the town's memory the market shut, stall by stall; the longest list of dead in the roll was the street of the carters. It keeps below its walls the ruin of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire³, and the market that refused the coin gave way at last only when the Company's tool-sellers would not cross its bridge for anything else. Known for the refusal of the mark.

Ceann àrsaidh (Ceann àrsaidh). Founded 17 an t-Sultain, GE 4,328. The walled river city on the old headland over the Abhainn fhionn sent Eachann Mòr to the council for nine years, and he lost his seat for what he said in the hall and wrote a letter over the sea. In the ninety-eighth year its custodian Aonghas Ruadh called the custodians of nineteen settlements to its hall behind the market square, and after three days of argument they set their grievance down in the petition that Peigi Ghlas carried to Ros dhomhain. In the war its companies burned the tithe-house and every ledger in it, though its custodian asked that one be spared. Its barges run down the Abhainn fhionn to Cathair dhomhain, and the custodians of the east met in its hall again in the war before the companies went out. Known for the first petition.

Ceann fhada (Muileann chrom). Founded 27 an Cèitean, LE 1,359. The long spit on the Abhainn uaine, a short hour's walk under Doire mhòr, held its foreshore in common, and the first Company surveyors found it covered with their own men. A' Chompanaidh⁴ built its coal quay there, and for a century barges loaded the hill's coal for the coast. On the first day of the rising the crews took the quay and sank two loaded barges across its mouth; the boatman Pàdraig Reamhar knocked the plugs from a hull he had built with his own father. No coal left the hills by water again in the age. Its pilots guided the Company's barges through the shoals below the spit for a century, and the rivalry with Inis ìseal downstream went on untouched by all of it. Known for the barges sunk across its quay.

3. the watch-fort ruin

4. the Company

Ceann mhòr (Ceann mhòr). Founded 6 an Cèitean, FE 163. The great harbour under the north-western headland took in the first human fishing families of the concession in the fifty-first year, the first humans to fish the island's waters for their own living. Tobacco grew on the concession farms behind it. Manannan's priests kept the grey night on its quay, and Ruth Pallant, who taught Hannah Webb the night watch, lived near it. Gorta Baile chrom⁵ struck it hard. At the close of the age its harbour officer carried the town's chest of keys two days south to Cuan shean. Its harbour lies under the beacon of Taigh-solais Baile chrom⁶, and in the hunger years it sent what boats it had south along the coast for grain. Known for the concession fishers.

Cill dhìreach (Cill dhìreach). Founded 12 am Màrt, FE 2,599. The temple village of Macha at the edge of the workings kept a small shrine where the pit crews left the first piece of coal from every new gallery. The Company suffered the custom, since it cost a stone a gallery, and the shrine was one of the two pit-mouth shrines where the crews kept the old words of the rock face in the strangers' years. It lies beside Ceann leathan, where the old contest is still held each year, and its druids tended the shrine through the whole of the age without a Company quarrel. Known for the first-coal shrine.

Cill thais (Cill thais). Founded 15 an t-Samhain, FE 1,933. The large village on damp ground beside the sacred wood of Macha took in the orphans of the Eleven of Cnoc fhiadhaich, in a long house of stone with new thatch that its custodians made ready at the end of the street, and raised them. The wood behind it gave shelter in the last years to the priests who had left the capital's temple, and the forest council of the war sat among its fires. The long house the custodians made ready stood at the end of the street for the rest of the age, and the orphans raised there were counted in its roll as children of the town. Known for the orphans of the Eleven.

Cnoc àrsaidh (Cnoc àrsaidh). Founded 11 am Màrt, GE 2,405. The walled town of the Stone, where the panther road passes, did in the first fever years what the hills only talked of: it turned the fever back at its gates. The Administration fined it for hindering trade, and it paid the fine in wool, more sacks than the humans knew what to do with. Its priests kept the oldest shrines of Òrd na Cloiche⁷ open through all the age. Its wool fine was long told in the southwest as the one bargain the humans ever lost by weight. Known for the fine paid in wool.

Cnoc bheag (Cnoc bheag). Founded 5 an t-Sultain, GE 3,908. The river port of the north-central country and heart of the hawk-faithful asked the Mission for a copy of Wren's grammar in the thirteenth year, to read what the humans wrote of them; of all the copies that survive, theirs bears the most notes in the margins. In the war the Leaden Hawk slept a night in a byre near it on the road to the Hawk coast. It lies on the Abhainn ìseal, and its hawk-priests kept that copy in the temple where anyone who could read the humans' letters might ask to see it. Known for the most-read copy of Wren's grammar.

5. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

6. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

7. the order of the Stone

Cnoc chaol (Muileann dhearg). Founded 22 an Cèitean, GE 2,404. The narrow hill was a mining camp worked by night crews in the last decades of the age. Griogair mac Ailein died in the Company's lock-up there, held for a short-weighted cartload he did not cut, and Thomas Hale came to read the surgeon's note over his grave. The day shift stood in the yard in silence for the night crews, the Lamp-Watch's purse ran dry keeping the strikers fed, and the strike was broken by crews brought in through Muileann dhomhain. The lung-rot was worse there than on any other hill. In the hundred and forty-eighth year its overseer threw down his staff in the week Mòrag broke hers. Its crews were among the first to work by the clay lamps of Baile ghorm, and the pithead there was lit all night from the year the night shift began. Known for the night-shift strike.

Cnoc dhìreach (Cnoc dhìreach). Founded 21 an Lùnastal, FE 2,845. The walled seat of the eastern mining district was walled by the Administration after the strikes. Its custodian Coinneach Ruadh signed the second petition in the hundred and thirty-ninth year and was turned out of his clerkship at the Company store within the week, in front of the queue for the week's flour; he was one of eleven who signed and lost Company work for it, and he rode the district roads with news for the rest of the age. Its post as custodian Coinneach Ruadh kept eleven years before the petition, and he went on keeping it after he lost the clerkship. Known for the eleven who signed.

Cnoc dhubh (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 10 an t-Iuchar, FE 93. The black hill of the charcoal burners kept an old customary cutting held by one family since An Aois Naomh⁸. Under Dunstan's rule the working was taken from them because a great-grandmother of the line had married a human sailor, and the rolls of the hill set down that this was the whole of the reason given. It is the largest of the cluster of charcoal hills, and its people burned charcoal for the Company's smithies after the cutting was taken. Known for the cutting taken.

Cnoc fhiadhaich (Muileann chrom). Founded 17 an Màrt, LE 488. The wild hill in the middle country gave its name to the Eleven of Cnoc fhiadhaich, the crew of the first great fall, whose orphans went to Cill thais. Raghnaill asked three times for timber at the heading before the roof came down. The road around Doire mhòr was cut through its ground, and the Company's huts followed. The wall of its old heading still stood above the camp at the close of the age, and the crews would not work the gallery beneath it. Known for the Eleven.

Cnoc naomh (Cnoc naomh). Founded 10 an t-Samhain, GE 2,894. The holy hill south of the capital laid the dead of the Green Death in its shrine's burial ground until it was full, and then in the field beside it, which was never ploughed again. In the months before the rising the crew-leaders of the north met by night on the moor above it and raised a cairn of spoil-stones from their own pits; the nineteen dead of the ford at Àth chiar were buried within sight of it. It has been a house of Macha since An Aois Scraidh⁹, and lies close by the old battlefield of Muileann ghlais. Known for the unploughed field and the two cairns.

8. the Holy Age

9. the Age of Sundering

Cnoc thais (Cnoc thais). Founded 19 an t-Sul-tain, GE 4,328. The damp hill of the north-west heard of the Levy as a rumour before it came as a list. In the high summer of the ninetieth year the Levy's officers took its masons, Dùghall Clachair and his crew of six, to build the tower at Baile chrom, and their small fields stood untitled that year. Dùghall cut the names of his crew into the lintel of the lamp-room, the only writing on any of the five towers. It is the market of the country of the two Muileann àrsaidh, and the Levy's officers came to it again in each of the three years the towers were building. Known for the masons of the lintel.

Cuan dhearg (Muileann chrom). Founded 12 an Dàmhair, LE 1,789. The river town under the red cliffs on the Abhainn uaine lives on river fish and the short ferries between its two landings. In the first spring of the war the crew-leaders of the river towns met seven men in the back room of its inn, An Cupa Dàna, gave them sealed letters and hawks cast in lead from the cartridges of Muileann chrom, and sent them north to the Hawk coast; they were Buidheann an t-Seabhaig Luaidhe¹⁰, the Leaden Hawk, and the boatman Coinneach Beag was among them. The ring of small river towns on the Abhainn uaine above Cathair mhòr heard the news of the war first at its inn fire, where word was turned over until everyone in the room had handled it. Known for the inn where the Leaden Hawk set out.

Cuan shean (Cuan shean). Founded 18 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,755. The old harbour of the west was the first town of Dia-thir to see the strangers, when three ships lay off its cape in the first year and their people spent forty days on the dunes below it while the council decided what to do with them. Oighrig nic Leòid, its custodian, gave them water before any vote allowed it. The humans prayed in one of its sail-lofts in those first winters, and the strangers' fever went out from its quays into the country. For a hundred years coal came down to it from the hill and went out in the humans' hulls. In the last autumn of the age its custodians shut the harbour to every Company ship, and it was from its quay that Lionel Strake sailed, with three chests of harbour keys set at his feet. Its sail-lofts and rope-stores filled with the humans' trade for a generation, and its custodians kept their own roll of every ship that came in, beside the harbour master's. In the siege year it was the one western harbour that answered neither side's letters. Known for the first landing, and the last ship.



Doire ghlas (Doire ghlas). Founded 26 an Giblean, GE 2,470. The grey oak grove of the Keeper stood in the hunger's country. In the winter of the ninety-fifth year the hunger took its old and its very young first, its custodian walked door to door to write who still stood, and in the spring the village sent its young folk south to the camps for the Company's ration; by the year's end it was half empty. Some of its men had dug for Lowe on the Company's winter wage. Its grove was cut for the camps' timber in the famine years, and those who went south to the camps did not, most of them, come back. Known for its young sent to the camps.

10. the Leaden Hawk company; lit. 'the company of the leaden hawk'

Dùn chrom (Dùn chrom). Founded 7 am Faoilleach, GE 2,801. The fortified city on the crooked hill commands the roads south of the capital. Its rope-walks, which had spun cable for the fishing boats, turned wholly to winding-rope for the pit-heads in the thirty-first year, and the town grew by half on the Company's pay. A barracks was built there in the years of the constables. When Ashdown's column fell back through it after the ford at Àth chiar, the town shut its gates on the soldiers in the barracks and kept the column's wounded to nurse or to bury. Its citadel commands the roads south of the capital, and the barracks it housed were empty at the close of the age. Known for winding-rope, and the gates shut on Ashdown.

Dùn dhearg (Dùn dhearg). Founded 9 an Gearran, GE 4,274. The red hill-fort of the east sent Fionnghal nic Artair to Cathair dhearg in the early years, and hers is the only defence of the Small-Burning Law that survives from the time it went out; the council filed her letter. The city kept its own counsel through the age. In the war its custodians sent grain south and read their declaration from the steps of the hall, quoting her sentence a hundred and twenty-seven years after she wrote it. The mills of Muileann dhomhain ground its bread and its custodians sent grain west to the camps in the hunger years by the old custom, asking nothing for it. Known for Fionnghal's letter, read again in the war.

Dùn iséal (Dùn iséal). Founded 9 an Lùnastal, GE 1. The low fort-city of the east, an hour's walk from the silver town, kept a small constable post from the years of the constables. Cut off by the rising, it yielded to the silver guild's riflemen after a single exchange of fire, and the whole east of the island stood clear of human arms. The old walls of Talla na Lasrach¹ stand at it, where the keeper of the flame once settled the silver quarrel of the guild by giving each side half. Known for the post that yielded.

Dùn thais (Dùn thais). Founded 28 am Màrt, GE 2,473. The great hill city of the north-east kept the last hall of the druid school, and Samuel Wren spent a winter there learning what the masters would teach a stranger. Its master Aonghas mac Coinnich put to his students the question why the humans cannot see the colour in broken coal that every Diathreach child sees, and did not answer it; a generation later George Tolley shut the hall over a lecture on whether that blindness was a kind of sickness, and Seònaid nic Dhùghaill was the last of its masters to teach openly. The grey fever came to it at the dark of a later year, and killed the physician the Administration had sent. The school's last masters went on teaching under the trees of Flidais after the hall was shut, and their pupils carried the disputations to Inis bhàn. Known for the shut hall of the druid school.

I

Inis bhàn (Inis bhàn). Founded 16 an Giblean, GE 3,916. The river port of the north-west opened a school of its own in the fifty-second year in answer to the Mission's, and taught the old reckoning, the rolls and the names of the hills; the next year the Mission complained in writing that the children who came to its school from Inis bhàn already knew how to argue, and the custodians kept the complaint as a testimonial. In the season of the hawk sermons its priests of the hawk sat down for the first time with the last teachers of the druid disputations. Its barges run down to Ros gheal on the coast, and its roll kept the names of the children who went to the custodians' school beside the names of those who went to the Mission's. Known for its school, and the Mission's complaint.

1. the Hall of the Flame

Inis mhòr (Inis mhòr). Founded 16 an Dàmhair, GE 4,328. The river port of the north-east grew in the age from a fishing town into a city on the trade of the strangers. Its shipwrights learned to build in the humans' fashion for the Company's coasting trade, and its fishwives kept the old market on the steps where cloth was still bartered for fish long after the mark was law. In the war the townsfolk burned the Company's coal where it lay stacked on the quays, sooner than let it fuel one more ship like the one that shelled Seann Toll. Its barges run down the Abhainn ghorm to the sea, and in the years of the Levy its carpenters were among the men the Administration took for the building of the beacon towers. Known for its shipwrights, and the coal burned on its quays.

Inis thais (Inis thais). Founded 21 an Lùnastal, GE 2,408. The walled temple city of the Stone in the south-west declined in the first years to join the joint council of Baile dhìreach, a few miles off, its custodian writing that one town may be a trial but two would be a rule. In the war its priests heard the Leaden Hawk's letter and would send no men, since that was not what the Stone was for, but shut the harbour to the Company's ships and opened the Fianna's roads to the hawk-faithful. Its temple of Lia Fàil¹, the stone that cries out, is the chief house of the order of the Stone, and its priests keep a driftwood fire that burns blue-white with the salt. Known for the harbour shut in the war.



Muileann bhàn (Muileann bhàn). Founded 24 an Dàmhair, GE 2,378. Where the coal road from the eastern diggings met the mills, silversmiths settled in the eighties and worked the guild's bar into brooches, clasps and buckles for the humans' own market. Theirs was the one craft of the island sold across the sea under its own name. It stands at the meeting of the coal road and the mills with a citadel above it, and its smiths' marks were known in the humans' shops across the sea. Known for its silversmiths.

Muileann bheag (Muileann leathan). Founded 14 an Giblean, LE 1,530. The small mill town on the north coast stands beside Taigh-solais Muileann bheag¹, the only one of the five lights to burn coal. Its keeper Ailig mac Griogair asked three winters running to go back to the old lamp, and its fishermen complained that the colour the coal flame cast on the water drove the herring off. Lowe came to see the flame and the keeper's son answered him on the point. Within a season the herring came back, and the complaint was withdrawn. In the stoppage of the hundred and forty-third year its pits stopped with the rest. The coal flame's colour on the water was still remarked by every stranger who passed the cape at night. Known for the coal-burning light.

1. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

1. the lighthouse at Muileann bheag

Muileann chaol (Cnoc bhàn). Founded 18 an t-Ògmhios, GE 3,218. The narrow mill town in the eastern hills held, in the cellar under its mill house, the copies of the custodians' rolls that the three households of the town made fair winter after winter, the fullest record of the eastern hills and the one no stranger's eye was meant to read. Gormshuil nic Fhearchair was called back from it to the council in the first years, and the rubbing of the first mark went to its loft. Seòna Bhàn kept the copying until her eyes failed, and Cailean mac Eachainn took up the hand at four-and-twenty; it was there he found the Line of Aisling and there, in the last days of the hundred and fiftieth year, that the four chests of the age's rolls came down to him by cart. The copying was done at a long table under a single window, and every copy was made twice, so that no one fire or flood could take the only record of a town. Known for the cellar of copied rolls.

Muileann chiar (Muileann chiar). Founded 23 an t-Iuchar, LE 365. The coal-breakers' mill town west of the silver country grew so crowded with the guild's refiners and carters in the eighty-second year that it was called by the silver town's name from then on, and the rolls speak of the old town and the new without always saying which. It lived on the carrying trade between the two. It began as a coal-breaking mill for the diggings in the hills east of the capital, and the carters of both towns shared one inn and one quarrel for the rest of the age. Known for the silver town's second name.

Muileann chiar (Dùn ìseal). Founded 10 an Lùnastal, FE 7. The silver town lies in the far east of the hills on a shelf of the valley under the moor, an hour's walk from the old walls at Dùn ìseal. Its guild, Comann an Airgid², held its seam under a compact that Ùna locked in the guild chest in the first half-century, and the surveyors who came for its ledgers were turned back at the adit. The guild sent its bar to the sea by Seann Bhràl rather than the Company's quays, paid for the mark in silver, refused Martha Gale's partnership in the sixty-seventh year by a count of hands in its hall, and in the years before the war bought rifles from the raiders of the eastern waters and entered them in its ledger as refining tools. In the rising its riflemen took Dùn ìseal and cleared the east of human arms. The seam is silver near the great vein but not of it. Catrìona nic Eachainn, a refiner of the guild, died there an old woman in the hundred and fourth year, and Ùna nic Choinnich headed the guild into her eightieth winter. Known for the guild compact and its riflemen.

2. the silver guild of Muileann chiar

Muileann chrom (Muileann chrom). Founded 11 an Gearran, FE 1,556. The mill on the bend of the river is the heart of the coal country. Six sacks of its hill's coal went down to the strangers in the first years, and the first contract was read aloud at the mill. Raghnaill mac Dhòmhnaill took A' Chompanaidh's staff here and a house with a slate roof, and his son Dòmhnall, his grandson Iain and his great-granddaughter Mòrag held it after him, until Mòrag broke it across her knee on the Company's step in the hundred and forty-eighth year. Seven men drowned in its flooded gallery, and the inquiry struck her testimony out. On the twenty-eighth of an Gearran in the hundred and forty-ninth year its people took the walled store at first light, and the war began here. Its mill still ground grain for the central country through all the years of the coal, and the steelyard ledgers of its weigh-house, in which the hill's coal had been set down by the ton since the first contract, burned green in the ledger fires of the hundred and fiftieth year. Known for the overseer's staff, and the first morning of the war.

Muileann dhearg (Muileann dhearg). Founded 30 an t-Sultain, LE 2. The mill town a short way from Cill ghlais was where Griogair mac Aonghais told Fearchar Bard to sing the song that went round every pit of the hills without his name on it. In the three years before the rising the smith Uilleam Gobha turned the Company's blasting-powder, bought a keg at a time on a Company chit, into bombs packed in tin from the coal sheds' scrap, and forged pike-heads by day out of rail-iron; the rebels' council wrote that without his forge the rising could not have been fought past its first weeks. The vein-house above the town kept the custody-book of the hill through the long centuries, and its keepers set down the Company's coming in the same hand as everything before it. Known for Uilleam Gobha's forge.

Muileann dhomhain (Muileann dhomhain). Founded 8 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,747. The mill on the deep race grew rich carrying grain to the camps. When the crews brought to break the strike at Cnoc chaol were marched through it, its townsfolk turned them from every door, and they slept in the Company's barns; several went home the next season. After the Rending of Cill ghlais its custodians met the people of the closed district on the moor road and lent them common ground, on which they built Achadh chaol. It is the seat of its province, and its custodians had long kept the right of the old roads to shelter any traveller who asked; they held that right did not reach men sent to take other men's work. Known for the doors shut on the strikebreakers.

Muileann shean (Muileann shean). Founded 1 an t-Samhain, FE 1,093. The old mill of the north, whose wheel the old king-lists already call ancient, took Merriman's first constable post in the hundred and thirty-second year, a stone house with a yard for horses on the northern coal road. The townsfolk called it the humans' second Residency, and did not mean it kindly. In the first week of the rising the post was taken at first light and its constables sent south on foot. Its walls went up in the years of the constables, around the post and the mill together, and its miller ground for the post and for the town at the same price. Known for the first constable post.

R

Ros bheag (Ros bheag). Founded 2 an Dàmhair, GE 1,274. The citadel harbour of the western coast was the humans' western port from the earliest years, and in the autumn of the hundred and fiftieth year it became the last seat of the Administration, when Strake came down the Abhainn gheal with his officers and clerks and the human families of the west and south came in behind its walls. It ran short of food within weeks, and Strake ordered the Company store opened to humans and townsfolk alike at one measure, with no ledger kept. The last ship from an Tìr Thall¹ anchored off it at Samhain. Its Dia-thirich townsfolk kept their own houses and their own market cross through three generations of Company officers at the quay, and found themselves strangers in their own gates in the last autumn. Known for the last seat, and the last ship.

Ros dhireach (Cnoc mhòr). Founded 22 an t-Ògmhios, LE 76. The harbour on the straight headland of the gulf became the Company's second coal port in the seventieth year, to carry off the yield of the southern workings without the long haul round to Ros dhomhain. Edward Vane laid an iron tram-road drawn by mules from the pits down to its quay; it halved the cost of shipping coal and ended the carting trade of the villages on the old road. The Green Death fell on it among the first of the coast towns. It is the harbour of Cnoc mhòr's cattle trade, and the drovers kept their own quay beside the Company's coal stage for the whole of the age. Known for the tram-road and the second coal stage.

Ros dhomhain (Ros dhomhain). Founded 19 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,694. Ros dhomhain lies a short walk below the capital on the lake shore, and it grew in the age into a second town of sawn timber and dressed stone beside the first. Pike's trading post stood on its quay, the Residency on the rise above it, and the Mission's chapel below. The mark and its hundred pence were first paid across its counter, its dockers struck beside the humans' own dockers, and the inquiry into the flood at Muileann chrom sat in the Residency's panelled room. In the war the harbour quarter held itself apart from both sides for a year, until its own men burned the tithe books of the counting-house by night and opened the lower gates to the council's companies. The Residency was found stripped at the end of an t-Sultain, its letter-books left whole on the shelves. Its quays took the coal of the hill from the barges for more than a century, and its steelyard and counting-house scales weighed every load. The Mission's chaplains kept their register of the dead in the chapel below the Residency, and Hannah Webb's brother Daniel was shipped from its quay with the human dockers after the strike. Known for the counting-house fire and the letter-books.

Ros gheal (Ros gheal). Founded 29 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,009. The largest of the three towns of the Hawk bay has been a hawk town since the second house of Òrd an t-Seabhaig² was founded there. When Lisle opened a customs house in a hired loft by its fish-steps in the forty-second year, its fishwives chased the officer out twice in his first year, and the roll says only that he went away by water. In the fever years its hawk-faithful raised a shrine to Mòd on the harbour wall itself, in open sight of the customs house. It shares its bay with Seann Skell and Ros leathan and has quarrelled with them over moorings for as long as the rolls run. Known for the customs officer who went away by water.

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

2. the Hawk order

S

Seann Bhral (Seann Bhral). Founded 30 an Lùnastal, VE 1,005. The greatest harbour of the south-eastern coast, where the oyster-beds lie in the shallows, loaded the silver town's bar for the coasting boats as it had since An Aois Naomh¹. From the forty-fourth year the guild sent all its silver south by this road, eighteen miles down the valley, and paid the custodians of the port in silver by the Muileann chiar weight on every bar. When a collier burned off the coast the Company's agents said at its quays that the guild had paid the raiders to do it; the charge was never proved. Torcall's crews built its new quay in the first years of the strangers. Its harbour is the largest of that coast, and in the war its custodians turned the Company's coasters away without a shot fired. Known for the silver road to the sea.

Seann Skell (Seann Skell). Founded 19 an t-Samhain, VE 1,833. The walled harbour of the Hawk bay heard Murchadh Seabhag preach the hawk's old freedom against the strangers' tithe, and a century later Ìomhar Seabhag's sermons went out from it in copies to the camps and the burial clubs. The hawk-shrines opened again along its bay in the season the fever returned. Its fishing families were proud to the end of the age of having chased the Company's first customs men off their harbour. Murchadh Seabhag preached from the steps of its temple, and copies of his sermons were carried inland to the camps by fishermen. Its harbour was shut to the Company's shipping in the war. Known for the hawk sermons.

Seann Skell (Seann Skell). Founded 6 an Gearran, VE 173. The great river port of the west, a short march north-east of Ros bheag, was where the company of the hawk-faithful mustered under Ìomhar Seabhag's eye in the early summer of the hundred and fiftieth year, and where the seven of the Leaden Hawk were told they were one company with one name. The company held the road between Ros bheag and the north-west for the rest of the war. It is the largest place on the island after the capital, and its barges run down the Abhainn naomh to Ros àrsaidh. Known for the hawk company's muster.

Seann Toll (Muileann chrom). Founded 8 an Gearran, VE 92. The old river port in the hollow of the rock was made a coal landing early in the age, and its barge-stage took the hill's coal down the Abhainn uaine for more than a century. In the first winter of the war a Company ship came up the river and shelled the stage to keep it from the rebels; three-and-twenty of the fishing town behind it died, and the ship burned island coal to do it. Its walls follow Macha. The Leaden Hawk passed the burned stage on the first day of their walk north and found a woman sorting stone from ash with her bare hands at what had been her hearth. Known for the shelling of the coal stage.

1. the Holy Age

Seann Vell (Ros dhomhain). Founded 29 an Lùnastal, GE 3,560. The harbour on the capital shore, eighteen miles down the river from Ros dhomhain, shut the only quay it had for the coal traffic in the season of the flux and let no barge tie up; it paid the Company's fine from the purse that had buried its dead. Anne Colby walked there to help lay out the last of them. In the dockers' strike of the hundred and thirty-fourth year its dockers, with no human among them, refused to load the coal sent round to them; they were not shipped over the sea, but neither were they hired again for two years. It stands on the old quay stones of the Seann-Dhaoine², still seen at low water, and its harbour-master's rolls show its dockers unhired two years running. Known for the quay shut against the flux.

Seann Warr (Seann Warr). Founded 27 am Màrt, VE 725. Seann Warr on the capital's western shore boils salt from the brine springs in the reed marsh behind the town, and it was the first place on the island to sell to Pike's counter, in the third year of the strangers, putting up its price when it heard what he would pay. Its carters took the salt round the lake to the capital for a century on their own roads. In the siege year it sent grain to the hills and the capital every month, by carts that went the long way round to avoid Strake's patrols. The Company tried twice to buy the pans outright and was twice refused, the salt-boilers holding that brine rising from the ground was no more theirs to sell than the rain. Known for brine salt, and the grain trains of the siege.

T

Tobar dhearg (Tobar dhearg). Founded 12 an Dàmhair, GE 2,947. The large village of the red well gave its name to Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg¹, the last of the five lights as the ring is counted round the coast from Baile chrom. Its first keeper was chosen by the Administration on the custodians' word. In the first spring of the war its keeper Raonaid nic Dhòmhnaill put the light out with her own hand, before any order reached her, rather than guide the Company's ships along a coast the council held; when the truce was signed the council had it lit again. The keeper's daybook there ends its entries for the war with a line of Raonaid's own, and takes them up again without comment at the relighting. Known for the light put out in the war.

Tobar dhìreach (Cnoc bhàn). Founded 25 an t-Iuchar, VE 42. The eldest of the three wells that claim the mason's crack is the home of Clann na Ceiste², who keep lines longer than any roll. Cailean mac Eachainn walked the hill road there in the hundred and twenty-sixth year with seven names copied on a scrap of paper inside his coat, to ask whether a line so old could truly be Donnchadh's own, and came back with the Line of Aisling. Its water runs along a straight stone channel through the village, and the keepers of the lines there asked Cailean nothing in return but that the line be copied fair. Known for the keepers of the long lines.

2. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

1. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

2. the Children of the Question

Tobar ghorm (Tobar ghorm). Founded 31 am Faoilleach, FE 950. The village of the blue spring holds the greatest wool fairs of the north, older than the strangers' coming. A second constable post was raised there in the hundred and thirty-third year near the northern workings; its custodian was paid rent for the ground, and with it bought the village out of its debts to the Company store. The post fell with Muileann shean's in the first week of the rising. The humans' wool-buyers came to its fairs every year of the age, and paid in marks once the coin was struck. Known for the wool fairs, and the rent that paid the store.

PART NINE

The Appendices

APPENDIX A

The Council, the Commissioners and the Overseers

For a hundred and fifty years Dia-thìr had two heads and would own to neither of them. The Council of Custodians, Comhairle a' Chùrain¹, sat at Cathair dhearg as it had since An Aois Naomh², with a high custodian, Ceann a' Chùrain³, at the end of its table; and from the eighth year the Administration of the strangers, Riaghaltas nan Coigreach⁴, sat in the Residency above Ros dhomhain under a Commissioner, An t-Àrd-mhaor⁵, sent from over the sea. Between them stood the Company, A' Chompanaidh⁶, which held the pits, and the overseers it set over the crews of the hill. This appendix gives each office as the rolls and the letter-books give it at the close of the age, with the years and ages of those who held it. Years are counted from the coming of the ships; ages are given as the rolls give them, at the taking of the office and at its end.

The high custodians

The high custodian was chosen by the council from among its own members, for life or until he laid the seat down, and signed for the council in all its dealings with the strangers. The seat carried no crown and no guard. Its holder read letters aloud to the sitting, kept the order of speaking, and put his name to what the council agreed.

Tormod mac Ailein, high custodian from the second year to the twentieth. He was forty-six when the rolls first name him in the seat and sixty-four when he died at Cathair dhearg. He signed the first written treaty for the custodians in the council hall in the eighth year, across the table from Josiah Pell, and could not read the tongue it

1. the Council of Custodians; lit. 'the council of the custody'

2. the Holy Age

3. the high custodian of the Council of Custodians; lit. 'head of the custody'

4. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

5. the Commissioner; lit. 'the high steward'

6. the Company

was written in. Six custodians carried him to the ground behind the hall with the bells of the capital ringing.

Coinneach Glas of Ceann àrsaidh, from the twentieth year to the forty-fourth. He was chosen on the second night of Tormod's waking, at forty-five, a broad, slow-spoken man from twenty miles up the east road, and died in the seat at sixty-nine. It was in his years that the coin was struck, the Small-Burning Law went out, and the first pits were sunk at Muileann chrom.

Alasdair Liath, from the forty-fourth year to the seventy-first. He was forty-nine when he was chosen, a custodian who had sat on the council since before the Harbour Articles and had voted to sign them; the roll gives his choosing in a single line with his age and the number of voices. He held the seat twenty-seven years, through the Green Death, and died at seventy-six.

The empty seat, from the seventy-first year to the eighty-first. The council could not agree on a head, and said among itself, in the hearing of no clerk of the Residency, that an empty seat answered no letters and signed no papers. Commissioners who wished to address the council in those years stood before the whole table.

Artair mac Iain of the eastern shires, from the eighty-first year to the hundred and fifth. He was six-and-fifty when he was seated, a quiet man who had kept his own town's rolls without a blot for thirty years and had never once been summoned to the Residency. Fearghas mac Mhuirich said the order's blessing over him, both horses named. He died at Cathair dhearg at eighty, high custodian twenty-four years.

The empty seat, from the hundred and fifth year to the close of the age. After Artair the council chose no head again. The old chair stood where it had always stood, since no one thought to move it and no one had the right to sit in it, and Edward Vane addressed the council in his good coat with his hat in his two hands before a table with no one at its end. In the first winter of his rule Lionel Strake had the council hall locked and its keys lodged at the Residency, and the custodians sat on the floor of Macha's temple for two years, until the townsfolk broke the locks in the spring of the hundred and forty-ninth year.

The forest council

In the late summer of the hundred and forty-eighth year the custodians of the mining country, the crew-leaders of the pits and the priests of Macha who had left the capital's temple met by night in the sacred forest near Cnoc bheag and made one council of the whole mining country, of which no human writing kept a line. It chose **Eilidh nic Raghnaill** of Baile thais to speak for it. She was forty-three, crew-leader of Baile thais and a member of the Lamp-Watch, and had drafted the sentence of the second petition

that the Residency had underlined. Strake ordered her taken with the council's members in am Faoilleach of the hundred and forty-ninth year; she had gone two days before, and the council sat on through the war. Its clerk in the war years was a woman named Fionnuala, who kept its roll and read the names of its dead aloud. The forest council's envoys signed the truce at Àth àrsaidh, and at the close of the age it held the hills, the east and the capital.

The Company

Edmund Harrow, captain of the three ships that lay off Cuan shean in the first year, founded A' Chompanaidh⁷ with Thomas Pike under licence of the Administration. Once Pell had built the Residency Harrow went back to the sea trade. He sailed north-about on a second voyage with three hulls and was lost at sea in the twenty-first year, at fifty-six.

Thomas Pike, trader of the post at Ros dhomhain, kept the Company's counter on the quay from the first years and was master of the Company after Harrow. He chose the ground for the warehouse at Cathair dhomhain and wrote home of the island's coal before anyone on the island called it a trade. The Company's later masters sat over the sea and are known on Dia-thìr only by their seals.

The Commissioners

The Commissioner was appointed over the sea and answered to the Administration there. His commission, read aloud at the Residency on his landing, named his powers and, until the last, the leave and counsel of the Council of Custodians.

COMMISSIONER	YEARS	AGE AT TAKING OFFICE	AGE AT ITS END
Josiah Pell	8–24	48	64
Henry Maddox	24–41	29	46
Arthur Lisle	41–61	41	61, died in office
Walter Crane	61–75	46	60, died in office
Martha Gale, holding the seal	75–76	45	46
George Tolley	76–98	46	68
Robert Haskins	98–114	53	69
Edward Vane	114–132	44	62, died in office

7. the Company

COMMISSIONER	YEARS	AGE AT TAKING OFFICE	AGE AT ITS END
Charles Merriman	132–146	47	61
Lionel Strake	146–150	46	50

Josiah Pell built the Residency of dressed stone on the rise above Ros dhomhain, signed the treaty, and sailed home at the end of his term and did not return. **Henry Maddox** barred the hawk-priests from the camps, for their preaching slowed the work. **Arthur Lisle** opened the customs house at Ros gheal, sent his surveyors to the adit at Muileann chiar, raised the tithe from one part in five to one part in three, and died at the Residency of a fever of the heart. **Walter Crane**, who had been the Company's chief agent at the pits, walked the camps in the worst of the Green Death and died of it at the Residency. **Martha Gale**, the Company's agent at Ros dhomhain, held the seal for the months between Crane's death and Tolley's landing; eight years before, the silver guild had refused her partnership by every hand in its hall save one. **George Tolley** set the quarantine at Caol mhin, asked Macha's priests to bless the new coin, issued the Levy, and retired with honours. **Robert Haskins** ordered that the council be consulted on the tithe and set the tithe before the council met; in the drought he answered each custodian's petition alone. **Edward Vane**, the only Commissioner born on the island, at the Residency itself, laid the tram-road to Ros dhìreach and died in the bed he was born in. **Charles Merriman** brought the first armed constables, built the posts at Muileann shean and Tobar ghorm, tripled the constables after the fight at Muileann chrom, and went home in poor health. **Lionel Strake**, a soldier, had the council hall locked, sent the iron bird over the coal country, issued the edict of seizure and the order to take the forest council, held the Residency through the first year of the war, went down the Abhainn gheal to Ros bheag in the autumn of the hundred and fiftieth year, and sailed from Cuan shean in the last ship able to make the crossing. Of his landing over the sea nothing is known.

The overseers of Muileann chrom

In the thirty-sixth year A' Chompanaidh⁸ set a man of the island over the Dia-thìreach crews of the hill, gave him a staff and a house with a slate roof, and called him its overseer; the hill called him the Maor. The custodians hoped the office would die with the first man to hold it. It passed instead from father to son for four generations, and the staff with it, brass-capped and iron-shod.

Raghnall mac Dhòmhnaill, Raghnall Maor, from the thirty-sixth year to the sixty-second. He was forty-six when he took the staff from the agent's hand, having led

the first crew of thirty under the first contract, and seventy-two when he died. His mother's neighbours gave him his byname the week he moved into the slate-roofed house.

Dòmhnall mac Raghnaill Maor, from the sixty-second year to the eighty-seventh. He took the staff at forty-two and died with it at sixty-seven. He signed the granary order after the strike at Baile thais.

Iain Maor, from the eighty-seventh year to the hundred and thirty-first. He took the staff at thirty-seven, the first overseer schooled at the Mission, and held it until his death at eighty-one. He wrote letters to the Administration for which he was dismissed, and was taken back because no one else would be trusted by the camps.

Mòrag nic Iain Maor, from the hundred and thirty-first year to the hundred and forty-eighth. She took the staff at thirty-six, the first woman to hold it, and the Company approved her in a letter as a safe pair of hands. At the inquiry into the flood at Muileann chrom she bore witness that the pumps were stopped on the agent's order, and her words were struck out. In the summer of the hundred and forty-eighth year, at fifty-three, she refused the order to clear eleven households and broke the staff across her knee on the Company's step. On the twenty-eighth of an Gearran in the hundred and forty-ninth year she led the crews that took the walled store at Muileann chrom, and the war began.

The overseers of the other pits held their staffs under the same terms. Griogar Camshron of the north pit at Muileann chrom, the overseer of Cnoc chaol, and a third at the edge of the silver country laid theirs down in the same season as Mòrag, and the Company set humans in their places.

The silver guild

Comann an Airgid⁸ of Muileann chlar governed its own seam under a compact older than any contract of the Company, and chose its heads by a count of hands in its hall.

Ùna nic Choinnich stood with the ledgers at the adit when Lisle's surveyors came, locked the compact in the guild chest, and headed the guild into her eightieth winter; she refused Martha Gale's partnership at about eighty-two and died at eighty-five, in the seventieth year. After her the guild's roll gives its heads by name and year and nothing else. In the war its riflemen took their orders from the guild hall.

8. the Company

9. the silver guild of Muileann chlar

The keepers of the five lights

The five beacons of the coast were built at the humans' asking on the headlands of the old driftwood fires, and kept by the households that had kept the fires, on the custodians' word.

- **Taigh-solais Àth dhearg**¹⁰, on the north-eastern cape: Tormod mac Pheadair, a mason, keeper from its lighting until his death at eighty-eight, who began the first daybook.
- **Taigh-solais Baile ìseal**¹¹, on the eastern cape: kept by the households who had kept the fire, and by no one else, which was the first thing they asked for.
- **Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg**¹², in the south: Anna nic Dhòmhnaill, a fisherman's widow, its first keeper; at the close of the age Raonaid nic Dhòmhnaill, who put the light out in the war.
- **Taigh-solais Muileann bheag**¹³, on the north shore: Ailig mac Griogair, who kept the coal-burning lamp and asked three winters running to go back to oil.
- **Taigh-solais Baile chrom**¹⁴, on the north-western headland, the last built: Uisdean mac Lachlainn, keeper from the ninety-first year, who was thirty when he took it and died at sixty-five; and his son Lachlann mac Uisdein, forty at the close of the age, who watched the last Commissioner's ship stand out north.

10. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

11. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

12. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

13. the lighthouse at Muileann bheag

14. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

APPENDIX B

The Faiths under the Strangers

The strangers brought one faith with them and found a great many. The orders of Dia-thìr were old when the ships came: Macha's order at the capital and in the south, the Stone in the south-west, the hawk along the north-central coast, Manannan in the harbours, the druid schools of the north-east, and the old keeping of the vein by the custodians, which was less an order than a habit of the whole island. None of them was put down in the age. Some were barred, some were bought, and one was shut by order, and each of them in its own way outlived the Residency that tried it. This appendix gives each as it stood at the close of the age.

The Church and the Mission

The humans' faith came ashore at Cuan shean in the first year. Its people prayed in a sail-loft of the town that first winter, and their clerics sat down with the custodians at Cathair dhearg in the season of speech-making. They worshipped one god and a son of his, and the Dia-thìrich wrote the son's name *Crìosd*¹ as the clerics said it; the whole company of their believers the priests called by a word the island made into *an Eaglais*. On the island the Church worked through its house, the Mission, which answered to its masters over the sea and not to the Commissioner, though the two were seldom far apart.

Samuel Wren, the thin, coughing cleric who made the word-lists with Gormshuil nic Fhearchair, finished a grammar of Dia-thìris for the Mission, careful and true in most things, which gave the word for the vein's custodians as "keepers of the coal." He copied the obelisk near Cnoc bheag and sent it over the sea, and no answer came; he spent a winter in disputation with the druid masters at Dùn thais. He died in the thirty-third year.

The Mission raised the first church on the island, a timber chapel on the quay at Ros dhomhain, with the first iron bell on Dia-thìr; the custodians asked that it not be

1. Christ

rung before the fishing fleet was out, and the bell was rung once before the fleet was out all the same. Thereafter the Mission kept a chapel in every camp and a chaplain to write the dead. It counted four hundred and six dead of the spotted pox, and the custodians counted more and wrote the difference in the margin of the Mission's list. Its nurse Anne Colby made a sick-house of the chapel in the flux, kept a canvas sick-house at Achadh dhomhain through the Green Death, and came back to the island for the famine kitchens at Baile chrom and Cathair gheal. It sank the deep wells at Achadh shean and Àth chrom in the drought. Its school at Ros dhomhain took thirty pupils in its first year, most of them overseers' children; Iain Maor was schooled there. Its cleric Edwin Lowe dug at Làrach an Teampaill² and copied the pillar at Cnoc chiar and the column at Cnoc ghorm, seeking an older faith, and left with his notebooks. Its minister Matthew Dunne preached from the chapel pulpit against the night shift, saying the Dia-thìrich were right that even the ground must rest, and was called home. Its hospital at Cathair gheal took in Dia-thìrich and human sick side by side in the grey fever. In the last autumn the Mission's clergy went down the Abhainn gheal with Strake, and its chapels stood empty.

The Mission counted its first Dia-thìreach converts among its first pupils. Neither the Mission's register nor the custodians' rolls give many more.

The rite of the rock face

Every hewer's son on the hill learned the old words said at the rock face before a man puts his pick in before he learned to swing. The custodians had kept the vein since An Aois Naomh³ by the handful and the measure, eleven baskets and not twelve, and the crews of the Company's pits went on keeping what they could of that under the ton. Two pit-mouth shrines held the rite in the strangers' years. At Cill dhìreach, a temple village of Macha at the edge of the workings, the crews left the first piece of coal from every new gallery, and the Company suffered it since it cost a stone a gallery. At Cill ghlas the custodians kept the old rites at the mouth of the oldest cutting while the Company's pits deepened round them; it was the last shrine in the district the crews still visited on the old feasts, and there the custodians met to agree the word *fuil-ghuail*⁴ for the physicians' book. The Rending swallowed the cutting and the shrine together. The custodians' roll set the loss of the shrine before the loss of the dead.

When Tolley's letter-book blamed the Green Death on the dust, the Dia-thìreach custom of sleeping near the fire, and the custodians' shrines, in that order, the camps

2. the temple ruin

3. the Holy Age

4. the coal-blooded; lit. 'coal-blood'

heard of it, and the coal set on the breast of the dead for the going-down went on being set.

The hawk

Òrd an t-Seabhaig⁵ keeps Mòd, the Hungry Hawk of Acaill, who starves those that eat faster than the land can feed them. Its houses lie along the Hawk bay at Seann Skell, Ros gheal and Ros leathan, and inland at Cnoc bheag, whose priests asked the Mission for Wren's grammar to read what the humans wrote of them and filled its margins.

Murchadh Seabhag preached Mòd's hunger at Seann Skell in the first decades of the strangers, and his sermon, copied and carried to the camps, was the first writing of the Dia-thìrich the Company ever seized. Henry Maddox barred the hawk-priests from the camps because their preaching slowed the work, and the overseers enforced it, though several of them were hawk-faithful. The camps carried the sermons in themselves instead, and in the Green Death the overseers' reports list hawk-feathers nailed above hut doors as a matter for punishment; they went back up as fast as they were taken down. The fishing families of Ros gheal twice chased the Company's customs officer off their harbour.

In the years of the grey fever Ìomhar Seabhag preached at Seann Skell that Mòd's hunger had turned on those who had eaten the hill. The hawk-shrines of the west became meeting-houses for the Lamp-Watch, and the shrine to Mòd that Ros gheal raised on its harbour wall was built again three times in a season after the constables ordered it down. At Inis bhàn the hawk-priests sat down in disputation with the last keepers of the druid questions, the first time in living memory, and settled nothing. In the war Ìomhar declared from the shrine at Seann Skell that the war was Mòd's own hunger turned back on those who fed it; the hawk-shrines became mustering houses, the Leaden Hawk carried the council's letters to them, and the company of the hawk-faithful held the road north of Ros bheag.

The druid schools

The masters of Scoiltean nan Draoidhean⁶ taught by question and disputation, and their hall at Dùn thais was the last of the old schools to teach in the open. They received Samuel Wren for a winter: he asked them why the vein should be holy, and they asked him why his fuel should be burned, and neither telling of that winter names a

5. the Hawk order

6. the druid schools

winner. About the fiftieth year the master Aonghas mac Coinnich put to his students a question the school's register calls new, why the humans cannot see the colour in broken coal that every Dia-thireach child sees, and did not answer it; his students carried it to the hall of disputation at Baile Mòr uaine, whose record of the argument runs to four hundred leaves. A generation later George Tolley shut the hall at Dùn thais over a lecture on whether that blindness was a kind of sickness. The masters taught in their own houses and under the trees of the sacred forest of Flidais near Muileann chiar, and held their last open disputation on the threshing-floor at Doire chiar on the eve of Bealltainn, on whether a question may be forbidden. Seònaid nic Dhùghaill, the last master to teach openly, died at Dùn thais, and the school's register ends with her death. In the grey fever the old houses of the masters at Dùn thais were opened as sick-rooms.

Macha and the blessing of the coin

Òrd Mhacha⁷, the order of the capital and the crown, keeps the rite of Macha's two horses, Dubh Sainglenn the black and Liath Macha the grey, each of which, the order teaches, has its due. At Tolley's asking its priests at Cathair dhearg blessed the Residency's new coin. Fearghas mac Mhuirich would not stand for the blessing, and he and the priests who refused with him left the capital's temple and settled in the sacred forest near Cnoc bheag. There they kept the older reading of the two horses, lit their fire of hazel under the oaks with both halves of the words said in the old order, and took in custodians who had lost their seats. Fearghas said the blessing over Artair mac Iain with both horses named.

The priests who stayed in the capital's temple and had blessed the coin opened their floor to the Council of Custodians when Strake locked the council hall, and sheltered there the custodians who had petitioned against the coin they had blessed. The dissenters in the forest took in the forest council of the mining country and sat at its fires. At the close of the age the order stood in two halves under one goddess, and neither half had unsaid anything.

The Stone, Manannan and the old rites

Òrd na Cloiche⁸ keeps the stone Lia Fàil⁹ at Inis thais, which cries out under the rightful king, and the oldest shrines of the order at Cnoc àrsaidh on the panther road. It de-

7. the order of Macha

8. the order of the Stone

clined the joint council of Baile dhìreach, took no part in the strikes, and would send no men to the war, since that was not what the Stone was for; but it shut Inis thais's harbour to the Company's ships and opened the Fianna's roads to the hawk-faithful.

Òrd Mhanannain¹⁰ keeps the harbours. The traders of the order founded Baile dhìreach, the whale-boats of Àth fhionn thanked Manannan for each whale, and at Ceann mhòr the priests of the order kept the grey night with the human fishing families of the concession. When the Mission reported that human labourers near Baile chrom kept vigil by night in the fields under the sign of a grey goose, which they called the wild goose of the Spirit, the priests of Manannan at Ceann mhòr answered that the practice owed something to the Dia-thìrich, but to their own harbours and not to Baile chrom. Hannah Webb, who first kept it alone behind a byre, said only that they kept the sky.

The ancestor rite of the old roads is kept at Àth fhionn and along the coast at Caol ìseal; the Old Spirits, the oldest folk rite of the island, at Baile ghorm. The strangers left all of them alone, having never learned where they were kept.

The keeper and the king's daughter

In the camps of the hill the washing-women of Achadh dhomhain said of a girl of the spoil-houses that she did not grow, and called her *nighean an rìgh*, the king's daughter, meaning Ailean Mòr, whom the gods crowned in the grove; most who said it did not believe a word of the thousands of years, or said they did not. The custodians met at the shrine of Cill ghlas and agreed a plain word for the change for the physicians' book, *fuil-ghuail*¹¹, coal-blood, and wrote it in their columns against four names by the close of the age, and reported none of them to the Residency. The camps said a person who kept their youth past its season had *Aisling-aois*. Cailean mac Eachainn found the girl's line in the roll of the camp at Àth ìseal, written seven names back, and Clann na Ceiste¹² at Tobar dhìreach told him whose son the last of them was. The camps told the rest as the camps tell things, and the rolls kept only the names.

9. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

10. the order of Manannan

11. the coal-blooded; lit. 'coal-blood'

12. the Children of the Question

APPENDIX C

Strikes, Sicknesses and the War of the Hills

The Age of Strangers was not an age of armies until its last two years. For a hundred and forty-seven years the Administration kept no standing force of its own until Meriman brought his constables, and the Dia-thìrich kept none at all. What killed people in those years was sickness, hunger and the pits, and what the crews had to answer with was the stopping of work. This appendix sets down, as the custodians' rolls and the Mission's registers give them, the sicknesses and hungers of the age, the strikes and the stoppage, the constables and their posts, and the fighting of the war of the hills, with the dead where the rolls count them. Where the Mission's count and the custodians' differ, both are given.

The sicknesses

SICKNESS	YEARS	WHERE	DEAD, AS COUNTED
The strangers' fever	9	Cuan shean and the west coast	91 Dia-thìrich, 11 humans
The coughing sickness	26	the camps at Muileann chrom and Cnoc fhiadhaich	38, most of them boys at the breaking
The spotted pox	39	Ros dhomhain, the coal road and the camps; Baile chiar	406 by the Mission's count; more by the custodians'
The bloody flux	59	the quays of Ros dhomhain; Seann Vell	under 200 at Ros dhomhain
The Green Death, A' Phlàigh Uaine	73–76	26 settlements of the mining country	uncounted whole; 40 in the first month at Achadh dhomhain
The drought-fever	109	Baile Mòr ruadh; Cnoc shean	17 at Baile Mòr ruadh
The lung-rot	from 119	the night crews at Cnoc chaol and Baile thais	slow, and never counted as one sickness
The grey fever	138–140	the whole island; returning in the north-west	the camps worst; one household in three at Tobar fhiadhaich

The strangers' fever came ashore with a crowded ship at Cuan shean and ran down the west coast. It killed the custodian of Baile àrsaidh and both her sons, in a town where no human lived at all, and the custodians of the west took note of it. Cuan shean shut itself to ships for a season, and Pell protested in writing. At Cnoc àrsaidh the townsfolk blocked the road with carts and turned back every traveller, and the fever never reached them; the Administration fined them for hindering trade, and they paid in wool.

The coughing sickness was a dry cough among the boys who broke coal at the pit-mouth. The Mission's surgeon called it a winter complaint, and it lasted through the summer. Cill thais took in the orphans at its own custodians' cost; the Company, asked to give toward the house, sent a crate of Mission primers.

The spotted pox came ashore at Ros dhomhain on a Company ship and climbed the coal road into the camps, worst in the huts at Àth ìseal and at Achadh dhomhain. The Mission counted four hundred and six dead, and the custodians wrote the difference between their count and the Mission's in the margin of the Mission's list. At Baile chiar in the south the custodians cut the names of their dead into the stone lintel of the shrine.

The flux broke out in the crowded quarters by the Ros dhomhain quays. Anne Colby made a sick-house of the chapel. The coal barges carried it to Seann Vell, whose custodians shut the only quay the town had for the coal traffic and paid the Company's fine from the purse that had buried their dead.

The Green Death began at Achadh dhomhain: a greenish pallor, then a cough that brought up dark dust, then weakness. It spread from the camp to Muileann chrom, Àth ìseal and Cnoc fhiadhaich, and wider along the coal roads. At Cnoc namh the dead filled the old shrine's burial ground and then a field that was never ploughed again; at Àth ghlas Sine Ruadh had every hut where a death had been burned with its bedding, and the sickness stopped sooner there than anywhere. Nathaniel Bright began to weigh the dust in the lungs of the dead at Muileann chrom and never finished his table. Commissioner Crane, who walked the sick-rows, died of it. Tolley blamed the dust, the custom of sleeping near the fire, and the custodians' shrines.

The drought-fever followed the Long Drought into the towns. At Baile Mòr ruadh the wells had been deepened into the old middens, and Coll of the Mission named the cause rightly. Cnoc shean closed its one well and drank from carts for a year.

The lung-rot was a wasting of the lungs among the night crews, slower than the Green Death. The Company paid the families of the dead a fixed sum and entered it under the cost of the working.

The grey fever was a fever of the chest that came in on the ships and killed the young and strong more than the old. It shut the market at Cathair mhòr for the first time in the town's memory, took the Administration's physician at Dùn thais and two of the Mission's nurses, and came back to settle in the north-west, where it killed humans as readily as Dia-thirich; at Cathair gheal the two peoples' sick lay in one ward. Muileann fhionn shut its roads for a season; Tobar fhiadhaich lost one household in three and burned no huts.

The hungers

The short hunger in the hills came in the thirtieth year, when the men were drawn from the farms into the pits and the oats of the hill villages rotted in the rain with none at home to cut ahead of it. The meal-carts came from Doire fhiadhaich by the custom of An Aois Naomh¹.

Gorta Baile chrom², the Great Hunger, followed a failed harvest across thirty-four settlements of the north-west from the ninety-fourth year, made worse because the Levy had taken one in five of the grown folk to the pits. It was worst at Baile chrom, whose people could see the new beacon from their empty fields. Doire ghlas sent its young folk to the camps for the ration; Inis mhin ate its seed corn in the second winter and the Mission fed three hundred a day at the harbour; at Seann Bhrenn the custodians opened the grain-pits of An Aois Naomh. A relief ship from an Tìr Thall³ lay a month at Ros dhomhain while the Residency and the Company disputed who should pay for its unloading.

Tiormachd Achadh shean⁴, the Long Drought, lay on the east three dry seasons together from the hundred and sixth year to the hundred and tenth: ten districts of drought country, cattle driven west in a column a day long, the herds of Baile chaol slaughtered, and the coal tally not lowered.

The strikes and the stoppage

The eleven days of Baile thais, in the seventy-seventh year, the first strike of the age: Catriona nic Eachainn called the halt when the Company would not close the gallery the Green Death had come out of, and it ended when the food ran out. After it the

1. the Holy Age

2. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

3. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

4. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

Company built its own granary at Muileann chrom and forbade the camps to keep grain beyond a week's ration.

The night-shift strike at Cnoc chaol, in the hundred and seventeenth year: the crews refused the night shift, and within the week were replaced by crews brought from the coast through Muileann dhomhain, whose townsfolk turned them from every door. The Lamp-Watch's purse ran dry keeping the strikers fed.

The dockers' strike at Ros dhomhain, in the hundred and thirty-fourth year: Diathìrich and human dockers refused to load coal for nine days over the new berth charges, the only strike of the age in which the two peoples stood together. Merriman broke it and shipped the human dockers over the sea. The dockers of Seann Vell refused the coal sent round to them and were not hired again for two years.

The first stoppage together, in the hundred and forty-third year: on one day, at a beacon lit on the hill above Doire mhòr, every working of the Muileann chrom district halted, and with them Baile thais, Cnoc chaol, the silver town, the north-eastern pits at Muileann bheag and the quarrymen of Cnoc gheal, unasked. It ended when the constables shut the Company's stores in every district at once. Forty crew-leaders were taken; thirty-two were let go without charge.

The constables

Charles Merriman landed with a small company of armed constables in the hundred and thirty-second year, the first standing force the Administration kept on the island. His first posts were at Muileann shean on the northern coal road and Tobar ghorm near the northern workings. After the fight at Muileann chrom he tripled the constables and posted companies at Muileann chrom, Baile thais, Ceann fhada and Cnoc chaol, each with a walled store, paid from the tithe, and built a barracks at Dùn chrom for two hundred men. Lionel Strake, a soldier, added patrols on the western roads out of Ros bheag.

The war of the hills

The companies of the council were the crews of the pits under their own crew-leaders, armed at first with pikes and felling-axes and the rifles of the stores they took, and later with the pike-heads and tin-cased powder of Uilleam Gobha's forge at Muileann dhearg. **The silver guild's riflemen**, armed through the raiders of the eastern waters, held the east with the riflemen raised at Cnoc leathan. **The company of the hawk-faithful** mustered at Seann Skell under Ìomhar Seabhag's eye and held the road

between Ros bheag and the north-west; **the Leaden Hawk**, Buidheann an t-Seabhaig Luaidhe⁵, seven men of the river towns under the lead hawk cast from the cartridges of Muileann chrom, carried the council's letters to the Hawk coast and stood in that company's first rank. Against them the Administration had its constables, the Company's guards, a few ships, and what came from over the sea, which was one ship with dispatches and some crates of cartridges.

The rolls give the war's course thus:

- **28 an Gearran, AE 149.** The store at Muileann chrom taken at first light by Mòrag nic Iain Maor's crews; eleven constables yield without a shot. The coal quay at Ceann fhada taken, and two loaded barges sunk across its mouth.
- **The same spring.** The constables of Baile thais hold the walled pithead eleven days and yield on the twelfth when the well fails; thirty-one are marched to the coast unharmed on Eilidh nic Raghnaill's word. The northern pits rise with the posts at Muileann shean and Tobar ghorm. The capital rises: the council hall retaken, the bridge held three days with carts, the warehouse at Cathair dhomhain emptied. Muileann mhin argues three days and sends its boats to the council. Strake fortifies the Residency and the Company's quarter of the harbour. The road cut at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr.
- **The ford of Àth chiar.** Major Peter Ashdown's column meets the crews of Baile thais on the far bank and falls back with forty lost and its baggage taken; the rebels lose nineteen. Dùn chrom shuts its gates on the barracks as the column passes.
- **The east cleared.** The silver guild declares for the council; the post at Dùn ìseal yields after one exchange of fire; Cnoc leathan's riflemen hold the eastern road; Dùn dhearg reads its declaration; Ros fhionn stops its pumps.
- **Winter, AE 149–150.** A Company steamship shells the coal stage at Seann Toll; twenty-three die. Inis mhòr burns the Company's coal on its quays; the fishing boats of both Seann Chwen burn a coaster at anchor. The southern beacons go dark, Tobar dhearg first by Raonaid nic Dhòmhnaill's own hand, then Àth dhearg and Baile ìseal; two Company ships are lost on the reefs.
- **Spring and summer, AE 150.** The Leaden Hawk walks to the Hawk coast in six days. The hawk-shrines open and the hawk company musters at Seann Skell. Cath-air gheal shuts its gates and asks to be left alone. The lines hold: the council has the hills, the east and the capital; Strake the Residency, the harbour quarter and the western ports.
- **An t-Iuchar to an t-Sultain, AE 150.** The burning of the tithe-books, in three raids: the counting-house at Ros dhomhain, the tithe-house at Ceann àrsaidh, the

weigh-house at Muileann chrom. The sally at Cnoc ghorm driven back, the last the Administration made. The harbour quarter of Ros dhomhain opens its lower gates to the council; the Company's flying machine is burned in its shed; Cuan uaine opens its quays. Strake leaves the Residency by water on the twenty-first of an t-Sultain, and the council's companies find it stripped next morning, its letter-books whole.

- **An Dàmhair to an Dùbhlachd, AE 150.** Ros bheag the last seat, with outposts at Ros àrsaidh; hunger, and the stores opened to both peoples. The truce of Àth àrsaidh. The columns go north under the council's guard; no column is attacked on the road.

- **1 am Faoilleach, AE 151.** The war ends, and the crossing is shut.

5. the Leaden Hawk company; lit. 'the company of the leaden hawk'

APPENDIX D

Two Dates on Every Page: Reckoning, Coin and Measure

The strangers changed how the island counted three things: time, value and coal. They changed none of them by proclamation. Each change came in on paper, in a treaty or a contract or a schedule written in the humans' tongue, and each was taken up first by the clerks who had to settle the paper and only afterwards by anyone else. By the close of the age every page the custodians wrote carried two dates, most of the island's trade went by a coin it had not struck, and the hill that had once been measured by the handful was weighed by the ton. This appendix sets down those three reckonings as they stood when the rolls came down to Muileann chaol.

The two dates

Before the ships the custodians dated their rolls by their Diosal year, counted from the sunwise turn of the fleet of the Sundering, and by the moon. They reckoned time by nights and not by days: the night went before its day, a feast began at dusk on its eve, and a debt of ten nights fell due at the tenth dusk. The year began at Samhain with the dark half of the year and held twelve moons of thirty nights and twenty-nine in turn, each begun on the night of the full and turning at the dark: Samhnas, Dubhlas, Faolach, Gearras, Siolach the seed-time, Bearnach the gap, Bealltach, Ògach, Teasach, Lùghnas, Pailteach and Damhrach the stags' moon. About every thirtieth moon the keepers of the reckoning put in a thirteenth, Eadrach, the between-moon, at the year's end, so that Samhain should not come round before the summer was over.

The humans' calendar was fixed to the sun and paid no heed to the moon. Its year began in the dead of winter and had twelve months of set lengths; they counted by days from midnight, divided the month into weeks of seven days, and numbered their years from an epoch in their own land that no scribe of the island set down. In the season of speech-making Samuel Wren drew his year for Gormshuil nic Fhearchair as a wheel cut into twelve, and she set her moons against his months one by one, as near as they would go. When she drew the thirteenth moon he could find nowhere on the

wheel to put it, and wrote it in the margin with the humans' sign for a question after it. That wheel, which survives in Wren's list in the Administration's letter-books, is the first writing on Dia-thir in which the two reckonings meet.

The first written treaty, in the eighth year, was dated by the humans' day, month and year alone. The custodians entered it in their roll under its Diosal year and the moon in which it was signed, and left the day to the Administration. So it went with the Harbour Articles, the Company's charter and every contract for the pits. From those years the custodians' clerks wrote the humans' year at the head of each page and its Diosal year beneath it, and kept the moon in the margin where the roll needed it; the copyists of the cellar at Muileann chaol, making their fair copies, set the two years side by side and it is from them that the practice takes its name, *the two dates*. A contract that fell due on a day of the humans' month could not be settled by the moon, and the clerks who settled such contracts went over to the humans' months first and to the humans' new year after. By the third change of coin, in the hundred and twenty-ninth year, every contract on the island ran from am Faoilleach, and the civil year of the Dia-thìrich had moved to the humans' beginning without any decree.

The humans' months took Dia-thìris names in the clerks' mouths, most of them from the moon Wren's wheel set beside each: am Faoilleach from Faolach the wolf-moon, an Gearran from Gearras the short moon, an Cèitean for the first of summer as Bealltach was, an t-Ògmhios the young month, an t-Iuchar the hot month, an Lùnastal from Lùghnas, an Dàmhair from Damhrach, an t-Samhain from Samhnas and an Dùbhlachd from Dubhlas, the black month. Am Màrt and an t-Sultain the clerks took from the humans' own names for them; an Giblean no one could explain, and the old folk said it meant the gap, as Bearnach had. The old folk went on calling am Màrt the seed-time and an t-Sultain the month of plenty through all the age. An Gearran takes a twenty-ninth day every fourth year, as the humans' calendar has it; the moon-year had no such day and needed none, since the between-moon did its work.

The moon-year did not die. It kept the four fire-feasts, each on the first night of its moon, in the shrines and the hill villages; it was taught as the old reckoning in the custodians' school at Inis bhàn from the fifty-second year; and the hewers of the hill kept their rest on the nights of the full and the dark as they always had. The Administration's count of the people in the hundred and twenty-second year and its register in the hundred and twenty-seventh were dated by the humans' reckoning alone.

The week

The week came to the island with the Company's contracts before it came with the Mission. The first contracts paid their crews by the week and let them rest on the hu-

mans' day of rest, so that the Dia-thìrich who worked for the Company learned the week before any of them was christened. When the Mission raised its chapel on the quay at Ros dhomhain in the thirteenth year and opened its school in the fifty-first, it taught the week with its prayers, and its first converts named the days. Gormshuil had counted Wren's absent mornings on her fingers, one in seven, and written the seven names into her list with the thing she knew of each beside it, which for six of them was nothing.

The hewers made less of the difference than the Mission did. Matthew Dunne, the Mission's own minister at Ros dhomhain, told the Company against the night-shift order that the Dia-thìrich were right that even the ground must rest, and was recalled over the sea for it.

The coin

The mark and its hundred pence. The humans' coin was brought in beside the old barter in the seventeenth year, for ease, it was said. The coins were struck at Ros dhomhain from silver and copper shipped from an Tìr Thall¹, and the first striking bore a ship on one face and nothing of Dia-thìr on either. Within ten years nothing that needed a tool from over the sea could be had for anything else. Cathair mhòr refused the mark for a whole year and gave way when the tool-sellers would not cross its bridge; at the market of Cathair dhearg the tool-sellers took only marks while cloth and fish still went by barter, and the custodians' clerks began to keep two sets of books and complained of it in both. The market's clerk Tadhg kept the dues by the old reckoning in his left-hand book, so many fleeces and so many creels, and by the mark in his right-hand book, ruled in the humans' manner.

Silver for marks. From the eighty-third year the silver guild of Muileann chiar sold bar silver to the Company for marks at a price the guild set, the only ware on the island in the age priced by Dia-thìrich hands.

The blessing and the second change. In the eighty-fifth year, at George Tolley's asking, the priests of Macha at Cathair dhearg blessed the Residency's new coin, and in the eighty-sixth the barter goods of the Dia-thìrich were marked down against the coin a second time, on terms the Administration alone set.

The third change. In the hundred and twenty-ninth year the old barter was struck down as lawful payment altogether, and every bargain on the island went by the humans' coin. The barter houses at Ros dhomhain and Cathair dhearg, where cloth and fish had changed hands without coin since before the Crossing, were shut by or-

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

der, and a clerk of the Residency wrote that the ledgers were now complete for the first time. The fishwives of Inis mhòr took no coin for a week and gave their fish away. The hill villages borrowed marks at interest from the Company's stores to buy seed, and within a few years most of the villages of Muileann chrom owed the Company more than a year's crop. The old barter market at Muileann òg closed after its last season. Barter went on regardless in quiet corners the clerks never reached, cloth for fish at the steps of Inis mhòr and a day's labour for a day's milk between crofts, and at the end of the age the wool merchants of Caol leathan were selling inland by barter again, against the law.

The measure of coal

Before the strangers the coal of the hill was measured and counted, but never weighed. The custodians kept the vein by the handful and the basket: a hewer's measure in the season of the handful, eleven baskets to a cutting and not twelve. The first contract of the eleventh year paid the crew of thirty at Muileann chrom by the ton, in iron tools and lamp-oil, and from then on the Company's steelyard stood at every pit-head. The weigh-house at Muileann chrom kept the steelyard ledgers, in which the coal of the hill was entered by the ton from the first contract to the last, until they burned green in the hundred and fiftieth year. The ton was the humans' weight, and the island had no word of its own for so much coal in one place.

The Company measured its crews by the tally, the yield each working was bound to raise in a season. The tally was not lowered for the Green Death, nor for the drought, nor for the night shift, and when the custodians of the east petitioned Robert Haskins against it in the drought each was told that the matter was under consideration.

Nathaniel Bright, the Administration's physician, kept one other weighing: from the seventy-fifth year he weighed the dust in the lungs of the dead at Muileann chrom, in a table he never finished. His book, with its broken-off row, was filed at the Residency and never taken up again.

The tithe

The Administration took a share of all the coal mined on the island, the tithe, paid to it by the Company and entered against every settlement of the hills in the tithe-house at Ceann àrsaidh. The first schedule set it at one part in five. In the fifty-seventh year Arthur Lisle's schedule raised it to one part in three, and what the Dia-thìrich received did not rise with it; the custodians had their copy in the humans' tongue with a render-

ing made by a Mission pupil. In the next year the tithe-gatherers at Dùn fhiadhaich began to weigh grain as well as coal, saying the farms fed the pits, and the custodians' roll called it the tithe on the tithe. Robert Haskins ordered the council consulted on the tithe and set it before the council met. From the hundred and fortieth year the constables were paid from it.

In the war the rebels burned the tithe ledgers in three raids, at the counting-house of Ros dhomhain, the tithe-house of Ceann àrsaidh and the weigh-house of Muileann chrom. The custodian of Ceann àrsaidh asked that one ledger be spared to keep the record entire, and his townsfolk refused him.

The daybooks

The five lights kept a count of their own. Each keeper wrote a daybook every night of the year: the wind, the oil, the wick, the ships seen and their bearing. The first was begun at Àth dhearg by Tormod mac Pheadair, and the Company's clerk who read it called its keeper civil but of no assistance. Because the daybooks were kept every night by the same hand in the same plain words, the copyists of Muileann chaol leaned on them wherever the other witnesses quarrelled, and dated by them what the rolls left undated. It is from Lachlann mac Uisdein's daybook at Baile chrom that the day and the hour of the last Commissioner's leaving are known. On the nights when no ship passed, the keepers wrote three words, first at Baile chrom and then along the whole coast: *Cha tàinig long*, no ship came. In the last winter of the age they wrote them every night.

APPENDIX E

Words of the Age of Strangers

The age that began with a cup and a loaf held up across a table ended with two peoples who could each say the other's word for most things and still did not always mean the same by it. Gormshuil nic Fhearchair and Samuel Wren made some hundreds of words on each side in their first season, near enough even by the council clerk's count, and the island went on making words for the strangers' things, and for what the strangers did, through all the hundred and fifty years. This appendix gives the words of the age that the rolls and the camps kept, as they were used at its close. Words the island already had are given only where the age changed their meaning.

The forty colours

On the morning of the basket Gormshuil laid broken coal on the table between herself and Wren and named its colours one by one, as any child of the hills could have done: the green that lies under the black like deep water under weed, *uaine*, and the word for that green and no other, which is not the green of grass nor of the sea; the red at a fresh break that deepens if you breathe on it; the grey-violet of the old cuttings that no dyer has matched; the brown that shows a piece came from near the surface; the blue that runs along a split edge like the light on a mackerel's back; colours like heather in Lùnastal, the dark of a blackberry and rust on a nail left out in the rain; the ember before it goes grey and the ember after; a hair-line like gold; and a sheen like a pigeon's neck, with a word for each of the two colours it shows and a third for the piece that shows both. She gave forty. There were more. She stopped because Wren had stopped writing. He tapped the whole heap with his pen and wrote one word for all of it.

The first leaf of Muireall's fair copy holds the forty words in the left-hand column and, in the right-hand column where Wren's words should stand, nothing but a note at the foot saying what happened. It is the most handled leaf in the cellar. Nine years later Raghnaill, guiding the prospectors, named the colours at a fresh break for Hugh Mercer, *gual donn-ruadh*¹ where the red ran into the brown and *gual airgid*² for the

1. the mahogany coal, of life

sheen, and Mercer nodded the way a man nods at a child who has shown him a pebble. Aonghas mac Coinnich's question at Dùn thais, why the humans cannot see what every Dia-thìreach child sees, was never answered in the age.

Words for the strangers and their things

an Tìr Thall³ · "the land beyond". The strangers named their homeland in their own tongue, but no scribe of the island wrote the word down. From the first season the scribes called it an Tìr Thall, and its people simply the humans.

an Eaglais · the humans' faith, from the word their priests used of the whole company of their believers. The son of their god the scribes wrote *Crìosd*⁴, as the clerics said it.

A' Chompanaidh⁵ · the Company, the trading house that Edmund Harrow and Thomas Pike founded under licence, which held the pits.

Riaghaltas nan Coigreach⁶ · "the government of the strangers", the Administration.

An t-Àrd-mhaor⁷ · "the high steward", the Commissioner; his house above Ros dhomhain was **Taigh an Àrd-mhaoir**⁸, the Residency.

Puingean a' Chalaigh⁹ · "the points of the harbour", the Harbour Articles of the nineteenth year, which fixed the dues and anchorages of Ros dhomhain in the Company's favour. Gormshuil refused them.

maor · "steward". Under the Company, a Dia-thìreach set over Dia-thìrich crews, with a staff and a slate roof. The byname Raghnaill Maor was given at a mill door by a woman who said, loud enough to carry, "There goes Raghnaill Maor to his castle," and the hill kept it for four generations.

mòine · peat. The island's old word, which Wren learned over a brazier; beside it Gormshuil wrote what he told her of *the black stone the humans dig in their own country and burn on their hearths*. It was one line among two hundred, and she thought nothing of it.

seachdain · the week, which came with the Company's contracts and the Mission's prayers. The island had never before divided time by seven.

2. the silver-sheen coal, of river water

3. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

4. Christ

5. the Company

6. the Administration; lit. 'the government of the strangers'

7. the Commissioner; lit. 'the high steward'

8. the Residency above Ros dhomhain; lit. 'the house of the high steward'

9. the Harbour Articles; lit. 'the points of the harbour'

Eadrach · the between-moon. Wren could find no place for it on his wheel and wrote it in the margin with a question after it.

eun-iarainn · "the iron bird", the Company's flying machine, which went the length of the working districts in the winter of the hundred and forty-seventh year. By evening of the day it first flew over Muileann chrom every hearth had the word, borrowed from nowhere and understood at once. The old women said a bird that did not beat its wings had no soul in it and could carry none away.

Words the age made for itself

fuil-ghuail¹⁰ · "coal-blood". The plain word the custodians agreed at the shrine of Cill ghlais, fit for the physicians' book, for the change that had come upon some children of the camps, so that they did not grow as others do. The humans rendered it *coal-touched*. The custodians wrote it in their columns against four names by the close of the age, and reported none of them to the Residency.

nighean an rìgh · "the king's daughter". What the washing-women of Achadh dhomhain called the girl of the spoil-houses who did not grow, meaning Ailean Mòr, whom the gods crowned in the grove; half in jest, and as the seasons went by, half not.

Aisling-aois · "Aisling-age". The camps' word for anyone who kept their youth past its season, the kind of word boys use for a thing they are half afraid of and wholly certain will never touch them.

Tìodhlac a' Choimhdich¹¹ · "the Keeper's gift". What the camps called the change, holding that it was the gift of the kin's Keeper woken in the first king's line. The rolls do not use the phrase. The copyists of Muileann chaol found that the line itself stood written, seven names back.

A' Phlàigh Uaine¹² · "the green plague", the Green Death of the seventy-third year, named for the greenish pallor it gave its dead.

Gorta Baile chrom¹³ · the Great Hunger of the north-west, named for the town where it was worst, whose people could see the new beacon from their empty fields.

Tìormachd Achadh shean¹⁴ · the Long Drought, named for the town whose wells failed first.

10. the coal-blooded; lit. 'coal-blood'

11. the Keeper's gift

12. the Green Death; lit. 'the green plague'

13. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

14. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

Scàineadh Cill ghlas¹⁵ · "the Rending of Cill ghlas", the collapse of the hill under the old cutting in the hundred and thirty-seventh year.

Buidheann an t-Seabhaig Luaidhe¹⁶ · "the company of the leaden hawk", the seven of Cuan dhearg who carried the council's letters to the Hawk coast, each with a hawk cast in lead from the cartridges of Muileann chrom at his throat.

Sayings

Cha tàinig long. "No ship came." The line a keeper wrote in the daybook on a night with no ship to note, first at Baile chrom and then along the whole coast. By the last winter of the age it was habit more than grief; the sentence had outlived the asking it once answered.

Loisc iad an leabhar, ach cha do loisc iad an cnoc. "They burned the book, but they did not burn the hill." The verse the camp folk of Muileann chrom made while the steelyard ledgers were still burning green, sung by the market women of Ros dhomhain within the week without knowing where it came from.

Further than a man can walk in one day. Abel Stone's words for the black seam, the only words of the prospectors' walk the humans kept.

Put what happened. Gormshuil's answer to Muireall, asking what to write in the empty column beside the forty colours. The copyists of the cellar took it for their rule.

I never told you a man lived four thousand years. I told you whose son he was. Said by an old woman of Clann na Ceiste¹⁷ at Tobar dhìreach, of a line kept by people who had stopped expecting anyone would come asking for it; carried to Muileann chrom by a copyist.

A debt kept on paper can always be raised again by whoever next holds the paper. Said by a woman of Ceann àrsaidh whom the telling would not name, as the last ledger went on the fire.

Write down that they were gentle about it. Said by an old man lifted from his own doorstone at Doire mhòr under the edict of seizure.

We keep the sky. Hannah Webb's answer when the Mission asked what she kept in the fields at night.

One town may be a trial, but two would be a rule. The custodian of Inis thais, declining the joint council of Baile dhìreach.

An empty seat answers no letters and signs no papers. Said in the council, in the hearing of no clerk of the Residency, in the years it chose no head.

15. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

16. the Leaden Hawk company; lit. 'the company of the leaden hawk'

17. the Children of the Question